

In the name of God most Gracious, ever Merciful!

The Beloved and I

Volume 1: The Books of Moses

Thomas McElwain

New Jubilees Version of Sacred Scripture in
Verse

With Verse Commentaries

Revised Edition

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Puijonrinne 7

70200 Kuopio, Finland

ThomasGMcElwain@gmail.com

www.lulu.com

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Contents

<i>Preface, page 5</i>
<i>Foreword, page 7</i>
<i>Genesis, page 11</i>
<i>Exodus, page 136</i>
<i>Leviticus, page 232</i>
<i>Numbers, page 291</i>
<i>Deuteronomy, page 376</i>

Preface

The New Jubilees Version is an extended collection of contemplations on the Bible, the Qur'an, and some other ancient texts translated mostly from the original languages into English verse. The texts have been chosen in view of three factors: their being within the Decalogue tradition, their historical relevance, and their claims, however tenuous, to canonicity. The last text to be included, the holy Qur'an, is, I believe, the expression of the early, non-Monophysite Abrahamic faith of Yemen and Ethiopia, and so deserves its place at the end of the canon accepted by Christianity and Judaism. I have not considered inconsistencies irrelevant to the Decalogue nor ambiguities of authorship to be important enough to exclude any work. As late as the seventh century A.D. ecclesiastical authorities were making individual pronouncements on the constituency of the Canon, generally for less than justifiable motives and criteria. While the collection that appears here is a uniquely personal Canon, its trinity of criteria is more objective by far than the motivations of the Church Councils in establishing a more limited one.

The comments upon these texts reflect an appreciation for traditions outside those of the texts themselves, not only Jewish, Christian, and Islamic, but even some further afield. There is no implication for or against these various religious traditions as such. In my view, all are valid to the extent they conform to the Ten Commandments, and all have gone astray to the extent they ignore and conflict with the Decalogue.

My assumption is that the Ten Commandments are the criterion not only for determining what is valid Scripture, but also the criterion for evaluating one's understanding not only of Scripture but of life and experience. This contrasts with popular religious traditions and accounts for the ambiguous relationship to them found in the following pages. It is hardly unique in the contemporary, fragmented world that one's religious experience becomes so personal as to exclude

establishment and even in some cases congregation.

The first concerns in translation are readability and faithfulness to the Massoretic text, a Byzantine Greek text and the Arabic Qur'an, while consulting other Scriptural sources in critical editions. The translation process begins with a recitation and investigation of these source texts. Even in those parts where I have made only sporadic recourse to non-English sources the work goes far beyond a mere versification of an English text. The original language versions I have followed are NIV Interlinear Hebrew Kohlenberger 1987, Biblia Hebraica Leusden 1822, Stuttgartensia 1997, Koren 1997, and British and Foreign Bible Societies n.d.; The Septuagint Version Bagster n.d., Biblia LXX et Testam Novum Moscow 1842, Greek New Testament Nestle, Westcott and Hort 1948, United Bible Societies 1968, and The New Testament, Trinitarian Bible Society.

Few translators of Scripture are foolish enough to ignore earlier translations, and in this I am no exception. For difficult points of translations I have consulted the following scholarly versions: the King James Version, New King James Version 1982 especially for names of people and places in the Torah, Modern King James Version, 21st Century King James Version, the Good News Bible 1976, the American Standard Version 1901, Revised Standard Version 1947 especially for the Apocrypha, Darby 1889, Douay Rheims 1899, Weymouth 1912, Young's Literal Translation 1898, Green's Literal Translation, The New English Bible New Testament 1961, The Jerusalem Bible, The Psalms, singing version 1963, Latin Vulgata, Ethiopic Version, Pismo Swiete 1964, Ksiega Psalmow Milosz 1982, Pyhä Raamattu 1861, 1933-38, 1992, Psalmit Nykysuomeksi Aro 1973, Uusi Testamentti Saaristo 1978, Diodati 1649, La Sacra Bibbia v. riveduta 1986, Die Bibel Luther 1545, Elberfelder 1871, Die Gute Nachricht 1967, Bibeln 1917, Biblia Sagrada Paulus 1993, Y Bibl, Y Beibl Cymraeg Newydd 1975-79, Sagradas Escrituras 1569, Dios

Llega al Hombre 1966, La Bible Second 1910, Bonnes Nouvelles Aujourd'hui 1971, Russian Synodal edition 1956, Kitabi Mukaddes Ali Bey, Arabic Bible 1991, New Testament in Church Slavonic 1897, Gaelic New Testament 1829. I have consulted the Qur'an as paraphrased by Yusuf Ali, Zafrulla Khan, Shakir, S.V. Mir Ahmed Ali, Sayyid Ali Quli Qarai, and others. For Enoch and Jubilees I have consulted Joshua Williams's editing of Charles's reworking of Lawrence's translation, Ras Feqade II's rendering from Amharic, and Geza Vermes' The Dead Sea Scrolls in English. I am completely dependent on the translation of Lonsdale and Laura Ragg for the Gospel of Barnabas, which goes beyond being a mere versification only because I have taken into consideration as much as possible the textual criticism of the work.

There has been an attempt to use italics for all words, phrases and occasionally lines that have been added in commentary to the text within the verse numbered passages themselves. Given that this is a verse rendering, the accuracy achieved by the masterful King James Versions is not attained here, although it goes beyond that of some modern versions.

With the exception of some Psalms cast in the eleven-syllable format used by Turkish folk-hymns of Bektashi dervishes and other Alevis, the Scriptural portions are set in octosyllabic, following the same Turkish tradition. Obviously, besides Turkish poetics, English hymnodic tradition, specifically Long Metre, has been influential. The rhyme scheme is based on the couplet with variation. A hint is taken from Medieval Hebrew poetry as well as Turkish tradition in the predilection for complete identity rhymes, something that is not acceptable in traditional English poetry except in the *sestina*. The poetics is thus a combination of Turkish, English, and medieval Hebrew traditions. Although the syllable count, based on Turkish-style scansion is exact, except for feminine rhymes, it sometimes includes weak syllables, which of course contrasts with normal English scansion. The result is that

the entire text of the Scriptures could conceivably be sung to the tunes of Christian Long Metre hymns and many folk tunes in Turkish and other traditions, including such obscure ones as Finnish Kalevala melodies. Of course octosyllabic lines are the most English of all verses since before the time of Chaucer. The challenge is to imbue a translation into that ancient form with any degree of freshness.

The commentaries are distinguished, for the most part, by a form combining features from the Shakespearean sonnet and the Oriental ghazel. It consists of fourteen lines of iambic pentameter, the English heroic line. The rhyme scheme, however, is the same as that for the Scriptural translations, mirroring a ghazel style.

There are three passages in which the Hebrew cognate of the name Ali is rather enigmatic, and in those cases efforts to translate rather than transliterate the word have consistently resulted in confusion. Against all other translators known to me, I have chosen to leave this word in those three Torah texts untranslated, merely providing the transliteration Ali and leaving the reader to interpret as she wishes. A similar situation obtains with thirteen texts using a Hebrew cognate of the word Muhammad. It appears to me that the instance in Psalm 106:24 must be accepted as a prophetic prediction of a coming figure of that name, if we are to accept the far less clear instance in Isaiah 7 to refer to Jesus. Consistency demands accepting either both or neither. To accept Muhammad as a proper name in the one instance makes it plausible to accept it in any or all of the twelve or more other instances in which it seems possible to do so. I have gone so far as to assume the original Hebrew cognate behind the Greek even in a passage of Sirach, and behind the Ethiopic in several passages of Enoch and Jubilees. The cognates of Ali and Muhammad quite simply exist in the Hebrew Scriptures, and the reader has a right to know this, whether or not she chooses to apply it prophetically.

Finally, I have occasionally translated the Hebrew word *shalom* not as peace, but as Islam, with the view that the word refers,

not to a particular religious establishment, but to that peace with God that comes through submission to His revealed will. No implications favouring a religious establishment should be inferred. Indeed, the unbiased reader of the Qur'an will soon become aware that its intention was not to create a new religious tradition, but to call people of all sects back to the faith of Abraham.

This work is unique in several ways. Others have single-handedly translated great bodies of Scripture, although it is fairly rare in this age of committees, at least in such languages as English. A few have even translated large segments of Scripture into verse. Examination of the greater portion of the material in early languages and directly from critical texts is hardly unusual for translators of Scripture. But the combination of critical investigation with translation into verse of such an enormous canonical collection, coupled with extensive mystical commentary in poetic form, is unusual in the Oriental context and even more so in a Western one.

At least since the Protestant Reformation, Scripture has been increasingly perceived as factual literature instead of the more evocative mythical. The fact that so many today perceive Scripture as myth, by which they mean it is not true, only demonstrates the blind and narrow factuality that has oppressed the human soul in recent centuries. Nothing in post-modern thought mitigates this approach: factuality has merely splintered into the meaningless. It is the conscious attempt of the author and translator to avoid not only the deconstructionist fashion of the present as well as historical conventions and outlooks. But this work does not replace the functions of prose translations, study Bibles, or critical editions. Its unique form implies a different function altogether, yet one that approaches the early usage "to be read in churches." Its intention is to provide a reliable text for the purpose of devotional, liturgical, mystical and perhaps sacramental recitation of Scripture. That does not prevent its being read as poetry or even as a novel. The personal practice of the author,

however, is to use the Torah portion for a Sabbath reading in congregation, and the rest of the work as devotional readings throughout the week.

The mysticism at the foundation of this work is the realization that absolute existence belongs to the one God alone. The implication for the identity of the "I" and the unity of humankind ought, with a little contemplation, to become evident. In this context the self of illusion and the Self which is God are in variable tension. The result is sometimes the expression of contempt for institutions and even individuals. This should be understood mainly in terms of the microcosmos of the individual, rather than a projection of suspicion on the world about. To understand these expressions in a literal and exterior sense is to miss the entire point in terms of the self in mystical thought. By the same token, those expressions of love and adoration that may appear to refer to human beings should be understood in the mystical contemplation of the human face, whereby God is apperceived. This danger of misapprehension is well known and is at the root of secretiveness among such mystical groups as Sufis, Kabbalists, and others. One can only pray that the spiritual benefits of this contemplation will outweigh any detriment that careless reading may experience.

The conscientious and spiritual will immediately see beyond the shiny surface of these waters of revelation to the towers and pinnacles of the jewelled city arising from the seabed below. Let these lines be a springboard for the truly adept to plunge into the refreshing flood. These meditations, by contrast to many readings of the Scriptures, couched in the form of verse dialogues, are conversations or love letters between the Beloved, who once inspired the Scriptures, and the lover who now turns to their contemplation.

Foreword

FIND truth, my soul, and do not flee away
From light that pains the darkened eye with
day.

Is man the gauge of right and wrong, one
man

Who rules, the erudite or strong, who can
Impose by arm or reason his own will,
Or even the free soul that's standing still?
I think not, my experience shows me
That human search has limits it can be.
If I am limited, it does not follow
That there is greater in the world to wallow.
But if there is One violent Beloved,
He may extend a hand, though it be gloved,
A hand of revelation in my need,
A word of knowledge and a loaf to feed
The soul whose barren corners lack the
light

To know the right from wrong at the first
sight.

Sweet Reader, dearest, take this book in
hand,
And open it, and read, and understand.
It holds the words of One divine and true,
Called Allah, Alohim, or God, or YHWH
[Huu].

I sip the bright and glowing syllables
Of revelation, myth and miracles,
As some contend, but none of these
describe

Those words to me. I see no lie or bribe,
But only billets-doux from the Beloved.
I answer them, cloved, cinnamoned, fox-
gloved,

Rose-watered and in bitter lime inured,
Yet shyly pausing to pluck at His word.
Sweet Reader, dearest, take this book and
read

The words of one Beloved, if you'll not
heed
My flocked rejoinders. Meet the Sabbath
day
With book in tow and in it lose your way.

I might cast curses on that education
That turned me preacher to the church and
nation
That will have nothing of the words I say.
I speak to bare walls who once spoke for
pay.

And yet I cast suspicion on the priest
Who eats his hearers' bread, offence
increased.
Instead of bare walls I preach on to God,

Call Him Beloved who am made of the sod.

Since none stop on the corner where I
preach

My livid rhymes, I'm free of those
constraints

That hired bishops lay on self and each.
I live among wild creatures and their saints.
I thank that education that gave me
The languages to read the sanctity
Entombed in Bible and Qur'an for earth,
And taught me what a lexicon is worth.
With Hebrew text and facile dictionary
I can dispense with other commentary.

Caedmon alone in Saxon tongue was bold
To start the brave tradition of the old
Medieval singers of the divine Word.
Such troubadours but copied Arab style
That spoke Qur'anic language for awhile.
A pox upon Wickliffe's and Tyndale's curd,
Who turned the poetry to prose and thus
Began tradition of translating worse.
I laud the two, however, for their fame
Of opposition to priestly acclaim,
And setting every ploughboy on the hill
To knowing Scripture better than church
mill.

The only way to translate's with the heart
And rhythming and rhymings from the
start.

But divine Word bears no translation well.
Its incarnation in body a spell
Quite failed to rend the veils and fill the
earth

With knowledge of the Lord and of His
worth.

Rather than a translation, I shall speak
Of sermons for the listener that I seek,
The barkings of a dog let off the leash,
The contemplations of a lone dervish.

I read the Massoretic text and take
The Byzantine or Received Text in stake,
Just as did those who followed good King
James,
And so relieve myself of blames and
claims.

I trace Apocrypha attached in Greek,
And add to this two other works I seek,
The Book of Enoch and of Jubilees,

Whose language is beyond my expertise
That must rely on Lawrence, Charles and
Josh Williams's edition out of hand,
But most upon delighted reading of
Ras Feqade the First's compelling love.
And so I here recuperate the narrow
Canon of Ethiopic church and marrow.
I hesitate not to redeem a few
More ancient texts that have freshness of
dew

And speak of our Lord in his infancy,
Or like Clement affirm morality,
Or like Thomas reveal a secret word
Of what Christ said and of what then
occurred.

Axum and Yemen must have taught the
first

Of Muslim refugees what was not worst,
The popular faith, not official go
Of king, but that of peasant and the low.
This unspoiled, pristine faith by some
called Jew

And by some Christian is retained by few,
And is expressed in Qur'an to guide to
Reform behind the sectarian view.

And so I take also Arab Qur'an,
And try its glowing words and put them on
To wear in English eight-step lines as brash
As any Turkish folk bard makes from trash.
My speeches to the Lord I make resound
In ten-step lines with some ghazal-like
sound,

Although in both I sometimes let the
measure

Run in a rhyme feminine for its treasure.
These freely singing sonnets from the heart
Reply to the Beloved from horse and cart.
I let the modern translator run prose
In pseudo-scientific power pose,
And take each word I taste as full inspired
No matter what the critic has admired.

The old scholars say faith arose in time
Through fear of ghosts or high gods in their
prime.

Both evolution and diffusion make
Some errors that the new-come seems to
take.

I lay off every theory and instead
Know that all faiths are of one power bred.
They all began once when a crowd
complained

They heard God speaking on a mountain
trained.

Some call the mountain Sinai some
Redstone

Pipe Quarry, others have their grant and
throne,

But all are right as far as they retain
The message of the Decalogue amain.

All is just book and visions of the wary,
The Torahs, Psalms, and Gospels, no doubt
true,

Are ancient words repeated, ancillary
To that one revelation that will do
For all time, I mean Decalogue. That's all
We find in any book of faith that's call
Direct from God to multitudes to show
What is belief and faith and how to go.
To me the words are lovely things to hear,
That God is one, and yet He is so near
To me that I cannot see Him at all,
As I cannot see heart, vein, or eye-ball.

No thing can express Him in image or
Be object of my worship, but abhor.
His name is lovely to be called upon
In joy, in fear, in quietness and calm,
Who holds guiltless who do not call in
vain.

Though He is always present, I can gain
No hiding place from Him, yet He appears
Each Sabbath day with happiness or tears.
He gives one duty only to be done,
Not great feats nor things tiring to be won,
But simply honour to one's mom and dad,
By doing so, one avoids all things bad,
In judgement has the chance to come home
free.

He lovingly protects from harm by saying
Not to kill, not commit adultery,
Not to steal, and in bearing witness staying
Within the truth. But greatest satisfaction
Comes in not coveting another's faction.
The Bible and Qur'an have just one plot,
Examining the Decalogue's love-knot.

O pagan Christian, lay this book aside.
You've not honesty to bear truth, abide
In your Mithraic sacrifices and
Their festivals to sun on every hand.
Or else put off idolatry that wears
The false face of three gods in one for
dares,

Put off your human sacrifice and cup
Of human blood you drink and then look
up,

Put off your hate and criticism of
The sacred Word of God dwelt on in love.
Bow down in sacrifice of self this day
Of Sabbath rest held in repentance' sway
Instead of the emotions of false story,
Seductions of fanfare and churchly glory.

The dross of seven evils I replace
With gold of love to God, before His face
Obedience to His word rightly known
That He sent out from Sinai and His throne.
The first evil eschewed is pagan gods
Set in their trinities cast on the sods.
The second evil is the works of hands
Set up for worship, iron credo bands.
The third is Sunday worship, sun worship,
The fourth is priestcraft and bowing from
hip.
The fifth is payment to the priest and
crown,
The sixth is violence and killing for
The so-called faith and weal, and what is
more,
The last is pride of power, seeking renown.

Sweet reader with a loving heart, read not
This book at once as in an hour taught.
Instead take it each day in sacred draught,
And after whirling holy names at eve
As Sabbath draws on, do not take your
leave

Until you've made a portion of its fire
And calm one with your secret soul's
desire.

A daily, weekly guide its pages are
To those who follow David's key and star.
The Baptist way of worship guides my
hand

With prayer and song and preaching to the
band.

The Torah is a song, the Psalms a prayer,
The Gospel and Qur'an preach to the fair,
And so the whole's a Sabbath meeting's
share.

Beloved, God of the Universe, the One
Who stands alone in royal dignity,
Creator of the worlds and all things done,
Look in Your love and mercy upon me.

I put Ed Elwall's turban on my crown
And don his white and seamless Turkish
gown.

I start my pilgrimage at Eden's gate,
Pass Egypt and fair Babylon with hate,
Bow at the Kaaba of my own threshold,
And penetrate the streets of Salem, old
And worn, kiss Ephrata's steep hills and fly
To Yemen and Axum beneath clear sky.
Beloved, God of the humble and the small,
Hear one poor dervish and his single call.

The camels and the caravans pass by,
The trains of pomp and wealth beneath a
sky
Clear sunned. I walk my circle now alone,
No comrade here to share my wine and
bone.

None hears my footsteps fall in sacrifice
But You alone, Beloved, and You suffice.
I lay Ed Elwall's turban now aside,
Take off the Turkish gown once donned in
pride,
And naked step into the slaughtering
ground.

The sighing of Your name's the only sound
That touches on my ear. Alone I whirl
While the great and the true come to unfurl
A flag of conquest and a seat of state.
Outside the fold I humbly kiss Your gate.

The wilderness about my ringing ears
Re-echoes with the sermons in arrears
E. Eckerlin recites into the wind.

Like his my fellows are both winged and
finned,

Who can sit through the rhetoric of hours,
Day after day, night after night, in showers
Of jewels let loose from Your eternal
Word.

I meet the lone dervish of beast and bird.
The man was satisfied to be alone,
Cabined in the woods, friend of earth and
stone.

He was again in peace when others came,
Establishing about him halls of fame.
He lived to see the comers go away.
Still he was satisfied to stay and pray.

The most obscure of Your band is St.
Beathan,
Not even certain which of two we mean,

Or if he is progenitor of mine
 Or only mentor of my fathers' wine.
 The Celtic hermitage beside the lake
 Was where he learned in every beastie's
 wake
 And taught the humble who came to his
 door
 To pray to You, Beloved, upon the shore.
 I too in centuries beyond his ken
 Avoid the tabernacles of strong men
 And sit between the lake and forest trees
 And learn from robins and the bumble bees
 To take my breath and nourishment from
 You
 Alone beside the pansies and the dew.

Genesis

THE idea that the Book of revelation in its four parts, the Torah or Tawrat, the Psalms or Zabur, the New Testament or Injil, and finally the holy Qur'an, makes up a coherent whole, is one that has been fostered in practice by most Muslims for centuries, and forms a basic tenet of the Bektashi-Alevis. In his book *What does God Demand of Humankind*, the late Turkish teacher of Islam, Şinasi Koç, maintains that the differences between Judaism, Christianity, Islam and the less numerous faiths of East and West would find a common path if they adhered to the divine law found in the pages of the Bible and the Qur'an. This call to return to the common faith was the focus of his life work. The 17th-century Christian writer, Edward Elwall, in addition to wearing Turkish dress in witness of this common faith, also wrote many tracts defending the Decalogue as the foundation of a common revelation, and the universality of the one God of revelation.

The book of Genesis, the first part of this grand conversation between God and humankind, is a compilation of stories that give the fundamentals of this common revealed faith. Rather than a philosophical point of departure in the definition of God, the story begins by affirming Deity through creation. The universality of the sovereign Creator-God comes to a pinnacle in the

story of Abraham and Melchizedek, both of whom, while representing different tribes, recognize the same God. Polytheistic systems fostered the worship of different, local gods as one moved from place to place. The experience of Abraham, who as a nomad worshipped one and the same God all of the time, no matter where he wandered, was a telling witness against idolatry. This is the first principle of revealed faith.

Other fundamental principles are also found in the book. The story of Cain and Abel establishes the principle of divine justice, one carried out through the story of the Flood and later episodes. Again and again the principle of prophethood as the medium of revelation appears, until finally God tells it to a heathen king in a dream in Genesis 20:7, claiming Abraham to be a prophet. The same passage establishes the practice of righteous dissimulation or *taqiyya*. The first woman to be a prophet appears in Genesis 16, Hagar, the mother of Ishmael. Others, such as Miriam the sister of Moses, Hanna the mother of Samuel, and Deborah in the book of Judges follow in line.

The principle of divinely appointed leadership is established throughout the book of Genesis, as the line moves from the hereditary one of Genesis 5 to the appointment of the righteous Abraham. The book of Genesis moves through twelve successions of divinely appointed leadership, establishes them as divine proof or witnesses to the world of the oneness of God, and finally, tells the story of the first occultation, the disappearance of the prophet Enoch to walk with God.

The principle of human responsibility before God, or judgement, is approached from several points of view in the story of Joseph, where the factors of God's sovereignty and foreknowledge are placed opposite human choice and responsibility. Thus, although the oneness of God is the major theme of Genesis, the basic principles of divine justice, revelation through prophets, divinely appointed leadership, and divine judgement are fully

portrayed to the one who approaches the Book of revelation from the beginning.

Christians have made a great issue of the prophecy of the coming of Christ to be found in Genesis 3:15. I find this text ambiguous for such purposes. More telling is the principle of revelation through the Angel of YHWH, whose role as messenger of God is so strong that he always speaks for God in the first person, and is even in Genesis 16 and 22 as well as other passages elliptically referred to by the name YHWH as well as the Angel of YHWH, a convention that may go far to explain the strong anthropomorphism that is applied to YHWH in some texts. The personification of the Word of God is laid down in Genesis, preparing the way for the Logos of John and the Qur'anic recognition of the Messiah, a word from Allah. But this should not be construed in any sense that attributes creaturely characteristics to the Creator or denies His absolute oneness.

The Angel of YHWH appears at the binding of Isaac as well. The awareness of the anthropologist that the sacrifice of Isaac is a replay of a rite of passage with a set liturgical text after the manner of Van Gennep rather than a unique and straightforward event is perhaps my most important original exegetical contribution. The fact that it accounts for all of the factors, however, is not enough to establish its validity as a hermeneutical alternative among those who wish to maintain as many points of division as possible between faith traditions. The explanation of course allows both the Bible and the Qur'an to be correct in describing the rite for both Isaac and Ishmael.

As the bridge of faiths, Genesis arises most fully in its presentation of the loving relationship between Ishmael and Isaac and their descendants. Both sons are established in Genesis 17 as heirs of the promise of God, and both are fathers of twelve princes. The passage containing the names of the sons of Ishmael in Genesis 25:13-16, when cantillated in Hebrew, is one of the most exquisite hymns of the entire Book of Revelation.

BELOVED, that I know I am here to think,
Aware of all illusion at the brink,
And being so aware, I come to know
That You are one above, beyond the go
Of changing things, as witness to the show
Of justice You make when You steel Your
Word

By prophet and divine guide to the stirred.
Your revelation of the right in these
Three paths as one in treasured trinities
Of law and prophecy and word made flesh
Come to my soul today and now make
fresh

My coming to Your face in judgement and
Extinction of illusion's will and hand
To find Your paradise on silver sand.

Week One Genesis 1

Speak out, O my Beloved, of Your
creation,

How You made all things that exist and yet
Existent as You are, You have no nation
But are as One apart from all things met.

Speak out, O my Beloved, of light and air,
Of all the signs and wonders that appear
In earth and sea and sky and everywhere
Fowl flutter, cattle wander without fear.
Speak out, O my Beloved, command and
blessing

To fill the earth and have dominion in
The things to eat, if they are seeds, I'm
guessing,
They may be fruit, grain or nuts without
sin.

Speak out, O my Beloved, and at Your
speaking

Find me here always answering and
seeking.

1 In the beginning He created,
Alohim, heaven and earth *as stated*.

"In the beginning," O Beloved, You give
Just what the startled soul must have to
live.

I need not seek a hidden path for You,
But from the start You tell me what to do.
First song of divine revelation, sweet
To tongue and ear, here, O Beloved, we
meet.

And yet not meet, Beloved, for You are He
Whose being, essence is unknown to me.

You come not in Your single glory but
Creator, undefined, defined in what
The scintillating universe is made.
O Hidden Treasure, One, Alone, You
 stayed
The whirling suns of time and space and
 sound,
Stooped to creation that You might be
 found.

2 The earth was without form, and void,
And darkness on the surface of
The deep, and a great wind *employed*
With hovering on the surface of,
The surface of the waters' *love*.
[A great wind, or the Spirit of Alohim].

I turn from heaven and seeking to the earth
To find beneath my foot one thing of
 worth.

I find You, O Beloved, in all the Gates
Wherein the lovely hidden Treasure waits:
The Gate of Earth, one without form and
 deep,

Reality, where soul's distinctions sleep,
I find You in the Gate of waters where
There is no light, but Your awareness bare,
I find You in the Gate of air, in law
That touches the prostrated soul with awe.
In earth and water, wind and darkness
 sought

You are the Treasure that cannot be bought,
The Treasure of Tehowm, the depth of fire,
In all the Gates, Beloved, my One desire.

3 Said Alohim, "Let there be light"
And *certainly* there was the light.

Let me not worship light, for now I see
That light is just a word that says let be.
Indeed it is a thing created so
That in the everlasting night might glow
That word resounding from the mouth of
 God.

Let there be light, a path where angels trod,
And being so, let light be trodden down.
Created first, let this be light's renown.
Created glory is but darkness when
The Uncreated One appears to men.
Illumination of the human heart
Reveals an empty temple without art.
But even darkness may suffice to show

That You, Beloved, are there though light
 may go.

4 And Alohim saw light for good,
And Alohim *did what He should*
In separating darkness from
The light *created that had come*.

Beloved, I fear to hear that You see light
For in my seeing light is only night.

By light I see the other, not the right,
The light is but the medium of my sight.
But You have need of nothing, so You
 know,

Perceive directly both the yes and no.
You only may divide the light and dark,
Distinguish good and evil in the park.
Beloved, You see the light, and what You
 see

Is good, if good, Beloved, look not on me.
There is none Good, none Good at all but
 One,

Look not, look not, Beloved, on me
 undone,

And let not me be Good, but You alone
Who are not made of blood and flesh and
 bone.

5 And Alohim called the light "Day!"
And darkness He called "Night!" That way
Evening and morning were first day.

Beloved, You cantillate the name of Day,
But I can never hear a word You say.
Again Your lovely voice lifts to recite
The words of darkness and there is the
 Night.

I see the Day, the glories of its birth
That go from topaz, emerald, then in worth
To ruby, last to diamond, then to dusk.
I smell Night's perfumes and I smell its
 musk.

But I hear nothing of your diurnal song.
Speak, sing, Beloved, to tell me I've no
 wrong!

I see the Day and smell the Night but hear
No whisper of divine upon my ear.
It is not mine to hear Your words out-flung
Who am the whispered word upon Your
 tongue.

6 Said Alohim, "Now let there be

Expanse *as of beaten sheet metal*
 Between the waters *where they settle*
 And to divide waters from sea."
 7 Thus Alohim made the expanse,
 Divided waters *that advance*
 Under expanse from those above.
 And it was so. The expanse of
Like beaten metal sheets on high
The dear Alohim called the sky.
 8 Then eve and morn came *in their way*
 To make *creation's* second day.

The second day You spoke the firmament
 Into existence, with Your word and scent,
 Dividing thus the gate of waters there
 Above the gates of earth and fire and air.
 Yet when I look into the sky, behold,
 There is no stretch of beaten metal cold
 Against stupendous reaches into space.
 I find no firmament in time or place.
 And still I raise my eyes from earth to sky,
 Between awareness and reality,
 And look in awe, not on a firmament,
 But on the bare, uncircumscribed ascent.
 Nothing divides the heaven and earth in
 time
 Except the tinkling hammers and their
 rhyme.

9 Said Alohim, "Let there be gathered
 The waters under heavens *untethered*
 Into one place, and let appear
 The dry *land*." It was so *and clear*.
 10 Called Alohim the dry *land earth*.
 The gathering of the waters' *girth*
 He called seas. Alohim then saw
 That *it was good and it was law*.

The gates of earth and water at Your word
 Appeared before my heart and my soul
 stirred
 At Your call, my Beloved, to enter in.
 I try it with a toe instead of fin
 And brace myself for some regeneration
 Or at the least uplifting jubilation.
 This miqwe is too cold I say aloud,
 And try to hide myself amidst the crowd.
 Ablutions, baptisms are for the mind
 Or body, rather, literally inclined.
 My spirit is a higher class and one
 Imbued with spirituality hard won.
 Dive in, I find this is no dunking pool,

But seas of love for every swimming fool.

11 Said Alohim, "Let earth bring forth
 Grass, herb seeding seed from henceforth,
 The fruit tree making fruit to its
 Own kind, which in itself seed fits
 Upon the earth. And so it was,
Both herb and tree and seed and cause.
 12 And earth sprouted the grass, the herb
 Seeding seed to its kind, and tree
 Making fruit in itself to be
 According to its kind. He saw,
 Did Alohim, for good *and law*.
 13 So evening was and morning came
 The third day *of creation's fame*.

I step upon the earth with dripping hair
 And see it sprouting green leaves
 everywhere
 At Your command, Beloved, and at Your
 ease.
 It brings forth grass and herb and fruitful
 trees.
 The gate of air I need at every breath.
 I plunge into the water, that small death
 Does not at all quench any of my fire.
 But only when I step into the mire
 And feel the scratch of prickle on my sole
 Do I at last enter the chambered goal.
 Instead of barren rocky shore and cloud
 I find the luscious fruit and table bowed
 And banquet set for One reality,
 I join with You and You, Beloved, with
 Me.

14 Said Alohim, "Let there be lights
 In the expanse of heaven, from nights
 Divide the day, and let them be
 For signs and feasts appointedly,
 And days and years. 15 And let them be
 For lights in the expanse of sky
 To give light on the earth." That's why.
 16 Then Alohim made two great lights:
 The greater light to rule the rights
 Of day, and then the lesser light
 To dominate over the night,
 The stars also. 17 Gave Alohim
 To the expanse of skies the dream
 To lighten up the earth, 18 and rule
 Over the day, over the *cool*
Of night, and also separate
 Light from the darkness *inchoate*.

And Alohim saw it for good.
19 On eve and morn, the fourth day stood.

Beloved, You give from day to day the
lights
Upon the skies to rule the days and nights.
By night and day I look to see their signs
For good or ill, for what their glow divines.
I see them measure off my days and years,
Their regular ascents to calm my fears.
But fourth day of creation knows no feast,
No new moon nor a Sabbath at the least.
The only festival appointed must
Be that tryst secretly in wine and crust
I have with You, Belovèd, day by day,
As greater, lesser lights go on their way,
Appointments momentarily below
The hundred thousand stars that come and
go.

20 Said Alohim, "Let waters swarm
Abundance of living, not warm,
And let birds fly above the earth
Upon the face of skies' expanse."
21 Created Alohim for worth
Sea creatures and all that advance
With which the waters swarmed to their
Own kind, and every bird of air
According to its kind of wing.
For good saw Alohim each thing.
22 And Alohim blessed them, and said
"Be fruitful, multiply, and fill
The waters in the seas, be led
The birds on earth to increase still."
23 So evening and the morning ran
Fifth day *as soon as it began*.

Out of the gathered waters of the deep,
The dyeing vat, miqwe, baptismal font,
Above the great wind's sighing and its
sweep,
You conjure up, ethereal and gaunt,
The living nafs, the self, that fleeting fish
That turns from wraith to silver with one
wish
And disappears, a droplet in the vast
And mobile sea. If I take fly and cast,
It may take all my three-score years and ten
To find and catch that silver fish again.
I shall not wait upon the shore, shall not!
I care not whether silver fish are caught.
Instead I plunge into that rising foam,

And quickly pass into eternal home.

24 Said Alohim, "Let earth produce
The living creature to its use:
The cattle and the creeping thing,
Beast of the earth each according
To its own kind." It came full-swing
25 Made Alohim the beast of earth
According to its kind *and worth*,
Cattle according to its kind,
And everything on earth that creeps
According to its sort *inclined*.
And Alohim *who never sleeps*
Saw *it was good and good for keeps*.

Beloved, You blessed the birds and fishes
And made them souls upon their wishes,
But when it came to creeping things
You seem to have some questionings.
At least You do not bless the cattle
Nor wild beasts going out to battle.
Since these are closer, bone and claw,
To humans, and they stand in awe
Of human powers, one might think
They too deserve, a missing link,
To enter in the books of those
You set apart, and marked and chose.
Treat me, Beloved, I truly wish,
Not like the cattle, but the fish.

26 Said Alohim *then to Himself*,
"Let us make humankind, *not elf*,
Into our image, by our plan,
Let them have rulership *who can*
Over fish of the sea, the birds
Of the air, and the *lowing* cattle,
All earth and over those that *prattle*
And creep on the earth *without words*."

Your image is a canvas vaster than
What sea and sky and earth forever can.
Yet Your self-portrait in perfection lies
Within the atom's small peripheries.
To each wrought figure either small or vast
You have his own dominion wisely cast.
Each mite within Your image has been
crowned
And granted each its nourishment and
bound.
Your sovereignty of sovereigns knows no
press,
While I'm in Your creation, free to guess.

Though I myself am not Your image whole
As some would trust whose faith has
greater goal,
I glory in the honour of the part
I have in Your creation's noble art.

27 Created Alohim into
His image humankind, as two
Into Alohim's image made,
Male and female *two in parade*.
28 And Alohim blessed them, and said
Alohim to them, "Merited,
So multiply, fill up the earth
And live throughout its breadth and girth,
Rule over the fish of the sea,
Birds of the air *or where they be*,
And over every living thing
That moves on earth by foot or wing."

Beloved, this is the first of Your
commands,
A double statute that perhaps still stands.
Although You set the bounds of
reproduction
As what the earth is able in construction
Of living space and eating, You impose
The duty first of all since men arose
And women too, to live and propagate.
One half of all required in every state
Remains to fill this first command, obey
The human urge to make, produce, and
play.
Consumption and production are the whole
These words imply, to make and take the
goal.
Belovèd, I fulfil Your will devoutly
By merely breathing inwardly and outly.

29 And Alohim said "See, I give
You every herb with seeds that live
On all the surface of the ground,
And every tree where fruit is found,
To you it shall be for your food,
Your nourishment and for your good.
30 "Also, to every beast of earth,
To every bird in air *for berth*,
To every earthly creeper living,
The green herb for their food I'm giving."
31 Saw Alohim that everything
Was very good He was making.
So evening came and morning *won*
The sixth day *was creation done*.

Beloved, I jump to no conclusions when
I hear You give dominion now to men
And women as the second of commands.
I do not think that makes us kings of lands
Or even animals. Dominion's but
The word you use when You would tell us
what
We ought to eat, and what the others
choose.
Dominion's nothing more, a right to lose,
Than eating seeds and such instead of
greens.
The one that eats more than corn, squash
and beans
Has lost dominion, eating leaf and root.
Dominion's not a sceptre, crown and suit.
Let me, Belovèd, crack the sacred nut,
Divide the grape and sit beneath Your hut.

Genesis 2

1 So skies and earth, without delay,
Were finished. 2 On the seventh day
Alohim ended all His work.
Observed the Sabbath, *did not shirk*,
The seventh day, from what He'd done.
3 Then Alohim, He blessed the one
Day, seventh day and made it holy
Because He observed Sabbath *slowly*
From all the work that He had made;
What Alohim created stayed.

Beloved, the sixth day You blessed man
and beast,
And gave them nourishment from great to
least,
The seventh day You stepped upon the
throne
To reign Creator-God, and reign alone.
As this blessed day affirms Your
sovereignty
Week after week let me too seek to be
The sign to all that You are God alone.
Submerge this self caught up in flesh and
bone
Into Your Self, to praise Your love and
power,
Nor as the Sabbath for a day, an hour,
A moment be enough to satisfy
My humble wish to praise and magnify.
Let me not turn from sixth day prayer to
seek

My tasks, but Your remembrance of the week.

When in Your wisdom You had laid
Foundations of the earth,
In pause You saw what You had made,
And then proclaimed its worth.
When in Your power You set abroad
The flaming arch of heaven,
You looked up from the budding sod
And blessed the fruit of seven.
For on that first Sabbath of rest
You saw the good in all.
Who brought forth right and reaped the best,
Taught us to hear Your call.
So on this day as I survey
In pause my week again,
Let me see good in my own way
And in my fellowmen.
And may the Sabbath blessing rise
This Sabbath as of old,
And recreating grace devise
To turn my dross to gold.

4 These *are* the stories of the skies
And of the earth, *do not despise*,
They were created, in the day
That YHWH [Huu or Jah] Alohim took His way
With earth and heavens, 5 before wild plant
Was in the earth as habitant,
Before a wild herb had been grown.
For YHWH Alohim, *as is known*,
Had not caused rain on earth as yet,
And no one worked that ground *unwet*,
6 But mist went up from earth to water
The whole ground's surface *without slaughter*.
7 And YHWH Alohim formed Adam,
The human *being without sham*
From earthy dust and breathed into
His nostrils breath of life to do
His purpose and Adam became
A living being *without shame*.

A living being, nafs it's called in speech
Heard round the hearth and gallows, and by each
Lone dervish in his solitary dance
With death. The living dead too wish to prance

About the dust and breath. But You who form

A man or woman merely from a storm
Of desert dirt and wind make miracles
From less than nothingness. Dust disannuls
In no way breath of life and both together
Despoil and recreate in every weather
The nafs. Poor soul, whose breath is in the nostril
And not the cosmic universe, is wastrel
That's worth the void upon whose fecund screen
Is played the universe, the nafs, the scene.

8 Then planted YHWH Alohim there
A Pleasure garden, Eden *fair*,
And there He put the human being
He had formed, *for doing and seeing*.
9 And from the ground YHWH Alohim
Made grow each tree that grows to seem
Pleasant to sight and good for food,
Within the garden tree of life
Also, *and never to be rude*,
The tree, *that caused a world of strife*,
Of knowledge of the righteous way
And of the evil *path astray*.

Ah, tree of life and life immortal I
Shall have if only, even with a sigh,
I let go hope of knowing right and wrong
For my own self. Instead I sing the song
Caught from Your lips, Beloved, instead I dance
To Your tunes sung not only to enhance
Creation but to make it real or all
But real. Instead I listen for Your call.
It is not knowledge You prohibit but
Desire to define right and wrong and what
Should be and what should not be on the earth.

You only, my Beloved, know what is worth
A sense of justice. Right and wrong demand
The knowledge of all things, and out of hand.

10 A river now went out of Pleasure
To water Eden without measure,
And, as it went out from its launches,
Divided into four new branches.
11 Pishon is the first river's name,
That goes round Havilah, the same

Is where there's gold, 12 and good gold too,
And pearls and onyx stones, not few.

[possibly pearls or the gum of the *Borassus flabelliformis* tree or *Commifora africana*]

13 Gihon's the second river's name,
Surrounding all of Cush [Ethiopia] *its fame*.

14 Hiddekel [Tigris] is the third to come,
A river before gladness won. [or east of *Assyria*]

The fourth river is called Euphrates
(I saw it in the nineteen-eighties).

Beloved, the four gates that four rivers
make

Delight my soul bent to the torture stake,
A whirl upon the slaughtering ground and
then

I find the gold provided for all men.

Another whirl and fragrant pitch and stone
Create a temple on the earth alone.

For love I fly to Cush and whirling there

I turn to Hiddekel and eastward stare

Until Euphrates comes in sight and with

It I climb castle walls beset with myth

Until I reach the throne at last that seems

An empty one from all the gates of dreams,

And find it filled with all reality

More than I hear and more than I can see.

15 Then YHWH Alohim took the man

And put him in the Pleasure gan

To dress and keep it as he can.

They ask me, my Belovèd, what I am

And what I do for my career or scam,

And when I say that I am Truth alone

They look at me to say I can't atone.

I am would be enough I trow for me

Since I am is enough simplicity

For Your estate. But no, I must have here

Profession, title, salary, career,

Or join the loony bin. The state I'm in

I'm glad You put me here and it's no sin

To say I am a farmer, tending, keeping

The Pleasure garden for the one who's

weeping.

The only valid work there seems to be

Is keeping vine and flower and tending
tree.

16 And YHWH Alohim gave command

To Adam saying "On each hand

Of every tree set in the garden

You may eat freely *without warden*

17 "But from the tree of knowledge good

And knowledge evil know you should

Not eat, for in the day you try of it

You shall indeed and surely die of it."

You give, Beloved, the right to eat the fruit

Of every good tree and sweet thing to boot,

You give the pleasure and the obligation

Of having children to fill up the nation.

Yet you retain one thing for You alone,

A thing that irritates man to the bone.

You would not let us know the wrong from
right

For our own selves, or give us clearer sight

To make a verdict just and good about

The neighbour's actions when he fights it

out.

Instead You make the human heart rely

On You alone for what, no matter why.

You only know what's right and wrong for
us

No matter how we try and stew and fuss.

18 And YHWH Alohim said "It's not

Good that the man should be alone,

I will make him a helper *taught*

And comparable to him *full-grown*."

19 Out of the ground YHWH Alohim

Formed every wild beast of *esteem*,

And every bird that flies the air

And brought them all to Adam where

He might see what he would call them.

And in that divine stratagem

What Adam called each living creature

Became its name *and a fixed feature*.

20 So Adam gave names to all cattle,

To birds in air and each wild beast,

But Adam found he'd lost the battle

Without a helper, one *at least*

Comparable to him *increased*.

Of all the beasts who help, none there was
found

Who was compared to him brought from
the ground.

And after every name and suit was set

There still was not a soul whose fancy met

The namer's clue. The common origin

Was not enough to brighten Adam's chin.

The ecstasy of mating in one being
 Began to taste flat when they kept on
 seeing
 The animals go two by two together
 To mate on rare occasion in good weather.
 Let's see if You will answer our one prayer
 And separate our being with clean air,
 So that we may spend lives in longing,
 longing
 For that reed-bed to which the pipe's
 belonging.

21 And YHWH Alohim caused a deep
 Trance to fall on Adam, and sleep.
 He took one of his sides and closed
 The flesh up where it was exposed.
 22 Then the side which YHWH Alohim
 Had taken from the man in dream
 He made into a woman, and
 He brought her to the man *first-hand*.
 23 And Adam said "This *is* now bone
 Of my bones, *I am not alone*,
 And flesh of my flesh, she shall be
 Called woman, because truly she
 Was taken out of man." 24 Therefore
 A man shall leave his father and
 His mother and join up once more
 With his wife, and they shall *give hand*
 And become one flesh. 25 And they were
 Both naked, man and wife, *confer*
 Without shame *or to be demur*.
 [Naked, a play on words with "cunning"
 and "wise" in the following chapter].

The trance of revelation brings the knowing
 That face to face is needed for the showing
 That You, Beloved, are never far from
 here.
 From every side I look, the he and she
 Look back from mirrors always being me
 And look back always without hurt or fear.
 The trance of revelation that first brought
 The happiness in otherness I sought
 May yet bring out illusions in my sight,
 But this first moment is a blessed night.
 The wedding chemical still blurs my eyes
 To know no difference twixt nude and
 wise.
 Go on to know or then turn back to be
 One with Creator and eternity.

Genesis 3

1 But the serpent, watcher, magician,
 Was more cunning *and for sedition*,
Cunning, wise, not more naked than
 Any wild beast YHWH Alohim
 Had made. He said to the woman
 "Has Alohim said *what you dream*
 'You shall not eat of every tree
 That's in the garden'?" So then she,
 The woman said to the serpent
 "We may eat fruit the trees present
 Within the garden, but the fruit
 Of that tree, *which you may dispute*,
 Is in the middle of the garden
 Alohim said, *begging your pardon*,
 'You shall not eat nor even touch of it,
 Or you will die,' *and that's as much of it.*"
 4 The watcher said to the woman,
 "You will not surely die. 5 "The ban
 Is that Alohim knows the day
 You eat from it, then your eyes may
 Be opened and you will be like
 Exalted ones, judges *who strike*
A pose of knowing all things better,
 Both good and evil *to the letter.*"

I have not eaten of the bidden fruit
 Nor blackened hand in any sinful suit,
 Yet I know very well both right and wrong
 Whose teeth in human hide continue strong
 Wherever interest and self-interest grow.
 Just ask me, my Beloved, see if I know.
 No serpent-watcher hands me luscious
 things,
 Yet I do eat as well as queens and kings,
 At least I munch the quartered grape and
 seed
 And with the nut, I have all that I need.
 And knowing right from wrong by
 revelation,
 I guess I'm ripe for every allegation.
 I die, but You, Beloved, live on and on.
 So may I live in Your eternal dawn.

6 So when the woman saw that tree
Was good for food, and pleasantly
 Appealing to the wondering eyes,
 A tree desired to make *one* wise,
 A tree *like* Muhammad, desired,
 She took the fruit and ate, *inspired*.
 She also gave her husband *who*
Was with her, and he ate it too.
 7 Then opened were the eyes of both,

They knew their nakedness, by troth,
As opposed to their being wise,
And sewed fig leaves about their thighs.
8 And then they heard the thunder
sounding,

The voice of YHWH Alohim bounding
Throughout the garden at the breath
Of day, *at evening. Fearing death,*
Both man and wife hid from the coming
Of YHWH Alohim, *both succumbing*
To fears of Pleasure garden's breeze
As the Lord walked among the trees.

Into the garden where I hear Your voice,
Let me not hide myself, but make my
choice

To come into the gallows, give my life,
And sacrifice myself, gift without strife,
That Self may be the only One I know.
I come into the Pleasure grounds where
grow

The trees of knowledge and of life with
fruit

For all, but I prefer to taste the soot
Of sacrifice, let others have the gain.
I wait within the garden for the rain.
The joyous thunder of Your song reveals
Creation's purity and dancing reels,
And as I wait I hear Your voice come near,
And I stand trembling, waiting without
fear.

9 Then YHWH Alohim called the man,
And sang his loved name as he ran,
"Adam, Adam, where are you, man?"

If every man is Adam, You call me,
Beloved, and search through valley, bush
and tree.

Find me here where I am and never leave,
I answer Your call and I pluck Your sleeve,
Turn now, Beloved, and show Your divine
face

To everyone who waits in time and place.
Ah when Your face appears, I disappear,
And though I hide from You, it's not from
fear,

But only since by searching can be found
Your one face only from the stars to
ground.

When You call me, I only start to be,

And when You look again, You find not
me

But You alone who are the all in all.
And so I answer, though You call and call.

10 And he said "I heard Your voice in
The garden, and I feared *my sin*
Since I was naked, so I hid."

11 And He said "Who has raised the lid
Revealing you were naked, did
You eat from that tree that I told
You not to eat from, *were you bold?*

12 Then the man said "The woman whom
You gave *to be* with me, *made room*
For me beside her at the tree
And gave me fruit to eat for free."

Beloved, no man can lie to You, no fear!
The bald and simple truth must just appear
When You ask questions and demand our
fate.

You ask, and no one's answer can be late.
No plan nor thought nor any fond excuse
Is there to shift the blame, is any use.
So rare is simple truth I barely can
See that in these expressions of the man.
He merely states the woman gave the fruit.
He casts no blame, he does not aim the
boot.

Ah my Beloved, how clearly You decide
To turn from truth to truth and yet not
slide!

Create in me the truth alone and speak
Without a hidden motive in my cheek.

13 And YHWH Alohim said to her,
The woman, "What did you incur?"
The woman said "The watcher came
Deceived me *saying wise for shame*
Of nakedness. I ate, his blame."

Deceived! You gallantly accept the
woman's word.

Leave not my sinful actions undeterred!
What courage to revolt if I can blame
The passing serpent trickster for my shame!
Ah, truth takes precedence to policy.
The fact was there was trickster in the tree.
Deceived by plays on words, a naked room
Instead of insight into fruit and bloom,
And now my eyes, unveiled and open,
show

Me neither wisdom nor new life. I go
In search of love instead, since knowledge
flies
And life is dead. Now greater hopes arise,
That neither know nor live, but find in You,
Beloved, the Knowing, Living, and the
True.

14 Then YHWH Alohim *turned His gaze*
Upon the serpent, read *his ways*,
"Because you have done this, you *are*
Cursed more than cattle, more *by far*
Than wild beast of the field, and so
Upon your belly you shall go
And eat the dust of all your life.
15 And I'll put enmity *and strife*
Between you and the woman, and
Between your offspring and the hand
Of her offspring, and he shall bruise
Your head, and you his heel, *you lose*."

Beloved, which of Eve's sons had the wit
To bruise the serpent's head, whose heel
was hit
By that sharp fang that fascinated Eve
And Adam? As I read, I don't believe
I find that story there for Abel, Cain
Or Seth. The mortal dust of all has lain
In quiet in the tomb for centuries,
(No resurrections enter in here, please!)
While no one's heel is bruised and no head
aches.
And yet Your words were written for our
sakes.
The lovely Hebrew syllables require
No meaning to set heart with love on fire.
I still look round for injured heel and head
With body watered and my soul well-fed.

16 And to the woman He said "I
Will greatly multiply your cry,
And your conception will bring sorrow,
Your children will give pain tomorrow,
Your passion for your husband will
Give comfort *for your children's ill*.

With every choice there comes a divine
grace.
The woman chose the fruit and its disgrace
To know that You, Beloved, would
intervene

To tell her future and what might have
been.

The grace was just to know before the fact
That brother against brother in vile act
Would seal the fate of both, the one to die
To life, the other one to live to die. That's
why

Her great desire turned back to the one man
Whose impregnation started the wild plan.
No other comfort could assuage the pain
Born from her sons, she suffered sun and
rain.

Is it a grace indeed, Beloved, to know
The future tragedy? I don't think so.

17 To Adam He said "Because you
Have followed your wife's voice to do
The wrong thing and eat from the tree
Of which I told you 'Let it be
And do not eat,' Cursed *is* the ground
For your sake, and in toil is found
Your bread as long as you shall live.
18 Both thorns and thistles it shall give
Forth for you, like a fugitive
You shall eat the wild herb of field,
Like animals, the green leaf's yield.

My lost dominion's that I eat the herb.
My salad plate will whet but never curb
My vulture's appetite. With my wings
clipped
I've plucked bud leaf of thistle and I've
sipped
Its nectar till it seemed too sweet for more.
My punishment is grace, and grace in store.
Beloved, curse me the ground again and
give
The purple thistle and it's fruit to live,
And I shall toil my days and nights of life,
Relinquishing no peace and love for strife.
Though seed and fruit and leaf remain my
meat,
The taste of these is neither good nor sweet
Compared to fasting in Your loving
pleasure.
I lose dominion, but find You, my treasure.

19 "With face in sweat you shall eat bread
Until back to the earth you're led,
For out of the earth you were taken,
And made of *earthly* dust *forsaken*,
And to that dust you shall return,

The humble dust you shall not spurn."

Return to dust, my Love? Then let it be
That dust at first from which You fashioned
me.

My dust is dear because it felt Your hand,
Received Your breath and gained the
power to stand.

Your hand and breath could consecrate my
life.

Your hand and breath may cut me like a
knife,

But still there is no loss to self and soul.
Let dust and dust alone be my life's goal.
The hand that fashioned me must still
remain.

Return to dust can only be my gain,
As breath that once went out returns at last
Into that home where my Beloved is fast
And bound to me forever and for good.
Let dust return and be as dusty would.

20 And Adam called his wife Eve, mother
Of every living *sister, brother.*

The mother of all living, that may be,
The mother of myself, my ancestry,
And yet the formula does not quite stand.
She is herself alive and even manned
By one whose mother she is not, so three
Of living are not sons or daughters, she
Her husband and her Maker, You, Beloved.
The Scripture stands embarrassed and
ungloved.

Some read the sacred word to find the print
That's inconsistent with their dare and dint.
Some read the sacred word to justify
The things they do and find the reasons
why
The other man is wrong. Some read alone
To find the cross-starred meat and chew the
bone.

21 Also for Adam and his wife,
YHWH Alohim made them for life
Skin belts and clothed them, *that is why*
We still wear clothing, by the by.

I am too wise and full from eating fat
To go out naked in the place I'm at.
In gratitude, Beloved, I take the belt
Of skin You give to hide the shame I've felt

At my implacable disorientation.
I stand in top-hat palteau on the station
To see if any train will dare arrive
To take me back to Paradise alive.
It's only when I take my eye from skin
And cease to worry at my rate of sin
That I find rather truth both out and in.
I close my ear to worship and its din
To hear Your still small voice and see Your
light
Light up the dark caves of my heart and
sight.

22 Then YHWH Alohim said "Indeed,
The man's become like one of us,
To know good and to have no need
For one to show the evil muss.
And now, lest he put out his hand
And take also from the fruit stand,
The tree of life, and eat, and live
Forever," 23 Therefore to misgive
YHWH Alohim sent him down out
Of Pleasure garden round about
To till the ground he had come from.
24 So He drove out the man, *in sum,*
And He placed cherubim in front
Of Pleasure there to bear the brunt
With flaming sword turned every way
To guard the path to tree of life
With subtle argument of knife.

Guard not the way to living trees from me,
Beloved, I seek not leaf, nor fruit, nor tree.
I do not turn to where the bright sword
swings
Nor beat toward heaven with my impatient
wings.

I'm satisfied with earth and with its gate.
I let the guardian angel stand and wait.
I do not want to live forever there
Where shining angels stand to make the air
Ring with the wealth of universe and gold.
I covet rather daily growing old
And dying on Your breast, self turned to
You,
Self one forever in Beloved's true
Self. And so let me die today and now
And live in You alone. For that I bow.

Genesis 4

1 Now Adam lay with his wife Eve
And that's how Eve came to conceive

And gave birth first to Cain, and said
"I have acquired a man from YHWH."
2 Then she gave birth again, as led,
This time his brother Abel, who
Was keeper of the sheep, but Cain
Was tiller of the earth's domain.

Let me give reasons here and now for
better
Why Cain's the man to choose, the true go-
getter.
He was the first born and no doubt his
mother
Thought Abel was the one would kill his
brother.
He did not leave apprenticeship that You,
Beloved, appointed for all men to do,
To follow sheep. No, he remained a farmer,
And what is more to place upon his armour,
It seems he was a vegetarian,
A pacifist not to harm any man.
I guess You too were taken in by him.
You spoke to Cain, while You and
cherubim
Said not a word of warning to poor Abel.
The prophet is not always the best label.

3 As time went on it came about
When Cain had brought an offering out
To YHWH made of fruit of the ground,
4 That Abel brought *one good and sound*,
Firstborn of flock, and of their fat.
YHWH had respect for Abel that
Brought his offering, 5 but He had none
For Cain *when his offering was done*.
So Cain was very angry then
And that's why his face fell again.

You did not give command to sacrifice,
But these two did not think about it twice.
They brought an offering each one of his
wares,
And by that gift they thought to climb the
stairs
To paradise and stop before its gates
Where cherub with a flaming sword awaits.
Each gift was perfect in its right and each
Conformed to that law Moses came to
preach.
You favoured one, the other cast aside,
And so religious strife began the tide

Of bloodshed that still haunts the faded
earth.
Each brings a different sacrifice of worth,
And brother kills his brother in Your name,
And follows on the self-indulgent game.

6 So YHWH said to Cain, "Why are you
Angry? And why's your face downcast?
7 "If you do well, then won't you too
Be one accepted? And at last
If you do not well, sin lies at
The door. To you it's passion that
You ought to overcome by trying,
Unless you prefer loss and dying."

My heart is angry when I see the grace
You give to others in this earthly place.
No sacrifice can please You, that I know,
No thing that man can do will ever show
A great advantage here before Your throne.
Each one must stand in judgement there
alone
Without a lamb or blood or fruit or bread,
And give account for what he's done and
said.

No use to see the other's jealous eye,
Since there's no sacrifice to meet the sky.
The only thing that counts, Beloved, with
You,
Is making just and right the things we do.
If not, it's sin that's lying at the door,
And offering is no better than before.

8 Now Cain talked with his brother Abel,
And then it happened, *not in fable*,
When they were in the field, that Cain
Rose up against his brother. *Vain*
Were Abel's struggles, he was slain.

Three things are to avoid, first not to talk,
Then not to have a brother, not to walk
Alone in fields, at least not when the other
Has talked a while and claimed to be a
brother.

It is the good and great in their own sight,
The ones who know they only have the
right
To oil and gold and power because they are
So infinitely worthier by far,
Who come to blows against the one who
seems

To block the shortest way to oil pipe
dreams.
It is the favoured ones, the one's God's
given
The chance to rule and own, the ones
who've striven
To better self and theirs who strike down
dead.
Beloved, I'm too among the better fed.

9 Then YHWH asked Cain, "Where *is* your
brother
Abel?" He said "I do not know.
Am I my brother's keeper, *mother?*"
10 And He said "*What is this you show?*
What have you done? Your brother's blood
Lifts up its voice *where like a flood*
Upon the ground it calls to Me.
11 "So now you *are* cursed from the earth,
Which opened up its mouth to be
Receiver of your brother's *birth*
Blood from your hand *as of no worth*.
12 "When you shall till the ground, no
longer
Shall it yield to you strength or stronger.
A fugitive and vagabond
You shall be on the earth beyond."

Though You speak not to Abel, Abel's
blood
Cries out to You, soaked earth like in a
flood.
There's only Cain now that You can
address,
And so You speak to him to curse and
bless.
The blessing is You take away the trade
He had so fondly kept, and keeping made
Himself seem to obey Your brave
command
To tend and keep the soil with tender hand.
You strike indeed what he loves best and
that
Is blessing sure for future habitat,
And punishment. You always give the
choice
Of blessing or of punishment. The voice
Is man's to utter which he will. I take
The blessing, my Beloved, for Abel's sake.

13 Cain said to YHWH, "My punishment
Is more to bear *than I had meant!*

14 "You surely drive me out today,
Out from the land where I would stay,
I shall be hidden from Your face,
A fugitive in every place,
And vagabond upon the earth,
And there will not be any dearth
Of those to find and kill me there.
Do You really think that is fair?"
15 And YHWH said to him, "Therefore,
who
Kills Cain, vengeance of seven is due."
YHWH set a mark on Cain, lest one
Should find and kill him *on the run*.

Cain fears that he who finds him in the
field
Will rise to kill him. Each man's tasks so
yield
The fruit of hope and fear as it may be.
What I have done returns oft to haunt me.
Appeal of hope, and after all the slaying,
You still, Beloved, address him no
delaying.
You speak to him who killed his brother
but
You leave the just and good to wonder
what.
Yet Cain is still the slave of his own fear
No matter what You say, what You hold
dear.
You mark him out with love, so no one can
Kill him in vengeance for his crime to man.
Mark me too, my Beloved, despite my
crime
In thought, in act and word, and last in
rhyme.

16 Then Cain went out from YHWH's
presence
And lived in Nod, before Pleasure,
The land of Farting, to commence
17 To know his wife in *fullest measure*,
And she conceived and birthed Enoch.
Cain built a city *out of rock*
And named after his son Enoch.
18 To Enoch there was born Irad,
Mehujael's the son he had,
The next in line Methushael
Who sired Lamech, *a man from hell*.

You gave, Beloved, the task to humankind,
Profession and career that he should mind

The earth and till it for its fruit and glory.
But what result is this in Enoch's story?
His father Cain lost the one good
profession

That You approve, and so by Your
confession

It's not his fault if he goes on to build
A city and to found a mason's guild.
Initiating his son into sin

Was what gave him the head-start then to
win.

If we judge things by reputation of
Inventors, then the city's not above
The evil lust and passion of Cain's crime.
As such Manhattan is not worth a dime.

19 Then Lamech took himself two wives:

The name of the first *was* Adah,
Then Zillah too, *the name survives*.

20 'Adorned' gave birth to Jabal, ah,
The father-patron of tent-dweller,
And cattle-breeding, *an exceller*.

21 His brother's name was Jubal, he
Was father-patron of *the free*
Who play the harp and flute. 22 And as

For 'Her Shadow' she also was
A mother, first to Tubal-Cain,
Father-instructor to the strain
Of craftsman in iron and in bronze.
Tubal-Cain's sister, *for by-gones*
Was named Naamah, a pleasant soul,
All civilized to reach their goal.

Ah, new professions of an evil breed
Enhance the world of passion, lust and
greed!

The tent-maker and livestock breeder are
The children of a murderer, the star
Of crime. While Rome burns Jubal plays a
flute

And Caesar's violin is heard to boot.
And metal-work is needed to make locks
And weapons to protect the shipping docks.
Let me go back to Adam's dibble stick
And burn no candle but the inner wick
Of my own rock-hewn, dusky, chambered
heart.

To love You, my Belovèd, be my art,
And my craft be to cantillate Your name
Rejecting Cain's brood and their irony
fame.

23 Then Lamech piped up to his wives:

"Adah and Zillah, hear my voice,
Wives of Lamech, my speech contrives,
Hear how I've killed a man *of choice*
For wounding me, and for my hurt,
A young man *I could not avert*.

24 If Cain shall be avenged for seven
Then seventy-seven is Lamech's heaven."

Who killed a man before appointed prime
And took his name was the first man in
time

To take a second wife. Let that be fair
And warning that the origins are there:
Polygamy for vaunted lawfulness
Is brother to the boasting crime and mess
Of violence and murder. Lamech would
Appropriate the mark on Cain that should
Protect him from th' avenger. Lamech

boasts
Ten times the vengeance, in his pride he
toasts

His evil deeds as deeds of divine blessing.
Beloved, put on our wounded hands a
dressing,

And wake the human soul to know her way
Of violence and lust has gone astray.

25 And Adam knew his wife again,
And she gave birth, *man among men*,
A son named Seth, for she decreed
"Appointed as another seed
Alohim has given me instead
Of Abel, killed by Cain, *who fled*."

26 And as for Seth, to him also
A son was born, a name to know
As Enosh. So they then began
To call or cantillate *by plan*
The name of YHWH *for partisan*.

Let others fight the fight of faith and go
To battle and the march, let others show
Their strength and willingness, I stay to
fight

The peaceful battle of the day and night.
I follow, breath to breath, Your lovely
name,

I hear its sounds and syllables. No shame
Bear I who am not civilized nor couth.
No shame have I who merely grasp the
Truth.

Al-Haqq, Al-Haqq my beating pulse repeats.

I have no other miracles or feats
Of faqir or of dervish dance and whirling.
I count no alms in carets gold or sterling.
I join the growing grass in whisper shout
Allah Allah and Huu and turn about.

Genesis 5

1 This is the line *of faith* that takes
From Adam . Now Alohim makes
The man according to His plan.
2 He thus created them, both man
And female, blessed them, and began
To call them humankind when they
Were first created, on that day.
3 And Adam lived one hundred years
And thirty more, *those years of tears*,
Then sired in his own likeness one
In his own shape, named Seth, his son.
4 After Seth's birth Adam lived on
Eight hundred years, he lived to spawn
More sons and daughters. 5 All the days
That Adam lived, (*it may amaze*),
Were nine hundred and thirty years,
And then he died. 6 Seth, *it appears*,
He lived one hundred and five years,
Then sired Enosh. 7 After he sired
Enosh, Seth lived, *loved and admired*
Eight hundred years and seven, and had
Both sons and daughters, *not too bad*.
8 So all the days of Seth amounted
To nine hundred and twelve years *counted*,
And then he died. 9 Enosh lived on
For ninety years, and sired Cainan.
10 After the birth of Cainan, he,
Enosh, lived eight hundred, *let's see*,
And fifteen years, had sons and daughters.
11 So all the days, *my seals and otters*,
Of Enosh were nine hundred and
Five years, and he died, *understand*.
12 Cainan lived seventy years, and then
Produced Mahalalel. 13 *Say men*
After Mahalalel was born,
Cainan lived eight hundred, *both morn*
And eve, plus forty years, and had
Sons, daughters too, again, *not bad*.
14 So all the days of Cainan were
Nine hundred and ten years, *aver*
That he died *too*. 15 Mahalalel
Lived sixty-five years *to an ell*,
And sired Jared. 16 After the swell

Sired Jared, then Mahalalel
Lived eight hundred, *if truth to tell*,
And thirty years, and he had sons
And daughters too. 17 So all his *funds*
Were eight hundred and ninety-five
Years, he died *and was not alive*.
18 Jared lived one hundred and two
Plus sixty years, and had a boy
Named Enoch, *which he counted joy*.
19 And after Jared had sired him,
Jared lived *like the cherubim*
Eight hundred years, and had both sons
And daughters. 20 So the length of life
Of Jared was nine hundred *rife*
And sixty-two years, and he died
With all the honours that implied.

I Jared give my son the name that Cain
Gave to his firstborn, though I'm sound and
sane.
The first Enoch was an initiate
Into the urban veil of sin and hate,
While this my son I dedicate to You
To find bucolic sense in flower and dew,
Initiated in the whirling of
Your lovely name and in Your tender love.
I Jared give my son the name that cursed
The world with city-life and with its worst,
That a new Enoch might come in his place
And start a new page and a faithful race.
I Jared give my son to You for life
And pray that he will stop the blood and
strife.

21 Then Enoch lived sixty-five years,
And sired Methuselah. 22 *One hears*
After he sired Methuselah,
Then Enoch walked around in *awe*
With Alohim three hundred years,
Had sons and daughters *without tears*.
23 So all the years of Enoch were
Three hundred sixty-five *and sure*.

Enoch, initiate, the seventh son
From Adam whirled the flaming gates and
won.
His secrets are not known to any but
The few who read the hidden words and
what
Is written in his book. The number of
His years is made of one year or above
By an eternal day. Three hundred years

Sufficed to whirl to heaven without fears.
Let me, Belovèd, whirl for one brief day
And find myself on earth, on earth to stay
Within the gate of truth where I may meet
The blessed Enoch, study at his feet,
And see beyond the veils to where You
stand
Beside my stomach, near my tongue and
hand.

24 And Enoch walked with Alohim,
And he *was* not, but *as in dream*
Alohim took him, *coat and seam*.

Take me too, my Beloved, I would not be.
That's why I walk and whirl eternally,
Neglect my living and my earthly host
To find by whirling I am with my Dost.
Take me too, my Beloved, I would not
speak
Another syllable, but Your name seek
In every word I say. Let me return
And in confession's love, oh let me burn.
Take me too, my Beloved, I would not fear
The sounds of strife that daily strike my
ear.

I turn the hammer strokes to melody,
The copper kettles to eternity.
Take me too, my Beloved, I walk with You
This gallows floor, let all my days be few.

25 Methuselah lived one hundred
And eighty-seven years, *it's said*,
And then sired Lamech. 26 After that,
Methuselah lived *where he sat*
Seven hundred and eighty-two,
Had sons and daughters, *not a few*.
27 The length of Methuselah's life
Was nine hundred years *done in strife*
And sixty-nine to end his life.

O my Beloved, why did you tell Enoch
To name his son Methuselah? What stock
Should any take in that the while? Why
should
The people stop to think? I doubt they
would
Or did. So it shall come upon his death?
Beloved, You surely know why you give
breath
To one for centuries and then to one
To die in childhood before life's begun.

What is it that should come the year that he
Will die? Your mercy lies here openly.
You make him live longer than other men
So that the Flood should not be seen till
then.

I think my knowing of hate would have
left,
Had I been You, his parents grieved, bereft.

28 Then Lamech lived one hundred and
Eighty-two years, and was well-manned
With one son, 29 "Noah known by name,"
He said "Will comfort in our *game*
Of work and toil because the ground
That YHWH has cursed *is spread around*."
30 After the birth of Noah, then
Lamech lived five hundred and when
Ninety-five more years passed, he got
Both sons and daughters *for his plot*.
31 So all the life of Lamech was
Seven hundred seventy-seven years,
And then he died. 32 And so that does
Leave Noah five hundred years old
With Shem, Ham, Japheth, sons all told.

What comfort has the baby Noah brought
To those who toil and work upon the
ground?

Methuselah lived a long life and sought
The way to heaven, while Enoch whirled
around

And walked with God. And Lamech was a
fighter.

What comfort needed they? Their lives
were filled.

Could Noah make their balanced burdens
lighter?

I think not, since it seems that Lamech's
killed

While still a youth of seven hundred years.
And even Noah was mere youngster when
His father died. Poor orphan, caught by
fears

Of violence and what the earth was then.
The comfort of a day is often long
In coming, whether Noah's weak or strong.

Genesis 6

1 It happened, when men once began
To multiply upon the earth,
And daughters were brought forth by man,
2 That sons of Alohim, *that is*,

*The heavenly watchers that were His
Devoted servants, saw that beauty
Was more marked in those girls than duty,
And took wives from the daughters of
Men, all they chose to take and love.*

Genetic engineering's no new thing.
The watchers of creation, wondering,
Decided that experiment would be
The better part of angel destiny.
The products of their meddling fingers
were
The children of the chosen for their fur.
As humankind were given trees to tend
And berry-bushes stretching without end,
The angels too decide to plant and grow
New combinations in genetic row.
No doubt, Beloved, they thought
experiment
Was beautiful no matter where it went.
Creation went on splintering away
To prove that You are one at least today.

3 And YHWH said "Now My Spirit shall
Not strive with man forever, all
He is indeed is flesh, and yet
Six scores of years *I shall forget.*"

You gave the world and angels Your fair
warning
That You would not put up with grief and
scorning.
The problem with mankind was merely
flesh
That could be moulded in an awful mesh,
And was, it seems, resulting in a mess
Of violence. Probation to confess,
One hundred twenty years, and then the
flood
Should put an end to shedding of the blood.
I doubt that I have got such time since now
My hair is grey above a wrinkled brow.
Let Your mind then, Belovèd, strive with
me
For those few years remaining on my tree.
I too am flesh, though not yet violent.
Strive still with me till every veil is rent.

4 In those days there were fallen ones
Or giants on the earth *in tons*,
And also afterward when those,
The sons of Alohim, once chose

To lie with daughters of men, they
Bore mighty men of ancient day,
Men of renown. 5 And then YHWH saw
Man's wickedness was great *for awe*,
And every intent of his heart
Was only evil *from the start*.

The products of genetic engineering
Were giants strong and mighty, nothing
fearing,
Men of renown and mighty men of old.
Their intellects leave moderns in the cold.
Their thoughts and plans were lofty ones
and bold.
Yet evil only marked their course of
thought,
And evil only came from hands so taught.
It is no wonder that You killed the lot.
If any hand devised ancestry's code
On my behalf, that must have been Your
load.
Thus I am better than those giants were
If in me genes and godly plans concur.
Plant in my heart Your thoughts, the
thoughts of good,
And I shall fly in thought by field and
wood.

6 When YHWH took comfort that He'd
made
Man on the earth, His grieved heart stayed.

O changeless One, Beloved, I seek that
heart
That can be grieved. If grieving be my part,
Then grieve on, my Beloved, let comfort
come
When You and I make up a single sum.
Take comfort, my Beloved, in me as then
When You chose Noah from among all
men.
The earth may be a place of strife, and yet
The earth is highest gate, both dry and wet.
Creator, see not wickedness arise
From my hands like the iridescent flies
That feed on fecal faith. Take comfort,
Lord.
Let my hand be the one to grasp the sword
Of peace. In peace let me repeat Your name
While others play at violence and game.

7 So YHWH said "I will destroy man

Whom I've created and lay ban
Upon the earth, for man and beast,
And creeping creature from the least
Up to the birds that fly in air,
I'm sorry that I made them there.

The fondest question is why did You make
A world where man and bird and beast
could take

The road towards destruction and worse
still

To violence on other creatures' will.
You cannot rub it out and say that You
Did not get it just right, once more will do.
The infinite in power, omniscient mind
Preclude creating monsters in a blind.
It does not wash to blame celestial sons
For what You knew beforehand of their
guns.

It does not wash to say You're sorry either,
Or that You merely had to take a breather.
Beloved Creator and Destroyer I
Look all about the crowded earth and sky.

8 But Noah, *man of God*, found grace
In eyes of YHWH *and every place*.

Week 2

9 This is the line of faith of Noah.
A just man living *before Shoah*,
Perfect in all his generations.
Noah walked in Alohims' stations.
10 And Noah sired three sons: Shem, Ham,
And Japheth, *names in cryptogram*.

How did the blessed Noah find grace in
Your sight, Beloved, instead of cherished
sin?

The first thing was his genealogy,
The line of faith to Eve and Adam's tree.
The second was that he was just, the third
That he was perfect, while the gracious
word

Of the fourth gate was that he walked with
You.

Let me too find grace in the things I do,
As I lay hold upon the faith of him
Who kept the burning light that had grown
dim.

I take the gate of righteously transmitted
Divine law, and the gate of justice fitted
Into the gate of Your perfection till

I walk with You like Noah in Your will.

11 The earth was spoiled also before
Alohim, and was filled with gore.

12 So Alohims looked on the earth,
Indeed it was spoiled of its worth,
For all flesh had spoiled their own way
Upon the earth *and every day*.

13 And Alohims told Noah, saying
"The end of all flesh comes for paying
Before Me, for the earth is filled
With violence through those who've killed,
Indeed I shall destroy them all
All flesh and all the earthly ball."

For violence and not for love the Flood
Came on the earth, for violence and blood.
All flesh corrupts its way and takes a stand
To battle with the flashing sword in hand.
Destruction bears its own destroying seeds,
And slaying hands decay to useless weeds.
There is but One eternal to be sung,
Your name, Beloved, is first and final rung.
The end of all flesh comes before Your

face,
All things return to You and find their
place.

I here relinquish all my striving will
And stop the sword and make the harrow
still.

I quietly destroy all things but You,
And find behind all forms the One and
True.

14 "So make yourself an ark of wood,
Of gopherwood, make rooms as good
Within the ark, and cover it
Inside and out with pitch to fit.

15 "And this is how you shall make it:
Three hundred arm-lengths for the ark,
And fifty wide, and thirty high.

16 You shall make a light for the bark,
The Zohar one arm-length apply
Above, and set the door in place
In the ark's side above the base
Of three decks made *for breathing-space*.

You told the prophet when he made the ark
To make a light to penetrate the dark.
Beloved, You must have told him how it's
done,

And with what magic tools and skills
begun,
And what ingredients concocted well
Produce the mystic Zohar's sentinel.
I only know it is a thing above,
In breadth an arm-length, but the usage of
This window on eternity and You
Escapes my powers and knowledge.

Beloved, do
Whisper the secrets of its powers to me,
Light, light has always been a mystery.
Within this darkened ark I turn my face
Toward Your light, perchance it is an ace.

17 "Indeed, I, I Myself am bringing
Floodwaters on the earth, and springing
Surprise destruction under heaven
On all flesh living, breathing here,
All creatures from both whales to leaven,
Upon the earth shall die *in fear*.

The gate of water opens wide its doors
Inviting dance upon the crystal floors
Of seas of glass. I enter and I know
What eating bidden fruit could never show.
A whirling waterspout, I motionless
Regard the universe and its caress.
I know You for Yourself when breathing
fails

Beneath the tiding waters and their gales.
Baptisms follow wave on drowning wave
And carry all things living to their grave.
But in the soul's destruction hour there is
A moment when life's neither hers nor his,
But clarity dawns for a fleeting spark
And I return to dance around the park.

18 "But I will make a pact with you,
And you shall go into the ark,
You and your sons, your wife, shall do,
And your sons' wives, shall all embark.

19 "And of each living thing of all
Flesh you shall bring two *at a call*
Of every *sort* into the ark,
To keep *them* safely *in the dark*
Alive with you, and they shall sport
Among both male and female sort.
20 "And of the birds after their kind,
Of animals duly resigned,
Of every creeping thing on earth
After its kind and counted worth,
Two of each sort come *to the hive*

For you to keep them all alive.
21 "And you shall take both for yourself
And for them food *upon the shelf*
All that is eaten gather in
For you and them in bale and bin."
22 Thus Noah did, according to
What Alohim told him to do.

Beloved, it seems You left to Noah all
The work involved, You just extend the
call.

He had to convince sons and wives to go
Inside the ark with tales of rain to show
A miracle unheard of, then convince
The animals to come in also since
A flood was coming fast, and after that
Talk birds to come in where the docile sat.
Not any two would do but he should get
A mated pair of each and their food set
In store. It seems the simpler part to bring
A flood on all the earth. No wonder king
And commoner failed to respond. He had
No time for preaching to wicked and bad.

Genesis 7

1 And then YHWH said to Noah, "Come
Into the ark, you and in sum
All your household, because I've seen
You're just before Me and have been.

See me too, my Beloved, that I may be
One righteous in this generation, see!
Your act of seeing is the power that
Makes good of evil and makes lean of fat.
I choose creative action from Your eye
And choosing so, I choose the righteous
die.

I cast no dice below Fortuna's face,
But lay my fate beneath the gazing mace
That crushes dross and lays the statue bare.
See into being righteous, good and fair.
So there shall be no I-ness in my breast,
No self existing in the east or west,
But only You will be my I's command,
My eye be Yours, and Yours too be my
hand.

2 "You shall take with you seven of each,
Of every clean beast, male and peach,
Two each of animals unclean,
One buck and with each one his queen,
3 "Also seven each of birds of air,

Male and female, to keep them there
The species live on all the earth,
Each original for its worth.

4 "In seven days I shall bring rain
In forty days and nights ordain
Destruction of all living on
The earth I've made *from mastodon*
To sheep and ox and calling crane."

Seven of clean in seven days You teach
To enter in the ark no man can reach
Without Your guidance. Seven pairs of
clean

In secret walk the plank and are not seen
Again beneath the faithful course of sun
Until the cleansing water flood is done.
Bring to the secret places of my soul,
The inner temple chamber of my whole,
The fourteen innocent ones in their pairs
To teach their mystic doctrine unawares.
Come enter in my thinking and my being,
And sanctify my seventh sense of seeing,
That from the seven councils' purity
The visions of Your oneness come to me.

5 And Noah did what he was told
By YHWH, *both he and his household.*
6 Six hundred years was Noah's age
On earth when it came to flood stage.

You breathe out once and earth sprouts
living things
That stay to blossom once and reign like
kings
And then to perish as You draw Your
breath
Once more back to Yourself. The end is
death
And dark destruction for both man and
beast,
For all things from the greatest to the least.
So You destroy and remake all the earth
As with Your breath all things receive their
worth.

Breathe on me too for seven days and then
Let me return to You as must all men.
For forty days the world is bathed in light,
And with the forty alternates the night.
Beloved, I seek the gentle rising of
Your sleepless wonder and returning love.

7 So Noah, with his sons, his wife,

And his sons' wives, went in the ark
Each one went in to save his life
From flood *and thunder, rain and dark.*
8 Clean animals, and the unclean,
And birds and everything that's seen
Moving on land, 9 went two by two
To Noah in the ark, so few,
Just male and female of each kind
As Alohim made Noah mind.
10 It happened after seven days
A flood was on the earth *in haze.*

You told the blessed Noah what to take
Into the ark, but nowhere do You make
It clear what animals are clean and which
Are not. I think I would have found a glitch
In regulations as I tried to count
The pairs of clean and unclean's right
amount.

I thank You that Your guidance right and
straight
Has not left ancient man to fortune's fate,
But every prophet knew without the Book
The law of good and evil acts, the look
Of clean and unclean thing. Then let the
sound

Of truths that rang in blessed Noah's bound
Guide me too as I enter in the ark,
With clean and unclean things when I
embark.

11 The year six hundred in the days
Of Noah, saw the fountains raise,
The second month, day seventeen,
The deep broke up, and there were seen
The heavenly windows opened 12 till
For forty days and nights rains spill.

Rain on my heart for forty days and nights
To drown all violence and set to rights
The word and flame that guide my
wandering way
Along the strange paths of the night and
day.

O my Beloved, what brightness is the cloud
That overshadows earth and sea with loud
And pounding thunders! Some may ask a
firm

And rocky refuge, I am glad to worm
My way into a rocking, running boat
Before a raging storm, driven to float

At chance and luck it seems from east to west.
Your will, though random motion, is the best.
For all the seeming of the wind and rage
I know Your guidance does not miss the gauge.

13 On one day Noah and his sons,
Shem, Ham, and Japheth, they're the ones,
And Noah's wife, the three sons' wives
Came in the ark to save their lives.

14 They and each beast after its kind,
All cattle in each sort designed,
And every creeping thing that creeps
On earth and to its kindred keeps,
And every bird of every feather
Each of its kind *and kind of weather*.

15 And they went in the ark by twos
To Noah, all flesh not to lose
The breath of life *which is their dues*.

16 So those that entered, spouse and male,
Went as commanded, without fail,
By Alohim, YHWH shut the gaol.

My preaching days are over and no more
Than eight have entered in, and not a score,
Despite my frantic Bible thumping. My
Charisma does not seem to make the sky.
The dumb beasts favour homilies of mine
More than the churchly, even the wild
swine.

One chased me as a child once in the wood,
His back not grazing toes where as I could
I grasped and hung on grape vine on the
bank

Of one dark algae-covered stream and dank
Weed growth. The wild pig has but little
smell.

I wonder, my Beloved, if pigs did well
To enter in the ark, if just one pair.
If so, what did the humans do for air?

17 The flood is on earth forty days.

The waters increase and upraise
The ark to float high over earth

18 The waters increased much in worth
And volume where the ark still floated,
Both safe and sound, fully devoted.

19 The waters rose and rose until
They covered every *slumbering* hill,
High under heaven. 20 The waters rose

Fifteen arm-lengths then to repose
Upon the mountains that were covered,
On earth no hill left undiscovered.

For forty years times three the wicked
waited

Then rain for forty days fell unabated,
And forty days the waters were assuaged,
While forty days on Sinai You engaged
The prophet Moses, Israel wandered long
The wilderness for forty years, no song
Nor meat came on Elijah's lips for those
Long days and nights of forty that he chose
To spend on Horeb, praying there and
fasting,

While Nineveh spent forty days contrasting
In revelry before repenting well.

The forties pass four gates before they tell
The secret of dividing grape in forty
For forty saints preoccupied and warty.

21 And all flesh that moved on earth died:
The birds and cattle alongside
The beasts and every creeping thing
That creeps on earth, and man *and king*.

22 All in whose nostrils *was* the breath
Of the life spirit, all met death.

23 So He destroyed all living things
On the dry ground, *with feet or wings*,
Men, cattle, creeping creature, bird,
Were all on earth destroyed, interred.

But only Noah and those who
Were with him in the ark stayed true.

24 While water remained on the land
One hundred fifty days unscanned.

The dry and violent earth of my heart
Needs water pacifying. Slay the part
In me, the beastly, cattly, fowly lust
That goes its own way when I ought to
trust.

Let only that true spirit that entranced
The soul of blessed Noah and enhanced
The darkness of his journey stay alive
In me. I rise upon the waters, dive
And rise again. My wooden rafters
shudder.

A cow, in plaintive mooing, shrinks at
udder.

None yet have learned to drink the milk or
eat

The richly roasted and the savoury meat.

I ride the fine destructive waves of grace
Until I come at last to see Your face.

Genesis 8

1 To Alohim there came to mind
That Noah and each living kind
Remained alive within the ark.
And Alohim made wind to pass
Upon the earth, above flood mark.
The waters decreased then en masse.

Ah my Beloved, my tongue remembers
You

So often that my sleeping heart does too.
I whisper day and night Your lovely name,
And cantillate aloud each week the same.
Remembrance is the only faith I know,
And I remember You as my hours go.
Draw near, Beloved, and as in Noah's time,
Remember me, and give me words in
rhyme

To praise Your lovely name with all my
hours.

In truth my only being is the powers
Within Your whispered word creating me
From moment into moment secretly.
You are, though I should fail to speak Your
fame.

I only am because You know my name.

2 The fountains of the deep were stopped
The heavenly windows' gates were
dropped,

The rain from heaven at last restrained,

3 The flood receded, waters reined.

After the hundred fifty days

The flood had entered its last phase.

4 The seventh month, day seventeen

The floating ark at last was seen

To land on hills of Ararat.

5 And the waters decreased until

The tenth month, and the tenth of that,

Were seen the tops of highest hill.

I crave Your rains, Beloved, stop up no
deep

Beneath my feet nor heavenly windows
keep

From flowing unrestrained! Bless me once
more

With all the waters, snows and dews in
store!

Receding flood, I settle on the heights
Of Ararat to watch the brilliant lights
Newly disclosed since You have opened
heaven.

I count the awesome stations up to seven.
Before, the veils of firmament between
My face and Yours kept glory hid, unseen.
After destruction of myself the sky
Is open wide, infinities pass by.
I gaze now undeterred on Self alone,
A galaxy in light before unknown.

6 It happened, after forty days,
That Noah opened up *ablaze*
The window of the ark he'd made,

7 Then sent a raven out, which stayed
In flight above receding sea
Until the winds had dried the lea.

8 He sent a dove also to see
If all the waters had receded
To leave the dry ground *unimpeded*.

9 But there was not a resting space
Where dove could put her foot in place,
So she returned into the ark,
Since water covered all *the park*,
And he put out his hand and took
Her in the ark *to her own nook*.

Remember, Lord of earth and sky, that I
Eternally spread tiring wings above
Seas stretching endlessly beneath the sky,
That I, despite my task, am but a dove.
Faint on the waiting watches of the night,
Oppressed by bending heads of false
messiahs,

Rose red above the sea-sun's signal-light,
How long must I reject the open, pious
Eyes of this world's hypocrisy, and wait?
Remember, Lord of sea and fish, that birds
Found rest and haven at the open gate
Of the sixth day. Make cease the wind and
words.

Out of long noon and night create a jinn
To open up his heart and take me in.

10 He waited yet another while
To send the dove out *for a mile*
Around the ark. 11 The dove came back
At evening to him with *a pack*,
A fresh-plucked olive leaf *in tow*,
Stuck in her beak, and that would show
To Noah that the waters had

Receded from earth. *He was glad.*
12 He waited still another piece,
For seven days more, then to release
The dove again. This time the bird
Did not return. *It might have erred.*

The holy spirit is not one to beckon,
Nor does it come whenever I may reckon,
But finds its way across the desert air,
Dips to taste wonders that lie everywhere
Beneath its glowing wings, and then is
gone.

So does it go at dusk and come at dawn.
The only gift Your spirit gives to me
Is just a single leaf from olive tree.
And yet that leaf reveals the secrets of
The cosmic journeys and the ways above
My earthly sight. The heavenly touch of
bird

Renews the world, and makes earth at Your
word
Return to pristine loveliness uprising
From its baptismal watering's devising.

13 The year six hundred one, the first
Month and first day it seems *the worst*
Was over, and the water dried
Up from the earth, so Noah lifted
The covering off the ark and shifted
His gaze and saw dry earth beside.
14 The second month, day twenty-seven
The earth was dry *and clear and even.*
15 Then Alohim told Noah, saying
16 "Exit the ark, *why are you staying?*
Go out, both you, your wife and sons
And your sons' wives with benisons.

With animal and creeping thing I peep
Out of the ark to see what rocky, steep
And shining mountains water has created
Since wind and storm and flood have now
abated.

The silence of the new and unbreathed air
Is broken by the raven's calling there.
I and the hedgehog sniff and nose short-
sighted

Upon the daylight, ready, if affrighted,
To seek the further shadows of the ark.
My safety has within a year made dark
A haven. Now I learn as never then
To test the new and light for bogeymen.

The coast is clear. We both come out to
frolic,
Forgetting times and spaces melancholic.

17 "Bring out with you each living thing
Of all flesh with you *on a string*:
Both birds and cattle, every creeper
To move on earth *that's been made steeper.*
Be fruitful, multiply and keep her."
18 So Noah went out, and his sons
His wife and his sons' wives, *no nuns.*
19 And every beast, creeper, and bird,
Whatever moved, *or flew, or stirred,*
Their families *and all their kin*
Went out the ark *they had been in.*

The soul comes first with fish according to
The divine word vouchsafed to the fine
few,
And thus I learn humility before
The host of heaven and earth and what is
more

Before my Self. Now here I find the fact
That families are not a human act,
But are the property of creeping thing.
It is not only humans can be king.
The creeping families come out of ark
Spread out in fur and scale around the park,
On four legs and on six and even eight,
And set up households with a curious mate.
Beloved, who sets each creature's family,
You have a home hearth waiting here in
me.

20 Then Noah built a place of slaughter
When they at last had conquered water,
To sacrifice to YHWH clean beast
Of every sort, and bird, at least
The clean of those, and burnt them on
The altar. 21 YHWH, in orison,
Smelled sweet aroma. So He said,
Said YHWH within His heart *and head*,
"Never shall I curse anymore
The ground for man's sake as before,
Since every thought that comes to mind
Of man is evil from his youth,
So now I am at last resigned
Not to destroy life more *in truth.*

22 "While earth remains, seedtime *for*
planting
And harvest, cold and heat, *I'm granting,*
And summer's *light* and winter's *peace,*

And day and night shall never cease."

Smell, my Beloved, aromas sweet and pure,
Though that breath by which I speak is not
sure,

And often reeks of garlic and the stench
That age imposes, yet from my marked
bench

I raise a sacrifice that's living still.

From breath to breath my sacrifices will
Ascend and hope to find Your saving grace
Until my body is acquired for space
Upon the gallows floor for one last turn
Before it's set alight and made to burn.
Despite the low imaginations of
My simple heart, make it a heart of love,
While my days cold and hot continue here,
And my nights sleep or wake without a
fear.

Genesis 9

1 So Alohim blessed Noah and
His sons, and made them understand:

"Be fruitful then and multiply,
And fill the earth too *by and by*.

2 "The fear of you, your dread as well,
Shall be on earthly beast, *compel*
The birds *to flight* in air, the cattle
To move upon the earth *for battle*,
And even fish within the sea
Are in your hand, *not to be free*.

3 "And every moving thing among
The *clean* beasts *from the ark* is *strung*
Up for you to be food. All these
I give, as green leaf herbs, *to please*.

4 "But you shall not eat any meat
Containing blood, its life, replete.

The gate of earth, the gate of truth gave me
Dominion to eat fruit from every tree.
The gate of fire a-burning in my breast
Gave tree of life, and made of me the guest
Of every diet but the fruit of knowing
For me myself the right and wrong of
going.

The gate of water gave to humankind
The thorn and thistle with the leaf and rind.
And now the gate of air, if all else fails
Gives pounds of flesh to eat upon the
scales.

I flee toward earth to satisfy the pain
Of hunger in the soul, in truth I gain

A nutmeat sweeter than I dreamed in air
To find You, my Beloved, abiding there.

5 "Surely for your lifeblood I will
Demand a *reckoning*, and still
From every beast I shall require it,
And from the hand of man desire it.

And from the brother of each one
I shall require the life when done.

6 "Whoever sheds man's blood, by man
His blood shall be shed *if one can*,
For in image of Alohim
He made man *both to be and dream*.

7 And as for you, be fruitful and
Become abundantly a band
Upon the earth and multiply
Until you fill earth by and by."

Beloved, require the vengeance of my life
That I have lost in this illusion's strife.
Must I eat meat and thus lift hand to kill
While there is oxen's grass enough to fill
Both oxen's bellies and the paunch of man?
I shall eat green grass if that's all I can.

But why should I eat grass when there is
fruit,
And nuts abound, and ripened grain to
boot?

Give me rightful dominion on this earth
And I shall crack the nut for all it's worth.
But if I find the wilderness of flood
I shall tread water and not drink the blood,
Nor slay the unclean thing to quench my
thirst

And eat the roasted lamb until I burst.

8 Alohim told Noah and sons
With him, saying 9 "And as for Me,
Indeed, I form, *and without guns*,
My pact with you, your progeny,
10 "And every living creature here:
The birds, the cattle, every beast
That walks the earth or does appear,
That go out of the ark from least
To greatest, every single beast.

11 "Thus I make my pact with you now,
I shall not cut off anyhow
All flesh again by means of flood
Of water, *rain or hail or mud*,
Never again shall there be such
A thing to do the earth so much."

The church of God is made of men and
 their
 Descendants, born and yet unborn. Despair
 Not every living creature, woman too,
 And beast and cattle, creeping things that
 do
 Not mind the pinch of pew. The birds that
 fly
 Above the transept also qualify.
 The million congregation of this day
 May be those tiny ones in sand and clay
 Beneath the feet of this one man in prayer.
 The ethnocentric vision sees but one,
 While all the others, being microscopic,
 Are also in the verse, chapter, and topic,
 And sing their hymns to You, the Great and
 Fair
 Until the liturgy of flooding's done.

12 Alohim said "This *is* the sign
 Of My pact that I shall align
 Between myself and you and all
 The living creatures *on the ball*,
 As long as time *shall peregrine*.
 13 "I set My rainbow in the cloud,
 A sign that speaks *as though aloud*
 Of covenant twixt earth and Me.
 14 "It shall be always there to see
 When I bring clouds over the land,
 The rainbow *makes you understand*,
 And shall be seen there in the cloud.
 15 "And I shall bring to mind my pact
 Between Myself and you, in fact,
 With every living creature here,
 That waters shall no more appear
 A flood destroying all things *dear*,
 A flood destroying all things *dear*.
 16 "The rainbow shall be in the cloud,
 And I shall look on it allowed
 To keep in mind the covenant
 Between Alohim and all living,
 And every creature that is meant
 To walk the places earth is giving."
 17 And Alohim told Noah then,
 "This *is* the sign of covenant
 Which I've established and I've sent
 Between Me and all flesh that moves
 Upon the earth as it behaves."

Do You remember, my Beloved, again
 The rainbow that You set against the rain?
 You are the only lover on the earth

Who makes a promise of eternal worth
 And yet demands no sign of love in turn,
 Such love is Yours that it must always
 yearn
 And yearn still though no sign is ever seen
 That any loves You in the hours between.
 You set the bow though every eye turns
 back
 And looks for satisfaction in the lack.
 Your constant whispered memory goes on
 Creating rainbows through the night till
 dawn.
 Without conditions You come bearing love
 Such as my simple soul fails dreaming of.

18 Now Noah's sons who came out of
 The ark were Shem and, *hand in glove*,
 Both Ham and Japheth. Ham's son's name
 Was Canaan. 19 These three *true* sons
 came
 And from these the whole world were born.
 20 And Noah then began *to be*
 A man of the ground, *could mean farmer*
Or then religious chief alarmer.
 He planted there a vineyard *or*
Believing congregation for
Himself and family. 21 Then he drank
 The wine *perhaps of ecstasy*
 And having drunk the wine he sank
 Down in a state where you could see
 Him, and as the passing there went,
 Lie naked *or as it may be*
Vulnerable within his tent.

I found You, my Beloved, within the tent
 Pitched for gods made by hands, pitched
 where I went.
 And yet I did not dream that You accept
 Prostration there, where jealously You
 wept.
 I found You in the tavern and the bar
 Where men drink deeply and the slatterns
 are.
 And yet I do not dream Your thirst is
 quenched
 When I'm well-wined and dined and better
 wenched.
 I found You at the altar in the choir
 That praised the Trinity beyond desire.
 And though all praise is Yours I never
 dreamed

That You rose up and took the place that
seemed
To human hearts to be Lord God's
Almighty.
Your jealous heart's too tender and too
flighty.

22 And Ham, the father of Canaan,
Saw in the tent a naked man
Or vulnerable and would deride
His father and told them outside,
Two brothers in whom to confide.
23 But Shem and Japheth took a cloak
Laid on their shoulders lest he woke
And went backward and covered there
The naked father, not aware,
They came with faces turned away
And did not see their father's shame
And so those two were not to blame.

I whirl with face to sun and moon and lack
A glance for priestly hands stabbing my
back.

I have no guard but You alone, my Love,
And brazenly step out with sky above
And earth beneath my wildly dancing feet,
As I pour in my mouth the sherbet sweet,
To give myself a naked offering here
In a brave gallows without faith or fear.
My ecstasy mounts up as I take sip
Of swirling sherbet sweet and sour and dip
And cast my cloak in my own blood, as I
Fall down to earth when all my senses die.
Naked and vulnerable I lie upon
The gallows floor unconscious of the dawn.

24 So Noah woke from *ecstasy*
Or wine and knew who had made free
With him: his son, the youngest one.
25 Then he said "Cursed *be* Canaan, *son*
Of Ham, a servants' servant may
He be, his brothers' *without pay*."
26 And then he said "Blessed *be* YHWH,
God
Of Shem, may Canaan live *to plod*
His days in service to him. 27 May
Alohim enlarge Japheth, may
He live in Shem's tents and there may
Canaan serve them from day to day."

A servant, slave is what I am to be.
Curse me again, for all the hope I've got.

Until I die not once shall I be free.
Rise star, set hope, and let my free soul rot.
Sometime, somewhere, will any human
know,
Efficiently recording histories
Of how the proud and great and strong got
so,
None but the innocent are cursed with
ease?
Can anyone tell me to do my best
And let God right the wrong? The wrong's
not right,
Not long as I must work and have no rest.
All cursed ones go into eternal night.
Alone the innocent are cursed and tried.
None but the innocent are crucified.

28 And Noah lived after the flood
Three hundred fifty years *by blood*.
29 So all the days of Noah were
Nine hundred fifty years *astir*
And then he died, *new world in bud*.

Genesis 10

1 This *is* the genealogy
Of Prophet Noah's progeny:
Shem, Ham, and Japheth who also
Bore sons after the flood was past,
Whose names were great as this will show.
2 The sons of Japheth *were not last*:
Gomer, Magog, Madai, Javan,
Tubal, and Meshech, and Tiras.
3 The sons of Gomer *to a man*
Were Ashkenaz, Riphath, Togarmah.
4 The sons of Javan *without karma*:
Elishah, Tarshish, Kittim, and
Dodanim. 5 From these came the *band*
Of peoples each in their own land,
According to his speech and kin,
Their peoples *and their discipline*.

Language, family, people You have set
As valid visions of all beings met.
But governments and nations are not there
As divine ordinance or yoke to bear.
The new world order of today would take
Away the thousand languages that make
Our human thought reflection of divine.
And patriotism and its wicked wine
Replace the family and water drink.
I choose the family instead of church
And when it comes to nation then I think

It is a power to prop unlawful smirch
By economic plunders. Family
And You, Belovèd, are enough for me.

6 Ham's sons *were* Cush, Mizraim, Put,
And Canaan. 7 Cush's sons *afoot*
Were Seba, Havilah, Sabtah,
And Raamah, and then Sabtechah,
And Raamah's sons were Sheba and
Dedan. 8 Cush sired *a master hand*
In Nimrod, a great one on earth.
9 He was a mighty hunter *worth*
His weight before YHWH, that is why,
You can hear people classify,
As is said "Like Nimrod, *it's true,*
The mighty hunter before YHWH."

I thank You, my Beloved, that those who
seem

To be the mighty live a darkened dream,
And they too stand before You on the earth.
The Self is all in man and woman worth
The time of day: You are the only "I."
Though Nimrod is a mighty hunter's cry,
He is no more than any other king
Who takes delusion for the real thing.
Express the emptiness of human power
That breeds a shell of conquest for an hour
By saying one is like Nimrod before
The Lord, a mighty hunter, nothing more.
A hunter seeks and sometimes finds in
seeking,
And finding only kills for all his peeking.

10 His kingdom began with Babel,
And Erech, and Accad as well
As Calneh in the land of Shinar.
11 And then to make his kingdom finer,
He went to Assyria from there
Built Nineveh, Rehoboth Ir,
Calah, 12 and Resen there between
The two great cities to be seen,
Nineveh and Calah which is
The principle city of his.
13 Mizraim sired Ludim, Anamim,
And Lehabim, and Naphtuhim,
14 And Pathrusim, and Casluhim
From whom Philistines, Caphtorim.

Poor Babel, Babylon, the best that men
Have in their heart's desires built and again
Rebuilt in every episode of self

Aggrandizement. Gold, silver, china, delf,
And jewelled things joust with theologies
To make a soulless, glittering syncretese.
The towers, the walls, the gates, the street
of gold

Are all I can in vision take that's sold
For Paradise. The book that casts her down
Brings in her place and in her false renown
A picture that to human eyes repeats
Her hanging bowers and wealthy market
streets.

Deliver me from visions of that city,
Poor Babylon, poor human soul, have pity.

15 Canaan sired Sidon his first son,
And Heth, 16 the Jebusite begun,
The Amorite, and Girgashite,
17 The Hivite, Arkite, and Sinite,
18 The Arvadite, the Zemarite,
And Hamathite. Afterward then
Their families dispersed again.
19 The border of the Canaanites
Was from Sidon toward Gerar
As far as Gaza, and as far
As Lasha in direction of
Sodom, and of Gomorrah, of
Admah, and Zeboiim, so far.

From Eilat on the sea I turn my face
And cross the rugged desert of the place
Toward Sodom and the salt infested sea.
No hurry, haste, nor worry follow me.
I find of Sodom but the ruins taught
To lie unblinkingly beneath the sun
And wait for sinners to come or be brought
To taste the wicked dust in search of fun.
The heavy waters cover secrets now
That on a day made bare at last make bow
The disillusioned heart. Beloved, I pass
The valley of the dead, its solemn mass,
Cast off hypocrisy and turn my feet
Towards Jerusalem, towards Your seat.

20 These *were* the sons of Ham, and by
Their families, languages, and by
Their nations and their lands. 21 And Shem
Also had born to him of them
Of Eber, Japheth's elder brother.
22 The sons of Shem, Elam, another
Was Asshur, and then Arphaxad,
Lud and Aram were all he had.
23 The sons of Aram: Uz, Hul, Gether,

And Mash. 24 Arphaxad's only feather
Was Salah, who sired Eber. 25 To
Eber were born two sons whose names
Were Peleg, in whose days the *claims*
For measuring the earth were done,
And Joktan was his other son.

The whole earth measured out at seven
paces
And marked and numbered lovingly in
places
Set out for growing things both tame and
wild,
For pleasure of both man and woman,
child.

The alveolic circles intersecting
Above the secret fountains, springs
affecting
The growth of leaf and bud, mosses and
sprout,
The saxifrage by rock and shade, no doubt
Reflect the stars that sweep the sky at night.
By day I dig and water in the light,
And enter earthy gates fraught with the
noon,
And soiled with rich loam for a sacred
boon.
Beloved, all things You make are measured
here,
While You alone have neither bound nor
fear.

26 Joktan produced Almodad, and
Sheleph, Hazarmaveth, Jerah,
27 Hadoram, Uzal, and Diklah,
28 Obal, Abimael, Sheba,
29 Ophir, Havilah, and Jobab.
All these *were* the sons of Joktan.
30 Their dwelling place was from Mesha
As you go toward Sephar *by plan*,
The mountain of the east, *now drab*.
31 These *were* the sons of Shem, by their
Families, and languages and their
Lands and their nations. 32 So these *were*
The families of Noah's sons
By generations, *benisons*,
By nations as they spread abroad
On earth when the flood dried *and thawed*.

Genesis 11

1 Now the whole earth was of one speech,
One language only *within reach*.

2 And as they journeyed from the east,
It happened they found *unpoliced*
A plain in Shinar's land and where
They settled down to living there.
3 Then they said to each other, "Come,
Let us make bricks and bake *them* some."
They had their bricks for stone, and they
Had asphalt for mortar *and clay*.
4 And they said "Come, let us build up
Ourselves a city, tower whose top
Is in the heavens, let us make
Ourselves a name *and for our sake*,
So that we're not scattered around
The surface of the whole earth's *bound*."

How many towers have I built around
The world! Quaint churches and retreats
abound
Among the temples, synagogues and
lodges,
Theologies syncretic and hodge-podges.
I make myself baked bricks instead of
stone,
A thousand minute statutes that alone
Replace the sapphire glint of ten small
words.
The worship of the creeping things and
birds
Is more demanding than the Decalogue.
Although it keeps the worshipper in fog,
And mind caught up in myriads of things,
It lets me keep my human priests and kings.
Cast down my brick and asphalt palaces,
And give me humble houses where truth is.

5 But YHWH came down to see the city
And tower that men had built *for pity*.
6 And YHWH said "Now these are one
people
Of one language *and of one steeple*.
And this is what they start to do,
And there is nothing to construe
An end to their hullabaloo.
7 "Come, let's go down there and confuse
Their language, and see what they choose
When they can't understand their
neighbours'
Commands, complaints, comforts and
labours."

8 So YHWH scattered them all abroad
Around the whole world *for their fraud*,
And they stopped building on the city.

9 Therefore its name, *just to be witty*,
Is called Babel, because there YHWH
Confused the whole world's language too,
And from there YHWH scattered them out
Over the whole world *without doubt*.

Was it in anger that You shattered speech
So that men could no longer talk to each
Man that he found on tower or bridge or
street?

Speech once was like a crystal bright and
sweet.

It gave such meanings that none now can
know

So clearly and precisely that the slow
Could not mistake. Communication was
A perfect thing and worked as perfect does.
But then Your hand brushed from its
pedestal

That splendoured, rainbowed, iridescent
ball,

And left it splintered. It's no wonder that
All human speech is deaf and dumb and
flat,

Chips shining in the sun and meaningless
Except to bring remembrance to Your
dress.

10 This *is* the genealogy
Of Shem: Shem *was* a hundred. He
Sired Arphaxad two years after
The flood. 11 Then he did not defer
After Arphaxad, Shem lived still
Five hundred years, *by Allah's will*,
And had both daughters and more sons.
12 Aged thirty-five Arphaxad's sons
Produced Salah. 13 And after that
Arphaxad lived four hundred flat
And three years more and also bore
Daughters and sons *in greater store*.
14 And Salah lived for thirty years,
And sired Eber *to dry his tears*.

15 And after Eber, Salah stood
Four hundred and three years *for good*,
And more sons and more daughters too.
16 Well Eber lived to thirty-four
And sired Peleg, 17 And then lived more,
Four hundred thirty years, and yet
Sired sons and daughters *rarely met*.

18 Peleg lived thirty years, and then
Sired Reu. 19 Afterward again
Peleg lived two hundred and nine

Years more with daughters *just as fine*
As sons. 20 Reu lived thirty-two
Years, and sired Serug. 21 So Reu
Lived after that two hundred seven
With sons and daughters *up to heaven*.
22 Serug lived thirty years, and sired
Nahor. 23 And *since he wasn't tired*
Serug lived two hundred years more,
Produced daughters and sons therefore.
24 Aged twenty-nine years was Nahor
And sired Terah. 25 After were seen
Nahor's one hundred and nineteen
Years siring sons and daughters well.
26 Now Terah lived for seventy years,
And sired Abram, *and truth to tell*,
Nahor, and Haran *without fears*.

27 This *is* the genealogy
Of Terah: Terah lived to see
Abram, Nahor, and Haran, *three*.
And Haran produced Lot. 28 But he
Saw death before his father in
His native land, in Ur of the
Chaldeans, *land of Terah's kin*.
29 Then Abram and Nahor took wives:
The name of Abram's wife's Sarai,
And Nahor's wife, Milcah, contrives
To be daughter of Haran by
The father also of Milcah
And also father of Iscah.

30 But Sarai, barren, had no child.
31 And Terah took his son Abram
And grandson Lot, *a little wild*,
Who was the son of *his* Haran,
And Sarai, his daughter-in-law,
Son Abram's wife, and fled *the law*
Of Ur of the Chaldeans for
To go to Canaan, what is more,
They came to Haran and lived there.
32 So all the days of Terah were
Two hundred and five years, the span
Till Terah saw death in Haran.

I sit in Haran's mosque with its green dome
And make it, with my recitation, home.
What words in Arabic sound on my tongue
As I take in Your name to heart and lung.
Who knows where Terah lies, his great
grandson

Already with his father's work long done
Lies buried there behind the grill and stone.
The prophets' children are not here alone.

What holy feet have pressed this ruined
earth!
Now windy rain's mere spatter on its
dearth.

The women gather at the running well.
A cripple hobbles past, and who can tell
Who else may whisper in this ancient place
Your names, Beloved, then pass without a
trace.

Week 3 Genesis 12

1 Now YHWH had said to Abram "Get
You out of your own country, set
Yourself apart from family
And from your father's house go free,
To that place I will show you. 2 I
Will make of you a nation by
And by, one great, and bless you and
Make your name great, and where you
stand
You shall become a blessing. 3 I
Will bless those who bless you, and I
Will curse the one who curses you,
Blessed all earth's families in you."

You give command, Beloved, and I obey.
There's nothing else of prayer or plaint to
say.

I bless Your name and then do not forget
Another name to bless remaining yet.
How few bless Abraham, how few, how
few!

Some bless in word, but few in what they
do.

You did not say to wash and wash again
In river Jordan or some stream in vain.
You did not give a task that some could not
For lack of strength pursue. We've only got
To say a blessing brief and to the point
On Abraham. His grandsons will anoint
New kings and priests and prophets in good
time.

Beloved, I bless both You and him in
rhyme.

4 So Abram left as YHWH had told
Him to, and Lot went with him. So
Abram was seventy-five years old
When he left Haran Lot in tow.

5 Then Abram took Sarai his wife
And Lot his brother's son, and rife
With great possessions they had got

And all the people they *had taught*,
Acquired in Haran, and they went
To Canaan where they had been sent.

Possessions every man can understand,
Such things acquired are found on every
hand.

But what I fail to fathom is the show
Of acquisition in the here below
Of people. Does it mean that Abraham,
Your blessed one, brought with cattle,
sheep and ram,

A crowd of slaves and servants for his use?
Or does it mean that wanderers had excuse
For brigands and for robbers' threat to stay
Close to protecting leaders in the way?
A family or factory or church,
It does not matter, Abrahamic perch
Is where, Beloved, Your guidance could be
found:

An Abrahamic tent-pin in the ground.

6 Abram passed through the land to where
Shechem was seen where the lands bear
The terebinth of revelation,
Called Moreh. At that time *the nation*
Of Canaanites was in the land.

7 Then YHWH appeared to Abram and
Said "To your descendants I'll give
This land, *a place for them to live*."
And there he built an altar to
The one who appeared to him, YHWH.

It is Your habit, my Beloved, it seems,
To show Yourself not only in men's
dreams,

But in the unconsuming burning bush,
Or terebinth or oak from shove to push.
The tree of revelation is as old
As tree of knowledge of the good and bold,
It is as new as tree of life to come
In future revelation's glorious sum.
And as with Abraham it is of now
And is the tree before me anyhow,
The terebinth or birch or fir or pine,
The desert drought of water or the wine,
In all I find You, my Beloved, and fair,
The root in earth, the head and hair in air.

8 He moved to the mountain from there
That's east of Bethel, and that's where
He pitched his tent, Bethel behind

Or on the west, Ai you'll find
Before or on the east, he built
A place of sacrifice to YHWH
That he might worship without guilt
And cantillate the name of YHWH.
9 Then Abram journeyed, going still
Toward the south *through vale and hill*.

I turn from east to west and call Your
name,
Beloved, and whirl again and then take aim
Toward Your house, the house of God, and
bow
And then raise hand from heart to show
men how
The sun and moon whirl on and pray to
You
Who made them all and made all that they
do.

I journey in the desert and the sun
And follow star to southward as I run,
In every place I go around the earth
I find Your name is far above all worth.
And as I cantillate from east to west,
My back to north while searching out the
best,
I find my journey's goal each place I go
Is at my lip and heart for what I know.

10 Now there was famine in the land,
So Abram went to Egypt and
Lived there, for famine was severe.
11 It happened, when he had come near
To Egypt that he told his wife,
Sarai, *"I do fear for my life*
Since you are such a pretty one
When everything is said and done.
12 "That's why when the Egyptians see
You they will say 'This *is* his wife',
And then kill me, but save your life.
13 "Please say you *are* my sister, so
I might survive here where we go,
For what's between *both* you and me."

Beloved, I thank You that You keep Your
way
A secret from the masses that might slay
Me for the gold You lay upon my heart.
They'd fight me truly for the treasured part
That I have on my tongue to sound Your
name.
But now they only see old man for shame

That mutters on the road, they do not hear
The jewels that I utter, I've no fear.
If they knew how sweet is Your name to
me

And what fine nectars are its melody,
They'd surely kill to have its treasures
theirs.

But now the murmur passes unawares.
I thank You that You are a hidden treasure
Poured out on me in secret without
measure.

14 And so it was, when Abram came
To Egypt, people asked her name
When they saw how pretty she was,
Though pretty is as pretty does.

15 The princes of Pharaoh also
Saw her and praised her to Pharaoh,
And she was taken to the court.

16 He treated, because of consort,
With Abram well. He had both sheep
And oxen, male donkeys to keep,
Servants and maids, she-donkeys too,
And camels for *what camels do*.

The Book of Jubilees does not make
mention
That Abram got rich off his wife's attention
To Pharaoh's court. That smacks of
prostitution
Of wife and hearth, but then, the best
solution
To every problem has its fame and hour.
The expectation that the good is dour
Is founded on no sense nor on Your word.
If sense nor word do not leave undeterred
The lust of kings, then common men take
wings.

The prohibition not to kill comes first,
So that adultery is not the worst.
Wherever roses bloom and bulbul sings
The steps to righteousness are ordered
right,
And day to day give precedence to night.

17 But YHWH plagued Pharaoh and his
house
With great plagues, *perhaps mouse or*
louse,
Because of Sarai, Abram's wife.
18 And Pharaoh called Abram with strife
And said "What have you done to me?"

Why did you not tell me that she
Was your wife? 19 "And why did you say,
 'She *is* my sister'? I might lay
 With such a one, take her away,
 Your wife and go." 20 So then Pharaoh
 Commanded men to have him go,
 They sent him off, both him and her,
 And all he had from where they were.

The master of the age gives me no right
 To violent recourse here in my plight.
 I bow to thievery but, silent, pray
 That You, Beloved, will come to save the
 day.

A plague on every man that takes the
 sword,
 That graduates to pistol when he's bored,
 And bomb to take the widow's precious
 hoard.

The congress of warlords goes on apace
 With talk of war and peace met face to face
 In strategies to get the gold and oil,
 Commodities one never wraps in foil
 Nor puts upon a plate. Beloved, remark
 Illusion tempts both owner and the clerk
 As well as those of us who sleep and toil.

Genesis 13

1 Then Abram went up from Egypt,
 He and his wife *and all his script*
 And all he had, and Lot with him,
 Up to the south, *ship-shape and trim*,
 2 For Abram *was* most rich in stock,
 In cattle, silver, gold and flock.
 3 And he went on his journey from
 The south so far until he'd come
 To Bethel, to the place where he
 Had pitched his tent at first, *you see*,
 Between Ai and Bethel 4 where
 He'd made the place to worship there
 At first, and there he just the same,
 Abram did so, call on YHWH's name.

As Abram called, Beloved, upon Your
 Name
 When he left Egypt with his wealth and
 came
 To Bethel, so may I seek resting place
 Upon Your altar and turned toward Your
 face
 Call on Your lovely names. Between the
 city

Of Ai and of Bethel, without pity
 Then marching northward Abraham and
 Lot
 There found a place to pitch their tents and
 got
 A haven where to keep their livestock, gold
 And silver. There too they found made of
 old
 An altar consecrated to Your name,
 There waiting silently until they came.
 I seek my old forsaken altars where
 I once repeated Your name to the air.

5 Lot too, who went with Abram, had
 Flocks, herds and tents. 6 Now it was bad,
 The land could not support them both,
 That they might live together, growth
 Of their possessions was so great
 They could not both accommodate.
 7 So there was clash between the men
 That herded Abram's flock again
 And those that herded Lot's livestock.
 What made things worse *of a dead-lock*
 Was Canaanite and Perizzite
 Both in the land, put up a fight.
 8 So Abram said to Lot, "Please let
 There be no strife between as yet
 Yourself and me, and those who herd
 My flocks and yours, it is preferred
 Since you and I are relatives.
 9 "Is not the whole land that God gives
 Before you? Let us separate,
 If you go left, I'll hesitate
 Not one minute to take the right.
 Or if that way is in your sight
 Then I'll go left." 10 And Lot lifted
 His eyes and saw how well gifted
 Lay all the plain of Jordan there,
 It *was* well watered everywhere
 (Before YHWH picked off Sodom and
 Gomorrah) like YHWH's plot, like land
 Of Egypt out toward Zoar's *command*.

How many eyes, Beloved, mistake the
 towers
 Of Sodom and Gomorrah for the flowers
 Of Paradise. I lift my eyes to seek
 The blessing voice of Eden where You
 speak,
 And see the rushing traffic, hear the din
 Of market and of worship from within

The temples filled with peace and love and still
 More idols than could in the desert fill
 The Kaaba when the Prophet came to find
 Its true heart to bestow on humankind.
 The place most often sought to know You
 best
 Is far more often where the idols rest.
 Turn me, Beloved, away from Paradise
 And watered plain, let desert ways suffice.

11 Then Lot chose for himself the plain
 Of Jordan, all *its luscious gain*,
 And journeyed east. And there they parted.
 12 And Abram lived in Canaan, *charted*
Its land, and Lot lived on the plain,
 In cities *drenched in northern rain*,
 As far as Sodom pitched his tent.
 13 But men of Sodom, as men went
Were wicked and exceedingly
 Sinful against YHWH shamelessly.

The land I choose makes hardly difference
 now,
 And Sodom would seem heaven anyhow
 Compared with wealth of wickedness now
 told.
 Take London, for example, where the bold
 And insensate find every ruse of art
 And beauty to cover their hidden part
 In the destruction of the world and those
 Who try to live and die on pea and rose.
 Do not succumb, I tell myself and You,
 But seek out dwelling in the treed and true,
 And since all human institutions fare
 No better than Gomorrah, I look where
 The water is the best, since water's rare,
 Yet still is found in Sodom's sun and glare.

14 Then YHWH spoke after Lot had gone
 To Abram, said "Lift your eyes on
 The place where you are, north and south,
 Toward east and west, *despite the drouth*,
 15 "For all the land you see I give
 To you and yours, a place to live
 Forever. 16 "And I'll make your seed
 More than the dust of earth indeed,
 If one could count it then they might
 Count your descendants in their sight.

Though I may not be child of Abraham,
 (My family history's opaque as a clam),

I ought to count it glory that I must
 Be treated in this world like common dust.
 The promise that You made to Abram then
 Was not the common one made to sweet
 men,
 But most astonishing and it's no wonder
 That Abram had to second-guess and
 blunder.
 Though to be frank Your word was clear
 enough.
 It's just that clarity is such strange stuff
 To us who live our lives in this illusion
 That even useless gold seems an effusion.
 But Abram knew the truth that children are
 The only wealth one has on barren star.

17 "Get up and walk the land, its length
 And width, to you I give its *strength*."
 18 Then Abram moved *his* tent, and went
 And lived beneath the terebinth,
 The trees of Mamre, which *are* in
 Hebron, and built an altar in
 That place to worship YHWH therein.

In Mamre's revelation, in the shade
 Of terebinth or oak and one grass blade
 I pitch my tent and raise a slender psalm
 Above the scent of frankincense and balm.
 I rise and walk and pitch my tent again
 Till my life seems a whirling in the fen,
 A whirling and a march across the floor
 Of earth beneath a sky without a door.
 Since I cannot climb to the gate of heaven
 I joy to find You here on earth at seven
 Days in the forty-nine, and breath to breath
 Each day I walk the altar without death.
 Beloved, I rise and walk the land You give,
 And pitch my tent and prostrate while I
 live.

Genesis 14

1 When Amraphel was king of Shinar,
 And Arioch king of Ellasar,
 And Chedorlaomer enshriner
 Of Elam, and Tidal so far
 The king of the Goyim, 2 they made
 War with Bera king of Sodom,
 Birsha king in Gomorrah *strayed*,
 Shinab of Admah, Shemeber
 King of Zeboiim, and the fer
 King of Bela, that is, Zoar.
 3 All these joined battle in the Vale

Of Siddim where now salts prevail.
 4 Twelve years they served and in the year
 Thirteen they shed Chedorlaomer.
 5 The next year Chedorlaomer came
 And the kings with him *just the same*
 Attacking the Rephaim there
 In Ashtoreth Karnaim, where
 The Zuzim had gathered in Ham,
 The Emim too *and without sham*
 In Shaveh Kiriathaim, 6 and
 The Horites in their mountain *stand*
 Of Seir, down to El Paran
 Beside the wilderness, 7 began
 Their way back there by En Mishpat,
 That is, Kadesh, and then fell flat
 On all the land of Amelek
 And then subdued *the stubborn neck*
 Of all the Amorites *whose fire*
Was lit in Hazezon Tamar.

The kings who seek a tribute and their
 taxes
 Form coalitions, allied powers, and axis
 And go to war to help democracy,
 They cross the deserts and the rolling sea
 To ferret out of mountain wilderness
 The people whose wealth they truly confess
 Should be their own. I stand on Seir and
 gaze
 Across miles of uninhabited maze
 Of oak and maple and think what will come
 Of this campaign or that for centuries
 The same. The generations die, life flees
 To dandelion holes to reappear
 As soon as danger's past, and without fear,
 Beloved, to raise a golden head and hum.

8 And kings of Sodom and Gomorrah,
 The king of Admah *without Torah*,
 The kings of Zeboiim and Bela,
 That is, Zoar, to the last fellow
 Went out and gathered for the battle
 In Vale of Siddim, like drawn cattle,
 9 Against Chedorlaomer king
 Of Elam, Tidal also king
 Of the Goyim, Amraphel king
 Of Shinar, and Arioch the king
 Of Ellasar, four kings to five.
 10 Now the Valley of Siddim's drive
Was full of asphalt pits, and so
 When Sodom and Gomorrah fled,
Some fell there, others had to go

Into the mountains. 11 Then they took
 The goods of Sodom and Gomorrah,
 All their provisions, then they *shook*
Their heels as though off to Andorra.
 12 And they took Abram's brother's son,
 Lot, who lived in Sodom *for fun*,
 And his goods, and left on the run.

There are but two great sources of what
 men
 Desire, Beloved, and these are labour and
 The goods the labourer produces. Then
 As now I see the presidents command
 War to procure the wealth of those who
 make
 And what they make for earth and heaven's
 sake.
 And so they took the people and the goods
 From Sodom and Gomorrah, left the woods
 And valleys well-provided. The best way
 Avoiding such attack is not to stay
 To make or have, but sink in poverty,
 And live on water and on acorns, free
 To all as long as no pollutions sink
 The world from where it stands upon the
 brink.

13 Then one who had escaped came by
 And told Abram the Hebrew why,
 For he lived by the terebinth
 Trees of Mamre the Amorite,
 Brother of Eshcol and the right
 Brother of Aner, colocynthe
 They were to each other, allies
 With Abram. 14 Now *with such good ties*
 When Abram heard his relative
 Was taken captive, *as I live*,
 He armed three hundred and eighteen
 Trained *men* born in his own demesne,
 And went pursuing up to Dan,
With every faithful partisan.

The art of war was forged in secret by
 Your faithful Abraham, who with the cry
 Of three hundred and eighteen warriors
 could
 Without bloodshed rout armies that
 withstood
 Five kings and more. Beloved, let me take
 up
 The battle for the king of Salem's cup.

Whether there be three hundred here or
more
I join in arms, the sword of tongue in store,
Throat swelling with the cantillation of
Your exquisite names spoken here in love.
The martial art You taught to David finds
Its roots in Abraham, as all that binds.
Its vast engagements meet from breath to
breath
And fearlessly go onward into death.

15 At night he separated all
His forces and then gave the call
To attack and pursue them to
Hobah, north of Damascus' view.
16 So he brought back both all the goods,
His brother Lot, also his goods,
The women and the people too.
17 The king of Sodom went straight out
To meet him at the Valley of
Shaveh, King's Valley, without doubt,
When he came back from defeat of
Chedorlaomer and the kings who
Were with him. 18 King of Salem too,
Melchizedek, and with both bread
And grape juice, *let it thus be said,*
No proof of alcohol is nigh,
And he was priest of God Most High.
19 And he blessed him and said "Blessed
be
Abram of God Most High, and He
Possesses heaven and earth, 20 And blessed
Be God Most High, who gave you rest
And victory from enemy."
So he gave him a portion's hest.

A funny thing it seems to be that Your
Command that every man should bless the
store
Of Abraham went round the world and
sank
Into the consciousness and habits rank
And file. At least Melchizedek came out
And first of all blessed Abraham, no doubt
He knew his own worth and survival meant
That he acknowledge the one man You
sent.
Beloved, I too bless Abraham today,
Though I live here millennia away.
The eye upon the past is not mere folly,
Inertia, but the second sight, by golly,

And second eye that gives depth to my
seeing
Beyond the flat and clutter of world's
being.

21 Now king of Sodom said to him,
To Abram *since the times were grim,*
"Give me the persons, take the goods
For yourself, *I'm out of the woods.*"
22 But Abram said to king of Sodom,
"I've raised my hand to YHWH, *don't prod*
'em,
To God Most High the One who holds
Both heaven and earth, *and who beholds*
23 "That I *will take* nothing from you,
Not thread nor strap nor sandal shoe,
Lest you should say, 'Abram got rich
When I and mine fell in the ditch,'"
24 "Except just what the men have eaten,
And those who went with me unbeaten,
Eshcol and Mamre and Aner,
Let those three men take all their share."

The booty of the war is in the hand,
At the discretion, by the Lord's command,
Of Your appointed to do as he will.
Your Abraham had right to all, and still
He gave the wicked Sodom all his own,
And to his allies just shares not in loan.
Your friend relinquished all rights to the
store
Of wealth, that no one might find grief or
door
To criticise or gloat. There is but One
Of true wealth when the longer battle's
done:
Beloved, You are possessor of both earth
And heaven, the mighty God, no thing of
worth
Escapes Your hand or knowing, who
created
All worlds here, and for You all things
were fated.

Genesis 15

1 After these things the word of YHWH
Came to Abram in vision, "Do
Not fear, Abram. I *am* your shield,
Your very great reward revealed."

Beloved, I covet Abraham's reward!
I need no wealth nor honour nor the sword.

The shield You are is sword enough and more,
 And You Yourself are wealth more than the store.
 "Exceeding great" You say, exceeding what?
 Exceeding all that's sought and loved, the butt
 Of every joke, the touch of art and rhyme,
 The taste of wise confection in the time
 Of hunger, finest wine before the thirst,
 Security of oil, bombs at their worst
 That save the world for bright democracy:
 Exceeding all of these, and great to see
 Is that reward You are. Beloved, I covet
 Reward of Abraham, desire and love it.

2 But Abram said "Lord YHWH, what will You give me, seeing I go still
 Without a child, and this the heir
 Of my house *is* Eliezer
 Of Damascus?" 3 Then Abram said
 "Look, You've given me no child, instead
 One born in my house is my heir!"
 4 And then the word of YHWH *was there*,
 "This one shall not be your heir, but
 One from yourself *shall claim the pot*."

I am a servant born indeed upon
 The gallows floor of Your house before dawn.
 I am no heir, though Abraham would take
 Me for his son and in the taking make
 Me heir of all the earth. In pilgrimage
 I walk a stranger in the land. No cage
 Nor palace guards my steps. My life is free
 From such encumbrances as property.
 My mothers wandered Africa and more,
 From India to the most northern shore
 Of Europe, Asia, and America.
 There is no land with name of home and awe.
 You give, Beloved, a servant no place here
 But living in Your heart and being dear.

5 Then He brought him outside *the bars*,
 "Look now toward heaven, and count the stars
 If you can count them all." And He
 Said to him, "So shall your seed be."
 6 And he believed in YHWH, and He
 Accounted it to him freely

For righteousness. 7 And then He said
 To him, "I'm YHWH, who when you fled
 Out of Ur of the Chaldees, brought
 You to this land to give to ought."
 8 And he said "Lord YHWH, how shall I
 Know that I shall inherit it?"
 9 So He said to him, "Bring Me by
 A three-year heifer that is fit,
 A three-year female goat and ram,
 A turtledove, and pigeon's *dam*."
 10 Then he brought all of these to Him
 And cut them each in two, and trim,
 And placed each piece against the other,
 But did not cut the birds *or smother*.
 11 And when the vultures came to feed,
 Abram drove them away indeed.

Some birds are sweet, both in their song
 and meat.
 Some birds appearing here appear a treat.
 But not the vulture. Even Abram drives
 Away the vulture. Yet the vulture thrives.
 When You, Beloved, set out a table decked
 With sweetmeats and sweet wine for the
 elect,
 Do not drive out, like Abraham Your
 prophet,
 The vulture who would choose a morsel off
 it.
 Though I may be an ugly bird and truly
 A filthy one, do not treat me unduly
 With harshness. I too join the rushing
 throng
 That hears the siren calling of Your song.
 I am content, Beloved, to taste what's left
 When sweeter birds have fed. Leave none
 bereft.

12 Now when the sun was going down,
 A deep trance fell on Abram's *crown*.
 13 And then He said to Abram, "Know
 That certainly your descendants
 Will be but strangers where they go,
 A land not theirs, make acquaintance
 With harsh service and bitter tears,
 Afflicted for four hundred years.
 14 "Also the nation whom they serve
 I will judge, then they shall not swerve,
 But come out with possessions great.
 15 "Now as for you, you'll not be late
 To go to your ancestors' peace,
 But shall be buried at great age.

16 "Four generations set the stage
For their return. Iniquity
Of Amorite come before Me
Has not yet filled allotted page."

Three generations, or if sin takes more,
The generations might be stretched to four.
You limit, my Beloved, the stakes of sin
To three or four and then pull the nets in.
The Amorites' iniquity has ceased
Long since, but Abram's progeny's
increased.

Let me, too, my Beloved, go down in peace
Like Abraham to some grave and release
My wandering in the world in pilgrimage
From strangers' hearths. At every doorstep
here
I find the Kaaba and my heart takes cheer.
The thousand generations of my stage
And line look not to see, how fine my
grave
But if its future tenant is a knave.

17 It happened, when the sun went down
And it was dark on field and town,
A smoking oven there appeared,
A burning torch between the seared.
18 On the same day YHWH made a pledge
With Abram, saying "From the edge
Of Egypt's river to the great
One of Euphrates I instate
All this land for inheritance,
19 "The Kenites, and all the expanse
Of Kenezites, the Kadmonites,
20 "The Hittites, and the Perizzites,
The Rephaim, 21 "the Amorites,
The Canaanites, the Girgashites,
And all the land of Jebusites."

I understand, Beloved, You gave the land
To Abraham's descendants, understand
That they should live between the flowing
Nile

And the Euphrates. So it has been while
The Kenite is no more and no one knows
The Kenezite and Kadmonites in rows
Have disappeared. The Hittites are a find
For archeologists, there is no kind
Of Perizzite or Rephaim, and when
Did Amorite last walk the earth with men?
The Canaanite is gone, the Girgashite
Lies in the grave beside the Jebusite.

You promised land, Beloved, and land's
release.
Why did You never promise them world
peace?

Genesis 16

1 Now Sarai, Abram's wife, had borne
Him no *children*. And she, *forlorn*,
Had an Egyptian maid whose name
Was Hagar. 2 So Sarai, *for shame*,
Said to Abram, "See now, YHWH has
Restrained me from bearing, whereas
This maid, go in and marry her,
Maybe I'll get one by transfer."
And Abram did as Sarai said.
3 And then Sarai, Abram's wife, led
Out Hagar who had been her maid,
Egyptian maid, and gave her to
Her husband Abram to be wife,
After Abram ten years of life
Had spent in Canaan *in virtue*.

Beloved, think once more now about the
one
You gave that Abraham might have a son.
Did You remember then to ask if she
Was really willing, in her state, to be
A second wife, one taken for excuse
The first one had no more need for abuse?
Ah, Hagar's lot! Was fame enough reward
To heal the wound made in her heart by
sword
Of circumstance? I think not, I think not.
Was son enough, the rampant one she got?
Perhaps, perhaps, but still the wound was
sore
And tears were shed a-plenty there before
He was a man. Beloved, I wonder whether
You thought about her and her son
together.

4 So he went in to Hagar, and
She conceived. When she saw first-hand
That she'd conceived, she looked down on
Her mistress. 5 Then Sarai anon
Said to Abram, "My wrong *be* on
You! I gave my maid to embrace,
And when she saw she had conceived,
I was despised before her face.
YHWH judge were you or I *deceived*."

I am not now astonished that the wife,

New taken from her servant's state and life,
Is dazzled with a husband rich and kind.
There's no surprise that each one changed
her mind.

I only wonder Sarah ever thought
She would be satisfied when Hagar got
A place in Abram's bed, and arms and
heart.
Did she think Hagar'd play a humble part?
How could she be so slow to understand
Her jealousy before 't was out of hand?
It may be stupid to agree to take
A second wife, it may be dumb to make
A married man one's choice, but surely no
Mistake is greater than this Sarah's show.

6 So Abram said to Sarai, "Your
Maid's in your hand, do as you please."
And when Sarai was harsh, for sure
She fled away not to appease.
7 The Angel of YHWH found her by
A desert spring of water nigh
The road to Shur. 8 He said to her,
"Hagar, you Sarai's maid, where were
You coming from and where are you
Now going?" She said "*To tell you
The truth* I'm fleeing from Sarai
My mistress." 9 The Angel of YHWH
Said to her, "Return by and by
To your mistress, and there must you
Submit yourself under her hand."
10 After YHWH's Angel gave command
He then said to her, "I indeed
Shall greatly multiply your seed,
So none can count them for their number."
11 The Angel of YHWH *not to slumber*
Said to her, "Indeed, you're with child,
And you shall bear a son whose name
Is Ishmael, since YHWH heard your claim.
12 He shall be like a donkey wild,
Whose hand's against all other men
And all against him too again.
And he shall live in the presence
Of all his brothers *with good sense*."

I walk, Beloved, the semi-arid strand
Of Cyprus, where the turtles come to land.
The little hills look down and smile to see
The wild ass running there as shy and free
As new from Your creating hand and voice.
Of animals the wild ass is my choice.
None of creation is so fine and wise,

With arching neck, high hoof and flashing
eyes,
Its mane a standing brush defying sun
And star and moon. I watch the wild ass
run.
Beloved, let no wild ass be caught by rope
Or fence, Beloved, be the wild ass's hope.
Do You not love the wild ass too as I,
So much like You, almost a glimpse and
cry?

13 And then she called the name of YHWH
Who spoke to her, You-Are-God-Who-
Sees, for she said "Have I also
Here seen Him who sees me?" 14 And so
The well's Beer Lahai Roi by name,
Between Kadesh and Bered came.

First prophetess since Eve, it seems is she
Who was a servant, second wife, to be
The mother of the prophet's eldest son,
To whom the angel spoke as if to one
Who bore the book of revelation then.
Indeed she did, within her womb were men
And women who should have the greatest
honour.
The blessing of the first at last fell on her.
But not alone because she had a child,
A child of promises, and wise and wild,
Was she picked out to see the heavenly
vision,
And bear the first child of the circumcision.
She saw Your glory, O Beloved, because
Of what she knew and hoped, and what she
was.

15 So Hagar bore Abram a son,
And Abram named his son, the one
To whom Hagar gave birth, Ishmael.
16 Abram *was* eighty-six the while
Hagar bore Ishmael Abram's son.

Genesis 17

1 When Abram was aged ninety-nine,
YHWH came to Abram and said *fine*,
"I'm El Shadai, Almighty God,
Walk by Me blameless on the sod.
2 "And I will make My covenant
Between Me and you, which is meant
I'll multiply you most greatly."
3 Then Abram fell on his face, *see*,
And Alohim talked with him, saying

4 "As for Me, indeed, *while you're praying*,
My covenant's with you, and you
Shall be the ancestor in view
Of many nations. 5 "No more shall
Your name be Abram, *so banal*,
But Abraham, for I have made
You father of a grand parade.
6 "Fruitful indeed I shall make you,
And father of the nations, too."

Of all the kings that came from Abraham,
Some have been good, and as sure as I am
Of that, some have been wicked too. No
sure

Thing comes from our biology. The pure
And fated both proceed and unabated.
The good lad and the kind, once he's
instated

May just as well turn out an Ahab or
A Solomon. Importance lies not in
The pedigree but if the lad will sin.
The covenant with Abraham, though true
And bright will never guarantee that You
Accept the progeny. The fruitful nation,
Product of grief or joyful jubilation,
May side with either heavenly queen or
whore.

7 "And I'll affirm My pact with you
And your descendants after you
Through all their generations, I
Shall be your God and also I
Shall be their God. 8 "Also I give
To you and your seed place to live,
The land where you have been a stranger
And all of Canaan for your own,
Forever where you've been a ranger,
And I shall be their God alone."
9 And Alohim still spoke and said
To Abraham, "*As for your thread*,
You shall keep covenant with Me,
You and your seed eternally.
10 "This *is* My pact which you shall keep,
Between Me, you and your descendants
After you: all the males that peep,
Each child among you and dependants
Shall be one circumcised, 11 "and you
Shall be cut in your foreskins' flesh,
A sign of covenant with you.
12 "He who is eight days old and fresh
Among you shall be circumcised,
Each male child that you've realized,

Born in your house or bought with money,
From foreigner *not patrimony*.

13 "He who is born in your house and
He who's bought with your money stand
Both to be circumcised, and My
Pact in your flesh continues by.

14 "And the uncircumcised male child,
Whose foreskin's left to flesh gone wild,
That person shall be cut off from
His folk, pact broken, *heathendom*."

Well and indeed. To cut a pinch of skin
As symbol of the hopeful lack of sin,
Disarming strange advice and even worse,
Seems to neglect the daughter as a curse,
Unless the cutting of the son's a plague.
The whole thing strikes me now as
somewhat vague.

Does anything in Decalogue require
Such action, does it anywhere inspire
The soul, devout, to private circumcision?
I do not doubt the devout, wise decision.
The sacrifice, if sacrifice it be,
Seems much too small to take it seriously.
I add to it, Beloved, myself and all,
Body and soul and hear, calf in the stall.

15 Alohim spoke once more and said
To Abraham, "As for Sarai
Your wife, call her Sarah instead.

16 "And I will bless her, also I
Shall give you a son by her, then
I shall bless her, and among men
Nations and kings from her shall spread."

The way that Sarai acted from the first,
If I were You I would count her the worst,
And let another woman take the fame,
And let another lady earn her name.

If grace is Your heart's will, than Sarai
shows

That grace is all Your great heart ever
knows.

I would have long since sent the woman
packing,
With machinations and complaint nerve-
wracking.

That You still promise her a son is greater
As miracle than age was when to mate her.
If You bless Sarai, that is news indeed
To joy the heart of everyone in need.
If You keep promises to awful Sarai,

Then everyone has hope and can say "Dare I."

17 Then Abraham fell on his face
And laughed inside, and said *in case*,
"Shall I have children at my age?
And Sarah at ninety engage
To give birth?" 18 Abraham said to
Alohim, "Let live before You
Ishmael!" 19 Then Alohim replied
"Sarah your wife shall sure abide
And bear a son, and Isaac shall
Be his name before one and all,
And I will make My pact with him
For always and through bright and dim,
And with his seed come after him.
20 "And as for Ishmael, I have heard.
Indeed, I bless him by My word.
I make him fruitful, multiplied,
A mighty nation to abide,
Twelve princes shall his children be,
A nation mighty, great, and free.
21 "And with Isaac I'll make my pact,
Whom Sarah will bear in the act,
Within the year and faithfully."

I thank You, my Beloved, You heard the
prayer
Of Abraham, who loves the son who's
there.

Beyond his prayer You also bless the son
Who will appear before the day is done.
The human view is that a choice is made
Between the two, one only makes the
grade.

The other must be left without a hope.
It's always so with cardinal and pope.
Divine view is that both sons are unique
And both receive the blessings that they
seek.

Let me not stray where choices are in vain,
Let me not suffer artificial pain.
Give me the blessing of my prayer today,
And unexpected ones along the way.

With every fifty feet it seems the wealth
Of Arab culture scintillates in stealth,
And changes with kaleidoscopic speed
Across the jewelled mountains to take heed
To Beduin boys following their flocks.
The crystal patchwork turns to barren
rocks.

I miss the variegated dress and frills,
Embroidered coins shining upon the hills,
I miss the handwork and the tintured
loom,

The thousand things that have since met
their doom.

I would deprive the harassed Jew of no
Homeland nor place of refuge where to go,
But sicken at the loss of all things fair
That disappeared from Palestine in air.

22 Then He finished talking with him,
And Alohim went up from him.

23 So Abraham took Ishmael and
Not just his son, but all who stand
Born in his house and all males bought
With money, all males to be sought
In Abraham's household and cut
The flesh of their foreskins for what
Alohim said that day. 24 The age
Of Abraham was ninety-nine
When circumcised *by God's design*
In flesh of foreskin *for a gauge*.

25 And Ishmael his son *was* thirteen
When he was circumcised *come clean*.

26 That very same day Abraham
Was circumcised, and in one slam
Also Ishmael his son, 27 and all
The men of his household, *both small*
And great, born in his house or bought
From strangers at cost, *not begot*,
All these were circumcised *from first*
To last with him, *both best and worst*.

So still today the Muslim way to do
The circumcision is to wait a few
Years and perform the operation on
Each lad before his childhood is quite gone,
Like Ishmael rather than like Abraham
Or Isaac who was an eight-day-old lamb.
The law says follow Isaac, so the Jew
Is right, though Muslim statutes say so too.
I guess the Christian teller takes the cake.
He waits like Abraham for age to make
Him ripe for circumcision and when he
Approaches one hundred he will make free
To stand before the knife. It's never late
To obey You, Beloved, at any rate.

Week 4 Genesis 18

1 Then Angel of YHWH came to him
By Mamre's oaks, in interim

As he sat in the noonday heat
 By his tent door *to rest his feet*.
 2 He raised his eyes and looked and there
 Were three men standing *in the glare*,
 And seeing them he ran to meet them,
 And from his tent he stood to greet them,
 And bowed himself down to the ground,
 3 And said "My Lord, if I have found
 Grace in Your sight, do not pass on
 By Your servant. 4 "Let water drawn
 Be brought, and wash your feet, and rest
 Beneath the tree. 5 "I'll do my best
 And bring a bit of bread and such
 And you'll rejoice your hearts as much.
 And after that you may pass by,
 Come to your servant such as I."
 They said to him, "Do as you say."
 6 So Abraham went on his way
 To Sarah in the tent to pray,
 Saying "Quickly, make ready three
 Measures of fine meal, avidly
 Knead *it* and make cakes *for the three*."
 7 And Abraham ran to the herd,
 And took a tender calf and spurred
 A young man to prepare it well.
 8 So he took butter, milk, and calf,
 Which was prepared by personnel,
 And set before them both carafe
 And plate and stood to serve the mate
 Beneath the tree while the three ate.

Your angels met with hospitality
 Beneath the terebinth rabbinically,
 Or rather not, unless the meal was slow.
 I rather think they ate there on the go,
 Both meat and milk together at a meal.
 Let them lie down and then see how they
 feel.
 Blessed in Your name, Beloved, that food
 was good,
 And slaughtered and prepared and served
 as should.
 The reason divine law becomes so fine
 Is just because, before one starts to dine,
 One asks too many questions of the cup.
 Your will and love are easy to fill up.
 Who look for angels instead of new laws
 Find visions and a meal instead of claws.

9 They said to him, "Where *is* your wife
 Sarah?" So he said "*By my life*,
 Here, in the tent." 10 Then he said "I

Will surely come and not pass by
 But come to you according to
 The time of life, and surely you
 And Sarah your wife shall *be blessed*
 To have a son." But *for the rest*
 Sarah was listening at the door
 Of her tent there behind *the four*.
 11 Now Abraham and Sarah were
 Old, well advanced in age, for her
 Childbearing age was past.
 12 Therefore Sarah was flabbergast
 And laughed within herself, and said
 "I who am old, shall I be led
 To pleasure, while my husband is
 Older than I?" 13 YHWH's Angel riz
 To say to Abraham "Why did
 Sarah laugh, doubt in her heart hid,
 Saying 'Shall I who am so old
 Still bear?' 14 "Is anything *too bold*
 Or hard for YHWH? At time appointed
 I shall return to you, *anointed*,
 According to the time of life,
 A son shall be born to your wife."
 15 But Sarah denied what she said
 "I did not laugh," she was afraid
And troubled on her own behalf.
 And He said "No, but you did laugh!"

Like any Arab woman, Sarah hid
 Behind the door and listened should he bid
 Her do some service there, 'twas not her
 wish
 To eavesdrop on the angel, no, some dish
 Or pitcher was her claim to hiding there.
 If You should visit Arab, then beware!
 Like any visitor in Arab tent
 The guest was irritated ere he went
 To find the women of the house all hidden
 Yet standing by in case they might be
 bidden.
 And that's why angels cast the blame on her
 For laughing. Abraham did not incur
 Such censure when he also laughed inside.
 Beloved, our pleasure's always not to hide.

16 Then the men rose from there and
 looked
 Toward Sodom, and Abraham hooked
 Himself to go part way with them.
 17 YHWH's Angel said *ad hominem*,
 "Shall I hide from Abraham what
 I plan to do, 18 "since Abraham

Has been blessed and has surely got
The promise of the great I AM
To be a fine and mighty nation,
And all the nations of the earth
Shall be blessed in him *and his station?*
19 "For I have known him, that he will
Command his household to be still
Obedient in the way of YHWH,
To righteousness and justice do,
That YHWH may bring to Abraham
Whatever He has promised him."

Why did You choose, Belovèd, Abraham?
No doubt You had the choice of each I am
And every beggar's son. Then why this
one?

From what You say here I think that I know
When sun is set and all their tasks are done,
Each man goes to his place, but teaching's
slow.

Few teach their sons and daughters to obey
Creator and their Sovereign after day
Has tired bone and muscle, few there are.
But Abraham You knew to be a star.
I have not many children, but I seek
To teach them to know Your law week by
week.

I cantillate Your Decalogue again
And once again as Sabbath comes to men.

20 YHWH's Angel said "Because the cry
Against Sodom *does amplify*

Against Gomorrah too as great,
And since their sins perpetuate,
21 "I will go down now and see whether
They've done wickedly altogether
According to the outcry that
Has come up to Me where I'm at,
And if not, then I'll know the thing."
(*We've already met Sodom's king.*)

22 And so the men turned back from there
And went toward Sodom, but *as fair*
Stood Abraham upon the spot
To know YHWH's Angel *and His plot*.

I stand before destroying angel here,
The one that bears the name of awe and
fear,
And pray that my soul shall be spared to
last
And go on living when all sin is past.
Destroy in me each thought of evil gain,

And every hope to find a place to reign.
Destroy the neglect of the morning sky,
The prayers that give the joy of passing by
In leaf and bloom new opened to the day.
Destroy in me, Beloved, each evil way.
Make bare my plain like Sodom's plain and
now
Teach me new waters and new ways and
how
The morning freshness of Your knowing
can
Reach to the sunset of a living man.

23 And Abraham came near and said
"Would You destroy the righteous led
Along with those who are wicked?"

24 "Suppose there were within the city,
Fifty righteous, would You take pity
And spare it for the sake of those?"

25 "Far be it from You to oppose
The wicked as the proselyte,
And slay them both there in their clothes,
Shall not the Judge of all do right?"

26 So then the *Angel of YHWH* said
"If I find fifty righteous led
Within Sodom then I will spare
The city and all living there."

27 Then Abraham answered and said
"Indeed now, I'm *but dust for bread*
And ashes, yet I speak to You,
The Lord, about the things You do.

I who am dust and ashes take on me
To speak to You, Beloved, as bold and free
As if to friend and brother, yet I know
Your glory behind veils can never show
To human sight. I dare to open lips
And lifting cup, receive Your name in sips,
Whose majesty is far beyond compare
With any of creation, glacier mass,
Gigantic fir pinned to the spacious air,
The firmament like living, moving glass,
The scintillating carpets of goutweed
And dandelion forever without need
Or hope abandoned in wild continent.
I who am only dust know what You meant.

28 "Now let's suppose there lacked but five
Of those righteous to keep alive,
Would You slay all for lack of five?"
So He said "If I find that sum,
I'll not destroy residuum."

29 He spoke to Him yet a third time
 "Would forty righteous be a crime?"
 So He said "If the righteous make
 That sum, I'll save it for their sake."
 30 Then he said "Let not the Lord be
 Angry, and I'll speak once more free:
 Suppose thirty should be found there?"
 He said "For thirty, I would spare."
 31 He said "Indeed now, I have dared
 To speak for what the Lord declared,
 Suppose there should be twenty found?"
 He said "For twenty, I'll be bound."
 32 He said "Let not the Lord be wroth
 And I'll return to eat my broth,
 Supposing ten should be found there?"
 He said "For ten I'll still be fair."
 33 So *the Angel of YHWH* went on
 His way, and Abraham was drawn
 Back to his place after his speaking
 In favour of peace and peace-seeking.

Your prophet might have saved his time
 and breath.
 You're going to judge, condemn, and put to
 death
 The population of whole cities where
 The prophet's sure ten righteous live and
 care.
 He no doubt made a mission tour and found
 That fifty joined the congregation sound.
 But just in case, he got Your promise right
 For those who may have somehow missed
 the light.
 He slept well knowing that his fervent
 prayer
 Had saved the day, come morning they'd be
 there.
 He failed to count the loss of those who
 think
 That faith begins and ends in what you
 drink.
 All who had kept the law but failed to see
 True Self in You alone burned with the
 free.

Genesis 19

1 Now the two angels came to Sodom
 And it was evening, Lot sat in
 The city gate, would have unshod them.
 He rose to meet them like his kin,
 Bowed down to greet them to the ground.
 2 He said "Here now, my lords, be found

To sleep this night beside my board,
 As I am servant, you are lord,
 Then rising early you may go
 In safety to the next depot."
 But they said "No, we'll spend the night
 Upon the open square in sight."
 3 But he insisted strongly, so
 They turned in with him for to go
 Into his house. He made a feast,
 Baked bread, they ate it without yeast.

I came for the first time to eastern bank
 Of the Euphrates. Dusk I had to thank
 That from the imams' training school came
 out
 Five young men, by the river walked about
 And took me by compulsion, gave me meat
 And kept me in the mosque, a special treat,
 Until the evening prayers were done. I
 found
 A bed and home for one night. I am bound
 The gate of Sodom was no better place
 Nor more hospitable. No stranger's face
 Was seen but recognized as face of God.
 Beloved, I find Your face wherever mine
 Is recognized by what small mark and sign.
 The kernel's sweet, though we see only
 pod.

4 Before they could lie down, the men
 Of Sodom, old and young again,
 From every quarter, here they came
 All to surround the house for shame.
 5 They called to Lot and said "Where are
 The men who came to you tonight?
 Bring out the guests from near or far
 And let us get acquainted right."

From loving contemplation of the face
 The evil heart will without guide give place
 To lust, and lust bring forth at last the fruit
 Of violence in rape to follow suit.
 So great and civilized reduced in lust
 And violence, sank faith to humble dust.
 The heart imagines shining faith to be
 Its hallmark in any depravity.
 The pristine "I" remains divine through all
 The byways of transgression's beck and
 call.
 Beloved, I turn from contemplation of
 Your face upon creation's screen of love
 And find how easily illusion's pall

Falls on the empty heart without recall.

6 Lot went out to them through the door,
And shut the door behind him, for
7 He said "Please, do not, brothers mine,
Act wickedly, *but well and fine!*
8 "See now, I have two daughters of
My congregation who've had love
From no man yet. I'll bring them out
And you shall choose *without a doubt*
Which of you men shall marry them.
But do no harm, do not condemn
These guests of mine, and stay aloof,
For they are guests beneath my roof."

The laws of marriage never fail to stand,
And hospitality to give a hand
To traveller in the way remains for good.
All brothers must behave the way they
 should,
No matter what the level of their power,
Degree of wealth, no matter what the hour
Or what the vision of Your glory be.
The mystic state does not set any free
From duty to obey the divine law.
Just as the master of high algebra
Does not give up the simple two plus two,
I bow to ethics even in the pew
Of mystic brotherhood. Beloved, the roof
Casts shadows on the friend and the aloof.

9 They said "Stand back! This one came in
To live *here* and tell us what's sin.
Keep acting as a judge and we
Shall deal worse with you than with them.
You certainly shall not go free."
So they pressed hard, Lot tried to stem
The tide against him, but in vain,
They nearly broke the door in twain.
10 The men reached out their hands and
 took
Lot in the house, shut door, 11 and struck
The men who *were* at the doorway
Of the house with blindness, *they say*,
Both small and great, and so they wore
Themselves to rags to find the door.

Blindness on blindness does not stop the go
To find the door to heaven and to show
Both self and world that I am never wrong
Though rightness cannot taste my weary
 song

In truth. The frantic flight toward the sky
In search of spirituality and pie
Does not give up though clouds of dark and
 mist
Protect the frozen heights of thought, insist
That on the sunny side of firmament
There is the gold-filled pot to which I'm
 sent.
I shall beat down the door and show I'm
 brave
Who search for You, Beloved, not like a
 slave,
But with a virile sense ignoring doom,
A man who knows his place and well-
 stocked room.

12 Then the men said to Lot, "Have you
Anyone else here? Son-in-law,
Your sons, your daughters, and whom you
Have in this grand basilica,
Take all and leave this wretched place!
13 "We will destroy this place, because
The outcry of their breaking laws
Has grown great in front of YHWH's face,
And YHWH has sent us to destroy it."
14 So Lot went out not to enjoy it
But warning to his sons-in-law,
Who'd married his daughters, his awe
Did not affect them when he said
"Get up, and leave this place, for YHWH
Will spoil this city!" But his head
Was foolish to his sons-in-law
Who were not worth the talking to.

This world is upside down, and yet its folk
Walk upright as it were. My faith, I poke
My head around the corner just to see
How civilized upside down things can be.
All things continue as they ought and
 should
Since time was made, and mount and
 valley stood.
And yet a day can come when all things
 change,
When narrow breaks out in a further range
Of mountains, smoke on valleys, rising
 seas.
Who spoke of variance from routine lees
Met storms of ridicule. I make my days
Eventless, yet unique in all their ways
As I seek You, Beloved, each day anew,
Infinities of stays in what You do.

15 When morning dawned, the angels
 urged
 Lot to hurry, "Get up, diverged,
 Take wife, both daughters who are here,
 Lest you be consumed *in the fear*
 And punishment of Sodom." 16 And
 While he lingered, they took his hand,
 His wife's and both his daughters' too,
 Since mercy came to him from YHWH,
 And brought him out *as they had pity*,
 And set him down outside the city.

Lay hold on me, Beloved, I linger here
 Beneath the rosy dawn. I have no fear.
 Is it not good I have no fear at all?
 Is it not grand my hearing of Your call
 Has well inured me to the fateful ball,
 And left me set apart, serene and calm
 While others frantically avoid the bomb,
 The others being angels even? My
 High state of spirituality, so high,
 Prevents any response to hue and cry.
 Is it not fine, Beloved, I know no rage
 And sit emotionless from age to age?
 They are but prisoners of dark illusion,
 (Are they not?) who succumb to the
 confusion.

17 It happened, when they'd brought them
 out,
 He said "Escape, don't turn about!
 Don't look behind you, no, nor stay
 Anywhere in the plain or way.
 Go to the mountains, lest you be
 Destroyed." 18 Then Lot spoke to them, he
 Said "Please, no, O my lords! 19 "Indeed
 Now, I, your servant, in my need,
 Have found grace in your sight, and you
 Have multiplied the mercy you
 Have shown me by saving my life,
 But I can't escape with my wife
 Into the mountains, lest some danger
 Come overtake me while a ranger
 And I die. 20 "See now, this city
Is near enough for me to flee,
 And it's a small one, please now give
 Me leave to go there and to live."

The city is a symbol of Your beauty,
 Beloved, and so I live in one as duty.
 The duty to bring to the civilized

The divine message should be realized.
 The mystic cup kept to oneself alone
 In time turns fat and meat to tasteless bone.
 So let me join the throngs in some bright
 city
 Where men are great and women know no
 pity.
 If I should have to live on mountain slope
 Who knows what evil might destroy my
 hope,
 Who knows what tender flowers after the
 rain
 Might clog my path to wealth and mystic
 gain?
 Let my soul live near possibilities
 And not beneath the stars and awful trees.

21 And he said to him, "See, I grant
 You your request as habitant,
 And shall not overthrow this city
 For which you have appealed in pity.
 22 "But hurry and escape there quickly.
 For I must wait for you and prickly
 Till you arrive, so I can act.
That is part of my promised pact."
 That's why Zoar's the city's name,
And it means small, but not to blame.
 23 The sun had risen upon the land
 When Lot entered Zoar with his band.
 24 Then YHWH rained brimstone down
 with fire
 On Sodom and Gomorrah, ire
 From YHWH out of the heavens come
 25 So He destroyed them, made them
 dumb,
 And all the plain, the people in
 The cities, and what grew for bin.

I understand Your killing all the people
 And breaking down both wall and dome
 and steeple
 With fire and brimstone fully justified.
 But everything that grew on the ground
 died.
 Are plants and flowers sinful, and is fruit
 Worth nothing in Your sight, like dust and
 soot?
 Ah, kill the worried people, Lord, but spare
 The violet and coltsfoot, make not bare
 The lovely earth, the fragrant ground and
 soil.
 Curse not again the earth for human toil.

Keep brimstone on the city and the fashion,
But when it comes to wild wood, have
 compassion.
My I-ness with a curious willingness
Relinquishes the people You would bless.

26 But his wife looked back behind him,
Became a tower of salt for whim.

The wife of Lot, she was a comely lot
Of sack, and popular for what she'd got.
Salt of the earth, they said who knew her
 best.

Shoulders and head she stood above the
 rest.

She knew the score, and kept her man in
 hand,

Her husband so susceptible to grand
And noble visions, quite up in the air.
But Lot's wife handled more than was her
 share.

She looked back to be sure nothing
 forgotten

Preyed on her mind, not gold, linen or
 cotton.

She looked back on a life ordered, well
 kept,

And stood to take a hand, and stood, and
 slept.

Who handles well the world and life and
 show

Remains asleep, and salted down to mow.

27 And Abraham went early out
To where he and YHWH'd stood about.

28 Then he looked toward the city plain,
To Sodom and Gomorrah's pain,
And toward all the land of the plain,
And he saw, and indeed, the smoke
Of the land about which God spoke
Went up like smoke from a furnace.

29 And it happened, that, when alas,
Alohim spoiled the cities on
The plain, that Alohim went on
To mind Himself of Abraham,
And sent Lot out of all the *sham*

And spoil, when He destroyed the place
Where Lot had lived *and shown his face*.

I look at rosy dawn toward the place
Your Angel stood, and see again his face
Set in compassion and in well-sought duty.

I see again Your Angel in his beauty.
The burning love You hold to all mankind
Will not be satisfied with torn and blind,
But must take of the first and best of all
To sacrifice in sweetness and in gall.
I turn toward the flames of charity
And feel the hotness on my face, I see
The longing fires sprung quickly from
 Your heart

To cleanse the soul in every nook and part
Of othernesses and of other gods,
Till You alone are left above the clods.

30 Then Lot went out of Zoar and lived
Up in the mountains, negated
Had been his living in Zoar for
Himself and both his daughters, more
Could not be borne, and so he went
To live in caves instead of tent.

31 Now the firstborn said to the younger,
*"Our father, leader without hunger
Of this diminished dervish order,
Is old, and there's nor man nor boarder
To marry us in all the earth.*

32 *"Come, let us make our father-priest
Of congregation and of worth
Drink wine of ecstasy. At least
He'll marry us and thus preserve
His line of children and not swerve."*

Afraid to live among the riot ways
Of city nights and polished city days,
Lot takes two women from his
 congregation

To build on ashes towards another nation.
And yet his scruples as a man of God
Will not permit him to plough up the sod.
Loss, loss is all a man can ever find
In Zoar or in Sodom with the blind.
He offered them in marriage to blind fools
Who came at last in refuge to the pools
Of solitude and duty. Sometimes there
Is nothing left but water and still air.
Bless then, Beloved, the refugee and star,
The wandering satyrs wherever they are.

33 So they made their father *and priest*
Drink wine *of ecstasy increased*
That very night and the first born
Contracted marriage and was sworn,
And consummated though he knew
Not when she came nor when withdrew.

34 It happened on the next day too
The firstborn told the younger, "Do
As I did with our father-*leader*,
Let him drink wine, become conceder,
And enter marriage contract so
You shall lie with him to make grow
The line of our father *and beau*."

If wine of ecstasy is what is taught
In this crude story or if wine that's bought
From liquor outlet is intended here,
It makes but little difference, I fear.
The story is a warning for both things,
The weaknesses of labourers and kings.
I drink the clear draught of water of life
I find served at Your table, and not strife.
Beloved, I find the drunkenness You give
Makes mind and senses clearer where I
live.

The heady realizing You are One
Is stronger stimulation than the fun
Of drinking and carousing. You are my
Sane knowing, my Beloved, without the
pie.

35 Then they made their father drink wine
Of ecstasy and countersign
A contract of wedding and so
The younger lay, nor did he know
When she lay down nor when she rose.
36 So both young ladies as they chose
Were pregnant by the priestly throes.
37 The firstborn gave birth to a son
And called his name Moab *when done*.
He *is* ancestor to this day
Of Moabites. 38 The younger's way
Was to give birth to son also
And Ben-Ammi was his *chapeau*.
He's ancestor to Ammon now
Or till the last day *anyhow*.

The two last members of Lot's hearth cry
out
In anguish at the wicked world about.
They fear the faith in You, Belovèd, ends
Since they and Lot alone remain Your
friends.

If the last coal upon the hearth grows cold,
No longer shall the sparks fly up and bold
Hearts whirling, whirling there shall cease.
The wicked world is gone, their isle of
peace

Contains the leader of the faith and them
Alone to bow before the seamless hem.
He will not in his faithfulness agree
To take advantage of the souls that be
Beneath his sole protection, then we must
Bind fast the marriage contract and but
trust."

Genesis 20

1 And Abraham journeyed from there
Into the south, and lived somewhere
Between Kadesh and Shur, and stayed
In Gerar. 2 Now Abraham said
Of Sarah his wife, "She's my sister."
That was a bit of a truth twister.
The king Abimelech of Gerar
Then sent and took to himself Sarah.
3 But Alohim came to the king
By night as he dreamed of the thing,
And said to him, "Indeed you're dead
Because the woman you would wed
Is a man's wife." 4 Abimelech
Had not come near her *or her deck*,
And he said "Lord, and will You slay
A righteous nation? 5 "Did he say
To me, 'She *is* my sister'? And
She herself said no countermand,
'He *is* my brother.' In my heart's
Integrity and in my parts
Of innocence I've sought my hand."

Since You, Beloved, spoke to Cain and not
Abel

I have not been convinced prophetic label
Is worth the having. Now You speak to one
That Abraham feared for his life once done.
Abimelech was king and dangerous.
Granted he was a righteous man if fuss
That he did not commit adultery
At least on one occasion sets him free
Of every other accusation found.
It seems to free his nation whole and sound.
In such a sarkie I too might be tempted
To tell a lie and hope to be exempted.
You deal with both these princes in a way
That makes me wish I too had word to say.

6 And Alohim said to him in
A dream, "I know you meant no sin.
That's why I kept you from the thing,
Nor let you touch her *nor her sting*.
7 "Now therefore, restore the man's wife,

For he's a prophet, for your life
He'll pray and you shall surely live,
But if you shall refuse to give
Her back, then you shall truly die,
Both you and all your passers-by."

Abimelech himself became a prophet
By hearing Your voice, not a thing to scoff
at.

Does this mean that the wife need not
return

To husband if that man has none to earn?
I'd think she should be given back to any,
To labourer or prince, with piles or penny,
And all alike. I guess that's just my bias
For the democracy that's come to try us.
Let either Abraham or king say prayers
For me to live and not put on their airs.
Withhold me too, Beloved, from sin at
heart

And hand, and I shall do my humble part.
I need not be a prophet, need not hear
More than Your loving silence at my ear.

8 Abimelech rose in the morning,
Called all his servants to give warning,
And told the news in all their hearing,
And all the men were greatly fearing.
9 Abimelech called Abraham
And said to him, "What is this sham?
What have you done to us? Have I
Offended you, that you should try
To bring great sin on me and mine?
What you have done is not benign."

In horror of my dreams I wake and rise
And seek the comfort of the morning skies
Turned red with all Your servants walking
there

Beneath the stars, above the icy air.
Your warning, my Beloved, burns in my
breast

As morning light turns from the east to
west.

"Look not to beauty and attractive face"
You tell my soul. "In this brief time and
place

There is no safety following desire."
Yet I desire Your face, Beloved, aspire
To hear Your silences, and weigh Your
sight
Invisible. Let me awake from night

To find Your day notes ringing on my ears,
Gone dreams, illusions and their empty
fears.

10 Abimelech told Abraham,
"What intention's behind this scam,
That you have done a thing like this?"

11 And Abraham said "If I miss
My guess, because I thought, the fear
Of Alohim surely's not here,
And they will kill me for my wife.

12 "But indeed *she, upon my life,*
Is truly sister. She, the daughter
Of my father's *tribal ancestor*,
But not the daughter of my mother,
Became the wife of me, her brother.

13 "And it happened, when Alohim
Caused me to wander from the team
Of my ancestral home, that I
Said to her, 'When we're passing by
These foreign places be so kind
To say I am your brother, mind.'"

Brother and sister is the thing I hear
In every place I go, no doubt sincere.
The folk demand my prayers on their
behalf

As though I had a mitre and a staff.
At first I made for each true supplication,
A separate prayer for each one's
consolation,

But with time started making one for all,
A list of names, a puppet and a doll.
And then I noticed brothers had forgotten
They'd asked for prayers at all.
That should have taught one
That brother, sister's just a word to say
When silence threatens to appal the day.
I have no siblings, sincere ones or not,
But do not covet Abraham nor Lot.

14 Abimelech took oxen, sheep,
Gave him maids and servants to keep,
And gave to Abraham his wife,
Sarah, *because he feared for life.*

15 Abimelech said "See, my land
Is here before you, stay and stand
Wherever in it you may please."

16 Then to Sarah he said "*To ease*
My conscience I have given your brother
A thousand in silver to smother
The taint upon your reputation

Before my people and my nation."

And thus she was rebuked, *I deem*.

17 So Abraham prayed Alohim,

And Alohim healed both the king

Abimelech, his wife's bearing,

And all his maids to bear again,

18 For YHWH had closed up all in vain

The wombs in all the royal court

Of king Abimelech in sort,

For Sarah, Abraham's consort.

A thousand pieces made of silver or
Of gold would hardly begin to restore
The reputation lost. Indeed, it would
In my eyes raise suspicions, yes, it could.

Why give a thousand, if he had not laid
A lawless hand or leg on her or made
A fatal kind of proposition? My
Mind rests alone because of, by the by,
What You said, that You'd kept the man
from sin.

So why was she rebuked? The men came in
The matter just as much as she, or more.
The lying increased cattle, wealth and
store.

Why did You close the womb, Beloved,
and not

The testicle of king and prince besot?

Genesis 21

1 And YHWH visited Sarah as

He had said, and YHWH truly has

Done for Sarah as He had spoken.

2 Sarah conceived, *no promise broken*,

And bore to Abraham a son

In his old age, the set time done

Which Alohim had promised him.

Who knows what Sarah had been up to
while

She was in court of king with rankle file?
Abimelech indeed may have been shy
To touch the lady as she's passing by,
But what's to say her barrenness was
changed

To fruitfulness by younger courtiers
ranged?

The miracle may not be more than that
A younger rod rose to occasion's fat.
If she would keep her virtue and good
name,

She should have kept herself out of harm's
game.

But You, Beloved, come to the rescue fast
Of every virgin birth, no stone to cast,
And claim for Yourself only victory
In saying "Be!" And so the soul's set free.

3 And Abraham did call the name
Of his son who was born to him,
Whom Sarah bore him without shame,
Isaac. 4 Then Abraham recalled
The pact and circumcised his son
Isaac when eight days had been run,
As Alohim commanded him.

The first involuntary circumcision,
Unless protesting servants lacked the
vision,
Made Isaac son of Abraham. I wonder
If he complained for being cut asunder,
As some did later when the Greeks thought
better

Of flaunting all in gymnast chain and fetter,
And so they stretched their foreskins out
again.

Not so with Isaac, man among the men.
What scrappy things we humans choose to
fight on,

A piece of pork or die, run naked right on
The main street of Jerusalem, or cut
The hair or beard in such and such a rut.
Men heat themselves for and against this
practice
Even now. Beloved, give me slice of
cactus.

5 When Abraham was one hundred
Years old his son Isaac was bred.

6 And Sarah said "Alohim has
Made me to laugh, *and* as well as
All who hear." 7 And she also said
"Who would have said to Abraham
That Sarah'd be pushing a pram?
For I have borne a son in his
Old age." 8 So the child grew, as is,
Was weaned. And Abraham made feast
On the same day that Isaac ceased
To suckle, was weaned from his dam.

The greatest of temptations in this world
Is that before which Sarah doubtless curled.
It is believing that no thing can come

As a surprise, that all things are clear sum
Of what is known, and drab, and failing
grey.

The fact is that the sun of each new day
Arises on surprises, expectations
Are almost always like somnambulations,
Imaginations. But reality
Is full of unsought possibility.
And Sarah might have not had so much
grief
If she had doubted more grounded belief.
You do, Belovèd, what You do and not
What women and old men were taught and
thought.

9 And Sarah saw the son of Hagar
The Egyptian, whom she had borne
To Abraham, and it did plague her
To see him scoffing him to scorn.
10 Therefore she said to Abraham,
"Cast out this woman and *the ham*
She calls a son, for he, son of
This bondwoman shall not be heir
With my son, Isaac, whom I love."
11 The matter did not appear fair
To Abraham, who loved his son.
12 But Alohim told Abraham,
"Do not fret for the thing that's done,
Nor for the lad nor for *the lamb*,
Your bondwife, hear what Sarah says,
Isaac truly shall wear the fez
And give birth to your descendants.
13 "Yet I too shall greatly enhance
The nation the bondwoman's son
Shall sire, since he's your number one."

Displeasing in the sight of Abraham
It may have been, in that I doubt no scam.
But what about his wife named Hagar, she
Was thrown out on her ear and had to be
A bitter sort for that. Was not the prophet
Concerned for Hagar too when she got off
it?

Beloved, a son is one thing, so's a daughter.
But I cannot believe he quite forgot her.
He split his household, true, and so his
heart
Was split forever for that jealous part.
If Sarah's plaint was founded, still the cure
Was only in externals, never sure.
Whatever comes or may there is no way

To split my heart from Yours by night or
day.

14 So Abraham rose early in
The morning, and took bread and skin
Of water, and put on her shoulder,
He gave *it* to Hagar *and bolder*,
The boy, and sent them both away.
Then she departed on her way
And wandered in the wilderness
Of Beersheba. 15 The water *less*
And less inside the skin was soon
Used up, and *at the hottest noon*
She put the boy beneath a shrub.
16 Then she went and sat *in the scrub*
Across from *him* as far as bow
Might shoot an arrow, and said low
To herself, "Let me not see how
The boy will die." *Beneath the bough*
She sat across from where he slept
And lifted up her voice and wept.

The vale of Baca, so it's called in Psalm
Where Ishmael's and his mother Hagar's
balm
Was not so easy come by. Vale of Baca,
The Vale of Weeping, now turned into
Mecca,
Poor, blind, commercial Mecca, so much
like
Her sister old Jerusalem, a hike
To northward. There the boy with Hagar
wept
And waited, drank, rejoiced and at last
slept.

That valley enters many dreams to sweep
The memory awake with all its deep,
Dark longings. Hagar wept that she was
there,
And since that day millions have not the
fare
To trek a pilgrimage commemorating
Her sorrow and, Beloved, her reinstating.

17 And Alohim heard the lad's voice.
Alohim's Angel saw her *choice*,
And called to Hagar out of heaven,
And asked her *without sour or leaven*,
"What ails you, Hagar? Fear not, for
Alohim hears the lad's tenor
There where he is. 18 "Get up and lift
The lad and hold him *like a gift*,

For I shall make him a great nation."

19 Then Alohim opened her eyes,
She saw a well *in her elation*
And went and filled *to her surprise*
The skin with water, gave the lad
A drink of the water *she had*.

20 So Alohim was with the lad,
In the desert he lived and grew,
Became an archer *without crew*.

21 The wilderness of Paran was
His home. His mother, *as one does*,
Looked for a wife for him and got
One from Egypt *where she was bought*.

A water bottle and a loaf of bread
I take from You, Beloved, when all is said
And set out on the morning for the road,
The desert road that must be my abode.
When I have taken all provisions that
You gave me, comes a time when I have
sat

Bereft beneath the sparsely shading bush,
Entangled in a world of pull and push,
No bread, and empty bottle on my
shoulder.

Beloved, at this moment make me bolder
To reach beyond the daily portion's fare
And know that in the desert You are there.
Though I have eat and drunk the heavenly
tract,

I turn from You to You to be exact.

22 And it happened that at that time
Abimelech, *partner in crime*
Phichol, Commander of his forces,
Told Abraham, *without remorses*,
"Alohim *is* with you in all
You do. 23 "Now therefore, swear by all
And Alohim that you will not
Deal falsely with me, nor begot
By me, nor my posterity,
But with the kindness that you see
That I have done to you, you will
Do to me, to the land fulfil
The kindness you have met with here."
24 And Abraham said "I will swear."
25 Then Abraham rebuked the king
Abimelech because a spring
Of his that he had dug hard squeezed
Abimelech's servants had seized.

I too live in the shadow of a well

That I did not dig, but with pick and spell
Was dug before my father had been born.
So I come to another's well forsworn.
To find its fragrant waters I left home
And house, lifted my baggage, came to
roam

To this one well. I drink it when I wake
And just before I sleep, at noon I take
Deep draughts, and every time between I
find

My thirst renews and quenches in that
vined

And lilac-ed spring. Beloved, my thirst
renews

Not only with the morning and the dews,
But in the intervals that I forget
Your presence with and in me since we
met.

26 Abimelech said "I don't know
Who did this thing, you did not show
Me this before, and just today
I heard the thing." 27 *So in his way*
Abraham took oxen and sheep,
Gave to Abimelech *to keep*,
And both of them made covenant.
28 And Abraham *was adamant*
And set seven ewe lambs of the flock
By themselves. 29 Then *the king took*
stock,

Abimelech asked Abraham,
"What *means this pile of* female lamb
Seven in number you have set
By themselves?" 30 And he said "I let
You take seven ewe lambs from my hand,
To be a witness that my hand
Has dug this well." 31 Therefore he called
That place Beersheba, *unappalled*
That both of them swore an oath there.
32 Beersheba means they stopped to swear.
Abimelech and Phichol rose,
Commander of his army, chose
To go back to the Philistines.
To further there their own designs.
33 Then he planted a tamarisk
In Beersheba, and there was brisk
To call the name YHWH El Olam,
34 And Abraham stayed under palm
And in the land of Philistines
For many days in his confines.

By seven ewe lambs Abraham did swear

The well was dug by him both fair and square.

By seven lambs of guidance You came late
To covenant Your will and human fate.

The water springing up in life is brought
In charger of green malachite well-sought
By hand of Ali and his blessed sons
As far as daylight on the heavens runs.

The sevens come again though rarely seen
To whirl upon the pedestals of green,
And spark the sacrifices towards the sky
Whence sacrificial lambs lie down to die.
So hidden Ismail gives his place to Moses
And both know what another just supposes.

Genesis 22

1 It happened after these things that
Alohim tested Abraham,
And then said to him, "Abraham!"
And he said "Here is where I'm at."
2 Then He said "Take now then your son
Your only son Isaac, the one
You love, and go to Moriah,
And offer Isaac there as a
Burnt offering on one of the mountains
Which I shall show you *with its fountains*."

There never was a time when Isaac was
The only son of Abraham, because
Ishmael his brother was the older one.
That clearly shows this text to be in fun,
Corrupted, or a liturgy of passing
From childhood status to adulthood
classing.

Such rites are known throughout the
blessèd world
Where masks and mock death pageants are
unfurled
To end in resurrections finely staged.
Since most men have one wife alone
engaged,

The words of rite speak of the eldest child
As being only one. We're not so mild
We moderns, but insist on human gore.
Primitives enjoyed celebration more.

3 So Abraham rose early in
The morning, saddled *for the spin*
His donkey, and took two of his
Young men, also Isaac who is
His son, and he split wood for burnt
Offering, rose, went to where he'd learnt

From Alohim to go. 4 Then on
The third day Abraham was drawn
To lift his eyes and saw the place
Afar off. 5 "We'll just go a pace
Up yonder and worship, and we
Shall come back where you wait *freely*
Here with the donkey," so said he.

I'm not much one for rites and celebration.
I'd let father and son go to their station
And stay myself to take care of the donkey,
Preferring silence to the honkey-tonkey
And din of Christian worship. Prayer is
made

Best when the shepherd before the parade
Of Your creation stands alone to call
To prayer and then prostrating before all
The crowds of bugs and beetles prays
alone.

Better than Persian carpet's sand and stone.
I guess I'm wild ass of some sort myself
And cannot stay upon the mosquely shelf.
With Ishmael I run out alone, Beloved,
Avoiding being hit and kicked and shoved.

6 So Abraham took of the wood
For the burnt offering, *where he stood*
He set it on Isaac his son
And took the fire in hand and one
Knife, so the two went on together.
7 But Isaac spoke to Abraham
His father and said "O my father!"
And he said "My son, here I am."
Then he said "Look, the fire and wood,
But where's the lamb an offering should
Require?" 8 And Abraham said "Son,
Alohim will provide Him one
Lamb for offering before we've done."
So then the two of them went on
Together. 9 Then they came upon
The place Alohim had told of.
And Abraham built there above
An altar and placed wood in order,
And bound Isaac his son *a warder*,
And laid him on the altar and
Upon the wood. 10 And then his hand
Did Abraham stretch out and take
The knife to cut his son *like cake*.

The ritual in theatre goes on,
Each spoken line is hallowed since the
dawn

Of time. How many sons and fathers have
 Repeated, aborigine to Slav,
 A variant on the theme. And Abraham
 Himself had once before this holy sham
 Enacted, re-enacting course of life
 That all must live upon the edge of knife.
 He stretched his hand on Ishmael once
 before
 And heard once then the ritual in store
 For every faithful father and first son.
 And yet the heart beats higher when it is
 done.
 In rite there is reality of meeting,
 As You, Beloved, bend down to human
 greeting.

11 The Angel of YHWH called to him
 From heaven and he said "Abraham,
 Abraham!" He said "Here I am."
 12 And He said "Do not lay a *grim*
 Hand on the lad, nor do him harm,
 For now I know *beyond all charm*
 That you fear Alohim, since you
 Have not withheld your son, but drew
 The knife on your darling for Me."
 13 Then Abraham *delightedly*
 Lifted his eyes and looked, and there
 Behind, a ram caught in the *hair*
Of thicket by its horns. So he
 Went, took the ram, and *thankfully*
 Offered it for a burnt offering
 Instead of his *own* son. 14 *To bring*
The story to a close he named,
 Did Abraham the place (*unblamed*
For human sacrifice) YHWH-Will-
 Provide, and as it is said *still*
To this day, "In the Mount of YHWH
 It shall be *all* provided *too*."

No lesson for mankind was ever clearer,
 That You, Beloved, in drawing ever nearer
 The human heart, reject the sacrifice
 Of human life from gate of Paradise
 To threshold of atomic war. You take
 No blood in bond or prosecution for
 Sin or forgiveness. Grace alone is more
 Than any offering of blood can bring.
 The living sacrifice of love is king.
 Who trust in blood of Jesus Christ mistake
 Reality and temple metaphor.
 Obedience and love are all You take.
 The sacrifice of rising up to live

Is what I must be satisfied to give.

15 The Angel of YHWH called to him,
 To Abraham a second hymn
 Out of heaven, 16 and said "By Myself
 I have sworn, says YHWH, since *no elf*
But you have done this thing, and not
 Withheld your son, your only *got*,
 17 "I will surely bless you, and I
 Will your descendants multiply
 As much as the stars in the sky
 And as the sand upon the shore,
 And your descendants, *what is more*,
 Shall possess their enemies' door.
 18 "In your seed all the nations of
 The earth shall be blessed *from above*,
 Because you have obeyed My voice."
 19 So Abraham turned to *rejoice*,
 Came to his young men, (*Isaac too*),
 And they rose and without ado
 Went together to Beersheba;
 Abraham lived at Beersheba.

Each son must learn the lesson of the
 father,
 Or otherwise there is no use to bother.
 Each generation has to give a life
 To You, Beloved, or renew the strife
 Of trying to be self and self alone
 Instead of self in Self, and not atone.
 So Isaac learned, as Ishmael had before
 him,
 To lie beneath the knife till You restore
 him
 To live a life of faith and trust in You,
 And when You give commandment, then to
 do.
 Then blessings rain on father and on son
 Like stars for multitude, and when that's
 done,
 Like sand upon the shore. The open gate
 Invites to enter life proportionate.

20 It happened after these things that
 It was told Abraham *out flat*
 That "indeed Milcah also bore
 Children to your brother Nahor,
 21 "Huz his firstborn, and Buz his brother,
 Kemuel Aram's father *another*,
 22 "Chesed, Hazo, Pildash, Jidlaph,
 And Bethuel." 23 Bethuel *had last laugh*
 Producing Rebekah. These eight

Milcah bore to Nahor, *her mate*
And Abraham's brother. 24 He had
Also a concubine, (*a fad*),
Whose name was Reumah, also she
Gave birth to Tebah, Gaham, *see*,
And Thahash, and Maachah *for free*.

The brother of the prophet also had
A concubine, the first man who's not bad
To have that fling. His brother who
invented

The just polygamy, if not demented,
Set that example for the future woe
Of every man and woman who should go
That route to familial unhappiness.
Yet You, Beloved, did never fail to bless
But granted Reumah four sons for her pain.
She named them strangely Slaughter and a
Burning

And Badger or a Seal and Bruising. Vain
Indeed to curb a mother's only earning,
Yet Maachah shows the feminine in ending
Can be a man's name too without
offending.

Week 5 Genesis 23

1 Sarah lived one hundred and twenty-
Seven years, *and these years were plenty*
In Sarah's life. 2 So Sarah died
In Kirjath Arba (that's *beside*
Hebron) in Canaan's land, and came,
Did Abraham, to mourn *the name*
Of Sarah and weep for her *fame*.

The brittle, angry Sarah now in death
Calls forth from Abraham more than a
breath

In sighs. I wonder did she oft regret
The indoor plumbing gracing Ur, forget
The miles of waste and sand between her
land

Of birth and land of death and what is
worse

Her land of living. Few can understand
How many years of disappointment curse
The life of Sarah. Few can know her pain.
Her only joy was Isaac's birth and plain
And lifelong jealousy for men and looks.
Her desert life did not include good books,
Or theatre and concerts: dreary dying
Without tv or videos for vying.

3 Then Abraham stood up before
His dead *wife*, and then spoke some more
To the sons of Heth, saying 4 "I
Am just a foreigner and my
Visit among you is extended.
Give me a burying place intended
To bury from my sight my dead."
5 The sons of Heth replied to him,
To Abraham, 6 "Hear *to the brim*,
My lord: You *are* a mighty prince
Among us, bury your dead since
The choicest places are all free
And none of us will charge a *pea*,
So bury your dead where you wish."
7 Then Abraham stood up *to fish*
And bowed himself before the folk
Of the land, sons of Heth and spoke
And said to them 8 "If it's your wish
That I bury my dead, then dish
A deal for me with Ephron son
Of Zohar 9 "that he may give me
(*When everything is said and done*)
The cave of Machpelah which he
Has, which *is* at the end of his
Field. Let him give it as it is
To me at the full price, as place
To bury my dead from my face."

With Ephron like a fawn before the light
Of Zohar where the mystics come recite
The tricks of centuries, the prophet calls
For some place clad in peace and with
stone walls

To bury Sarah. Out of death the morning
Enchantment rises with its mists adorning
Departed soul of Sarah. Let men weep.
She lies at rest who stirred the wounded
deep

Of man's imagination. Shallow soul,
But dear, poor Sarah had no other goal
But son and grave. Her golden trinkets
graced
A skin-deep beauty, now all but effaced.
Beloved, I bless the prophet out of duty,
But of my own will bless his wife's lost
beauty.

10 Now Ephron lived among the sons
Of Heth, and Ephron the Hittite
Replied to Abraham who shuns
Not any sons of Heth in sight,
Within the city gate where pacts

Are made, and said 11 "Nothing distracts,
 Dear sir, me giving you the field,
 The cave that's in it, I will yield
 It all to you in presence of
 The people of my own *I love*,
 I give it to you, bury then
 Your dead *wife!*" 12 Abraham then *when*
He heard that bowed himself before
 The people of the land, 13 put oar
 To Ephron in their hearing, saying
 "If you *will give it*, please hear me.
 I'll give you money *without staying*
 As price for the field, take from me,
 And I shall bury my dead there."
 14 And Ephron answered Abraham,
 And said to him, 15 "Dear sir, beware
 The land *is worth* four hundred drachm
 In silver shekels. What *is* that
 Twixt you and me? Bury madame."

I am a stranger in this land, indeed,
 In every land, the sons of Heth proceed
 To live their lives of ownership. The streets
 Of towns and villages, squares where one
 meets
 A varied, shining throng, are filled to
 flowing.
 Their food and pleasure on the margins
 growing
 Stop breath for beauty, my Beloved, and
 bare
 The leaf and blossom and the fruit. I swear
 That beauty covers all things. I see You
 Peer out from eyes of strangers, almost
 raise
 A shout of greeting and run to embrace,
 And then see that You fail to see, You do,
 You do not recognize me, do not know,
 Beloved, I see it in the eyes that go.

16 And Abraham heard Ephron's word,
 And Abraham weighed out the *cured*
In silver for Ephron which he
 Had named in hearing of the free
 Men of Heth, four hundred shekels
 Of silver, in the clientele's
 Of merchants' favoured currency.
 17 The field of Ephron which *was in*
 Machpelah, east of Mamre, cave
 And field and all the trees therein,
 And all the borders of the place
 Were deeded to him *and with grace*,

18 To Abraham as a possession
 In presence of the sons of Heth,
 Before *the elders* all *in session*
 At city gate, *for Sarah's death*.
 19 After this, Abraham buried
 His wife Sarah in cave agreed
 Upon within the field that is
 In Machpelah, the one that is
 To east of Mamre that is called
 Hebron in Canaan. 20 And the *walled*
 Field and the cave that *is in it*
 Were given to Abraham by writ
 From the *generous* sons of Heth
 As place for burial at death.

Four hundred shekels weighed out clear
 and free
 In silver cold and bright that wonderfully
 Lay glinting in the sun: How soon does
 tarnish
 Make black the brightest coin! No magic
 varnish
 Can stay the valiant course of time, no rent
 Can make a house seem quite so permanent
 As does the tomb. The patriarch had gone
 A weary way from year to year from dawn
 Of hope to dimming of the light without
 An inch of sand to call his own. No place
 For living man to dwell and leave a trace
 Was his. And now the only land he owns
 Is cave to shut upon dead flesh and bones.
 Beloved, man's life is but a war with doubt.

Genesis 24

1 Now Abraham was old, advanced
 In age, and YHWH had blessed, *enhanced*
 Him in all things. 2 Abraham then
 Said to the foremost servant in
 His house, who ruled all in the pen
 And field, "Please, put your hand *and pin*
 Under my thigh, 3 "and I will make
 You swear by YHWH, the God of sky
 As well as God of earth, your *eye*
 Shall not seek my son's wife nor take
 One from the daughters *of the land*
 Of Canaan where I live. 4 "Your hand
 Shall seek my own country and go
 To my family, and take a wife
 For my son Isaac *for his life*."
 5 The servant said to him, "Perhaps
 The woman fearing some mishaps
 Will not be willing to come here.

Must I take your son back to see her
In the land from which you have come?"

6 But Abraham said to him, "*Rum*
Beware you don't take my son there.

7 "YHWH Alohim of heaven was fair
And took me from my father's house
And from the land of my family,
And spoke to me and did not douse
My hopes but swore and said to me,
'To your descendants I shall give
This land for them a place to live,'
He will send His angel before
You, and you shall take on the chore
To get a wife for my son there.

8 "And if the woman does not care
To follow you, then you will be
Released from this oath and duty.
Only do not take my son there."

9 The servant put his hand under
The thigh of Abraham, master,
And swore to him of this matter.

Two things appal me in the way Your
prophet,
O my Beloved, does things, enough to scoff
at,

And someone might. The first is swearing
with

A hand on thigh, that seems a local myth,
And none too savoury now. The second is
That enormously racist way of his
For choosing wives. Is not a Canaanite
Who had long chosen God of heaven and
right

A better choice than Laban's clan with gods
And goddesses of hearth and gate and
clods?

Why not search out a local girl with bright
Faith and good works? Or did the burning
sight

Of Sodom spoil his faith in mission work?
A third trap's wedding by disguise and lurk.

10 The servant took ten of his master's
Camels and left without disasters,
With all his master's goods in hand.
He rose and went into the land
Of Mesopotamia, to where
The city of Nahor stood fair.

11 He made his camels kneel down out
Beside the city well about
The time of evening when the girls

Came to draw *water in their curls*.

12 Then he said "O YHWH God of him
Who is my master Abraham,
Give me success this day, and show
Kindness to my master's trousseau.
13 "Indeed, *here* I stand by the well
Where all the lassies come a spell
To draw their water. 14 "Now let be,
The lady of Your choice be she
To whom I say 'Let down your jug
For me to drink,' says 'Take a slug
And I will give your camels drink,'
Your servant Isaac's wife, and so
Your kindness shall be where I know."

The servant of the prophet Abraham
Had learned his prayers by prophet's
epigram,
And so began to pray addressing You
As Sovereign and his master's God, great
Huu,

And then went to petition for divine
Guidance, the leading in the way for sign.
So too today the faithful pray in name
Of God, and as they worship You they
claim

The right to ask of You the guidance clear
In the right way, that of those blessed and
dear,

Not of the earners of Your wrath nor those
Who go astray. And so the servant throws
His voice abroad to glorify Your power
And then petitions guidance for the hour.

15 It happened, while the man was
speaking,

Rebekah Bethuel's daughter came,
Granddaughter of Milcah, came seeking,
Nahor's wife Milcah was the same,
Brother of Abraham Nahor,
Came with her pitcher on before,
Laid on her shoulder. 16 Now the girl
Was beautiful to see, no churl
Had ruined her virginity.

Down to fill up her pitcher she
Went and returning, the servant
Of Abraham marked where she went
To meet her and say "Please, let me
Drink just a bit from your lovely
Pitcher." 18 So she said "Drink, my lord."
Then quickly let her pitcher down
To her hand, and gave him a drink.

19 When she'd given him a drink, a word
 More she said "I would never frown
 To draw water and *in a wink*
 Give to your camels too until
 They've had enough and more to fill."
 20 Then she quickly emptied her pitcher
 Into the trough, ran back no richer
 To draw until she'd drawn for all.
 21 And the man, wondering at her haul,
 Stayed quiet to know whether YHWH
 Had made his trip success or no.
 22 So it was, when the camels finished
 Their drinking from the well diminished,
 He took a golden nose-ring that
 Weighed half a shekel where it sat
 And two bracelets for wrists that weighed
 Ten more of gold if they were paid.
 23 And said "Whose daughter *are* you?
 Say,
 If your father has room to stay."

It seems perennial gold nose ring was then
 As popular as now. I'd rather wen
 Had graced my brow. Be as it may, I say,
 The servant helped You find the wedded
 way.
 He did not take a chance that You would
 choose
 A lazy girl, he did not throw to lose.
 Should I too weight my prayers with
 golden coin
 And stipulations I require to join?
 If Eliezer could not trust You to
 Find wife without wealth and some task to
 do,
 Can I trust You to fill my plate and store
 With bounties promised without keeping
 score?
 Ah, my Beloved, I give You free rein here,
 No stipulations, no wealth and no gear!

24 "The daughter of Bethuel" she said
 "I am, and he is Milcah's son,
 To Nahor he was born *and bred*,
So genealogy is done."
 25 Moreover she said to him, "We
 Have straw enough and feed to be
 A place of lodging." 26 Then the man
 Bowed down his head and worshipped
 YHWH
 In prostration. 27 He said "*By plan*
 The blessed YHWH God, *what does He do,*

God of my master Abraham,
 Has not forsaken *by a gram*
 His mercy and His truth towards him.
 And as for me, while on my way,
 YHWH led me and led *not astray*
 To the house of my master's brothers."
 28 So the girl ran and told her mother's
 Household these things. 29 Rebekah had
 A brother whose name *was* Laban,
 And Laban *who was not a cad*,
 Ran out to the well and the man.
 30 It happened, when he saw the ring
 In her nose and the bracelets *sing*
 On his sister's wrists, and when he
 Heard the words of his sister *free*,
 Rebekah saying "And so he
 Spoke to me," that he went to see
 The man beside the camels at
 The well. 31 And he said "Come in, that
 Blessed of YHWH! Why do you stand here
 Outside? For I've prepared the place
 For you, and for the camels space."

The leavening of gold unites the man
 Of God to those whose thoughts must
 always span
 The golden hope, the secret that for life
 None so avails as gold to appease strife
 And give man immortality. Each new
 Born generation without fail believes
 The divine body's made of gold voodoo
 And having gold makes sure one never
 grieves.
 So gold made greedy Laban quick agree,
 And Eliezer found a pot of tea,
 A stable and a bed, and what is more
 The wife that Isaac would love and adore.
 Lay gold aside, Beloved, and see how
 many
 Still worship You, do You think there'll be
 any?

32 The man came to the house, and he
 Unloaded all the camels free,
 Provided straw and feed for them
 And water to wash from the hem
 And to his feet and of the men
 Who had come along with him then.
 33 *They* set before him spread to eat,
 But he said "I must first repeat
 My errand before taking bread."
 "Speak on," *the gracious host* then said.

34 He said "I'm Abraham's servant.
 35 "YHWH's blessed my master where he
 went,
 And made him great and He has given
 Him flocks and herds beneath the heaven,
 Silver and gold, servants and maids,
 Camels and donkeys, *accolades*,
 36 "And Sarah my master's wife bore
 A son to my master and for
 Sarah's old age, and now to him
 He's given all his gear and trim.
 37 "Now my master made me swear,
 saying
 'You shall not take a wife that's staying
 Among the Canaanites for my
 Son nor from their daughters where I
 Am living, 38 'but you shall go to
 My father's house and where I grew,
 To my kin and there find a wife
 For my son *now and all his life*.'
 39 "And I said to my master, 'May
 Be such a woman will not say
 That she will follow me.' 40 "But he
 Said to me, 'YHWH, before whom be
 My steps, will send His angel with
 You and prosper your way with kith
 And you shall take a wife for my
 Son from my kin *or wonder why*.
 41 'You will be clear from this oath when
 You come among my family, then
 If they will not give *her* to you,
 Then you are free from what you do
 And from my oath.' 42 "This day I came
 To the well and I said the same,
 'O YHWH God of my master Abe
 Raham, if You will now give luck
 To me so I don't pass the buck,
 43 'I stand beside the well, the babe
 That comes to draw and I ask her
 "Please quench my thirst with the liqueur
 Of water in your pitcher there,"
 44 'And she says to me, "*Fair is fair*,
 Drink, and I'll give your camels too,"
Let her be the woman whom YHWH
 Appointed for my master's son.'
 45 "But before I had got quite done
 The speaking in my heart, there was
 Rebekah, coming out to pause
 With pitcher on her shoulder, and
 She went down to the well to stand
 And draw. And I asked her, 'Please let
 Me drink.' 46 "And she made haste and let

Her pitcher down and said 'Drink, and
 I shall give your camels a hand.'
 So I drank, and she gave the camels
 A drink also *faster than Tamils*.
 47 "Then I asked her, and said 'Whose
 child
 Are you?' And she said *meek and mild*,
 'The daughter of Bethuel, son
 Of Nahor, whom Milcah, *hard-won*,
 Bore to him.' So I put the nose
 Ring on her nose and as it goes
 The bracelets on her wrists. 48 "And I
 Bowed down my head and worshipped
 YHWH,
 Prostrating there, and then blessed YHWH
 God of my master Abraham,
 Who'd led me truly to come by
 To take my master's brother's lamb
 A wife for his son. 49 "Now if you
 Will deal kindly and also true
 With my master, tell me. And if
 Not, tell me, that I may turn skiff
 To right or left." 50 Then Laban and
 Bethuel answered, "*Understand*,
 The thing comes from YHWH, we cannot
 Speak to you either bad or aught
 Of good. 51 "Here *is* Rebekah now
 Before you, you may take the frau
 And let her be your master's son's
 Wife, as YHWH said *without refunds*."
 52 And so it happened, when he heard,
 Did Abraham's servant their word,
 That he prostrated before YHWH,
Bowing to earth. 53 Then it is true,
 The servant brought out silver jewels,
 Jewellery of gold, and *other tools*,
Fine clothing, and gave *them* to her,
 Rebekah. He also gave things
 Of precious worth and furniture,
Fit only for queens and for kings,
 To her brother and mother too.
 54 Then he and his, men not a few,
 Ate, drank and stayed to sleep the night.
 Then they arose early to say,
 "Send me to my master today,
As it is but fitting and right."
 55 But her brother and mother said
 "Let the young woman stay instead
 With us *a few* days, at least ten,
 After that she may go again."
 56 And he said to them, "Do not stop
 Me from my task, since YHWH is prop

And stay to make my way the faster,
 Send me away now to my master."
 57 So they said "We will call the young
 Woman and hear from her own tongue."
 58 Then they called Rebekah and said
 "Will you go with this man *full fled?*"
 And she said "I will go." 59 So they
 Sent their Rebekah then away,
 Their sister and her nurse, and then
 Abraham's servant and his men.
 60 And they blessed Rebekah and said
 "Our sister, *may you be the mother*
Of thousands of ten thousands other,
 And may your children have each gate
 Of anyone that's filled with hate."
 61 Then Rebekah and her maids rose,
 Rode on the camels they each chose,
 Went with the man. The servant took
 Rebekah, left, no backward look.

The call of love and duty intervenes
 Between my soul and You for land and
 means,
 To cast the blessed vision in the way
 Of future years without the light of day.
 And so it would make that reality,
 The taste of salt and sweet on tongue for
 me
 A figure of imagination's dreams
 That shadows what behind me only seems.
 I shall not stop to play, not stop to sing,
 But rush to taste the marrow of the thing.
 Not cloistering nor losing in the play,
 But penetrating veils of where I stay.
 While others fly to heaven, I fling the boast
 Behind me where I sit upon the coast.

The coast I sit upon looks out to see
 The Gulf of Aqaba and Eilat's wee
 Port bringing in the slight and silver tide.
 Beneath the palms are camels for a ride,
 Upon the one of which my wife in stride
 Would fulfil lifelong dream to drive aside.
 To her chagrin the camel's seat is higher
 By twice the length a good horse would
 inspire,
 With nothing to hold onto while the mast
 Dips to the desert sand and then avast
 With rolling that sea legs alone can bear.
 I wonder that Rebekah sat down there
 To ride two hundred miles and more to
 share

No twinge of fright on the echoing air.

62 Now Isaac came from the way of
 Beer Lahai Roi from above
 Where he lived in the south. 63 And he,
 Isaac, walked in the field to be
 In meditation as the night
 Drew on, and raised his eyes to sight
 The camels coming home. 64 And then
 Rebekah lifted her eyes, when
 She saw Isaac she got down from
 Her camel, 65 for she had said to
 The servant, "This man walking, who
Is he, along the fields' edge come
To meet us?" Then the servant said
"It is my master." So she sped
 To take a veil and hide her *face*.
 66 And then the servant told the case
 To Isaac, all the things he'd done.
 67 Then Isaac brought the bride he'd won
 Into his mother Sarah's tent,
 He took Rebekah with consent
 To be his wife, and he loved her.
 So Isaac found comfort after
 His mother's *death and was content*.

I too at evening go abroad to find
 The field of sacrifice, and there I bind
 Myself to You, Beloved, I turn and whirl
 A meditation on the sky of pearl.
 You meet me veiled with hidden face
 withdrawn,
 The face whose beauty none can look upon,
 Fall from Your camel to come near to me,
 Beloved, unseen, but seeing faithfully.
 I take You to my mother's tent to sleep
 And find no slumber can touch You, nor
 keep
 You from Your vigil, my Beloved. Beware,
 The gold and silver threads embroidered
 there
 Make even thicker veils. I am content
 Whatever veils to be Your cherishment.

Genesis 25

1 Then Abraham married again
 A wife named Keturah. 2 And then
 She bore him Zimran, Jokshan, and
 Medan, Midian, Ishbak, and Shuah.
 3 Jokshan sired Sheba and Dedan.
 The sons of Dedan were *some fewer*,
 Asshurim, Letushim, and *last*

Leummim. 4 And the sons that passed
 From Midian *were* Ephah, Epher,
 Hanoch, Abidah, and Eldaah.
 All these *were* children of Keturah.
 5 And Abraham gave, *to assure her*,
 All that he had to Isaac, 6 but
 Abraham gave gifts and somewhat
 To all of his concubines' sons,
For Abraham had some such ones,
 And while he was still living sent
 Them eastward, there *to pitch their tent*
 Away from his son Isaac's *feast*,
 To live in the land of the east.
 7 This *is* the sum of all the years
 Of Abraham's life, *it appears*
 He lived one hundred seventy-five.
 8 Then Abraham, *no more alive*,
 Had breathed his last and he had died
 In good old age, an old man *tried*
 And full, and he was gathered to
 His people. 9 And as *good* sons do,
 Isaac and Ishmael buried him
 In the cave of Machpelah, which
Is east of Mamre, *with a hymn*,
 It's in the field of Ephron, *rich*,
 The son of Zohar the Hittite,
 10 The field which Abraham's *foresight*
 Had made him buy from sons of Heth,
 To be *the palace* where in death
 Lay Abraham and his *dear* wife
 Sarah *when they had finished life*.
 11 And after Abraham had died,
 Alohim blessed Isaac's *fireside*,
 Who lived at Beer Lahai Roi.

Two men above all men did Isaac love,
 His son the great and mighty hunter of
 The fields, and Ishmael, big brother that
 While playing near the tents where Isaac
 sat
 Upon the earth with paddle in the sand
 He saw ride out with bow and fearless
 stand
 Against the beasts of desert and of night.
 Big brother Ishmael was the strong and
 right
 In Isaac's eye from birth until the day
 That death took father Abraham away.
 And then he wept on Isaac's shoulder where
 They buried him together with fanfare.
 That moment Isaac knew that Ishmael's
 heart

Was knit to his in tears never to part.

12 Now this *is* genealogy
 Of Ishmael, Abraham's son, whom
 Hagar the Egyptian, gave womb
 When she was Sarah's maidservant,
 Bore Abraham *with her consent*.
 13 These *are* the names of Ishmael's sons,
 By name according to the ones
 That came first, firstborn of Ishmael,
 Nebajoth, then Kedar, Adbeel,
 Mibsam, 14 Mishma, Dumah, Massa,
 15 Hadar, Tema, Jetur, Naphish,
 And last of all came Kedemah.
 16 These *were* the sons of Ishmael,
 These *were* their names, *as one might wish*,
 By towns and settlements, that fell
 From twelve princes and by their nations.
 17 These *were* the years of *life and*
stations
 Of Ishmael: one hundred thirty
 And seven years, after which he
 Breathed his last and died, and was buried
 By his people. 18 They lived *and married*
 From Havilah as far as Shur,
 East of Egypt toward Ashur.
 And Ishmael died before the faces
 Of all his brothers *in their places*.

Loyal to death he was, proud Ishmael was,
 And died among his brothers just because
 He could not bear to part from them. His
 sire
 Had sent them all apart in his desire
 To keep peace reigning with the just and
 fair.
 Vain worry that, and empty was the care,
 For Ishmael with his great heart knew to
 keep
 His brothers well and peaceful like the
 sleep
 Of babes. He died with Isaac at his side
 And all his sons, tall, righteous and grief-
 eyed,
 Their names like sweetly wafting desert
 scents
 That whisper here and there among the
 tents.
 Ah my Belovèd, give to us again
 The peace of Isaac's Ishmael, peace of men.

Week 6

19 Now Isaac's genealogy,
 Abraham's *beloved* son was he.
 And Abraham produced Isaac.
 20 Isaac at forty sent to pick
 A wife in Rebekah, the daughter
 Of Bethuel, from where he sought her
 In Syria in Padan Aram,
 Sister of Laban the Syrian.
 21 Now Isaac prayed for his harem
 To YHWH, because she *was* barren,
 And YHWH granted his plea, and so
 His wife Rebekah went to grow.
 22 But the children within her fought,
 And she said "If *all is* as ought,
 Then why am I like this?" So she
 Went to inquire of YHWH. 23 And He,
 YHWH said to her, "Two nations *are*
 In your womb, two peoples shall be
 Taken from your body, *one star*
 Shall be the stronger, and the first
 Born shall be servant to the younger,
As though the first had been the worst."
 24 So when her days of infant-monger
 Were done for her to bear her child,
 Twins came from her womb, *meek and*
wild.
 25 The first came out red like a hairy
 Garment all over, so his very
 Name was Esau. 26 And afterward
 His brother came out, as though spurred
 His hand took hold of Esau's heel,
 So he was Jacob *for his zeal.*
 Isaac *was* sixty years old when
 She gave birth to each denizen.

I wonder if the vision had been sent
 To Isaac as well as the babies' mother,
 Things might have turned out better than
 they went
 With only that one woman's word, no other,
 To testify that You had chosen younger
 And left the elder to his thirst and hunger.
 If mild, this Isaac is still born a man
 Not likely to hear what Rebekah can
 Say of Your will and vision. Life is straight
 And filled more with dry hills and hardened
 fate
 Than grace. The deathbed dream in which
 all things
 Fall into patterns and unwaverings
 Is little comfort in the here and now.

Beloved, if it takes faith, then teach me
 how.

27 So the boys grew. And Esau was
 A skilful hunter, and because
 He loved the field, but Jacob *mildly*
 Stayed in the tents *and was not wildly.*
 28 And Isaac loved Esau because
 He ate his game, but Rebekah's
 Loved one was Jacob. 29 Now he cooked
 Did Jacob, a stew. Esau looked
 Weary to death come from the field.
 30 And Esau said to Jacob, "Yield
 Me some of that red stew, for I
Am weary." That's the reason why
 His name was Edom, which means red.
 31 But *wily* Jacob thought, *then* said
 "Sell me your birthright from this day."
 32 And Esau said "Look, I could die,
 So what's this birthright in my eye?"
 33 Then Jacob said "Swear to me now."
 So he swore to him, anyhow,
 And sold his birthright to Jacob.
 34 And Jacob gave Esau some grub,
 Both bread and stew of lentils too.
 He ate and drank, and *said adieu,*
 Arose, and went his way. The sight
 Shows Esau despised *his* birthright.

The competition was between the son
 Of Abraham and his own wife begun,
 Not Ishmael beloved brother. First
 Born of the twins, Beloved, Your hoax the
 worst

That comes on families, Esau was not
 Too keen on taking Ishmael's place, but
 taught

By father to look up to him. The mother
 Who loved the quiet Jacob was another
 To cause conflict. So Esau sold the blight.
 Who could guess this would some day
 cause a fight?

One cannot eat gold, silver, nay, nor
 honour.

A bowl of lentils, better buyer than pawnner,
 Would also satisfy my soul, who know
 All joys in knowing You, Beloved, below.

Genesis 26

1 There was a famine in the land,
 Besides the first that hit *the sand*
Of Palestine when Abraham

Walked on its soil. *It was no scam*
 That Isaac went to Gerar where
 Abimelech was reigning there
 King of the Philistines. 2 Then YHWH
 Appeared to him and said "Do you
 Not go down to Egypt, but live
 In the land which I truly give
 To you. 3 "Live in this land, and I
 Shall be with you and bless you by
 Descendants to whom I shall give
 All of these lands, a place to live,
 And so perform the oath I swore
 To Father Abraham before.
 4 "And I will multiply your seed
 Like stars of heaven, and I indeed
 Shall give to your descendants all
 These lands, and in your seed all nations
 Shall be blessed because in his stations
 5 "Abraham heard My voice and call,
 Kept My charge, My every command,
 My statutes, and My laws on hand."

Your charge, the Decalogue, contains three
 things:

Commandments telling what to do for
 kings
 And common folk, and statutes telling how
 To find forgiveness for the guilty brow,
 And finally laws that describe the way
 That humans must conceive You to
 forestay
 The errors of philosopher and priest.
 Thus wisdom of all things from great to
 least
 Is found in that soon charge known from
 the time
 That Adam stepped out of Edenic clime,
 And Noah wandered safely from the ark,
 And Enoch whirled apace like morning
 lark.
 So Abraham too kept eternal charge,
 Though folk of faith neglect it by and large.

6 So Isaac lived in Gerar. 7 And
 The men of the place asked *first-hand*
 About his wife. And he said "She
Is my sister." The reason he
 Said so was fear to say, "*She is*
My wife, 'because the thought was his,
'Lest the men of the place kill me
For Rebekah, because that she
Is beautiful to look at." 8 Now

It happened, when he had *somehow*
 Been there a while, Abimelech
 King of the Philistines *on deck*
 Looked through a window, and he saw,
 And there was Isaac, *with his paw*
 Showing endearment to his wife,
 Rebekah, *secret of his life*
And helpmeet. 9 Then Abimelech
 Called Isaac to him for a speck
 And said "Quite certainly she's your
 Wife. So how could you say before,
 'She *is* my sister'?" Isaac said
 To him, "I had it in my head
 'Lest I die on account of her.'" 10
 Abimelech said "*My dear sir,*
What is this you have done to us?
 One of the people might soon thus
 Have lain with your wife, and you would
 Have brought guilt on us." 11 So for good
 Abimelech charged all *his* folk
 And said "Who gives this man a poke
 Or touches his wife surely must
 Be put to death *and bite the dust.*"

Taqiyya was established, it is true,
 Since Abraham was threatened by a few
 Egyptian courtiers who thought Sarah fair
 And might make fine addition anywhere
 The house of women raised a cloistered
 tower,
 And latticed windows shaded tree and
 flower.
 So Isaac too kept up the noble trait
 And used it when he entered stranger's
 gate.
 How many since have, without thought of
 threat,
 Lied to no purpose greater than to get
 A bit of gold or fame! Let Abraham
 And Isaac both correct the anagram.
 The law says not to make one's witness
 false.
 True faith's a march and battle, not a waltz.

12 Then Isaac sowed in that land, and
 Reaped in the same year *at his hand*
 A hundredfold, and YHWH blessed him.
 13 The man began to prosper *limb*
By limb, and still prospered until
 He prospered and he had his fill
 14 Of *fine* possessions both of flocks
 And herds and servants *in their hocks.*

So the Philistines envied him.
 15 The Philistines filled *to the brim*
 The wells his father's servants dug
 In Abraham's his father's fug,
 And they had filled them all with earth.
 16 Abimelech said to Isaac,
 "Away from us, and go, be quick,
 For you are mightier than we."
 17 Then Isaac heard *their prayer and plea*.
 Departed from there and pitched tent
 In Gerar's valley where he went
 To live. 18 And Isaac dug again
 The wells of water which the men
 Had dug in days of Abraham
 His father, for Philistine *dam*
 Had stopped them up after the death
 Of Abraham. *In the same breath*
 He called them by the names which were
 The ones his father would confer.
 19 Also Isaac's servants dug in
 The valley, and found well *to win*
 Of running water there. 20 But then
 Gerar's herdsmen with Isaac's men
 Quarrelled and said "The water's ours"
Since quarrelling was in their powers.
 So he called the well Esek, since
 They quarrelled *but did not convince*.
 21 Then they dug there another well,
 They quarrelled over that *a spell*.
 So he called its name Sitnah. 22 And
 He moved from there and out of hand
 He dug another well, and they
 Did not quarrel for it *that day*.
 So he called it Rehoboth, since
 As he had said "*We need not wince*
 For now YHWH has made room for us,
 And we'll also be prosperous
 In the land." 23 Then he went from there
 To Beersheba. 24 And YHWH came where
 He was the same night and said "I
Am your father Abraham's God,
 Do not fear, I'm with you and I
 Will bless you and will multiply
 Your descendants upon the sod
 For My servant Abraham's sake."
 25 So he built an altar to make
 A place to call on YHWH's name there,
 And there he stopped to pitch his tent.
 His servants dug the well *they meant*.

With neither promise nor a blessing here,
 (Is this not faith in You, Beloved, I rear?)

I lay a floor of sacrifice and call
 On Your name, though I am a soul too
 small
 To claim a heritage, a well or tent.
 You are enough for me in what You meant
 By saying You would bless the holy seed.
 I follow and hold to that simple creed.
 Just bless and multiply the one You will,
 As long as I can come and there be still
 Upon the sacrificial floor where You
 Are present in the whispered word of Huu.
 My sowing and my harvest prosper where
 Your lovely voice stays trembling on the
 air.

26 Abimelech came from Gerar
 To him with Ahuzzath, *a star*
 One of his friends, and Phichol who
 Was commander of his army.
 27 And Isaac said to them, "Why do
 You come to me, since you hate me
 And have sent me away from you?"
 28 But they said "We have surely seen
 That YHWH is with you. So we *mean*
To say 'Let there now be an oath
 Between you and us, between both,
 And let us make a pact with you,
 29 'That you will do us no harm too,
 Since we have not touched you, and since
 We've done nothing *to make you wince*
 But only good and sent you out
 In peace. You *are without a doubt*
 The blessed of YHWH.'" 30 So he made
 them

A feast *after their stratagem*,
 And they ate and drank, 31 then arose
 Early that morning so's to close
 The deal and swear an oath with each
 And one another without breach,
 And so they left him then in peace.
 32 It happened on the same day that
 Isaac's servants came where he's at
 To tell him of the well's increase,
 How they had dug it and they'd found
 The water coming from the ground.
 33 So he called it Shebah. Therefore
 It's still Beersheba evermore.

Beersheba stands in Negev to this day,
 A place where Jew and Arab still hold
 sway,
 And still hope that the promises are true

That Isaac's seed might thrive and yet
 renew
 The peace once sworn to king and flock
 and well.
 The market place continues, where they sell
 The needful and the luscious, while the sky
 Is like the sky was when Isaac passed by.
 I seek beyond the timid oaths of men
 That last while spear and arm rattle again
 The well, the springing well, that rushed
 out in
 Reward for dusty work and flight from sin.
 In You, Beloved, I find that well of life
 That once and always ends all human strife.

The second explanation of the name
 Of Beersheba now enters in the game.
 I guess for some this is the proof and sure
 That Scripture is a compilation pure
 And outright merely human in its scope.
 Two explanations are proof there's no hope
 You speak to any by Your word or less
 By mountain thunder or the wind's caress.
 If every day becomes a revelation
 Of new blessings and pacts in explanation,
 It does not mean that all before has failed.
 The wilderness is heavenly city veiled.
 Each day renews both veiling and the spark
 Of light that penetrates the human dark.

34 When Esau was forty years old,
 He took as wives Judith *the bold*
 Daughter of Beeri the Hittite,
 And Basemath also Hittite,
 The daughter of Elon. 35 And they
 Were grief of mind *in their own way*
 To Isaac and Rebekah *who*
Wished only kinfolk for their due.

Genesis 27

1 Now it happened when Isaac's eyes
 Were dim with age, not to advise,
 He called Esau his older son
 And said to him, "My son, my son."
 And he answered him, "Here I am."
 2 Then he said "Indeed now, *my lamb*,
 I'm old. I do not know the day
 When I shall die. 3 "Now therefore, say
 Will you take weapons, quiver, bow,
 And go out to the field and show
 Your hunting skills for me. 4 "And make
 Me savoury food, such as I take

With joy, and bring *it* to me so
 I may eat, that my soul may know
 To bless you before I shall die."
 5 Now Rebekah was listening why
 Isaac was speaking to his son
 Esau. And *with the speaking done*
 Esau went to the field to hunt
 The game and bring *it to the front*.
 6 Rebekah spoke to Jacob then,
 Jacob her son, saying "The men
 Were talking and I heard your father
 Speak to Esau your brother rather,
 Saying 7 'Bring me game and make food,
 A savoury dish for me and good,
 That I may eat it and bless you
 Here in the presence of Lord YHWH
 Before my death.' 8 "Now therefore, son,
 Obey my voice and get it done
 Whatever I tell you to do.
 9 "Go to the flock and bring me two
 Choice kids of goats, and I will make
 The savoury dish of tasty steak
 Such as your father loves. 10 "Then you
 Shall take *it* to your father, do,
 That he may eat *it*, and bless you
 Before his death." 11 And Jacob said
 To Rebekah his mother bred,
 "Look, Esau my brother's a man
 Of hairy skin while I'm a man
 Of smooth. 12 "Perhaps my father will
 Feel me, and I shall seem worse still
 To be deceiver in his sight
 And get no blessing, but a blight."
 13 But his mother said to him, "*Let*
Your curse be on me, and forget,
My son, only obey my voice,
And go, get them for me and choice."
 14 And he went and got *them* and brought
Them to his mother, and she wrought
 The savoury dish his father sought.
 15 Then Rebekah took the choice clothes
 Of her elder son Esau, chose
 From what was with her in the house,
 And put them on, *to fool her spouse*,
 Jacob her younger son. 16 And she
 Put the skins of the goats to be
 On his hands and on the smooth part
 Of his neck. 17 Then she gave the *tart*
 Of savoury food and bread, which she
 Had made, to her son Jacob free.

How many mothers and their sons seek
 blessing
 From fathers, hands and arms and necks
 caressing,
 To find the world a harsh and heated waste
 Despite the pot of savoury herbs they taste.
 The damp and clinging skins contrived to
 seal
 The sought for fate of glory always feel
 Just what they are, the bloody, sodden
 things
 Of sure deceit known to all who'd be kings.
 With loathing I shake off the woollen bands
 That tell the world what it less understands
 That I seek divine love with heart and
 voice.

Abandoned, naked, I renew my choice
 In poverty to sing Your lovely name
 Enjoying that wealth more than any claim.

18 So he went to his father and
 Said "My father.' And "Here I stand"
 Said he, "Who *are* you, my son?" 19 Then
 Jacob said to his father, "*When*
You sent me Esau your firstborn
 I went and did as you would warn,
 Please rise, sit, eat the game I've brought
 And give to me the blessing sought."
 20 But Isaac said to his son, "How
 Have you found it so quickly now,
 My son?" And he said "Because YHWH
 Your God brought me *the barbeque*."
 21 Then Isaac said to Jacob, "Please
 Come near, and let me feel at ease,
 My son, if you are Esau *or*
Someone that I've not bargained for."
 22 So Jacob went near to Isaac
 His father, and he felt *the thick*
Hair on him and said "The voice is
 Jacob's voice, but these hands *of his*
Are those of Esau." 23 And he did
 Not recognize him, since he hid
 His hands with hair like that upon
 His brother Esau's hands to con,
 And so he blessed him *on the skid*.

Believe the half of what you see and none
 Of what you hear, my father told his son.
 All things are changed and all are made to
 fit
 The purposes of those who've chosen it.

Things are not what they seem in this dark
 world,
 The wicked core is gold embossed and
 pearled.
 So I believe no angel nor prophet
 That's come to say his piece both on and off
 it.
 Instead I listen to the voice that can
 In no wise be mistaken. Voice of man
 Betrays, but Your voice, my Beloved, is
 sure
 And thunders in the silence loud and pure
 Despite the centuries since You last spoke
 A sermon on Mount Sinai when men woke.

24 Then he said "*Are* you really he,
 My son Esau?" He said "The same."
 25 He said "Bring *it then* near to me,
 And I will eat of my son's game,
 So that my soul may bless you here."
 So he brought *meat* and grape juice near
 To him, he ate and drank. 26 Then *dear*
 Father Isaac said to him, "Here,
 Come near now and kiss me, my son."
 27 And he came near and kissed him one,
 And he smelled the smell of his clothing,
 And blessed him and said nothing loathing,
 "Surely, the smell of my son's as
 The smell of fields that Lord YHWH has
 Blessed. 28 Therefore may Alohim give
 You heaven's dew *while you shall live*,
 Earth's fatness and grain plenty and
 Grape juice. 29 Let folk *of every land*
 Serve you, and nations bow down to
 You and be master in your due
 Over your brothers, and let your
 Mother's sons bow to you *the more*.
 Cursed *be* the one who curses you,
 And blessed *be* those who bless you too!"

The prophet Jacob, though he heard his
 mother,
 Betrayed both father and his elder brother.
 Yet blessings given cannot be retracted
 Despite the underhanded way he acted.
 I bless the prophet Jacob and not curse
 Lest I find perils in my way for worse.
 I bless the fields that smell of fresh and
 new,
 I bless the fatness of the earth and dew,
 I bless the harvest kernel and the grape
 Cut into forty pieces in a scrape

For those who whirl about the throne of
God.

I bless the ear and bless the greening pod.
Bless me, too, my Beloved, and bless me
well,
Though I am dressed in veil and mask and
shell.

30 Now it happened, when Isaac finished
Blessing Jacob, *and not diminished*,
Jacob had scarcely gone out from
His father's presence, Isaac's sum,
That Esau his brother came in
From his hunting where he had been.

31 He also had made savoury food,
And brought it where his father *stood*,
And said to his father, "Get up,
And eat the morsel, taste the cup,
Of his son's game, and bless me here."

32 And his father Isaac said to
Him, "Who *are* you?" So he said "*True*
It is I am your son, your first
Born, Esau." 33 Then fearing the worst,
Isaac said "Who? Where *is* the one
Who hunted game and brought *it done*
To me? I ate it all before

You came here calling at the door,
And I have blessed him, *and* indeed
He shall be blessed *and all his seed*."

34 When Esau heard his father's word
He cried greatly for what occurred
And bitterly said to his father,
"Bless me, me also, O my father!"

Note he who steals my honour and my
bread

Is one who lacks both, but pours on my
head

The ill-gained fruit of his ill-starred
ambition.

Therefore I write and read this small
petition.

I am the grateful son, obedient
And true, and all my life I've surely spent
In honour of my parents. All I do
Is for their pleasure and also their due.
He is the cheat and slinking man of fate,
And I do well to bide my time in hate.
For all of that, Beloved, I still desire
Your blessing on one walking in the mire.
If with my dirty feet I come before
Your throne, I come as primogenitor.

35 But he said "Now your brother came
Deceitfully and stole your claim
To blessing." 36 And *Esau* said "Is
His name not rightly Jacob? His
Supplanting me has come now twice.
He took my birthright in a trice,
And now look, he has also taken
Away my blessing!" Then forsaken,
He said "Have you not kept for me
A blessing?" 37 Isaac answered "See,"
And said to Esau, "I have made
Him master, and the whole brigade
Of all his brothers servants to
Him, and with grain and grape juice too
Have I sustained him. What's to do
For you, my son?" 38 And Esau said
To his father, "Have you instead
Only one blessing, O my father?
Bless me, me also, O my father!"
And Esau lifted up his voice
And wept *because he had no choice*.

The world takes all, and takes it by deceit,
Yet You, Beloved, stand by it seems to
treat

Them with the blessings they have grasped
outright

And trampled poor and innocent with fight
And guile. And so I come with call and
tears

To beg a blessing beyond what appears.
I rend in anger or in patience veils
And cry that You will listen to my tales.

I boil a soup of my own kidneys and
Give up my liver to Your bowl and hand.

O my Beloved, grant me poor Esau's
blessing,

Though without sauce and without savoury
dressing,

I come to You, Beloved, and come again.
Deliver me from all deceitful men.

39 Isaac his father answered and
Said to him, "Fatness of the land
Shall be your dwelling, and the dew
Of heaven above. 40 By your sword too
You shall live, and you shall serve *long*
Your brother, but you shall be strong
And break his yoke from off your neck."
41 So Esau hated Jacob for
The blessing which his father *bore*

And blessed him, Esau said within
 His heart, "The days are coming in
 To mourn my father, then I will
 Kill brother Jacob *for my fill*."
 42 And the words of Esau her older
 Son were told to Rebekah, bolder,
 So she sent and called Jacob her
 Younger son, and said to confer
 With him, "Surely your brother now,
 This Esau comforts himself how
 He'll kill you *later*. 43 "Now therefore,
 My son, obey me on this score.
 Get up, flee to my brother who
 Lives in Haran, my brother Laban.
 44 "And stay with him a day or two,
 Yes, go and stay with brother Laban
 Until your brother's fury dies,
 45 "Until your brother's anger flies
 Away from you, and he forgets
 What you have done to him. So let's
 Wait till I send for you from there.
 Why should I be bereaved with care
 Of both of you in one day?" 46 And
 Rebekah told Isaac, "Disband
 My weariness of life because
 The daughters of Heth *show their claws*.
 If Jacob takes a wife like those
 Daughters of this land, let life close."

Rebekah's words to Isaac do not tell
 The thoughts of heart but only cast a spell
 To further aims she does not want to speak.
 The mother of the faithful thus is weak
 As she relates to her own husband's pride.
 To hide the truth to save a dear son's hide
 In face of death may very well be fair.
 We have to kill the gnat to breathe the air.
 Yet it is sorrow to my heart to know
 The best and dearest must be dealt with so.
 I turn from veils of words to say Your
 name
 And thus change choking dust for lasting
 fame,
 And blackened coals for diamonds out of
 hand
 While trying to make sense and understand.

Genesis 28

1 Then Isaac called Jacob and blessed
 Him, and charged him, and made request,
 "You shall not take a wife from these
 Daughters of Canaan. 2 "Get up, please,

And go to Padan Aram, to
 The house of Bethuel, mother's father,
 And take yourself a wife there, rather,
 Among the daughters of the brother
 Laban, the brother of your mother.
 3 "May El, El God Almighty bless
 You, also make your fruitfulness
 As great and multiply you, that
 You may become a caveat
 Of peoples coming in great number.
 4 And may He give you *without slumber*
 The blessing of Abraham, to
 You and your descendants with you,
 That you may claim the heritage
 Of the land where in your nonage
 You are a stranger, and which He,
 Alohim gave Abraham free."
 5 So Isaac sent Jacob away
 To Padan Aram and to stay
 With Laban the son of Bethuel
 The Syrian, brother *ne'er-do-well*
 Of Jacob's and of Esau's mother,
 Laban who was Rebekah's brother.
 6 Esau saw that Isaac had blessed
 Jacob and sent him off in quest
 Of a wife from Padan Aram,
 Blessed with blessings of *Abraham*,
 And told him "Do not take a wife
 From Canaan's daughters *in your life*,"
 7 And that Jacob obeyed his father
 And mother too, gone to the bother
 Of going to Padan Aram.
 8 Esau saw that the daughters of
 Canaan had not his father's love.
 9 So Esau went to Ishmael and
 Took Mahalath his daughter's hand,
 Ishmael's, Abraham's son, the sister
 Of Nebajoth, (*Jacob had missed her*)
 To be his wife along with those
 That he *Esau* already chose.

One wonders at such racist policy
 That father tells son that his family
 Is only source of rightful mate to find.
 One wonders that Esau thought they would
 mind

His due attempt to find a better wife,
 And make his parents happier in life
 By multiplying his polygamy.
 Daughter of Ishmael's fine as I can see,
 But is not it a matter greater if
 The Canaanite wife in faith's gained a whiff

That You, Beloved, are One and Sovereign
here?

A Canaanite that bows to You in fear
And love must be a better wife than one
Of Laban's daughters or I'm simpleton.

Week 7

10 Now Jacob went out from Beersheba,
Toward Haran *from his zareba*.

11 Then he came to a certain place
And stayed there all night, *the scape-grace*,
Because the sun had set. And he
Took one of the stones there to be
A pillow at his head, and lay
Down in that place to sleep *and stay*.

12 Then he dreamed, and indeed, a ladder
Was set up on the earth, *not sadder*
That its top reached to heaven in height,
And there Alohims' angels might
Ascend and descend on it right.

13 Indeed, YHWH stood above it, said
"I'm YHWH God of Abraham, *dread*
Of your grandfather and the God
Of Isaac, the land where you *plod*
Or as it may be lie, I'll give
To you and to your seed *to live*."

14 "Also your descendants shall be
As dust on earth, you shall spread out
To west and east, and *without doubt*,
To north and south, and in you and
In your seed every family band
On earth shall be blessed. 15 "Indeed, I
Am with you and will keep you by
The way you go, and bring you back
To this land, nor will let you lack
Until I have done what I've spoken.
Remember now when you've awoken."

What You spoke in a waking trance with
awe

To Abraham, and what You said for law
To Isaac, Jacob has to hear in sleep.
The ancient story makes the new heart leap
To know the golden age when beasts could
talk

And You came down to men to speak and
walk.

Beloved, You spoke to one aloud and then
Spoke to another in a dream. Now men
Hear and see nothing of Your steps and
speech.

The world is silent except for what each

Man makes in noise and babbling. Are You
far

That I hear nothing but the tinkling star
And dripping of the shining acid rain?
Or are You so close that words are in vain?

16 Then Jacob awoke from his sleep
And said "Surely YHWH's here to keep
This place, and I did not know *it*."

17 And he was awed and said "How *fit*
And awesome *is* this place! This *is*
Alohim's house, and this gate's His
To heaven!" 18 Then Jacob rose early
And in the morning took the *pearly*
Stone where he had laid down his head,
Set as a pillar, oiled and said
19 The place's name should be Bethel
Or house of God, that villanelle
Had been called Luz before the vow
20 That Jacob made, "If Alohims
Will be with me, *as in that dream*,
And keep me in this way that I
Am going, and will satisfy
With bread to eat and clothes to wear,
And look after by safe welfare,"

2 "So that I come back here in peace,
And to my father's house, I'll cease
Not ever to make YHWH my God.
22 "And this stone I've set on this sod
A pillar shall be God's house too,
Of all You give, I'll give to You
A portion or a tenth endue."

Though I see nothing stretched from
heaven to earth,
Not ladders iron rung nor weighed in worth
With jewels and gold, not angels on the
stairs,
Though I am not bowed down with awe nor
airs,

But simply sleep and wake from day to day
Without a promise that I'm here to stay
Until my children multiply like sands,
I do not lay conditions on my promise
To be a little more than doubting Thomas.
I do not say if You do this or that
Then only I shall render You the fat.
My heritage is not bound up in bands.
I freely give myself and what I earn
In love to You. Let me and pasture burn.

Genesis 29

1 So Jacob went on his journey
 And came to the land *presently*
Where lived the people of the East.
 2 And he looked, and saw *unpoliced*
 A well in the field, and indeed,
 Three flocks beside it and in need
 Of water, and a large stone on
 The well's mouth. 3 Now all the flocks
 drawn
 Together there, and they would roll
 The stone from the well's mouth *for toll*,
 Water the sheep, and put the stone
 Back in its place *after the loan*.
 4 And Jacob said to them, "My brothers,
 Where *are* you from?" And then the others
 Said "We're from Haran." 5 Then he said
 To them, "Do you know Laban *bred*
 The son of Nahor?" And they said
 "We know him." 6 So he said "Is he
 Well?" And they said "*He's* well. And see,
 His daughter Rachel's coming here
 With sheep." 7 Then he said "Have good
 cheer,
 It's still high day, not time to gather
 The cattle, water the sheep rather
 And go and feed." 8 But they said "We
 Cannot until all the flocks be
 Gathered together, and they roll
 The stone from the well's mouth, *control*,
 And then we water all the sheep
That all the shepherds have to keep."

The well in Haran now is springing up
 Throughout the day to fill the wanderer's
 cup.
 In many-coloured dresses they come still
 Toward evening, laughing, talking, come to
 fill
 Plastic containers with the water that
 Runs down unstoping from the place
 they're at.
 Who knows if Rachel stepped upon this
 sand,
 Or if her well was on the other hand?
 The gates of Haran still stand stone on
 stone,
 Roads going to four winds and every zone.
 The women's clothing shines in every hue
 Beyond the emerald mosque, beneath the
 blue.
 Their husbands come all dressed in
 glowing white

To bow to You beneath the green dome's
 light.

9 Now as he spoke Rachel arrived,
 A shepherdess with father's sheep.
 10 When Jacob, *who was still unwived*,
 Saw Rachel, mother's brother's daughter,
 And Laban's sheep *not yet for slaughter*,
 He went to water Laban's sheep,
 Unrolled the stone from the well's keep.
 11 Then Jacob kissed Rachel, and lifted
 His voice and wept, 12 said he was gifted
 To be her Rachel's father's kin,
 Rebekah's son in origin.
 So she ran and told father all.
 13 When Laban heard the *crow and call*,
 That Jacob, sister's son had come,
 He ran to meet him, kissed him some,
 Embraced and brought him to his house.
 And he told Laban and *his spouse*
 All of his history. 14 Laban said
 To him, "Surely you're *born and bred*
 My bone and flesh." And so he stayed
 With him a month *though not delayed*.

I made a great mistake to open heart
 To Laban, knowing just a worthy part
 Would have sufficed to make him take me
 in.

Hindsight is far the better part of sin.
 I spoke like some teenager rather than
 A well-experienced forty-year-old man.
 Too eagerly I thought each man my brother
 Who only spoke the accent of my mother.
 Let me, Belovèd, stop and mend my ways,
 Trust only You, and not the vain displays
 Of those who would impose authority,
 The patriarch, the priest, the customs
 tender,
 The president, police, and power vender.
 Bowing to You alone I am set free.

15 Then Laban said to Jacob, "Since
 You *are* kin should you serve for mince?
 Demand your wages." 16 Laban had
 Two daughters: the elder *was* Leah,
 The younger Rachel. 17 Eyes of Leah
Were delicate, but Rachel was
 A beauty to see and *to pause*.
 18 Now Jacob loved Rachel, so he
 Said "I will serve you seven years
 For Rachel younger of your dears."

19 And Laban said "Better that I
Give her to you than passer-by.
Stay here with me *and have a try.*"

"Look not upon the outward beauty, man,"
Is what You should have said to Jacob
there.

"Look rather on the inward if you can
And know that doing is more than the fair.
If mother said to marry Laban's daughter,
You should not just take who was fetching
water.

You will find Leah makes the better wife
While Rachel is good at the call to strife."
But You let every man make his mistakes
Until he learns to know that what it takes
Is killing his own will and taking Yours,
Biding his time, rejecting hopes and mores.
I place my hope in You, Beloved, and wait
Among the joys and sorrows of each gate.

20 For Rachel Jacob served seven years,
And they seemed a few days *arrears*
To him because he loved her so.

21 Then Jacob said to Laban, "Oh,
Give *me* my wife, my days are done
So I may have the wife *I've won.*"

22 And Laban gathered all together
Men there to make feast *in good weather.*

23 At evening, he took Leah, elder
Of his daughters, brought her and held her
Out to Jacob who went in to her.

24 And Laban gave his maid to do her
As a maid, Zilpah for his daughter
Leah. 25 At morning when he sought her,
The one *he'd slept with* was Leah.

So he said to Laban, "*Aha,*
What's this that you have done to me?
Did I not serve for Rachel's *hand*?
Why have you given contraband?"

26 And Laban said "It must not be
Done so *here* in *this* our country,
To give the younger first as bride.

27 "Fulfill her week, and by your side
We will give this one also for
The service which you will serve me
Still another seven years *for free.*"

28 Then Jacob did so and fulfilled
Her week. So he gave to *the thrilled*
Jacob his daughter Rachel as
Wife also. 29 And then Laban has
Given his maid Bilhah to his daughter

Rachel as maid. 30 Then, *as to slaughter,*
Jacob also went in to Rachel,
And he also loved *his wife* Rachel
More than Leah. Still he was serving
Laban seven years more *without swerving.*

I swear, Beloved, injustice greater than
What fell to Leah never was nor can.
Until her day of death she knew the touch
Of Jacob for loved Rachel, knew as much
From one night's happenings. I swear
Such knowing was too much for her to
bear.

Sure that she loved, she thought it was
enough

To take one moment and then bear the
rough

A lifetime of remembering would bring.
Like multitudes before she planned to sing,
But life is made of many other voices.
Who knows so soon can wisely make her
choices.

Perhaps she thought one moment of the
true

Sufficed to live, indeed, that's so with You.

31 When YHWH saw that Leah *was* not
Loved, He opened her womb and got
Her children, Rachel though *was* barren.

32 So Leah conceived and bore bairn
And called him Reuben for she said
"YHWH has looked on my pain and *bed.*
Now sure my husband will love me."

33 Then she conceived again freely
And gave birth to a son, saying
"Because YHWH has heard of my thing
That I'm unloved, He has therefore
Given me this too and will give more."
And she called his name Simeon [hearing].

34 She conceived and bore one more son,
And said "Now this time I have won
My husband's love, since I have had
Three sons in all, *which is not bad.*"
Therefore Levi [joined] became his name.

35 And she conceived again and came
To bear a son and said "Now I
Will praise YHWH." Thus to dignify
Him with the name of Judah [praise]. Then
She stopped conceiving, bearing men.

Four sons of Leah to express four gates
Of human life in four spiritual states

Command my view. Behold, a son is first
Establishing relationship not worst,
That is, obedience to Sovereign God.
The second son is hearing as I trod
The gallows floor in recitation clear
Of Your bright names, the best names I can
hear.

The third son and third gate is joined to
You

So only Your will comes in what I do.
The fourth son is in very truth Your praise
That is the outcome and goal of life's maze.
I banquet with the sons of Leah now
Whose names alone show every mystic
how.

Genesis 30

1 When Rachel saw she bore no sons
Nor daughters to Jacob, (*which stuns*)
Rachel envied her sister, and
Said to Jacob, "*Hear my demand*
And give me children, else I die!"

2 And Jacob's anger was thereby
Aroused against Rachel, and he
Said "*Am I in the place of God*
Alohim, who has not thought odd
To withhold from you a baby?"

3 And so she said "Here is my maid
Bilhah, go in to her *afraid*
Of nothing, she will bear on my
Knees, that I also may *or try*
To have children by her." 4 Then she
Gave him Bilhah her maid as wife,
(*And gave her as a wife freely*)

And Jacob went in to her (*Strife*
Can only come and family war!).

5 And Bilhah conceived and she bore
Jacob a son. 6 Then Rachel said
"Alohim's judged my case and bed,
And He has also heard my voice
And given me a son *of choice*."
And that's why she called his name Dan
[judge].

And everything went by her plan.

7 And Rachel's maid Bilhah conceived
Again and bore Jacob *deceived*
A second son. 8 Then Rachel said
"With great wrestlings *and with great*
dread

I've wrestled with my sister, *and*
Indeed I have prevailed *as planned*."

So she called his name Naphtali [my
wrestling].

9 When Leah saw *and with a sigh*
That she had stopped bearing, she took
Zilpah her maid and then forsook
Her to Jacob as wife. 10 And she,
Zilpah, the maid at Leah's plea
Bore Jacob a son. 11 Then she said
Did Leah, "A troop comes *and led!*"
So she called his name Gad [good fortune].

12 And she,
The maid of Leah Zilpah, *see*,
Bore to Jacob a second son.

13 Then Leah said *when that was done*,
"I'm happy, for the daughters will
Call me blessed." So she *had her fill*
And called him Asher, blessed *still*.

When Jacob gave the model of four wives
He also taught us how to ruin our lives.
It seems his wives and father-in-law
thought

Polygamy was an excellent plot.
The plot was thickened with controversy,
And led poor Jacob on a living spree.
All things are lawful, says Apostle Paul,
But not expedient, oh, not at all.
Expedient to Jacob must have been
An open door to riot if not sin.
Yet You, Beloved, go on beyond the treat
Domestic unrest gives observer's seat
And make the best of human vanity,
And cause Your will to win the lottery.

14 Now Reuben went in the days of
Wheat harvest and found mandrakes' *love*
Root [*Mandragora officinarum*] in the
field, and brought them to
His mother Leah. *To beshrew*
Said Rachel to Leah, "Please give
Me your son's mandrakes *relative*
To my fecundity." 15 But she
Said to her, "A small matter be
It that you take my husband, would
You take my son's mandrakes *for good?*
And Rachel said "Therefore he will
Lie with you tonight for the bill."
16 When Jacob came out of the field
At evening, Leah went to meet
Him and said "Now you have to *yield*,
Come in to me, *and be my treat*,
For I have surely hired you with

My son's mandrakes, *and that's the pith.*"

And he lay with her that night. 17 And Alohim heard Leah's *remand*, And she conceived and bore Jacob A fifth son. 18 Leah said "*What rub*, Alohim's given me my wages, Because I gave up heritages Handing my maid to my husband."

So she called his name Issachar [wages].

19 Then Leah conceived again and Bore Jacob a sixth son. 20 "By far" Said Leah, "Alohim's endowed

Me *with* a good endowment, proud, Now my husband will live with me, Because I've borne him six and won."

So she called his name Zebulon [habitation, toleration, lordship].

21 Afterward she gave birth *finely*

To a daughter, and called her name

Dinah [vindicated]. 22 And then Alohim came

To the remembrance of Rachel,

And Alohim heard her *love spell*

And opened her womb. 23 And she got

Pregnant and bore the son she ought,

And said "Alohim's taken off

My *old* reproach." 24 So *philosophe*

She called him Joseph [addition], "once begun

YHWH shall give me another son."

Some men buy women's favours on the town,

While women take turns and exchange their turns

For superstitious magic of mandrake.

The whole thing might produce a divine frown

If You, Beloved, took seriously what burns

In human breast and marked it for his sake.

I fear You look on human love with eyes

Of condescension rather than with wise.

Yet You too say Your jealousy is burning Against created ones who've not been spurning

Idolatry. Perhaps the human scene

Was meant to show the human heart on screen

The burning pain idolatry must cast

Upon the universal heart to last.

25 It happened, when Rachel had borne

Joseph, that Jacob *the lovelorn*

Said to Laban, "Send me away,

That I may go to my own *pay*

And to my country. 26 "Give me my

Wives and my children for whom I

Have served you, and now let me go,

How good my work's something you know."

27 And Laban said to him, "Please *stay*,

If I've found favour *for a day*

In your eyes, *for* I've learned to take

Blessing of YHWH and for your sake."

28 Then he said "Name for me your wages,

I'll give *even more concubinages.*"

29 But he said to him, "You know how

I've served you and how your livestock

Has been with me. 30 "What you have now

Is great compared to what in hock

You had before and under lock.

YHWH has blessed you since my coming.

And now, when shall I also ring

Up an account for my own house?"

31 So he said "Now what shall I souse

You with?" And Jacob said "You must

Not give me anything. Adjust

This thing for me and I again

Will feed and keep your flocks *and men.*

32 "Let me pass through your flock today,

Removing from there all the way

The speckled and the spotted sheep,

And all the brown ones I shall keep

Among the lambs, among the goats

The spotted, speckled *in their coats*,

And *these* shall be my wages. 33 "So

My righteousness' *portfolio*

Will answer for me in the time

To come, and when the matter prime

Comes before you, the one that is

Not speckled or spotted in his

Coat among goats and brown of lamb

Shall be held stolen where I am."

34 And Laban said "Oh, that it were

According to your word, *occur!*"

35 So he removed that day the male

Goats speckled and spotted *of tail*,

All the female goats that were speckled

And spotted, every one that's freckled

With white and all the brown among

The lambs, and gave them to his young

To keep. 36 Then he put three days' walk

Between himself and Jacob's flock,

And Jacob fed the rest of what

Remained to Laban *that he got*.

I put three days of journey between me
And heritage and all my family
To watch my flocks for what they ought to
earn,

And gaze at night skies for what I might
learn.

I do not work by day nor hourly wage,
Nor take the profit from each printed page.
Instead I take the increase of the earth
And keep the speckled lambs for what
they're worth.

Beloved, look on this man by night, by day,
And keep him finely in the narrow way
That leads to heart of hearts divine and true
To count the stars of Your appealing
names,

So shall I know You in the things I do,
And set aside ambitious means and games.

37 Now Jacob took himself rods of
Green poplar, almond, chestnut trees,
Peeled white strips in them, from above
Exposed the white that *was* in these.

38 And now the rods that he had peeled,
He set before the flocks to yield
In the watering troughs where the flocks
Came to drink, so they should conceive
When they came to drink. 39 So the flocks
Conceived before the rods to *leave*
And bring forth streaked, speckled and
spotted.

40 Then Jacob separated lambs,
And made the flocks, *cunningly plotted*,
Face toward the streaked and spotted
jambs,

And all the brown in Laban's flock,
But he put his own in a block
By themselves, not with Laban's flock.

41 And when the stronger livestock came
To conceive, Jacob placed the same
Before the eyes of the livestock
In the gutters, that they might *knock*
Conceiving in the rods. 42 But when
The flocks were feeble *in the pen*,
He did not put *them* in *to play*,
So feebler ones were Laban's *sheep*,
The stronger ones Jacob's *to keep*.

43 And thus the man became that way
Most prosperous, and had large flocks,
Maid, servant, camel, donkey, *ox*.

Bless me, too, my Beloved, despite the
game

And convolution I set out for shame.
Forgive my superstition and contriving,
My restless wantonness and foolish
striving.

My rods are stripped and whittled to the
bare

Ridiculous desire to beat what's fair.

I wonder can a human being touch

A just ground in his dealings, I doubt
much.

And yet the spite of hopelessness is worse
Than blind participation in the curse.

I flee to You, Beloved, from my ambition,
From greed and lust, and from my own
volition.

You are the pristine centre of my being,
Creator of my life, my soul and seeing.

Genesis 31

1 He heard the words of Laban's sons,
Who said "Jacob has taken tons
Of wealth that was our father's and
From what was his enriched his hand."

2 And Jacob saw the countenance
Of Laban was no longer glance
Of favour as it was before.

If blood is thicker far than water is,
A penny is much thicker than the both.
So when it came to an issue of his
Rights to the well, then Laban made an
oath

Of kinship. Now that flocks and herds and
wealth

Come in between, kinship steps out in
stealth.

With what magical, superstitious ways
Did Jacob seek to breed the sheep and
glaze

His fortune! My Beloved, keep me from
going

In human ways so bluntly far from
knowing,

And where I do follow a human rhyme,
Treat me like Jacob and bless for the time.

Deliver me from both my foolish claims
And also from those who have means and
aims.

3 Then YHWH said this on Jacob's score,
 "Return to the land *and the place*
Where your ancestors walked in grace
 And to your family, and I
 Will be with you." 4 So Jacob aye
 Sent and called Rachel and *her sister*
 Leah to the field, to his flock,
 5 And said to them, "I see a *blister*
 Here from your father's face, a *rock*
 Not toward me as before, but still
 My father's God's been with me *till*
This day. 6 "And you know that with all
 My strength I've served your father's call.
 7 "Yet your father has deceived me
 And changed my wages ten times, but
 Alohim let no hurt touch me.
 8 "If he said thus: 'The speckled shall
 Be your wages,' then *every belle*
Of all the *herds* and flocks bore speckled.
 And if he said thus: 'Let the *freckled*
And the streaked be your wages,' then
 All the flocks bore streaked *for the men*.
 9 "So Alohim took stock away
 From your father and gave me sway.

If Jacob thought his machinations with
 The speckled whithes and stakes were not a
 myth,
 But that his clever doings brought him
 wealth

In sheep and goat as well as in good health,
 Is it not vain hypocrisy to thank
 You, my Beloved, for what he had in bank?
 Perhaps not. Rather every act of man
 And woman is, if good and goodness can,
 Your own act. All things good and true
 aspire
 To come from You and in Your name's
 desire
 Are fashioned by the shadows we call men.
 There's nothing done by humankind for
 good
 But is Your own, and if not then is hood
 Of nothingness. I flee to You again.

10 "It happened, at the time when flocks
 Conceived, I lifted up my eye
 And saw a dream, *not of an ox*,
 But leaping rams that jumped up high
 Upon the flocks *were* streaked, and
 speckled,
 And grey-spotted, *not to be heckled*.

11 "Then the Angel of Alohim
 Spoke to me once more in a dream,
 Saying 'Jacob.' And I said 'Here
 I am.' 12 "And He said '*Do not fear*,
 Lift your eyes now and behold all
 The rams which leap *and those that fall*
 Upon the flocks *with* streak and speckle,
 And grey-spotted, *worth goodly shekel*,
 For I have seen all Laban's doing
 To you. 13 'I *am* the God that's cuing
 You from Bethel, where you anointed
 The pillar, made a vow appointed
 To Me. Now get up, and get out
 Of this land, and return, *no doubt*,
 To the land of your *own* family.'" 14
 Then Rachel and Leah replied
 And said to him, "Is there beside
 Still any portion or heirloom
 Found for us in our father's room?
 15 "Are we not strangers before him?
 He's sold us, and what is more dim,
 Consumed our money every bit,
 Till nothing at all's left of it.
 16 "For all these riches that were taken
 By Alohim from him *forsaken*,
 From our father, are really ours,
 And our children's *and children's flowers*.
 Now then, what Alohim has said
 Do so, *and by your God be led*."

Naive, perhaps, to see in every dream
 Of mine of jumping goat and ram and
 stream
 A witness from You, My Beloved, to say
 That what I want to do is the right way:
 I think it would be clearer and more certain
 A matter of Your will without a curtain
 Or veil of vain desire if You revealed
 That what I want to do has been repealed.
 I'm surest that the act I do is free
 If it is not a thing I'd wantonly
 Choose for myself, and yet I choose the
 doing.
 The free to follow passion is construing
 A thralldom as an empty liberty.
 My will is Yours, Beloved, and then I'm
 free.

17 Then Jacob rose and set his sons
 And wives on camels, they're the ones
 18 That carried away all his goods

And livestock *through both fields and woods*,
What he had gained, his herds and sheep
Gained in Padan Aram to keep,
To go to his father Isaac
In Canaan's land. 19 Now Laban's track
Led him to shear his sheep, the while
Rachel had stolen one big pile
Of household idols of her father.
20 And Jacob stole away, no bother
To tell Laban the Syrian,
Of his intention when he ran.
21 So he fled with all that he had.
He rose and crossed, *like Galahad*,
The river towards mounts Gilead.

If Jacob thought that he was doing right,
Why did he not go openly in light?
Did he think Laban might restrain him after
All he had done in service, tears and
laughter?
Perhaps, and with good reason for the
doubt.
Then too, one need not act with din and
shout.
The household gods reveal how near the
well
Of heathen worship good men love to
dwell.
Times do not change, and neither do their
men.
I've hidden idols still I'm loath again
To leave behind to seek a promised land.
Like Jacob, I too love to flee at night
And give no reason for my show of right.
Give me, Beloved, the emptiness to stand.

22 And Laban was told on the third
Day Jacob fled *without a word*.
23 Then he took his brothers with him
And pursued him for seven days,
He overtook him *in his vim*
In the mountains of Gilead.
24 But Alohim had His own ways,
Came to Laban the Syrian
In a dream in the night he had,
And said to him, "Be careful, man,
To speak to Jacob good nor bad."

I flee from confrontation, too, Beloved,
And often fail the hawk for being doves,
And like shy Jacob turn my frantic flight

Toward Bethel, yet stumble in the night.
If your speaking to me is just illusion,
I pray prostrated here in life's confusion
That Your night warnings to the ones who
seize
My footprints to do me the wrong might
freeze
Their burning hearts and turn their
passioned hate
To good-will for this doubtful deviate.
Do this, Beloved, and I too shall repent
That I had stolen their gods when I went.
Warn not the righteous of the foul
intention,
But break the onslaught and the crowd's
invention.

25 Laban caught up to Jacob, who
Had pitched his tent along the hills,
And Laban with his brothers too
Pitched in the hills of Gilead.
26 And Laban asked Jacob, "What ills
Have you done to me, and what bad
Thing that you steal away unknown
To me, and carried off alone
My daughters like captives with sword?
27 "Why did you flee, *a thing deplored*,
So secretly, and steal away
From me, without a word to say,
And not tell me, I might have sent
You out with joy and songs *well spent*,
With timbrel and with harp? 28 "And you
Did not let me kiss them adieu,
My sons and daughters. Now you do
Foolishly in *this* thing. 29 "It's in
My hand's god to do you harm's *sin*,
But God of your father told me
Last night, and spoke and said to be
Careful to speak to Jacob nor
Good nor bad. 30 "You have found the
door
Surely because you greatly long
For father's house, *and not for wrong*,
But what did you steal my gods for?"

The predator is always injured by
The insult of the prey's escape. Defy
Not predator or he will weep. His heart
Is softer than I think, Beloved. Your art
Made lamb and lion in the raw or in
The flesh and blood inside the human skin.
The stalking predator has his own grin

To mask the wrong. He always has his
sights

On something else, until he takes his rights
In one quick pouncing and surprise. Indeed,
His claws are hidden by the harp, they feed
On certain prey alone, but in their need
They are as soft as stone. Beloved, let me
Scape that claw to be your gratuity.

31 Then Jacob answered and said to
Laban, "Because I was afraid,
And told myself that perhaps you
Would take your daughters as your due
From me by force.' 32 "With whomsoever
You find your gods, then you may sever
His life. In presence of our brothers,
Show what I have of yours *or others*
And take *it* with you." For Jacob
Did not know that, *and there's the rub*,
Rachel stole them. 33 And Laban went
Into Jacob's then Leah's tent,
And into the two maids' tents too,
But did not find. Then he went out
Of Leah's tent and went into
The tent of Rachel for a rout.
34 Now Rachel had taken the gods,
The household idols *made of clods*,
And put them in the camel's saddle,
And sat on them. And Laban's paddle
About the tent turned up no clue.
35 And she said to her father, "Do
Not be displeased that I cannot
Rise up before my lord, as ought,
Since manner of women's on me."
He searched about *diligently*
But did not find the household idols.

Beloved and Father, search my fleshly tent,
Leave hiding place revealed, and all veils
rent,

But find the last of clay and household
gods

And crush them under foot and iron rods.
Whirl round the bleeding saddle where I
sit,

Helpless as I remain in exquisite
Denial of my fault, and in that turning
Leave every false god in my heart there
burning.

The fire of love and wrath are one to me,
But let its flames arising set me free
From every self and every vain desire,

Seven times purified in gates of fire.
I rise to whirl and leave my scorner's chair
To find that only You are everywhere.

36 Then angry Jacob took the bridles,
Rebuked Laban, Jacob replied,
And said to Laban "*Be my guide*
And say what's my trespass and sin,
That you so hotly, in such din
Pursued me. 37 "Although you have
searched

All my things, *my name's unbesmirched*.
Now what things of yours have you found?
Set *it* here before yours and mine,
Between these brothers *on the ground*,
That they may judge who pays the fine!
38 "These twenty years I've *been* with you,
Your ewes and female goats, *not few*,
Have not miscarried their young, I
Have not eaten the rams *set by*
From your flock. 39 "That which was torn I
Did not bring to you, I bore loss.

You took from me, I had to toss
In from my own to make it up,
By morning *crust* or evening *sup*.
40 "There I was! In the day the drought
Consumed me, and by night was caught
In frost, and my sleep left my eyes.

41 "Thus I have been *without reprisal*
In your house twenty years, I served
You fourteen years and *never swerved*,
For your two daughters, and six years
For your flock, and *for what appears*
You have changed my wages ten times.
42 "Unless the God of my grandfather,
The God of Abraham *sometimes*,
And the Fear of Isaac, had rather
Been with me, surely now you would
Have sent me empty *in the wood*.
Alohim saw my troubled labour
And last night rebuked you the neighbour."

Who knows what hidden plots lie under all
The calls to justice, who is short and tall
Before the judgement eye that You lay on
The midnight treachery and on the dawn.
Fault lies in human actions that seek gain
And in their seeking lay a mask in vain
On every face. Jacob was brave to say
What hurts had festered twenty years to
day,

Because he thought he was more innocent

Than he was really in his wife's back tent.
Make me, Beloved, more humble in my cry
Against oppressor, less inclined to try
My innocence against other illusion.
All human things begin and end confusion.

43 And Laban answered Jacob, saying
"*These* daughters *are* my daughters, and
These children *are* my children staying,
And *these* flocks *are* my flocks that stand,
All that you see *is* mine. But what
Can I do this day to begot
Of me or to whom they have borne?
44 "Now therefore, come, let us be sworn
In covenant, both you and I,
Witness between us under sky."

Illusion of wrongness in Laban makes
Him gentle for his daughters' children's
sakes.

The ploy is always useful, whether as
Intended or unplanned as this one was.
The victim's always wrong, the hero stands
With spoils in cart and unwashed, bloody
hands.

I turn from right and wrong in all their veils
And seek Your face alone where justice
pales

Before reality. I lift a song
Made of Your name alone that knows no
wrong.

Let market and the battle field both swear
To be comrades in action everywhere.
I eat and drink and bathe me once a week,
And leave the grasping to the ones who
seek.

45 So Jacob took a stone and set
It up a pillar. 46 Then he told
His brothers, Jacob did, to get
More stones. And all of them took hold
Of stones to bring and make a pile,
On top of which they ate a while.
47 And Laban had a name to give
The place, Jegar Sahadutha,
Jacob, *less imaginative*,
Called it Galeed. 48 And Laban *saw*
And said "This heap *is* witness here
Between you and me this day *clear*."
Therefore its name was called Galeed,
49 Also Mizpah, since he decreed
"May YHWH watch between you and me

When we are absent mutually.

The stones and standing pillars set with
names
Are all that humans have to make their
claims.

With signatures and promises men prove
That utterance alone can never move
The human heart to loyalty and truth.
My prowess is expressed in beads and stays
And contracts lest I be caught up in ruth.
The witnesses on witness steel my days.
Beloved, I turn to You with only breath,
A single word to council before death,
And rise to find above the pillars song
And that the day as well as night is long.
Our whisperings are mutual when said.
You speak and I become and take the
bread.

50 "If you afflict my daughters, or
If you take *other* wives before
My daughters, *although* no man *is*
With us, see, Alohims *has His*
Witness between the both of us
To see if we're contrarious!"

51 Then Laban said to Jacob, "Here
Is this heap which I am *sincere*,
And pillar, in placing between
The both of us, which may be seen
52 "This witness heap and pillar that
Is a witness, from where I'm at
I will not pass beyond this heap
Nor shall you, *while we wake or sleep*,
To do the other harm. 53 "The God
Of Abraham, of Nahor, God
Of their father judge between us."
And Jacob swore, *commodious*,
And by his father Isaac's Dread.
54 Then Jacob offered up instead
A sacrifice on the mountain,
And called his brothers to eat bread.
And they ate bread and stayed therein
All night long upon the mountain.
55 And early in the morning rose
Up Laban, kissed his sons and *chose*
To kiss his daughters, blessed them all.
Then Laban left, went home withal.

The contract that is basic in men's lives
Is not the one that rises in beehives.
Suffice to man another will not harm

His life and wife and child and cattle farm.
 Belovèd, You are just the Dread that keeps
 The equal in invading strength from sweeps
 Into full warfare. There's no shadow more
 Of You in human thoughts from aft to fore.
 The only dread that rises when the power
 Is unequal is that invasion's hour
 Is not postponed, but dread of attack comes
 To release the impoverished of their sums.
 I rise up early to kiss You and go.
 Belovèd, do not let my weakness show.

Genesis 32

1 So Jacob went on his way, and
 The angels of Alohim stand
 To meet him. 2 When Jacob saw them,
 He said "God's camp *and diadem*."
 And he called that place Mahanaim.

This tiny story of the angel bands
 That met Jacob along the blowing sands
 South of Gilead rarely is bespoken.
 A crowd of angels also is the token
 Of my day's walk, and yet I rarely see
 Their iridescent wings and symmetry.
 Perhaps the mere remarkable is reason
 Enough to mention this scented bright
 season,
 Event cut off from the mundane and yet
 Wedged firmly in between the struggles set
 In old survivals. And Jacob's brief hymn
 "The camp of the exalted ones" is dim
 Reverberation on my soul as I
 Walk through the foothill paths beneath a
 sky.

3 Then Jacob sent messengers to
 Esau his brother *to accrue*
Peace in his sight into the land
 Of Seir, the country of Edom.

Week 8

4 He spoke and this was his command,
 "Speak thus to my lord Esau, 'Come,
 Thus your servant Jacob says "I
 Have lived with Laban and stayed by
 Him there till now. 5 "I have *great herds*
 Of oxen, donkeys, flocks, and *birds*,
 Male and female servants, and I
 Have sent to tell my lord, that I
 May find favour beneath your eye.'"

There's nothing mollifies the festered grief
 Like wealth put on display before the thief.
 All friendship is the boughten kind except
 The rarest parts almost in secret kept.
 The brother with age and steel seems to
 find

A fragile moment in which to be kind.
 So Jacob and Esau meet for embrace
 And touch the moment before turning face.
 Rare are the friends that, born of enemies,
 Despite all odds and all the kingly pleas,
 Make all things fragile in comparison.
 But such friends were David and Jonathan.
 Belovèd, You are the Friend beyond the
 pale
 That makes all friendships pause to strike
 the nail.

6 The messengers returned and said
 To Jacob, "We were finally led
 To your brother Esau, and he
 Also is coming to meet you,
 With a four-hundred-man army."
 7 Jacob *did not know what to do*,
 Greatly afraid and more distressed,
 And he divided in two groups
 People, flocks, herds and all the rest,
 And camels too, *to meet the troops*.
 8 And he said "If Esau comes to
 The one group and attacks it, then
 The other group can flee the men."

A four-hundred-man army sets against
 Jacob, led by brother not revered.
 Some hold philosophy divide and conquer,
 But Jacob is not that kind of a honker.
 In desperation he tries to divide
 To save half of his people on one side.
 I too fear blood and kin as well as stranger
 For meeting half a century of danger.
 I do not trust myself much less the other,
 And Esau's enough example of brother.
 In peace or conflict let me trust in You
 No matter what I myself try to do.

9 Then Jacob said "O God whom knew
 My grandfather Abraham and
 My father Isaac, YHWH who *planned*
 And said to me, 'Return to your
 Country and to your family, for
 I will deal well with you': 10 "I am
 Not worthy of the least of all

The mercies and truth *without sham*
 Which You have shown *in Your clear call*
 To Your servant, for I once crossed
 Over this Jordan with my staff,
 And have become two groups, *though lost*,
 11 "Save me, I pray, from the riff-raff
 My brother Esau brings against
 Me, for I fear him, he's incensed,
 Come to attack not only me,
 Mother and child abusively.
 12 "For You said 'I will surely treat
 You well, and make your children's fleet
 Like sea-sand in their multitude.'"

Nostalgia for the time when only staff
 Was his companion and his wealth, a quaff
 Of water without wine, a stone neath head,
 A stone, and in the morning mom's dried
 bread,
 Now blesses Jacob's heart weighed with
 abundance.
 He realizes everything's redundancy.
 Beloved, be my wealth and my poverty,
 Be my companion in prayer's ecstasy,
 Drink with me in Your tavern, Tavern-
 keeper,
 From sip to sip and breath to breath and
 deeper.
 Save me from church and mosque and
 synagogue,
 Where I find You, Beloved, with unwashed
 dog
 To spoil my fond ablutions with wet
 touches.
 I rush to You and throw away my crutches.

13 So he lodged there that very night,
 And took what came to hand *in sight*
 As a present for Esau his
 Brother. 14 The list of presents is:
 Two hundred female goats and twenty
 Male goats, two hundred ewes *a-plenty*
 And twenty rams, 15 and thirty milk
 Camels with their colts *soft as silk*,
 And forty cows and ten bulls, and
 Then twenty female donkeys and
 Ten foals. 16 Then he delivered *them*
 To his servants, *not to condemn*,
 Each drove by itself, and told them
 "Pass over now before me, and
 Put distance between every band."
 17 And he commanded the first one,

And said "When Esau *on the run*,
 My brother, meets you and asks you,
 And says, 'To whom do you belong,
 Where are you going with this crew
 And whose are these in front of you,
To auction, butcher, sale for song?'
 18 "Then you shall say, 'They *are* your
 servant

Jacob's. It is a present *fervent*
 Sent to my lord Esau, indeed,
 He also *comes* behind *full speed*."
 19 So he commanded second, third,
 And all who followed the same word
 And said "This is how you shall speak
 To Esau, *who is out to seek*
My life, when you find him. 20 "And say
 'Your servant Jacob's *on his way*.'
 For he said "I will appease him
 With presents *and with gear and trim*
 That go before me, afterward
 I'll see his face, perhaps *deterred*
From harm, and he will accept me
At least I'll try and we shall see."
 21 So the present went on over
 Before him, but he stayed to stir
 Himself that night within the camp.
 22 And he arose in dark *and damp*
 And took his two wives, and his two
 Maids with eleven sons, and crossed
 Over Jabbok's ford *and withdrew*.
 23 He took them, sent them *not for lost*
 Over the brook, and all he had,
Kit and caboodle, not too bad.

At last I find the use of wealth and gain!
 My humble diet and house would make
 vain

It seems, the race for the abundant life.
 You, my Beloved, suffice and without
 strife.

But now I know the purpose of gain got
 To the superfluous, as Jacob taught.
 Give me, Beloved, the wealth I need to buy
 Peace from the violent in stealth and sly.
 But let me not experience as he
 Return to pillow stone and staff and tree,
 And see four wives and twelve sons walk
 the gate

Towards their slaughter on the path of hate,
 Oh yes, and Dinah too, and all the sheep.
 Leave me, Beloved, some comfort and
 some sleep.

24 Then Jacob was left there alone,
 And a man wrestled him unknown
 Until the breaking of the day.
 25 Now when he saw he could not win
 He touched the socket of his hip,
 Jacob's hip socket then gave way,
 Was out of joint *to his chagrin*
 As he wrestled with him *to slip*.
 26 And he said "Let Me go, day breaks."
 But he said "I will not, *earthquakes*
Will not indeed make me let go,
 Unless you stop to bless me!" 27 So
 He said to him, "What *is* your name?"
 He said "Jacob." 28 *With that acclaim*
 He said "Your name shall be no longer
 Jacob, but Israel, you were stronger,
 Prevailed with Alohim and men."

What angel did You send, Beloved, who
 could
 Not break a man one full night in the
 wood?
 Shall I believe the patriarch was stronger
 Than Your sent angel who could not fight
 longer?
 Truly such hero tales are great to hear
 On dark and snowy evenings end of year.
 He wrestled with an angel, broke a hip,
 Then held the angel tightly lest he trip,
 And made the angel beg to be released,
 Till he at last was blessed, then only
 ceased.
 I do not struggle with You or Your sent,
 But take what You give, satisfied or spent.
 Hold me in trust then any name You will,
 I have enough already to my fill.

29 Then Jacob asked, and said again,
 "Tell *me* your name, I pray." And He
 Said "Why *is* it you ask my name?"
 And he blessed him there *just the same*.
 30 And Jacob called the place Peniel:
 "For I've seen, *and there's no denial*,
 Alohim face to face, and yet
 My life is still preserved *and set*."
 31 Just as he crossed over Penuel
 The sun rose on him, *from the duel*
 He still limped on his hip. 32 Therefore
 To this day Israelites do not
 Eat the muscle that shrank, *as taught*,
 Which *is* on the hip socket where

He touched Jacob's hip's socket there,
 The muscle shrank *from that affair*.

I who have not prevailed with God or men,
 Continue limp as though I had again.
 I ask no name of angel in the dark
 Nor in the morning light. I just remark
 The story's like a tale set to explain
 A practice that would otherwise seem vain,
 Avoiding muscle of the meat that shrank.
 But at the same time this story's to thank
 That in the divine Word appears a scene
 That raises questions now that contravene
 The principle that You cannot be seen.
 I call this place where I wake up Peniel
 To see if I shall find room for denial.
 Still I see no divine face at the trial.

Genesis 33

1 Now Jacob lifted up his eyes
 And looked, and there he could apprise
 Esau coming, and with him were
 Four hundred men. No waverer
 He divided the children twixt
 Leah, Rachel, the two maids, 2 fixed
 The maids and their children in front,
 Leah and her children behind,
 Last Rachel and Joseph *to find*
Best haven and not bear the brunt.

I realize, Beloved, that self-defence
 And defence of the weak dependent on
 Me is incumbent, and in consequence
 The better part of my obedience
 Is to make that provision for the dawn
 Of any kind of danger. Jacob sent
 The handmaids and their lesser children
 first
 Into the line of fire. They were the worst
 In his heart's love, while Rachel was the
 best,
 Who had the safest place in caravan.
 Beloved, obedience in the heart of man
 Reveals a skeleton that is well dressed.
 Would it be wiser to put the best loved
 In greatest danger just to prove I'm gloved?

3 Then he crossed over before them
 And bowed himself *by stratagem*
 To the ground seven times, until
 He stopped before his brother still.
 4 But Esau ran to meet him, and

Embraced him, *did not stay to stand*,
But fell on his neck and kissed him,
And there they wept *the interim*.

For more than twenty years no meeting
came

Between two brothers known for Jacob's
shame.

He bowed himself to the ground as if in
An evening sacrifice for all his sin,
In seven deep prostrations to the ground.
A more repentant brother's never found.
I too run out to meet my enemy
And find him long lost brother still to me.
Beloved, your face is seen not anywhere
Except reflected in the other's heir.
While I kiss all my enemies and fall
On every neck, remind me of the gall.
All men in truth are brothers, but the blind
Of veils lies between mind and covered
mind.

5 And he lifted his eyes and saw
The women and children *in awe*,
And said "Who *are* these *come* with you?"
So he said "These children *are few*
Whom Alohim has graciously
Given to your servant's *husbandry*."

6 Then the maidservants came near, they
And their children, and bowed that way.

7 And Leah also came near and
She with her children to the sand
Bowed down. And afterward Joseph
And Rachel came near *in their feoff*,
And they bowed down. 8 Then Esau said
"What *do you mean by* all this spread
I met?" And he said "*These are to*
Find favour in your sight *anew*."

9 But Esau said "I have enough,
My brother, keep your herds and stuff."

10 And Jacob said "No, please, if I
Have now found favour in your eye,
Then receive my gift from my hand,
Since I've seen your face, understand,
As though I'd seen Alohim's face,
And you were pleased with me *in grace*."

11 "Please, take my blessing that is brought
To you, because Alohim's wrought
Graciously with me, and because
I have enough." And *without pause*
He urged him, and he filled his claws.

The only one I know refused a gift
That was three times pressed on him, was
not miffed

To see the door behind departing guest
Shut with the money safe tucked in the vest
Of the would-be doner, was certain monk
In the Egyptian desert. Self was sunk
In the security of monastery,
Where food was free of all the monetary.
So Esau took what tempted him of goats
And added to the greedy anecdotes.
I thank You no one ever offered me
So much that I could not get myself free
From the temptation to take on the wealth
Belonging to a brother's hearth and health.

12 Then Esau said "Let us take our
Journey, let us go *on the hour*,
And I shall go before you." 13 But
Jacob told him, "My lord knows that
The children *are* weak, and the flocks
And nursing herds can bear no shocks.
And if the men should drive them hard
One day, then all the flock will die.

14 "Please let my lord go on, *no guard*
Is needed by his servant. I
Shall lead on slowly at a pace
Which the livestock before my face
And the children, are able to
Endure, until I come to you
My lord in Seir." 15 And Esau said
"Now let me leave with you *some* folk
Who *are* with me." But then he spoke,
"What need is there? Just let me find
Favour before my lord *inclined*."

With half-hearted confession wrenched by
fear

I send my wealth in offering and draw near
To You, Beloved, expecting a reward
For all the small betrayals of my Lord.
How often I betray You by my grasping
Of veils on veils, pretending that the
claspings

Of gold and silver on the cover's greater
Than the illumined page. The formulator
Of petty rules, I nullify Your state
Of divine oneness with my fork ingrate.
Teach me, Beloved, how to discriminate
Between the action of the veiled and sense
Of divine oneness in the veilings' rents.

Beloved, make loves of all my love and hate.

16 So Esau returned that day on His way to Seir. 17 And Jacob's gone To Succoth, built himself a house, And made booths for his livestock's *chouse*.

That's why the place is called Succoth.

18 Then Jacob came safe *in the cloth* To the city of Shechem, which *Is* in Canaan's land where he'd pitch His tent before the city when He came from Padan Aram's *den*.

19 And he bought the parcel of land, Where he had pitched his tent *to stand*, From the children of Hamor who Was Shechem's father, at price due Of one hundred kesitas *worth*.

20 He made an altar *on the earth* Called El Elohe Israel, God, God of Israel, *goes the spell*.

Peace that endures is peace that makes a line

Of distance between brothers that is fine As far as Seir from Succoth where to build A house for defence and lest milk is spilled Booths for the livestock lest somebody cheat

And take what's left of a depleted fleet Since Esau got rich on Jacob's confession. The distance makes good for the good possession.

That's something Abraham taught Lot to know

And sent him off to Sodom and the snow Of fire and brimstone on his salt and bread. Ah, my Belovèd, give me peace that takes Up all the slack that Succoth-Seir makes. Then I shall wear peace on my hands and head.

Genesis 34

1 Now Leah's daughter Dinah whom She'd borne to Jacob *to their doom*, Went out to see the daughters of The land. 2 And when Shechem, *her love*, The son of Hamor the Hivite, Prince of the country, saw her *right*, He took her and lay with her, and He violated her *and flanned*.

3 His soul was strongly attracted To Dinah, Jacob's daughter bred. And he loved the young woman and Spoke kindly to her what he planned.

My soul returns to You, Beloved, though I Am often blinded by the veils to spy On every other kind of false attachment. The market-place abounds in bright dispatchment

For this and that position and right friend. But all of these require the buy and lend Of every man's integrity. Set free Of vain hopes and despairs I often see The rest alive in You, Beloved, to be None other but Your loved and complement.

My will made Yours is always cheaply spent.

I spread aside the silken curtains and Come naked before Your light sword and stand, Awaiting the stroke of the divine hand.

4 So Shechem spoke to Hamor his Father and said "Please get me this Young woman as a wife." 5 And so Jacob found out *the gigolo* Had spoiled his daughter Dinah. Now His sons were with his herds, somehow Jacob held his peace till they came.

6 Then Hamor Shechem's father came Out to Jacob to speak with him.

7 And the sons of Jacob were grim When they came from the field and heard, And the men were grieved and angry, Because he had done and incurred Disgraceful things that should not be In Israel lying with the daughter Of Jacob *when he loved and caught her*.

According to Mosaic law, the plan Of Shechem was the right thing that a man Who had lain with a virgin ought to do. Disgraceful it may be, but then he drew The right conclusions of what's good and fair.

He promised to make Dinah's child his heir. The punishment for fornication is Not death but only repenting of his Mistake, and sacrifice and proper dowry,

And having so, he should not miss the
hour.

But Jacob held his peace. It was his sons
That were so angry they could have laid
tons

Of bombs on Shechem's city. I too hold
My peace, Beloved, but need a son who's
bold.

8 But Hamor spoke with them, and said
"The soul of my son Shechem's *fed*
On longing for your daughter. Wed
Her please to him as wife *and bed*.

9 "And make marriages with us, give
Your daughters to us, and let live
Our daughters as your wives. 10 "So you
Shall live with us, the land in view
Shall be for you to live and trade
In it, acquiring goods *well-made*."

11 Then Shechem told her father and
Her brothers, "Please now let me stand
In favour in your eyes, and what
You say, I'll give *of what I've got*.

12 "Ask me ever so much dowry
And gift, I'll give accordingly
To what you say to me, but give
Me the young woman wife *to live*."

Beloved, my soul is filled with longing for
Your presence. I unlock the seven locks
And then trembling unbolt the inner door.
I enter in the temple carved in rocks,
Not in beloved Cush, but in my heart.
I penetrate the silken veils and part
The hangings all embroidered in fine gold
For thread, pass by the lamps seven all told
And made of beaten and spun gold, pass by
The table and the bread, the censor's tie
With cherubim wings spread, come to the
ark

And see the burning light, walls damp and
stark.

Beloved, I call and call. The echoing room
Is empty, is this now the day of doom?

13 But Jacob's sons answered Shechem
And Hamor his father *pro tem*,
Deceitfully, because he had
Defiled their sister Dinah bad.

14 And they said to them, "We cannot
Do this thing, and give *on the spot*
Our sister to uncircumcised,

Reproach to us *and thing despised*.

15 "We shall consent on this *condition*,
If you'll correct this one omission,
And every male of yours become
As we *are*, circumcised, in sum,
16 "Then we will give our daughters to
You, and we'll take your daughters to
Us, and we will stay on with you,
And we will be one people, too.
17 "But if you will not heed us and
Be circumcised, we'll leave the land
And take our daughter and be gone."

Tell me, Beloved, is there in all the land
A righteous and a diminishing band
Of twelve or more, whose proclamation of
Your truth and law is tempered with Your
love?

Or do all preachers of Your name and fame
Conceal their filthy devisings of shame,
Yet shamelessly fulfil their plans' deceit?
I hear the noble words repeat, repeat,
And see the smiling greetings, yet I've been
Once circumcised and circumcised for sin
Again and once again till naught remains
To cut from my flesh but skin and
chillblains.

I offer You alone, Beloved, the pity
That's left after Mecca and Athens city.

18 And their words pleased Hamor anon
And Shechem, Hamor's son. 19 So he
Did not delay to do the thing,
Since he delighted *like a king*
In Jacob's daughter. He *was* more
Honourable than all those before
In his father's household. 20 Hamor
And Shechem his son came before
The gate of their city, and spoke
With their city's men and they broke
Their mind thus saying 21 "These men *are*
At peace with us, *come from afar*.
Therefore let them live in the land
And trade in it. Indeed the land
Is large enough for them. Let us
Take their daughters to us as wives,
And let's give them our daughters thus.
22 "This one condition just contrives
To make us one people and they
Will thus consent to come our way,
If all our males are circumcised
As they are too, *so they've advised*.

23 "Will not their livestock, property,
And all their herds be ours for free?
Let us only consent to them,
And they will live with us." 24 Both stem
And stern all who went out the gate
Of his city heeded Hamor
And Shechem his son, *what is more*,
And every male who could not wait
Was circumcised, there at the gate
Of his city, *and walked no more*.

Hamor had sense enough to speak of
wealth
To all the men, who cared not for their
health,
But let greed take them. It is always greed
Or sex or honour that blinds those in need
Who search out the ways to a heavenly
home.
These three turn from Jerusalem to Rome
The weary traveller. Purify my soul,
Beloved, from these three in a common
goal,
And I shall find Your presence easily.
Set me from greed, lust and ambition free,
And I shall find the palaces of gold,
The heavenly thrones, rivers of wine and
bold
Houri in what I knew before. Reward
Me not with future gifts, but the restored.

25 Now it happened on the third day,
When all the city men were sore,
(*Try circumcision then for gore*)
Two sons of Jacob came that way,
Simeon and Levi, Dinah's brothers,
Each took his sword, came on the others
Boldly upon the city and
Killed all the males *found in the land*.
26 And they killed Hamor and his son
Shechem with their sword *one for one*,
And took Dinah from Shechem's house,
And went out *quiet as a mouse*.
27 The sons of Jacob came upon
The slain, and plundered every john
In the city, because their sister
Had been defiled *before they missed her*.
28 They took their sheep, their oxen, and
Their donkeys, what *was* in the land
And city, what *was* in the field,
29 And all their wealth, and all concealed,
Their little ones and their wives too

They took all captive, not a few,
And they plundered even all that *was*
In all the houses. 30 *Father-in-laws*
Do not act so, then Jacob said
To Simeon and Levi instead,
"You've troubled me to make me stink
Before this land's inhabitants.
The Canaanites will sure not wink,
Nor will the Perizzites come dance,
Since I *am* few in number, they
Will gather themselves in the way
Against me and kill me. I'll be
Destroyed, my household, bond and free."
31 But they said "Should he treat our sister
Like a harlot? *He more than kissed her*."

Beloved, this Jacob is most sorry that
A hundred men or more that nobly sat
At city gate for judgement have been slain.
Such sympathy for lost life would be sane,
Except he worries not a hair for those
Who've lost husband and father and rich
clothes,
Their livelihoods and cattle, all their
wealth,
Since two sons acted violence and stealth,
And all the rest came to the plunder fast.
He says not one word of the rue and blast.
He only worries that some angry man
Might take revenge on son and partisan.
Beloved, may I repent the evil act,
Because it's evil, not because I'm sacked.

Genesis 35

1 Said Alohim to Jacob, "Now
Get up, go up to Bethel and
Live there, and make an altar *how*
To *worship* there *by My command*,
El, El God, who appeared to you
When you fled *without friend or crew*
From the *wrath and the angry face*
Of brother Esau to this place."

When it is to the purpose of my profit
Or my safety, I find no way to scoff at
The claim that You, Beloved, give me
advice
To do whatever I myself think nice.
When Jacob thought the people's
vengeance came
Too close, he had a vision to his shame

That drove him out and helped him save his face.

"Oh no, it's not for fear I leave this place
Nor shame my sons are murderers by band.
I got a vision from the dear Lord God,
And that's the only reason I take rod
In hand and head toward the Río Grande."
Beloved, when I obey let there be no
Advantage in my going when I go.

2 And Jacob said to his household
And to all with him, "Now, *be bold*,
Put away the foreign gods that
Are with you, *enter dyeing vat*
And purify yourselves, and change
Your garments, *that is nothing strange*.

3 "Then let us get up and go up
To Bethel, and I *shall lift cup*
Of sacrifice and I shall make
An altar there to El God El,
Who answered me, *and for my sake*,
In the day of *my heavenly spell*,
And my distress and He has been
With me on the way that I'm in."

It was not just Rachel his wife that had
Those foreign gods. Jacob was not that bad.
It was the passel of Shechemite herd
Of womenfolk and children, in a word,
The widowed and the orphaned by the hand
Of Jacob's sons, who followed the
command

Of foreign gods, fat, breasted terra cotta
Baked figurines to help the crops or ought
to.

If Jacob's sons are bloody men, the man
Himself turns all to missions when he can.
He set the pattern for the world to come,
Since blood and theft are missionaries' sum.
Beloved, speak to each human heart direct,
Make missions a redundancy to reject.

4 So they gave Jacob all the gods
The foreign gods *of sods and clods*
In their hands, and the earrings which
Were in their ears, and Jacob hid
Them under a tree without hitch,
The terebinth by Shechem's mid.

5 And they journeyed, and they went on,
Alohim's terror was upon
The cities that *were* all around,
Not to run Jacob's in the ground.

Why earrings too? The Torah makes such
rings

As put in ear with awl shot through the
things

To show eternal servanthship and true.

That's why the celibates do what they do.

It seems these earrings with their weight in
gold

Convinced their wearers that the gods of
old,

Whose bodies and flesh made of gold
repair

To modern wearers, come in state and fair

To perch below the ears in those things
made

Of divine bodies pounded, plied and
stayed.

Who seek the gold seek idols under trees
That are of no worth other than to please.

Give me, Beloved, such pleasure in the
fading

Of flowers more gold than those in ears
parading.

6 So Jacob came to Luz (that is,
Bethel), in Canaan's land, and his
People with him *and all they'd found*.

7 He built an altar there and called
The place El Bethel, there installed,
Because there Alohim appeared
To him when he fled *and he feared*
Before his brother, *and appalled*.

8 Now Deborah, Rebekah's nurse,
Died, and was buried *for the worse*
Below Bethel beneath a tree,
The terebinth. So came to be
Its name Allon Bachuth, which see,
Means oak of weeping, *such a curse*.

Now Deborah, Beloved, is hardly known,
Except by her great namesake who was
shown

To be among the greatest women prophets.
Poor Deborah was not one with great
profits,

A wet-nurse, she had her own family
That trailed to Luz behind her hopefully,
A son perhaps or daughter and their own
Offspring, the nameless servants there to
groan

And weep at loss of mother and
grandmother.
Of all the women in Jacob's life she
Was probably better than any other.
She no doubt took loved Joseph from the
womb,
And cared for him and loved him in the
bloom
Of her own grandsons. Blessed may
Deborah be!

9 Then Alohim appeared again
To *our dear* Jacob, when he came
From Padan Aram *with his men*,
And blessed him *for what he became*.

10 And Alohim said to him, "Your
Name *is* Jacob, your name no more
Shall be called Jacob *for your fame*,
But Israel shall be your name." So
He called his name Israel. 11 Also
Alohim said to him, "I *am*
El El God Almighty, *no sham*.
Be fruitful, multiply, a nation
And company of nations shall
Proceed from you, *and your location*,
And kings from you *perpetual*."

12 "The land which I gave Abraham
And Isaac I give you, I am
Giving to your descendants too
This very land come after you."

13 Then Alohim went up from him
In the place where He talked with him.
14 So Jacob set up there a pillar
In the place where He talked with him,
A pillar of stone *as instiller*
Of memory, and he poured drink
Offering on it, and oil to *sink*.

15 And Jacob called the name of it
Bethel, where Alohim spoke *fit*.

Just here is where you made, Beloved,
mistake.

You set aside this land for Abram's sake.
And now You seem to give it all to one,
To Jacob, who is not the only son.
No doubt it's Your intention to affirm
His right after his absence from the firm.
But just see what an impasse came between
Ishmael's children and Jacob's. Intervene!
To Abraham You give the broadest stretch
From Nile to Euphrates, both corn and
vetch.

To Jacob You give lesser room below,
A pillar and a stone, but more to show,
A ladder reaching up to heaven above,
An offering and its oil, a gift of love.

16 Then they journeyed from Bethel down
To not far from Ephrath, *the town*,
And Rachel laboured *in childbirth*,
And had hard labour on the earth.

17 Now it happened, when she was in
Hard labour and harsh discipline,
The midwife said to her, "Don't fear,
Your second son too shall appear."

18 And so it was, with soul departing
(For she died *from the birth-sting*
smarting),

That she called his name Ben-Oni,
But father called him Benjamin.

19 So Rachel died and was buried
On the way to Ephrath (but read
Bethlehem). 20 And Jacob set up
A pillar on her grave *no tup*
Might overturn, and to this day
Rachel's grave's pillar's in the way.

Son of my sorrow ought to be the name
Since that was the last wish, his mother's
claim.

But Jacob wanted to be positive
And this was his chance to have his own
way

As well as superciliously to give
A name for one he would be proud to say
On any Canaanitish market day.

Son of my sorrow would remember blame
As well as call to mind the shoddy game
That Jacob always played, and to his
shame,

With kith and kin. Despite his
machinations,

Beloved, You blessed him in all his
relations

And in his tackle and his gear. Bless me,
Beloved, as him and for eternity.

21 Then Israel journeyed, pitched his tent
Beyond Eder's tower. 22 As it went,
When Israel lived in that land, that
Reuben lay with Bilhah, *the rat*,
She was his father's concubine,
And Israel heard *the libertine*.

The Hebrew text, at least applied by note
And music mark the Massoretics wrote,
Cannot be read, at least not cantillated,
To understand. The text is separated
Into three halves, which does not lend
support

To mathematically accurate report.
Three halves are one too many, to be sure,
And that may be the meaning in the pure.
Reuben was one too many in the bed,
Which was true and a hard thing to be said.
And so the cantillating tongue is tripped
On triple halves confounding one verse
sipped.

Beloved, let there be no halves, no, nor
thirds,
But only One, You only and Your words.

Now the sons of Jacob were twelve.
23 Their names were, *we can dig and
delve*:

The sons of Leah *were* Reuben,
Jacob's firstborn, and Simeon,
Levi, Judah, Issachar, and
Zebulon. 24 The sons of Rachel
Were Joseph and last Benjamin.
25 The sons of Bilhah, on command
To Rachel, *were* Dan and as well
Naphtali. 26 And then Zilpah's sons,
Leah's maidservant, *were the ones
Named* Gad and Asher. These *were all*
The sons of Jacob *great and small*
Born to him in Padan Aram,
All descendants of Abraham.

The names of the twelve sons are so
arranged
To represent the twelve steps never
changed
In entering the palace and the city,
The temple of the holy and the witty.
The names of Ishmael's twelve had set the
pace,
And here the twelve of Jacob join the race.
Each slot in human searching for divine
Is captured in one word each for the sign.
Behold a son begins the traveller's toil
Until he reach the blessedness and soil
Of Asher in the gate of earth and see
That all the gates return eternally
Upon the bright slopes of reality.

Beloved, anoint all twelve names with
Your oil.

27 Then Jacob came to his father
Isaac at Mamre, or rather
Kirjath Arba (that *is*, Hebron),
Where Abraham had lived with son
Isaac. 28 Now Isaac's lifespan was
One hundred eighty years, 29 because
Isaac breathed his last and he died,
Was gathered to his people's side,
Well aged. His sons *like seraphim*,
Esau and Jacob, buried him.

Genesis 36

1 This *is* the genealogy
Of Esau, who is Edom. 2 He,
Esau, took his wives from the daughters
Of Canaan: Adah from the daughters
Of Elon the Hittite, and then
Aholibamah, daughter of
Anah, who was the daughter of
Zibeon the Hivite again,
3 And Basemath, Ishmael's daughter,
Sister of Nebajoth. 4 Now her
Son, son of Adah and Esau
Was Eliphaz, and Basemath
Bore Reuel. 5 And *no psychopath*,
Aholibamah bore Jeush,
Jaalam, and Korah *in her rush*.
These *were* the sons of Esau who
Were born to him in Canaan's land.
6 Then Esau took both his wives and
His sons, and all his daughters too,
And all the persons of his house,
His cattle and all them that browse,
And all his goods which he had gained
In Canaan's land *when it had rained*,
And went to a country away
From his brother's, that's Jacob's, sway.
7 For their possessions *were* too great
To live together *in one state*,
And the land where they lived as strangers
Could not support stock *without dangers*.
8 So then Esau lived in Mount Seir,
(Esau *is* Edom), *to be freer*.

Like Abraham and Lot, two brothers could
Not live together for the weight of wealth.
So it was not hate nor the lack of health
That separated two men in the wood.
You give, Beloved, gifts of diverse regards

To keep brothers apart, lone beacons on
The deeper darkness that precedes the
dawn.

Soon evidence of both is strewn in shards.
And yet their households both were full and
great.

It was not a lone dervish separate
That each became. But separation in
Love and friendship, though it is never sin,
Leads to the rumours of hostility.
Beloved, from all such rumours set me free.

9 This *is* the genealogy
Of Esau, father of the *free*
Edomites *living* in Mount Seir.

10 These *were* the names of the *yet freer*
Sons of Esau: Eliphaz son
Of Adah Esau's wife begun,
And Reuel son of Basemath
The wife of Esau *not in wrath*.

11 And the sons of Eliphaz were
Teman, Omar, Zepho demur,
Gatam, and Kenaz. 12 Now there was
A concubine of Esau's son
Eliphaz named Timna who was
Mother of Amalek his son.
These *were* Adah, Esau's wife's sons,
With all their grace and benisons.

What multitudes of names suggestive, O
Beloved! Adah, adorned but with the show
Of being swarm, is also known as
fragrance.

The names reach out to both great faith and
vagrance.

Eliphaz, My strength's God, looks like it
might

Be gold instead of strength. Who knows
what night

Hides in the holy family. The friend
Of God, Reuel, has no sons here to tend
That heritage of Abraham, but gold
For God and strength are making five all
told:

The south in Yemen, speech, a watch and
wait,

The puny, and the side. I flee from hate
To Yemen, restraint for my concubine
And warlike rush to You and to Your wine.

13 These *were* the sons of Reuel:
Nahath, Zerah, to end the spell

Shammah, and Mizzah. These would tell
Esau's wife's Basemath's sons well.

The four gates to You, My Beloved, are
wrote

In four names that Reuel's children quote.
The first gate, Nahath, is the calm of law,
In which the soul before Your throne in
awe

Bows to its Master in perfect submission.
Zerah expresses the next gate's position,
Enlightenment of love, a rising star
To guide the longing heart to where You
are.

Awareness is the third gate, devastation
Is its name, that with sudden protestation
The soul sees all things as You wish to see.
The devastated fields turn into fear
That melt into well watered earth with tear
And then in all their splendours cease to be.

14 These were Aholibamah's sons,
Esau's wife, daughter of Anah,
Who's a daughter of Zibeon's.

And she bore these sons to Esau:
Jeush, Jaalam, and *last* Korah.

15 These *were* the chiefs of Esau's sons.

The sons of Eliphaz, the firstborn
Of Esau: Chief Teman, not worst born,
Chief Omar, Chief Zepho, Chief Kenaz,
16 Chief Korah, Chief Gatam, *and when as*
Last Chief Amalek. These *were* chiefs
Of Eliphaz in Edom's fiefs.

They *were all* the sons of Adah.

17 These *were* the sons of Reuel,
Esau's son: Chiefs Nahath, Zerah,
Chiefs Shammah, and Mizzah *befell*.

And these *were* the chiefs of Reuel
In the land of Edom for life,
Sons of Basemath, Esau's wife.

18 These sons of Aholibamah,
Esau's wife were: Chief Jeush, Chief
Jaalam, and *at last* Chief Korah.

These *were* the chiefs of every fief
Who came from Aholibamah,
Esau's wife, daughter of Anah.

19 These *were* the sons of Esau, who
Is Edom *with sons not a few*,
And *all of these sons were* their chiefs
In all their villages and fiefs.

20 These *were* the sons of Seir the Horite
Inhabiting the land *with more right*:

Lotan, Shobal, Zibeon, Anah,
21 Dishon, Ezer, Dishan in manner.
These *were* the chiefs of the Horites,
Seir's sons in Edom's *land and rights*.
22 And the sons of Lotan were Hori
And Hemam *who were neither sorry*.
Lotan's sister *was* Timna too.

23 These *were* the sons of Shobal: Alvan,
Manahath, Ebal, Shepho, Onam.

24 These *were* the sons of Zibeon:
Both Ajah and Anah *begun*.

This *was the* Anah who found water
In the desert searching for fodder
For donkeys of his father Zibeon
Not to make of them an amphibian.

25 These *were* the children of Anah:
Dishon and Aholibamah
The *famous* daughter of Anah.

26 These *were* the sons of Dishon:
Hemdan,
Eshban, Ithran, and last Cheran.

Though Malachi is certain that You hate
Poor Esau with no reason but his fate,
The fact remains, despite the wondered
store

Of Jacob on the famed and fortunated shore,
That Esau's family came up with the name
That would be the last prophet's claim to
fame.

Hamdan is known to the sacred Vulgata
And so stays in ecclesiastic larder.
Beloved, the great grandson of Esau stays
To welcome his own namesake to the
plays,

And I join in the praise and the desire
That name is always ready to inspire.
I wait for comfort not in this world's grief,
But in the praise of Paradise relief.

27 These *were* the sons of Ezer: Bilhan,
Zaavan, and *finally* Akan.

28 These *were* the *two* sons of Dishan:
Uz and *his brother called* Aran.

29 These *were* the chiefs of the Horites:
Chief Lotan, Chief Shobal *for lights*,
Chief Zibeon, and Chief Anah,

30 Chief Dishon, Chief Ezer, Chief Dishan.
These *were* the chiefs of the Horites,
According to their chiefs *and law*
In Seir's land *and for their mission*.

31 Now these *were* the kings who reigned
in

The land of Edom before *sin*
Set any king to rule the people
Of Israel *or raise a steeple*:

32 Bela the son of Beor reigned
In Edom, and *no one complained*
His city was called Dinhabah.

33 And when Bela died, Jobab son
Of Zerah of Bozrah'd begun
To reign there in his place *for fun*.

34 When Jobab died, Husham of the
Land of the Temanites reigned free
In his place. 35 And when Husham died,
Hadad the son of Bedad tried,
Who attacked Midian in the field
Of Moab, reigned *and did not yield*.

And his city's name *was* Avith.

36 When Hadad died, then it was with
Samlah of Masrekah to reign
In his place. 37 And when Samlah'd lain
In death, Saul of Rehoboth-*by*
The-River reigned in his proxy.

38 When Saul died, Baal-Hanan the son
Of Achbor reigned where he'd begun.

39 And when he died then Baal-Hanan,
The son of Achbor *in the canon*,
Hadar reigned in his place, the name
Of his city *was* Pau. The fame
Of his wife *was* Mehetabel,
Daughter of Matred, who was well
Sired by Mezahab *truth to tell*.

40 And these *were* the names of the chiefs
Of Esau, by families and fiefs,

And by their names: Chief Timnah, and
Chief Alvah, Chief Jetheth's command,

41 Chief Aholibamah, Chief Elah,
Chief Pinon, 42 Chief Kenaz, *a stele*
To chief of Yemen and the south
Teman, Chief Mibzar, 43 Chief Magdiel,
And Chief Iram. *As with one mouth*

These *were* the chiefs of Edom's *weal*,
According to their dwelling places
In their possession, *by their graces*.
Esau *was* father *we may call*
Ancestor of Edomites *all*.

Belovèd, Ishmael sets the common pace
Found throughout Scripture that the holy
race
Must come from twelve fruits on one
sacred tree,

Brothers and sons of one great patriarch
Whose faith goes almost to the Pleasure
park.

The pace was set, and so twelve there must
be.

Behold the mortal genealogy:
Esau's chiefdoms make just eleven told,
While Jacob's sons are always counted,
sold,

And bound as twelve, although the tribes
are set

At thirteen, count the lists, what do You
get?

They juggle Simeon, Manasseh, Ephraim,
Embarrassed with too many. One of them
Give to Esau, or make Yourself cadet!

Week 9 Genesis 37

1 Now Jacob lived in the land where
His father was a stranger, there
In Canaan's land. 2 This *is* the history
Of Jacob. Joseph, *without mystery*
Was seventeen years old, and feeding
The flock with his brothers, *and leading*
The sheep with his father's wives' sons,
Bilhah and Zilpah *were the ones*.
And Joseph brought a bad report
Of them to his father, *the sport*.

Beloved, there's no one loves a tattle-tale,
And that's the truth, yet Joseph did not fail
In telling father what his brother's done.
The prohibition on backbiting won
Its place in law, but it too can be taught
To do its own injustice. I have sought
To live that what is told of me can stand,
And I need not hold tales in contraband.
Say of me what you wish, and it is true,
And I shall not rehear the tale with rue.
Who is oppressed has right to tell the story.
Say not backbiting when I show what gory
And evil deeds I know, am witness to.
Such prudery, Beloved, is beneath You.

3 Now Israel loved Joseph more than
All of his children *to a man*,
Because he *was* the son of his
Old age. He made him a cloak of
Colours *by which to show his love*.

4 But when his brothers see that their
Father loves him more than *the fair*
Of all his brothers, their hate is

Aroused so that they cannot speak
To him peaceably day nor week.

Beloved, give me no coloured cloak to
waken

The envy of my neighbour, a garb shaken
From window and from housetop, worn in
heat

And frost to rouse envy in those I meet.
Envy I have to meet and that to spare.
Give me rather in love the coloured air
That's free to all, the hundred coloured lake
That my forest hillside birch and fir make,
The meadowed steps about my door a-paint
With balsam and nasturtium and the quaint
Last blue forget-me-not. Beloved, no cloak
Of greater love ask I, instead invoke
The melting of the mists and rending veils
That separate me from You. All else fails.

5 Now Joseph had a dream, and he
Told *it* to his brothers *for free*,
And they hated him even more.

6 So he said to them, "Hear *the score*,
This dream of mine that I have dreamed.

7 "There we were, binding sheaves, *it*
seemed,

There in the field. Then indeed, my
Sheaf rose and stood toward the sky,
While truly your sheaves stood around
And bowed themselves toward the ground
To my sheaf standing straight and high."

8 And his brothers said to him, "Shall
You truly wax imperial,
Reign over us? Or indeed shall
You have dominion over us?"
So they hated him even more
For his dreams *of what was in store*
And for his words *and for the fuss*.

There's hardly man alive who does not
dream
To take precedence over brother's scheme.
Nor is it rare such dreams cause fuss and
feud

Between siblings so righteously imbued.
Each recognizes the divine right in
His own heart and the other's awful sin
Of blasphemy to block the divine glory.
All this, Beloved, is just the same old story.
It is not strange for one to brave the boast,
Declaring his intentions to the host

Of low fraternal future servant peer.
What's rare instead is Joseph's chancicleer
Expecting praise and petting for his
dreaming.
He is too good to stoop to boast or
scheming.

9 Then he dreamed still another dream
He told for his brothers' esteem,
And said "Look, I have dreamed another
Dream. And this time, the sun, *and mother*
Moon, and eleven stars bowed to me."

10 So he told to his brothers gloomy
And to his father who rebuked him
And said, *because his dream beducked him*,
"What *is* this dream that you have
dreamed?

Shall your mother and, as it seemed,
I and your brothers indeed come
To worship you to earth in sum?"

11 And his brothers envied him, but
His father kept *in mind* the spot.

Now even prophets must not be naive,
Expecting elders to give them reprieve
For proclamation of the honour due them.
No, no, the best plan is always to woo
them.

Beloved, You cause Joseph the innocent
The suffering he endured where he was
sent.

No father will condone a dead wife's station
Beneath a son, no matter what elation.
You ask, Beloved, too much of human
pride.

Ask us for worship, fasting, and a side
Of charity to feed the poor, but not
That little brothers from whose noses snot
We've wiped away be raised to reign above
Their betters, no, the thing is unheard of.

12 Then his brothers went out to feed
Their father's flock on Shechem *weed*.

13 And Israel said to Joseph, "Are
Not your brothers feeding *not far*
In Shechem? Come, I'll send you to them."
So he said to him, "Here am I."

14 Then he said to him, "Please go through
them

And see if it's well or awry
With your brothers and well with flock,
And bring back word to me *at dock*."

So he sent him out of the Valley
Of Hebron, and to Shechem's alley.

One day these men are killing in the city,
The men both young and old and without
pity

Who had converted to the faith and Lord,
For motive of wealth, yet unsheathed their
sword

In gauge of their fidelity to You,
Sword limp and dripping blood and not the
dew,

To find the missionaries come upon them
And slaughter all before it could dawn on
them,

And now the same and ruthless pastors
make

Of those blood fields a bed for their sheep's
sake

And pasture for the literal in lambs,
Wealth got from their pastoral, churchly
scams.

Beloved, Your missionaries always thought
They owned the lives of those they cut and
taught.

15 Now a certain man found him, and
There he was, wandering in the land.
And the man asked him, saying "What
Are you seeking *and what's the butt*?"

16 So he said "I'm seeking my brothers.
Please tell me where they're feeding
others."

17 And the man said "They have departed
From here, I heard them, *when they started*,
Say, 'Let us go to Dothan.'" So
Joseph went after them *in tow*

To Dothan and there found his brothers.

18 Now when they saw him afar off,
Before he ev'n came near the others,
They conspired against him to *scoff*

And kill him. 19 Then they said to one
Another, "Look, now let's be done,
This dreamer's coming *to us fast*!"

20 "Come therefore, let's now kill him, cast
Him in some pit, and say, 'Some wild
Beast has *killed and* devoured *the child*.'
We'll see what comes of all his dreams!"

21 But Reuben heard, and stopped their
schemes,

And told *them*, "Let us not kill him."

22 And Reuben said to them, "It's dim

To shed blood, cast him in this pit
Here in the desert, don't touch him!"
That he might save him and to wit,
Return him to his dad's outfit.

Beloved, that's par for brothers everywhere.
There's one in ten not to kill of the fair
In fratricide when in the situation.
That one, though, makes no public
acclamation.

I've lived to learn the man who calls me
brother

Is there to stab me faster than another.
The act is justified experiment
To see where all my failing dreamings
went.

Joseph was right when he whirled in the
field

Of Shechem without aim until appealed
To by the stranger and asked for his goal.
Let me, lone dervish, find there my lost
soul

Where You alone are present. Grant no
church

Of brothers to leave me soon in the lurch.

23 So it turned out, when Joseph had
Come to his brothers, and was clad
In coloured cloak, they stripped it off him.

24 They took him then *as if to shroff him*
And cast him in an empty pit,
One that had no water in it.

25 And they sat down to eat a meal.
Then lifting eye, they saw a deal
Of Ishmaelites, with camels coming
From Gilead, bearing spices, drumming
Both balm, and myrrh, and on their way
To Egypt to sell things for pay.

26 So Judah told his brothers, "What
Profit *is there* to kill the mutt
Our brother and conceal his blood?

27 "*Come and let's take him from the mud,*
Let's sell him to the Ishmaelites,
And let us not take such delights
In killing, for he *is* our brother
And our flesh, and so let's not smother
Fraternal feelings." And they heard
His brothers did, and kept his word.

Beloved, if I knew not the better sight,
I'd say You had become anti-Semite.
You say that Judah said "What profit comes

Of killing brothers when we could make
sums?"

You seem to think a Jew will sell his
brother

As soon as he's the chance, and tell the
other

He'd sold him in compassion not to take
His life, but sold him for his own sweet
sake.

Beloved, I'm stripped of cloak and honour
too,

Cast in a pit to die, by one not Jew.

I'm here to tell You violence to mate
Knows neither race nor creed nor civil
state.

You meet me in the pit, I'm honour-clad,
And fed and drunk where desert had gone
mad.

28 Then Midianite traders passed by,
So *they* pulled Joseph from the dry
Pit and sold him to Ishmaelite
For twenty silver spots for spite.
And they took Joseph to Egypt.
So Joseph's brothers sinned and slipped.

Beloved, You have no better picture of
The Arab than the Jew, both whom You
love.

If Jew will sell his brother, Arab's willing
To make a child a slave for twenty shilling.
One nation out for profit, one out for
The servant institution more and more.
The Filipina slave, the Indian chore,
Rivals the flesh traffic in Amsterdam,
Which city only shows that Abraham
Is not alone in children for whom greed
Remains forever the primary need.
Beloved, have pity on one here indeed,
And cleanse me of the veiling lust to take.
Give me the giving heart beside tent stake.

29 Then Reuben returned to the pit,
And indeed Joseph *was* not there,
And so he tore his clothes and hair.

30 Returning where his brothers sit,
He said "The lad's *no more*, and I,
Where shall I go *or shall I die*?"

Beloved, I turn to find You in the pit
Where I had hidden You, who had not fit
For shame the company I sought to keep.

And on a moment I woke up from sleep,
And knew I had turned from the jewel to
loss,
From love to preening at the smoking
dross.

Ashamed to claim my own Love, I hid You
In a dry pit beneath the stars and dew.
But when I woke in terror and forlorn,
Repenting of the Love that I'd foresworn,
I rushed to find You where the freshly
morn
Had glistened in Your hair and brightened
thorn.

I came, but found the empty pit and sand,
Dry, whisper-silent, stealing on the land.

31 So they took Joseph's *outer* cloak,
Killed a kid of the goats to soak
It in the blood. 32 Then they sent it,
The bloody coloured cloak, brought it
To their father and said "We've found
This *bloody garment on the ground*.
Do you know whether it's your son's
Or some one of the other ones?"
33 And he knew it and said "*It is*
Indeed that coloured cloak of his
A wild beast has with tooth and claw
Devoured Joseph with cruel paw."
34 Then Jacob tore his clothes, and put
Sackcloth on his waist, and *barefoot*
Mourned for his son for many days.
35 And all his sons and all his daughters
Arose to comfort for his slaughters,
But he refused comfort, compassion,
And said "For I shall in this fashion
Go down into the grave in mourning
My son." Thus was *Jacob's* forlorn.

They came and told me You were caught
and bound,
Who had been Sovereign, free, in sight and
sound,
And meshed in Trinity and creed and
crown,
And set up golden in a palace down,
Where rich and poor might come in
pilgrimage.
They said that You were taught, no
sacrilege,
By priest and church and baked in hopeful
bread,
Who had fled joyous on the face of dawn

With wings that sped infinities and on
And then came back to pledge and comfort
me.

And what they said filled my free heart
with dread.

So now I bend and genuflect to see
Your face cut in such marble that I flee
To veil my eye and heart and mourn for
Thee.

36 The Midianites had sold him in
Egypt to Potiphar, who's been
An officer of Pharaoh *and*
Captain of the guard in the land.

Genesis 38

1 It happened at that time and came
To pass that Judah, *praise and fame*,
Departed from his brothers, and
Visited Adullamite's land
Whose name's Hirah, Nobility.
2 And Judah while there chanced to see
The daughter of a Canaanite
Whose name *was* Shua, and he married
Her and went in to her. 3 She carried
And gave birth to a son, and he
Called his name Er, or Watchfully.
4 She conceived again and gave birth
To son named Onan, Strong on earth.
5 And she conceived yet again and
Gave birth to a son, called and planned,
By name of Shelah. He was at
Chezib when she gave birth to that.
6 Then Judah took a wife for Er
His firstborn, and her name's Tamar.
7 But Er, Judah's firstborn, did wickedly
Before YHWH, and YHWH killed him
quickly.

8 And Judah said to Onan, "Go
In to your brother's wife and so
Marry her, and raise up an heir
To your brother *who's not to spare*."
9 But Onan knew the heir would not
Be his, and so when he had got
In to his brother's wife, that he
Emitted on the ground, lest he
Should give an heir to his *dead* brother
Instead of for himself another.
10 And the thing which he did displeased
YHWH, so He also killed the *sleazed*.
11 Then Judah said to Tamar his
Daughter-in-law, "Remain, *that is*,

A widow by your father's throne
Until my son Shelah is grown."
For he said "Lest he also die
Like his brothers." So by and by
Tamar went home *to mourn and sigh*.

The levirate was once law and the custom,
Though time and weather have done much
to rust them.

It does not seem inheritance of wife
Was always joyous in the ancient life.
Your Word is where I flee, however, for
Another thing impressing me much more.
When a man is a wicked one, You blow
Him down with sudden death and at one
go.

The wicked now continue in their sport
Live with evil as witches live with wart.
Strike down, Beloved, the wicked one in
me.

If even promise does not set You free
To slay the wickedness, I take up arms
Against my self, take refuge in Your
charms.

12 In time Judah's wife, Shua's daughter,
Died, and Judah was comforted,
And went to Timnah to the slaughter,
Or rather sheering of the sheep,
He and that friend of his both did,
Hirah Adullamite, to peep.

13 And it was told Tamar, "Look, your
Father-in-law is going for
To shear his sheep at Timnah's *store*."

14 So she took off her widow's weeds,
Covered *herself* with veil, as needs,
And wrapped herself, and sat out in
An open place, *as though for sin*,
Which *was* on Timnah's road, for she
Saw that Shelah was grown, and she
Was not given to him as a wife.

15 When Judah saw her, *by his life*,
He thought she *was* a harlot, for
She'd covered up her face *and more*.

16 Then he turned to her by the way,
And said "Let me lie with you, say,"

For he did not know she *was* his
Daughter-in-law. So she said "Is
Your dowry to me up to price?"

17 And he said "I will send a nice
Young goat from the flock." So she said
"Will you give *me* a pledge for bed

Until you send *it*?" 18 Then he said
"What pledge shall I give you?" So she
Said "Your signet and cord let be,
And your staff that *is* in your hand."
Then he gave *them* to her *command*,
And went in to her, and she was
Pregnant by him *by all due laws*.

If Judah thought a temporary marriage
Then fit the bill in circumstance and
carriage,

Let him look to the matters of deceit
With which such confrontations are replete.
The issue of legality can bear
Its debates and discussions anywhere.
But on the dusty road and after feast
Of labour and of song, two men increased
Their lusty cogitations there together.
Such meetings always end in nasty
weather.

Guard, guard the chambers of the soul
unless

I should lose signet, cord, and staff and
dress.

Beloved, I turn to You instead of neighbour
When fleeces are all cut and I cease labour.

19 So she arose and went away,
And laid aside her veil and stay,
And put on weeds of widowhood.

20 And Judah sent her, as he should,
The young goat by the hand of his
Friend the Adullamite, that is,
To get *his* pledge back from her hand,
But he found no one in the land.

21 Then he asked the men of that place,
"Where is the harlot who *showed face*
Openly by the roadside here?"
And they said "No harlot was here."

22 So he returned to Judah and
Said "I cannot find in the land
Such a one, also, the men there
Said there was no harlot to spare."

23 Then Judah said "Well, let her take
Them for herself, lest for her sake
We be shamed, for I sent this goat
But you found of her not a mote."

24 And it came, about three months after,
Judah was told, *the thing was dafter*,
"Tamar your daughter-in-law has
Played the harlot, and further as
Is with child by her harlotry."

So Judah said "Bring her to me
 And let her be burned publicly!"
 25 When she *was* brought out, she sent to
 Her father-in-law, saying "You
 Say by which man I have conceived,
 His things are here to be believed."
 And she said "Please determine whose
 These *are*: the signet and cord, choose,
 And also staff." 26 Judah did see
 And recognize *them* and said "She
 Has been more righteous here than I,
 Because I did not give her by
 The right time to Shelah my son."
 And he took her no more for fun.

What Judah here admits, Beloved, as fault
 Is not his one arrangement for his salt,
 But that he did not give his son the dame
 Who waited for the child to gain his name.
 When Judah knew who was the father of
 The child of Tamar, he gave not a glove
 To repent of his lying with a harlot.
 He thought his contract binding with the
 starlet,
 And equal to a marriage. This gives cheer
 To two kinds of agreement: levirate
 And temporary marriage for career.
 Results of both speak for themselves and
 grate
 On human happiness if not on gall.
 Beloved, I'd rather wait here for Your call.

27 Now it came, at the time of birth,
 That indeed, twins *were* in her girth.
 28 And so it was, when she was giving
 Birth, that *the one* put out a *living*
 Hand, and the midwife took some red
 And bound it on his hand, and said
 "This is the one that came out first."
 29 Then it happened, *as at the worst*,
 He drew his hand back, that his brother
 Came out surprising all and other,
 And she said "How did you break through?
Therefore this breach be upon you!"
 And so his name was called Perez.
 30 After his brother, *without fez*,
 Came out with scarlet on his hand.
 And his name was Zerah *unplanned*.

What pagan connotations there may be
 In Perez, Breaking Out, there's more to see
 In Zerah, Rising Sun, no doubt allusion

To the red thread and the midwife's
 confusion.
 The story smacks of mythic rising of
 The sun from earth's dark womb to sail
 above
 The forest and the sea with streaming red.
 I flee to You, Beloved, from all that's said
 In loving confirmation of the world
 And deity of beauty when unfurled.
 I bow to neither sun nor to the light
 Of my illumination or my sight
 Awakened in remembrance, contemplation,
 Or whirling beneath stars and sun in
 station.

Genesis 39

1 Now Joseph had been taken down
 To Egypt. Potiphar, renown
 Officer of Pharaoh, captain
 Of the guard, and an Egyptian,
 Bought him from the Ishmaelites who
 Had taken him down there *in crew*.

O my Beloved, I look about for You,
 In haste I glance from face to face but few
 Regard my hopeless search, and no one
 cares.
 The king is known by regal clothes he
 wears.
 But You, Beloved, have neither form nor
 mask
 Nor even any whereabouts to ask.
 Without associates and without parts,
 One without limits known to human arts,
 How can I find You who is without where?
 From dungeon to king's gates I only dare,
 At last I find You standing to be bought,
 A slave in the slave market, You I sought.
 Beloved One, I should buy You in a trice,
 But I have not the silver of Your price.

2 YHWH was with Joseph, a success,
 In the house of Egyptian master.
 3 His master did not have to guess
 That YHWH *was* with him, but saw faster
 That YHWH made all he did succeed,
 All in his hand from flour to seed.
 4 So Joseph found grace in his sight,
 And served him. Then he gave him right
 To oversee his house, and all
 He put under his beck and call.
 5 So it was, from the time *that* he

Had made him overseer to be
 Head of his house and all he had,
 That YHWH blessed the Egyptian's pad
 For Joseph's sake, and YHWH's blessing
 Was on house and field impressing.
 6 Thus he left all he had in hand
 With Joseph, *and in his command*,
 He did not know what he had but
 The bread he ate *and in his gut*.
 Now Joseph was a handsome lad,
 Form and appearance not too bad.

Like David and Joseph, there are some men
 That all men love and turn and love again,
 While others, like Renoir, arouse suspicion.
 There's charismatic and the bleak edition.
 My sense of caution lacks conformity,
 And I suspect the brash and favour-free.
 But sometimes virtue is and virtue seems,
 And beauty goes beyond the skin and
 dreams.

Beloved, Your love of Joseph's not
 misplaced,
 Despite the trammels that his travels traced.
 I see Your Self peer through his harnessed
 trial,
 And stop to give the sweet young man a
 smile.
 I give You, my Beloved, my wealth's
 command
 And only know my pot of peas at hand.

7 It happened after these things that
 His master's wife cast her eyes at
 Joseph in longing, and she said
 "Lie with me *here upon the bed*."
 8 But he refused and told the wife
 Of his master, "Look *not for strife*,
 My master does not know what *is*
 With me in the house, and what's his
 He has committed to my hand.
 9 "There's no one greater in this band
 Than I, nor has he kept back any
 Thing from me, *not the slightest penny*,
 But you, because you *are* his wife.
 How then can I do this great rife
 And wicked thing, and sin against
 Alohim?" 10 So it was commenced,
 She spoke to Joseph day by day,
 That he did not heed her, nor lay
 With her *or* to be with her there.

Joseph, leader of slave rebellion, sought
 To make slaves master of their destiny,
 To make an honest day of labour wrought,
 And then refuse to part with chastity.
 Most slaves prefer the opposite, and rest
 Beneath the flogging foreman with the best,
 And then when chastity is thrown aground,
 Consider as slaves there's no freedom
 found

But due compliance. Joseph's was
 command
 And it was duty to obey in hand
 Mistress as well as master. Joseph's fate
 Was in that innovation that made great.
 There is a choice beyond determination
 For those determined to supply the station.

11 But it happened, *not to ensnare*,
 About this time, when Joseph went
 Into the house to do his work,
 And none of the men of the tent
 Were in the house, and to his irk,
 12 She caught him by his garment, saying
 "Lie with me now, *and don't be playing*."
 But he left his coat in her hand,
 And fled and ran out in the land.
 13 And so it was, when she saw that
 He had left his coat in her hand
 And fled outside *across the sand*,
 14 That she called to the men that sat
 In her house and spoke to them, saying
 "See, he has brought in here for staying
 With us, a Hebrew to mock us.
 He came to lie with me, a fuss
 I made about it with loud voice.
 15 "And so he heard, *and made his choice*,
 When I cried out aloud he left
 His garment with me, and was deft
 To flee and went outside." 16 So she
 Kept his coat with her until he
 Came home, his master did. 17 Then she
 Told him with words like these, and said
 "The Hebrew servant, *bought or bred*,
 Whom you brought to us came to me
 To mock me *and to lie with me*,
 18 "So it happened, I lifted my
 Voice and cried out, and that is why
 He left his coat with me and fled."

Beloved, the wife of Potiphar looked out
 On useless, idle days and without doubt

Wished that something might come to
 claim her own,
 Instead of merely being wife alone.
 She could buy everything she saw for sale,
 But nothing bought could dignify her tale.
 All saw her as the wife of Potiphar,
 While she would be in her own right a star.
 No wonder she was angry when her lust
 Was thwarted by a servant and whose trust
 Saw her as nothing more than master's
 wife.
 For God and angels, she'd have her own
 life.
 Beloved, all are such passionate paupers
 here
 Who are dissatisfied when they appear.

19 So when he heard what his wife said
 "Your servant did to me like this,"
 His master's anger went amiss.
 20 Then Joseph's master took and put him
 Into prison, and there he shut him
 In with the king's captives confined.
 And he was there in prison, *mind*.
 21 But YHWH was with Joseph and
 showed
 Him mercy, and gave him abode
 And grace before the prison's keeper.
 22 The prison keeper gave command
 Of all the prisoners in his hand,
 So Joseph did what was done there
 To all the captives *to be fair*.
 23 The prison keeper did not look
 Into a thing that *Joseph* took
 To do, because YHWH was with him,
 And YHWH made what he did right trim.

Genesis 40

1 It happened after these things *that*
 The butler and the baker sat
 In sentence from their lord the king
 Of Egypt for offensive thing.
 2 And Pharaoh was angry with his
 Two officers, butler, that is,
 And the chief baker. 3 So he put
 Them in custody *hand and foot*
 In the house of the guard's captain,
 In the prison Joseph was in.
 4 And the captain of the guard charged
 Joseph with them, and thus enlarged
 His service duties for a while,
 While those two sat in gaol for guile.

The situation is surrealistic:
 The perfect man, prophet and cabalistic
 Is set to serving criminals, some true
 And some manipulated there with rue.
 The task of Joseph is in part like mine.
 Beloved, You set all servants to divine
 Illusion from the True. Let me in this
 Great task and pure not turn my mind amiss
 To sigh and sorrow for accommodations
 And harsh dealing from those of other
 stations.

The master is not he who wields the whip
 But rather he who knows the ardent sip
 Of Your wine in its ecstasy of showing
 That You are one and that is worth the
 knowing.

5 Then both butler and baker of
 The king of Egypt, *push and shove*,
 Who *were* confined in prison there,
 Had a dream, both of them *his share*,
 Each man's dream in one night *and* each
 Man's dream with meaning out of reach.
 6 And Joseph came in to them in
 The morning and looked *with a grin*
 At them, and saw that they *were* sad.
 7 So he asked Pharaoh's officers
 Who *were* with him in custody
 Of his lord's house, saying and bade,
 "Why do you look, *as it occurs*
 So sad today?" 8 And they said *free*
 To him, "We each have had a dream,
 And *there's* no meaning, *it would seem*."
 So Joseph said to them, "Do not
 Interpretations fall the lot
 Of Alohim? Tell *them* to me."

I'm not cunning Joseph, Beloved, it seems.
 I would not dare to interpret one's dreams,
 Although I know a pair or three who do,
 Despite the fact they know some less than
 You
 Or I. Of course he had experience
 Of his own dreams and how his dreams
 made sense.
 No doubt his faith in dreams come true
 made it
 A tad more hopeful to make fortune fit.
 Without his dreams he might succumb to
 doubt
 That he would be a slave and not come out

Of either bondage or his prison. I,
Despite the many stories that go by,
And are I daresay true, dream's not my cup.
I'd rather be awake when I look up.

9 Then the chief butler told his dream
To Joseph, spoke to him, *made free*,
"Indeed, in my dream *was* a vine
Before me, 10 "and three branches *fine*,
It *was* as though it budded, then
Its blossoms shot forth, and then when
Its clusters brought forth ripe grapes, 11 "I
Had Pharaoh's cup *there* in my hand,
And took the grapes and *by command*
I pressed them in Pharaoh's demi,
And placed the cup in Pharaoh's hand."
12 And Joseph said to him, "This *is*
The meaning: three branches *are his*
Three days. 13 "Now within three days he,
Pharaoh *indeed* will *set you free*,
Lift up your head, restore your place,
And you will put Pharaoh's cup in
His hand as at the origin,
When you were his butler. 14 "But now,
Remember me *before his face*
When it is well with you, allow
Kindness to me and make mention
Of me to Pharaoh *once begun*,
And get me out of this house. 15 "For
Indeed I was stolen *and more*
And brought from the land of Hebrews,
And also I've done but my dues
Here that they should put me into
The dungeon *with the derring-do*."

A little lack of satisfaction shows
In Joseph's speech, he's not a flower that
grows

Without complaint as best it can and makes
Do with the acid or the base, and takes
The weather as it comes, without a word.
Despite the divine banquet that occurred
From day to day to turn the prison to
A heavenly palace, still the prophet's shoe
Seeks freedom from the bars. One thing is
true,
The body and the soul live not two lives,
But both receive the impulses and drives
That share the beauty of the world and
pain.

Awakened yet to Truth, the self knows gain
And how to make distinctions sun and rain.

16 When the chief baker saw the meaning
Was good, he said *and without keening*
To Joseph, "I also *dreamed* dream,
And there the three white baskets seem
To be upon my head. 17 "And in
The uppermost basket *for bin*
Were all kinds of baked goods *I made*
For Pharaoh, and the birds *that stayed*
Ate from the basket on my head."
18 So Joseph answered and he said
"This *is* the meaning: the three baskets
Are three days, (*might as well be caskets*).
19 "Within three days Pharaoh will lift
Off your head from you, *that's the drift*,
And hang you on a tree. The birds
Will eat your flesh from you *like curds*."

If I had to be prophet in this world,
I'd hate to be a true one and an earled.
The fate of prophets false must be the
better,
Despite the fact they often miss the letter.
A false prophet in this case could have
given
A good report to both and then been
shriven.

To get half right is good enough almost,
At least to keep alive if not to boast.
This bringing bad news never hits the spot,
And this time only made the baker's lot
Seem sadder than was needed since it
robbed
The man of three days' hope from being
cobbled.

Just wait, Beloved, and see if gratitude
For good news even makes the latitude.

20 It happened now on the third day,
Which was indeed Pharaoh's birthday,
He made a feast for all his men,
His servants, and he lifted then
The head of the chief butler and
Of the chief baker by command.
21 Then he restored the chief butler
Again to his butlership's lure,
To place the cup in Pharaoh's hand.
22 But he hanged the chief baker, as
Joseph had prophesied with snazz.
23 Yet the chief butler did not make
Remembrance of *poor Joseph's sake*,
But *just* forgot him *on the take*.

I too have been forgotten for the good
I've done, although that is as may and
should.

But like Joseph, I fail to make complaint.
Perhaps the evil is forgotten too,
And thus I'm neither criminal nor saint
For all the good and all the bad I do.
It's neither good nor bad that makes one's
fame

These days, but advertizing is to blame.
Because he had no website for his dreams
Joseph's release would have to wait, it
seems.

Beloved, let me dream on without Your
meaning,

And I shall just as quickly, without
screening,

Forget both dream and meaning and the
bars

That once stood between me and all the
stars.

Week 10 Genesis 41

1 It happened, at the end of two
Full years, that Pharaoh had a dream,
Behold, he stood along near to
The river. 2 At once out of stream
There came up seven cows, and fine
Looking and fat, and they would dine
Upon the meadow. 3 Then indeed,
Another seven cows stampede
After them from the flood, and they
Were thin and ugly in their way
And stood beside the other cows
Upon the river bank *to browse*.

4 The thin and ugly cows ate up
The seven good-looking for sup
And fat cows. So Pharaoh awoke.
5 He slept and dreamed a second stroke,
At once seven heads of grain grew out
On one stalk, plump and without doubt
Good. 6 Then indeed, seven thin and
blighted

Heads, blighted by the east wind *sighted*,
Sprang up after them. 7 And the thin,
Those seven thin heads devoured *in*
A brief space the seven plump and full.
So Pharaoh woke from fanciful
Dream. 8 Now it happened in the morning
That his spirit in him took warning,
And he sent and called for magicians

All of the wise men *and physicians*
Of Egypt. And Pharaoh told them
His dreams, but none found *stratagem*
To tell Pharaoh their theorem.

The Pharaoh's dreams sound like
nightmares to me,
But I wonder why such are held to be
Signs of the future or of meaningful
Content. I see dreams as acceptable
And brief insanity during one's sleep.
True many tribes think madnesses do keep
The inspirations of the gods. Perhaps
You use, Beloved, at times the pagan lapse
To further Your own will. All things work
for

Your purposes, the evil and what's more
The good that people do in pride. Lead me,
Beloved, in waking or in sleep, to be
A walker in Your will beside the stream
Of cows and corn for future and for dream.

9 Then the chief butler spoke to him,
To Pharaoh, saying "My faults *grim*
I now remember on this day.

10 "When Pharaoh's anger was in sway
Against his servants, he put me
In the guard's captain's custody,
In that house *both* chief baker and
Myself together, 11 "We each scanned
A dream in one night, he and I.
Each of us dreamed to prophesy.

12 "Now there *was* a young Hebrew man
With us there, servant of captain
Of the guard. And we told him, and
He told dreams' meanings on demand
For us, to each interpreted
According as his *own* dream led.
13 "And it happened, just as he said
So it happened. He restored me
To my office, corroborree
He hanged *for his long history*."

Now think of this, Beloved, when You give
doubt's

Benefits to the butler in his clouts.
He lies, I say, when he says he forgot
The service Joseph rendered when his lot
Was not so good. The men promoted do
Not wish to think of those who put them
there,
But wish to disremember favours due.

Note well he did remember fine and fair
As soon as he could raise his own position
Before the king with the improved
condition

Of his lost memory. Let me beware
Of officers official everywhere.
Beloved, promote Your sovereignty on
earth
As One alone, knowing officers' worth.

14 Then Pharaoh sent and called Joseph,
And they brought him quickly by clef
Out of the dungeon, and he shaved,
Changed his clothing, came well-behaved
To Pharaoh. 15 And the Pharaoh said
To Joseph, "I have had a dream,
And *there's* no one can tell its theme.
But I have heard it said of you
That you can understand what do
Those who interpret dreams, *those few*."
16 So Joseph answered Pharaoh, saying
"It is not in me, *no delaying*,
Alohim will give Pharaoh peace
In answer to his dream's *caprice*."

Now I suppose this means to shave both
head
And beard, Beloved, as pictures I have read
Upon the walls of the Egyptian tombs
Deep buried in the pyramidal glooms.
Is not shaving abomination and
Prohibited by Your divine command?
Shame, shame on Joseph for defiling act
Of cutting off his beard just to react
To what the king and court expect of him!
My picture of this action remains dim,
Unless, Beloved, externals in Your view
Are not so rampantly required to do.
Then why did You require removing shoe
When there was only Moses there and
You?

17 Then Pharaoh said to Joseph, "Lo,
Indeed, in dream I stood *to know*
On the bank of the river. 18 "So
Suddenly seven cows came up
Out of the river, fine for sup
And good looking and fat, and they
Fed in the meadow *by the way*.
19 "Then behold, seven other cows
Came up after them there to browse,
Poor, thin and ugly such as I

Have never seen in Egypt's lie.
20 "And the thin, ugly cows ate up
The first seven, fat cows *out to sup*.
21 "When they had eaten them up, no
One would have known they'd seen the
show,
For they *were* just as ugly as
At the beginning. So as has
Happened, then I awoke. 22 "Also
I saw in my dream, suddenly
Seven heads came up on one free
Stalk, full and good. 23 "And then indeed,
Seven heads, withered, thin, *and* blighted
By the east wind, followed *in seed*.
24 "And the thin heads devoured the good.
So I told magicians enlightened
To explain it, but no one could."

Perhaps the reason no doctor could say
What Pharaoh's dreams meant in the light
of day,
Despite their awful portent in the dark,
Was simply they were madness, madness
stark.
It's only You, Beloved, can touch insanity
And give it sense, and send cosmology,
Reflecting more the quirks of human mind
Than any truth or its reality,
To home and heart as if an arrow blind
Had hit the mark. Ah yes, the stony flint
Is always blind. The human heart has glint
Of truth not for blind reason nor instinct,
But because You, Beloved, in faith once
winked
And kings awoke, and prophets not extinct.

25 Then Joseph answered Pharaoh's
speech,
"The dreams of Pharaoh *are* one, *each*
Means just the same, Alohim's shown
Pharaoh what He's about to do:
26 "The seven good cows *are not alone*
Seven years, but seven good ears
Represent also seven years,
And so the dreams are one *and true*.
27 "And the seven thin, ugly cows
That came up after, *it allows*,
Are seven years, and so the ears
Empty and blighted by the east
Wind are also those seven years
Of famine *without bread or yeast*.
28 "This *is* the thing which I have spoken

To Pharaoh, *before he'd awoken*.
Alohim has shown Pharaoh what
He *is* about to do *in plot*.

29 "Indeed seven years of great plenty
Will come to all Egypt, *not twenty*.

30 "But after them seven years of
Famine will come, *but not above*,
And all the plenty'll be forgotten
In all Egypt for famine gotten.

31 "So the plenty will not be known
Because of what the famine's shown,
For it *will be* very severe.

32 "And the dream came twice to appear
Because Alohim's done the thing,
And it will soon come *on the king*.

Beloved, I have enjoyed the bounteous
plenty
Bestowed on me, that could have been for
twenty.

I've known the seven years of wealth and
food,

I've also seen about me famine's brood.
This world is made of light and dark but yet
In life and death there is one thing to get,
Which is the only thing that can be taken
By the soul that before death's shroud is
shaken,

And that is love of You, Beloved, set free
From reward and fear of calamity.
Let me love You despite the thick and thin,
Despite the peace or trouble that I'm in.
Let me not even seek Your love for me,
Since I am satisfied to love and be.

33 "Now therefore, let Pharaoh select
One wise and discrete to protect
And guide the land of Egypt through
The crisis. 34 "Now let Pharaoh do
This, and let him appoint men to
Collect one-fifth *of all* the land
Produces in the good years' stand.

35 "And let them gather all the food
Of those years coming that are good,
And store up corn in Pharaoh's hand,
And let them keep food in the land.

36 "Then that food shall be as reserve
When the seven years of famine serve
The land of Egypt, that the land
May not perish by famine's hand."

What did poor Joseph then imagine in

The land of Egypt without kith or kin?
That there were men discreet and wise to
find?

No, one cannot find anywhere that kind.
The men of Pharaoh were like butler able
Only to think of their own fame and table.
The statesman of today as well as priest
Is selfish every one from great to least.
There's none that would not steal the
coffers blind

And put away the corn in his own rind.
Let Africa burn foodless for the art
Of curing tobacco so those who fart
Tobacco smoke may do so at their ease.
Beloved, look down in judgement upon
these.

37 The thing was good in Pharaoh's eyes,
And in the eyes of all his men.

38 And Pharaoh said to them again,
"Can we find *such a man as wise*
As this, a man in whom *there lies*
Alohim's spirit's *regimen*?"

39 Then Pharaoh said to Joseph, "Since
Alohim has shown you the prints,
There's none discreet and wise as you.

40 "You shall be over my house too,
And all my people shall be ruled
By your word, but not to be fooled
Only I in the throne shall be
Greater than you *in majesty*."

41 And Pharaoh said to Joseph, "See,
Now I have set you over all
The land of Egypt *gate and wall*."

Imagine, my Beloved, Joseph's surprise
To be instated ruler before eyes
Of all the Pharaoh's men as well as wives.
The wives knew all the stories and
contrives.

The rub is to be faithful despite all
The gold and power that have a siren call.
Joseph was able to preserve his soul
And keep his body chastely in control
When he was forced it seemed to do as
slave

As his mistress commanded to behave.
Can he now do the same again when faced
Not with compulsion but with honour
placed

On those who fail to cherish purity?
Beloved, be his and mine for surety.

42 Then Pharaoh took his signet ring
 Off his hand and put it upon
 Joseph's hand, his apparelling
 Was fine linen in which to don,
 And *Pharaoh* put a gold chain round
 His neck. 43 And he had him ride in
 The second chariot *from his inn*,
 And as he rides before him sound
 The cry to "Bow the knee!" So he
 Set him to rule all he could see.
 44 And Pharaoh said to Joseph, "I
Am Pharaoh, and without your hie
 No man may lift his hand or foot
 In all the land of Egypt put."

The word is power, Joseph was given
 power,
 The worst thing a man can have for an
 hour,
 Much less for days and years. Beloved, the
 test
 So far shows Joseph among men the best.
 And yet the righteous prophet wears the
 gold
 The king has given him, is virtue sold?
 The Muslim law contends man shall not
 wear
 Gold, only women have that right and fair.
 By Joseph's lone example gold can be
 Worn by a man and that man yet go free.
 Traditions of men it is known and well
 Conflict with divine revelation's spell.
 Yet giving value to gold comes too close
 To idol worship for both sexes' dose.

45 And Pharaoh called Joseph's *new* name
Zaphnath-Paaneah, for fame
As revealer of secrets came.
 And he gave him as wife *one named*
Asenath, daughter of *the famed*
Poti-Pherah the priest of On.
 So Joseph went out *all alone*
To rule beside Egyptian's throne.
 46 Joseph was thirty years old when
 He stood before Pharaoh king's men,
 The king of Egypt. Joseph went
 Out from Pharaoh's presence and sent
 Throughout all the Egyptians' land.
 47 Now in the seven years of grand
 Production the ground brought forth well.
 48 So he gathered all *he could tell*

Of the food of the seven years which
 Were in the land of Egypt rich,
 And laid up the food in the cities,
 He laid up in every city
 Food of the field *and committee*
 Which was around *without bandittis*.
 49 Joseph gathered very much corn,
 As the sand of the sea, *no bourn*,
 Until he stopped its counting, for
It was immeasurable and more.

The daughter of a priest of Egypt was
 The mother of two tribes of chosen claws.
 Monolatry is something Abraham
 Himself regarded as the great I AM.
 What differences lay in worship here
 Is something that does not quite well
 appear.
 Did Joseph make concessions to the art
 Of heathen worship to play well his part?
 You do not tell me so, Beloved, so doubt
 Is not the better side of in and out.
 In any case no heathen god could stop
 His gathering of corn for store and shop.
 He gathered more than numbers in the
 speech
 Of Egypt for corn, cane and plum and
 peach.

50 And to Joseph were born two sons
 Before the years of famine came,
 Whom Asenath, *for benisons*,
 Daughter of Poti-Pherah, same
 As priest of On, bore to his *claim*.
 51 Joseph called the name of the first
 Born Manasseh: "For *as I durst*
Alohim has made me forget
 All my toil and my father's home."
Thus Manasseh meant God would let
Him forget how he had to roam.
 52 And the name of the second he
 Called Ephraim, *which means to be*
Doubly fruitful: "For *Alohim*
 Has caused me to be *and to seem*
 Fruitful in the land of distress."
 53 The seven full years that did bless
 The land of Egypt ended, 54 and
 The seven famine years' command
 Began to come, as Joseph said.
 The famine was in all lands spread,
 But in all Egypt there was bread.
 55 So when all the land of Egypt

Was famished, people were equipped
 To cry to Pharaoh for their bread.
 Then Pharaoh said to all the folk,
 "Go to Joseph, and what he spoke
 Do." 56 The famine was over all
 The face of the earth *in its thrall*,
 And Joseph opened all the stores
 Sold to Egyptians *at the doors*.
 And the famine became severe
 In the land of Egypt *for fear*.
 57 So all the countries came to buy
 From Joseph in Egypt, the cry
 Of famine was loud and severe
 In all the lands *it did appear*.

It may have seemed creative policy
 To gather corn as tax when corn was free,
 And then to sell it back to citizen
 At a good price for every specimen.
 But that was recipe for social mire
 Before the people would at last retire.
 Creating slavery could aye backfire,
 And no doubt helped to cause the problems
 with
 The people who arose in later myth.
 The famine made the state monopole
 And turned free men to slaves' commodity
 That they might eat what they themselves
 had grown.
 Here Joseph is not innocent alone,
 But civil servant's heart cuts his in stone.

Genesis 42

1 When Jacob saw that there was corn
 In Egypt, Jacob said to warn
 His sons, "Why do you look at one
 Another?" 2 And he said "Indeed
 I've heard that there's grain *by the ton*
 In Egypt, go down there *for seed*
 And buy for us there what we need
 That we may live and not undone."
 3 So Joseph's ten brothers went down
 To buy corn in Egyptian town.
 4 But Jacob did not send the brother
 Of Joseph, that is, Benjamin
 With his brothers, for he said rather,
 "Lest some calamity *or other*
 Befall him *by men or by jinn*."
 5 And Israel's sons went down to buy
 Among those travelling *for the rye*,
 For famine was in Canaan's land.
 6 Joseph was ruler of the land,

And it was he who sold to all
 The people of the land withal.
 And Joseph's brothers came and bowed
 To him with face to earth *allowed*.

Divine example of the prophet lets
 Me know it's right clever to hedge one's
 bets
 And buy from even heathen hand the
 needful
 If but in all it is no more than seed full.
 Thus heathen lands also have role to play,
 And not always for war to win the day.
 Commerce is better far than staking out
 With armaments and with attacking shout.
 The only problem is as things go now,
 There's not enough of profits in the cow
 And corn, nor even in the rowdy oil.
 There's just not wealth enough in honest
 toil.

We need to sell fear now, Beloved, whereas
 The stomach has a bottom, no fear has.

7 Joseph saw his brothers and knew them
 But acted as a stranger to them
 And spoke roughly to them and said
 "Where do you come from *seeking bread*?"
 And they said "We're from Canaan's land
 Come to buy food *at Dad's command*."
 8 So Joseph knew his brothers, but
 They did not know him *from the pot*.
 9 Joseph remembered then the dreams
 Which he had dreamed about their
 schemes,

And said to them "You spies have come
 To see the land's nakedness *numb*!"

10 And they said to him, "No, my lord,
 But your servants come *not with sword*
But in peace for to buy us food.

11 "We are all one man's sons, *not rude*
 But honest, your servants are not
 Spies, *nor have we been by spies taught*."

12 But he said to them, "No, but you
 Came to see the land's nakedness."

13 And they said "Now what can we do,
 Your servants are brothers *not less*
Than twelve, the sons of one man in
 The land of Canaan, and akin,
 In fact, the youngest is today
 With our father, and one's away."

Ah, truth be told, Beloved, indeed, it's so

That one's away. The brothers do not show
The dastardly way they dealt with the one,
Oh no, they did not tell the thing they'd
done.

Beloved, let me live so the truth I tell
Has nothing in it of the hidden spell.
There is enough of accusation in
The naked land for unacknowledged sin.
For gain or hidden motives everywhere
Men make threats on the livelihood and
bare

Lives of others whose fortune brings them
to
Their thrones in some petition for their
meat.

I pray my own petitions be to You,
Beloved, alone where we two only meet.

14 But Joseph said to them, "*It is*
As I have said '*You're spies of his!*'

15 "*In this manner* you shall be tested:
By Pharaoh's life, you'll not be vested
To leave this place unless your brother,
The youngest comes here from the other.

16 "Send one of you, and let him bring
Your brother, and the rest shall sing
In prison, that your words may be
Tested if there is truth to see
In you, or else, by Pharaoh's life,
You surely *are spies out for strife!*"

17 So he put them together all
In prison three days. 18 Joseph's call
Came to them the third day, "Do this
And live, *for* I fear Alohim:

19 "If you're honest, let one remiss
Of your brothers confined redeem
In prison, but the rest go carry
Corn for famine home *and be merry.*

20 "And bring your youngest brother here
To me, so your words will appear
To be true, and you shall not die."
And they did so *and wondered why.*

When Joseph's memory turned to dreams of
youth,

He turned events to make the second truth
As well. His brothers bowed already, now
The sun and moon must be summoned to
bow:

Small vengeance that for thirteen years a
slave

And hardly hope of else before the grave.

The one most guilty stays in prison so
The brothers watching the results can know
That God's hand reaches out in punishment
For what they did to Joseph, where they
sent.

Joseph does with his power no evil thing,
Though he is second only to the king.
Beloved, give me but half integrity
That Joseph has for his felicity.

21 Then they told one another, "*We*
Are truly guilty for the fee
Of our brother, for we saw how
Anguish of soul had marked his brow
When he pleaded with us, and we
Would not hear, therefore this distress
Has come on us for wickedness."

22 And Reuben answered them, and said
"Did I not speak to you instead,
Saying 'Don't sin against the boy',
And you would not listen *ahoy?*
Therefore indeed, his blood is now
Required of us, *I do avow.*"

23 But they did not know Joseph heard
And understood *them, every word,*
For he spoke with interpreter.

24 And he turned away where they were
And wept. Then he came back again
Once more to confer with the men.

And he took Simeon and bound
Him while they watched him all around.

25 Then Joseph gave command to fill
Their sacks with corn, *and not to spill*
But to restore each man his coin,
And give provisions for the way.

And so he did. 26 They came to join
Together, load their donkeys grey
With corn, departed on their way.

27 But as one *of them* opened sack
To give his donkey feed *or snack*
At the encampment, he saw money
In the sack's mouth, *which was not funny.*

28 So he said to his brothers, "My
Money's restored, and see it lie
There in my sack!" Then their hearts failed
Them and they were afraid *and paled,*
Saying to one another, "What
Does Alohim against us plot?"

Joseph was moved by one thing only here:
His brothers still remembered all his fear
And anguish when they lifted him to sell

To the traders from out of the dry well.
He turns to weep, not for the grown men's
part,

Nor for the years passed by nor for the start
Of a new life with all its pleasant hopes,
But for the laddy whose grimy hand gropes
A tear-streaked face, for this the ruler turns
And feels the knotty throat and eye that
burns.

Joseph was moved his brothers knew regret
For what they did to him that day, and yet
He did not know how soon regret had
come.

More tears, Beloved, would have made up
the sum.

29 Then they went to Jacob their father
In Canaan's land and told the bother
That happened to them, saying that
30 "The man *who's* lord of the land *sat*
And spoke roughly, and took us for
Spies of the country, *what is more*.

31 "But we told him 'We're honest, we
Are not spies *come to your country*.

32 'We *are* twelve brothers, sons of one
Father, one's not, the youngest *son*
Is with our father this day in
The land of Canaan, *genuine*.'

33 "Then the man, ruler of the land,
Told us 'By this I'll understand
That you *are* honest *men*: Leave one
Of your brothers with me *to shun*,
Take *food* for the famine of your
Households, and be gone *to your land*.

34 'And bring your youngest brother for
Me to see, so I'll know *your hand*
That you're not spies, but honest men,
And I'll release your brother then
And you may trade here in the land.'"

35 It happened when they emptied sacks,
Surprise, each one's money in stacks
Was in his sack, and when they saw
The money they were struck with *awe*
And fear, both the father and son,
For what had happened and begun.

36 And Jacob their father told them,
"You have bereaved me: Joseph's not,
And Simeon's gone, and now you're lost
To take off Benjamin. All these
Things are against me *and my ease*."

37 Then Reuben told his father, saying
"Kill my two sons *and for my slaying*

If I do not bring *back* to you,
But put him in my hands, for true
I shall bring him back to you, do."

38 But he said "My son shall not go
Down with you, for what's left *to show*,
Since his brother is dead, and he
Is left alone *of his family*.

If anything befell him on
The way in which you go upon,
Then you would bring down my grey hair
With sorrow to the grave, *beware*."

I somehow don't think Reuben's plan to kill
A grandchild was the thing to change the
will

Of Jacob. Human plans often are start,
Despite their wisdom and their plotful art,
Of new catastrophes. Sometimes I shrink,
Beloved, standing one day in seven to think
That task and journey would be better far
Than six in seven to fight and follow star.
Six Sabbaths ought to keep the human late
For doing all the things he thinks are great.
But such suggestion as Reuben's may be
Just about par for every human tee.
The loving You, is better far than doing
And planning for and making out the
stewing.

Genesis 43

1 Now the land's famine *hit* severely.
2 And it happened, they'd eaten nearly
All the corn that they had bought from
Egypt, their father told them "Come,
Go back, buy us a little food."
3 But Judah said "*I shan't be rude*,
But the man warned us solemnly,
Saying 'You *surely* shall not see
My face unless your brother *comes*.'"
4 "If you send our brother with us,
We will go down and buy up *drums*
Of food and *never make a fuss*.
5 "But if you will not send *him*, we
Will not go down, for the man, *see*,
Said to us, 'You shall not see my
Face unless your brother *comes by*.'"
6 And Israel said "Why did you deal
So wrongfully with me *to steal*
A march and tell the man you had
Still *one more* brother? *That was bad*."
7 But they said "He asked us right out
About ourselves and family's *scout*,

Saying 'Is your father alive?
Does your *one* brother still *survive*?'
And we told him the things he asked.
Could we have known that he had masked
His question to say, 'Bring him down'?"

Hindsight is always best for what is said,
And I'd be rather quiet than well-bred,
For any talk can come back in one's sleep
And turn to accusation and make weep.
Instead I find I am verbose, verbose,
I chatter on to You in greater dose,
Beloved, than You perhaps care to lend ear,
And if I'm asked a question, I take cheer
In answering at length and oft in rhyme.
Like Israel's sons, as soon as ruler speaks
And asks me this or that, my loose tongue
seeks
To inform power of all its jackass notions.
Even a sonnet does not give me time
Enough to say my peace. I need more
oceans.

8 Then Judah told Israel his father,
"Send the lad with me, *do not bother*,
And we will get up, *do not frown*,
And go, that we may live, not die,
We, you *and* our children forebey.

9 "I myself will be surety
For him, and from my hand shall be
Requirement of him, if I do
Not bring the laddie back to you
And set him here before you, let
Me bear the blame forever yet.

10 "For if we had not lingered, sure
It is by now we'd be secure
And all returned this second time
Instead of waiting for the rhyme."

Now Judah's argument is better far
Than Reuben's was, to kill a child and star,
If he did not bring Benjamin back home
From the Nile waters and its fertile loam.
Judah quite simply offers to bear blame
If what he does turns out to be his shame.
His second argument carries more weight,
As always does: hurry, or we'll be late.
I lay aside my reticence and rush
To You, Beloved, and in the morning hush
Remember Your sweet names with heart
and tongue
As I climb the new daylight rung by rung,

And think that once I too beside the Nile
Sought Your sweet comforts on its banks a
while.

11 And Israel their father told them,
"If *it must be*, then stratagem
Provide, and take some of the best
Fruits of the land *and then go west*
With vessels and carry down gifts
For the man, a little balm lifts
The spirits and a little honey,
Spices and myrrh, *beside the money*,
Pistachios and almonds too.

12 "And take double money with you
And take back in your hand the coin
That was returned *and so rejoin*
What was in the mouth of your sacks,
Perhaps an oversight's the knacks.
13 "Take your brother also, and get
Up, go back to the man. 14 "And yet
May El El God Almighty give
You *grace and* mercy relative
To the man, that he may release
Your other brother and *in peace*
Benjamin too. If I'm bereaved,
Then *let it be* I am bereaved!"

I sit with one beneath pistachio trees
And look toward the River Euphrates,
And wonder that Jacob had gifts to send.
Sometimes pistachio harvest is a blend
Of work and sorrows to no fruitful end.
The barley harvest is a surer thing
With coloured clothing spread like
coloured wing
Across the green of fields. But Jacob's ring
Of famine left a treasure or two for
The ruler of Egypt he might implore
For barley and for bread. Gift for reprieved
In hand, Jacob lives on hopes though
bereaved.

I come, Beloved, to You almonds in hand,
Pistachios and apricots and sand.

15 So the men took that present and
Benjamin, and took *by command*
Double the money in their hand,
And rose and went down to *the land*
Of Egypt, and they stood before
Joseph. 16 When Joseph saw before
Him Benjamin with them, he said
To the steward of his house, "Take

These men to my home *to eat bread*,
 And slay, make ready for their sake,
 For *these* men dine with me at noon."
 17 Then the man did as Joseph bade,
 And the man brought the men *in soon*
 To Joseph's house. 18 They were afraid
 Because they were *all* brought into
 Joseph's house, and they said "*It's true*
 Because of the money, which was
 Returned in our sacks the first time,
 That we are brought in, so he does
 Make case against us *for the crime*
 To fall upon us, take us as
 Slaves with our donkeys *for the razz*."

The sons of Israel were right he had
 Secret intentions that could have been bad.
 Unusual it is such secrets are
 The roots of something pleasant in the far
 Off future or the near. The summons clear
 Before a ruler is an omen's fear.
 I'd just as soon not be invited to
 A senator's house party or shindo.
 Take me, Beloved, as slave if that's Your
 will,
 And I shall bow to fortune and be still.
 Take me to serve angels and men and yet
 I shall be grateful for the crumbs I get.
 But save, I pray, the freedom of my donkey
 From hunger, servitude, and honkey-
 tonkey.

19 When they drew near to the steward
 Of Joseph's house, they had a word
 With him at the door of the gate,
 20 And said "O sir, we did come late
 The first time to buy food, 21 "but it
 Happened, when we came with outfit
 To the encampment, that we saw
 Each man's money was in the maw
 Of each man's sack, our money in
 Full weight, so we have brought, *no sin*,
 The money back in hand. 22 "And we
 Have brought down other money, *see*,
 In our hands to buy food, we do
 Not know who gave our money back
 Nor yet do we know at all who
 Put that money into each sack."

I shyly stand before Your gates and tell
 The porter that I got back too much change.
 I gave in payment waking from the spell

Of sleep and got back range on dawn-felt
 range
 Of crimson sunrise painted without flame
 On snows each morning never in the same
 And never changing glories. Now I bring
 Back to You what I got winter and spring.
 I gave in payment breath and strutting on
 The street and got back perfumes noon and
 dawn
 Of bird cherries in bloom and sweet peas
 too,
 I got too much change for what I gave You.
 So I bring back the money in my sack,
 Beloved, can I somehow make up the lack?

23 But he told them, "Peace *be* with you,
 Do not fear, your God and the God
 Of your father has given *sod*
 And treasure in your sacks, I had
 Your money, *so fear nothing sad*."
 Then he brought Simeon out to them.
 24 So the man brought the men into
 Joseph's house and gave *them their due*
 In water, and they washed their feet,
 And gave their donkeys feed *and treat*.
 25 Then they made the gift ready for
 Joseph's coming back at noon, for
 They heard that they would eat bread there,
And so they waited for their share.

Beloved, I shall eat in Your house today,
 In palaces beyond the cold and grey
 That is the fashion now the gold is kept
 Hidden beneath the ground and in well-
 swept
 Steel rooms instead of out for faith and
 show
 To make the multitudes know that kings
 glow.
 Beloved, I shall eat in Your house today,
 In palaces of living fir that sway
 Above the pines and towering on the birch,
 In halls carpeted better than a church
 With dandelions and plantain and the must
 Of chickweed in the damp, and in the dust
 Brambles and nettles with their blooms in
 white.
 Beloved, today I shall eat in Your light.

26 And when Joseph came home, they
 brought
 Him the gift in their hand, and got

Into the house, and bowed down to Him to the earth. 27 Then he asked "Do You well, and is your father well The old man that you spoke a spell About, is he alive now still?" 28 And they replied, "*Do not take ill*, Your servant our father's in good Health, still alive as he *well should*." And they all bowed their heads again Down and prostrated, all the men. 29 Then he lifted his eyes and saw His brother Benjamin *with awe*, His mother's son, and said "*Is this Your younger brother not remiss Of whom you spoke to me?*" And he Said then, "Gracious Alohim be To you, my son." 30 Now his heart yearned For his brother, *as Joseph learned* So Joseph made haste and sought *where* To weep, and found his chamber there And wept. 31 And then he washed his face And came out *once more to the place*, And he restrained himself, and said To the servants, "Now serve the bread."

Though my heart yearns for You, I rarely weep.
Perhaps that is because You do not keep
Out of my presence for dozens of years,
And do not leave me alone in my fears.
Though I do not see You, Beloved, I know
Your tracks about the garden in the snow
That look exactly like a rabbit's, but
I'm not fooled with the which and why and
what.
Though I do not hear You, Beloved, I hear
The echoes of Your passing at the ear,
And see a swallow whisk the sounds away,
A swallow behind which You hid today.
Though my heart yearns for You, and it
yearns still,
I know that You are closer than my will.

32 So they set him a place apart
From the brothers because the mart
And custom mores did not allow
Egyptians to eat with such now
As Hebrews were, for that would be
For Egyptians abominably.
33 And they sat before him, the first
Born by his birthright to the worst
According to his youth, while they

Looked with surprise at each one's stay.
34 Then he took servings to them from
Before him, but Benjamin's sum
Was five times more than any other.
So they drank merry with their brother.

Three bones I have to pick, Beloved, with
You.

The first is what Egyptian people do
In eating separately from those that keep
Their herds of goats and those that follow
sheep.

No man is an abomination but
Contains I-reflection of divine what.
The second thing is that Joseph gave more
To Benjamin in food and in his store.
Democracy requires equality
In eating as well as in being free.
And finally I take exception to
The drinking if it's alcohol You do.
Besides these things for issues there're no
others.

Drink on then and be merry with Your
brothers.

Genesis 44

1 And he commanded the steward
Of his house, saying "Fill *ill-starred*
The men's sacks with food, as much as
They can carry, and put what has
Each man in money in the mouth
Of his sack. 2 "Also put *for drouth*
My cup, the silver cup, into
The youngest's sack's mouth and his due
Of money for the corn." So he
Did according to the word he,
Joseph had spoken. 3 As soon as
The morning dawned, the men whereas
Were sent away, their donkeys too.
4 When they had gone out of the *view*
And city, and were not yet far
Off, Joseph said to his steward,
"Get up, follow the men, and when
You overtake them, tell the men,
'Why have you repaid evil for
Good?' 5 '*Is not this the one in store*
From which my lord drinks, and with
which
He indeed divines? What a *stitch*
Of evil you've done doing so.'" *So the steward set out to go.*

The plot of Joseph was well tried and true,
Beloved, but what the steward had to do
Was evil, since he did not know the case.
It's civil servants always blast the race,
And not the wicked tyrants on the throne.
It's not the president, but customs crone
That blights the world with rot and tyranny.
Not from the kings but servants set us free.
Blame not the servant, o my soul, for he
Better than Moses obeys Enoch's fee,
Ready to drown a boy before denying
The command of his master in the lying.
The inward and the outward meaning tries
Each soul and lays the choice before its
eyes.

6 And he overtook them, and he
Spoke to them these same words *and free*.
7 And they said to him, "Why does my
Lord say these words? Be it not nigh
To us that your servants should do
Such thing. 8 "Look, we brought back to
you
From land of Canaan the money
Which we found in our sacks' mouths free.
How then could we steal silver, gold
From your lord's house? 9 "*Now then be
bold,*
With whomsoever it is found,
Let him die, and we shall be bound
As my lord's slaves." 10 And he said "Now
Also *let it be* just done how
You have spoken, he with whom it
Is found shall be my slave befit,
And you shall all be blameless then."

The innocent call down the curse of heaven
Upon their own heads, knowing not the
leaven
Of spite the palace dweller has in store
To crush the innocent by plot and gore.
The wily judge knows how to treat the
words
Of innocent ones caught among the turds
Of intrigue, and to make himself seem just
While trampling hungry poor into the dust.
I've learned I hope the lesson what to do,
When questioned by authorities, be true
To truth and self best by a silent tongue,
Not knowing vested interests, to be hung.
Let me live so, Beloved, that no blame can
Be cast on me, then sealed lips are the plan.

11 So each man quickly let down his
Sack to the ground, and *as it is*
Each opened his sack. 12 So he searched.
He started with the oldest *perched*
And left off with the youngest, and
The cup was in Benjamin's sack.

The silver cup is always in the store
Of innocence. The evidence is more
In pointing to deceiver plot to frame.
The condemned are more often not to
blame.

Yet wheels turn on and the protected now
Tomorrow fall before the biting plough.
The silver plaited on the palm turns black
And buys no more the pleasures nor the
slack.

Slight comfort this to thousands in their
need
Who see with horror silver in the seed.
Though justice comes tomorrow, then it's
late,

And those today have time to meet their
fate.

Perhaps tomorrow some souls will gain
time

Because a felon toppled paid his crime.

13 They tore their clothes, and then went
back

With donkeys loaded to the city,
To see the man and beg for pity.

14 So Judah and his brothers came
To Joseph's house, and he *was game*,
Still there, and they fell before him
On the ground, *since the dream was dim*.

15 And Joseph said to them, "What deed
Is this you have done to succeed?
Did you not know that such a man
As I can divine, surely can?"

The touching thing about these men of old
Is that they never let donkeys go cold,
But in their direst hour remember beast
And tenderly see to their needs at least,
While Joseph pretends to divine, not guess,
The future by his powers of no and yes.
Even the good and fair sometimes for gain
Confirm the superstitions of the vain,
And let them fear eternal punishment,

Because they have no eyes and ears are
spent.
Be wise, my soul, and do not speak
contrary
To popes who have both power and truth to
parry.

There is no winning calling balls and
strikes.
Beloved, I give up limousines for bikes.

16 Then Judah said "What shall we say
To my lord? What shall we speak, say?
Or how shall we clear ourselves here?
Alohim has made to appear
Iniquity of your servants,
Here we are, my lord's *recompense*,
Slaves all, both we and *he* also
With whom the cup was found *to go*."

The wisdom of Judah is great I see.
When framed and damned he still sees
regency
Of divine providence. Though innocent,
He knows You guide the outcome with
consent.
He shows more patience before his
sentence
Than Joseph was when in his innocence
He entered prison to serve there as seer
Of secrets for the convicts that came near.
Judah does not know what Your plan may
be,
But firmly stands prepared for jeopardy.
I do not ask for courage in the face
Of such trials here that Judah had to face,
Nor for his patience in the face of wrong.
I only ask, Beloved, You lead my song.

17 But he said "Far be it from me
That I should do so *to the free*,
The man in whose hand the cup was
Shall be my slave, *and that's as does*.
And as for you, go up in peace
To your father *in full release*."

Now Joseph gives his brothers their good
chance
To sell once more a brother, song and
dance,
Into Egypt and into slavery.
They did it once for spite, now to be free

They come once more before the same
temptation.
It's praise, Beloved, to You to find what's
hard

One time that saw my feet slip on the
shard,

Come round again and passes with elation,
Without an effort or a condemnation.
Let's see if Joseph's brothers pass the bill.
I have a sneaking feeling that they will.
The road to heaven on earth is round and
round

Upon the scintillating slaughter ground,
There You by sacrificial sparks are found.

Week 11

18 Then Judah came near to him and
Said "O my lord, please *lend a hand*
And let your servant speak a word
In my lord's hearing, and not stirred
To anger against your servant,
For you are Pharaoh's *adjutant*.

19 "My lord asked his servants, saying
'Have you father or brotherling?'

20 "And we said to my lord, 'Indeed,
We have father, old man agreed,
And a child of *his* old age, *who*
Is young, his brother is dead too,
And he alone is left of his
Mother's children, and indeed his
Father loves him.' 21 "And then you said
To your servants, 'Bring him down led
To me, that I may set my eyes
On him.' 22 "And we gave our replies
To my lord, 'The lad cannot leave
His father, for *if* he should leave
His father, *his father* would die.'

23 "But you said to your servants, 'Fie,
Unless your youngest brother comes
Down with you, you shall not *for plums*
See my face any more.' 24 "So it

Was, when we went up there *to sit*
With your servant my father, that
We told him my lord's words *out flat*.
25 "And our father said 'Go back *and*
Buy some food for our little *band*.'

26 "But we said 'We cannot go down,
If our youngest brother *in gown*
Is with us, then we will go down,
For we may not see the man's face
Except our youngest's in the place.'

27 "Then your servant my father said

To us, 'You know my wife had bred
 And borne me two sons, 28 'and the one
 Went out from me, and then I said
 "Surely he's torn to pieces, done,"
 And I have not seen since that son.
 29 'But if you take this one from me
 Also, and some calamity
 Befalls him, you shall bring down my
 Grey hair with sorrow *under sky*
 And to the grave.' 30 "Now therefore, when
 I come to your servant my father,
 And the lad *is* not with the men,
 Since his life is bound up the rather
 In the lad's life, 31 "it will happen,
 When he sees lad's not with the men,
 That he will die. So your servants
 Will bring down the grey hair's *expense*
 Of your servant our father by
 Sorrow to the grave *under sky*.
 32 "For your servant became surety
 For the lad to my father free,
 Saying 'If I do not bring him
Back to you, then I shall *be dim*
 To bear the blame before my father
 Forever *and to carry bother*.'
 33 "Now therefore, please let your servant
 Remain as lad's executant,
 As a slave to my lord, and let
 The lad go up *on donkey set*
 With his brothers. 34 "For how shall I
 Go up to my father *the by*
 If the lad *is* not with me, lest
 Perhaps I see the evil pest
 That would come on my father's *chest*?"

I put a sonnet here perversely set,
 While reader waits results with bated
 breath,
 And hangman stops with judge to make a
 bet,
 And the whole courtroom's silent as the
 death
 To see what Joseph's hand's about to do.
 My sonnet is in praise of Judah's speech
 That shines with love to father and to each
 Brother and brother's child within his reach.
 Judah, the harlot monger's become new.
 I praise You, my Beloved, for what men
 do,
 Who go beyond the human hope and shape
 To act a divine play in this landscape.

May every man and woman have Your
 grace
 To live and love in Judah's trysting place.

Genesis 45

1 Joseph could not restrain himself
 Before those who stood by like delf
 And he cried out, "Let all go out
 From me!" So no one stood about
 With him while Joseph made himself
 Known to his brothers. 2 And he wept
 Aloud, Egyptians *there that kept*
His house and Pharaoh's house heard it.
 3 Then Joseph told his brothers *fit*,
 "I'm Joseph, does my father live?"
 But his brothers could hardly give
 Him answer, for they were dismayed
 In his presence. 4 And Joseph said
 To his brothers, "Come near to me."
 So they came near him, and then he
 Said "I'm Joseph your brother, whom
 You sold into Egypt *for doom*.
 5 "But now, do not therefore be grieved
 Or angry with yourselves *deceived*
 Because you sold me, Alohim
 Sent me before you, *it would seem*,
 To preserve life. 6 "For these two years
 The famine *has been to our fears*
 In the land, and *there are* still five
 Years in which *there will* neither *thrive*
 The plough nor harvest. 7 "Alohim
 Sent me before you to redeem
 Posterity for you on earth,
 And save your lives *for their great worth*.

The question is whether one is indeed
 Accountable for sowing seed of weed.
 The fact that You are all goodness and do
 Eventually make every falsehood true
 Does not change hate, does not change
 wrong intention
 To something better than evil's prevention.
 Truly the heart repents when veil is lifted
 And in Your sight the empty soul is gifted.
 Time when condensed by truth releases all
 Its secrets to the shimmery anthem's call,
 And sight cannot be held to blame for what
 Blindness crushed in the dayward garden
 plot.
 Beloved, I come before You in dismay
 To find You on the throne instead of stray.

8 "So now *it was* not you *who* sent
Me here, but Alohim, who went
And made me father [counsellor] to
Pharaoh,

And lord of all his house *to grow*,
And ruler throughout Egypt's land,
And all do just what I command.

9 "Make haste and go up to my father,
And say to him *and make no bother*,
'Says your son Joseph, "Alohim
Has made me lord of Egypt's *stream*,
Come down to me, and do not tarry.

10 "You shall live in Goshen's land *merry*,
And you shall be near me, you and
Your children, children's children, and
Your flocks and herds, all *in the land*.

11 "There I will provide for you, lest
You and your household, all your *best*,
Come into poverty, for *there*
Are still five years of famine's *care*."

If Joseph is the father of Pharaoh
At under forty years, my mind is slow
To take in when he sired the king, as slave
Or as a prisoner above the grave.
The fact is Pharaoh probably was older
Than Joseph or, if not, not young enough
To be his son. That makes me therefore
bolder

To say that son of God and God as tough
And father is not something to be made
A point of dogma since it suits no staid
And common speech. Beloved, be father to
Me as Joseph gave council what kings do,
And be my king as Pharaoh remained still
To father Joseph who lived by his will.

12 "And indeed, your eyes and the eyes
Of brother Benjamin apprise
That *it is* my mouth telling you.

13 "So you shall tell my father, do,
Of all my glory in Egypt,
And all you've seen *upon the script*,
And you shall hurry and bring my
Father down here *before my eye*."

14 Then he fell on his brother's neck,
Benjamin's neck and wept *a speck*,
And Benjamin wept on his neck.

15 Moreover he kissed all his brothers
And wept upon them, *all the others*,
And after that his brothers spoke
With him *as though they'd just awoke*.

Fall on my neck, Beloved, though I have
sold

You into Egypt as a slave untold
Times when the caravan held to the stars
As guide, the moon as god, the sun as bars
Of golden god-flesh on a safe stock market.
Let me take my idolatry and park it.
Fall on my neck, Beloved, and weep for joy
That I have followed in Your steps'
employ,

From hunger only, truly, but to find
You in the buying rooms not left behind
The moment when at last I had forgotten
Or thought I had, Your silk and wool and
cotton.

Fall on my neck, Beloved, and as You
weep,
Let veils fall from my eyes like tears from
sleep.

16 Now the report of it was heard
In Pharaoh's house, saying the word,
"Joseph's brothers have come." So it
Pleased Pharaoh well and all his kit.

17 And Pharaoh said to Joseph, "Say
To your brothers, 'Do this *today*:
Load your beasts and go on your way
To Canaan's land. 18 'Bring your father
And your households and come prefer
The best of Egypt's land I'll give,
You'll eat the land's fat here *and live*.

19 'Now you're commanded, do this too:
Take wagons out of Egypt for
Your little ones, wives *you adore*
And bring your father and come, do.
20 'Also do not be worried for
Your goods, for all the best is yours
From Egypt's land and all its stores.'"

The statues of Egyptian kings reveal
Benevolence of monarchs in the wheel
Of ancient times. Their sweetness still
looks out

Of staring stone eyes showing without
doubt

Concern felt proper at the time and place
To be seen on a living monarch's face.
Little by little with time expectations
Changed with the passing of new sovereign
nations.

With Alexander came the longing look

Towards horizons instead of the book
Of human heart justice, while Caesar's
made

The lust for power the natural human
shade.

But ancient Pharaoh's thought of little ones,
And old men's comfort and respect of sons.

21 Then the sons of Israel did so,
And Joseph gave wagons to go,
According to Pharaoh's command,
And gave stuff for the trip in hand.

22 He gave them all, to each in turn,
Changes of raiment, *stuff to burn*,
But Benjamin got three hundred
In silver and five suits *of thread*.

23 And he sent to his father these:
Ten donkeys loaded *from the knees*
With the good things of Egypt, and
Ten female donkeys loaded *grand*
With corn and bread and food to go
For his father not to be slow.

24 So he sent his brothers away,
And as they left he had his say,
"See you don't fall out on the way."

A trick for Benjamin, this going back,
Joseph reminds that worry is not slack
And temptation there may well be to hide
Through some new escapade what they had
lied.

The first word of arrival must be to
Say Joseph lives, no matter what they do.
The lie is out, unless some new plan can
Be hatched to save each criminal and man.
"Do not fall out along the way" he said.
That's sound advice to those who came for
bread.

It's falling out of men at middle age
That often cuts the bread out of the page
Of human history. Beloved, I've fallen
Out with the fair and not, both flower and
pollen.

25 Then they went up out of Egypt,
And came to Canaan's land *equipped*
To Jacob their father. 26 And they
Told him, saying "Joseph *today*
Is still alive, and he *rules all*
The land of Egypt *at his call*."
And Jacob's heart stood still, because
He did not credit from their jaws.

27 But when they told him every word
Which Joseph said, what had occurred
And when he saw the wagons that
Joseph had sent to *where he sat*
To carry him, the spirit of
Jacob their father rose above.

28 Then Israel said "*It is enough*.
Joseph my son's alive *and tough*.
I will go *down where they reside*
And see him once before I've died."

Beloved, I'm too enraptured with the fact
That You are here and now and still intact
Despite philosophy and industry,
That I fail to remember the degree
To which they lied who said that You were
bound

In three alone. I sought You in the sound
Of liturgy, and forgot how they lied
Who said You were one God of none
beside

The culture-honed and self-identified.
I sought You sorrowing and when I'd given
Up all the ways and means in which I'd
striven,

Your wagons and Your donkeys came
before

The tent door where I kept depleted store,
Brought bread and resurrection, what is
more.

Genesis 46

1 So Israel took his journey with
All that he had, *both kin and kith*,
And came to Beersheba, and there
Offered his sacrifices *bare*
To his father Isaac's God's *care*.

2 Then Alohim spoke to Israel
In the night visions for a while
And said "Jacob, Jacob!" And he
Said "Here I am and *here I be*."

3 So He said "I *am* El God El,
God of your father, *in this spell*,
Do not fear now to go down there
To Egypt, for I'll make your share
A great nation *while you are there*.
4 "I'll surely go down with you to
Egypt, and I'll bring you up too,
And Joseph shall lay his hand on
Your eyes *at evening and at dawn*."

I lay the evening sacrifice and bow

Toward Your house, Beloved, and make
 my vow.
 The universe is empty, silent, and
 Meaningless until You state the command.
 Your word in song makes darkness filled
 with light
 And blindnesses' wrong disappear with
 sight.
 The divine dream beyond the eye and ear
 Awakens heart, makes disappear the fear
 Of flight. For promises I step head high
 Across Egyptian sands and let the sky
 Take me above the worries in my breast.
 Beloved, make food and shelter not the
 quest
 Forever of these children. Let the place
 Where they are always be before Your
 face.

5 Then Jacob arose from Beersheba,
 And Israel's sons *from their zareba*
 And carried their father Jacob,
 Their little ones, and wives *in mob*,
 In the wagons which Pharaoh'd sent
 To carry him *and desert tent*.
 6 So they took their livestock and goods,
 Which they'd acquired *around the woods*
 In Canaan's land, and went down to
 Egypt, Jacob and *not a few*
 With all his descendants with him.
 7 His sons and his sons' sons, and slim
 His daughters and his sons' daughters,
 And all his descendants *and curs*,
 He brought to Egypt all *that stirs*.

What happened to the captives they had
 taken
 When Simeon and Levi'd gone and shaken
 The city Shechem to its roots, killed all
 The men and taken children with the fall
 And mothers too, and made them Jacob's
 slaves?
 Had these been freed or were they laid in
 graves,
 Or left to scrounge the Negev for a bite
 Of honey, weed or anything in sight
 That might save life? Or did they go along
 To Egypt as servants without a count
 To disappear without a trace or mount
 Among the seething, breathing river
 throng?

Beloved, what nameless ones of these knew
 You,
 Who walked the way to Egypt, sought the
 dew?

8 Now these *were* the names of the sons
 Of Israel, Jacob and his sons,
 Who went to Egypt: Reuben first
 Of Jacob's, *perhaps not the worst*.
 9 The sons of Reuben *were* Hanoch,
 Pallu, Hezron, and Carmi's *stock*.
 10 The sons of Simeon *were* Jemuel,
 Jamin, Ohad, Jachin, *for fuel*
 Zohar, and then Shaul, the son
 Of *nameless* Canaanite woman.
 11 The sons of Levi *were* Gershon,
 Kohath, and Merari *alone*.
 12 The sons of Judah *were* Er, and
 Onan, and Shelah, Perez, and
 Zerah (but Er and Onan died
 In Canaan's land *since they defied*).
 The sons of Perez were Hezron
 And Hamul. 13 And the sons alone
 Of Issachar *were* Tola and
 Puvah, Job, and *the last* Shimron.
 14 Zebulon's sons Sered, Elon,
 And Jahleel. 15 These *were* the sons
 Of Leah, whom she bore *by runs*
 To Jacob in Padan Aram,
 With his daughter Dinah *and lamb*.
 All the persons, his sons and daughters,
Were thirty-three *and without slaughters*.
 16 The sons of Gad *were* Ziphion,
 Haggi, Shuni, and then Ezbon,
 Eri, Arodi, Areli.
 17 The sons of Asher, *one plus three*
Were Jimnah, Ishuah, Isui,
 Beriah, and Serah, their sister.
 Beriah, *who was no persister*,
Had two sons: Heber, Malchiel.
 18 These *were* sons of Zilpah, who fell
 To Leah Laban's daughter, and
 These she bore to Jacob well-manned:
 Sixteen souls *all, counted and scanned*.
 19 The sons of Rachel, Jacob's wife,
 Joseph and Benjamin *for life*.
 20 And to Joseph in Egypt's land
 Were born Manasseh's brother and
 Ephraim, whom Asenath, the daughter
 Of Poti-Pherah priest of On,
 Bore to him *by the Nile's broad water*,
To be two sons not just his own.

21 The sons of Benjamin *were* Belah,
 Becher, Ashbel, *another fellow*
 Gera, Naaman, Ehi, Rosh, Muppim,
 And Ard *younger brother of* Huppim.
 22 These *were* the sons of Rachel, who
 Were born to Jacob: fourteen *few*.
 23 The son of Dan *was* Hushim. 24 And
 The sons of Naphtali *that stand*
Were Jahzeel, Guni, Jezer,
 And Shillem *too at last was there*.
 25 These *were* the sons of Bilhah, whom
 Laban gave to his daughter's room,
 Rachel's, and she bore these to Jacob:
 Seven souls all *each morn to wake up*.
 26 All the souls who went to Egypt
 With Jacob, who came *and equipped*
 From his loins, besides his sons' wives,
Were sixty-six souls in all *lives*.
 27 And the sons of Joseph who were
 Born to him in Egypt's *land were*
 Two souls. All the souls of the house
 Of Jacob who went *down to browse*
 In Egypt were seventy's *transfer*.

The whole, Beloved, was seventy by count,
 But at the bottom of the pecking score
 There was only one tenth of that amount:
 The seven souls of Bilhah and no more.
 The weakest one is hidden at the core,
 The secret of Ismail who disappeared
 Before his father and the folk who feared.
 Dan's set for judgement with a single son,
 Hushim, the hasters, know the judgement's
 done

At every Sabbath eve. While Naphtali
 Has four sons for four gates beneath the
 sky.

Jahzeel for God divides obedience,
 Guni, coloured with love, Jezer the sense
 Of form, Shillem in peace a recompense.

28 Then he sent Judah before him
 To Joseph, to point before him
 To Goshen. And they came into
 The land of Goshen *with its dew*.
 29 So Joseph made ready his car,
 His chariot and went up *and far*
 To Goshen to meet his father
 Israel, *where he and his sons were*,
 And he presented himself to
 Him, and fell on his neck *anew*
 And wept on his neck a good while,

While his brothers stood rank and file.

I rush to You, Beloved and Father, where
 You wait in Goshen in the fresh sea air,
 And fall upon Your neck as though the
 time
 That separated me from You in mime
 Had been a score of years, and yet one
 breath
 Alone between my tender soul and death
 Extends infinities of veils that rend
 In one fell sound and then come to an end.
 I rush to You, Beloved, and in that rush
 I find straight footsteps turning in the hush
 To whirl about since you are never found
 At end of bourne nor at the break of bound,
 But at the centre of all life and being,
 Beyond and yet within both ear and seeing.

30 And Israel said to Joseph, "Now
 Let me die, since I've *any how*
 Seen your face, and you're still alive,
How you managed so to contrive."

Let me die then, Beloved, since I have
 found
 Your face beside the river and the sound
 Where the great Nile from Ethiopian strand
 Comes once and all to meet the bright sea-
 sand.
 Let me die then, since I have seen Your
 face
 That none can see and live in any place,
 Though in your presence there can only be
 One face, one name and one eternity.
 Let me die then and wake to the grand
 whole
 That always was the psalter of my soul,
 Where one voice still repeats the solemn
 rhymes
 Upon whose walls Your living ivy climbs.
 Let me die then, Beloved, and wake anew
 More than I ever was embraced in You.

31 Then Joseph told his brothers and
 His father's household, "*By command*
 I will go up and tell Pharaoh,
 And say to him, 'My brothers *show*
 And those of my father's house, who
Were in the land of Canaan, do
 Come down to Egypt and to me.
 32 'And the men *are* shepherds, for their

Work's *always* been to feed and care
For livestock, and they've brought their
flocks,
Their herds, and all they've got *in stocks*.'
33 "So it shall be, when Pharaoh calls
You and says, 'What is your profession?'
34 "That you shall say *and make*
confession,

'Your servants' occupation's been
With livestock from our youth and in
Our lives till now, both we *and all*
Our fathers *have followed that call*,'
That you may live in Goshen's land,
For every shepherd *and his band*
Is an abomination to
Egyptians *whether much or few*."

No man among my fathers has kept sheep
Four hundred years since in the Scottish
keep
Of fell and grassland the ancestors
ploughed
The lowlands doubtless with an ovine
crowd.

I do not say I'm so Egyptian that
Sheep are abomination where I'm at.
I only say I do not know the room,
And closer to my life and to my doom
May well be sheep stealer than shepherd
fair.

Beloved, I shall keep sheep if only there
Can I find place to be within Your care.
I'll give up my wild ways in forest glade
And follow any sheep you wish or made,
I shall even become straight-laced and
staid.

Genesis 47

1 Then Joseph went and told Pharaoh,
"My father and *in the first row*
My brothers, their flocks and their herds
And all they have *in tents and words*,
Have come from Canaan's land, indeed
They're in Goshen *about to breed*."
2 And he took five men from among
His brothers and with *that small throng*,
Presented them before Pharaoh.
3 Then Pharaoh said to them "Hello,
What *is* your occupation?" And
They said to Pharaoh, "Your servants
Are shepherds all, from sons to *aunts*."
4 And they said to Pharaoh, "We have

Come here to live, *pasture and calve*,
In the land, since your servants have
No pasture for their flocks, because
The famine's severe *above laws*
In the land of Canaan. Now please
Therefore let your servants *have ease*
To live in Goshen's land *and breeze*."

Beloved, this place is ruled by You alone,
And yet I must petition iron and stone
To eat my bread and wear the woollen belt.
Let me not be bitter for earthly spelt.
The order that You set to run the world
And keep a flag of justice well unfurled
Is often better for the multitude
Than is the rule of bandit, squire and feud.
It shall receive its due in praise and fire,
And fail before the onslaught of desire.
We who prefer humbly to guard the sheep
Drink of the golden waters vast and deep,
While statesmen quaff the wine and go to
bed
With stomach ache and terrors in the head.

5 Then Pharaoh told Joseph, and said
"Your father and your brothers bred
Have come to you. 6 "Now Egypt's land
Is before you. Have father and
Your brothers live in the land's best
Let them live in Goshen's bequest.
And if you know competent men
Among them, make them herdsmen then
In chief over my livestock *blessed*."

Sometimes, but rarely, it is true the state
Lifts head and sees advantage not too late
To pay the perfect for the good they do,
Although to him it may seem humble shoe.
Beloved, let me take from Your living
breath

The wisdom to avoid the shibboleth
That power sets before the iron gates
Where empty scribbling warns of dire fates.
The real life is sheering, feeding and
Leading to water and in patience stand.
It is not in the record and the count,
But in the wind and gushing water fount.
The flocks are mine because I touch the
wool,
And Pharaoh's because he is full of pull.

7 Then Joseph brought his father in,

And set Jacob before Pharaoh,
 And Jacob blessed Pharaoh *and kin*.
 8 Pharaoh said to Jacob, "How old
Are you?" 9 And Jacob told Pharaoh,
 "The days of the years of my *cold*
And weary pilgrimage are one
 Hundred and thirty years *soon done*,
 Few are the days and evil of
 The years of my life, and *above*
 The days of the years of the life
 Of my fathers' pilgrimage rife
 They've not attained *though lived in strife*."
 10 So Jacob blessed Pharaoh, and went
 Out from before the Pharaoh's *tent*.

The powerless alone have power to bless,
 Because alone they live in righteousness.
 Pharaoh is sure and rules the world of state
 And guides the halls of justice to be great,
 But must relinquish all the better part
 Of blessing and rely on others' art.
 The powerless have power to bless alone,
 They have no wealth to give, nor can atone
 The wrongs of progress nor praise gathered
 rights
 When rarely these come to the peoples'
 sights.
 Beloved, make me an instrument of
 blessing,
 Though powerless, and late with futile
 guessing,
 And I shall whirl with blessings in my hand
 Both in and out of Pharaoh's finest land.

11 And Joseph placed his father and
 His brothers, and gave in the land
 Of Egypt possession to them
 In the best of the land *and stem*,
 In the land of Rameses, as spoken
 By Pharaoh and commanded *token*.
 12 Then Joseph nourished his father,
 His brothers, and all *with them there*
Of his father's household with bread,
 By family count *were they all fed*.

Indeed I dwell upon the land supported
 By sun god and by his servants comforted.
 My true place in Your house is dry and
 bare
 Without the wealth of water, only air.
 I flee to the house of another god
 To herd another's sheep upon the sod

That bakes beneath the sun that tears my
 heart
 While I and Your house are so long apart.
 The weeks pass with the sun-god's
 celebration
 Fed by the drunkenness of that whole
 nation
 That bows to the empiric law of sun
 In sciences so-called and in the run
 To sell the sun's blood for a slave and
 smile.
 I quietly rest here, but without guile.

13 Now no bread was in all the land,
 For the famine *was* very grand,
 So that the land of Egypt and
 The land of Canaan languished by
 The famine *come to multiply*.
 14 And Joseph gathered all the gold
 And silver found in Egypt's hold
 And in the land of Canaan, for
 The grain which they bought *and bought*
more,
 And Joseph brought the money to
 Pharaoh's house *as the thing to do*.

Beloved, it seems that Joseph was a ruler
 Who made reforms where he could, and no
 fooler.
 He made the slaves rebel to dominate
 Each one his or her own sexual estate.
 And now he would release economy
 Of its reliance on money and fee
 By taking metals out of circulation
 And setting foodstuffs as the staff of
 nation.
 His theory may be good, but what will be
 The end of the experiment in coin?
 He risks to fail because they do not join
 His hopes who rule the altar and the throne.
 Just wait until rise up the hearts of stone.
 One can oppress as well commodity.

15 So when the money failed upon
 The land of Egypt, Canaan's dawn,
 All the Egyptians came and said
 To Joseph, "Now then, give us bread,
 For why should we die before you?
 For money has failed *and is few*."
 16 Then Joseph said "Give your livestock,
 And I'll give *bread* for your livestock,
 If money has melted *like dew*."

17 So they brought their livestock to him,
And Joseph gave them bread *to brim*
For horses, flocks, cattle in herds,
And for donkeys, *for all in words*.
Thus he fed them with bread for all
Their livestock that year sans rainfall.

Here Joseph takes away one level of
Authority between herds and their love.
That cattle shall be owned by Pharaoh's
hand

And man and beast be equal in the land.
Ah blessed return to Paradise ensured
In Joseph's plot both stable and inured.
Beloved, the benign communism sought
Was something that could never be
untaught,

But must re-echo in the coming years
Not only of Egypt but in the ears
Of every empire fated to arise
And rule beneath Your ever silent skies.
Beloved, see that the donkeys always come
To savour that things will change in the
sum.

18 When that year ended, they came to
Him the next year and told him true,
"We will not hide from my lord that
Our money's gone *with dog and cat*,
My lord also has *all* our herds
Of livestock. There's nothing *but words*
Left in my lord's sight but our land
And bodies. 19 "Why should we *unplanned*
Die before your eyes, and our land?
Buy us and our land for our bread,
And we and our land will *instead*
Be servants of Pharaoh, give seed,
That we may live and not *in need*
Die, that the land may not become
A desolation *cumbersome*."

The people themselves come to make the
deal

And sell themselves beneath the donkey's
heel.

Not Joseph and not Pharaoh ask the while
To enslave Egypt's people and with guile.
But rote democracy is sword enough
To equalize the better and the rough.
Beloved, there is no change upon the
screen

Of nothingness that reflects divine dream.

That dream floats in the mind of multitude
And arms the populace for common feud.
I watch the power of populace sell all
Its freedom for the fun of bread and ball,
While fatted calves stand in the fattening
stall,
And porkers run the ramp and hear the call.

20 Then Joseph bought all Egypt's land
For Pharaoh, each Egyptian's hand
Sold his field, since the famine was
Severe upon them. So the land
Became Pharaoh's *under the laws*.

21 And as for the people, he moved
Them into cities, *the which proved*
To be from *one* end of the land
Of Egypt to the *other* hand.

22 Only the land of the priests he
Did not buy, for the priests had rations
Allotted by Pharaoh, those rations
They ate which Pharaoh gave them free,
Therefore they did not sell their stations.

The priests of the sun-god remain aloof
From siren calls democracy of hoof
Send out as the only measure to make
The world safe for bread and for bakers'
sake.

Remember that the baker met his fate
With well-filled baskets sitting on his pate
And all the birds came down to eat his
wares.

The butler too can meet the public stares.
The priests of the sun-god take up the gold
And purge the land of everything that's
sold.

Wait for them, they will end the common
reign

With one more ringing of the neck and
pain.

Beloved, Pharaoh may be a righteous man,
But what can he do now that the priests
can?

23 Then Joseph said to all the folk,
"Indeed I have bought you and spoke
Up for your land this day to take
It for Pharaoh. Look, *here's a stake*
Of seed for you, and sow the land.

24 "And it shall come to pass *as planned*
In the harvest that you shall give
One-fifth to Pharaoh. You shall live

On four-fifths as your own, as seed
 For field and food, for those *who need*
 Of your households and as food for
 Your little ones *and any more.*"
 25 So they said "You have saved our lives,
 Let us find favour *as arrives*
 In the sight of my lord, and we
 Will Pharaoh's *faithful* servants be."
 26 And Joseph made it law over
 The land of Egypt *to occur*
 To this day, *that* Pharaoh should take
 One-fifth, except for what lands make
 The fields of priests only, *which* did
 Not become Pharaoh's *by the bid.*

The one-fifth to the ruler was a stake
 That Joseph instituted for the sake
 Of divine ruler in the years to come
 Into a universal, bright kingdom.
 Perhaps he did not know that right must fall
 Into an occultation and a call
 To live in passive obedience to those
 Who have no mandate but that people
 chose

Or that they took by force the divine
 throne.

Or then perhaps he did know, since the loan
 Of Enoch had been made before his day.
 No men alive now but the guided say,
 And their words are whispered beneath the
 pale
 Of Four Books oft recited in the tale.

27 So Israel lived in Egypt's land,
 In Goshen's country *on the sand*,
 Possessions there they had and grew
 And multiplied greatly there too.

Week 12

28 And Jacob lived in Egypt's land
 For seventeen years *with his own band*.
 So the whole age of Jacob nears
 One hundred forty-seven years.
 29 When the time drew near that he must
 Die *and Jacob return to dust*,
 He called his son Joseph and said
 To him, "Now if there's favour shed
 On me in your sight, please put hand
 Under my thigh, and deal outspanned
 In kindness and truth with me here.
 Do not bury me in Egypt,
 30 "But let me lie by fathers' bier,

You shall carry me from Egypt
 And bury me there in their crypt."
 And he said "I'll do as you've said."
 31 Then he said "Swear to me *with dread.*"
 And he swore to him. On the bed
 Israel *lowly* bowed down his head.

Let me lie, my Beloved, by Abraham
 Who talked like Moses with the great I
 AM.

The promise is that death shall make the
 sleep

In Abram's bosom a safe place to keep.
 Swear to me, my Beloved, that when my
 lips

Cease to repeat Your name in holy sips,
 And I go down to wait the final call
 To come before Your face with all and all,
 That I shall rest upon the lovely breast
 Of Abraham and find my mortal quest.
 Keep all the acts of freedom I have made
 Within Your house eternal and Your shade,
 But let my weary life in slumber pass
 In Hebron of the spirit, on its grass.

Genesis 48

1 It came to pass after these things
 That Joseph was told *of lifesprings*,
 "Indeed your father's sick," and he
 Took with him his two sons *and free*,
 Manasseh and Ephraim *truly*.
 2 And Jacob was told, "Look, your son
 Joseph is coming *on the run*
 To see you," and Israel strengthened
 Himself and sat up on the bed.
 3 Then Jacob told Joseph like friend,
 "El El God the Almighty *led*
 Me *and* appeared to me at Luz
 In Canaan's land and blessed me, 4 "Who's
 Said to me, 'Indeed, I will make
 You fruitful, multiply and take
 From you a multitude of folk,
 And give this land *of which I spoke*
 To your descendants after you
 As everlasting residue.'
 5 "And now *these* your two sons, who were
 Born to you, Ephraim *to prefer*
 And Manasseh, in Egypt's land
 Before I came *at your command*
 To you in Egypt, *they are* mine,
 As Reuben and Simeon *fine*,

They shall be mine. 6 "Your offspring
whom
You may beget after their *room*
Shall be yours, they will be called by
Their brothers' name as heirs for aye.
7 "But as for me, when I came from
Padan, Rachel died *without crumb*
Beside me there in Canaan's land,
Not far to go to Ephrath's *stand*,
And there I buried her upon
The way to Ephrath *at the dawn*
(That is, to Bethlehem *withdrawn*)."

Jacob gives Joseph two shares of the pie,
Already cut up slender with a sigh
In twelve portions. I cut the noble grape
In forty and see all the fare take shape.
What's blessed is just enough to reach the
strength
Of all the needs of man and beast and
length
Of land. The portion brings to mind the
sight
Of Ephrata and what dusty road might
Conceal of fate. Poor Rachel could not wait
To come to where the lands capitulate
To hills, but lay down by the road to sleep.
Even today the women come to weep
Beside the tomb and ask a double share
To comfort for the pilgrimage of care.

8 Then Israel saw Joseph's sons, and
Said "Who *are* these *by my command*?"
9 And Joseph said to his father,
"They *are* my sons, *and I defer*,
Whom Alohim has given me
In this *place*." And he said *freely*,
"Bring them to me, and I'll bless them."
10 Now Israel's eyes with age were dim,
So that he could not see. And so
Joseph brought them near him *to go*,
And he kissed them and hugged *the beaux*.
11 And Israel said to Joseph, "I
Had not thought to see your face nigh,
But Alohim has also shown
Me your offspring *almost full grown*!"

I had not thought, Beloved, to see Your
face,
Since You are not born in my time and
place,
And have no form that I can grasp or see,

Who don't become as I, but only be.
I had not thought to see Your face since I
Am blind and see alone with human eye.
But now that Joseph has brought You
nearby,
I find Your presence precious without
sight,
And know Your fond embrace without the
light.
Enlighten my soul never with the bliss
That mystics see beyond Your hug and
kiss.

I shall not see, nor do I wish to see,
For seeing means that You are far from me.
Let me give up the mystic sight for Thee.

12 So Joseph brought them from beside
His knees, and bowed down *in his pride*
With his face to the earth *and land*.
13 And Joseph took them both *in hand*,
Ephraim with his right hand toward
Israel's left hand, *without a sword*,
And Manasseh with his left hand
He placed toward Israel's right hand,
And brought near him *the both as planned*.
14 Then Israel stretched out his right hand
And laid *it* on Ephraim's head,
Who was the younger *though well-fed*,
And his left on Manasseh's head,
Guiding his hands both knowingly,
Manasseh was the firstborn, *see*.

I cross my hands in faith against the world
That has its mind made up, its coiffure
curled,
And still progresses in stable oppression
By wealth's seniority without confession.
I cross my hands in faith and choose the
small
And set the great at nought, despite their
call.
The younger son is purer, without hope
Of being king or governor or pope.
I cross my hands in faith because I'm blind
To false discriminations based on kind,
But stop to know the name of morning
come
And linger with the setting of the sum.
I cross my hands, Beloved, and then choose
You
Because where I turn choices become few.

15 And he blessed Joseph then, and said
"Alohim, before whom my *dead*
Fathers *faithful* Abraham and
Isaac walked *by the Lord's command*,
The God who's fed me all my life
Unto this day, 16 The Angel's *fife*
Who has redeemed me from all bad,
May He bless each and every lad,
Let my name be named upon them,
And the name of my fathers' *gem*
Of Abraham and Isaac, and
Let them grow many in the land."

17 When Joseph saw his father laid
His right hand on Ephraim's head,
It displeased him, so he took hold
Of his father's hand, *trembling, old*,
To take it off from Ephraim's head
And place it on Manasseh's head.
18 And Joseph said to his father,
"Not so, my father, *please concur*,
For this *one* is the firstborn, put
Your right hand on his head, *not foot*."

19 But his father refused and said
"I know, my son, I know, *I'm led*.
He also shall become a folk,
And he also shall be no joke,
But truly his younger brother
Shall be greater than he, *don't err*,
And his descendants shall become
A multitude of folk in sum."
20 So he blessed them that day, and said
"By you Israel will bless *your head*,
Saying 'May Alohim make you
As Ephraim and as Manasseh!'"
And thus he set Ephraim to do
Before Manasseh *in the way*.

The prophet Joseph without fault or fear
Was not wise in the annual of mere
Being and knowing what's behind the cloud
Of witnesses that rise up in the crowd.
He knew to tell the meaning of the dream
He had before his brothers split his beam.
He knew to make the Pharaoh hear his
word,
And what he prophesied indeed occurred.
But even Joseph did not know the real
Behind illusion and what he might feel.
He took his father's hand to right his choice
And in exasperation raised his voice.
Beloved, let me submit my will to Mine,

And kiss the darkness that's behind the
shine.

21 Then Israel said to Joseph, "See,
I'm dying, Alohim will be
With you and bring you back unto
The land of your fathers [ancestors] and
true.

22 "Moreover I have given you
One portion above your brothers,
Which I took from the hand *and spurs*
Of the Amorite with my sword
And with my bow *when unimplored*."

Genesis 49

1 And Jacob called his sons and said
"Gather together *round my bed*,
That I may tell you what shall come
On you in the last days in sum:
2 "Gather together now and hear,
You sons of Jacob, *do not fear*,
And listen to Israel your father.
3 "Reuben, you are my firstborn, rather,
My might and starting of my strength,
The excellence *and also length*
Of dignity and of my power.
4 Unstable as the water's *hour*,
You'll not excel, because you went
Up to your father's bed, defiling,
He went up to my couch, *reviling*.

Like Cain, the great hope of his mother
Eve,
Reuben, the first son was a cause to grieve.
He always started well, but then he failed
Because when clouds came up he often
quailed.

His mother's hope and father's pride, he set
His sights on what things were nearby to
get,
Instead of weighing wish upon the heart
And finding love the better part of art.
Like water, he ran downhill and beside
He let desire remain to fire his pride.
I too like water seek the lowest place,
But place instead desire upon the trace
Of Your burnt offering on the slaughter's
floor.

I find, Beloved, that water's stable shore.

5 "Now Simeon and Levi *are*
Brothers, vessels of cruelty

Are in their dwelling place by far.
 6 Let not my soul enter *freely*
 Into their council, let not my
 Honour be joined to assembly,
 For in their anger they slew one,
 A man, and in their self-will done
 They hamstringed an ox *by the by*.
 7 Cursed *be* their anger, *it is fierce*,
 And their wrath, for it's cruel to *pierce*!
 I will divide them in Jacob
 And scatter them in Israel's *hub*.

Your law, Beloved, is sweet to tooth and
 maw,
 But there's a better way than divine law.
 Without the law Dinah and Shechem saw
 The bliss of heaven and paradise to gain,
 But Simeon and Levi chose the rain,
 Because they thought that justice was not
 vain.
 But all is vain without the loving touch,
 And even Shechem could have said as
 much.
 Save me and this poor world, Beloved,
 from law
 That's in the angry hand and cutting claw.
 Let right lead into love, and not the might,
 And scatter wrath from nothing in Your
 sight.
 There's no commanding love is thought
 true still,
 But that's all that one can command, not
 will.

8 "Judah, you *are he* whom your brothers
 Shall praise, your hand on neck of others,
 Your father's children shall bow down
 Before you *and before your crown*.
 9 And Judah *is a lion's whelp*,
 From the prey, my son, *without help*
 You have gone up. He bows down, lies
 Down as a lion, and as *tries*
 A lion, who shall rouse him up?
 10 The sceptre shall not *in his cup*
 Depart from Judah, nor lawgiver
 From between his feet, *nor deliver*
 Until he comes to whom belongs,
 And to him *shall* obedience
 Of *all* the people *before sense*.

Some say the one to come is some Messiah
 Not yet appeared but who'll be both pariah

To wicked ones, and Saviour of the true.
 Some say the one to come has come
 already
 Named Jesus or Muhammad or some
 Freddy.
 I doubt not that the three great forms of
 posing
 As faithful to Your law will find a closing
 To their debate and quarrel when there
 comes
 The prophesied Dajjal and Anti-christ.
 Until then all may fight for silver sums
 And soak themselves in whiskey and get
 iced.
 The one who unites all with derring-do
 Will not be sent, Beloved, I know from
 You,
 Who have Your own state and law for the
 few.

11 Binding his donkey to the vine,
 And his donkey's colt to the fine
 Vine, he washed his garments in wine,
 And his clothes in the blood of grapes.
 12 His eye darker than wine *escapes*,
 And his teeth whiter than the milk,
That flows out shining on the silk.

The fourth son then touched the reality:
 Reuben was simply law and failed to be,
 While love and true awareness of the two
 Was spent on Levi and his brother's due.
 A lion and a donkey represent
 Judah, the two best beasts where Judah
 went.
 The sceptre is Judah's alone until
 The one desired shall come to take his fill.
 Let everyone guess who the prophesied
 May be, but knowledge only takes the ride.
 A cryptic Bacchus with milk, grape and
 wine
 Comes riding on the donkey doing fine,
 Clothing drenched with the purple blood of
 grapes,
 And peacocks calling to the dancing apes.

13 "Zebulun shall live by the haven
 Of the sea, He *shall be* a haven
 For ships, bordered by Sidon *graven*.
 14 "Issachar, a strong donkey, lies
 Down between two burdens, *and cries*
 15 That rest is good as he can see

And that the land *is fair to me*,
 He bowed his shoulder down to bear,
 Became a band of slaves *to care*.
 16 "But Dan shall judge his people *right*
 As one of Israel's tribes *in sight*.
 17 And Dan shall be a serpent by
 The way, a viper for ally,
 That bites the horse's heels so that
 Its rider falls from where he sat.
 18 I've waited for salvation, YHWH!
 19 "Gad, troops shall tramp upon his *few*,
 At last he'll triumph in his due.
 20 "Bread from Asher is rich and *sweet*,
 He'll bring dainties to royal *feet*.
 21 "And Naphtali's a deer let loose,
 With fine words *culminating truce*.

Beloved, this Jacob knows to flatter sons,
 He has them decked in famous names by
 tons.

The one's a donkey while the other's claim
 To fame like viper's striking at the chain
 Of every passing steed put on parade.
 With such reminders these sons are
 unmade.

A deer seems better to be pictured by,
 A deer with fine words makes me rather
 shy.

The deer I've known are quiet in their way
 Despite the snort and rare stunt for their
 say.

For all the flying ships of Zebulun
 I still vote for the coming seventh son
 Who follows rest with justice in a ride,
 A carousel that leaps and bucks beside.

22 "Joseph's a fruitful bough *to tell*,
 A fruitful bough beside a well,
 His branches run over the wall.
 23 The archers bitterly *gave call*
 And grieved him, shot and hated him.
 24 His bow stayed strong and was not dim,
 His arms in hand grew stronger still
 By Jacob's Mighty God's own will.
 (From there's the shepherd, and the stone
 Of Israel *who's his sent alone*),
 25 By the God of your father who
 Will help you, by Almighty who
 Will bless you *with the blessings of*
 The heaven above, the heaven above
 And blessings of the deep that rests
 Beneath, and blessings of the breasts

And of the womb. 26 The blessings of
 Your father have excelled above
 The blessings of my fathers to
 The highest bound of everlasting
 Hills. They shall be on the *forecasting*
 Head of Joseph, and on the crown
 Of the head of him who *with frown*
 Was separated from his brothers,
Lived in Egypt without the others.
 27 "Benjamin is a ravenous
 Wolf, in the morning *without fuss*
 He shall devour the prey, and at
 Night *too* divide the spoil of that."

Beloved, both Israel's shepherd and her
 rock

You come to Joseph and here You take
 stock.

This is the son that's truly blessed to be
 With heaven and earth, and with the mighty
 sea.

His grief and patience is at last rewarded,
 Though most who suffer such can ill afford
 it.

His brother is a wolf and spoiling prey
 While Joseph wears the crown and holds
 the sway.

I too look to the hills, the everlasting,
 And like good Joseph also cease my
 fasting.

Alone in Egypt I have learned a thing
 As well, and that's not to rely on wing
 Of brotherhood, but stand upon the wall,
 The only soul at last to hear the call.

28 All these the twelve tribes of Israel,
 And this *is* what their father's spiel
 Spoke to them. And he blessed them, he
 Blessed each one and accordingly.
 29 He charged them and said to them then,
 "I'm to be gathered to my folk,
 Bury me with my fathers, men
 In the cave that's from Ephron's *yoke*,
 The field of Ephron the Hittite,
 30 "In the cave at Machpelah's site,
 Which *is* before Mamre, a place
 In Canaan's land, which *in his pace*
 Abraham bought with Ephron's field,
 Ephron the Hittite, *bought and sealed*,
 Possession for a burial place.
 31 "There they buried Abraham and
 Sarah his wife, there, by command,

They buried Isaac and his wife
Rebekah, and at end of life,
I buried Leah *after strife*.
32 "The field and the cave that *is* there
Were purchased from the Hittites fair."
33 And when Jacob finished commanding
His sons, he drew his feet *from standing*
Up in the bed and breathed his last,
Was gathered to his folk *aghas*.

All men die daily, my Beloved, though not
With sons about their sofa to be taught,
Though not with feet drawn on the braided
bier
Embroidered in gold threads, shrouded in
sere
Silk canopies. All men die daily, breath
To breath invites the living soul to death.
I exhale and life leaves my inner cave
Abandoned and dark, but You come to save
And with Your divine kiss breathe in again
The breath of life that animates all men.
I share that kiss of life with all things that
Breathe on the clay, both beast and those
that chat.
Breathe still on me the sacred name of
YHWH,
Beloved, until my soul comes back to You.

Genesis 50

1 Then Joseph fell upon his face,
His father's face and wept a space
Over him, and kissed in embrace.
2 And Joseph commanded his servants
The physicians, *for the observance*,
To embalm his father. So they
Embalmed Israel *that very day*.
3 Forty days were required for him,
As is embalming Egyptian,
And the Egyptians mourned for him
Full seventy days. 4 And when the days
Of his mourning were past, *for praise*,
Joseph spoke to the household of
Pharaoh, and said "If now I have
Found favour in your eyes, then speak
In the hearing of Pharaoh, seek,
5 'My father made me swear, and said
"Indeed, I'm dying, in my grave
Which I dug for myself *a bed*
In Canaan's land, there you shall go
To bury me." Now therefore, *show*
Me favour, let me go up there

And bury my father, *I swear*,
And I'll come back *from his grave there*."
6 And Pharaoh said "Now go up there,
Bury your father, as you swear."

By forty days of mourning reading Psalms
I was introduced in this path of palms.
In forty sips of wine and with each breath
I wept for Jacob's passing and the death
Of Abraham and Isaac, Hagar, Sarah,
Rebekah, Rachel, Leah, and not narrow,
For Zilpah and for Bilhah, Miriam,
And even for Isaiah where I am.
I wept for dead Muhammad and for him
Who wept himself beneath the olives dim
In old Jerusalem, and for Hussein
In thirst beside the river on the plain.
Upon the seventieth day of weeping
I entered, my Beloved, the house You're
keeping.

7 So Joseph went to bury his
Father, and with him went all his
And the servants of Pharaoh, too,
The elders of his house, *not few*,
And all the elders of the land
Of Egypt, 8 as well as *was planned*
All the house of Joseph, his brothers,
And his father's house, *all the others*.
Only their little ones, their flocks,
And their herds they left in *the docks*
Of Goshen's land. 9 And there went out
With him both chariots and *the shout*
Of horsemen, a great gathering,
A great crowd not like anything.
10 Then they came to the threshing floor
Of Atad, that's beyond the shore
Of Jordan, and they mourned him there
With great and very solemn share
Of lamentation. He observed
Seven days for his father deserved.
11 And when the people of the land,
The Canaanites, saw mourning band
At Atad's threshing floor, they said,
"This *is* a deep mourning of *dead*
For the Egyptians." That is why
Afterward that place is known by
The name of Abel Mizraim,
Which *is* beyond the Jordan's rim.
12 So his sons did for him as he
Commanded them *instructively*.
13 For his sons carried him into

The land of Canaan, and to *do*
As he said, bury him in cave
 Of Machpelah's field and the *grave*
 East of Mamre, which Abraham
 Bought with the field, *he bought it* from
 Ephron the Hittite as possession
 For burial place *and in concession*.
 14 After he had buried his father,
 Joseph returned to Egypt rather,
 He and his brothers and all who
 Went up with him for father's due.

There is a chance that I may be occulted,
 Beloved, and taken up, and not insulted
 By earth's stains on my shroud within the
 grave.

Unlike some I do not pray You will save
 Me from the greater baptism of death.
 I know its sting already with each breath.
 But I do pray that when my passing here
 Arrives, and I finish with shedding tear,
 That I shall not go to the grave alone,
 But that a woven shroud cover my bone
 And washen skin. A woven shroud's
 enough

I need no bin of lead or wooden rough.
 I naked dance alive upon this floor,
 So let me enter clothed death's open door.

15 When Joseph's brothers saw that their
 Father was dead, they said "*Beware*,
 Perhaps Joseph will hate us, and
 May even take vengeance *he's planned*
 For all the evil which we did
 To him *and from our father hid*."

16 So they sent to Joseph, and said
 "Before your father died *in bed*
 He said commanding, 17 'Thus you must
 Say to Joseph, "I beg you first,
 Forgive the trespass of your brothers
 And their sin, *just as to the others*,
 For they did wickedly to you."
 Now, please, forgive the trespass, do,
 Of your father's God's servants true."
 And Joseph wept to hear them speak,
Because they thought he'd vengeance
wreak.

18 His brothers also went and fell
 Down before his face, and they tell,
 "Indeed, *we are your servants well*."

19 Then Joseph said to them, "Do not
 Fear, for *am I surely* in plot

With Alohim? 20 "But as for you,
 You meant evil against me, true,
But Alohim meant it for good,
 In order to bring out what should
 As *it is* this day, to save many
 People alive, *should there be any*.
 21 "Now therefore, do not be afraid,
 I will provide for you *arrayed*
 And for your little ones." And he
 Comforted them and spoke kindly.

I weep that Sacred Book reports to me
 Commandment clear and often, though I'm
 free,

That I must not kill or steal from my
 brother,
 Despite my knowing that there is no other
 Besides You, my Beloved, to lend the
 knowing
 Of conscience on the screen's reflected
 showing.

I weep that law insults my love for You,
 The You that hides revealed in all You do,
 In every face created in the image
 Of universe that shows Your own
 sublimage.

I weep to be reminded that I share
 Responsibility for crimes that bear
 Another's name for scapegoat just because
 That other's hand performed against Your
 laws.

22 So Joseph lived in Egypt, he
 And his father's household *freely*.
 And Joseph lived one hundred years
 And ten years *more and without fears*.

23 Joseph saw Ephraim's children to
 The third. The children of Machir,
 The son of Manasseh, were too
 Brought up on Joseph's knees *for cheer*.

24 And Joseph told his brothers, "I
 Am dying, but Alohim's by,
 And He will surely visit you,
 And bring you from this land to do
 As He swore to Abraham, to
 Isaac, and to Jacob *and crew*."

25 Then Joseph made the children of
 Israel swear *to the thing above*,
 "Alohim will surely visit
 You, and you shall carry up *fit*
 My bones from here *to Canaan's land*."

26 So Joseph died, one hundred and

Ten years old, and they embalmed him,
And he was put in a coffin
In Egypt *for the interim*.

When Joseph died there was no court to
know
The lovely things he did for Pharaoh's
show,
The friends he'd had, the elders of the
people
Were lying dead beneath the village
steeple.
The kings and princes that knew Joseph's
name
Had died before him, took with them his
fame.
There was no grand march into Canaan's
land
To fetch him to Machpelah by command.
And so he waited in the lonely chest
For when his folk might go up from the
west
And find a place at last where slave might
rest.
Beloved, the story takes hold of my soul
Enjoying Egypt's pyramids and scroll.
I wait the coming Exodus and goal.

Exodus

The Book of Exodus is divided in two by the proclamation of the Decalogue on Mount Sinai. This is a central story in the Qur'an as well, where the Decalogue is called the Criterion or Furqan given to Moses in Qur'an 2:53. Thus the Book of Exodus contains at its heart the only extensive text in all of classical religious literature, that claims to be a direct and public revelation of God, spoken without the mediation of prophet, messenger, vision or dream, and heard by six hundred thousand fighting men along with their families and retainers. It is the document of divine justice on which all faith in fact is founded.

The theme of justice is developed in both the beginning of Exodus, and the second half. The beginning of the book relates the story of the victory of justice over oppression as the people escape from

slavery in Egypt. The second half of the book develops the theme of justice within a living society, through laws of justice and through the symbol of the tent of meeting, in which reconciliation between God and humankind and between one human being and another are made through sacrifice and worship.

The book of Exodus contains the enigmatic passage of Moses' appeal to Ali in Exodus 8:9. This is obscured in most translations with an attempt to make sense of the word Ali in one of its literal meanings. This is the first of three such texts in the Bible in which the word is best left untranslated in the form it appears in Hebrew. The context of all three texts is enigmatic, but the Muslim at least will be left with the impression that the Torah or Tawrat has within it a prophecy by name of a figure to come.

As Genesis has its apparent theme
In showing that You are the God You seem
Without another, so Exodus too
Has its own theme that grasps the things I
do.

Oneness of God gives way to justice here,
You are above all just to those who fear.
The book turns on the centre, in that fold
The Decalogue of justice has been told.
The first leaves tell of justice to oppressed
And how You save such ones and give
them rest.

The last leaves tell of justice in Your tent
By which You dwell among the homeless
sent.

Beloved, I bow to justice and Your throne
As I bow to You who are God alone.

Week 13 Exodus 1

1 Now these *are* the names of the folk,
The children of Israel who woke
To come to Egypt, each man and
His household came with Jacob's *band*:
2 Reuben, Simeon, Levi, and
Judah, 3 Issachar, Zebulon,
And Benjamin, 4 *and also* Dan,
Naphtali, Gad, and Asher's *man*.
5 All those who were descendants of
Jacob were seventy persons (for
Joseph was in Egypt *already*).

6 And Joseph died, *and all above,*
 His brothers, and all *those before*
Of people from that generation.
 7 But the children of Israel *steady*
 Were fruitful and *became a nation,*
 Increased abundantly *in number,*
 Multiplied and grew *without slumber*
 Exceeding mighty, and the land
 Was filled with them *on every hand.*

Beloved, while twelve sons were clear and
 well-known

To all the populace in Canaan grown,
 Unknown to all the hidden one ruled on
 The throne of Egypt and the Pentagon.
 It may have seemed to Canaanite the king
 Of Egypt was the most important wing,
 But behind him the unseen hand and eye
 Of Joseph held the reins of power and why.
 It may seem that the ministers of state
 Along with industry divide our fate,
 But You have placed behind the throne of
 power

A shadow hand, and hidden twelfth son's
 hour.

My passive non-compliance looks to him
 Whose truth makes all the oil and tinsel
 dim.

8 Now there arose a new king over
 Egypt, who did not *for a trover*
 Know Joseph. 9 And he said to his
 Folk moreover, "Look, *the fact is*
 The people of the children of
 Israel *are more and far above*
 Us in their might, 10 "come, let us deal
 Shrewdly with them, lest *in their zeal*
 They multiply, and it occur
 When war comes *and when flies the fur,*
 That they join also enemy
 And fight against us, and go free
 Up out of the land." 11 Therefore they
 Set taskmasters over their sway
 Afflicting them to their dismay.
 And they built for Pharaoh cities
 Of treasure, Pithom and Raamses.
 12 But the more they afflicted them,
 The more they multiplied *the hem*
 And grew *in number.* And they were
 Grieved by Israelite customer.
 13 The Egyptians made Israelites
 Serve with rigour. 14 They set their sights

On making their lives bitter *sick*
 With hard bondage, in mortar, brick,
 And in all manner of service
 In the field. And all their service
 They made them do *was rigorous.*

The master of the age proved false in this:
 He lacked for all his patience and his bliss,
 Not to speak of his contacts in the market,
 Life long enough both to see and to hark it.
 This fault will end in the necessity
 Of plaguing Egypt to set people free.
 You had, Beloved, an idea better taught
 When You invented masters for the plot
 That hide themselves from both the kings
 and fair,
 And live to fill both cup and pastry-ware.
 Invisible, occulted from the eyes
 Of senator or civil servant guise,
 He still controls the world of faith and
 power
 From day to day until the judgement hour.

15 Then the king of Egypt spoke to
 The Hebrew midwives, whose names true
 Were Shiprah, Loveliness, and her
 Friend Puah, 16 and he said *astir,*
 "When you do midwife's duties for
 The Hebrew women, *what is more,*
 And see *them* on the birthstools, if
 It is a son, then *in a jiff*
 You shall kill him, but if it is
 A daughter, then let live *like whiz.*"
 17 But the midwives feared Alohim,
 And did not do as it did seem
 Good to the king of Egypt and
 To kill the boys by his command,
 But saved the boys alive instead.
 18 So the king of Egypt had led
 The midwives to him and he said
 To them, "Why have you done this thing,
 And saved the boys alive *to sing?*"
 19 And the midwives said to Pharaoh,
 "Because Hebrew women *are so,*
 Not like Egyptian women, for
 They're lively and give birth before
 The midwives come to them." 20 Therefore
 Alohim dealt well with midwives,
 And the folk multiplied in lives
 And grew exceeding great. 21 And so
 It was, because the midwives feared
 Alohim, that He *let them go*

And built them houses *well appeared*.

22 So Pharaoh commanded his folk,
And this is what the Pharaoh spoke,
"Every son who is born you'll cast
Into the river *not to last*,
And every daughter you shall save
Alive, *and so you shall behave*."

There is a statute known of old for which
The Flood came on the earth with rock and
pitch,

And that is prohibition of the slaying
Of living man or woman or child playing.
Conceit a man can control female womb
Compounds the Pharaoh's wicked sin and
doom.

The way to confront power is chosen word
That is polite, agreeing with the turd,
Excusing non-compliance with the way
Things are that can't be helped this time of
day.

Give flattery to kings with tongue and lip,
But curse them in the heart of daily sip
In prayer, and in the hand that fails to do
Their bidding. Thanks, Beloved, for shirt
and shoe.

Exodus 2

1 A man there was of Levi's house,
Went, took *as wife a tender grouse*,
A daughter of Levi *as well*.

2 So the woman conceived *a spell*
And gave birth to a son. And when
She saw he *was a goodly ben*
She hid him three months. 3 But when she
Could no longer hide him *safely*,
She took an ark of bulrushes
For him, daubed it with slime, that is,
With asphalt and pitch, put the child
In it, and laid, *heart beating wild*,
In the reeds by the river's bank.

4 And his sister stood *at the flank*
Afar off, to know what would be
Done to him *on that river sea*.

The first point, my Beloved, that I would
make
Is that in crisis women seem to save
The day. It's the woman sticks neck out for
sake
Of male good fortune. Woman takes the
stave

And makes a basket, finds the slime and
pitch

And slides the safety airtight without stitch,
Or watertight as case may be. And when
She's done, she waits to scan the mouth of
den.

When women make the world by giving
birth

Men rule as kings and destroy what it's
worth.

When women save the world by making
ark,

Men shoot off deadly missiles in the dark.
Ah, since Judith women now take a part
In the destruction with an equal heart.

5 Then the daughter of Pharaoh came
Down to bathe at the river *tame*.

And her maids walked along the side
Of the river, and when she spied
The ark among the reeds, she sent
(In curiosity well meant)

Her maid to get it. 6 And when she
Had opened *it*, she saw the *wee*
Child, and indeed, the baby wept.
And *great* compassion on him *crept*
Into her heart, and she said "This
Is one of the Hebrews' amiss."

7 Then his sister said to Pharaoh's
Daughter, "Shall I go and who knows
Call a nurse for you from Hebrew
Women to nurse the child for you?"

8 And Pharaoh's daughter said to her,
"Go." So the maiden went *demur*

And *quickly* called the child's mother.

9 Then Pharaoh's daughter said to her,
"Take this child and nurse him for me,
And I'll give *you* your wages *free*."

So the woman took the child and
Nursed him. 10 And so the child grew, and
She brought him to Pharaoh's daughter,
And he was her son *princelier*.

So she called his name Moses, saying
"Since I drew him from water *straying*."

The sorrow of the world is that it takes
A vision of the babe before it wakes
To its humanity. But those who wait
To be touched to the quick by tears and
fears

Must also satisfy themselves with state

That first creates tears while it shuts its ears.

One does not right the wrong to follow heart

And loving thoughts compassionate in part.
One rights the wrong by going to the core
And knowing every "I" is divine shore.
Reacting is too late that moves the groan,
And Pharaoh's girl, instead of one alone,
Might have saved thousands more had she not waited

To be moved by the one in ark instated.

11 Now it happened that in those days,
When Moses was grown *in his ways*,
That he went out to his brothers
To see their burdens, *what occurs*.
And he saw an Egyptian beating
A Hebrew brother *and defeating*.
12 So he looked this way and that way,
And when he saw no one, he killed
The Egyptian and hid him *filled*
In the sand. 13 And when he went out
The second day, indeed, no doubt,
Two Hebrew men were fighting, and
He said to the one in whose hand
Was wrong, "Why did you strike your friend?"

14 Then he said "Who set you to tend
Judgement on us and be a prince?
Do you intend *without a wince*
To kill me as you killed Egyptian?"
So Moses almost had conniption,
He feared and said "This thing is known!"
15 When Pharaoh heard the matter *shown*,
He sought to kill Moses. But he
Fled from the face of Pharaoh's lea
And stayed in Midian's land, and he
Sat down beside a well *for tea*.

The first thing Moses does to set up right
Is kill a man when there's no one in sight.
Perhaps it was Your will, Beloved, and I
Shall not say Moses disobeyed Your cry.
I only say this first perception's wrong,
That killing solves the problem in the long.
To crucify someone in Middle East
Does not right wrongs or help things in the least.

It may pave better access to the oil,
But does not heal the broken towers in toil
On New York's skyline. Moses will live to

Learn something he can teach the world to do

For justice and for peace, but it will take
Forty years in the desert for sheep's sake.

16 Now the priest of Midian had seven
Daughters. And they came *at eleven*
And drew water, and filled the troughs
To water their father's flock's *maws*.
17 Then the shepherds came and drove them

Away, but Moses *raised his hem*,
Stood up and helped them, and watered
Their flock. 18 When they came *with the herd*

To Reuel their father, he said "How
Did you come back so quickly now?"
19 And they said "An Egyptian came
And saved us from the shepherds' claim,
And he also drew water for
Us and watered the flock, *what's more*."
20 So he said to his daughters, "And
Where *is* he? Why did you remand
The man? Call him, that he may eat
Bread *while you all recount the feat*."
21 Then Moses was content to live
With the man who agreed to give
Zipporah his daughter *as wife*
To Moses *for the rest of life*.
22 And she bore *him* a son, and he
Called his name Gershom, because he
Said, "I have been a stranger in
A foreign land *for my great sin*."

While Israel was in heathen Egypt's land,
The faith of Abraham burned bright in hand
Of his wife Keturah's children's descent.
They kept the faith pure wherever they went.

The priest of Midian taught Moses the law
That he would promulgate without a flaw
At Sinai after hearing Your voice rumble
In bass and descant and across the tumble
Of desert rock. What seemed a great mistake

Preventing Moses fighting for the sake
Of his people in fact brought him to hear
The Abrahamic stories by the cheer
Of evening fire before the desert tent.
Beloved, You guided Moses where he went.

23 Now in process of time it came
 To pass the king of Egypt died.
 Then Israel's folk groaned *in the frame*
 Of their bondage, and then they cried
 Out, and *the sound of their cry* came
 Up to Alohim for the blame.
 24 So Alohim heard of their groaning,
 And Alohim remembered *owning*
 His covenant with Abraham,
 With Isaac, and Jacob *in pram*.
 25 And Alohim looked *down* upon
 The children of Israel, *by swan*
 Alohim gave His benison.

When one bad president goes out at last
 We're certain that the calumny is past.
 Instead new concepts in oppression rise
 That were not imagined here otherwise.
 The king died and a new king rose instead
 And they found worse was possible ahead.
 And so those who have breath still in the
 wind
 Moan, groan, and groaning moan though
 disciplined.
 You hear, Beloved, the groaning of the
 weak
 That are despised for weakness as I speak.
 And though as yet no lightning bolt saves
 all,
 Your benison glows in Your silent call
 To king and slave to raise their eyes to You
 Who are both powerful and just and true.

Exodus 3

1 Now Moses was tending the flock
 Of Jethro his father-in-law,
 The priest of Midian. And the flock
 He led behind the desert, and
 Came to Horeb, Alohim's *land*
Of mountain. 2 And while there he saw
 The Angel of YHWH came to him
 In flame of fire *instead of hymn*
 And from a bush. He looked indeed,
 The bush was burning *but unfreed*
 In flames, and yet *was* not consumed.
 3 Then Moses said "I have presumed
 To turn aside and see this great
 Sight, why the bush meets no vile fate."

Your angel, my Beloved, before and since
 Has come to call a prophet, some may
 wince

And some turn round with curiosity.
 It just depends on what form they may see.
 The angel that appears in fearsome pose
 Awakes the would-be prophet from his
 doze
 To fear and tremble at the heavenly vision.
 The call to Moses came with that precision
 That so marks Your advent. The angel form
 Was burning bush that failed the public
 norm
 By simply not burning to ash and cinder.
 And Moses went to see the angel tinder.
 You call Your prophets each in his own
 way,
 And each sees angels somewhere on
 display.

4 So when YHWH saw he turned aside
 To look, *the angel to confide*
 Of Alohim called to him from
 The midst of the bush *with aplomb*
 And said "Moses, Moses!" And he
 Said "Here I am *and here I be.*"
 5 Then He said "Do not draw near here.
 Take off your sandals, *stand in fear*,
 For where you're standing's holy tier."
 6 And He said, words of Alohim,
 "I *am* the God *that you esteem*
 Of your father, of Abraham,
 The God of Isaac, too, I am,
 And the God of Jacob." And Moses
 Hid his face, for his fearing rose as
 Looking there upon Alohim.

It seems to take off shoe shows one's
 respect
 For messenger of God and the elect.
 I too take off my shoes and bow to earth,
 And like the prophets cast all of my worth
 Upon the dust. The flaming of Your love
 Burns here before me in the rooms above
 My chambered heart of stone. The unseen
 flame
 Sears through my weary reticence and
 shame
 And lifts my soul in drunken ecstasy,
 Both chained in You and yet forever free.
 I hide my face, but not for shame or fear,
 But only to reveal that You are here.
 My love will not allow another face
 To share Your sacred time and holy place.

7 And YHWH said "I have surely seen
Oppression of My folk who've *been*
In Egypt, and have heard their cry
Because of their taskmasters' *fly*,
For I know their sorrows *and why*.

8 "So I have come down to deliver
Them out of hand of the *misgiver*
Egyptians, and to bring them up
From that land to a *well-filled cup*,
A good and large land, to a land
Flowing with milk and honey, and
To the place of the Canaanites
And the Hittites and Amorites
And Perizzites and the Hivites
And to the land of Jebusites.

9 "Now therefore, see, the children's cry
Of Israel has passed Me by,
And I have also seen oppression
With which Egyptians make aggression.

10 "Come now, therefore, and I will send
You to Pharaoh that you may *spend*
Yourself to bring My people out,
Israel's folk from Egypt *in rout*."

Beloved, when You see something must be
done,

Instead of doing it under the sun,
Especially when it takes courage, too,
You always send someone to act and do.
You only work a miracle for those
Who step out in the void bare feet and toes.
So You send Moses back into the nest
To clear the brush and work hard at his
best,

And when all fails and he's back to the
wall,

Then You step in and work a miracle.
No harm is there in that if only You
Always stepped in to help the tried and
true.

But mostly the courageous rise to die
Remembering the Exodus and why.

11 But Moses said to Alohim,
"Who *am* I and that I should seem
To go to Pharaoh, and that I
Should bring Israel's folk by the by
Out of Egypt?" 12 And so He said
"I'll certainly be with you led.
And this *shall be* a sign to you
That I have sent you: for when you
Have brought the folk out of Egypt,

You shall serve Alohim *well tipped*
On this mountain *known but to few*."

13 Then Moses said to Alohim,
"Indeed, *when* I come *for esteem*
To Israel's folk and say to them,
'The God of your fathers and gem
Has sent me to you,' and they say
To me, 'What *is* His name, *we pray*?'
What shall I have for them to say?"

14 And Alohim said to Moses,
"I am who I am. *Just say this*."
And He said "Thus you shall say to
The children of Israel *and crew*,
'I am has just sent me to you.'"

15 Moreover Alohim said to
Moses, "This is what you shall say
To Israel's folk *upon that day*,
'YHWH God of your fathers, the God
Of Abraham, of Isaac, God
Of Jacob, has sent me to you.
This *is* My name forever, and
For Me memorial to stand.'

Beloved, You are the only who has right
To say "I am." There's no other in sight.
And so You have the right to give Your
sign

After the thing is done that You design.
That very thing shows that You are divine,
And unencumbered by both space and time.
If You were like us, You would know the
rhyme

That we need signs beforehand in the rush,
To give us courage here to meet the crush.
You give Your sign that You are with me
after

I face the music in Your name, and
laughter.

You are the one great I and God of all
The fathers of all men who stop to call
On Your name, so I do with breeze and
brawl.

16 "Go and gather the elders of
Israel together *as above*,
And say to them, 'YHWH God of your
Fathers, God of Abraham, more,
Of Isaac, and of Jacob, came
Appearing to me *without blame*,
And said "I have visited you
And surely *seen* what's done to you
In Egypt, 17 "and I've said I will

Bring you up from the *bitter pill*
Of affliction in Egypt to
The country of the Canaanites
And the Hittites and Amorites
And Perizzites and the Hivites
And Jebusites, to a land flowing
With milk and honey *in bestowing*."
18 "Then they will heed your voice, and
you

Shall come, you and the elders too
Of Israel, to Egyptian king,
And you shall say to him *this thing*,
'YHWH God of the Hebrews has met
With us, and now, please, let us get
Three days' journey into the *land*
Of wilderness, that *by command*
We'll sacrifice to YHWH our God.'
19 "But I am sure that *as he trod*
The king of Egypt will not let
You go, not even *with heart set*
And by a mighty hand *well met*.
20 "So I'll stretch out My hand and strike
Egypt with all My wonders like
I will do in its midst, and after
That he will let you go, *no laughter*.
21 "And I will give this people favour
In sight of the Egyptians *slaver*,
And it shall be, when you go, that
You'll not go empty-handed, *flat*.
22 "But every woman shall ask of
Her nearest neighbour, namely, of
Her who dwells near her house, to give
Both silver things *to fugitive*,
And gold, and clothing, and you shall
Put *them* on your sons' *punctual*
And on your daughters. So you shall
Plunder Egyptians' *arsenal*."

Beloved, You might have just created gold
And silver to give to Your folk of old.
Why did they have to take the lot from
neighbour
To pay for their decades of slaving labour?
The chances are they took from innocent
And not the beneficiaries meant.
I know the thing was meant in justice'
claim,
But it still bothers me now just the same.
Does arbitrary vengeance satisfy?
That is the wicked terrorist's reply.
But then few can tell what the difference
Is between terrorist and folk of sense

Who rule the cabinet and parliament.
I flee to You, Beloved, from Your own
rent.

Exodus 4

1 Then Moses answered and said "But
Suppose they will not believe what
I say or listen to my voice,
Suppose they say *on their invoice*,
'That YHWH has not appeared to you.'
2 So YHWH said to him, "What's that you
Have in your hand?" He said "A rod."
3 And He said "Cast it on the sod."
So he cast it on the ground, and
It was a serpent *by command*
And Moses fled from it. 4 Then YHWH
Said to Moses, "Reach out your hand
And take *it* by the tail, *please do*,"
And he reached out his hand and caught
It, and it was a rod *for naught*
In hand *once more*, 5 "that they may know
That YHWH God of their fathers' *show*,
The God of Abraham, the God
Of Isaac, Jacob's God *by rod*
Has come appearing here to you."

Since Serpent-Watcher in the tree appeared
The serpent worship of the world has
geared

For progress and for spreading in the state.
It once defiled dear Yemen and its mate
Beloved Axum, and every clown that stood
Before the Pharaoh with a rod there could
Cast down the rod and make a serpent coil.
You give to Moses a rod that can spoil
Magician's tricks, and yet such tricks are
faint

To turn magician into proper saint.
Serpent is serpent, magic magic still,
Though some be greater for the good or ill.
I too flee from the serpent and to You
I turn my fears and loves for what You do.

6 Then YHWH said to him, "Now put your
Hand in your bosom." As before
He put his hand in his bosom,
And when he took it out, *in sum*,
His hand *was* leprous, like the snow.
7 And He said "Put your hand *one go*
In your bosom again." And so
He put his hand again in there,
And drew it out again as fair

It was restored like his own flesh.

There is no worshipper of leprosy,
And so this sign is such one cannot see
Among the priests of Egypt and of Rome.
It's only Moses has a hand at home
Both with disease and with the glow of
health.

Until modern warfare there was no wealth
In causing sickness, only in the healing.
It must be progress now with which we're
dealing.

I put my hand also upon my heart
With fingers tucked beneath the cloth in
part

In sign or not that I bow down to You
And take my vows for faith in what I do.
The secret sign returns upon the flesh
Where love and fear for You always
enmesh.

8 "Then it will be, if they *get fresh*
And don't believe you, don't give heed
To the message of the first deed,
That they believe the message of
The latter sign, *as given above*.
9 "And it shall be, if they do not
Believe even these two *you're taught*,
Or listen to your voice, that you
Shall take water from the *bayou*
Of the river and pour it on
The dry *land*. And the *Amazon*
Which you take from the river will
Become blood on the dry *land still*."

The turning of the water into blood
Is sign of longest standing on the mud.
The gate of water may put out the fire
Of my love seeking and all my desire,
But still the vision of this awful thing
Reminds me I am glad not to be king.
After the air I search most for the drink
That I need hour by hour and not to sink.
Both air and water in my coursing veins
Turn into blood and into bleeding stains.
Water on earth, awareness on obeying,
Awakens blood and fire is what I'm saying.
I turn from all things, images and sign
To You alone, and so forget the wine.

10 Then Moses said to YHWH, "O my
Lord, I'm not eloquent, foreby,

Neither before nor since You spoke
To Your servant, but *I'm a bloke*
That's slow of speech and slow of tongue."

11 And YHWH said to him, "Who has
sung

Into being the mouth of man?
Who makes the mute, *say if you can*,
The deaf, the seeing, or the blind?

Have not I, YHWH, *Creator of*
Both speech and silence from above?

12 "Now therefore, go, and I will be
With your mouth and teach your decree
Of what to say." 13 But he said "O
My Lord, please send *and let him go*
Whoever *else* You may bestow."

14 Then YHWH's wrath kindled against
Moses,

And He said "Levite Aaron poses
As your brother? I know that he
Can truly speak well. Therefore see,
He's also coming out to meet
You. When he sees you *as a treat*,
He'll be glad in his heart *complete*."

15 "Now you shall speak to him and put
The words in his mouth, *foot by foot*.
And I will be with your mouth and
With his mouth, and I'll teach command
What you shall do. 16 "So he shall be
Your spokesman to the people, see.
And he himself shall be as mouth
For you, and you *come from the south*
Shall be to him as Alohim.

17 "And you shall take this rod *for beam*
In your hand, with which you shall do
Both signs and wonders not a few."

Two great concepts of You, Beloved, are
here
In Your speech to Moses who stands in
fear.

These two great concepts go forgotten by
The theologian, priest, and the rabbi
As well as by the mullah at the gate.
The first is that You are God to create
All speech and without divine leave there's
none,

Creator of the word without a son.
The second is that Godness means that You
Tell humankind what's right and wrong to
do.

I who have words so many, let me pray

That I shall from such human paths well
stray
That take the human heart for right and
wrong
And think it source of any divine song.

18 And Moses returned to Jethro
His father-in-law, told him so,
"Please let me go and return to
My brothers in Egypt, and see
Whether they're still alive *and free*."
And Jethro said to Moses, "Do
Go there in peace." 19 And then said
YHWH

To Moses in Midian, "Return
To Egypt, for the men who burn
To seek your life are dead, return."

20 Then Moses took his wife and sons
And set them on a donkey's *buns*,
And he returned to Egypt's land.
And Moses took by the command
Of Alohim his rod in hand.

21 And YHWH said to Moses, "When you
Go back to Egypt, see that you
Do all those wonders *in the land*
Of Pharaoh which I've in your hand.
But I will harden his heart, so
He will not let the people go.

22 "Then you shall say to Pharaoh, 'So
Says YHWH 'Israel's My son, My first.

23 "I say to you, let My son go
That he may serve Me, *not the worst*.
But if you do not let him go,
I truly will kill your son, your
Firstborn son *and your heir, what's*
more.""

Sweet Moses, I love more and more to see
That when he heard commands right
heavenly,

He still went to his wife's father to get
Permission for his journey and the set.
My heart wells up and surely with regret
My own wife's father no longer abides
That I might do him some such honour's
tides.

Meek Moses, make me, my Beloved, like
him

Before my hearing goes and eye grows
dim,

But give me not such messages of hate
To bear before the governors of state.

I should not like to bear the news in late
That some such prelate's son firstborn
should die.

Police on guard would have a question
why.

24 It came to pass upon the way,
At the inn that YHWH *for dismay*
Met him and sought to kill him *there*.

25 Then Zipporah took a sharp stone
And cut the foreskin off her son
And cast *it* at his feet, and said
"You truly are a bloody dread
To me!" 26 And so He let him go.
Then she said "*You're* a man of blood!"
Because of circumcision's *flood*.

Beloved, this text gives me to wonder why
The son of Moses missed the knifely try.
The Midianite was son of Abraham
And Arab as for sacred descent cam.
So circumcision was a thing well known
And should without neglect have been and
shown.

Perhaps the rite was acted in duress
To show that women as well as men bless
The world of action with obedience,
And cut by hand of woman makes good
sense

As well as that of man. She lacks good
grace

Though as she throws before her husband's
face

The bloody rests of her saving reaction.
The circumcision still creates a faction.

27 And YHWH said to Aaron, "Go to
The wilderness to meet *the crew*
Of Moses." So he went and met
Him on the mount of Alohim,
And kissed him *to show his esteem*.

28 So Moses told Aaron all that
YHWH said who'd sent him, and the bat
Of signs which He commanded him.

29 Then Moses and Aaron with him
Went and gathered together all
The elders of Israel *by call*.

30 And Aaron spoke all that YHWH said
To Moses. Then he did the spread
Of signs in sight of all the folk.

31 The people believed *what he spoke*,
And when they heard YHWH had come by

The children of Israel to spy
On their affliction, then they bowed
Their heads and worshipped *Him in crowd.*

The signs sufficed to make the Hebrew
slaves

Believe a saviour came and so behaves
One who might make the Pharaoh once
relent.

They believe at once Moses was one sent.
Perhaps old serpent worship did the trick,
Or white hand in the bosom. What must
stick

Each time is sight of blood. That still
proposes

Faith in the Christian follower of Moses,
Who thinks blood shed is better than the
good

You do, Beloved, each day in field and
wood.

Belief comes easily, with Aaron's speech
And Moses' wonder-working there to teach.
Let my belief arise in silence where
Your loving statutes still perfume the air.

Exodus 5

1 Afterward Moses and Aaron
Went in and told Pharaoh *anon*,
"Thus says YHWH God of Israel
'Let My people go *for a spell*,
That they may hold a feast to Me
There in the wilderness.'" 2 And he,
Pharaoh said "Who *is* YHWH, that I
Should obey His voice *on the sly*
To let go Israel? I do
Not *even* know YHWH *from my shoe*,
Nor will I say Israel adieu."

3 So they said "The God of Hebrews
Has met with us. *To pay our dues*,
Please, let us go three days' away
Into the desert there to *pray*
And sacrifice to YHWH our God,
Lest He fall on us with a *rod*
Of pestilence or with the sword
For failing to obey our Lord."

Not only did Moses lie to the king,
But claimed he spoke Your word to do the
thing.

The real intention was to leave the land
Never to come back to give them a hand.
So why this obfuscation? Are You Lord

Or must You too rely on lie and sword?
The powerless alone must lie to get
Their way. Who has the strength of arm to
set

His will need not hide his intention from
The king or populace. The people come
To You demanding truth in absolute.
Who in this world can bear the truth?

Dispute,

Refute, such talents are not rare. We lie
To be more comfortable beneath the sky.

Will You, Beloved, fall on the folk with
sword

Or pestilence who fail to be adored
With prayers and sacrifice? The pagan
thought

Might well do for the king who had been
taught

To deal in violence. Your law is done
In ten words, all the rest is worn for fun
Or fear or dear tradition of old time.
Religion's made of such tradition's rhyme.
Human authority must speak to such
Because it fears the truly divine touch
That must unmake the arm of man and
king.

That is the root and sum of everything.
I flee to You from faith and goodly speech
Where You and I know silently of each.

4 Then the king of Egypt told them,
"Moses and Aaron, *what's your game?*
Why take the people from their work?
Get to your labour, *do not shirk.*"

5 So then Pharaoh said "Look, the folk
Are many here that you convoke
In the land now to make them keep
The Sabbath instead of to sweep!"

6 So the same day Pharaoh commanded
The people's taskmasters remanded
And officers, saying 7 "You shall
No longer give folk *prodigal*
Straw to make brick as before now.
Let them go gather straw somehow
For themselves. 8 "And the tale of brick
They did before *their minds were sick*
You shall lay on them not diminished,
For they are idle, *when they've finished*,
Therefore they cry out, saying 'Let
Us go sacrifice God's banquet.'
9 "Let there more work be laid upon

The men, that they may labour on
And not regard vain antiphon."

The first thing Moses does to free the folk
Is command Sabbath be observed to stoke
The powers of spirit and of mind in slaves.
Result is seen in how the king behaves.
There's nothing that arouses wrath in those
Who sit on thrones like daring to suppose
There is a limit laid on human powers.
The Sabbath of the ten commands of ours
Is that which says the powerless have rights
Not to be cancelled by their own insights,
Much less by others. Rulers must feel free
To be the ones to grant soul's liberty,
And are insulted that such freedom is
Whether or not the crown is hers or his.

10 And the taskmasters of the folk
And their officers went and spoke
To the people, "Thus says Pharaoh:
'I will not give you straw. 11 ' But go,
Get yourselves straw where you can find it,
Diminish not your work behind it."
12 So the people were scattered out
Through all Egypt's land roustabout
To gather stubble for their straw.
13 And the taskmasters hasted *them*,
"Fulfil your work, *your* day's pro tem,
As when there was straw *on the draw*."
14 And officers of Israel's folk,
Whom Pharaoh's taskmasters awoke
To be over them, were beaten
And were asked, "Why have you not been
Fulfilling your task in making
Brick both yesterday and *to bring*
Today, as before, *for the king*?"

To observe Sabbath meant seven days of
toil
Were curtailed to but six upon the soil.
The fact is what was done in seven before
Could better work in six and not one more.
That's why an added task had to be found
To grind the Sabbath-keeper in the ground.
Sabbath observance inspires deepest hate
And reveals hidden fountains of the great
Malice that otherwise poses as love.
Proof against Sabbath will be showing of
The plagues on Egypt it results in bringing.
All disaster is thus the Sabbath's stinging,

And but affirms what Pharaoh thought was
true:
A king is not responsible to You.

15 Then the officers of the folk
Of Israel came and cried and spoke
To Pharaoh, "Why are you dealing
Thus with your servants? 16 "There's no
string
Of straw given to your servants,
And they tell us 'Make brick *like ants*!'
And indeed your servants *are* beaten,
But fault's what your *own* folk have eaten."
17 But he said "You *are* idle! Idle!
Therefore you say *as regicidal*,
'Let's go *and* sacrifice to YHWH.'
18 "Go therefore now, you've work to do,
For no straw shall be given you,
Deliver yet your bricks' tale, do."

The officers of Israel spoke sense
To Pharaoh and in the good king's
presence.
They said that added tasks could not be
done
In the same time as fewer under sun.
The concept is quite simple, take a jar
Of one litre and fill it up as far
As it will hold. Then take another cup
And try to fill the first and full jar up.
The water runs out on the table. This
Is scientific fact the king must miss.
Opposing Sabbath deprives men of reason
So when they're faced with facts within the
season,
They only answer "You are idle, idle."
That's why You use the day to show the
idol.

19 The officers of Israel's folk
Did see the evil that he spoke
"You'll not diminish from your bricks
You daily bring *instead of sticks*."
20 And they met Moses and Aaron
Who stood in the way they were on
As they came out from Pharaoh's *fawn*.
21 And they said to them, "Let YHWH
look
On you and judge, because you took
Trouble to make our smell abhorred
In Pharaoh's sight *who is our lord*
And in the sight of his servants,

To slay us in their hand with sword."
22 So Moses came to YHWH's *presence*
And said "Lord, why have You brought
evil
On this people? And like a weevil
You have sent me? 23 "For since I came
To Pharaoh to speak in Your name,
He has done evil to this folk,
Nor have You saved them as You spoke."

Moses and all the world besides are right
To come to You complaining of the blight
That Sabbath-keeping serves on those who
do

As You command. Obedience to You
Results in being killed by those who rule,
Perhaps not on this day but in some school.
All other things can hide beneath the sign
Of charity and loving hearts' sweet wine.
Who keep the Sabbath are accused some
day

Of one thing or another in the way
As pretext, insane pretext without proof
For why the disobedient are aloof.
I flee to You, Beloved, from their intent
And as a working slave fail to relent.

Exodus 6

1 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Now you
Shall see the thing that I will do
To Pharaoh. With a strong hand he
Will let them go, and it shall be
With a strong hand he'll drive them out
Of his land *with clamour and rout*."

Week 14

2 And Alohim spoke to Moses
And said to him "I'm YHWH *for this*.
3 "I appeared to Abraham, and
To Isaac, Jacob, *in the land*
As El El God Almighty, but
By My name YHWH I did not strut
Before them. 4 "I have also cut
My covenant with them, to give
Them the land of Canaan *to live*,
The land of their pilgrimage, in
Which they were strangers *or had been*.

If Your name YHWH was still unknown
before
You spoke to Moses on Nilotic shore,
Then all the stories I have read till now

Have been adjusted with that name
somehow.

The second of creation calls you YHWH
And so I've heard and spoken it as true
Since then as I recite Your lovely names.
No doubt all faith on earth today lays
claims

Of being brought down from Sinai's bright
flames,
And so all things before that great
announcement

Are rewritten in light of its pronouncement.
Rewrite my life as well, Beloved, to share
In every breath Your best names and repair
My emptinesses so that You are there.

5 "And I have also heard the groaning
Of the folk Egyptians were loaning
Of Israel to keep in bondage
With whip and lash and other frondage,
And I've remembered My treaty.

6 "Therefore say to Israel *for Me*:
'I am YHWH, I will bring you out
From under the Egyptians' clout,
I'll rescue you from their slavery,
And I'll redeem you with an arm
Outstretched and by great judgements'
harm.

7 'I'll take you as My people, and
I'll be your Alohim *and hand*.
Then you shall know that I am YHWH
Your Alohim who brings you through
Out from the things Egyptians do.

8 'And I will bring you to the land
Which I swore to give *by command*
To Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob,
And I will give it *when you wake up*
To you *as* heritage: I'm YHWH."
9 So Moses spoke thus to the folk
Of Israel, but they were *as oak*
In anguish of spirit and cruel
Bondage, and did not heed *the rule*
That Moses *in their favour spoke*.

At one stroke You, Beloved, could take the
whole
Of Egypt and divide it in a bowl,
Set one beyond the Nile and one in land
Of Canaan and let both of them there stand.
What is the sense of bringing one through
toil
And slavery to cringe upon the soil,

And then another through rebellious hate
Only to have the plagues rain on his pate?
That you tell the slave trouble's coming on
The one who wields the whip and lash at
dawn

Takes nothing from its sting. You have no
skin

And therefore do not feel the pinch we're
in.

Beloved, in skin I still turn to Your name
In hope and comfort before timely game.

10 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said

11 "Go in, tell Pharaoh *and the dread*

King of Egypt to let the folk

Of Israel go out of his land."

12 And Moses spoke before *the hand*

Of YHWH, saying "The children of

Israel have not heeded my *shove*.

How then shall Pharaoh heed me, for
Uncircumcised lips are my *score*?"

13 Then YHWH spoke to Moses and

Aaron,

And gave them a command *not barren*

For the children of Israel and

For Pharaoh king of Egypt's *land*,

To bring the folk of Israel out

Of the land of Egypt *in rout*.

Moses thinks that the humble and the good
Have not listened to his word as they
should,

How then will powerful and proud relent
To hear unwanted words when he is sent?

In this Moses errs in the principle.

The humble and the proud have both in full

Capacity to turn from Your names grace

And hide themselves before the divine face.

Oppressor and oppressed of this in hand,

Both ignore mercy and divine command.

From breath to breath illusion can create

The veils to hide the blessed human state.

I flee to You, Beloved, from power and
weakness

To You, and You alone, and Your
uniqueness.

14 These *are* the chiefs of the houses
Of their ancestors *and roses*:

The sons of Reuben, the firstborn

Of Israel, *were* Hanoch *his horn*,

Pallu, Hezron, and Carmi. These

Are families of Reuben *to please*.

15 And the sons of Simeon *were there*,

All six of them and all as fair,

Jemuel, Jamin, Ohad, Jachin,

Zohar, and Shaul the son *for spleen*

Of a Canaanite woman. These

Are families of Simeon *at ease*.

16 These *are* the names of Levi's sons

According to generations:

Gershon, Kohath, and Merari.

The years of the life of Levi

Were one hundred and thirty-seven,

Lived on the earth and not in heaven.

Of twelve tribes only three are given here,

And in this short list I find there appear

The three firstborn and yet the three most
hated:

Reuben, unstable, for an act ill-mated,

And Simeon and Levi who were scattered

For angry slaughter in a thing that
mattered.

The wilful strong come always to the fore

Admired for leadership who force the door.

Yet these are set aside, three gates well
tried,

For Judah's praise, whose name was well
applied.

The lives of these three give the other p's

Of prayer in penance, plaint, petition, these

With praise make up the life of faithful
prayer

In all the gates, earth, water, fire and air.

17 The sons of Gershon *were* Libni

And Shimi by each family.

18 And the sons of Kohath: Amram,

Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel.

And the years of Kohath's life *well*

Were one hundred and thirty-three,

Forty-two less than Abraham.

19 These *were* the sons of Merari:

Two boys Mahali and Mushi.

These the families of Levi

By their generations *go by*.

Again three sons step forward to relate

The first three gates and with each one its
state.

Gershon for law is exile, which is known

By everyone who follows law alone.

Korah, the gathering, is named for love

That follows law up to the gate above.
 Awareness comes with Merari whose is
 The bitterness of knowing truly His.
 The three deficient ones are perfect by
 The eight sons of truth they get in reply.
 Their names and their responses in the sly
 Are secrets known only to innocent.
 Hold back, Beloved, the secrets where they
 went
 Until the bright illusions are all spent.

Gershon the law brings forth Libni the pure
 And Shimi, the sema' or hearing sure.
 The gate of love, Kohath, brings forth the
 four
 Expressions of love's truth creating door.
 Amram is folk exalted, cast upon
 Your loving kindness from the rosy dawn.
 Izhar is shining and Hebron alliance
 Between Beloved and soul without
 defiance.
 Love's last truth is Uzziel, God's my
 strength,
 And so love is truth's happy breadth and
 length.
 Mahli and Mushi are the bitter fruit
 Of knowing, that's why true faith gets the
 boot.
 The mild and drawing out are truth's last
 goal,
 Beloved, and not the doing for the whole.

20 Now Amram took Jochebed for
 Himself, his father's sister's score,
 As wife, and she's the one who bore
 Him Aaron and Moses, *no mention*
Of Miriam comes in this recension.
 The years of Amram's life *were* one
 Hundred and thirty-seven *done*.
 21 The sons of Izhar *were* Korah,
 Nepheg, and Zichri, *plethora*.
 22 And the sons of Uzziel *be*
 Mishaël, Elzaphan, and Zithri.
 23 Aaron took to himself as wife
 Elisheba, the daughter of
 Amminadab, *a wife for life*,
 Sister of Nahshon (*not above*),
 And she bore him Nadab, Abihu,
 Eleazar, Ithamar, *all I knew*.
 24 But Korah's sons *were* Assir and
 Elkanah, Abiasaph's *stand*.
 These are the families *by rights*

Of *Izhar's sons* the Korahites.
 25 Eleazar, Aaron's son, took for
 Himself one of the daughters *store*
 Of Putiel as wife, she bore
 Him Phinehas. These *are* the heads
 Of the fathers' houses *and spreads*
 Of the Levites by families' *threads*.

The third of three series of three comes
 here
 Beloved, where three wives blessed at last
 appear.
 The first is Jochebed, mother, great aunt
 Of Moses and Aaron, whose name is grant
 That YHWH is glory. My beloved, be
 mine.
 The second wife is Elisheba, fine
 Name meaning my God's oath, and so Your
 glory
 Gives rise to promises of grace and story.
 The third wife's name's a secret, daughter
 of
 Putiel, God illuminates in love.
 The secret here unstated is the wife
 Of Moses, the fourth gate of real life,
 Whose name's Zipporah, sparrow, that
 shows me
 Truth's not deep thoughts but mere
 simplicity.

26 These *are the same* Aaron and Moses
 To whom YHWH said "Bring out the
 roses,
 Children of Israel from the land
 Of Egypt each and every band."
 27 These *are* the ones who spoke to
 Pharaoh
 The king of Egypt *to the marrow*,
 To bring from Egypt Israel's folk.
 These Moses and Aaron *both spoke*.
 28 It came to pass upon the day
 YHWH spoke to Moses in the way
 In Egypt's land, 29 that YHWH spoke
 saying
 To Moses, *who had not stopped praying*,
 "I *am* YHWH. Speak to Pharaoh king
 Of Egypt when I say the thing."
 30 But Moses said to YHWH, "Indeed,
 I *am* of uncircumcised lips,
 And how shall Pharaoh hear or heed
 Me *who is without guns and ships*?"

There is a thought that one must have some
 power
 To do a good thing in the witching hour.
 Reflection's false, the truth is that alone
 Good's done by powerless and to the bone.
 Since power itself is an evil thing
 When given to the pauper or the king,
 It follows that whatever's done with power
 Lacks goodness for its rate and for its
 tower.
 Indeed, Pharaoh shall not hear what I say,
 Because I have no power on him to play,
 But that is just the good part of my game.
 My strength could only suit me to my
 blame.
 Beloved, let me like You be goodness still
 And let the power reign until its fill.

Exodus 7

1 So YHWH said to Moses, "Behold,
 I've made you alohim to old
 Pharaoh, and Aaron your brother
 Shall be your prophet *and concur*.
 2 "You shall speak all that I command
 You. Aaron your brother shall *stand*
 To speak to Pharaoh to send out
 Israel's folk from his land about.
 3 "And I will harden Pharaoh's heart,
 And multiply My signs and *art*,
 My wonders here in Egypt's land.
 4 "But Pharaoh will not *understand*
 Or heed you, so that I may lay
 My hand on Egypt, *no delay*,
 And bring My armies *and* My people,
 Israel's folk, out from under steeple
 Of Egypt by great judgements done.
 5 "The Egyptians shall have begun
 To know that I *am* YHWH, when I
 Stretch out My hand on Egypt's *sky*
 And bring out Israel's folk from them."
 6 Then Moses and Aaron condemn
 Not to follow YHWH's just command
 To *meet Pharaoh and to withstand*.
 7 And Moses *was* eighty years old
 And Aaron *eighty-three and bold*
 When they spoke to Pharaoh *to scold*.

At last You tell the plan, Beloved, of what
 You'll do to Pharaoh, and how You will
 shut
 His heart up in its hardness to refuse
 To let the people go to where You choose.

It's rare You make such brittle revelations.
 More often You let people's agitations
 Run their own course in silence. Moses
 should
 Be grateful to know that You're planning
 good.
 I only ask, did You give Pharaoh choice
 In his refusal not to hear Your voice?
 And if You did or if You did not, why
 Did You require permission from the guy?
 Take Israel out directly, leave the bloke
 To stew and smoulder till he has a stroke.

8 Then YHWH spoke to Moses and Aaron,
 Saying 9 "When Pharaoh raises clarion,
 Saying 'Show for yourselves a miracle
And make your message more empirical,'
 Then you shall say to Aaron, 'Take
 Your rod and cast for Pharaoh's sake,
And so let it become a snake."
 10 So Moses and Aaron went in
 To Pharaoh, and they did to win
 Just as YHWH had commanded them.
 And Aaron *in the stratagem*
 Cast down his rod before Pharaoh
 And before his servants *to show*,
 And it became a snake *to go*.
 11 But Pharaoh also called the wise
 Men and the sorcerers in guise
 Of magicians of Egypt, they
 Also did in like manner *sway*
 With their enchantments. 12 Every man
 Threw down his rod, and they *by plan*
 Became serpents. But Aaron's rod
 Swallowed up their rods *like a clod*.
 13 And Pharaoh's heart grew hard, and he
 Did not heed them, by YHWH's decree.

You never give a sign, Beloved, but what
 There's explanation for the doubter's but.
 You might as well give ne'er a sign at all
 And just expect the troupe to heed Your
 call.

The human mind can always find a trail
 To make ambiguous and without fail
 The clear word You proclaim upon the
 mount,

Beside the river, or in Pharaoh's count.
 I flee to You from choices that contrast
 And yet give no sign clearly which is fast.
 The true and false may both produce the
 snake,

And who can know which one of them is
fake
Despite the appetite that one displays.
A bigger stomach's no proof of Your ways.

14 So YHWH said to Moses "Pharaoh's
Heart *is* hard, and *harder it grows*
Refusing to let people go.

15 "Go to Pharaoh at morning's *show*,
When he goes out to the water,
And you shall stand there *grimlier*
By the river's bank to meet him,
And the rod which was turned *by whim*
Into a serpent you shall take

In your hand. 16 "And you shall *awake*
To say to him, 'YHWH Alohim
Of the Hebrews has sent, *I deem*,
Me to you, saying "Let My people
Go, that they may serve *without steeple*
Me in the wilderness," indeed,
Until now you just would not heed!

17 "Thus says YHWH "By this you shall
know

That I *am* YHWH. Indeed, I'll go
And strike the waters which *are* in
The river with the rod that's in
My hand, and they'll be turned to blood.

18 "And the fish that *are* in the flood
Shall die, the river shall stink, and
The Egyptians will loathe the sand
To drink the water of the river.""

19 YHWH spoke to Moses *to deliver*,
"Say to Aaron , 'Take your rod and
Stretch out on Egypt's waters' hand,
Over their streams, over their rivers,
Over their ponds, and over sievers
Of all their pools of water, that
They may become blood *where they're at*.
And there shall be blood throughout all
The land of Egypt, both in *haul*
Of wood and in *pitchers of stone*.""

20 And Moses and Aaron *alone*
Did just as YHWH commanded them.
He lifted the rod's *diadem*
And struck the waters that *were* in
The river, in Pharaoh's sight, in
The sight of his servants. And all
The waters in the river's *sprawl*
Were turned to blood. 21 The fish that *were*
In the river died *silenter*,
The river stank, and the Egyptians
Could not drink water *by prescriptions*

From the river. So there was blood
Throughout all Egypt's land *for cud*.

You accept that the earthly ruler's word
Must be had before Your own and
preferred
Can lift a hand or foot obeying You.
And yet insist, without further ado,
On humbling the king and his right to rule.
Accept his right or cast aside the fool.
Why make the confused people drink the
blood

That seeps up from the river's staining
mud?

If You do this to prove idolatry
Is uncourageous in reality,
The proof lies unaccepted despite fate
Of death and all destruction for its mate.
If man cannot drink blood, then why should
gods

Takes too much brain to think despite Your
prods.

22 Then the magicians of the land
Of Egypt did so *by command*
Of their enchantments, and Pharaoh's
Heart grew hard *and harder*, he chose
Not to heed them, as YHWH had said.

23 And Pharaoh turned away *in dread*
And went into his house. His heart
Remained unmoved *by Aaron's part*.

24 So the Egyptians dug around
The river looking *in the ground*
For drinking water, because they
Could not drink water from the bay.

25 And seven days passed after YHWH
Had struck the river *and bayou*.

In my idolatry I dig around
The bloody edges of the wind-cursed
ground.

I do not doubt the Nile is still the vein
And artery of gods in sky and plain.
The bright illusions of creation's face
Are all that human mind and heart can
trace,

And so the best in my theologies
Is something hard to give up for no cheese.
Beloved, I leave my digging tool and book
And flee to You alone! See, I forsook
The well-thought trinities of gods I knew,
And they indeed, those gods, are not a few.

I cling to You alone, One and unknown,
Because You are not made of blood and
stone.

Exodus 8

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, "Go to
Pharaoh and tell him, 'Thus says YHWH,
'Let My people go, that they may
Serve Me. 2 "But if you block their way,
Indeed, I will smite all your land
With frogs. 3 "And so the river sand
Shall bring forth frogs abundantly,
Which shall go up and come freely
Into your house, into your room,
Upon your bed, *in your costume*,
Into the houses of your servants,
On your people, for your observance,
Into oven and kneading bowl.
4 "And the frogs shall come on your soul,
On your people, on all your servants.'""
5 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, "Say to
Aaron, 'Stretch out without ado
And tend your rod over the streams,
Over rivers, over ponds' *gleams*,
And cause frogs to come up upon
The land of Egypt *before dawn*.'"
6 So Aaron stretched out his hand over
The waters of Egypt, and rover
Frogs came up and covered the land
Of Egypt. 7 The magicians' hand
Of their enchantments did so too,
And brought up frogs *and not a few*
On the land of Egypt. 8 Then Pharaoh
Called *to come faster than an arrow*
Both Moses and Aaron, and said
"Entreat YHWH that He may *be led*
To take away the frogs from me
And from my people and country,
And I will let the people go,
That they may sacrifice to YHWH."
9 And Moses said to Pharaoh, "May
Ali be honoured! When, I pray,
Shall I intercede for you, for
Your servants, and your people *more*,
To destroy the frogs from you and
Your houses, *that they may leave land*,
Remaining in the river strand?"

Beloved, destroy the frogs from me and
mine,
The frogs of unbelief as well as wine
Of false belief, and honoured be Ali

Whom You appointed at Ghadir to be
The Prophet's viceroy and the one to speak
In favour of Your law, defend the weak,
And raise the banner of the Unity
Of God as one, Muhammad and Ali.
Some flatter kings and bow before their
reign,
And greet them with the finest words in
vain,
For none of them seek justice nor attain
To right rule in a world of loss and gain.
But Moses greets the king with right
submission
To God's appointed. Let that be my
mission.

10 And he said "Tomorrow." And he
Said "According to your word be,
That you may know that *there is none*
Like YHWH our Alohim *when done*.
11 "And the frogs shall depart from you,
From your houses, *though not a few*,
From your servants, and from your folk
To stay in the river *and croak*."
12 Then Moses and Aaron went out
From Pharaoh. And Moses cried out
To YHWH concerning frogs which He
Had brought against Pharaoh *in glee*.
13 And YHWH did by the word of Moses.
And the frogs died out of the houses,
Out of the villages and fields.
14 They gathered together their yields
In heaps, and the land stank. 15 But when
Pharaoh saw that there was relief,
He hardened his heart once again
And did not heed them *in their grief*,
Just as YHWH had said *to be brief*.

You leave the stinking refuse of what's
done
Of evil here beneath the blistering sun
So that I do not think illusion's fun
Will disappear like magic when I wake.
Though all the world is just a dream of
cake,
The waking is a stench for many's sake.
You might have had Moses wave magic
wand
Once more to rid the world of what it
donned.
Instead You make reality a stroke
On dearest senses of the blessed folk.

You may or may not bring the cursing
frogs,
But when You've done with miracles and
cogs,
It's human hands pick up the pickled freight
And human nostrils quivering at the gate.

16 So YHWH said to Moses, "Say to
Aaron, 'Stretch out your rod, *please do*,
And strike the dust of the land, so
That it may become lice *to grow*
Throughout all Egypt's land *and show*.'" 17
And they did so. For Aaron stretched
Out his hand with his rod and fetched
A strike upon the dust of earth,
And it was lice on man and beast,
All the land's dust was lice for berth
Throughout all Egypt's land *at least*.
18 And the magicians in a trice
With their enchantments to make lice
Tried but they could not, so there were
Lice in man's *hair* and in beast's *fur*.
19 And the magicians said to Pharaoh,
"This is Alohim's finger's *arrow*."
But Pharaoh's heart grew hard, and he
Did not heed them, by YHWH's decree.

I wonder if magicians have the wit
To make appear frogs that could stink a bit.
I doubt they stayed but only disappeared.
It's only You can make a frog that's feared.
But they could make no tiny lice at all
No matter how they tried to seek and call.
Because they met something they could not
do,
They said it had to be the hand of YHWH.
How faintly trite the argument goes round,
That I'm the fanciest thing to be found.
Pharaoh is not so motionless of mind,
But recognizes better magic's kind.
That's why his heart is hard before the sight
Of what You do, Beloved, both day and
night.

20 And YHWH said to Moses, "Rise up
Early in the morning and stand
Before Pharaoh who brings his cup
Out to the water. Make demand
'Thus says YHWH, "Let My people go,
That they may serve Me. 21 "Or else *know*,
If you'll not let My people go,
Indeed, I'll send swarms on you and

Your servants, your folk *in the land*
And in your houses. Houses of
The Egyptians shall swarm above
And on the ground on which they *stand*.

22 "And in that day I'll set apart
The land of Goshen, where *my heart*,
My people live, that no swarms shall
Be there, that you may *prodigal*
Know that I'm YHWH within the land.
23 "I'll make a difference by command
Between My people and your folk.
Tomorrow this sign shall provoke.""
24 And YHWH did so. Thick swarms of
flies

Came into Pharaoh's house *and eyes*,
Into his servants' houses, and
Into all the Egyptians' land.
The land was spoiled because *the flies*
In swarms *covered both earth and skies*.

The king like all men is powerless before
Swarms of flies or anything at the door.
A brave man can face strength and cunning
show,

But swarms of insects are another row.
And yet the miracle is nothing sure.
Science can always find, if not a cure,
At least an explanation of the kind.
The seeker loses fruit to taste the rind.
Whatever happens might be act of God
Or such blind fate with steady step and
plod.

The messages themselves are nothing but
The suffering and not the why for what.
I understand Pharaoh whose constant song
Can never reach the certainty of wrong.

25 Then Pharaoh called for Moses and
Aaron, and said "Go *by command*,
Sacrifice to God in the land."

26 And Moses said "It is not right
To do so, for we would in sight
Of the Egyptians sacrifice
Abomination for YHWH's price
Who is our Alohim. If we
Slay the abomination's fee
Of the Egyptians in their eyes,
Will they not stone us *by surprise*?

27 "We will go three days' journey in
The wilderness *where we have been*
And sacrifice to YHWH our God
As He'll command us *where to tread*."

28 And Pharaoh said "I'll let you go,
 That you may sacrifice *and show*
 To YHWH your Alohim there in
 The wilderness *to peregrine*,
 Only don't go too far away,
 And think of me too when you pray."
 29 Then Moses said "Indeed I go
 Out from you, and I'll *a propos*
 Entreat YHWH, that the swarms depart
 Tomorrow from *both bread and tart*
Of Pharaoh, from his servants, and
 From his people. But let Pharaoh
 Not deal deceitfully once more
 In not letting the people go
 Sacrifice to YHWH and implore."
 30 So Moses went out from Pharaoh
 And entreated YHWH *on the go*.
 31 And YHWH did by the word of Moses,
 Removing swarms *of flies from noses*
Of Pharaoh, from his servants, and
 His folk till none stayed in the land.
 32 But Pharaoh hardened his heart at
 This time also, from where they sat
 He would not let the people scat.

The king asks that the worshipper might
 share
 Petition for his sake within the prayer.
 That's why today in every church you find
 Prayers offered for the government, though
 blind.
 The hardened heart knows to confess in
 praise
 The worship of a dozen gods and ways.
 The king's hypocrisy finds a contrast
 In Moses' wisdom by Egyptian blast.
 He knows the people stone such likes as he,
 And so he does not act his faith as free.
 My sacrifice also is made today
 In secret from the rabble out to play.
 Beloved, I move between the holy mount
 And Egypt, yet I seek Your face and count.

Exodus 9

1 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Go in
 To Pharaoh and *to his chagrin*
 Tell him, 'Thus says YHWH Alohim
 Of the Hebrews, "Let go My people,
 That they may serve Me *without steeple*."
 2 "For if you refuse to let go,
 And still hold them *for work and show*,
 3 "Indeed, the hand of YHWH will be

On your cattle in field and lea,
 On the horses, and on donkey,
 On camels, on oxen, and sheep,
 A grievous pestilence *shall sweep*.
 4 "And YHWH will make a difference
 Between Israel's cattle *and fence*
 And the Egyptians' livestock, so
 Nothing shall die of all pertaining
 To Israel's folk *whom I'm sustaining*.""
 5 Then YHWH appointed a set time,
 Saying "Tomorrow YHWH *sublime*
 Will do this thing *here in the land*."
 6 So YHWH did this thing *by His hand*
 The next day, and all the livestock
 Of Egypt died, but not a pock
 Killed any of the cattle of
 The folk of Israel *in the shove*.
 7 Then Pharaoh sent, and indeed, not
 One of Israel's cattle's shot,
 But the heart of Pharaoh got hard,
 To keep the people locked and barred.

The ancient incidence of hoof and mouth
 Disease is evident from north to south
 In Egypt except in the land of Goshen,
 Exempt perhaps for lying near the ocean.
 If all the problems were caused by eruption
 Of some volcano, still the state's corruption
 Was well affronted by the act of God,
 A concept legal and religious that
 I duly note with scorn from where I'm at.
 If all destruction started with the rod
 That Moses waved, but is not mentioned
 here,

Then there is still today reason to fear
 Authorities may topple and the rabble
 Pass on to Sinai where to stop their babble.

8 So YHWH said to Moses and Aaron,
 "Take for yourselves handfuls of *barren*
 Ashes from a furnace, and let
 Moses scatter it toward the *set*
 Sky in the sight of Pharaoh. 9 "And
 It will be fine dust in the land
 Of all Egypt, and it will cause
 Boils that break out in *awful* sores
 On man and beast throughout all of
 Egypt's land *lower and above*."
 10 Then they took ashes from the furnace
 And stood before Pharaoh with *sureness*,
 And Moses scattered toward the sky.
 And *it* caused boils breaking thereby

In *awful* sores on man and beast.

11 And the magician *and the priest*
Could not stand before Moses for
The *pain they had* in boil and sore,
Because the boils were on magician
As well as on every Egyptian.

12 But YHWH hardened the heart of
Pharaoh,

And he did not heed them *for harrow*,
Just as YHWH'd told Moses before.

If mad cow plague is not enough to make
A king submit to God for goodness' sake,
A fistful of ashes thrown in the air,
And magnified by what viral affair,
Ought to turn mind to know one has no
power

To command earth to stay a blessed hour.
If I had been the one to blow the horn
On status quo and send a plague of scorn,
I would have sent this first against the
priest

And the magician in their fatal feast.
Beloved, why is the plague always hard
first

On vulnerable instead of on worst?
Dictator eats his ill-got lamb in peace,
While righteous poor goes to bed without
fleece.

13 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Rise early
In the morning and stand by *surlly*
Pharaoh, and say to him, 'Thus says
YHWH God of the Hebrews *for days*,

"Let My people go for My praise,
14 "For this time I'll send all My plagues
On your own heart and *to the dregs*
On your servants and on your folk,
That you may know *there's* not a bloke
Like Me in all the earth, *no joke*.

15 "Now if I had stretched out My hand
And struck you and all in your land
With pestilence, you would have been
Cut off from all the earth *by sin*.

16 "But indeed for this *purpose* I
Have raised you up *near to the sky*,
That I may show My power *in* you,
And that My name may be shown true
In all the earth. 17 "And as yet you
Exalt yourself against My folk
Not to let them go out unyoke.

18 "Indeed, tomorrow at this time

I'll cause great hail *in place and clime*

To rain down, such as not been seen
In Egypt since the time it's been.

19 "Therefore send now *and* gather your
Livestock and all you have *on shore*
Or in the field, for hail shall come
Down on all men and every beast
Found in the field *from great to least*
And is *left out and* not brought home,
And they shall die, *and that's the sum*.""

20 Who feared the word of YHWH among
Pharaoh's servants made slave *unsung*
And beast take refuge in the shed.

21 But who despised the word that said
YHWH left his servants and his cattle
Out in the field *to do hail battle*.

Not only Pharaoh, but each man is raised
Upon the earth where YHWH is to be
praised

For but one purpose chosen between two,
Either to submit his own will to You,
Or by rebellion show Your name is grand
Throughout the centuries in every land.
Those who return to You in truth and grace
Are armed both with the bliss and with the
face

Of suffering in this awful time and place.
Those who rebel sometimes find fleeting
peace,

And other times their pains fail of release.
There is no answer to the flesh that cries
For reasons why the body hurts and dies.
Reason is virtue and so bears no lies.

22 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Stretch
out

Your hand toward heaven, that *without*
doubt

There may be hail in all the land
Of Egypt: on man, on beast, and
On every herb of field *and sand*,
Throughout the land of Egypt *manned*."

23 And Moses stretched out his rod to
The sky, and YHWH sent thunder, blew
The hail, and fire ran to the ground,
And YHWH rained hail *in horrid sound*
On the land of Egypt. 24 So there
Was hail, and mingled everywhere
With hail, was fire, and hail so great
That there was none in all the state
Like it since Egypt was a nation.

25 And the hail made a devastation
 Throughout the whole land of Egypt,
 All that *was* in the field *was whipped*,
 Both man and beast, and the hail struck
 Every herb of the field *amuck*
 And broke every tree of the field.
 26 Only in Goshen's land *was shield*,
 Where the children of Israel *stayed*
 There was no hail *come in cascade*.

For once it seems plague fell upon the
 guilty
 Who sat for gain beside the river silty,
 While the blessed were to find a saving
 shield
 From the storm well wrought and so finely
 peeled.
 Now the hail takes the one and leaves the
 other,
 And there's no reason why the salvaged
 brother
 Is left in respite instead of in hell.
 There's no restraint in tolling of the bell,
 And plague does not define the good in
 heart
 And hand, against the wicked's flying dart.
 Since justice happened once I can relate
 To blind injustice now that seems my fate.
 Beloved, You live eternal present so
 One act of justice seems to let You go.

27 And Pharaoh sent and called for Moses
 And Aaron, his secret discloses,
 "I've sinned now, YHWH is right *and just*,
 I and my people wicked *dust*.
 28 "Entreat YHWH, that there may be no
 Thunder of Alohim *to show*
 Nor hail, enough, and I'll release,
 You'll stay no more, but go in peace."
 29 So Moses said to him, "As soon
 As I have gone out of the city,
 I'll spread my hands to YHWH *for pity*,
 Thunder will cease, there'll be no more
 Hail, that you may know that the earth
 Is YHWH's *and all in it of worth*,
 Both those who're safe and those who're
 sore.

30 "But as for you and your servants,
 I know that you'll make no relents
 To fear YHWH Alohim *with sense*."
 31 Now the flax and the barley were
 Struck, for the barley *was astir*

In ear and flax *was* in the bud,
So both were lost in hail and mud.
 32 But the wheat and the spelt were not
 Struck, for they *are* late crops *in plot*.
 33 So Moses went out of the city
 From Pharaoh to spread hands *for pity*
 To YHWH, and then the thunder and
 The hail ceased, and the rain on sand
 Was not poured out. 34 And when Pharaoh
 Saw that the rain, the hail, also
 The thunder had ceased, he sinned yet
 More, and he hardened his heart set,
 He and his servants. 35 So the heart
 Of Pharaoh was hard, *for his part*
 Neither would he let Israel go,
 As YHWH had told Moses to show.

My soul like every soul in trouble cries
 For just deliverance, or if not just,
 At least relief from pain of sore and sighs,
 And pleasure instead of the aching dust.
 And like Pharaoh and every other soul,
 As soon as pain stops and I've reached the
 goal,

I straight away forget the promise made
 That I'd do this or that in light or shade
 If You, Beloved, would only come in aid.
 The pink and purple blossoms flutter at
 The tugging autumn breeze turned acrobat.
 My fragile life and happiness are bold
 Against the waning summer and the cold.
 Beloved, let glorious visions not be sold.

Week 15 Exodus 10

1 Now YHWH said to Moses, "Go in
 To Pharaoh, for *in his own sin*
 I've hardened his heart and the hearts
 Of his servants *who play their parts*,
 That I may show these signs of Mine
 Before him, 2 "and to you consign
 The telling in the hearing of
 Your son and your son's son *in love*
 About the mighty things I've done
 In Egypt, and My signs I've done
 Among them, that you may know that
 I am YHWH *and an autocrat*."
 3 So Moses and Aaron came in
 To Pharaoh and told him *like kin*,
 "Thus says YHWH God of the Hebrews,
 'How long will you *indeed* refuse
 To humble yourself before Me?
 Let My people go to serve Me.

4 'Or else, if you refuse to let
 My people go, indeed, I'll get
 Locusts tomorrow on your land.
 5 'And they shall cover earth and sand
 So that no one can see the earth,
 And they shall eat what's left of worth
 From the hail, and they'll eat each tree
 That grows for you in field and lea.
 6 'They shall fill your houses, and all
 The houses of your servants small
 And great, and all the houses of
 The Egyptians, *for hate or love,*
Like neither your fathers nor your
 Fathers' fathers have seen before,
 Since the day that they were on earth
 To this day.'" And he, *without mirth,*
 Turned and went out from Pharaoh's *sight.*

Like nothing known before, Beloved, You
 say,
 Out of the east the locusts come to prey.
 Come with the east wind to proclaim the
 fate
 Upon Egyptian and Egyptian state.
 Since the day that they were on earth they
 saw
 That locusts limited themselves to law.
 Servants of You, Beloved, they come in
 wave
 Locusts well-armed, hungry, swarming and
 brave,
 On all the land of Egypt, everywhere
 Covering earth and sand, filling the air
 Upon all fields of green and every tree.
 Still and submitted, My Beloved, to Thee,
 Throughout the night I wait the coming
 horde,
 Submitted to Your hand, Your word and
 sword.

7 Then Pharaoh's servants said to him,
 "How long shall this man be a blight
 To us? Let the men go and hymn
 In service to YHWH Alohim.
 Do you not yet know that Egypt
 Is destroyed *and its wings all clipped?*"
 8 So Moses and Aaron were brought
 Again to Pharaoh, and he taught
 Them saying "Go, serve YHWH your God.
 Who *are* the ones to go *by prod?*"
 9 And Moses said "We will go out
 With our young and our old, *no doubt,*

With our sons and our daughters, and
 With our flocks and our herds in hand,
 For we must hold a feast to YHWH."
 10 Then he told them, "YHWH be with you
 When I let you and yours go out!
 It's evil you're thinking about!
 11 "Not so! Go now, you *who are* men,
 And serve YHWH *and come back again,*
 For that is what you *first* desired."
 Driven from Pharaoh, they retired.

The king's no fool, he knows that he will
 lose
 The labour force of all the land to choose
 To let them go out with both herd and
 child.
 He states his fears outright, he's not
 beguiled.
 It's Moses and Aaron equivocate
 And You Yourself, Beloved, the truth to
 state.
 The promise to the king is that they go
 To hold a feast only and then to show
 Up at their jobs once they've returned. The
 thought
 The king calls evil is not only wrought
 In Moses' heart, Beloved, but in Your own.
 You do not lie, who strike fear to the bone,
 But can show truth only to faces that
 Return in truth, Beloved, to where You're
 at.

12 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Stretch
 out
 Your hand over the land about
 Egypt for the locusts, that they
 May come on Egypt's land a way
 And eat all grass upon the land,
 All that the hail has left *in hand.*"
 13 So Moses stretched out his rod over
 The land of Egypt *and its clover,*
 And YHWH brought an east wind on all
 The land that day and all *that* night.
 At morning locusts came to fall
 From the east wind *and out of sight.*
 14 And the locusts went up on all
 The land of Egypt to rest on
 All the land of Egypt *at dawn.*
 Very severe, like none before
 Had there been such locusts in store
 Nor shall there be such after them.
 15 For they covered *in stratagem*

The face of the whole earth, so that
The land was darkened *where they're at*,
And they ate every herb of field
And all the fruit that trees might yield
Left by the hail, so there remained
No green thing *by the unrestrained*
On tree or herb of field throughout
The land of Egypt round about.

Beloved, I do not pity grass so much,
Although I know also that grass is such,
Despite its lower stature, still a voice
In every leaf and blade that must rejoice
In You and in Your holy name. The grass
Says constantly, repeating sacred mass
Of Your name and Your praises night and
day.

I hear its praise in whispers on its sway.
But what I pity, my Beloved, is trees!
You let the locusts touch the holy frieze
Of leaf and branch! Even today the land
Of Egypt is bereft of fir and oak.
Why did You give the fatal, foul command
And cut the world down with one blasting
stroke?

16 Then Pharaoh called for Moses and
Aaron in haste, and told the band,
"I've sinned against YHWH Alohim
And against you, *so it would seem*."

17 "Now therefore, please forgive my sin
Only this once, *I'm genuine*,
And entreat YHWH your God, that He
May take from me this death only."

18 So he went out from Pharaoh and
Entreated YHWH *at his command*.

19 And YHWH turned a very strong west
Wind, which took the locust *and pest*
Away and blew them in the sea,
The Red Sea, till no one could see
A single locust in the lea
In all the Egyptian country.

20 And so YHWH hardened Pharaoh's
heart,
Not to let Israel depart.

Before You let Your west wind blow on
me,
Beloved, Beloved, hear my apology
And my confession. Like Pharaoh I think
That my heart turns to you upon the brink
Of fear and exaltation. Feelings are

The human measure of the guiding star.
But You know what I in my ignorance
Deny with horror for my own defence.
Soften the heart in me that thinks I am
The meek and mild and humble woolly
lamb.

Remove the hidden Christian violence
From my unspoken motives. Hear my
prayer,

The words that Pharaoh failed at last to
share.

Save from the faith I feel and know and
bear.

21 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Stretch
out

Your hand toward heaven, that *all about*
There may be darkness in the land
Of Egypt, darkness felt *by hand*."

22 And so Moses stretched out his hand
Toward the sky, and there was thick
Darkness over the bishopric
Of Egypt three days. 23 They did not
See one another, and none got
Up from his bed for three days, but
In all the folk of Israel's hut

They had their light. 24 Then Pharaoh
called

To Moses *and Aaron* and bawled,
"Go, serve YHWH, only let your flocks
And your herds stay here in their docks,
But let your families go in pax."

25 But Moses said "You must also
Give us sacrifice and bestow
On us burnt offerings, that we may
Offer YHWH our God the right way.

26 "Our livestock shall go with us, not
A hoof shall be left *nor forgot*.
For we must take from them to serve
YHWH our Alohim *and not swerve*
Since we do not know what we need
To serve YHWH till we're there *indeed*."

27 And so YHWH hardened Pharaoh's
heart,

And he would not let them depart.

28 Then Pharaoh told him, "Get away
From me! Take heed, because you may
Not see my face again! The day

You see my face, *know* you shall die!"
29 And Moses said "You *do not lie*,
For you have spoken not in vain.

I'll never see your face again."

The hand of might comes to its last
defence,
Which is always threat of the death
sentence.

There is no power on earth but carries out
That threat despite all laws, the law of clout
Is basis of all rule, the clandestine
Or heavy-handed rule of Constantine.
The civil servant may be civil when
He has cooperation of all men.
But let a man make some polite request
To lift the yoke of service from his breast,
And governor, elected or well set,
Will smile at first, and then begin to fret,
And then pass the death sentence, for the
nation

Finds it expedient to deal that ration.

Exodus 11

1 And YHWH said to Moses, "I'll bring
Yet one *more* plague on Pharaoh king
Of Egypt. Afterward he will
Let you go from here *Semophile*.

When he lets *you* go, he'll surely
Drive you from here most earnestly.
2 "Speak now in hearing of the folk,

Let every man ask from the bloke
Next door, and every woman from
Her neighbour, articles in sum
Of silver and vessels of gold."

3 And YHWH gave the people a hold
On the Egyptians, and the man
Moses *was great as any can*
Be in the land of Egypt, in
The sight of Pharaoh's servants' *kin*
And in the sight of *all* the folk.

4 And then Moses *stood up and* spoke,
"Thus says YHWH 'About midnight I

Will tread upon Egyptian sky,

5 'And all the firstborn in the land
Of Egypt shall die *by My hand*,
From the firstborn of Pharaoh who

Sits on his throne, and even to
The firstborn of the maid behind
The handmill, and *also in kind*
All the firstborn of every beast.

6 'Then there shall be a great cry *triste*
Throughout all Egypt's land, such as
Was not like it *before*, *nor has*
Nor shall be like ever again.

There is just one response to threat of death
That governor and guard pass in one
breath,

And that is that You come down with a
sword

And slay the usurper and the adored.
Prohibited is killing to the free,
And so we cry for justice fervidly
At Your hand, O Beloved, from slavery.
Slay, slay oppressor and oppressor's son
Until the massacre of fate is done,
And the impoverished at last have won.
But give us no more revolution where
The anarchist's against the wall first flair.
Slay the oppressor in my heart as well,
And let the sceptres lie forlorn that fell.

7 'But against none of Israel's men
Shall even dog move its tongue then,
Against man or against beast, that
You may know that YHWH makes a flat
Distinction between Egyptians
And Israel.' 8 "These manikins,

All your servants shall come down to
Me and bow down to me, and sue,
'Get out, and all the people who
Follow you!' After that I'll go."

Then he went out from the Pharaoh
In great anger. 9 But YHWH said to
Moses, "Pharaoh will not heed you,
So that My wonders may be great,
Many on the Egyptian state."

10 So Moses and Aaron did all
These wonders in the Pharaoh's *hall*,
And YHWH hardened the Pharaoh's heart
Not to let Israel depart.

The people say that's why the dogs may eat
Of every unclean and unslaughtered meat,
As a reward that when the silent feet
Of Israel trod secretly the street
Out of Egypt, no dog raised warning cry
To hear the rabble softly passing by.

The meek Moses was known for showing
rage

Against the ruling class and governance,
But to the beast from dog to gliding bat
He was for kindness an aristocrat.

I too am such a dog and sometimes bark
To hear You pass, Beloved, beneath the
dark,

And so I chew the unclean bones in bliss,

Despised by priest and mullah for Your
kiss.

Exodus 12

1 YHWH told Moses and Aaron in
The land of Egypt, said herein,
2 "This month your first of months shall be,
The year's first month *eternally*.
3 "Tell all the congregation of
Israel, saying 'On the tenth of
This month each man shall take a lamb
For himself, according to dam
And father's house, for each household.
4 'And if the household *in its mould*
Is too small for the lamb, let him
And his neighbour next to his *limb*
Take *it* according to the number
Of persons that in each house slumber,
According to each man's need you
Shall make your count for the lamb's due.

Your feast is for the family, not church,
And even those alone, not left in lurch,
May join the score around the sacrifice,
The family and neighbour that is nice.
Though the feast may be made and once
again

In memory of Israel and when
The people went out from the scarred up
land
Of Egypt, it goes back to Abram's hand
On Mount Moriah, and to Noah's ark
Who counted months, and even to the park
Of the two sacred trees. First month of
years
Goes back beyond all human days and fears
To You, Beloved, Creator and earth's King,
Where prayer for sacrifice bows and takes
wing.

5 'Your lamb shall be without a fault,
A male of the first year *assault*.
You may take *it* among the sheep
Or from the goats *you have to keep*.

6 'Until the fourteenth day keep it
Of the same month *and keep it fit*.
Then the assembly of the whole
Of Israel's folk *in their patrol*
Shall kill it between lowering night.
7 'And they shall take *there in their sight*
Some of the blood and put *it* on
The two doorposts and put it on

The lintel of the houses where
They eat *the lamb without despair*.

What You provide, Beloved, in way of
lamb

Is without fault, that feeds the one I am
As years turn on in grace and sacrifice.
I lay the blood to place and time precise,
Between the lowerings of the day and
night.

I kiss the doorposts with my blood in sight
And come into the dergah where my death
Is placed above the whirl of time and
breath,

Around the posts that gather my
prostrations

As I go whirling all around the stations.
And still the doorposts glimmer glory seen
With every kiss of dervish in between.
Beloved, the whisper of the treading feet
Goes on past dreams, past every
judgement-seat.

8 'Then they shall eat the flesh on that
Night, roasted in fire, with a pat
Of bread unleavened *and with bitter*
Herbs they shall eat it *as befitter*.

9 'Don't eat it raw, nor boiled at all
With water, but roasted withal
In fire, its head and with its legs
And its entrails *and as it begs*.

10 'You shall let none of it remain
Until morning, but yet what grain
Of it is left till morning, burn.

11 'And eat it *then and do not spurn*:
With a belt on your waist, on feet
Your sandals, and your staff in hand.
So you in haste the lamb shall eat,
It is YHWH's Passover command.

12 'For I will pass throughout the land
Of Egypt on that night, to strike
All the firstborn in Egypt's land,
Both man and beast, and all the like,
Against all the gods of Egypt
I'll execute judgement *by script*:
For I *am* YHWH *and well-equipped*.

What You provide, Beloved, I shall not
save.

Though grain may be in store, it is a slave
Who works beyond his daily, weekly need
Except to keep in faith the goodly seed.

What You provide in meat to feed my soul
 From breath to breath as I sit on the goal,
 I shall not save, but only taste the sweet
 You have in store to grant me for a treat.
 Let government and culture wing across
 A failing sky and blossom to their loss.
 The first-born of establishment must die
 From wounds inherent in the heart and lie.
 I eat the lamb and lick the bone unbroken
 Behind closed doors and behind closed
 doors' token.

13 'The blood shall be a sign for you
 On the houses where you *are true*.
 And when I see the blood, I'll pass
 Over you *and over the grass*,
 And the plague shall not be on you
 To destroy when I give the cue
 To strike the land of Egypt's mass.
 14 'This day shall be to you a *sign*,
 Memorial *of memory's shrine*,
 And you shall keep it as a feast
 To YHWH through your lifetimes
 unceased.

You'll keep this feast by law forever.
 15 'Seven days you shall take to sever
 The leaven from the bread you eat.
 On the first day remove the leaven
 From your houses. From then till seven
 Days whoever eats leavened treat
 Shall be cut off from Israel's *feet*.

Beware Egyptians' leaven and regard
 No pseudo-scientific words that guard
 Behind a shield of benign sophistry
 Idolatrous oppression of the free.
 The people had not heard Your lovely
 voice
 Reciting ten things on the mount for
 choice,
 And so like Jesus' old disciples had
 To hear a warning of the good and bad,
 Avoid the leaven, yea, avoid it well,
 Turn back, spit over shoulder, cast a spell.
 The specious doctrine comes in clandestine
 And has to be swept out with dust and
 brine.
 Let me, Beloved, hold to Your Self alone
 And eat no leaven and bow not to stone.

16 'On the first day a convocation
 Shall be set off for the whole nation,

And on the seventh day again
 A holy convocation then.
 No work at all shall be done then,
 Except the necessary thing
 That all may eat, no suffering.
 17 'So you shall observe *then the feast*
Of unleavened bread (without yeast),
 For on this same day I'll have brought
 Your armies out of Egypt's *plot*.
 Therefore you shall observe this day
 Throughout your generations' way
 As everlasting ordinance.

18 'In the first month, upon advance
 Of the fourteenth day and at eve,
 You shall eat unleavened *to shrieve*,
 Until the twenty-first day come
 In that month and at eve *by drum*.

19 'For seven days no leaven shall
 Be found within your portical,
 Since who eats what is leavened, that
 Same person shall be cut off at
 The congregation of Israel,
 Whether a stranger clientele
 Or native of the land *and well*.

20 'You shall eat nothing leavened, in
 All your dwellings, *but hold it sin*,
 You shall eat unleavened bread *till*
The twenty-first day to your fill."

The leaven of the Pharisees must not
 Be eaten even by the stranger taught.
 False doctrine permeates the dough and
 makes
 A sour of sweet for its unholy sakes.
 But who shall pluck the heathen teaching
 out
 And tell the world the virtue of the doubt?
 By meditation long and sweet of law
 At last I find myself, Beloved, in awe
 Of You and of Your flashing word and
 power.
 Such things are not accomplished in an
 hour
 For even those who seek the Truth and
 marrow.
 The mass of men are comfortable and
 narrow.
 Beloved, the leaven spreads on every hand
 Despite the sullen sadness of command.

21 And Moses summoned all the elders
 Of Israel, *farmers, smiths or welders*,

And said to them, "Pick out and take
 Lambs for yourselves and for the sake
 Of your families, and slay Passover.
 22 "And you shall take a bunch *like clover*
 Of hyssop, dip *it* in the blood
 That's in the basin *like a flood*,
 And strike the lintel and two posts
 Of the door with the blood that *boasts*
 In the basin. And none of you
 Shall go out of the door *in view*
 Of his house until morning sun.
 23 "For YHWH will pass through *on the*

run

To strike Egyptian *first-born son*,
 And when He sees the blood upon
 The lintel and doorposts till dawn,
 Then YHWH will pass over the door
 And not allow destroyer more
 To come into your houses then
 To strike *your sons both small and men*.
 24 "And you shall observe this thing as
 An ordinance for you *that has*
Been given to you and sons forever.
 25 "It will happen when you endeavour
 To come to the land which YHWH'll give
 You, just as He promised, to live,
 That you shall always keep this feast.
 26 "And it shall be, that when your least
 Children say to you, 'Now what do
 You mean by this service?' 27 "that you
 Shall say 'It *is* the sacrifice
 Of Passover since *in a trice*
 YHWH passed over the houses of
 The children of Israel above
 In Egypt when He struck them *cold*,
 Egyptians and saved our household."
 So the people bowed down their heads
 And worshipped. 28 Then, *aside their*
dreads,
 The children of Israel went out
 And did just as YHWH *without doubt*
 Commanded Moses and Aaron,
 So they did *before day had gone*.

Your presence, my Beloved, must strike all
 dead
 Who live on earth and take it into head
 To be persons with I-nesses and free,
 For only one can be divine Creator
 Of fountains, earth, and the depths of the
 sea.
 Pass over the stone chamber that is traitor

To being as I set myself to see
 The multitude of gods in industry.
 Pass over the stone chamber of my heart
 And leave the soul prostrated from the
 start.
 I have no will at all but Your's be done
 And in that abnegation life is won.
 Beloved, pass over now my blood-stained
 door
 Closed tight against the pounding midnight
 shore.

29 And it happened at midnight that
 YHWH struck all firstborn *where they sat*
 In Egypt's land, from the firstborn
 Of the Pharaoh who sat *forlorn*
 On his throne unto the firstborn
 Of the captive who *was* in dungeon,
 Of all livestock, *even Melungeon*.
 30 So Pharaoh rose up in the night,
 He, all his servants, *in their plight*
 And all Egyptians, and there was
 A great cry in Egypt, *there was*
 Not a house where *lay* not one dead.
 31 Then he called for Moses and said,
 And Aaron in the night, "Rise, go
 Out from among my people, go
 Both you and Israel's folk. And go,
 Serve YHWH as you have said. 32 "Also
 Take your flocks and your herds, as you
 Have said, be gone, bless me also."
 33 And the Egyptians *and their crew*
 Urged the people, that they might send
 Them out of the land hastily.
 For they said "We're all *at an end*."
 34 So the people took their dough *free*
 Before it was leavened, having
 Their kneading bowls bound up *with string*
 In their clothes on their shoulders. 35 Now
 The children of Israel *somehow*
 Had done as Moses said, and they
 Had asked Egyptians on the way
 For articles of silver and
 Things of gold, clothing *second-hand*.
 36 And YHWH had given the people
 favour,
 In sight of the Egyptians' *waver*,
 So that they gave them *what they asked*,
 Plundered the Egyptians *unmasked*.

Great is Your mercy, my Beloved, when
 You

Strike with death all the firstborn of the few!

You only strike a token god or two
And leave the pantheon to greet the dew.
In justice You might strike all who draw breath

To live and set up idols ruling death.
Not horror that the innocent are taught
For Pharaoh's fleeing the divine love-knot,
But wonder fills my heart at Your restraint
To leave the multitude to live complaint
Of plundering their silver and their gold.
Strike my heart idol, leave me dead and cold,

Or plunder the wealth of my self too bold,
But let me not live, My Beloved, a saint.

37 Then the children of Israel travelled
From Rameses to Succoth *ungravelled*,
About six hundred thousand men
On foot, besides their families then.

38 A mixed multitude went also
With them, and flocks and herds *to go*
Much livestock. 39 And they baked their cakes

Of dough unleavened *for their sakes*
Which they had brought out of Egypt,
For it was not leavened *or dipped*,
Because they were driven out of
Egypt and could not wait *for love*,
Nor had provisions yet prepared.

40 And the time Israel's folk had dared
To stay in Egypt *was thirty*
And four hundred, *then they went free*.

41 And it happened at the end of
The four hundred and thirty years,
On that very same day above,
It happened *after all their tears*
That all the armies of YHWH went
Out from the land of Egypt *sent*.

42 A night of solemn observance
To YHWH for bringing from the fence
Of Egypt's land. This *is* that night
Of YHWH, a solemn, sacred rite
For all Israel's folk through their *days*
In all their generations' *ways*.

As soon as I am fled from slavery
To fashion and the folk's theology,
I stop to bake the cakes from that dough I
Have carried through the temple on the sly
And kept beside the market where I walk.

As soon as I have reached the desert chalk
And given up the wine and water of
Pseudo-science and idolatry's love,
I stop upon the sand to bake the cakes
That I have carried with me for the sakes
Of liberty to obey Your word once
Who for that freedom is considered dunce.
Beloved, I join You in the simple meal
Upon the desert sands and sit on heel.

43 And YHWH said to Moses and Aaron,
"This *is* the ordinance *not barren*

Of the Passover. No stranger
Shall eat of it. 44 "But all that stir
Of every man's servants who're bought
For money, when he has been *taught*
And circumcised, then he may eat.

45 "Stranger and hireling, both shall not
Eat it. 46 "In one house you'll take treat,
You shall not carry any flesh
Outside the house, nor take the *fresh*
Bone to be broken. 47 "All the folk
Of Israel keep it at a stroke.

48 "And when a stranger dwells with you
To keep the Passover to YHWH,
Let all his males be circumcised,
And then let him come near *advised*
And keep it, and he shall be as
A native of the land, whereas
No uncircumcised one shall eat.

49 "One law shall be for native-born
And for the stranger who is meet
To dwell among you, *beard or shorn*."

50 Thus all the folk of Israel did,
As YHWH commanded Moses, bid
Aaron, so they did. 51 And it came
To pass, on that day very same,
That YHWH brought out all Israel's folk
From Egypt's land, under its yoke
According to their armies' *number*,
To wake and rise up and not slumber.

I once was guest of Jewish folk who kept
Passover on a date in spring, inept
Perhaps in counting months as should be
counted,
Who knows, but that is all that it amounted.
They did not ask when they sat me to table
If I were circumcised and thus were able
To join them in the feast. I also thought
To eat standing was what the Bible taught.

At any rate, the child who asked the questions
 Contributed as well some new suggestions.
 "The hardest thing" she said "when we were there
 As slaves in Egypt was the porcine fare."
 Beloved, bless me too as that little girl,
 Who does not eat the ham or bacon curl.

Exodus 13

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
 2 "Consecrate Me all firstborn thing,
 Whatever opens womb among
 The children of Israel, *the sung*
Of both man and beast, it is Mine."
 3 And Moses told the people fine
 "Remember this day in which you
 Went out of Egypt, out of true
 House of bondage, for by the strength
 Of YHWH's hand you were brought *at*
length
 Out of this *land*. No leavened bread
 Shall be eaten. 4 "That's why it's said
 On this day you are going out,
 In the month of green ears, *green sprout*.
 5 "And it shall be, when YHWH brings you
 Into the land *promised and due*
 Of Canaanites and the Hittites
 And Amorites and the Hivites
 And Jebusites, which He swore to
 Your fathers to give it to you,
 A land flowing with milk and honey,
 That you shall keep this *without money*
 In this month, a service *to YHWH*.
 6 "Seven days you shall eat unleaven
 Bread, and on the day number seven
There shall be a feast made to YHWH.
 7 "Unleavened bread be eaten seven
 Days, and no leavened bread shall be
 Seen among you, nor shall you see
 Leaven in all your houses either.
 8 "And you shall tell your son *and writher*
 In that day, saying '*This is done*
 Because of what thing YHWH has won
 For me when I came from Egypt.'
 9 "It shall be a sign *plain as script*
 To you on your hand to remind
 Between your eyes, *not to be blind*
 That law of YHWH may be in your
 Mouth, for with a strong hand *and more*
 YHWH has brought you from Egypt's
door.

10 "You shall therefore keep this service
 In its season that year to this.

Although the words of law say that the
 feast
 Should be observed forever, at the least
 There is in different times prophetic word
 To change detailed observance as occurred
 In every time and place. So Jewish law
 Maintains no sacrifice of lamb or claw.
 The Christian takes the pagan rite of spring
 Instead of the Passover. Anything
 Goes, it appears, Beloved. The Muslim
 knows
 The seventh month or rather first that goes
 In Torah is a sacred one to keep,
 And maybe fast, but surely fail to leap
 Upon warhorses in the holy time.
 So men remember Your word and Your
 rhyme.

11 "And it shall be, when YHWH brings
 you
 Into the land of Canaanites,
The land of food and fame and lights,
 As He swore to your fathers true,
 And you, and gives at last to you,
 12 "That you shall set apart to YHWH
 All that open the womb, that is,
 Every firstborn that comes from beast
 That you have, all the males *are His*,
And shall be YHWH's from great to least.
 13 "But every firstborn of a donkey
 You'll redeem with a lamb *for wonky*,
 And if you'll not redeem *it*, then
 You'll break its neck *nor sell for yen*.
 And all firstborn of man among
 Your sons you shall redeem *unstung*.
 14 "So it shall be, when your son asks
 You in the future, 'Why these tasks?'
 That you shall say to him, 'By strength
 Of hand YHWH brought us out *the length*
 Of Egypt, out of bondage house.
 15 'When Pharaoh was stubborn as mouse
 About letting us go, that YHWH
 Killed all the firstborn *and on cue*
 In Egypt's land, both the firstborn
 Of man and the firstborn of beast.
 Therefore I slaughter *without scorn*
 To YHWH all males *from great to least*
 That open up the womb, but all
 The firstborn of my sons I call

Out for redemption.' 16 "And it shall
Be as a sign on your hand and
As frontlets between your eyes stand,
For by strength of hand YHWH brought
out
Of Egypt *all of us, no doubt.*"

The cattle must be all redeemed by
slaughter
Of the firstborn of males but not of
daughter.
The clean beast is assailed for sacrifice
And human sons redeemed with something
nice
And kept alive. Ah my Beloved, the
donkey
Is thrown out as a worthless honkey-
tonkey.
Cannot the donkey also be redeemed?
The Decalogue says not to kill. I dreamed
The donkey too was living thing, though
not
Greatly revered by most folks in the plot.
The Jews today give silver dollar to
A Cohen to obey in word or two.
The Muslims slaughter sheep or goat for
son,
And only Christians ran no race but won.

Week 16

17 Then it happened, when Pharaoh had
Let the people go, Alohim
Did not lead them *by a way bad*
Through Philistines' land, though it seem
Near, for Alohim said "Unless
The people repent at the stress
Of seeing war, and so turn back
To Egypt *led by their own track.*"
18 So Alohim led the folk round
The wilderness of the Red Sea.
And Israel's folk went safe and sound
And as orderly as can be
Up out of the land of Egypt.
19 And Moses took the bones from crypt
Of Joseph with him, for he'd placed
The folk of Israel *strongly braced*
Under oath, saying "Alohim
Will surely visit you, and you
Shall carry up my bones with you."
20 And they took their journey up from
Succoth, camped in Etham when done
At the edge of the wilderness.

21 And YHWH went before them *to bless*
By day in a pillar of cloud
To lead the way, by night *allowed*
Pillar of fire to give them light,
So as to go by day and night.
22 He did not take away the cloud
In pillar by day or the fire
By night before the people's choir.

Beloved, lead me not by the Philistines!
I've had enough of cats' evil designs!
I let them rest, indeed, I'll see no war.
Enough of Egypt too and that land's store,
If by Egypt I mean in symbol word
The place of bondage and the undeterred.
The real Egypt of today I'll take
For friendliness, Egyptian kindness' sake.
But when the spirit of religion sounds
I'll go to desert and avoid the rounds
Of resurrecting idols from the sea
That make the faith of Philistines seem
free.

Beloved, find me here guided by the cloud
And comforted in desert fire allowed.

Exodus 14

1 Now YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
2 "Speak to the folk of Israel spread,
That they turn and camp before Pi
Hahiroth, between Migdol by
The sea, opposite Baal Zephon,
You'll camp by the sea thereupon.
3 "For Pharaoh will say of the folk
Of Israel, 'The land will choke
Them where they go in wilderness.'
4 "Then I will harden Pharaoh's heart,
So he'll pursue them *relentless*,
And I'll gain honour *for my part*
On Pharaoh and on all his hosts,
That the Egyptians *in their boasts*
May know *I'm YHWH.*" And they did so.
5 Now it was told *so he should know*
The king of Egypt that the folk
Had fled, and the heart of Pharaoh
And his servants was turned *in stroke*
Against the people, and they spoke,
"Why have we done this, that we've let
Israel go from serving us yet?"
6 And he made ready his chariot
And took his people *on the spot*.

My freedom in the physical depends

On rulers thinking desert makes amends,
And I shall be entangled in my lack
Of gold to clink on silver in my sack.
And so they let me go my sacred way
To eat the manna and herbs every day.
Beloved, when You come to affirm the
heart

Hardened with power and its addicting part,
Authorities will fall and fail with me
Who trust in You alone to keep me free.
I flee to You One found in desert land
And joy in walking by Your dry command
That is a secret well of wine and fruit
Behind the stinging sand and soiling soot.

7 Also, he took six hundred choice
Chariots, and all the chariots of
Egypt with their captains above
Every one of them. 8 And YHWH's voice
Hardened the heart of Pharaoh king
Of Egypt, and he *on the wing*
Pursued the children of Israel,
And the children of Israel well
And bold went out. 9 Egyptians then
Pursued them, all horses *and men*
And chariots of Pharaoh, horsemen
And his army, and overtook
Them camping by the sea *in nook*
Beside Pi Hahiroth, before
Baal Zephon *on the sea-shore*.

Six hundred of the latest technique in
Their military hardware ought to win
Against a fleeing half civilian flock.
It seems armies are chiseled from a block,
At least they still do duty just the same
Against the helpless and the poor for shame
To get the benefit of what is best
In the economy that does not rest.
Beloved, look once more on the armies
now
That do a thing not far from Sinai's brow.
There's nothing changed in what we have to
face,
So let Your arm be bared in the same place.
I wait upon the seashore looking out
To where the winds and waves are not in
doubt.

The flattering lord of the land of fashion
Finds me backed in the corner, forehead
ashen,

And thinks the victory won with horse and
men,
And chariot on the highway once again
And powered with perfume and diesel fuel
As a car meets criteria of cool.
I hardly see the army in pursuit
Since I've long since disposed of Egypt's
soot.
The civilized are too kind everywhere
I turn, I'm courtesy itself and fair.
I know the sweet seller of sportsman's wear
Has heart as hardened as Pharaoh's at best,
And that is why I smile and pass the test,
They do not know, Beloved, I am Your
guest.

10 And when Pharaoh drew near *the place*,
The children of Israel *for grace*
Lifted their eyes, and *saw* indeed,
Egyptians marched after with steed.
So they were very much afraid,
And the children of Israel brayed
Out to YHWH. 11 To Moses they said
"Because in Egypt no graves were,
Have you taken us all astray
Away to die in wilderness?
Why have you dealt so to unbless
Us, to bring us out of Egypt?
12 *"Is this not what in Egypt's script*
We told you saying 'Let us be
That we may serve Egyptians free?'
For better for us to serve the
Egyptians than that we should die
In the wilderness *for a try.*"
13 And Moses said to the folk, "Do
Not be afraid. Stand still, and you
Shall see the salvation of YHWH,
Which He will make for you today.
For the Egyptians whom you see
Today, you truly shall not see
Anymore then forever. 14 "YHWH
Your Alohim will fight for you,
And you shall hold your peace *at lee.*"

"Because there were no graves in Egypt,"
that's
Funny, and humour is what the fat cats
Still use to bolster argument for reason.
For reason's dull and boring out of season.
When humour sets the tone, it rules the
course,
While reason reaffirms the prickly gorse

I'm sitting on is soft as ilk. Deprive
 Me not, Beloved, of either where I strive
 Or float, but let me not be blinded by
 Humour's reasons or reason's laughing eye.
 I hear, Beloved, Your laughter and the
 voice
 Of argument in fine beyond the choice
 Of silence by which You still speak to me.
 Remove the veils, Beloved, and set me
 free.

15 And YHWH said to Moses, "Why do
 You cry to Me with shout and hue?
 Tell the children of Israel to
 Go forward. 16 "But lift up your rod,
 Stretch out your hand on sea *and sod*
 And divide it. And so the folk
 Of Israel shall walk dry *for soak*
 Through the midst of the sea. 17 "And I
 Indeed will harden *up and dry*
 The hearts of the Egyptians, and
 They'll follow them. So I'll command
 Honour over Pharaoh and all
 His army, chariot, horse *and stall*.
 18 "Then the Egyptians shall know I
Am YHWH, when I have gained the sky
 For Myself over Pharaoh then,
 Over his chariots, and his men."
 19 And the Angel of Alohim,
 Who went before *in cloud and beam*
 The camp of Israel, moved behind
 Them, and the pillar of cloud *lined*
 Went from before them, stood behind.
 20 So it came in between the camp
 Of the Egyptians and the camp
 Of Israel. Thus it was cloud
 And darkness *to Egyptian crowd*,
 And it gave light by night *in sight*,
 So they did not come near all night.

The veil that separates my soul from You
 In fire and light is darkness to those who
 Pursue my life for slavery and gain.
 On one side's light, and on the other rain,
 While the same veil distributes to all men.
 The cock rules in the same barnyard as hen.
 Beloved, remove not all the veils from me
 And lay me naked for the world to see.
 As long as lance and gun are on the shore
 I pray for veils at window and locked door.
 Who stands before Your face without a fear
 Is one who first has no fear at the ear.

And yet, Beloved, remove the veils from
 me
 When cannon, horse and men are sunk in
 sea.

21 Then Moses stretched out his hand on
 The sea, and YHWH caused sea till dawn
 To go by strong east wind all night,
 And made the sea into the dry,
 Dividing the waters thereby.
 22 So the children of Israel went
 Into the midst of the sea *sent*
 Upon the dry, the waters' wall
 To them on their right hand to loll
 And on their left. 23 And the Egyptians
 Pursued and went *with their conscriptions*
 After them into the sea's heart,
 All Pharaoh's horses *at the start*,
 His chariots, and his horsemen too.
 24 Now it happened, at morning watch,
 That YHWH looked down, *and not to*
 botch,
 Upon Egyptian army through
 The pillar of fire and of cloud,
 And troubled the Egyptian crowd.

Despoiler of mankind and woman too
 Is always sure he's got his rights to do.
 Excuse is always reason in his sight
 And what he does of evil's always right.
 To be right and not wrong gives courage
 when
 One faces nature's danger or its men.
 The argument of courage never fails
 To lead men in the seabed where the
 whales
 Themselves know not to go. Beloved,
 preserve
 My simple soul from courage, let me rest
 Instead a coward on Your loving breast.
 Let me not in my single right and song
 Go trampling on the seabed of the wrong.
 Beloved, give me a fainter heart, not verve.

25 And He took off their chariot wheels,
 So they drove with uneven keels,
 And the Egyptians said "Let's flee
 From the face of Israel, for He,
 YHWH, fights for them and against the
 Egyptians." 26 Then YHWH said to Moses,
 "Stretch out your hand where the sea
 closes,

That the waters may come back on
The Egyptians, their chariots, on
Their horsemen." 27 And Moses stretched
out

His hand over the sea about,
And when the morning light appeared,
The sea returned to its full tiered,
While the Egyptians in it fled.
So YHWH overthrew *and with dread*
Egyptians upon the seabed.
28 Then the waters returned and covered
The chariots, horsemen, all *that hovered*
Of the army of Pharaoh come
Into the sea after them, *swum*.
Not so much as one of them stayed.

I've seen Egyptian chariot wheels at least
In pictures if not reconstructed beast
In some Coptic museum on the block.
They're thin, like leg of gazelle, on a rock
Or rut it seems to me they'd surely break.
I would not put my trust in chariot's stake.
So did You really, my Beloved, come by
And take the wheels off with Your hand or
eye?

Or is this Moses' speaking in his zeal
When he says You Yourself took off the
wheel?

The reason I ask's that I'd like to know
If there's a chance You might once again
show

An inclination to technology.
I know some cogs and wheels You might
set free.

29 But the children of Israel made
A walk on dry through the sea-bed,
The waters walled them in its stead
Upon their right hand and their left.
30 So YHWH saved Israel *with hand deft*
That day out of Egyptians' hand,
And Israel saw Egyptians dead
On the seashore, upon the land.

31 Thus Israel saw the great work which
YHWH had done in Egypt *for switch*,
So the people feared YHWH, believed
YHWH, His servant Moses *retrieved*.

A crowd of people might believe a while
That someone is a prophet for his smile
And the fact that his leadership improves
World safety, how the economy moves.

For miracles the people believed Moses
A prophet sent from You, one who
discloses
The secrets of the future and past fate.
But prophethood hides hook beneath the
bait,
And when the sting comes folk are never
late
To reject whom they once rose to instate.
Beloved, I trust Your hand though still
unseen
To turn the evil in my life to green,
And trust Your prophet, though no Red
Seas part
To pave a way for me into Your heart.

Exodus 15

1 Then Moses and Israel's folk sang
This song to YHWH, in great harangue:
"I'll sing to YHWH, for gloriously
He's triumphed! He's thrown in the sea
The horse and rider! 2 YHWH's my
strength
And song, He has become *at length*
My salvation, He *is* my God,
And I will praise Him *under rod*,
My father's Alohim, and I'll
Exalt *and praise* Him *all the while*.
3 YHWH *is* a great warrior, and YHWH's
His name. 4 Pharaoh's chariots *abuse*
And his army cast in the sea,
Brave captains drowned in the Red Sea.
5 The depths have covered them, they sank
To the bottom like a stone *shank*.
6 "Your right hand, O YHWH, has become
Glorious in power *unquietsome*,
And Your right hand, O YHWH, has
dashed
The enemy in pieces *crashed*.

O my Beloved, overthrow in power
The enemy I find without, within!
I seek You only in this darkened hour
Of conflict caused by greed and blinded
sin.
O Huu, You glorious in power and right,
Look on oppression and the bloody fight
And raise once more the hand of might that
brought
The slave from Egypt long ago and caught
Oppression in its own entangled feet.
Dash the oppressor now as then in pieces

And raise the slave to freedom from the
seat
Of every sovereign and master's caprices
To do Your will alone. To You, not
brother,
I flee for refuge from myself and other.

7 In greatness of Your excellence
You've overthrown at their expense
Those who rose against You, You sent
Forth Your wrath, it consumed them spent
Like stubble. 8 And with the blast of
Your nostrils the waters above
Were gathered together, the floods
Stood upright like a heap, *the muds*
Of the depths congealed in the heart
Of the sea. 9 *And then for his part*
The enemy said 'I'll pursue,
I'll overtake, I'll grasp my due,
My will shall be done upon them.
I'll draw my sword in stratagem,
My hand shall destroy them.' 10 You blew
With Your wind, the sea covered them,
They sank like lead in mighty waters.

11 "Who's like You among gods *and*
daughters,
O YHWH, among the gods? Who's like
You, glorious, holy, and to strike
Fear in praises, and wonders done?

12 You stretched out Your right hand *and*
won,
The earth swallowed them *on the run*.

The first time Your wind blew across the
face
Of the primeval sea it left a trace
Since then called earth, place where I live
and breathe.

No wonder some prefer to call the seethe
And boil of that creative wind Your Spirit.
The Red Sea wind must have been such or
near it.

The wind that moves from You, Beloved, is
power

Creating in a week, but in an hour
Destroying the mad rush to overcome
The souls in flight to freedom for a crumb.
As I look on the Red Sea, calm, benign,
Let me not think, because there is no sign
That You are here, that all things now are
free.

The ripple on the wave is bound to be.

13 You in Your mercy have led forth
The people whom You have redeemed,
You've guided in Your strength thenceforth
To Your holy dwelling *esteemed*

14 "The people will hear *and* will fear
Sorrow take hold of whom appear
In the land of the Philistines.

15 Then the chiefs of Edom's designs
Will be undone, the mighty men
Of Moab, trembling will again
Take hold of them, all they who dwell
In Canaan will melt *and dispel*.

16 Fear and dread will fall upon them,
By greatness of Your stratagem
They will be *as* still as a stone,
Till Your people pass on alone,
O YHWH, till the people pass over
Whom You have purchased *from slave-*
drover.

17 You will bring them in and plant them
In the mountain of Your bright gem,
Place of inheritance, O YHWH,
Which You've made for Your own house
too,

The sanctuary, O Lord, Your
Hands have established *times of yore*.
18 "Eternally YHWH shall reign more."

The song of Moses rings out on the wind
That covered Pharaoh and his folk that
sinned.

The song sings on a barren land for lee
Where there is hardly bush and not a tree.
No temple clad in cedar, made of stone,
Encloses melodies on air alone.

The slave that was has left the golden
throne

And decorated temple in his flight
And found instead that destitution's right
Upon his heels no matter what the gold
Hidden in bosom says to make him bold.
Yet Moses sings of sanctuary fair
Set as eternal heritage somewhere.
Faith sees the fact upon the wind and air.

19 For the horses of Pharaoh went
With his chariots and horsemen sent
Into the sea, and YHWH brought back
The waters of the sea *in stack*
Upon them. But the children of
Israel went on dry *above*

And in the middle of the sea
Which was the road they had to flee.
20 Then Miriam the prophetess,
The sister of Aaron , *to bless*
Took timbrel in her hand, and all
The women went out *at her call*
After her with timbrels and dance.
21 And Miriam answered *as in trance*,
"Sing to YHWH, for He's gloriously
Triumphed! And He's thrown in the sea
The horse and rider wonderfully!"

Three and a half millennia ago
She lived and sang, that's why she had to
show
A thing or two before the joyful people.
Today such figures enter not the steeple.
For all the row the fact is prophets come
Today and for some time in centuries
As men and not as women who are dumb.
She's lucky she lived in a time decrees
Were more progressive than they've been
of late.
Queens we may have, and ministers of
state,
But prophets must be men and more's the
pity.
A Miriam once again would be right pretty.
Beloved, I sing with Miriam in her song
And with her brother too if I'm not wrong.

22 So Moses brought Israel out from
The Red Sea, from the way they'd come,
Then they went out in the desert
Of Shur, went three days *without hurt*
In the desert and found no water.
23 Now when they came up *without*
slaughter
To Marah, they could not drink there
The waters of Marah *or dare*,
For they *were* bitter, and that's why
The place was called Marah foreby.
24 And the people complained against
Moses, saying "What shall we drink?"
25 So he cried out to YHWH *incensed*,
And YHWH showed him a tree which he
Cast in the waters to make be
The waters sweet. He made law there
And ordinance to test them fair,
26 And said "If you diligently
Heed the voice of YHWH who's to be
Your God and do right in His sight,

Give ear to His commandments and
Keep all His statutes, I'll command
None of the illnesses on you
Which I have made Egyptians' due.
For I *am* YHWH, one who heals you."
27 Then they came to Elim, where there
Were twelve wells of water *to share*
And seventy palms, and so they
Camped there by the waters *that day*.

The secret keys of health are plainly met
In this obscure and middle passage set
Between the two great episodes known by
The rank and file of readers gone awry.
Not herb nor shaman nor confectioned pill
In face of illness' fortune fit the bill,
But rather following, Beloved, the laws
That You established after Red Sea jaws.
What statutes are these made, and what the
test?
What is the thing that gives health more
than rest?
The Sabbath returns fast on the twelve
palms
To show the way to health until death
calms.
Beloved, the Decalogue shows health and
life,
Long life for one, and for the other fife.

Exodus 16

1 They journeyed from Elim, and all
Israel's folk en masse *at the call*
Came to the Wilderness of Sin,
Which is between Elim, between
Sinai, on the fifteenth day of
The second month *from the above*
After they had left Egypt's land.
2 The folk of Israel, the whole band,
Complained against *both* Moses and
Aaron in the wilderness. 3 And
The children of Israel said
To them, "Oh, that we had been dead
All slaughtered by the hand of YHWH
In Egypt's land, when we *were true*
And sat beside the pots of meat
And ate bread to the full *for treat!*
For you have brought us out into
This wilderness to kill en masse
With hunger *without drink or grass.*"
4 Then said YHWH to Moses, "Behold,
I'll rain you down bread from the sky,

And the folk shall go out when told
And gather a certain rate by
Each day, that I may test them, if
They'll walk in my law, or be stiff.
5 And it shall be on the sixth day
They shall prepare what's in their sway,
And it shall be twice as much then
As when they gather the day's yen.

Although I disdain Israel for complaint,
I too know how to pretend to be saint.
I too each day despise the great salvation
That You provide, by my bold
 consternation
That desert life sometimes feels hot or cold,
And think that since You saved, You
 should have told
Me that a trial of stinger might appear,
Or other form of blight or pain or fear.
But You, Beloved, gave me the wrong
 impression,
That ecstasy should never know cessation,
The beauty of the Sabbath rest You gave
Belied the fact that I'm still daily slave
To duties of the Sunday-Monday roll,
And I forget fleshpots were not the goal.

6 And said Moses and Aaron to
All the children of Israel, "*True*
At evening you shall know that YHWH
Has brought you out of Egypt's land.
7 "And at morn you shall *understand*
And see the glory *done* of YHWH,
For He hears your complaints against
YHWH, but what *are* we, that against
Us you address complaint?" 8 Also
Moses said "When YHWH *is not slow*
To give you meat to eat at eve,
And in the morning bread receive
To the full, for YHWH hears the plaints
You make against Him *and His saints*.
And what *are* we? All your complaint's
Not against us but against YHWH."
9 Then Moses spoke to Aaron, "Do
Say to all gathered Israel's folk,
'Come near before YHWH, for He *woke*
To hear the complaints that you spoke.'"
10 Now it happened, as Aaron spoke
To all the gathered Israel's folk,
That they looked toward the wilderness,
And indeed, in the cloud to bless
Appeared YHWH's glory *I confess*.

Indeed You gave a hint, Beloved, in what
You said, but it is human just to shut
The ear to what we hear and then pretend
You said the opposite of what You send.
You did not say it would be glory when
The quail came down at eve to feed the
 men,
But that they would know by the power and
 act
That Your bringing them from Egypt was
 fact.
The glory comes only when manna falls
And covers earth and even the tent walls.
Preserve me, my Beloved, from my
 complaint
That might make hearing ears deaf in the
 saint.
Let me hear only what you say and live
To eat alone the manna that You give.

11 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
12 "I've heard complaints from Israel's folk.
Speak to them, saying 'You'll be fed
At twilight meat, and at *the stroke*
Of morning you'll be filled with bread.
And you shall know that I *am* YHWH
Your Alohim *whate'er* you do.'"

The Hebrew melody lies with pathos upon
The words "complaints of Israel's folk." I
 swan
But human views fail to take in what You
Experience in the things we humans do.
Beloved, how like an arrow in the heart
Of God is the ingratitude on part
Of humans who find complaint in Your
 start
To lead through hungry desert paths up to
The promised ecstasies of derring-do.
Here I repent, Beloved, that I lack joy
When the way's rough and I fail to employ
The faith that sees Your presence closer
 still
In desert silences than in the thrill
Of knowing sweet expressions of Your
 will.

13 So it was quails came up at eve
And covered the camp sans reprieve,
And in the morning the dew lay
All around the camp *every way*.

14 And when the dew lifted, there on
 The surface of the wilderness,
 Was a small round thing *after dawn*,
As fine as frost as one might guess
 Upon the ground. 15 So when the folk
 Of Israel saw *it*, then they spoke
 To one another, "What is it?"
 For they did not know it was *fit*.
 And Moses said to them, "This *is*
 The bread which YHWH has given *of His*
 For you to eat. 16 "This is the thing
 Which YHWH's commanded, 'Let each
 bring
 His gathered portion for the need
 Of each, *what he can eat indeed*,
Of bread, one omer for each one
 Until the people's number's done,
 As many as are in each tent.'" 17
 Then Israel did so and went
 To gather, some more, and some less.
 18 So when they measured *what they guess*
 By omers, he who gathered much
 Had nothing left over *as such*,
 And he who gathered little had
 No lack *at all to make him sad*.
 And every man had gathered what
 He needed *to fill up his gut*.

If I had been there in the wilderness
 To gather up the manna, I can guess
 I would have been among those who took
 less.
 The stuff was small and down upon the
 ground
 And had to be picked on one's knees or
 found
 By bending over, crick in back and neck,
 To scrape the almost microscopic stuff
 Into the basket till one had a peck.
 Such work is not for lazy men and duff.
 I'd leave the field before I had enough.
 So do I now with prayer, so do I still
 With recitation of the lovely Word,
 I take a morsel and trust You are stirred
 To multiply the hope and make my fill.

19 And Moses said "Let no one leave
 Any of it till morning *cleave*."
 20 Notwithstanding they did not heed
 Moses, but some left part *indeed*
 Until the morning, and it bred
 Worms and stank. And Moses was *led*

To wrath against them. 21 And they picked
 It every morning, to be strict
 According to every man's need.
 And when the sun *at last* got hot,
The manna melted and was not.

And yet, Beloved, it surely is wise thing
 To provide for the future and not sing
 Away the day with only fruit enough
 For the one daily meal and no more stuff.
 Who saved the manna were wise and who
 thought
 They'd trust You for tomorrow, they were
 not.
 You've seen the northern hunter's family
 die
 Because when ice came they'd no stores set
 by.
 I in a land of wealth may seem to be
 Among those of relative poverty,
 But I too have a cupboard where the fare
 Upon occasion spoils for lack of wear.
 Let me in my wealth still, Beloved, trust
 You,
 And when the cupboard's bare, still give
 Your due.

22 And so it was, on the sixth day,
That they gathered twice *in their way*
 As much bread, two omers for each.
 And all the rulers *come to teach*
 The congregation came and told
 Moses. 23 Then he said to them *bold*,
"This is what YHWH has said 'Tomorrow
Is a Sabbath rest without sorrow,
 A holy Sabbath to YHWH. Bake
 What you will bake *today*, and boil
 What you will boil and *for your sake*,
 Lay up for yourselves *not to spoil*
 All that remains until tomorrow."

The sixth day from beginning saw the
 blessing
 You once pronounced on man and beast
 still guessing
 What they should eat and who should eat
 and how.
 That double blessing blesses even now
 And on each sixth day that returns to show
 That You alone provide the meal to go.
 A double portion of the manna or
 A prayer in congregation at the fore,

All show You are the best of all providers
Among farmers, canners, inside-, outsiders.
On the sixth day You still give nourishment
To body and to soul and thus prevent
Excuses that arise on Sabbath day
To trample it in search of manna's way.

24 So they laid it up till the morning,
As Moses told *them without scorning*,
And it did not stink *as before*,
Nor were worms in it *anymore*.

Food blessed on the sixth day when
Sabbath comes
Is goodness multiplied in all its sums.
The very food I eat pretends to show
The difference in days when blessings go.
What stinks and breeds worms every other
day
Becomes a sweet cake by Your blessing
way.
What You make sweet on sixth day's morn
and eve
On Sabbath day's a gift that I receive.
On Sunday You make stench and wormy
food
For those unfaithful to Your word and
brood.
On Friday you bless man and beast and
bread,
On Saturday they're still provided, fed.
Beloved, let me return to You each day
Without complaint take what You give
away.

25 Then Moses said "Eat that today,
For today *is* YHWH's Sabbath day,
Today you'll not find it abroad.
26 "Six days you'll gather from the sod,
But on the seventh day, the Sabbath,
There will be none *for him who grabbeth*."

As I throughout the worried week
Seek solace in Thy care,
Let me in everything I seek
Find Your grace everywhere.
Throughout the week the manna came
But kept for just a day.
The sixth day knew a double claim,
Sabbath without decay.
Although my plots may end in spoil
And not security,

Fruit of my toil born of the soil
Is manna sent from Thee.
This Sabbath let Your child sojourn
In prayer before Your throne
That I may learn that what I earn
Is grace and grace alone.

27 Now it happened that some went out
Upon the seventh day for doubt
To gather it, but they found none.
28 And YHWH said to Moses, "*I'm done*.
How long do you refuse to keep
My laws and My commandments deep?
29 "See! For YHWH's given you the
Sabbath,
Therefore He gives you bread that stabbeth
Two days *instead of one* upon
The sixth day. Let each man *at dawn*
Remain in place, let none go out
Of his place on the seventh day."
30 And so the people *went about*
To rest upon the seventh day.
31 And the house of Israel named it
Manna. And it *was* like white *fit*
Coriander seed, and its taste
Was like honey wafers *or paste*.

Once I ate coriander seed to know
How manna must have tasted long ago.
Yet I've long since forgotten that sweet
taste
And so my research ended in a waste.
Let me go no more in search of new food
To nourish my soul in the solitude
Of Sabbath day, instead let me contrive
To rest in Your provision and alive.
I see the Sunday rush to pagan din
And frantic pleasure search and other sin.
I see the flight to wealth on Sabbath day
Without a thought of what You had to say.
Beloved, I wait with day-old bread in crust
Upon the Sabbath day and find its lust.

32 Then Moses said "This *is* the thing
Which YHWH's commanded *in the ring*,
'Fill an omer with it, to keep
Throughout your generations' *sweep*,
That they may see the bread with which
I fed you in the desert stitch,
When I brought you out of the land
Of Egypt *with a mighty hand*."
33 And Moses said to Aaron, "Take

A pot and put an omer's sake
 Of manna in it, lay it up
 Before YHWH, to be kept *in cup*
 Throughout your generations' *wake*."
 34 As YHWH commanded Moses, so
 Aaron laid it up *in the glow*
 Before the testimony kept.
 35 Israel's folk forty years adept
 Ate manna, till they came into
 A land inhabited *anew*,
 They ate manna until they came
 To the border of Canaan's claim.
 36 An omer's one-tenth of an ephah
 To say *the measurement in briefer*.

So Aaron put an omer's worth in store
 Of manna that might stink and breed
 worms more.
 What did not last a day in circumstance,
 And only two with Friday's whirl and
 dance,
 Remained untainted throughout generations
 And may be somewhere still among the
 nations
 Or at Axum, who knows, set safe beneath
 The cherubim and what their wings
 bequeath.
 The manna that I take anew each day
 Runs risk of spoiling sometime on the way.
 And so I bring it still steaming and sweet
 To stay in the light of the safe retreat
 Of tables of the covenant that make
 What otherwise would spoil truth for my
 sake.

Exodus 17

1 Then all the congregation of
 Israel's folk set out *from above*
 On their journey going from Sin
 The desert, by command *between*
 Of YHWH, and camped in Rephidim,
 Where water was not, it would seem,
 For the people to drink. 2 Therefore
 The people contended before
 Moses, and said "Give us to drink
 Water." Said Moses to them, "*Think*
 Why do you contend with me? Why
 Do you tempt YHWH, *why do you cry?*"
 3 And the people thirsted there for
 Water, and complained what is more
 Against Moses, and said "Why did
 You bring us from Egypt, to rid

The world of us and our children
 And our livestock with thirst *again?*"
 4 So Moses cried out to YHWH, saying
 "What shall I do with this folk's *playing?*
 They are almost ready to stone me!"
 5 And YHWH said to Moses, "*Now own*
 Me,
 Go on before the people, and
 Take with you some, *by My command*,
 Of Israel's elders. Also take
 In your hand your rod by whose sake
 You struck the river, and *now go*.
 6 "Indeed, I will stand *without show*
 Before you there upon the rock
 In Horeb, and you'll strike the rock,
 And water will come out of it,
 That the people may drink it *fit*."
 And Moses did so in the sight
 Of Israel's elders *on the right*.
 7 So he called the name of the place
 Massah and Meribah, to trace
 The contention of Israel's folk,
 Because they tempted YHWH, and spoke,
 "Is YHWH among us here or not?"
They could not see Him whom they sought.

Beloved, I stand here in a desert place
 To hear no voice, and to discern no face
 Divine above the barren track and stone.
 I'm in the wilderness, and all alone.
 By neither faith nor sight I know that You
 Unseen, unheard stand by the rock and dew
 Fresh in the morning sun before the heat
 Of traffic and noonday come to defeat.
 By neither faith nor sight I know Your
 being
 Is firmer than my thought and act and
 seeing.
 I rather than You exist by Your act
 Of faith and word, fleeting and inexact.
 If You can have faith in my shadow here,
 Then I can reaffirm where You appear.

8 Came Amalek and so he fought
 With Israel in Rephidim.
 9 Moses told Joshua *to part*,
 "Choose us some *good men as you deem*
 And go out, fight with Amalek.
 Tomorrow I'll stand on the neck
 Of your hill with Alohim's rod
 In my hand, *only trust in God*."
 10 Joshua did as Moses said

To him, and fought *as he was led*
 With Amalek. And Moses, and
 Aaron, and Hur went *by command*
 Up to the top of the hill. 11 And
 So it was, when Moses held up
 His hand, that Israel won the cup,
 Prevailed, and when he let his hand
 Down, Amalek then took the stand.
 12 But Moses' hands *were* heavy, so
 They took a stone and put *it low*
 Beneath him, and he sat on it.
 And Aaron and Hur, *who were fit*,
 Supported his hands, on each side,
 And his hands were steady *and tried*
 Until the going down of sun.
 13 With Amalek Joshua won
 And killed his people with the mouth
 Of the sword *yonder in the south*.

You are about to say on Sinai that
 No killing is allowed where You are at.
 And yet You are the One to win the day
 With Amalek and Joshua in the fray.
 If I may not kill others, then it seems
 To take part in war is a thing for dreams
 And not my divine-portioned act to do.
 Of course killing's a thing all right for You
 Who have created and by rights You may
 Destroy what You Yourself have made to
 be.

Perhaps You may give command specially
 To kill in Your place and at Your own
 game.

I fear, however, that the ones who claim
 Are oft mistaken to kill in Your name.

14 And said YHWH to Moses, "Write this
 Memorial in the book and
 Recount *it without cowardice*,
 In Joshua's hearing remand,
 That I'll blot out and utterly
 Remembrance of Amalek's *tree*
 From under heaven." 15 And so built
 Moses an altar *without guilt*
 And called its name, YHWH-Is-My-
 Banner,

16 For he said "Because *in His manner*
 YHWH's sworn, YHWH *will have*
 disputations
 With Amalek for generations."

Granted that Amelek came out to fight

And thus created his own rankling plight,
 But does that mean for many generations
 There is no hope the children's
 congregations

May not do right and so have peace with
 You?

Or do You mean that doing right and true
 Cuts no ice if the fathers were not nice?
 I guess rebellion is a family vice
 That's handed down from mother to her
 sons,

And justifies extinction of such ones.
 Beloved, "and for my children, too" prayed
 he

Who became father to all nations free,
 While You gave answer that the moral code
 Was all that mattered as the human load.

Week 17 Exodus 18

1 And Jethro, priest of Midian,
 Moses' father-in-law, *the man*,
 Heard of all that Alohim did
 For Moses and for Israel's *bid*,
 His people that YHWH had brought out
 Of Egypt, Israel *with a shout*.

2 Moses' father-in-law Jethro,
 Took Zipporah, Moses' wife so,
 After he'd sent her back, 3 with her
 Two sons, of whom the name of one
 Was Gershom, for "I've been stranger"
 He said "under a foreign sun."

4 And the name of the other *was*
 Eliezer, for "Alohim does
 Deliver me from Pharaoh's sword,
 Who was also my father's Lord,"

5 Moses' father-in-law Jethro,
 Came with his sons and wife in tow
 To Moses in the wilderness,
 Where he encamped at the access
 Of the mountain of Alohim.
 6 Now he'd said to Moses, "*My scheme*
Is that I, Jethro, your wife's father,
Am coming to you with wife, rather
With her two sons in her esteem."

Egypt was not place good enough, it seems,
 As long as it stayed under Pharaoh's
 dreams,

For Moses' own wife and children to stay,
 And so he sent the three out of harm's way.
 I guess the other leader's, Aaron's, sons
 And daughters had no visa in their runs,

And could not leave the battle zone to play.
 The better part of bravery is not
 To introduce some slavery unsought
 To one's dependents when the battle's hot.
 The reasoned duty of each one who knows
 That You, Beloved, are One is to keep toes
 As warm as possible and not frost-bitten.
 That's why a man has feelings for the
 fitting.

7 Moses went out to meet the father
 Of his wife and bowed *without bother*
 And kissed him, and they asked each other
 Of their Islam, *or how the brother*
Did, then they both went in the tent.
 8 Moses told his wife's father *bent*
 What YHWH did to Pharaoh and to
 The Egyptians for Israel's due,
 And all the hardship that had come
 Upon them on the way, and YHWH
 Had saved them *from what they'd gone*
 through.

9 Jethro rejoiced for all the good
 Which YHWH did where Israel *stood*,
 Whom He delivered from the hand
 Of the Egyptians *and their land*.

10 And Jethro said "Blessèd be YHWH,
 Who has delivered *all of you*
 From the Egyptians hand and out
 Of Pharaoh's hand *in turn about*,
 Delivered the people from under
 The hand of the Egyptians's *thunder*.

11 "Now I know that YHWH's greater than
 All the gods *invented by man*,
 For in the very thing in which
 They behaved proudly, *for a switch*
He was above them." 12 Then Jethro,
 Moses' wife's father took *below*
 A burnt offering and sacrifices
 To Alohim *for His devices*.
 And Aaron came with all the old
 Ones of Israel to eat bread cold
 With Moses' wife's father before
 Alohim *whom they all adore*.

Jethro was heathen I suppose to those
 Today who find all belief must repose
 On human sacrifice, although he took
 Offerings to Alohim before the book
 Of legislation had been written. Now,
 It seems to me his faith was just a bough
 Of that planted by Abraham before

And spread as far as Ethiopian shore,
 Perhaps seeds blown there by the feisty
 wind,
 Or floating on the Red Sea scaled and
 finned.

At least his genes go back to Abram's
 stealth
 In taking Keturah and her bride-wealth.
 Beloved, the desert's filled with those Your
 own
 And lonely thus no servant stands alone.

Jethro rejoiced for all the good You did
 To Israel in Egypt where they hid.
 He did not thank you for the evil act
 That fell on them, nor for the rod exact
 Taskmasters used to scar the people's
 backs.

I guess his faith was not faith of the axe
 As some today who find Your finger where
 Oppression cracks and suffering seethes the
 air.

Some thank for good and bad and some
 rejoice
 Alone to hear, Beloved, Your still small
 voice

In justice and in mercy always given,
 And never partisan to evil driven.
 Beloved, I thank You for the things You
 do,
 And in the evil I am silence, true.

13 On the next day it happened that
 The people stood where Moses sat
 To judge the people *all day long*
 From morn to eve *without a song*.

14 When Moses' wife's father saw all
 He did for the folk *at their call*,
 He said "What thing is this that you
 Are doing for the people's *due*?
 Why do you sit alone, and all
 The folk stand before you *and call*
 From morning until evenfall?"

15 Moses told his wife's father, "Since
 The people come, *I do not wince*,
 But they inquire of Alohim.

16 "When they've a question, then they
 seem

To come to me, I judge between
 One and another *at the scene*,
 And show statutes of Alohim
 And His laws, *all that I have seen*."

The role wife's father takes seems mighty
 blessed
 That he can question prophets at their best.
 At least Jethro thinks he can tell a tale
 To make the prophet hit another nail.
 He asks him why he is accessible
 To one and all who never will get full.
 The hangers-on reveal the case of each
 Usurper that arises now to preach.
 Will Jethro make suggestion Moses follow
 That scheme of things and in the same
 pride wallow?
 Reality is every human claim
 Is limited in strength and time, no shame.
 Accessibility is not the thing
 That validates what You and prophets sing.

17 Moses' wife's father said to him,
 "The thing you do's not good, *but dim*.
 18 "Both you and these people with you
 Will surely wear yourselves out too.
 For this thing *is* too much for you,
 You by yourself cannot do it.
 19 "Listen now to my voice *that's fit*,
 I shall give you some good advice,
 Alohim will bless your device:
 Stand before Alohim to bring
 For the people every hard thing.
 20 "And you shall teach them the statutes
 And laws, and show *beyond disputes*
 The way in which they ought to walk
 And the thing they must do *and talk*.
 21 "Moreover you shall select from
 All the people able men, some
 As fear Alohim, truthful men,
 Hating covetousness, and then
 Place *such* over them *to be* rulers
 Of thousands, hundreds, *but not foolers*,
 Rulers of fifty, and of ten.
 22 "Let them judge the folk at all times.
 Then it will be *that* greater crimes
 They shall bring to you, but the small
 Matters they themselves shall recall.
 So it will be easier for you,
 For they'll bear *the burden* with you.
 23 "If you do this thing, Alohim
 Commands you to, then you will seem
 Able to endure, and all these
 Will also find their place in peace
Or in Islam as the wise sees."
 24 So Moses heeded the voice of

His wife's father *whom he did love*
 In all that he had said above.
 25 And Moses chose able men out
 Of all Israel, and gave them clout
 Over the people: rulers of
 Thousands, rulers of hundreds too,
 Rulers of fifties *to be true*,
 Rulers of tens. 26 And so they sat
 To judge the people *where they're at*
 At all times, the hard cases they
 Brought to Moses, *what he would say*,
 But they judged every small case for
 Themselves. 27 Then Moses let therefore
 His wife's father depart *the strand*,
 And he went into his own land.

Note well, Beloved, how my tribe has
 refused
 To follow in Your plot and been confused.
 You set Your leader, guide duly appointed
 To teach the laws and statutes as anointed,
 And rulers over groups to try the cases
 To see who's in the right or wrong in races.
 The rulers do not establish what's right,
 But rather who hit first when two men
 fight.
 Law and order are different things I see,
 You are the one appointing law to be,
 While Your prophet sets officer for order,
 Who is not divine guide but only boarder
 In Your house. Now, Beloved, I set aside
 Usurpers who rule in their wrong and pride.

Exodus 19

1 In the third month after the folk
 Of Israel had left Egypt's yoke,
 On the same day, they came *into*
 Sinai's desert. 2 For they *in due*
Course had departed Rephidim,
 Come *to* the Sinai desert's *rim*,
 And camped *there* in the wilderness.
 So Israel camped east of the hill.
 3 And went Moses, *a man to bless*,
 Up to Alohim, *not for ill*,
 And YHWH called to him from the hill
 Saying "Thus you shall say unto
 The house of Jacob *what to do*,
 And tell the folk of Israel,
 4 'You've seen what I did, *and seen well*,
 To the Egyptians, *how* I carried
 You on eagles' wings, how I *married*
 You to Myself. 5 'Now therefore, if

You will indeed obey My voice
And keep My pact *not in a tiff*
Then you shall be My special *choice*
Treasure above all people, for
All earth is Mine. 6 'And *what is more*,
You'll be to Me a kingdom of
Priests and holy nation *I love*.'
These *are* the words which you shall speak
To Israel's folk *to be unique*."

How language concepts change in time, I
think,
To opposites from what they were, and sink
From beauties to atrocities and yet
The people strive to win the selfsame bet!
The donkey in the Bible once was best
Of all its creatures from the east to west.
The eagle appeared in the sacred Script
As loving wings coming out of Egypt.
From tender care of its young in new flight
The figure turns to savagery and spite.
Beloved, I flee to You and to the source
Of love and beauty, and make my divorce
From steel institutions of a day
Between a sky of iron and earth of clay.

7 Came Moses and called for the old
Men and women of the folk, told
Before them all these things which YHWH
Commanded him *that they should do*.
8 Then answered all the folk together
And said "All that YHWH's spoken blether
We'll do." So Moses brought the answer
Of the folk to YHWH *in advancer*.

Let me not glibly, my Beloved, give answer
To Your call from the tender winging
dancer
That whirls me out of slave to sot and sane.
The desert's desert in the sun and rain.
Though I am old and wise as Yiddish
mama,
And know the sky better than desert
farmer,
Let me not strike a stroke to say I'll do
What I've not yet heard from Your word
and You.
Beloved, let me wait till Your silent word
Outsounds the trumpeting of baseless
herd,
Before I make a solemn promise wept
Because in faith I had no promise kept.

Let me obey Your known will now, today,
And let the morrow take its single way.

9 And said YHWH to Moses, "Indeed,
I come to you by thick cloud's *steed*,
That the people may hear when I
Speak with you, believe you for aye."
Moses told the words of the people
To YHWH. 10 YHWH said *without a*
steeple

To Moses, "To the people go
And consecrate them *for the show*
Today, tomorrow, let them wash
Their clothes, 11 "be ready *and not josh*
For the third day. For on the third
Day YHWH will come down *with His*
word

Upon Mount Sinai in the sight
Of all the people *to their fright*.

12 "You shall set bounds and all around
For the people, saying '*Be bound*,
Take heed to yourselves *that* you do
Not go up, the mountain's taboo,
Touch not its base. The one to touch
The mount shall die *for doing such*.
13 'Not a hand shall touch him, but he
Shall surely be stoned or shot *much*,
If man or beast, he'll not go free.'
When the trumpet sounds long, they shall
Come near the mountain *at the call*."

Beloved, the one to touch the ark was
struck
Down dead, by magic power or by bad luck
Or by Your hand of majesty and dread.
That man of course was not by manna fed.
You gave no order then to kill the bloke
Who disobeyed in good-intentioned stroke,
But killed the lad Yourself for his
blasphemy.
Was it that in Sir Moses' time the squeamy
Were not in evidence? I live a time
When few there be who hate the horrid
crime
Of taking life, at least when that life be
Defined as of a different faith and tree.
Death surely stays the bounds of life today
Just as it did when Moses' rules held sway.

14 So Moses went down from the mount
To the people, *all he could count*
He sanctified, and they washed their

Clothes. 15 And he told the people fair,
"Be ready for the third day, do
Not come near wives *or barley-broo*."

16 Then it happened on the third day,
In the morning, *they heard the bray*
Of thunderings and lightnings flash,
A thick cloud on the mountain *sash*,
And the sound of the trumpet loud,
So in the camp trembled the crowd.

17 And Moses brought the people out
Of camp to meet Alohim *stout*,
And they stood at the mountain's foot.

18 Now Mount Sinai *for leaf and root*
Was full of smoke, because YHWH came
Down on it in fire *and in flame*.
Its smoke ascended like the smoke
Of a furnace, and *at the stroke*
The whole mountain quaked greatly. 19

And
When the blast of the trumpet grand
Sounded long and louder became,
Moses spoke, Alohim by name
Answered him. 20 And then down YHWH
came

Upon Mount Sinai, on the top
Of the mountain. YHWH *did not stop*
Calling Moses up to the top
Of the mountain, Moses went up.

I should have known, Beloved, You're a
musician
As well as Lord, Creator, and physician.
I only might have guessed Your favoured
share
Of instruments was chosen with more care.
I guess a trumpet is a good choice too,
Although a harp or lyre might better do
For those convention binds in thought and
tongue.
Now days a guitar might be better strung.
I wonder what concerto You chose then
In Your performance to the sons of men.
I've heard the Mendelssohn for violin
Done on the trumpet, which, if not a sin,
Weds Christian sound to Jewish father's
pride.
I wonder if that pair was on Your side.

21 And YHWH said to Moses, "Go down
And warn the people, lest *with frown*
They break through to gaze at YHWH, and
Many of them die at My hand.

22 "Also let the priests who come near
YHWH consecrate themselves *in fear*,
Lest YHWH break out against them." 23
But

Moses told YHWH, "The folk are shut
From coming up to Mount Sinai,
For You warned us *that we should die*,
Saying 'Set bounds around the mount
And consecrate it *root and fount*.'"

24 Then YHWH said unto him, "Away!
Get down and then come up *to stay*,
You and Aaron with you, but do
Not let priests and people break through
To come up to YHWH, lest He break
Out against them, *make no mistake*."
25 So Moses went down to the folk
And told them *what the Lord God spoke*.

I laugh to think that Moses saw a duty
To tell You what You had forgotten,
Beauty.

At that You show Your temper to the man
And send him off to come as best he can.
Perhaps Moses did not intend to say
That You'd forgotten the bounds and belay.
Perhaps at eighty years he felt the trip
Back down to camp was not worth slide
and slip,
Since they'd been once warned to keep
distance right.

At eighty-odd an old man shows no spite
At hesitating to hike Sinai's slope
Both down and back just for a second
warning.

Beloved, I think Moses was never scorning,
But walked on tired feet and with a hope.

Exodus 20

1 Then Alohim spoke all these things
2 I am YHWH Alohim whose wings
Brought you from Egypt and slavery.
3 You shall have no gods except Me.
4 No graven image shall you make,
Nor heavenly likeness shall you take,
Nor from the earth beneath nor from
The waters under earth in sum.
5 Before them you shall not prostrate,
Nor shall you worship them *in state*.
For I YHWH am your Alohim,
A jealous husband *it may seem*
Who limits evil on the score
Of generations to not more

Than three or four, what parents do
 Affecting children's children too,
 By the hate that they bear to Me.
 6 But multiplying wonderfully
 To thousands of their generations
 Effects of any cultivations
 Of good they might do who love Me
 And keep My statutes faithfully.
 7 Do not lift up the name of YHWH
 Your Alohim in vain, for who
 Does so shall surely not receive
 Acquittal from YHWH *and reprove*.
 8 Remember now the Sabbath day
 To keep it holy *every way*.
 9 Six days work and do all your tasks,
 10 But seventh day's a rest that asks
 YHWH your Alohim to keep well,
Do no work in it, buy or sell.
 In it you shall not work nor labour,
 You, son nor daughter, nor the neighbour
 Man nor the maid in your employ.
 Let even animals take joy,
 And every visitor that's strayed
 Your gates. 11 For in six days YHWH
 made
 The pair of skies and earth and stayed
 To make the sea and what's in it.
 Then He lighted on seventh day
 To take comfort in it as fit,
 And *kneeling* blessed the Sabbath day,
 So did YHWH sanctifying it.
 12 Give honour to your mom and dad,
 So that your life may *not* be *sad*,
But long upon the ground YHWH's given,
 And Alohim for you to live in.
 13 You shall not kill. 14 And you shall not
 Commit adultery. 15 Do not
 Steal. 16 Do not bear against your
 neighbour
 False witness. 17 Do not covet neighbour
 Of his house, do not covet his
 Wife, nor his male worker, nor his
 Female worker, *oxen*, nor his
 Donkey nor anything which is
 Your neighbour's *property or labour*.

The Lord God spoke these words to say
 How we should walk the narrow way.
 "I am the Lord your God who brought
 You out from bondage" and then taught
 The holy name YHWH Alohim—
 Supreme Reality to beam

Light on the truth that God is one.
 If any man or mother's son
 Try to divide the human race,
 He disfigures the divine face.
 Nothing at all in all creation,
 Which is God's image of elation,
 Can give the model whereby He
 May be carved in His symmetry.
 Let me not grasp an image here
 As though the waverings that appear
 Were worthy of worship and fear.
 The workings of theology
 Are fornicate idolatry,
 Since any concept I confess
 Can only be the outer dress.
 Let me not bow to what is known
 Nor err about what has been shown.
 God's jealousy arouses wrath,
 And yet He limits on the path
 The natural effects of wrong
 And multiplies in grateful song
 Each act of goodness that men do
 A thousand times beyond the true.
 His mercy needs no sacrifice
 Beyond the love that will suffice
 Obeying His commandments' voice:
 His name uplifted to make choice
 Repenting every act mistaken
 And restituting what was taken
 Ends in the declaration that
 A man's not guilty where he sat.
 Let me lift up on Sabbath day
 That holy name by which I pray
 And set aside my daily tasks
 To do what His commandment asks.
 It refers to more than a day,
 But to the golden, blessed way
 That all the great must treat the small:
 Father to son and at her call
 Mother to daughter and the boss
 To worker, who has rights not loss,
 The landsman to the refugee
 Cast up a stranger on his lea,
 And every human being to
 The animal and nature's crew.
 The ethics of the Sabbath cast
 A limit on the right to last
 Of every strong upon the least:
 Sabbath divides man from the beast
 Denying in a world of care
 Survival of fittest to bear,
 Instead the duty of each one

To recognize a limit done
 On power and rights not to be won
 But inborn for servant and son.
 The Sabbath takes away the need
 Of labour union, nature's creed
 By limiting both power and greed.
 The arbitrary time it comes
 Undermines every despot's sums.
 In all the divine law I see
 Only one law to make men free,
 A positive act to be done
 To lengthen life beneath the sun.
 The only thing a man can do
 That remains on earth right and true
 Is honour to his mom and dad.
 Every other monument's sad
 Attempt at doing well, but clad
 In idol clothing of the cad.
 Let me not take another's life
 Nor enter in the door of strife,
 Competing in vain pursuit of
 Empty status and honour's love.
 The one I strike in striking him
 Is also my own self, thought grim,
 And every self is but the glow
 Of one true Self where God will show.
 Therefore adultery's a crime
 And stealing is to share the rhyme
 Of that delusion that makes some
 Superior for wealth and gum.
 Let me bear no false witness to
 Another's act that is not true,
 But in my speech and what I do
 Recognize God's face in the crew.
 The symbol and the chains of power
 Invested in contracts an hour
 Or in houses or in the wealth
 Of workers human or in stealth
 Bestial to create and transport
 Goods for profit from store to fort,
 Let me not covet. Let me go
 Naked upon the earth to show
 Dependence on Lord God alone,
 To howl aloft and chew the bone,
 To find gold and diamonds are strewn
 In plenty to whom hark the moon,
 And in my simple fakir way
 I chase my tail instead to pray,
 And cast aside all that is vain,
 Says dervish Thomas McElwain.

The prophets speak in ecstasy

Of what they hear prophetically,
 And critics rave and rage when Art
 Reels on the stage in glittering part.
 The markets for both fashion and
 The best in classics can't withstand
 The run on wares, the prices take
 A leap toward heaven for heaven's sake.
 Yet all the world stood still for once
 And all the merchants stopped their stunts
 While men and women duly heard
 The great pronouncements of Your word.
 For one time You Yourself came down
 And spoke commandments to the town.

No man or woman ever heard You speak
 The word that brought forth light, changed
 night to day,
 The word that touched with breath and
 place the way
 Toward sea and earth and life on that first
 week.
 No ear heard when You spoke the stars and
 moon
 Above the flight of wing and creeping
 thing,
 And only Eve and Adam heard You sing
 First Sabbath blessing. Noah heard You
 soon
 And Abraham and prophets one by one,
 You spoke the words to anxious crowds
 and waiting
 And trembling at the thunder, vacillating
 In pregnant silence till Your word was
 done.
 On one occasion only You spoke free
 So all might hear and know eternally.

You spoke these words. No others came
 So all could hear them just the same.
 You passed by prophets and their sons,
 You left off dreams and vision-puns
 And stood where all could see and hear
 The sight of flashing lightning, fear
 The break of thunder and go down
 On trembling knees before Your crown.
 You came down once, but never after
 Broke in upon our grief or laughter,
 That one trip and one speech unique
 Occurred one time on Sinai's peak.
 Since then mankind before Your face
 Tried to forget Your law and grace.

O my Beloved! Let me not have another!
Like You, Belovèd, I too have no brother.
If You are God alone, there is no thing
That can compare with You, there is no
king

But is beneath Your sovereignty, no man
Can take Your glory, honour, no man can.
The blessed Messiah also bows to You
In worship, and so do the prophets too.
The whole world is a temple, every face
Returns to You in every time and place.
Of all who breathe none can resist Your
call.

You are Creator and the Lord of all.
Let no one take Your place within my
heart.

One without equal, You're the better part.

The great I AM speaks to the crowd as
though

One soul alone were listening to the voice,
And one soul only had to make the choice
To follow You or let Your ten words go.
And every person stands from day to day
Alone beneath the mountain, silent, grim,
Where echoes of Your voice along the rim
Make blueberries quiver, maples turn away,
And fleeing slaves forget where they've
come from.

For every man was once a slave awhile,
And every woman's tasted of the Nile,
Who wait and hope a thunder cloud will
come.

Today at last we're free to stand and hear
What words of Yours may never disappear.

Let me make nothing to remind me of
The God You are, Your sovereignty and
love.

To make an image carved in stone or mind
Means that I think You're nowhere I can
find,

And so I need this thing or that to know
You in Your absence, since You do not
show.

But surely I do not hear when You speak
Because I'm not Your audience to seek,
I am instead the words upon Your tongue,
And not the climber on the ladder's rung.
The listener hears the story, not the one
About whom story's told and things are
done.

I see You not, not since You are too far,
But since You keep me close to where you
are.

They used to make gods' images in stone,
When stone turned dust they weren't left
alone.

They had intelligence enough to make
New images that time would never shake.
So we inherit images of hate,
Theological concepts that translate
Unknowable infinities of God
In well-said statements, polished to a nod.
These paper puppet gods go out, do battle,
And lead their followers like bleating
cattle.

But You immoveable in silent state
Reign over sect and every sect's god's fate.
Religion will pass on with empire dreams.
The Day of Judgement will replace what
seems.

Beloved, You are defined in human terms
In this one sermon that You preached to
worms.

You speak to humankind, call Yourself I,
YaHuwa, Allah, and bring by and by
All people from their bondage, You alone
Are God. You cannot be expressed in stone
Or image made, You fly in jealous rages
If anyone bows down to other sages.
You intervene to limit evil actions.
You multiply the good combining factions.
To those who love You and obey Your will
You are the Merciful, and judge all still.
Sovereign of time, Creator of all space,
You ask obedience before Your face.

O my Beloved, let me not bow to those
In acquiescence to the false they chose
Instead of Your command and blessed will.
If all turn back, make me obedient still.
Though my prayer fail in morning, noon
and night,

Keep me from idol worship, show the right.
I feel the burden of Your raging ire
For those who worship men, what they
inspire.

In desperation jealously You see
The world bow to a pagan Trinity.
Take here my offered love to You alone,

Though it be weak and laid on flesh and bone.

You weep and groan for the unfaithful wife.

Let me be faithful long as I have life.

I thank You, my Beloved, that You set bounds

On how much time a wicked act resounds.

Effects of evil might go on and on,
But You have set the limits, You have drawn

A boundary in generations three
Or four at most. You ask no litany
Of blood for grace. Your grace is free to those

Who love You best and whose obeying grows

From love of mercy and acknowledging
That there is none but You, eternal King.
Confession, penitence and restitution
Are of all things the most precious ablution.

You stretch the good and what it does in time

A thousand generations past its prime.

I raise Your name, Beloved, this day and speak

To You in hope You will defend the weak,
To You in praise that my self may be filled
With Self alone from twelve roses distilled,
To You in penance that Your word stands lame

At times as I go out to play the game,
To You in sacrifice, self disappearing
In Self alone, Beloved, in Your uprearing.
Thus my petition in Your name resounds
Through corridors of soul, above the bounds

The temple of the universe aligns.

I watch the morning sky for Your brief signs

The world's awake and tune my soul to set
Where evening makes Your names a singing yet.

Pause to remember, this I do each week,
And fill Your name with all the things I seek,

Setting aside a moment for my prayer
That its perfume may linger in the air

Of days and nights that follow one of rest.

What moment of the artist is the best?

It is not when the brush is set to white,
Nor when the first smudge turns the canvas bright.

It is not in the planning nor the pain
Of getting wrong and making right again.
The holy moment comes when all is done
And canvas is uplifted to the sun
And pause is made for judgement and to ask

If this is not success, a finished task.

The right to rest belongs to everyone,
The worker and the beast beneath the sun,
The child and daughter, all have graven rights

That cannot, must not disappear from sights.

But no one has the right of obligating
Another on this day to task or waiting.
The list of those subordinates is clear
In offspring, beast, employee without fear.
The fact no wife is in the list means not
That she has no rights in the rest for thought,

But merely that she is no underling
And equal in all things to priest and king.
The Sabbath's not mere time to take a break.

It is the sign of many things at stake.

Who breathe participate in that great act
Creation is, Beloved, and that's a fact.
Forgotten, though, the soul works to arrive
At God's state, mighty, active and alive.
To breathe is not enough, man wants to make

The world anew, created for his sake.
Illusion forces such to plan and do,
Forgetting You are I and I am You.
The building topples and the engine fails
And still I need Your breath to fill my sails.
If I cannot create a world in time
At least I can create its pantomime,
Presume, if prisoner of space, to change
At last the day You chose to fill my range.

The faithful and religious said
The law could not be kept, instead
We had to wait for grace and mercy
To settle up the controversy,

Or else that heaven or hell broke in
To change us and the state of sin.
I disagreed and asked them which
Commandment was too hard to stitch,
And what it was we couldn't do
Of Your plain word You told us to
On any and on every day.
They're right, it's true what people say.
The Sabbath may it still amaze,
Can just be kept on Saturdays.

Competing with the God of all creation
I make up one frenetic, rushing nation
In order to produce and satisfy
The instinct to create before I die.
Repentance is to turn around and see
That reproduction's all it's said to be:
But backward looking is the way to go
Toward the future in the greatest show.
To honour parents is the finest rule
Of divine guidance in this sacred school.
All goals achieve their ends in this one act
Where blessings of all kinds are tightly
packed.
Simplicity marks best this dervish order
From heart and centre to the furthest
border.

"There is no god but I" brings on the need
To kill all others in one divine deed.
For if the other is not I then he
Is some false god from heathen trinity
And must at all costs bear the brunt and
curse
And die at least or suffer something worse.
The only way to stay the killing hand
Is know that every one within the land
Is also I and conscious of that thing
That starts before the rainbow and the ring.
Deny there is no I but God and know
Denial is to kill the heart and glow.
"There is no I but God" fulfils this law
Alone and without praise and without awe.

For every act the soul finds motive in
A combination of the three for sin.
And this unholy trinity is made
Of greed, lust, cruelty, a spade's a spade.
There is no other motive in the heart
But that made up of these in measured part.
Beloved, You are alone God and no other

Can share the divine throne, not even
mother.

So greed and cruelty must fall away
And lust alone must always hold the sway.
The divine unity is found in lust
Among the creatures formed and breathed
in dust.

But lust has only one face as its goal.
Commit adultery, destroy the soul.

The gate of earth is where all creatures sit,
And so the highest vision has not wit
To live without the fruit and nut and grain.
All fervour must resign as void and vain
Unless the mouth is filled with bread as
well

As with the divine names, the truth to tell.
Who takes more on his plate than he can
eat

Reveals himself a robber and a cheat.
The ground brings forth enough and food to
spare,

But those religious souls would give us air
Who think that wealth unshared is worthy
of

The Church's approbation and her love.
Air does not feed the hungry. Those who
steal

The product of the earth must share the
meal.

Some spoke for law and some for grace
And some for welfare, some for space.
I wondered why some said the law
Was different from grace, aha,
Unless there was a point therein
They wanted to enjoy as sin.
So far as I could see the two,
Both law and grace were of one hue.
To me the day of rest is not
A duty but a grace unsought.
If law seems no grace when you steal,
Then turn around, see how you feel,
If law's not grace when someone comes,
Breaks in your house and steals your sums.

Beloved, I bear this witness of my
neighbour,
Who shares my street, and lives by his own
labour,
That I that lives in me lives so in him
And in all humankind, both right and dim.

There is no I but God and that I lives
 In everyone whose consciousness but gives
 Acknowledgement to life and its existence.
 And yet that I with rush and churning
 pistons
 Can foil its faith, extinguish in the dark,
 Or sound the Name, returning to the park.
 When all is done on earth and in creation,
 And all return to their own place and
 station,
 You shall not be, Beloved, at all
 diminished,
 Though darkness should take all when all is
 finished.

To seek the source of power that belongs
 To others is to compound heaven's wrongs.
 The property, alliance through the spouse,
 Employees working out and in the house,
 The trucks that move, the ploughs that pare
 the earth,
 All these are vehicles of power and worth.
 To covet them is to deny the Self
 That reigns in self, crown left upon the
 shelf.
 To covet's to deny what is one's own,
 And there is for each one his gift alone.
 But as for wealth, again there's gold to
 spare
 And everyone may eat of gold his share.
 Who knows but ox and donkey are enough
 To plough and take the road when things
 get rough.

What You said once for all to hear
 Can never, never disappear.
 It stays beside me in my toil
 Of pen in ink or spike in soil.
 It is a silent witness of
 My wanton hate and craven love.
 It fills with bright unseen perfume
 Obedience's white costume.
 It speaks in menace or in praise
 Of every human's passing days.
 It speaks in silence, biding time,
 Eternal, glorious paradigm,
 Until the Day of Judgement when
 It raises up or cuts down men.

I searched for gods in knowledge, found
 their limit,

And touched gods with delight in art and
 right.
 I drank deep draughts of god in what I
 might
 Take for my own with price, and saw time
 dim it.
 I revelled in the gods of house and kin
 And hid their images beneath my seat:
 They failed me in both warfare and retreat,
 And so I sought the mystic god within.
 My shattered soul rejoiced in purple void
 And praised the quiet god of emptiness
 Beyond the forms of gold and shadow-
 guess
 Until the stroke of grace broke overjoyed.
 I found my own in leaving off the search,
 For You were not in stable, state or church.

Some doubt that You spoke to that crowd
 one day.
 "Why doesn't He speak now?" such people
 say.
 It may be there's a difference in the crowd
 That now expects for You to speak out
 loud.
 Those ancient people worshipped golden
 calves,
 But what they did they never did by halves.
 When lightning lightened and the thunder
 thundered
 They stood and listened to Your words and
 wondered.
 We're better far than worshippers of gold
 In asking nowadays that we be told
 The scientific reasons for the sound,
 The speed of light and why the world goes
 round.
 The crash of thunder deafens us to what
 Is in Your lyrics and to what is not.

Two prophets' names are hidden in the text
 Of Decalogue to favour the perplexed.
 Once Adam rides the melody and then
 Twice Ahmed is the one desired by men.
 I covet not the neighbour's wife nor house,
 Nor his store of corn guarded by the mouse,
 But yet I covet by Muhammad's name,
 Which means 'the coveted' to find my aim
 In that Criterion and without shame
 That he in the Qur'an came to proclaim.
 I covet, my Beloved, the holy fire
 That burns away vested human desire

And in the prophet's footsteps follow on
To find the Decalogue's red and rose dawn.

The Sacred Books of all faiths and all lands
Have this in common: each one makes
demands

On consciences of fearful people, each
Lays open purple splendours beyond reach.
Commandments show us what we are, not
what

We should or must do. Images begot
Upon the soul turn into Grecian vases,
Or into blackened, silhouetted faces,
Depending on the eye that might behold it.
Some rage against the law and You that
told it.

Some grasp and hold the beauty of Your
vision.

Commandments draw the soul's lines with
precision,

The law remains for those who hate and
love it.

I've only more and more new things to
covet.

Let me remember, Lord, Your day,

The sanctified, the blest,

On all my days, in every way,

In work and play and rest.

Let me remember, Lord, Your name,

The holy and the true,

Beyond the names that vie in fame

And shadow what I do.

Let me remember, Lord, Your law,

The merciful and right,

And stand each day with You in awe

And walk within its light.

Let me remember, Lord, Your grace,

The infinite to spare,

That I may joy before Your face

Though weak in act and prayer.

Let me know, Lord, in this my place,

In this blest moment's gift,

Your day, Your name, Your law, Your
grace

Uphold me and uplift.

18 Now all the people saw the thunder,
The lightning flashing made them wonder,
The sound of trumpet, mountain smoking
They saw and trembled, and no joking
Stood far off, 19 and they said to Moses,

"Just you speak with us, *since YHWH chose
us,*

We shall hear you, but let not speak
Alohim, lest we die, *we're weak.*"

20 And Moses told the people, "Do

Not fear, for Alohim tests you,

And that His fear may be with you,

So that you may not sin." 21 So then

The people stood far off, but Moses

Drew near the darkness thick that closes

Where Alohim *was and not men.*

Why don't You, Lord, speak to us face to
face

As You did years ago to Israel's race?

You spoke so loud to them, the thunder
pealing

Could not drown out Your voice and its
revealing.

You made such clamour on Mount Sinai's
top

That no one in the camp had to eavesdrop.

But now, no matter how hard one may
listen

When mountain peaks in sun and granite
glisten

You do not make a peep or even show

A slight displeasure for how things here go.

You came down once and made the world a
stage

Where You dictated maybe half a page,

And then, good actor, knew to call the
curtain.

You had no more to say, that's one thing
certain.

They want excitement in the church and
meeting

And something more than just good light
and seating.

The celebration of rock music there

Will keep the crowd as well as anywhere,

But then one's got to follow in the fashion

Of what in music is considered smashing.

Religion falls behind in entertainment

When big names fail to offer their
attainment.

No one can listen to a preacher talk

In platitudes forever, but the shock

Of You Yourself come down to say a word

Would set things humming. Coming is
absurd,

Though, since scarce anybody ever does
here
The things God asked the first time when
He was here.

22 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Thus you
Shall say to Israel's folk to do:
'You've seen I've talked with you from
heaven.

23 'You shall not make *you any leaven,*
Or anything to be with Me,
Not gods of silver nor of gold
Shall you make of the things *you see*
For yourselves *claiming to be bold.*

24 'An altar of the earth you shall
Make for Me, where you prostrate all
Burnt offerings made in sacrifice,

Though penitence alone suffice,
Peace offerings of your ox and sheep.

And every place where I may keep
My name I shall come there to you
And bless you for the things you do.

25 'And if you make that place of stone,
You shall not make it hewn *with bone*
Or metal tool, which would profane it.

26 'Nor shall you walk by steps *to stain it*
When you go to My altar bare
No nakedness upon it there.'

I make prostration on an unhewn stone
Cast down, though I pray just to You alone.
That stone is not an idol as the weak
And ignorant suppose, but there I seek
To find an altar, place of slaughter, where
I offer up myself naked and bare.
I follow law and statute in that I
Lift neither tool nor nakedness, but try
To take my steps across the carpeting
And lay my prayer beside the carolling
Of cherubim and seraphim. I know
There is no need for altar or for show,
The place I put my brow can be as well
The hand by which I offer You the cell.

Week 18 Exodus 21

1 "Now these *are* the judgements which
you
Shall set before them: 2 "If you do
Buy a Hebrew servant, he shall
Serve six years, and *not prodigal*
In the seventh he shall go out
Both free and pay nothing *to flout.*

3 "If he comes in by himself, he
Shall go out by himself, if he
Is married, then his wife shall go
Out with him. 4 "If his master's given
A wife to him, and she has *striven*
To bear him sons or daughters, then
Wife and children are master's *men,*
And by himself he shall go out.
5 "But if the servant remains stout,
Saying 'I love my master, wife,
And my children, *and for my life*
I will not go out free *and sing,*'
6 "To judges shall his master bring
The man, also bring to the door
Or post and with an awl to bore
His ear to serve him evermore.

The Bektashi that will serve You alone
Forever and not take a wife as stone
About the neck, follows the sage device
To bore a hole in ear, insert a slice
Of silver as a mark that he is Yours.
Seven times seven years and my soul soars
A servant to You still, though family
About my serving ears romps loud and
free.

I have no awl nor hollow in my flesh
To indicate my status from the crèche.
I have no doorpost to attach my trust
With iron tool and overwhelming thrust.
Beloved, I still in love look up to You
And let the judges pass a verdict true.

7 "If one sells his daughter as slave
She'll not go out as males behave.
8 "If she does not please her master,
Who has to himself betrothed her
Then he shall let her be redeemed.
He shall have no right to sell her
To a foreign folk, since it seemed
He had dealt wrongfully with her.
9 "If he's betrothed her to his son,
He'll treat her as with daughters done.
10 "If he takes others, he shall not
Diminish her food, clothing got,
And her marriage rights. 11 "And if he
Does not do these three for her, she
Without paying shall go out free.

Three rules You give, Beloved, for the
slave wife:
Not to be sold to strangers; if her life

Is bought for son, then she is given all
A daughter of the house may have at call.
In case polygamy raises a head,
She must always be clothed, bedded and
fed

Or then set free without returning ought
Of the moneys with which she had been
bought.

The rules may seem today a bit forlorn,
But when reality steps in, the shorn
Statutes seem better far than many wives
Find husbands treating them all of their
lives.

Beloved, the selfish soul has ways and
means
To follow law and vice behind the scenes.

12 "Who strikes a man so that he dies
Shall be put to death *where he lies*.

13 "But if he did not lie in wait,
But Alohim allowed his fate,
Then I'll appoint for you a place
Where he may flee *to save his face*.

14 "But if a man acts out in plan
Against neighbour, to kill *the man*
By treachery, you shall take him
From My altar, to kill him *grim*.

The rule is blood revenge, it seems, and yet
For accidental killing You give set
Where unintending killer might flee to
And there be safe, unless some proof go
through

To show he lay in wait with treachery.
So You, Beloved, take interest in degree.
All's clear until I ask by whose hand shall
The murderer be slain in practical.
The "you" to whom You speak is Moses
truly,

But does that mean he was appointed duly
As executioner? Or did he make
His officers do actions for his sake?
If so, it does not follow now we can
Ourselves appoint a hangman for our man.

15 "Who his father or mother strikes
Shall surely die *for his dislikes*.

16 "The one who kidnaps one to sell
For gain and *as slave to compel*,
Or if he's still captive in hand,
Shall surely be *by My command*
Put to death. 17 "And also the one

Who curses his father, the son
Who curses his mother shall be
Surely put to death, *not go free*.

The purpose of prophetic Scriptures is
To support and enhance the Decalogue,
Your Word, Beloved, direct, not hers or his
Who by dream or vision see in a fog,
And public, not merely to one or few.
The Decalogue condemns both violence
And disrespect to parents in their due.
In that the Decalogue makes right good
sense.

But You said nothing of such punishments
As death for this and death for that nor who
Should carry out the penalties for cursing.
I guess my human view is still in nursing,
Since I'd defend my daughter if she said
A scathing curse upon my poor grey head.

18 "If two men fight together, and
One up and strikes with stone or hand
The other and he does not die
But confined on *his* bed to lie,

19 "If he rises again and walks
About outside with staff *and talks*,
Then he who struck shall be acquitted.
Only he must pay *for* the loss
Of his time, and provide *admitted*
Healing and thorough *for the boss*.

20 "And if a man beats his *own* slave,
Male or female into the grave
With rod under his hand, he shall
Surely be punished. 21 "But withal
If he remains alive a day
Or two, he shall not, for delay,
Be punished for his buggery
Because the man's his property.

In anger to curse one's own mother's worth
Death penalty on Moses' promised earth.
But if a man beats his own slave to death,
He's free if that slave lingers on in breath
Until the morning. Now, Beloved, admit
Prophetic word has something wrong with
it,

At least from that slave's son's or daughter's
view.

While I love Moses, I'd be loath for You
To take the blame for that bit of statute.
The Scripture's always something to refute,

And there's not one but has to pick and
choose
Or else to mourn the loss for what men
lose.
Beloved, I cantillate the awful words,
Cling to the Decalogue, avoid the herds.

22 "If two men fight, and hurt a pregnant
Woman, *even if a king regnant*,
So that the child is born too soon,
Yet no harm follows *the lacune*,
He shall be punished as the *man*,
Husband *and father*, might well scan,
And pay *the price* the judges say.
23 "But if harm follows *in the way*,
Then you shall give a life for life,
24 "An eye for eye, *and for the wife*
A tooth for tooth, a hand for hand,
A foot for foot, *and by command*
25 "A burn for burn, and wound for wound,
And stripe for stripe *unimportuned*.

Treatment of slaves hardly will turn an ear,
But eye for eye and tooth for tooth, I fear
Is famous in quotation to appeal
To every man for justice, how they feel,
And show old Jewish law is more blood-
thirsty
Than Anglo-Saxon justice, much, much
worsy.
The truth is that law's to instill behaviour
In men to be a pregnant lady's saviour
And not to fight and brawl and put in
danger
The pregnant and unborn, and if they do
To run the risk of eye and tooth and shoe.
Deterrent is the word, not something
stranger.
Beloved, Your regard for the mother's child
Leaves me at least to such laws reconciled.

26 "Who strikes the eye of his slave, male
Or female, and destroys the hale,
He shall let him go free for that
Eye lost by whip or by brickbat.
27 "And if he knocks his slave's tooth out,
Whether male or female about,
He shall let him or her go free
For the sake of one tooth *in fee*.

A slave's life is worth nothing or I guess
The slave that was beaten and left lifeless

Died free the next day for his plague to
boot.

His freedom paid for what he lost in suit.
But a slave's eye or tooth is also worth
The right to freedom on the solid earth.
Beloved, the lesson's sound in tooth and
eye

And so I praise Your name up to the sky,
Who frees the slave from Egypt on the sly
And sets the toothless, blind crone out to
buy.

With her experience in taking orders
She can live well cooking for take-in
boarders.

Beloved, have pity on society
And all who in its wake have been set free.

28 "If an ox gores a man to death,
Or a woman, that ox's *breath*
Shall surely be *cut off* by stoning,
Its flesh shall not be eaten *groaning*,
But the ox's owner *shall be*
Acquitted of fault and set free.

29 "But if the ox tended to thrust
With its horn in times past, and must
Have been made known to his owner,
And he has not kept it confined,
So that it killed a man, *loner*,
Or just as bad and unrefined,
A woman, the ox shall be stoned
And its owner also *unthroned*
Shall be slain. 30 "If there is imposed
On him a fine, *a fine disclosed*,
Then he shall so redeem his life,
Whatever fine *escapes the knife*.

31 "Whether it's gored a son or gored
A daughter, by this just accord
It shall be done to him. 32 "If ox
Gores male or female servant *stocks*,
He'll pay their master thirty shekels
Of silver, and the ox *with speckles*
Or of one colour shall be stoned,
Nor eaten by the one who owned.

The blood revenge established in the time
Of Noah at last finds a lesser crime.
Instead of killing, punishments relent
And take a fine and recompense in cent.
Redemption for the owner of the ox
Is broadened to include the entire box
In the Qur'an. Beloved, I note the price
Of man and woman here are of one slice.

Is thirty shekels for slave though enough?
I had thought humans made of better stuff.
At least the blood for blood was on a scale
That matched the value of the stock and
sale,
At least, of course, in democratic style
Where we count heads and not the
mercantile.

33 "And if a man opens a pit,
Or if he does not cover it,
And ox or donkey falls in it,
34 "The owner of the pit shall make
It good, he'll give money *in stake*
To their owner, but the carcass
Shall be his own, *bone and cuirass*.
35 "If one man's ox attacks another's,
So that it dies, *though they be brothers*,
Then they shall sell the live ox and
Divide the money out of hand,
And the carcass they'll also share.
36 "Or if it was known to beware
That ox used to thrust in times past,
And its owner did not keep fast,
He shall surely pay ox for ox,
And the carcass shall be his stocks.

I have no donkey, no ox, no nor pit,
At least no pit where donkey and ox fit.
My neighbour also walks the field and line
Without a beast or well to spoil the fine
Friendship we share, and my well is well
covered
With two doors shut tight where the lilacs
hovered
A moment in the summer, then fell bare
And left the leaves for many weeks to stare
Until the frost took all away except
The roots and grey branches that stayed and
wept.
Beloved, if my lilacs attack the neighbours'
I'll share with him the loss and common
labours,
If such comparison is legally
Binding on the unfettered and the free.

Exodus 22

1 "If a man steals an ox or sheep,
And slaughters it or sells *to keep*,
He shall restore five oxen for
An ox and four sheep for a sheep.
2 "If thief is found breaking the door,

And he is struck so that he dies,
No guilt for his bloodshed *then lies*.
3 "If the sun has risen on him,
Guilt for his bloodshed, *that were dim*.
He should give back in full his debt
If he has nothing, then he's set
To be sold for his theft. 4 "If theft
Is surely alive in his hand,
If ox, donkey or sheep *bereft*,
He shall restore double *the brand*.

The sly intruder struck down dead shall go
Unrevenged, in my day it is not so.
To shoot a bandit in your house today
Is straight to prison or even the way
To execution if you live in Texas.
Injustice everywhere seems to be nexus.
Yet the commandments also say don't kill,
And killing robbers at night's killing still.
A prophet's word gives right to stop the
stray,
Democracy sees thugs another way.
Worse still is that today the thief once
caught
Need not return the stolen stuff he got
If it's been spent. Beloved, I steal Your
heart
And spend it all on my own ravished part.

5 "If a field or vineyard be grazed,
And a man lets his cattle *dazed*
Loose, and it feeds upon the field
Of others, then he'll *surely* yield
In restitution from his best
In vineyard. 6 "And as for the rest,
If fire breaks out and catches thorn,
So that stacked grain or standing corn,
Or the field is consumed, he who
Kindled the fire shall pay the due.
7 "If one delivers to his neighbour
Money or things to keep for labour,
And it's stolen out from his house,
If the thief's found, he'll pay *the grouse*
In double. 8 "If the thief's not found,
Then house master shall go around
To the judges whether or not
He's put his hand to neighbour's draught.
9 "For any kind of trespass, ox,
Donkey, or sheep, or clothing *box*,
Or any kind of lost thing which
Another claims is from his *ditch*,
The cause of both parties shall come

Before the judges, double sum
 Shall be incumbent on condemned
 To pay his neighbour thus indemn'd.
 10 "If a man gives his neighbour donkey,
 Ox, sheep, or any sort of wonkey
 For safe keeping and then it dies,
 Is hurt or driven away *in guise*
 So no one sees it, 11 "then an oath
 Of YHWH shall be between them both,
 That he's not put his hand into
 His neighbour's goods *for ill or rue*,
 And its owner shall accept *that*,
 The other shall not suffer scat.
 12 "But if, in fact, it's stolen from
 Him, he shall make it good in sum.
 13 "If it is torn to pieces, he
 Shall bring in evidence, *and* he
 Shall not make good what had been torn.
 14 "And if a man borrows a *horn*
 From his neighbour, and it becomes
 Injured or dies, and while the chums
 That own it are not with it there,
 Then he shall surely pay what's fair.
 15 "If its owner *was* with it, he
 Shall not make *it* good, for surely
 If it *was* hired, it came for hire.
That's the law of borrowed entire.

I borrow daily life, Beloved, from You,
 And with each breath I let that life anew
 Die in illusion where I swim with will:
 I pray that life returns to You with fill.
 I borrow with each breath the life You give,
 And with Your living I'm content to live
 As well as die to darkness with each breath
 That turns me from and carries me to death.
 I borrow with each thought the golden life
 And cut it in a blissful loss with knife
 That draws again, again the divine touch
 Until the psalming sorrows know as much.
 I borrow life, Beloved, from You alone
 And turn that life, Beloved, to praise and
 stone.

16 "If a man entices a maid
 Who's not betrothed, and *in some glade*
 Lies with her, he shall surely pay
 The bride-price for the marriage way.
 17 "If her dad utterly refuse
 To give her to whom might abuse,
 He shall pay money calculated
 To the bride-price of virgins stated.

18 "You shall not permit sorceress
Or sorcerer to live *remiss*.
 19 "Whoever lies with animal
 Shall be put to death *prodigal*.
 20 "Who sacrifices to a god,
 Except to YHWH only, *the clod*
Here shall be utterly destroyed
Upon the land which he employed.
 21 "You shall neither mistreat a stranger
 Nor oppress him, for you *in danger*
 Were strangers in Egypt's land *once*.
 22 "You shall not afflict with *trick stunts*
 A widow or fatherless child.
 23 "If you afflict them, *tame or wild*,
And they cry at all to Me, I
 Will surely hear the *widow's* cry,
 24 "And My anger will become hot,
 And I will kill you *on the spot*
 With sword, and your wives shall be
 widows,
 And your children fatherless *kiddos*.

I who live in the wealth of by-product
 The rich pour down the drain of the good-
 lucked,
 Let me not dream my detached view of
 passion
 Relieves responsibility for fashion.
 Though I pour in the widow's paunch my
 store,
 It still relies upon the oilman's gore.
 Beloved, hear the cry of who would not
 take
 A penny from the orphan's narrow stake,
 And has no stand but prayer to make it
 good,
 Who knows but cannot wield the staff he
 should.
 I take the divine sword and at a blow
 Cut off my head for You and at one go
 Flap in a whirling dance upon the floor
 Of the dergah, before the garden door.

25 "If you lend money to My folk
 Who are poor among you *or broke*,
 You'll not play moneylender then,
 You shall not lay interest on men.
 26 "If you take your neighbour's garment,
The outer robe that's also meant
As blanket as a pledge, you shall
 Return it to him vesp'ral,
Surely before the sun goes down.

27 "For that's his only covering gown,
It is his garment for his skin.
Without it what will he sleep in?
And it will be that when he cries
To Me, I'll hear, *even his sighs*,
For I *am merciful and* gracious.

I do not glorify that poverty
That seems a virtue to the wealthy see,
Nor do I say the dervish must be broke,
But only that the gold not move the bloke.
But You, Beloved, envisage labour force
That has no more than one blanket's
 recourse
That serves as well as coat against the cold
Of winter and the storm hard to behold.
The more a belly gets the more it seems
To want to put in padding on its dreams.
What poverty was normal in the past
Now seems a faqir dance and a great fast.
Beloved, let me cling only to one treasure,
The You-ness of my I-ness without
 measure.

28 "You shall not become so audacious,
As to revile the judges gracious,
Nor curse a ruler of your people
By God appointed and not steeple.
29 "You'll not delay *what* first produces
Your fields in ripe corn nor in juices.
The firstborn of your sons you shall
Give to Me. 30 "And likewise you shall
Do with your oxen *and* your sheep
As soon as they are born to peep.
It shall be with its dam seven days,
On the eighth day to Me it strays.
31 "And you'll be holy ones to Me:
You'll not eat meat torn in the lee,
You shall throw it out to the dogs,
Whose right it is to eat the clogs.

The unclean meat is thrown out to the dogs,
The meat that's torn, dead of itself, and
 hogs,
Not because dogs, contemptible, were born
To eat the refuse, but because the morn
Of the Egyptian flight, the dogs held fast
And silently applauded as they passed
Toward the Red Sea and their freedom
 dream.
The dogs are thus rewarded with the cream
Of foods, the delicate and rare, the ham

Of hog, helping children of Abraham.
Beloved, I too am dog and bark for You
Although I do not eat the flesh that's due
My race in pork. Instead, in poverty
I eat sweet lentil soup enough for three.

Exodus 23

1 "You shall not circulate a false
Report. Don't join wicked assaults
To be an unrighteous witness.
2 "You shall not follow or confess
A crowd to do evil, nor shall
You testify in a dispute
So as to go along with crowd
To pervert the juridical.
3 "You'll not show in a poor man's suit
Bias in his favour allowed.

Two evils unmentioned by most appear:
The first is following the crowd to sear
The hide of any with the mob's own fear.
So easy, easy to be of one mind
When the whole witness crowd is deaf and
 blind,
As every crowd must be as is resigned
To rely on what ignorance knows best.
The popular opinion's always wrest
The truth to demonize both innocent
And guilty in one pale. The other error
Is like enough as well to cause a terror,
And that is being liberal, well-meant,
And biased in the favour of the poor,
More common than I'd think, though You
 are sure.

4 "If you meet your enemy's ox
Or his donkey *among the rocks*
Going astray, you'll surely bring
It back to him again *or sing*.
5 "If you see the donkey of one
Who hates you lying *and undone*
Under its burden, and you would
Refrain from helping as you should,
You shall surely help him with it.
6 "You shall not pervert judgement fit
Of your poor in his dispute. 7 "Keep
Yourself far from false matter's *heap*,
Do not kill the innocent and
Righteous, for I'll not justify
The *unrighteous* and wicked *band*,
Who slay deceitfully and lie.
8 "And you shall take no bribe, for bribes

Blind the discerning *of the tribes*
And pervert the righteous man's words.
9 "You'll not oppress a stranger's *herds*,
For you know how it feels to be
A stranger in a land unfree,
Because you were strangers *and slaves*
In Egypt's land *and without graves*.

I've been a stranger in the land by far
The better part of life, know how things
are.

I pity more than judge the ones who take
Respect away from stranger and his rake.
The lower profile's easy one to keep,
And does not give one any cause to weep.
My pity goes to those whose fine
gradations

Require so many levels of the nations:
Race and reward compete with wealth to
wreck

With boundaries and yokes on every neck.
Who look with condescension on the pride
Of ancient men have more fault on their
side,

Who cannot even marry one who's not
Of the same level in company slot.

10 "Six years you shall sow in your land
And gather in its produce *grand*,

11 "But the seventh you shall let it
Rest and lie fallow, as is fit,
That the poor of your people may
Eat, and what they leave there to stay,
The beasts of the field may consume.
So also with your vineyard's *room*
And with your olive grove. 12 "Six days
You shall do your work *in your ways*,
And on the seventh day you'll rest,
That your ox and donkey *at best*
May rest, and the son of your maid
And the stranger may all be stayed.

So few regard Your Sabbath day, I fear,
Beloved, because this is still in their ear
That Sabbath is made gracious for the beast
And for the son of servant maid, the least.
Who has but modicum of pride of eye,
And lust of belly, will not see the sky
In what You say to do with Sabbath day.
The Sabbath is too humble for their way,
Too literal and down to earth for those
Whose spirit rises on the wings that chose

To live on the oppression of the rude,
The ones who work instead of fight and
feud
For wealth of gold and oil and what
produces
The factories in forty hours with juices.

13 "And in all that I've said to you,
Be circumspect *and live the true*,
Mention no other gods by name,
Nor let it be heard *to your shame*
From your mouth. 14 "Three times you
shall keep

A feast to Me each year *you reap*.

15 "You'll keep feast of unleavened bread.
You'll eat your bread without the leaven
As I've commanded you for seven
Days, at the time appointed in
The month of green ears, *without sin*,
For then you came from Egypt's land,
None shall appear with empty hand.

16 "And the feast of harvest, first-fruits
Of your labours and your pursuits
Which you've sown in the field, the feast
Of ingathering year's end increased,
When you have gathered in your labours
From the field, *and also the neighbours*.

17 "Three times in the year every male
Shall come to Lord YHWH without fail.

18 "You'll not offer My sacrifice
And bloody with a leavened slice,
Nor shall the fat of sacrifice
Remain until the morning *light*.

19 "The first of the firstfruits *by right*
Of your land you shall bring into
Your God's house and the house of
YHWH.

You shall not boil a young goat in
Its mother's milk, *for that is sin*.

Although I do not come three times a year
To Quds to pay respects with tongue and
ear,

I still refrain to take on tongue of prayer
The names of trinities of Egypt fair,
Of Babylon and Rome, and so despair
Of winning wealth and fame as I repair
My daily fond prostrations toward Your
city

And toward Your house in hopes that
You'll take pity
Upon the hungry for bread with, without

The leaven or for kid boiled in the stout
Liquor of water or the mother's milk,
And yet I am one who's not of that ilk,
But rather eat the braisen goat instead.
Two out of three are virtue on my head.

20 "See, I send an angel before
You to keep you in way and door,
And bring you to the place which I
Have prepared. 21 "So beware *the spy*,
Obey his voice, do not provoke
Him, for he'll not forgive, revoke
Your misdeeds, for My name's in him.
22 "But if indeed you hear with vim
His voice and do all that I speak,
Then I'll be a foe to *make weak*
Your enemies, an adversary
To your *attacking* foes *and scary*.
23 "For My angel will go before
You and bring you to Amorites
To Hittites and to Perizzites
To Canaanites and the Hivites
And to the Jebusites, and I
Will cut them off *before your eye*.

Beloved, send Your angel before my feet
That circle in the wilderness and heat
Of my desire to rise in perfumed spark
Of sacrifice before gate of the park.
Send the archangel Michael as I share
The wafted winds of desert on the air
With bat and mouse who in Your loving
care
Also whirl in Your praise. Michael indeed,
The Prince of angels stoops to take them
heed,
And drops a grain to give the mouse a seed,
And startles mote for bat in what's her feed.
But let the archangel find me with ear
Ready to follow where You point his spear,
Obeying his voice like Your own in fear.

24 "You shall not bow down to their gods,
Nor serve them, nor *against the odds*
Do according to their works, but
You'll utterly overthrow what
Idols you find and break completely
Their pillars *into pieces neatly*.
25 "So you shall serve YHWH Alohim,
And He'll bless your bread *it would seem*
And your water. And I will take
Sickness away and for your sake.

A fair exchange it seems to me to give
Me bread and water just because I live
Not bowing down to gods other than You.
It's such a very simple thing to do.
But two things more place easy in the bin
Of hard to avoid acts that might be sin.
The first is not to do according to
Their works, now that is shift enough to be
Out of line with the present brave and free
Who have enough to do idolatry.
The second is to overthrow the stone
The power takes for idol on the throne.
Now that is quite impossible for me,
Especially on mere bread and water free.

26 "No one shall suffer miscarriage,
Be barren in your acreage,
I'll fill the number of your days.
27 "I'll send My fear before your ways,
I'll cause confusion among all
The people to whom you make call,
And will make all your enemies
Turn *their* backs to you, *refugees*.
28 "And I will send hornets before
You, which shall drive out *from the door*
The Hivite, Canaanite, Hittite
From before you *and for your right*.
29 "I'll not drive them out from before
You in one year, lest the land *sore*
Be desolate and the wild beast
Before you become too increased.
30 "Little by little I will drive
Them out before you *safe, alive*,
Until you have increased, and you
Inherit the land *with not few*.
31 "And I'll set your bounds from Red Sea
To the sea, Philistia free,
And from the desert to the stream.
For I'll deliver the land's team
Into your hand, and you shall drive
Them out before you, *safe, alive*.
32 "You shall make no treaty with them,
Nor with their gods *with golden hem*.
33 "They'll not be living in your land,
Lest they make you sin at My hand.
For *if* you serve their gods, it will
Surely be a snare to your *fill*."

I like this state of things much better than
The attack on the idol for the man.
You compel violence against the state,

The church and against gold-embroidered
plate,
To throw down idols everywhere they're
found.
But You do not compel to kill the crowned
Idolater. Instead, You promise that
You'll do the job Yourself against the rat,
And run the infidel out of the town,
So forest does not encroach when I'm
down.
The promise made three thousand years
ago
Is unfulfilled, it seems You're moving slow.
If I must live among unfaithful here,
At least I shall be faithful to Your fear.

Exodus 24

1 He told Moses, "Come up to YHWH,
You, Aaron, Nadab, Abihu,
And seventy elders of Israel,
And worship from afar *for weal*.
2 "And Moses alone shall come near
YHWH, but others shall not come near,
Nor shall people go up with him."
3 So Moses came *filled to the brim*
And told the people all the word
Of YHWH and all the judgements *stirred*.
All the folk answered with one voice
And said "*This is our common choice*,
All the words which YHWH has said we
Will do." 4 Moses, *for all to see*,
Wrote all the words of YHWH, and he
Rose early in the morning, built
An altar at the mountain's *tilt*
And at its foot, twelve pillars for
The twelve tribes of Israel *in store*.
5 Then he sent young men of the folk
Of Israel, who offered *the stroke*
Of burnt offerings and sacrificed
Peace offerings of oxen *sufficed*
To YHWH. 6 Moses took half the blood
And put *it in the basins' flood*,
And half the blood he sprinkled on
The altar. 7 Then he read upon
The book of the covenant and
Read in the hearing of the band.
And they said "All that YHWH has said
We will do, and be *safely* led."

Beloved, all that YHWH has said we will
do,
Is beautiful for word, above all true.

The sacrificial meal merely confirms
The beauty of the words Your law affirms.
I who look with safe condescension on
Those who doubted not their comparison
To heathen was most favourable to them,
Think now the optimistic promise gem,
That folk was better than my own who
know
They cannot keep Your law while on the
go.
I'd rather find one promising in hope
Day after day after repentance' scope
Than this, where no one even tries to keep
Your law between their movies and their
sleep.

8 And Moses took the blood, and set
It sprinkled on the people *wet*,
And said "This is the covenant
In *even* blood which YHWH has meant
To make with you by these words *sent*."
9 Then Moses went up, also Aaron,
Nadab, Abihu, and *not barren*
Seventy of elders of Israel,
10 And they saw the God of Israel.
Under His feet as it were paved
Work of sapphire stone *and engraved*,
And like the very heavens in brightness
And all around in dazzling lightness.
11 But on the nobles of the folk
Of Israel He did not lay hand.
So they saw Alohim *who spoke*,
And ate and drank *at His command*.

See God, and cease to be, destroyed by
light
Of brightness of Your glory in the sight,
And then be raised again to life for
knowing
The bliss of Your presence, eternal
showing,
What grace You gave, Beloved, to men of
old.
I, timid soul, never would be so bold
To seek You on the mountain in the vision.
I seek You in the everyday decision
Of right and wrong, of glory in Your will
That may seem desert dry, emotion-still,
But wakens in the quiet for a bliss
Far deeper and calm, though survived, than
this
Banquet of joy in fervent resurrection

For having with You physical connection.

12 YHWH told Moses, "Come up to Me
On the mountain and be there *free*,
And I'll give you tablets of stone,
Law and commandments I *alone*
Have written, that you may teach them."

13 So Moses rose *not to contempt*
With his assistant Joshua,
And Moses went up there in awe
To the mountain of Alohim.

14 And he said to the elders' *cream*,
"Wait here for us until we come
Back to you, see Aaron's *not dumb*
And Hur *also is* with you here.
If any has trouble or fear,
Let him go to them *and appear*."

15 Then Moses went up to the mount
A cloud covered it like a fount.

16 Now the glory of YHWH rested
On Mount Sinai, and the cloud *hid*
And covered it six days, but on
The seventh day *in benison*
He called to Moses from the cloud.

17 The sight of glory *without shroud*
Of YHWH *was* like consuming fire
On the mountaintop to inspire
The eyes of the folk of Israel.

18 So Moses went into the cloud,
Went up the mountain *and unbowed*.
And Moses was *both sane and well*
Upon the mountain forty days
And forty nights *in glory's ways*.

You wrote, Beloved, upon tables of stone
The summary of all faith in the bone
Of humankind. Although stone is preferred
To make idols of coal, oil, diamond sherd,
The sapphire engraved with the sacred
word

Is not enough for human hopefulness.
I thus wait six days for the word to bless
My ear and heart, the word on breath and
tongue

Revealing the truly engraved word sung
Upon the tables of my heart. I hear
Upon the Sabbath day Your loving, clear
Voice once again proclaim what still
resounds

From Sinai's cloud and fire. I know no fear,
Beloved, enfolded and kissed in Your
bounds.

Week 19 Exodus 25

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
2 "Tell the folk of Israel to bring
Me an offering, from everyone
Who gives it willingly *when done*
With his heart you'll take My offering.
3 "And this *is* the offering which you
Shall take from them: gold, silver *new*,
And bronze, 4 "blue, purple, scarlet *thread*,
Fine linen, goats', 5 "ram skins dyed red,
Badger (or seals') skins, and the wood
Of the acacia, 6 "oil that should
Give light, and spices for the oil
Of the anointing *not to spoil*
And for the sweet incense, 7 "onyx
Stones, and *the carved* stone set that sticks
In the ephod and in breastplate.
8 "And let them make for Me a *state*
Of sanctuary, that I may
Stay among them *both night and day*.
9 "According to all that I show
You of pattern *portfolio*
Of the tabernacle and all
The pattern of its furnished *hall*,
Just so you shall make *standing stall*.

I have no gold to bring, Beloved, to You,
Nor fine linen nor thread in purple, blue,
Nor sweet incense made of desert perfume
To fill with odours any sacred room.
I only have the temple of my heart,
And even that is not mine from the start,
But Yours alone, who own the universe,
The shy buck on the shady hill, not worse
Than rainy salamander in his track.
And yet for sacrifice I have no lack.
I bring You but Your own, this temple set
And built without hands from the pattern
known

To Your heart from eternity alone.
Beloved, this sacrifice is what You get.

10 "And they shall make an ark of wood,
Of the acacia two *for good*
And half a cubit for its length,
A cubit and a half *in strength*
Of its width, and a cubit and
A half for its height *by command*.

11 "And you shall overlay it with
Pure gold, inside, *shining like myth*,
And outside you shall overlay,

And make gold moulding all the way.
 12 "You shall cast four gold rings for it,
 And let them in four corners *sit*,
 Two rings *shall be* on one side, and
 Two rings upon the other hand.
 13 "And you shall make poles *of* the wood
 Of the acacia, and *for good*
 Overlay them with gold *as should*.
 14 "You shall put the poles in the rings
 On the sides of the ark *for things*,
 The ark may be carried by them.
 15 "The poles shall be *by stratagem*
 In the rings of the ark, they shall
 Not be taken from it *at all*.
 16 "And you shall put into the ark
 The testimony I remark.
 17 "You'll make a mercy seat of gold,
 Pure gold two and a half *all told*
 Of cubits *shall be the ark's* length,
One and a half its width in strength.
 18 "And you shall make two cherubim
 Of gold, of hammered work *to seem*,
 You shall make them at the two ends
 Of the mercy seat *that extends*.
 19 "Make one cherub at one end, and
 The other at the other hand,
 You'll make of one piece mercy seat
 And cherubim at the two feet.

Made of one piece of gold this mercy seat,
 I have no qualms about its cubit feet.
 I only ask, Beloved, the difference
 Between the cherubim in their incense
 And idols of false gods prohibited.
 My simple mind on simple things is fed.
 I cling, before the idols of the state
 And before the church with its love and
 hate,
 To the bare witness lying there within
 The ark of gold and grace against my sin.
 I stand on that great law, and stand alone,
 Against the iron laws and the church stone
 That would compel my conscience in Your
 name,
 And like Iblis I bow not to their claim.

20 "And the cherubim shall stretch out
Their wings above, covering about
 The mercy seat with *all* their wings,
 And they shall face each other's *swings*,
 The faces of the cherubim
 Toward the mercy seat *to beam*.

21 "You'll put the mercy seat on top
 Of the ark, in the ark you'll drop
 The witness that I'll give to you.
 22 "And always there I'll meet with you,
 And I will speak with you above
 The mercy seat, *and in My love*,
 From between the two cherubim
 Which *both* above the ark shall swim,
 Above the testimony, and
 About the things that I command
 You and the folk in Israel's band.

The tables of stone are nowhere I know
 Unless in Axum hidden in the glow
 Of inner sanctum. Yet the tables shine
 With sapphire glory in this heart of mine
 Where on the fleshly tables You have writ
 Your promises engraved here where I sit.
 Within an ark of flesh and bone You scribe
 Your witness instead of the golden bribe
 Upon acacia wood. Your scribings last
 No longer than a breath and then are past
 To come again upon the clean slate there
 That rises in desire to meet the air.
 Beloved, You meet me at that mercy seat
 That You make gold by Your creative feat.

23 "You shall also make table of
 Acacia wood, *carved out above*,
 Two cubits *shall be* its length and
 A cubit its width *in a band*,
 A cubit and a half its height.
 24 "And you shall overlay it *right*
 With pure gold, and make moulding of
 Gold all around it *and above*.
 25 "You shall make a frame a hand wide
 All around *and on every side*,
 And you shall make moulding of gold
 For the frame all around it *told*.
 26 "And you shall make for it four rings
 Of gold, and put the rings on things
 In the four corners of its legs.
 27 "The rings shall be close to the pegs
 Of frame, as holders for the poles
 To bear the table. 28 "And the poles
 You shall make of acacia wood,
 And overlay them with gold *good*,
 To carry the table as should.
 29 "You shall make its dishes, its pans,
 Its pitchers, bowls *by artisans*
 For pouring, you'll make of pure gold.
 30 "And you shall set the showbread *cold*

Before Me on the table *hold*.

I make the table of showbread to stand
A golden ornament within the band
Of my heart's temple, and I make it of
Obedience to Your commands and love
Sweet wooded from within and from
without
Inlaid with the gold of my love's redoubt.
I make the table of bread inch by inch
And pray, Beloved, that I shall never flinch
To find the bread of heaven come down to
me,
Grown from the ground as sweetly as can
be.
I make the table of showbread each day
By my aspiring breaths and sips that stay
But for a moment and again expire:
I make the table to shine in Your fire.

31 "You shall also make a lamp-stand
Of pure gold hammered out by hand.
Its shaft, its branches, bowls and knobs,
And flowers shall be *the best jobs*.
32 "Six branches shall come out its side,
Three branches of lamp-stand abide
On one side, and three branches on
The lamp-stand out the other con.
33 "Three bowls *shall be* made like almond
On one branch, *with* a knob and frond,
And three bowls made like almond on
The other branch, *with* knob upon
And flower, and so for the six branches
That come out of the lamp-stand flanches.
34 "On the lamp-stand itself four bowls
Made like almond *with* knobs and scrolls.
35 "And *there shall be* a knob beneath
The two branches out of the sheath,
A knob beneath *next* two branch pair,
A knob under the *last ones there*,
For all six branches in the air.
36 "Their knobs and their branches all *told*,
One hammered piece of purest gold.
37 "You shall make seven lamps for it,
And they shall arrange its lamps fit
So that they give light before it.
38 "And its wick-trimmers and their trays
Shall be of pure gold *too for stays*.
39 "A talent of pure gold shall make
The whole with all its vessels' sake.
40 "And see that you make *all things by*
The mountain pattern shown on high.

I make the last furniture of my heart,
The golden lamps with leaf and knob and
smart
Bud of the almond all contrived to stand
According to the mountain pattern planned,
The pattern that You still proclaim from
Mount
Sinai in hearing of each flesh-planed count.
I call Your seven spirits to be guides
In all I make of it and more besides.
But, my Beloved, a talent weight of gold
Is not a guide sufficient when all's told.
I make the lamp that fills my heart by plan,
But You did not reveal the height to man.
You left to me to decide when to stop
Beating and spinning gold up to the top.

Exodus 26

1 "Moreover you shall make the tent
Ten curtains *of* fine wovenment
Of linen and blue, purple, and
Scarlet embroidery by hand,
Of cherubim you shall weave them.
2 "The length of each curtain, *a gem*,
Shall be twenty-eight cubits, and
The width of each four cubits' *band*.
And every curtain shall be of
One size *for length below, above*.
3 "Five curtains shall be coupled to
Each other, and *the other* do
For five curtains each coupled too.
4 "And you shall make loops of blue on
The edge of the curtain and on
The selvedge of *one* set, likewise
You shall do on the outer guise
Of curtain of the second set.
5 "Fifty loops you shall make well-met
In the one curtain, fifty loops
You shall make on the edge *in groups*
Of the curtain that's on the end
Of the second set, that the loops
May clasp each to each *and extend*.
6 "And you shall make fifty gold clasps
And couple curtains so it grasps,
So it may as one tent suspend.

Surround me, my Beloved, with linen white
With loops of blue and precious in men's
sight,
And clasps of gold to make a desert tent
Within the wilderness of this world spent,

That You may dwell in me and I in You
Beneath a white- and gold-rimmed sky of
blue.

May that pure covering hide from the sight
Of the on-looker curious to fight
My courtyard ablutions and sacrifice,
The bread and light and perfumes that
entice

Into the inner sanctum of the soul
Where mercy-seat and decalogue and roll
Await the glory of Your presence here
Where I taste exquisite things without fear.

7 "You'll also make curtains of goats'
To be an upper tent that floats.
You shall make eleven curtains.

8 "And the length of all the curtains
Thirty cubits, and the width of
Each curtain four cubits *above*,
And the eleven curtains shall
Have the same measurements withal.

9 "And you shall couple five veils by
Themselves and six veils *not awry*
And double over the sixth veil
At the forefront of the tent *pale*.

10 "You shall make fifty loops upon
The edge of the veil that's upon
The outermost and in *one* set,
And fifty loops on the edge *get*
The curtain of the second set.

11 "And you shall make fifty bronze clasps,
Put the clasps into the loops' *hasps*,
And couple the tent, that it may
Be one. 12 "Now the remnants that stay
Of the tent's veils, the half veil *spun*
Shall hang over the back when done.

13 "And a cubit on one side and
A cubit on the other hand,
Of what remains of the length of
The curtains of the tent above,
Shall hang over the tent's sides, on
This side and that, covered upon.

14 "You shall also make covering
Of ram skins dyed red for the *wing*
Of the tent, and a covering
Of badger [seal] skins above that *thing*.

A goatskin covering the first of three,
Beloved, You demand for a canopy.
The little goats go running out at morn
To lead a village boy from branch to thorn,

And then come running back as night
draws near

With little feet that patter at the rear
For all the world like raindrops on the
stones

And dust of village paths, and by their
tones

Call me to prayer who hesitated at
The muezzin's clear voice heard where I
sat.

You do not ask for silks to grace Your
walls,

And so I also leave lace where it falls
And dress myself in sunset's gauzes till
The clattering of goatskins becomes still.

15 "And for the tabernacle you
Shall make acacia boards to do
The upright standing. 16 "Ten cubits
Shall be the length *where* a board *sits*,
And a cubit and half *shall be*
The width of each board *faithfully*.

17 "Two tenons *shall be* in each board
For binding each to each *when stored*.
Thus you shall make for all the planks
Of the tabernacle *for thanks*.

18 "And you shall make the tent boards
twenty

For the south side, *that should be plenty*.

19 "And forty silver sockets make
Under the twenty boards *in stake*:
Two sockets under each of them
For its two tenons *to begem*.

20 "And for the second side of tent,
The north, *also* twenty boards *went*

21 "Forty silver sockets with two
Under each board *as though they grew*.

22 "For the tent's far side to the west
You shall make six boards *of the best*.

My year is bound and held in the sweet
frame

Of forty silver sockets without name
But Ramadhan, Muharrem days of fasting
Returning on the bright wings and the
lasting

Year's flight and hover on the simple store.
The year returns as both window and door.
My year is kept in sockets set to bear
The days and weeks in single order there,
That without them would scatter and fall
down,

A pile of planks beneath a cloudy frown
Instead of a straight wall to keep the gold
Of love and obedience from the sold.
In forty silver sockets still I stand
In judgement and reprieve in a strange
land.

23 "And you shall also make two planks
At tent's two back corners *in ranks*.
24 "They shall be coupled at the base
And at the top by one ring's grace.
Thus it shall be for both of them
For two corners in stratagem.
25 "So there shall be eight boards with their
Silver sockets, *sixteen in air*,
Two sockets under each board there.
26 "And you shall make you bars of wood
Of acacia, five *as you should*
For the boards on the one tent side,
27 "Five bars for each of boards that slide
Into place on the other side
Of the tent, and five bars for those
Boards on the west side *and to close*.
28 "The middle bar shall pass through those
Boards from one end to other end.
29 "You'll overlay the boards *and spend*
With gold, and make their rings of gold
For the bars as a place to hold,
And overlay the bars with gold.
30 "You shall raise up the tabernacle
According to its pattern *crackle*
Which you were shown upon the mount
For which you shall give an account.

Make me, Beloved, inlaid with heavenly
gold
In overlay upon the wood of cold
Desert nights and of heated noons where
grew
Acacias with their small leaves begging
dew.
Make me, Beloved, according to the law
In pattern shown upon the mount in awe.
The heavenly pattern I would seek before
The golden idols set before tent door.
Let me raise up Your temple before men
Not in the fashion of the Parisienne,
The New Yorker, the Roman or the Greek,
The wealthy and the stealthy and the sleek.
The heavenly pattern, shown upon the
mount,
I take each word, each promise to account.

31 "You shall make a veil woven blue,
Purple, and scarlet, and fine too
Woven linen. It shall be woven
With fine design, cherubim *cloven*.
32 "You shall hang it upon the four
Pillars of acacia *in store*
And overlaid with gold. Their hooks
Gold, upon four sockets *for looks*
Of silver. 33 "And you'll hang the veil
From the clasps, then you'll bring *by rail*
Ark of the Testimony there,
Behind the veil, which it shall wear
As a divider for you where
The holy and most holy stand.
34 "You shall put the mercy seat *band*
On the ark of the Testimony
In the most holy place and zony.
35 "You shall set the table outside
The veil, and the lamp-stand to bide
Across from the table to ride
Upon the side of the tent there,
And you shall put the table *where*
It stands on the north side *and fair*.
36 "You shall make a screen for the door
Of the tabernacle *in store*,
Of blue, purple, and scarlet *thread*,
Fine woven linen, by well-bred.
37 "And you shall make for the screen five
Pillars of acacia *and strive*
To overlay them *all* with gold,
Their hooks *also shall be of* gold,
And you shall cast five sockets of
Bronze for them *beneath and above*.

Beloved, I have set lamp and bread in place
Within the temple of my heart and face.
Beloved, I have hung veil and gone inside
To place the golden altar on the tide.
The ark of testimony all undone
And put together with gold into one,
And set beneath the cherub wing to bide
Is in its place and I stand here to wait
And pray to You to make my harp and fate.
All things are done, I lie with open breast,
Come You, Beloved, to bless with song and
fest,
And set within the witness of my heart
Beneath the mercy seat the tabled part
Upon my flesh Your law, the promised
best.

Exodus 27

1 "Make altar of acacia wood,
Five cubits long, five cubits should
Be width as well, make altar square,
And its height of three cubits there.

2 "You shall make its horns on its four
Corners, its horns are of one score.

You'll overlay the thing with bronze.

3 "Also you shall make all of bronze,
Its pans to receive ashes in,
Its shovels too and each basin
And its forks and firepans, you'll make
All its utensils of bronze *take*.

4 "You'll make a grate for it, network
Of bronze, and upon the network
You'll make two pairs of bronze rings at
The four corners *of where it sat*.

5 "You shall put it under the rim

Of the altar beneath, the *trim*

Of network may be midway *to*

The *top* of the altar. 6 "And you
Shall make poles for the altar, poles
Of acacia wood, *from the soles*
And upward with bronze overlay.

7 "The poles shall be put in the way
Of the rings, and the poles shall be
On the two sides where easily

The altar can be carried free.

8 "You shall make it hollow with planks,
As it was shown to you *with thanks*
Upon the mountain, so shall they
Make it *duly in every way*.

I enter court and whirl around within
Encircling arms of linen veils for sin,
The burnished brass of this fair slaughter
ground

Reflects the fires of love from where I'm
bound.

The altar is of length that I may lie
Stretched out upon my back and there to
die,

Burnt in the loving fire until no loss
Appears upon the altar for the dross.
My soul arises in the glowing sparks
That fly and hover like the summer larks.
My soul flies up to You, my will falls
down,

A serene and silken veil, a bridal gown,
Beloved, there is no world left me but You,
I whirl again and enter what is true.

9 "You shall also make the tent court.

For the south side hangings of sort
Of fine woven linen, of one
Hundred cubits long one side done.

10 "And its twenty pillars and their
Twenty bronze sockets *they shall wear*.
Hooks of the pillars and their bands
Shall be of silver in their stands.

11 "Likewise along the north side length
Hangings one hundred *cubits' strength*,
With its twenty pillars and their
Twenty sockets of bronze *and fair*,
And the hooks of the pillars and
Their bands of silver *where they stand*.

12 "And along the width of the court
On the west side hangings *of sort*
Of fifty cubits, with their ten
Pillars and sockets *also* ten.

13 "The width of the court on the east
Shall be fifty cubits at least.

14 "Hangings on *one side of the gate*
Shall be fifteen cubits in state,
With their three pillars and their three
Sockets. 15 "And on the other lee
Hangings of fifteen *cubits*, *and*
Their three pillars with sockets *stand*.

Bind me about, Beloved, in linen white
For burial of sacrifice tonight.

I lie as dead, Beloved, as next of kin,
You take water and spice to wash my skin.
With bitter tears You stretch my stiffened
limbs

And hide me from the people's wicked
whims.

In secret and most privately You tell
My bones all in array before the well.
My scant flesh falls away in single breath
As I enter the silent, dusty death.

Bind me about, Beloved, in linen shroud
And bear me off, away from praying
crowd,

And hide me in the secret of Your heart
And leave the earth forever for its part.

16 "For the gate of the court a screen
Twenty cubits long, blue *of sheen*,
Purple, and scarlet, fine linen,
Woven by a weaver *again*.

It shall have four pillars and four
Sockets. 17 "And all the pillars *more*
Around the court have silver bands,

Their hooks of silver, sockets' *stands*
 Of bronze. 18 "And the length of the court
Shall be one hundred cubits' *sport*,
 The width fifty *cubits* throughout,
 And height five cubits without doubt,
 Fine linen woven, bronze sockets.
 19 "All the utensils the tent gets
 For all its service, all its pegs,
 And all the pegs of the court's *legs*,
 Of bronze, *each in its place and sets*.

Week 20

20 "And now you shall command the folk
 Of Israel that they bring *and stoke*
 Pure oil of pressed olives for light,
 To cause the lamp to burn *in sight*.
 21 "In the tent of meeting, outside
 The veil which *is* before the *bide*
 Of Testimony, Aaron and
 His sons shall tend it *by command*
 From evening until morning there
 Before YHWH. *It shall be a fair*
 Statute continuing to their
 Generations for *all* the folk
 Of Israel. *And so God spoke*.

Though I am neither Aaron nor his son,
 Let my lamp burn until this night is done.
 Let burn the kindly guiding light of God.
 Let gently lead the Shepherd's staff and
 rod.
 My darkened inner chamber opens wide
 To welcome heaven's light to dwell inside.
 Grant, My Beloved, a drop of olive oil,
 Illuminate my hour of midnight toil.
 The night work of my heart is but a tomb,
 Unless You enter in my lowly room.
 My inner chamber walls are dark and cold,
 But in Your light they turn to shining gold.
 Eternal is Your love on my desire,
 If You but ever kindle my heart's fire.

Exodus 28

1 "Now take Aaron your brother, and
 His sons with him, from out the band
 Of Israel's folk, that he may serve
 To Me as priest, *as I deserve*,
 Aaron *and* Aaron's sons: Nadab,
 Abihu, Eleazar rab,
 And Ithamar. 2 "And you shall make
 Holy garments for Aaron's sake,
 Your brother, for glory and beauty,

And wearing them shall be his duty.

Take You away my filthy rags and stained
 And leave my soul unfettered and
 unchained.
 Give me the holy garments of Your grace,
 White raiment here in this unholy place.
 Clean linen lay upon my tortured brow
 To cool the angers that inflame me now.
 Clothe me in glory for Your mercy's sake,
 Let beauty round about me garments make.
 The dark cloud turns to glory where You
 start,
 Your mornings dress in beauty from Your
 heart.
 Clothe me in silken melodies of grace,
 The offering of my soul before Your face.
 In glory and in beauty at Your throne
 I prostrate in Your mercies clad alone.

3 "So you shall speak to all *who are*
 Gifted as artisan *and star*,
 Whom I have filled with wisdom's spirit,
 To make Aaron's garments, *and near it*
 To consecrate him, that he may
 Serve Me as priest *and every day*.
 4 "And these *are* the garments which they
 Shall make: a breastplate *overlay*
 An ephod, a robe, skilfully
 Woven tunic, a turban, *see*,
 And a sash. And so they shall make
 Holy garments for Aaron's sake,
 Your brother and his sons, that he
 May minister as priest to Me.
 5 "They'll take the gold, blue, purple, and
 Scarlet *thread*, and fine linen, 6 "and
 They shall make the ephod of gold,
 Blue, purple, scarlet *thread all told*,
 And fine woven linen, well worked.
 7 "And it shall have its two straps *jerked*,
 Joined at the shoulders by the edges,
 And *so* it shall be joined *like wedges*.
 8 "And the close woven band upon
 The ephod shall be *polygon*
 Of the same workmanship, *of* gold,
 Blue, purple, and scarlet *all told*,
 And fine woven linen. 9 "Then you
 Shall take two onyx stones to do
 And engrave on them the names of
 The sons of Israel: 10 "six *above*
 Of their names on one stone, and six
 Names on the other stone, *no tricks*,

In order of their birth. 11 "With work
Of an engraver in stone work,
Like the engravings of a ring
Of signet, you shall grave the thing
Of the two stones with *all* the names
Of the sons of Israel's *claims*.
You shall set them in settings gold.
12 "And you shall place the two stones
hold

On the shoulders of the ephod
Memorial stones *before God*
For the sons of Israel. So
Aaron shall bear their names *to go*
Before YHWH on his two shoulders
As a memorial *occurs*.

13 "You shall also make settings of
Gold, 14 "and then you shall make *above*
Two chains of pure gold like braided
Cords, and fasten the chains braided
To the settings *as you are led*.

Why do You demand gold, Beloved, when
You

Cannot hold gold worth anything and true.
The human mind and hand grasp gold to be
Eternal and unchanging sure beauty,
And as such like Yourself, but that likeness
Is blasphemous, profane and cannot bless
The human heart. All gold is mere cold
stone.

The pagan thought is gold is god flesh,
bone.

The heathen hounding's seeking gold alone.
But You seek neither gem nor precious
thing

Except loving obedience to sing.
Is this the priesthood's last Egyptian fling?
Or is gold not to be disputed for
A flower's beauty, if not less, no more?

15 "You'll make the breastplate of
judgement.

Finely woven without relent
According to the workmanship
Of the ephod make without slip,
Of gold, blue, purple, scarlet *thread*,
And fine woven linen outspread,
You shall make it. 16 "And it shall be
Doubled into a square: a span
Its length, a span its width *by man*.
17 "And you shall put settings of stone
In it, four rows of stones *alone*:

A sardius, a topaz, and
An emerald, the first row *manned*,
18 "The second row turquoise, sapphire,
And a diamond *of great desire*,
19 "The third row, a jacinth, agate,
And an amethyst *finely set*,
20 "And the fourth row, beryl, onyx,
And a jasper, all set *with tricks*
In gold settings. 21 "And the stones shall
Have names of sons of Israel,
Twelve according to *all* their names,
Like engravings of signet *frames*,
Each one with its own name, they shall
Be by twelve tribes of Israel.

Twelve precious stones engraved with
precious names
Eternally adorn terrestrial frames.
The secret names are carried to the throne
Where You, Belovèd, sit and reign alone,
And there receive the kiss of progeny
Blessed from the time of Abraham's degree.
Appointed ones for guidance in each age,
These shining stars lead on the pilgrimage.
Their flashing colours from the sky cast
down

Rest on the breast and heart, though worth
a crown.

Beloved, I seek the precious jewels that
You set to guide the world to where You're
at.

I find them hidden still, occulted close
In silence instead of the vain verbose.

22 "You shall make chains for the
breastplate
At the end, like braided cords' *mate*
Of pure gold. 23 "And you shall make two
Rings of gold for the breastplate *too*,
And put the two rings on both ends
Of the breastplate *and at the bends*.

24 "Then you shall put both braided *chains*
Of gold where two rings' *broach* remains
Which are on the ends of breastplate,
25 "And the *other* two ends *as mate*
Of the two braided *chains* you shall
Fasten to the two settings *well*,
And put them on the shoulder straps
Of the ephod in front *perhaps*.

26 "You shall make two rings *more* of
gold,
And put them on the two ends *rolled*

Of the breastplate, on the edge of
It, on the inner side above
Of the ephod. 27 "And two rings more
Of gold you shall make, put before
On the two shoulder straps, beneath
The ephod toward its fronted *wreath*,
Right at the seam above the fine
Woven band of the ephod's *twine*,
Where its holy beauty convenes.

28 "They shall bind the breastplate by
means

Of its rings to the rings attached
To the ephod, *and so well-matched*
Using a blue cord, so that it's
Above the well woven band *fits*
Of the ephod, so the breastplate
Does not come loose from ephod *mate*.

Bind me, Belovèd, with a bright blue cord
To Your heart and be my Lover and Lord.
The golden rings You share with me make
fast

With ties of love to You and make them
last.

I bear the names upon me of Your own,
Set in the gold of love and in the stone
Of my obedience to You alone.
Bind up my heart tightly within the zone
Of Your divinity until there be
Nothing left of my will, nothing of me.
Bind me, Beloved, so that I do not come
Loose from the ephod of that martyrdom.
The golden pairs pass on and two by two
Join into one all things that come to You.

29 "So Aaron shall bear the names of
The sons of Israel and above
The breastplate of judgement upon
His heart, when he goes in *at dawn*
And eve into the holy *place*,
A constant sign before YHWH's face.
30 "And you shall put in the breastplate
Of judgement the Urim *offate*
And the Thummim, and they shall be
Over Aaron's heart whene'er he
Goes in before YHWH. So Aaron
Shall bear the judgement there upon
His heart for Israel's children by
YHWH and there continually.

Beloved, You make a secret of the stones

Called Urim and Thummin, like craven
groans

That frighten hags and children in the
night.

You do not mention here the shadow light
That comes to speak Your will to priestly
question.

You leave each reader to his poor
digestion.

Enough, perhaps, it is these magic gems
Bear every child of Israel's diadems
Before Your face within the hidden tent.
In love at least the secret jewels are spent.
Urim and Thummin, sacred windows on
Your revelation's bright and rosy dawn,
Comfort my heart that seeks to know Your
will

As I awaken to shiver and chill.

31 "And you shall make the ephod's robe
All of blue. 32 "There shall be a scope
Opening for his head within
The middle of it, and its *skin*
Of woven binding all around
Its opening, like the one found
In coats of mail, so it won't tear.

33 "And upon its hem you shall wear
Pomegranates of blue, purple, and
Scarlet, all around its hem, and
Bells of gold between them around:

34 "A golden bell and pomegranate,
A golden bell and pomegranate,
Upon the robe's hem all around.

35 "And it shall be upon Aaron
When he ministers, and its sound
Will then be heard when he goes on
Into the holy *place* before
YHWH and when he comes out *the door*,
That he may not die. 36 "You'll also
Make a plate of pure gold *to show*
And engrave on graven signet
Holiness to YHWH. 37 "And you'll put
It on a blue cord, *not for foot*
But on the turban, it shall be
On the front of turban *to see*.

I take no turban for myself to wear
Although Ed Elwall wore one everywhere,
And half the crooks in Iran are adept
At winding turbans with their hearts
unswept.

Instead I beg You, my Beloved, to give

That golden signet graven where I live,
Not in cold metal nor in written word,
But in the way I live, clear and unblurred,
As holiness to You. And on blue cord
Of loyalty to You without steel sword,
But with the sword of truth from Your own
lips.

Let that turban invisible that slips
Unnoticed on the humble head obeying
Be mine bowed on the altar and there
staying.

38 "So it shall be on Aaron's forehead,
That Aaron may bear all the horrid
Iniquity of holy things

Which every son of Israel brings
To hallow in all holy gifts,
And it shall always be where lifts
His forehead, that they may all be
Accepted before YHWH *wholly*.

39 "You shall skilfully weave the tunic
Of fine linen, and make the *runic*
Turban of fine linen, and you
Shall make the sash of woven hue.

40 "For Aaron's sons you'll also make
Tunics, and sashes for their sake.
And you shall make hats for them too,
For glory and beauty. 41 "So you
Shall put them on Aaron your brother
And on his sons with him. You'll smother
Them all with oil and consecrate
Them, and sanctify their estate,
That they may minister to Me
As priests. 42 "And you shall make them
free

Linen trousers for nudity
To be covered, and they shall reach
From the waist to the thighs for breech.
43 "They shall be on Aaron and on
His sons when they come *eve or dawn*
Into tabernacle of meeting,
Or when they come near *in their seating*
To the altar to minister
In the holy not to incur
Iniquity and die. *It shall*
Be a statute and eternal
To him and his descendants all.

Give me no linen, my Beloved, but wool!
I want no priesthood, had it to the full.
The cool and lovely linen give another

Who calls his co-rebellious saint and
brother.

I rather take the woollen pant and shirt
And in the worker's garb unfinely girt
Whirl in the turmoil of the friendly street
Or then pass on or then stop one to greet.
Eternal statutes bent to time and place,
When all return to stand before Your face.
Iniquity itself is temporary,
And only You eternally are merry.
No priest am I, but only slaughtered lamb
Dressed in the flesh and bone and wool I
am.

Exodus 29

1 "This is what you shall do to them
To hallow them *in stratagem*
For ministering to Me as priests:
Take one young bull, two rams *for feasts*
Without blemish, 2 "unleavened bread,
Unleavened cakes mixed with a *shred*
Of oil, and unleavened wafers
Anointed with oil *as prefers*
Made of wheat flour. 3 "You shall put them
In one basket and then bring them
In the basket, with the bull and
The two rams *there and make them stand*.
4 "And Aaron and his sons you shall
Bring to the doorway *eternal*
Of the tent of meeting, and you
Shall wash them with the water *due*.
5 "Then you shall take the garments, put
The tunic on Aaron, from foot
The robe of the ephod, ephod,
And the breastplate, and gird him *shod*
With the fine woven ephod band.
6 "You'll put the turban *in your hand*
Upon his head, and put the crown
Of holiness on turban down.
7 "And you shall take anointing oil,
Pour on his head, anoint no spoil.

The consecration of Aaron is like
Baptism in the early church to strike
A contrast with the ordination of
The priest and rabbi or mullah for shove.
Those hierarchies have no place allowed
Within Your revelation: they're too proud.
What once was high priest becomes in the
day
Of Christ the settled status all the way
Of everyone within that kingdom of

Kings and priests, duly dressed and dipped
above

And chrismed with the oil demanded by
The didachè, and that's the reason why.
Consecrate me also, Beloved, into
The priesthood given to both all and few.

8 "Then you shall bring his sons and put
Tunics on them *from head to foot*.

9 "And you shall gird them with their
sashes,

Aaron and sons, beauty for ashes,
And put hats on them. The priesthood
Shall be theirs as statute for good.

So you shall consecrate Aaron
And his sons with these clothes upon.

10 "You shall also have the bull brought
Before the tent of meeting *sought*,

And Aaron and his sons shall put
Their hands on the head *not the foot*

Of the bull. 11 "Then you'll kill the bull
Before YHWH, *by* the portical

Of the tent of meeting. 12 "You shall
Take *some* of the blood of the bull

And put *it* on the altar horns
Of the altar with finger bournes,

And pour all the blood by the base
Of the altar. 13 "And you shall chase

All fat that covers the entrails,
The fatty lobe *that forms the shells*

Of the liver, and the two reins
Or kidneys and their fat that *stains*,

And burn *it where* altar obtains.

14 "But the flesh of the bull, with its
Skin and its offal, burn those bits

With fire outside the camp for sin.

The so-called Christian takes the death of
Christ,

Replacing sacrifice of bull fair priced.

Baptized into his death the saying is,

And so the consecrated death is his.

I know from many words that You dote not
On blood of bulls, if on more than just
thought,

And still Your care, Beloved, for human
woes

Allows You to sigh and accept our blows.

You limit sacrifices men insist

On bringing to Your house to fill Your list,

But do not break the bending human reed

That must it seems retreat again to feed

In order to take in a serious tone
The promises to serve You God alone.

15 "You shall also take one ram in,

And Aaron and his sons shall put

Their hands on the ram's head, *not foot*,

16 "And you shall kill the ram, and you

Shall take its blood and make it do

To sprinkle all around the altar.

17 "Then cut the ram, *and do not falter*,

In pieces, wash its entrails and

Its legs, and put *them all in hand*

With its pieces and with its head.

18 "And you shall burn the whole ram said

Upon the altar for burnt offering

To YHWH, with sweet aroma proffering,

An offering made by fire to YHWH.

19 "And you shall also take the ram,

The other one, and *for a lamb*

Aaron and his sons shall put their

Hands on the head of the ram *fair*.

20 "Then you shall kill the ram, and take

Some of its blood and for the sake

Of putting on the right ear's tip

Of Aaron and his sons, *not hip*,

On the thumb of their right hand and

On the big toe of their right foot,

And sprinkle all the blood *in hand*

All around on the altar put.

21 "And you shall take some of the blood

That's on the altar, and some stud

Of the anointing oil, and sprinkle

On Aaron and garments *no wrinkle*,

On his sons and the garments of

His sons with him, *all them for love*,

And he and his garments shall be

Hallowed, and his sons *faithfully*

And his sons' garments with him too.

22 "Also you shall take the fat through

From the ram, the fat tail, the fat

That covers entrails *where they're at*,

The fatty lobe of liver, and

The two kidneys, the fats that stand

On them, and the right thigh, for it

Is consecrated ram and fit,

23 "One loaf of bread, one cake *of* oil,

And one wafer *and not to spoil*

From the basket of bread unyeasted

That's before YHWH *and not yet feasted*,

24 "And you shall put all these in hands

Of Aaron and in the commands

Of his sons, and you shall wave them

As wave offering before YHWH's *hem*.

Mark my ear too, Beloved, a sacrifice,
And I shall walk into the paradise
Of slaughter and whirl on the night wind
till

I come a rising spark up to Your hill.
Perhaps You ought to mark my thumb and
toe

On left hand and left foot because I show
The aptitude to use the left, not right.
So unworthy am I before Your sight.
In Turkey once or twice they thought I ate
With my left hand to share the devil's plate.
I swear such is not my intention here,
But only to bow to You thumb and ear,
And take the sacrificial blood upon
My toe as I whirl on the rising dawn.

25 "You shall receive them back from their
Hands and burn *them* on the altar

As a burnt offering, as a sweet
Aroma before YHWH as meet.

It is an offering made by fire
To YHWH. 26 "Then you shall have desire
To take the breast of the ram of
Aaron 's consecration *above*

And wave it *as* a wave offering
Before YHWH, your portion proffering.

27 "And from the ram of consecration
You shall select the breast *oblation*
Of the wave offering which is waved,
And the thigh of heave offering *saved*
Which is raised, of *that* which is for
Aaron and his sons *in their store*.

28 "It shall be from Israel's children
For Aaron and his sons till when.

For it's a heave offering, it shall
Be a heave offering *punctual*
From the children of Israel

From the sacrifices *done well*
Of their peace offerings, heave offering
To YHWH *to cantillate and sing*.

29 "The holy garments of Aaron
Shall be his sons' after him done,
To be anointed in them and

To consecrate them *by command*.

30 "That son who becomes priest instead
Of him shall wear them and not shed
For seven days, when he enters
The tent of meeting, ministers
Within the holy *place*. 31 "And you

Shall take the selected ram too
And boil its flesh in holy place.

32 "Then Aaron and sons *face to face*
Shall eat the flesh of the ram, and
The loaves that in the basket stand,
By the door of the tent of meeting.

33 "They shall eat those things *at that*
seating

With which the atonement was made,
To consecrate *them in their grade*
And sanctify them, but outsider
Shall not eat *them with the provider*,
Because they *are* holy. 34 "And if
Any of the flesh of the *stiff*
Consecration offerings, or of
The bread, remains *of the above*
Until the morning, then you shall
Burn with fire the residual.
It shall not be eaten at all,
Because it *is* holy, *though small*.

Like priest in consecration eating loaf,
Although outsider counted and an oaf,
I too look to Your hand providing meat
From day to day, and that is what I eat.
The store for winter set aside by those
Rodents whose wisdom divine You too
chose

Is not for the grasshopper cast like me:
I take from Your hand bread and take daily.
One sent and wise thus taught me how to
pray

For daily and not weekly bread and stay.
I come at dawn to Your tent door
unblessed,

With empty hand after the long night rest,
And eat the consecrated bread You give,
And on that bread and Word contrive to
live.

35 "Thus you shall do to Aaron and
His sons, by all that I command.
Seven days you shall consecrate
Them. 36 "And you shall offer a *great*
Bull every day *as* sin offering
For an atonement. You shall bring
Atonement to cleanse the altar,
Anoint to sanctify *the bar*.

37 "Seven days you shall make atonement
For altar, sanctify its ownment,
And the altar shall be most holy,
What touches it is also holy.

There's none holy but You, Beloved, and true,
 Yet what touches the holy altar's due
 Becomes holy, what touches the vain thing
 Becomes vain in both word and song and ring.
 For seven days I follow the footsteps
 That You make on creation's wicker skeps,
 And see Your form almost, but not because
 You have no edge nor limit but Your laws.
 Your unseenness becomes the way You go,
 Because there is no distance in Your show,
 But Your holy presence remains unseen
 While still arising on unholy scene.
 My heart unholy on Your heart I lean
 And by that divine touch I holy grow.

38 "Now this *is* what you shall offer
 On the altar: two lambs prefer
 Of the first year, day by day for
 Continual offering. 39 "One lamb for
 The morning offering and the other
 Lamb between evenings *as its brother*.
 40 "With the one lamb shall be a tithe
 Of flour mixed with one-fourth of hin
 Of pressed oil, and one-fourth of hin
 Of grape juice *as drink offering blythe*.
 41 "The other lamb you shall offer
 Between the evenings, and confer
 With it grain and drink offering as
 In the morning sweet savour has,
 An offering made by fire to YHWH,
 42 "Continuing burnt offering through
 Your generations *at* the door
 Of the tent of meeting with YHWH,
 Where I will meet to speak with you.
 43 "And there I will meet as before
 With the children of Israel, and
It shall be sanctified *and stand*
 By My glory. 44 "So I will make
 The tent and altar holy *stake*.
 I'll also consecrate as priests
 Both Aaron and his sons *with feasts*.
 45 "And I will dwell among the people
 Of Israel, be God *without steeple*.
 46 "And they shall know that I *am* YHWH
 Their God, who brought them up out
 through
 The land of Egypt, that I may
 Dwell with them, I, YHWH, God, *this day*.

Between the evenings when the sacrifice
 Is due to You, Beloved, in Paradise,
 I bring myself of flesh and grain and wine,
 A human sacrifice to the divine.
 On my heart burns the offering of love
 Continually between evenings above,
 Before the tent of meeting and its door
 Seeking to see Your glory in the store.
 Beloved One, You who dwell among the
 folk,
 Dwell also here with me the way You
 spoke
 On Sinai, and I shall know as did then
 That You are God alone of all earth's men.
 And in the silence of that ancient tent
 Go on living as generations went.

Exodus 30

1 "You shall make an altar to burn
 Incense upon, you shall *discern*
To make it of acacia wood.
 2 "A cubit its length truly should
 Be and a cubit its width, so
 It shall be square *as two ways go*,
 And two cubits *shall be* its height,
 Its horns of one piece with it *right*.
 3 "And you shall overlay its top,
 Its sides all around, *do not stop*,
 But its horns also with pure gold,
 And you shall make for it a mould
 Of gold upon it all around.
 4 "Two gold rings you shall make *and*
found,
 Under the moulding on both sides.
 You shall place *them* on its two sides,
 And they will be holders for poles
 With which to bear it. 5 "Make the poles
 Of acacia wood, overlay
 Them with gold. 6 "And you'll let it stay
 Before the veil that *is* before
 Ark of testimony, before
 The mercy seat that *is* upon
 The testimony, whereupon
 I will meet with you. 7 "Aaron shall
 Burn there sweet incense *clerical*
 Each morning, when he tends the lamps,
 He shall burn incense *for the camps*.
 8 "And when Aaron lights up the lamps
 Between two evenings, he shall burn
 Its incense always before YHWH
 Throughout your generations too.
 9 "You'll not there offer strange incense

Or burnt offering *in consequence*,
 Or a grain offering, nor shall you
 Pour a drink offering on it *too*.
 10 "And Aaron shall make atonement
 Upon its horns each year that went
 With the blood of the sin offering
 Of atonement that he shall bring
 Once in a year where he shall make
 Atonement upon it *in stake*
 Throughout your generations *too*.
 It is most holy unto YHWH."

The golden altar of my heart is laid
 With mould and horn of gold and not afraid
 With skeleton of tough acacia wood:
 My golden altar gleams fair as it should.
 I wait Your coming to the altar's care,
 Born through the noonday shuttle and the
 air
 Of busy street and heat: I wait Your feet.
 At evening at the altar, Loved, we meet.
 The sweet incense of prayer delights the
 room
 With cloud that veils Your presence from
 my doom.
 At morning on the sky the lamps are lit
 And fleck with burnishing my altar knit
 From heart to heaven. My Beloved, take
 place
 Before my golden altar and my face.

Week 21

11 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 12 "When you take the census instead
 Of the children of Israel for
 Their number, then each man in store
 Shall give a ransom for his soul
 To YHWH, when you have reached the
 goal,
 That there may be no plague among
 Them when *you* number them *by rung*.
 13 "This is what everyone among
 Those who are numbered shall give: half
 A shekel by the temple staff,
 (A shekel's twenty gerahs *weight*),
 Half-shekel, offering to YHWH's *state*.
 14 "Everyone included among
 Those who are numbered, *though unsung*,
 From twenty years old and above,
 Shall give an offering for YHWH's *love*.
 15 "The rich shall not give more, the poor
 Shall not give less than half a *pure*

Shekel, when *you* give an offering
 To YHWH, to make atonementing
 For your souls. 16 "And then you shall take
 Atonement money for the sake
 Of Israel's folk, and shall appoint
 It for the service of the joint,
 Tent of meeting, that it may be
 Memorial and atonely
 For the children of Israel
 Before YHWH for your souls *and well*.

The head tax is a thing that has been used
 Against the helpless and oppressed, abused,
 To force them from the squatter's shack and
 rights
 Out of the way of right of ways and fights.
 I wonder if You thought, Beloved, when
 You
 Gave this command in shekels to a few,
 That Sabbath-breakers would make laws to
 track
 Your faithful in the forests with a knack
 For living off the land without the gold
 Or silver for which poor are usually sold.
 Set me down in Your book as one of
 Yours,
 Although there are no shekels in my stores,
 And I will set Your name down on my
 tongue
 As I climb ecstasies by silver rung.

17 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 18 "You shall also make a bronze *spread*
 As laver, with its base also
 Of bronze, for washing *on the go*.
 You shall put it between the tent
 Of meeting and the altar *leant*.
 And you shall put water in it,
 19 "For Aaron and his sons *found fit*
 Shall wash their hands and their feet in
 Water from it *and cleansed from sin*.
 20 "When they go in the tent of meeting,
 Or when they come near altar *seating*
 To minister, to burn an offering
 Made by fire to YHWH *in their proffering*,
 They'll wash with water, and not die.
 21 "So they shall wash their hands and feet,
 Lest they die, and it shall be *meet*,
 A statute forever to them
 To him and his descendants *stem*
 Throughout their generations *fleet*."

Between the altar and the tent I stand
 With unwashed heart and foot and face and hand.
 As I dip in the brazen water pool,
 The sponge on hand and foot and face is cool,
 But heart burns on, untouched, unwashed, unrazed.
 I wash the hand and pray Your grace amazed
 May guide it from all sinful acts of choice.
 I wash the face and pray Your burnished voice
 May always turn my face to You instead
 Of light and sound set out to move the head.
 I wash the foot and pray Your guidance must
 Lead it in righteous paths though paved with dust.
 With burning heart uncooled, unspent, but rent
 I lean on You between altar and tent.

22 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 23 "Also take yourself fine spice bred,
 Five hundred *weight* of liquid myrrh,
 Half as much sweet-smelling *confer*
 Cinnamon (two hundred fifty),
 Two hundred fifty of sweetly
 Smelling cane, 24 "five hundred of cassia,
 According as the shekels face you
 In the temple, and one hin brew
 Of olive oil. 25 "And you shall make
 From these a holy oil for sake
 Of anointing, an ointment made
 By the perfumer's art and aid,
 To be holy anointing oil.
 26 "With it you shall anoint *with toil*
 The tent of meeting and the ark
 Of the testimony, 27 "*remark*,
 The table and all its utensils,
 The lampstand and all its utensils,
 The altar of incense, 28 "also
 The altar of burnt offering's *glow*
 With all its utensils, and yet
 The laver and the place it's set.
 29 "You shall consecrate them, that they
 May be most holy, in the day
 Something touches them it shall be
 Also holy *with certainty*.

A thing is made holy it seems by touch.
 Beloved, look also on me for as much.
 A thing is made unholy no doubt by
 A touch as well: Belovèd, testify.
 The Zoroaster's worry to be clean
 Arises in the mullah's cry and spleen
 To make the law a round of washings and
 A rinsing of the foot and spit on hand.
 Beloved, I turn from human law to You
 And beg Your touch divine on what I do
 And what I am, and what I seem to be.
 You who have neither form nor symmetry,
 Touch yet the blindness of my eye to see,
 And touch my heart to bind it close to You.

30 "And you shall anoint Aaron and
 His sons, and consecrate their hand,
 That *they* may minister to Me
 As priests. 31 "And you shall speak *freely*
 To Israel's folk, saying 'Let be
 This oil a holy anointing
 Oil to Me *and a holy thing*
 Throughout your generations. 32 'It
 Shall not be poured on man's flesh *fit*,
 Nor shall you make *others* like it,
 According to its composition.
 It is holy, *an aquisition*
 Holy to you. 33 'Whoever makes
 Compounds like it, whoever takes
 It to put on outsiders, shall
 Be cut off from his people's sal."
 34 And YHWH said to Moses, "Take sweet
 Spices, stacte and onycha *neat*
 And galbanum, pure frankincense
 With *these* sweet spices, and condense
 Equal amounts of each. 35 "You shall
 Make of these incense *capital*,
 A compound by perfumer's art
 Salted, pure, holy, *set apart*.

Of all the things the universe contains
 Choose spices, leave the bitterness and
 pains.
 You know I cannot live on sweet perfume
 And yet are silent about bread and room.
 Four spices make the temple and its gates,
 Within, the secret treasure lies and waits.
 Faith's altogether useless, like incense,
 A passing breath of unseen providence.
 The insubstantial One upon His throne
 Is hidden from my sight by iron and stone.
 Eternal sweetness is Your near abode,

Yet none can enter in with mortal load.
The holy temple and its reigning King
Come in one breath, in one abandoning.

36 "And *some* of it beat very fine
And put some of it *in design*
Before the testimony in
The tent of meeting *without sin*
Where I will meet with you. Let it
Be most holy to you *and fit*.
37 "But *as for* the incense which you
Shall make, indeed you shall eschew
To make any for yourselves like
Its composition, it shall strike
You as holy for YHWH. 38 "Who makes
The like, to smell it, that one takes
The risk of being once cut off
From his people *and for his scoff*."

Exodus 31

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
2 "See, I have called by name *and bred*
One Bezalel the son of Uri,
The son of Hur, *and in a hurry*,
Of the tribe of Judah. 3 "And I
Have filled him with a skilful spirit
In wisdom, understanding *near it*,
In knowledge in each *kind of* task,
4 "To design fine works, such as ask
Skill in gold, in silver, in bronze,
5 "In cutting jewels for setting *fronds*,
In carving wood, each kind of task.
6 "And I, indeed I, have appointed
With him Aholiab *anointed*
The son of Ahisamach, of
The tribe of Dan, and *as above*
I have put wisdom in the hearts
Of all gifted in the fine arts,
That they may make all I command
You, 7 "tent of meeting, *on one hand*,
Ark of covenant, mercy seat,
That *is* on it, vessels complete
Of the tent, 8 "table and its store,
The pure *gold* lampstand *on the floor*
With all its utensils *and more*,
The altar of incense and *yet*,
9 "The altar of burnt offering *met*
With all its holdings, laver and
The confectioned place of its stand,
10 "The garments of the ministry,
The holy garments for to see
On Aaron the priest and the ones

Of garments for *the priestly* sons,
To minister *therein* as priest,
11 "And the anointing oil, increased
Incense for the holy *place*, just
As I've commanded, so you must."

The origin of art spelled out as plain
As anything, Beloved, for woe and gain,
Is in Your spirit gifts bestowed upon
The wilderness artist and paragon.
Gloria Dei only writes the scribe
Of melody in memory of the tribe
That once invented art and beauty for
To glorify of Your name and to adore.
I hear the faint reverberations of
Those harmonies set down in faith and
love,

I see the brush-strokes of the cadmium lore,
And know Your spirit still rests as before
On all descendants of the chosen man
Who decorates the universe or can.

12 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
13 "Speak also to Israel's folk *bred*,
Saying 'My Sabbaths you shall keep,
For it's a sign *gracious and steep*
Between Me and you throughout your
Generations, to keep in store
The knowledge that I'm *truly* YHWH
Who *on Sabbath* sanctifies you.
14 'You shall keep the Sabbath, therefore,
It's holy to you *as I swore*.
Everyone who profanes it shall
Surely suffer death *capital*,
For whoever does *any* work
On it, that person shall *not lurk*
But be cut off among his folk.
15 'Work shall be done for six days' stroke,
But the seventh *is* Sabbath rest,
Holy to YHWH, *of days the best*.
Whoever does work on the day
Of Sabbath, he'll be put to death.
16 'Therefore the folk of Israel's way
Shall keep the Sabbath *with their breath*,
To observe Sabbath throughout their
Generations *as they concur*
Upon perpetual covenant.
17 'It is a sign *that I have sent*
Between Me and Israel for
Always, since in just six days' *chore*
YHWH made the heavens and the earth,
And on the seventh day *of worth*

He rested and He was refreshed,
Example to man work enmeshed."

Beloved, Your holy Sabbath's secret place
Where You meet with the chosen of the
race.

It seems the grace to love and seek Your
face
Is given to but few, the rest deface
The soul with harsh forgetfulness, replace
The love tryst with the heathen Sunday
chase

Gyrating to the rock of the debase
Or elevated to the awe's embrace.
My soul elated with Your call and trace
Seeks out umbrage of Your day to erase
The metal of the week that goes apace
Draped in its royal velvets and its lace.
Beloved, I meet the ecstasies and pains
From week to week in Sabbath suns and
rains.

The sentence fell in harshness on
The sons of Israel long ago.
Now all receive his benison,
So all must share his woe.
We stand today before the Lord
As then before the Mount
Within our mothers' loins God's word
Brought us to an account.
As we forget the Sabbath day
And struggle on for ill,
Depending each on his own way,
The prophecies fulfil.
The spirit that returns each week
Partakes of life and song,
But they who turn away the cheek
Do their own souls the wrong.
The spirit dies that does not crave
God's blessing and His rest.
The anguish and the yawning grave
Receive each week their guest.
O God, help me to flee that tomb
Of living death and fires,
And for that rest let me make room
That quenches vain desires.
As Thou didst whisper Adam's name
In thy creation's joy,
Remember me too just the same
In this Sabbath's employ.
And I too shall remember Thee,
Though troubled, toil-enmeshed,

Escape the hour that threatens me,
To rest and be refreshed.

18 And when He had finished His speaking
With him on Mount Sinai's *critiquing*,
He gave Moses two tablets of
The Testimony, tablets of
Stone, written with the finger of
Alohim in *His grace and love*.

Exodus 32

1 When the folk saw Moses delayed
To come down from the mount, *but stayed*,
The people came to Aaron , and
Said to him, "Come, make *by command*
Gods for us that shall go before
Us, for this Moses, *we deplore*
The man who brought us up out of
The land of Egypt, *for both love*
Nor money we do not know what
Has become of him, *and clear-cut.*"
2 And Aaron said to them, "Break off
The golden earrings which *are shroff*
In the ears of your wives, your sons,
And your daughters, bring me *by tons.*"
3 "So all the folk broke off the gold
Earrings which *were* in their ears *told*,
And brought *them* to Aaron. 4 And he
Received from their hand, and *in fee*
He fashioned with engraving tool,
And made a moulded calf, *the fool*.
Then they said "This *is* your god, O
Israel, that has made you go
Up out of Egypt's land!" 5 And so
When Aaron saw, he built an altar
Before it, and Aaron, no falter,
Made proclamation and he said
"Tomorrow's a feast in YHWH's *stead.*"
6 Then they rose early the next day,
Offered burnt offerings *in their way*,
And brought peace offerings, and the folk
Sat down to eat and drink *and joke*,
And then rose up *again* to play.

Idolatry has always the same root
And therefore always bears a common
fruit.

It always claims to offer prayer and praise
In sacrifice to You, Beloved, in stays.
It has a form of godliness indeed,
But leaves the people poorer for their
greed.

Idolatry is always dealt in gold,
 It always has attractive forms and bold,
 It always has to end it in the lounge
 Coffee and doughnuts, never has to
 scrounge,
 And last and best it is a lot of fun
 And full of music good and loud when
 done.
 The golden calf is worshipped everywhere
 A crowd comes out when the weather is
 fair.

7 And YHWH said to Moses, "Go, get
 Down! For the folk *for whom you sweat*,
 Whom you brought out of Egypt's land
 Have somehow gotten out of hand.
 8 "They have turned aside quickly out
 Of the way I told them about.
 They've made themselves a moulded calf,
 Bowed, sacrificed in its behalf,
 And said *and sung*, 'This is your god,
 O Israel, that brought from the sod
 Of Egypt!'" 9 And YHWH said to Moses,
 "I've seen what this people discloses,
 And indeed it's a stiff-necked folk!
 10 "Now therefore, let Me lay the stroke,
 That My wrath may burn hot against
 Them and consume them *once commenced*.
 And I will make of you a great
 Nation." 11 Moses pleaded a rate
 With YHWH his God, and said "YHWH,
 why
 Does Your wrath burn hot against *my*
 And Your people whom You have brought
 Out of the land of Egypt *sought*
 With great power and a mighty hand?
 12 "Why should Egyptians understand,
 'He brought them out to harm them and
 To kill them in the mountains, and
 To consume them from the earth's face'?
 Turn from Your fierce wrath, and retrace
 Your steps from this harm to Your folk.
 13 "Remember Abraham, *his oak*,
 Isaac, and Israel, Your servants,
 To whom You swore by Your own grants,
 And said to them, 'I'll multiply
 Your descendants as in the sky
 The stars stand, and all of this land
 That I have spoken of remand
 To your descendants, and they shall
 Have inheritance eternal.'" 14 So YHWH relented from the harm

He said He'd do His folk *by arm*.

You hate, Beloved, the din of heathen song
 So much that even Moses begs You long
 Not to destroy them pintle, paunch, and
 neck.

When rock comes on, You'd rather have a
 wreck.

Between You and Moses, if I must choose
 Sides, O Beloved, I have no time to lose,
 But join You in Your clamour to be rid
 Of worship music that You would forbid.
 Ah Moses, ever gracious, merciful,
 Caused troubles in the earth which is now
 full

Of raucous beats and melodies galore.
 He should have let You nip the bud before.
 But once the lesson has been taught, I'm
 free

To abhor the sounds of the Trinity.

15 And Moses turned and went down from
 The mountain *to where he had come*,
 And the two tablets of the law
 Were in his hand, the *algebra*
Of tablets written on both sides,
 On the one and on other sides
 They were written. 16 Now the tablets
Are the work that Alohim sets,
 And the writing the writing that
 Alohim on the tablets set.

17 And when Joshua heard the noise
 Of the people shouting *like boys*,
 He said to Moses, "Noise of war
Is in the camp," 18 "No, troubadour"
 He said "not the noise of the shout
 Of victory, nor cry of rout,
 The sound of singing's what I hear."

The kind of singing that the people used
 In their fond worship of the dread abused
 Was rather modern in kind and in savour.
 It had a very jazzy, rocky flavour,
 So much so that one took the sound for
 war.

You can hear such in every record store.
 At distance, though, such music sounds to
 me

More like the strains running high and
 freely
 Of washing machine in the basement set
 To do the laundry in a due time yet.

Beloved, speak in a still small voice or
thunder,
But do not leave my stricken soul to
wonder
About the rate of the idolatry
That comes from Christian rock and other
blunder.

19 So it was, soon as he came near
The camp, he saw the dancing calf.
So Moses' anger *for riff-raff*
Burned hot, he cast the tablets out
Of his hands and broke them *about*
At the foot of the mountain *there*.
20 Then he took their calf *in repair*,
Which they had made, and burned *it* in
The fire, and ground *to genuine*
Powder, and scattered *it abroad*
On the water and *where he strawed*
He made Israel's folk drink *the fraud*.

The wrath of Your servant Moses appeared
At last when he saw and heard what he
feared
From Your warning of what took place
below.
No doubt he would have tempered all the
show
Of patience and his intercession for
The people in idolatry and roar.
If You had not opened occasion to
Pray for the folk, I'm sure he would not do
It when he saw the thing, and heard the ring
Of tambourine, and saw them dance and
sing.
He threw the table of the law down crash
And saw the sapphire stones in splintered
trash.
Beloved, I cast the tables down again
Before the golden calves of modern men.

21 And Moses said to Aaron, "What
Did this people do to you that
You've brought *so* great a sin on them?"
22 So Aaron said "*I touch your hem*,
Do not let my lord's anger burn,
You know the people, set to *spurn*
The good and take the evil row.
23 "For they said to me, 'Make us gods
That shall go before us, *as prods*,
This Moses, the man who brought us
Out of Egypt's land *with a fuss*,

We do not know where this man went.'
24 "I said to them, 'Who has unspent
Gold, let them break *it off*.' So they
Gave *it* to me, I cast away
Into the fire, this calf came out."
25 Now when Moses saw without doubt
That the people there danced about
And unrestrained (for Aaron had
Not restrained them who acted bad,
For shame among their enemies),
26 Then Moses stood *for homilies*
At the entrance of the camp, said
"And who's on YHWH's side, *born and*
bred,
To me." And all of Levi's sons
Gathered to *Moses' benisons*.
27 And he said to them, "Thus says YHWH
God of Israel, 'Let each man do
His duty his sword on his side,
And go through the camp *and not hide*,
From one side to the other and
Let every man raise slaying hand
Upon his brother and his friend,
And on his neighbour to the end.'"
28 And so the sons of Levi did
According as Moses' words bid.
And about three thousand men of
The people fell in that day's *shove*.
29 Then Moses said "Now consecrate
Yourselves to YHWH, and that He state
On you a blessing on this day,
For every man has gone his way
Against his son, brother *and mate*."

Theory of spontaneous generation
Is not invention of Darwin, Lamarck.
It is a flight of fancy every nation
Has taken since we left the heavenly park.
For those who believe gods arise and stand
To be worshipped and played to in the land
There is a strange and livid countermand:
Death by the sword of right and human
hand.
Since raving dance and jazzing haunch
deny
The Decalogue, that safety passes by.
Thou shalt not kill is for those who will
keep
Your word, Beloved, but not for those who
sleep.
By Your command alone may killing be.
Without command to kill, I remain free.

30 Now it happened on the next day
 That Moses told the people, "Say,
 You have committed a great sin.
 Now I'll go up to YHWH *within*,
 Perchance make atonement for sin."
 31 Then Moses returned to YHWH and
 Said "Oh, these people *in the land*
 Have committed a great sin, and
 Have made themselves a god of gold!
 32 "Yet now, if You'll forgive the told
 Sin, but if not, I pray, blot me
 Out of Your book writ *faithfully*."
 33 And YHWH said to Moses, "Who has
 Sinned against Me, I'll blot him as
 A sinner out of My book. 34 "Now
 Therefore, go, be the people's prow
 To *the place* of which I have spoken
 To you. My Angel as a token
 Shall go before you, but the day
 When I lay punishment's *dismay*,
 I'll visit punishment on them
 For their sin *and their stratagem*."
 35 So YHWH plagued the people because
 Of what they did *against His laws*
 With the calf which Aaron had made
While Moses in the mountain stayed.

The human heart is moved to anger or
 To mercy, but both are the graceless store
 Of winds of foul desire to cling to show
 Of illusions beyond the power to let go.
 Who prays for pardon to the world prays
 ill,

Who prays for punishment too prays ill
 still.

Who pray for that mercy that must arise
 From unbroken tables of law, surprise
 You, my Belovèd, to step down again
 And speak in love to sleeping hearts and
 men.

Let me not act in anger or in suit
 Of sympathy for hardened human brute,
 But let me act unswerving by the love
 Of Decalogue alone, sight high above.

Exodus 33

1 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Depart
And go up from here, for a start,
 You and the people whom you've brought
 Out of Egypt's land *to be taught*,
 To the land of which I swore to

Abraham, Isaac, Jacob too,
 Saying 'To your descendants I
 Will give it.' 2 "And I will send *My*
 Angel before you, and I'll drive
 Out Canaanites, *each one alive*,
 And Amorite and the Hittite,
 The Perizzite and the Hivite,
 And Jebusite. 3 "Go to a land
 Flowing with milk and honey *scanned*,
 For I will not go up with you,
 Lest I consume you *to be true*
 On the way, you're a stiff-necked folk."
 4 When the people heard what He spoke,
 They mourned, and none put on his jewels.
 5 For YHWH'd told Moses, "Tell *the fools*,
 Children of Israel, 'You're stiff-necked.
 I could come up *where you have trecked*
 In one moment, destroy your tents.
 Therefore, take off your ornaments,
 So I'll know what to do to you."
 6 So Israel's folk stripped off their *few*
 Ornaments *there* by Horeb's *dew*.

The people made the calf of gold, god's
 blood,
 Because they sensed that metal was a flood
 Of blessing and protection, changeless well
 Of wealth of well-being, to cast a spell
 To shield them from all harm. The ring
 today
 That keeps its wearer from hazards bears
 sway
 Among the people of the east who still
 Like Israel claim to follow Your known
 will.
 That's why You tell them to strip off
 pretence
 Of ornaments' protection, have good sense,
 And stand before You with no guiles
 between.
 Stripping off idols is thing rarely seen.
 Naked I come onto the slaughter floor,
 And yet I seek a window and a door.

7 Moses took his tent and pitched it
 Outside camp, far from their outfit,
 And called it tent of meeting. It
 Happened *that* everyone who sought
 YHWH went outside the camp to sit
 At tent of meeting to be taught.
 8 So it was, when Moses went out
 To the tent, all the people rose,

And each man stood *and looked devout*
At his tent door and watched until
Moses went in the tent's enclose.

9 And it happened, to Moses' *thrill*
When he went in the tent the cloud
In pillar came down *like a shroud*
Before the door of the tent and
He talked with Moses there first-hand.
10 And all the people saw the cloud
In pillar at the tent door *proud*
And all the people rose again
Prostrating at tent door *like men*.

11 YHWH spoke to Moses face to face,
As a man speaks to his friend's *grace*.
And he would return to the camp,
But Joshua, servant *and champ*,
The son of Nun, a young man, did
Not depart from the tent, *but hid*.

The many stand afar and bow down to
The ground in worship, but the thirsty few
Come out to the tent of Your presence for
Instruction from the prophet at the door.
The lawful and the loving thus presume
To find a nearness that does not consume.
The prophet enters in the tent aware
Of all Your glories as they abide there.
But let me, O Beloved, like son of Nun
Come in the glorious fourth gate when I've
won,

And hide within Your heart. I shall not go
Back to the camp and make prostration so.
Let me be so near there is no direction
Toward which I may raise my insurrection.

12 Then Moses said to YHWH, "See, You
Tell me, 'Bring up this folk.' But You
Have not let me know whom You will
Send with me, You speak to me still,
'I know you by name, and you've found
Also grace in My sight *around*.'

13 "Now therefore, I pray, if I've found
Grace in Your sight, show me Your way,
Now that I may know You *today*
And I may find grace in Your sight.
And see that this nation's Your right."

14 And He said "My Presence will go
And I will give you rest *also*."

15 He said to Him, "If Your Presence
Does not go *with us*, there's no sense
To bring us up from here. 16 "For how
Then will it *ever* be known *now*

That Your people and I've found grace
In Your sight, except *to that place*
You go with us? So we shall be
Separate, Your people and me,
From all the people on the earth."

17 So YHWH said to Moses *in worth*,
"I will also do this thing that
You have spoken *from where you're at*,
For you have found grace in My sight,
And I know you by name *and sight*."
18 And he said "Please, show me Your
glory."

19 He said "My goodness pass before you,
And I'll proclaim the name of YHWH
Before you, I'll be gracious to
Whom I will be gracious, and I
Will have compassion on whom I
Will have compassion." 20 But He said
"You cannot see My face, *you're dead*,
For no man shall see Me, and live."

21 And YHWH said "Here's a place *I give*
By Me, and you'll stand on the rock.

22 "So it shall be, while *with a shock*
My glory passes by, that I
Will put you in the cleft of rock,
Cover you with hand and pass by.

23 "Then I will take away My hand,
And you shall see My backside *spanned*,
My face shall not be seen *by eye*."

Beloved, show me not backside, no, nor
face.

I bow before You, sink my will, efface
My vain desires and so desire You only.
Show me no part of You but leave me
lonely.

I know You have no parts nor limits that
I might perceive with sentiments and fat.
So show no part and I shall escape vain
Imaginings. Leave my dark memory sane.
Though You are absolutely one, I know
There is no youthness to be seen or go
Towards. Leave me alone and yet not be
Far in the distance nor yet near to me.
Be, my Beloved, so close to heart and mind
That to Your being my eyes must be blind.

Exodus 34

1 And YHWH said to Moses, "Cut two
Tablets of stone like the first, do,
And I'll write on tablets the words
That were on the first tablets' *sherd*s

Which you broke. 2 "So be ready in
 The morning, and come take a spin
 In the morning to Mount Sinai,
 Present yourself there *high and dry*
 Before Me on the mountaintop.
 3 "And no man shall come up with you,
 And let no man be seen all through
 The mountain, let no flocks nor herds
 Feed on that mountain *of storm-birds.*"
 4 So he cut two tablets of stone
 Like the first *ones*, then he *alone*,
 Moses rose early in the morn
 And went up Mount Sinai *trueborn*,
 As YHWH commanded him, and he
 Took in hand two tablets stonely.

Each day anew You call Your servant to
 Cut new tablets of stone from his heart's
 due
 For You to write again the broken law
 The world refuses to accept in awe.
 I hold my shredded heart up to Your pen
 Awaiting the new scribblings there again.
 All men are one, and that's eternal pain,
 Since what all men do falls again like rain
 Upon the head of all. Though I prostrate
 My soul in humble straightness at the gate,
 Obedience is met upon the scroll
 With idol worship taking on its toll.
 Let my obedience this day once more
 Repair the splintered stone the idols tore.

5 Now YHWH descended in the cloud
 And stood with him there, proclaimed
proud
 The name of YHWH. 6 And YHWH
 passed by
 Before him and proclaimed, "YHWH, aye
 YHWH El El God, merciful and
 Gracious, and longsuffering, and
 Abundant in goodness and truth,
 7 "Keeping mercy for thousands' *ruth*,
 Forgiving iniquity and
 Transgression and sin *in the land*,
 By no means clearing *the guilty*,
 But visiting iniquity
 Of the fathers no further than
 Upon the children *of each man*
 And children's children to the third
 And fourth generation *deterred.*"
 8 Moses made haste and bowed his head
 Toward the earth, prostrate *like dead*.

9 Then he said "If now I have found
 Grace in Your sight, O Lord, abound,
 Let my Lord, I pray, go among us,
 Though *we're* stiff-necked, *You should*
have hung us,
 And pardon our iniquity
 And *from* our sin *do set us free*,
 And take us as Your property."

Belovèd, let my life be straight and true
 According to Your law leave me to do
 So that my doing is a prayer to keep
 Your mercy on the dreaming world asleep.
 I do not pray for mercy on the guilt,
 But that the guilt in mercy might be spilt
 And washed away in floods of
 righteousness.
 That is the prayer of my life and no less,
 Not written in calligraphy nor spoken,
 But written in commandments left
 unbroken.
 Gracious You are, and merciful, I see,
 And that You are from time eternally.
 I too therefore make haste to bow before
 Your Word and Throne, and sacred open
 door.

10 And He said "Indeed, *now* I make
 A covenant *and for your sake*.
 Before all your people I'll do
 Marvels such as have not been true
 In all the earth, in any nation,
 And all the earthly generation
 Among whom you *are* shall see how
 That YHWH has not worked until now.
 For it's a truly awesome thing
 That I'll do with you *as your King*.
 11 "Observe what I command this day.
 I am driving out of your way
 The Amorite and Canaanite,
 The Hittite and the Perizzite,
 The Hivite and the Jebusite.
 12 "Take heed to yourself, lest you make
 A treaty for the dwellers' sake
 Of the land toward which you take
 Your way, lest it become your snare.
 13 "But you shall destroy all of their
 Altars, break up their pillars, and
 Cut down images *in the land*.
 14 'For you'll worship no other god,
 Since YHWH, whose name's Jealous, *will*
prod

*Being a jealous God, 15 "lest you
 Make a covenant with a few
 Of the land's inhabitants, and
 They play the harlot with their gods
 And make sacrifice to their gods,
 One invite you and you eat of
 His sacrifice, 16 "and you take of
 His daughters for your sons, and his
 Daughters play the harlot, that is,
 With their gods and make your sons play
 The harlot with their gods one day.
 17 "You shall make no moulded gods for
 Yourselves nor none within your door.*

There is no horror in the sacrifice
 Of idols in this modern world and nice.
 It is a churchly club of the refined
 Who get together for a lunch and kind
 Reception of the same financial class,
 To break the bread and taste the glittering
 glass,
 To lift up hands and sway the hip awhile,
 Greet with a hug, good morning, and a
 smile,
 Read the epistle and the psalm to boot,
 And hardly notice the revealing suit
 Until a private get-together after
 Replaces solemnity with a lustful laughter.
 The harlotry of faith's an ancient thing
 Symbolic in the way the people sing.

18 "The feast of unleavened bread you
 Shall keep, seven days you shall do
 Eating unleavened bread, as I
 Commanded you, in the time I
 Appointed in month of green ears,
 For you came in month of green ears
 Out from Egypt. 19 "And so all that
 Open the womb *are* Mine *out flat*,
 And every male firstborn among
 Your livestock, ox or sheep *unsung*.
 20 "But the firstborn of a donkey
 You shall redeem with a lamb's *fee*.
 And if you will not redeem *it*,
 Then you shall break *its* neck *unfit*.
 And all the firstborn of your sons
 You shall redeem *with orisons*.
 And none shall appear before Me
 Empty-handed *and then go free*.
 21 "Six days you shall work, but upon
 The seventh day you shall rest on,
 In plowing time and in harvest

You shall *take that day for a rest*.
 22 "And you shall observe feast of weeks,
 Of the firstfruits of corn harvest,
 And the feast of ingathering seeks
 To come at the year's end. 23 "Three times
 In the year all your men in primes
 Shall appear before the Lord, YHWH,
 The Alohim of Israel.
 24 "For I will cast out nations well
 Before you and enlarge your borders,
 Neither will any men *nor hoarders*
 Covet your land when you go up
 To appear before YHWH *to sup*
 With your God three times in the year.
 25 "You shall not offer, *though sincere*,
 The blood of sacrifice with leaven,
 Nor shall sacrifice *under heaven*
 Of the feast of passover be
 Left over until morning, *see*.
 26 "The first of firstfruits of your land
 You shall bring to the house *as planned*
 Of YHWH your God. You shall not boil
 A young goat in its mother's milk."
 27 Then YHWH said to Moses, "*No spoil*,
 Write these words, for by these words' ilk
 I've made a covenant with you
 And with Israel's *people too*."

Why should I not boil baby goat along
 With its own mother's milk for wrong?
 Beloved, I guess the reason why You say
 Not to do that thing is in mercy's way,
 An odious trick revealing that the owner
 Sees animals with eyes of a condoner
 Of cruelty. To make a rule beyond
 That not to mix milk and meat's to respond
 To Canaanite ways and their superstition.
 To me that is idolatrous position.
 Let me, Beloved, take You at Your word
 true,
 And do exactly what You tell me too,
 Not going beyond nor in innovation
 Replacing Your commands with my
 gyration.

28 So he was there with YHWH forty
 Days and forty nights, no bread he
 Ate nor did he drink water. And
 He wrote on the tablets the words
 Of the covenant, each command
In view of humans, beasts and birds.
 29 Now it was so, when Moses came

Down from Mount Sinai with the same
Two tablets of testimony
In Moses' hand when *faithfully*
He came down from the mountain, that
Moses did not know that the skin
Of his face shone while he was at
The council with Him *as akin*.

30 So when Aaron and all the folk
Of Israel saw Moses, the bloke
Had skin on his face shining so
They were afraid to come or go.
31 Then Moses called them, Aaron and
All the folk's rulers *by command*
Returned to him, and Moses talked
With them *and so none of them balked*.
32 Then all the folk of Israel came
Near, and he gave them of the same
Commandments all that YHWH had
spoken

With him on Mount Sinai *with token*.
33 And when Moses finished speaking
With them, he put a veiling thing
On his face. 34 But whenever Moses
Went in before *where* YHWH *incloses*
To speak with Him, he would take off
The veil until he left the trough,
And he would come out and speak to
Israel's folk what God said to do.
35 And whenever Israel's folk saw
The face of Moses, and *with awe*
That the skin of Moses' face shone,
Then Moses would put veil *high-flown*
On his face once again, until
He went back to His domicile.

The veil, the veil, Beloved, men always
think
Lies between the soul and the precious
drink
Of paradise, but it's not so, not so!
The veil is not between the human soul
And You, Beloved, of all lovings the goal.
The veil is placed between the company
Of congregants and every holy see,
And the lone soul that lives in You alone
And drinks Your nectar though in flesh and
bone.
Not between Moses and Your face it lies,
But between Moses and the others' guise.
The masks are made for the magician's
show.
I set me here within the veil to be

One with You and for all eternity.

Week 22 Exodus 35

1 Then Moses gathered all the folk
Of Israel together and spoke
To them, "These *are* the words which
YHWH

Has commanded *for you* to do:
2 "Work shall be done for the six days,
But the seventh day *in your ways*
Shall be a holy day for you,
A Sabbath *day* of rest to YHWH.
Whoever does any work on
It shall be put to death *undrawn*.
3 "On Sabbath you shall light no fire
Throughout your dwellings *in a pyre*."

Death sentence, My Beloved, for failing to
Take breaks for rest from all the work I do?
No doubt, no doubt, the sentencing is true
And cannot be avoided. Soul of death
Is all that results from one's holding breath.
There is the natural moment to exhale,
And that comes long before the face turns
pale.

The soul dies and the husk remains to be
Driven by all the winds that blow freely.
Ah, freedom of the tumbling husks that vie
And jostle for position on the try!
Let my rest come between the earth and
sky,
Not when I will, but when You say the
word
Illuminating living heart and stirred.

O God of Jacob, guide my days
With flickering flames of light.
Enlighten all my wavering ways
And teach me paths of right.
Oh let me kindle not mine own
Indulgent flames of lust,
Nor lights of wisdom that alone
Search where should only trust.
Let not appear fanatic fires
In me in place of Thine,
Nor let me follow what inspires
Conforming crowds' design.
Let not the eager music pound
My heart in sensual thrill,
That in the groves today is found
And in the high-place still.
Inflame me with another faith

On this new Sabbath eve,
 Not made to image, gold or wraith.
 To Jacob's God I cleave.
 I offer no strange fire upon
 The altar of my heart.
 Breathe but the Sabbath flame of dawn
 To show me where Thou art.

4 And Moses spoke to all the folk
 Of Israel, saying to convoke,
 "This *is* the thing which YHWH
 commanded,
 Saying 5 'Take from among you *handed*
 An offering to YHWH. Whoever
Is of a willing heart, *or clever*,
 Let him bring it as offering to
 YHWH: gold, silver, and bronze, 6 'and
 blue,
 Purple, and scarlet, linen fine,
 And goats' *hair*, 7 'ram skins *in design*
 Dyed red, badger skins, and the wood,
 8 'Of the acacia, oil for light,
 And spices for anointing *good*
 Oil and for the sweet incense *quite*,
 9 'Onyx stones, and stones to be set
 In ephod and breastplate *facette*.
 10 'All *who are* gifted artisans
 Among you shall come and make *plans*
 For all that YHWH has commanded:
 11 'The tabernacle, tent, its lid,
 Its clasps, its boards, its bars, its pillars,
 Its sockets, 12 'the ark and its *drillers'*
 Poles, *with* the mercy seat, and veil
 Of covering, 13 'the table grail
 And its poles, all its utensils,
 And the showbread, 14 'and *for no ills*
 Also the lampstand for the light,
 Its utensils, its lamps, and oil
 For the light, *that it might not spoil*,
 15 'The incense altar, its poles, and
 Anointing oil, the sweet *command*
Of incense, and screen for the door
 At the tent entrance and before,
 16 'The altar of burnt offering and
 Its bronze grating, its poles, *at hand*
 All its utensils, laver and
 Its base, 17 'the hangings of the court,
 Its pillars, their sockets, *the sort*
Of screen for the gate of the court,
 18 'The tent pegs, the pegs of the court,
 And their cords, 19 'the garments to serve,
 For ministering *and not to swerve*

In the holy *place*, the holy
 Garments for Aaron the priest, *see*,
 And the garments of his sons, to
 Minister as priests *as they do*."

Give me the wisdom of Your heart to build
 The palace of my soul one Spirit-filled.
 Let me construct the gifts of willing heart,
 The preciousness of gold, empurpled art.
 From priceless treasures let me build my
 room,
 From twenty kinds of gem and sweet
 perfume,
 Let rise my tabernacle with its bars
 And forty steps of love toward the stars.
 Beyond the altar, laver, curtain there,
 Let my soul bathe in heaven's light and air,
 Unkindled but by divine touch this day,
 Let Sabbath bread and prayer console my
 way.
 Within my inmost heart and secretly
 Reign You alone, unseen Your majesty.

20 And all the congregation of
 The children of Israel *with love*
 Departed from Moses' presence.
 21 Then everyone came whose heart's
sense
 Was stirred, and everyone whose spirit
 Was willing, *and* they brought gifts near it
 To YHWH for the tent of meeting,
 For all its service, completing
 The holy garments. 22 They came, both
 Men and women, who *were not loath*
But had a willing heart, *and* brought
 Earrings and nose rings, *finger* rings
 And necklaces, all jewels *sought*
 Of gold, that is, each man's offerings
 Of gold to YHWH. 23 And every man,
 With whom was found blue, purple, and
 Scarlet, fine linen, and goats' *hair*,
 Red skins of rams, and badger's fair
 Skins, brought *them*. 24 Everyone who
 offered
 An offering of silver *or proffered*
 Bronze brought YHWH's offering. And all
 With whom was found acacia wood
 For any work of service call,
 Brought *it in offering as they could*.
 25 All women gifted artisans
Finely spun yarn with their *own* hands,
 And brought what they had spun, of blue,

Purple, scarlet, fine linen *too*.
 26 And all the women whose heart stirred
 With wisdom spun yarn of goats *shirred*.
 27 The rulers brought onyx stones, and
 The stones to be set *by command*
 In the ephod and in breastplate,
 28 And spices and oil for the *great*
 Light, for the anointing oil, and
 For the sweet incense *at close hand*.
 29 The children of Israel brought
 A freewill offering to YHWH *sought*,
 All the men and women whose hearts
 Were willing to bring *in their parts*
 For all kinds of work of which YHWH,
 By Moses commanded to do.

Gold is the offering that the lovely bring
 Out to the stores of every precious thing.
 Lovely indeed are those who have a share
 Doing Your will, Beloved, with heartfelt
 care.

Beloved, You ask for many things of
 weight,
 Linen and blue, scarlet and purple state,
 Until the lines are drawn and it's enough,
 Enough of brights and sweets, the smooth
 and rough.

Polished to bear the rays of every sun
 Under the sapphire sky, the hard stones run
 Riot in colour in the nobles' gifts.
 Perhaps there is an offering still that lifts
 Love and the heart, but such I do not know:
 Enough, a gift in empty hand I show.

30 And Moses said to Israel's folk,
 "See, YHWH has called by name *and*
spoke

To Bezalel the son of Uri,
 The son of Hur, *not in a hurry*,
 Of the tribe of Judah, 31 "and He
 Has filled him, made in him to be
 A skilful spirit, in wisdom
 And understanding, knowledge sum,
 And all manner of workmanship,
 32 "To design fine works *without slip*,
 To work in gold, silver and bronze,
 33 "In cutting jewels for setting *fronds*,
 In carving wood, to work in all
 Kinds of fine workmanship *by call*.
 34 "And He's put in his heart to teach,
In him and Aholiab's reach,
 The son of Ahisamach, of

The tribe of Dan. 35 "He's filled *with love*
And skill to do all kinds of work
 Of the engraver *without shirk*
 And the designer and the maker
 Of tapestries, in blue *by acre*,
 Purple, and scarlet *thread*, and fine
 Linen, and of weaver *design*,
 Those who do every work and those
 Who design fine works *as God chose*.

Beloved, You call by name, I answer quick,
 But do not give me wisdom to be slick.
 I've had enough of envy from the crowd.
 Fill me with wisdom to avoid the crowd.
 I need no wisdom for the building of
 A house to You whereby express my love.
 The world is filled with monuments and
 fine

To Your glory and glory's undersign.
 Let me admire the tapestries and stone,
 And turn from them to worship You alone.
 I praise the skill You give to artist and
 The knowing way the beggar holds his
 hand.

I neither give scribed art, Beloved, nor
 take.

I merely am in sort and for Your sake.

Exodus 36

1 "Bezalel and Aholiab,
 And every gifted *and not drab*
 Artisan in whom YHWH has put
 Wisdom and understanding's *foot*,
 To know how to do all kinds of
 Work for the service *and the love*
 Of the sanctuary, shall do
 Accordingly as all that YHWH
 Commanded." 2 Then Moses called to
 Bezalel and Aholiab,
 And every gifted *and not drab*
 Artisan in whose heart YHWH had
 Put wisdom, every maid and lad
 Whose heart was stirred, to come and do
 The work. 3 And they received from Moses
 All the offering *in gold and roses*
 Which the children of Israel had
 Brought for the work of making *glad*
In service of the sanctuary.
 So they continued bringing *merry*
 To him freewill offerings each morning.
 4 All the craftsmen who were not scorning
 To do all work of sanctuary

Came, each from the work he was doing,
5 And they spoke to Moses, and suing,
"The people bring much more than what
We can use in the service cut
Out for the tasks which YHWH
commanded

To do." 6 So Moses gave *outlanded*
Commandment, and they caused it to
Be proclaimed in the camp and through,
Saying "Let neither man nor maid
Do more, let the work now be stayed
For offering of the sanctuary."

And the folk were stopped in *the quarry*
From bringing, 7 for the things they'd
brought

Were enough for the work they'd sought,
And more than enough *to be sharey*.

Here is the greatest barrier I claim
For any modern man to know Your name,
Beloved, by reading in the sacred book.

We are so different today, just look
How different we are. Those who forsook
Your law heard personally by the mount
Are an incredible source and a fount
Of unselfishness and desire to give.

That is not now the way the noble live.
We only give a fraction and in charity.
No fundraiser today says "Stop, let be!"
With greed the best today are blocked and
blind,

So nothing of Your word can enter mind.
We understand the opposite You see.

8 All gifted artisans among
Them who'd worked on the tent *and sung*
Made ten curtains woven of fine
Linen, and blue, purple *in line*,
And scarlet *thread*, with fine design
Of cherubim they made them *shine*.

9 Length of each curtain: twenty-eight
Cubits, and the width *without weight*
Of each curtain four cubits, so
The curtains *were* all the same size.

10 And he coupled five curtains' *row*
To one another, and *this wise*
The other five curtains he joined
To one another. 11 He purloined
Loops of blue on the curtain edge
Of one set and on the selvedge,
Likewise he did the outer edge
Of curtain of the second set.

12 Fifty loops he made there *to get*
On one curtain, and fifty loops
He made on the edge of the *groups*
Of curtain on the second end,
The loops held each one *to its friend*.
13 And he made fifty clasps of gold,
And coupled the curtains *all told*
To one another with the clasps,
That it might be one tent *with hasps*.

By Your command, Beloved, the artists
came

Made tapestry to glorify Your name,
A tapestry toward which each who bowed
In prayer to You bowed also to a crowd
Of shining cherubim embroidered on
A field of blue and scarlet, purple drawn.
Did You not once deny on Mount Sinai
The right to make images of the sky,
Of earth or what's in them, and worse to
bow

Before them in worship and service now?
How then do You command the making of
Images toward which all should bow in
love?

There are distractions in prophetic word
That leave the law of Sinai cut and stirred.

14 He made curtains of goats' *hair* for
The canopy of tent *and floor*,
He made eleven curtains *more*.

15 Thirty cubits each curtain's length,
And four cubits each curtain's *strength*
In width, eleven curtains all,
Each of one size *and where they fall*.

16 Then he coupled by themselves five
Curtains, and by themselves six *drive*.

17 He made fifty loops on the edge
Of the curtain on outer edge
In one set, and fifty loops he
Made on the edge of that which be
The curtain of the second set.

18 He made also to join where met
The tent together to be one.

19 He made a covering *when done*
For the tent of ram skins dyed red,
And covering of badger skins
Above. 20 For the one in its stead
He made standing boards upright *pins*,
Acacia wood. 21 The length of each
Board *was* ten cubits, and the reach
Of width for each board *was just one*

And a half cubits. 22 Each board *done*
Had two tenons for binding one
To another. Thus he made for
All the boards of the tent *and door*.

23 He made boards for the tabernacle,
Twenty boards for the south side *tackle*.

24 Forty sockets of silver he
Made to go underneath *the tree*
Of twenty boards: two sockets to
Go under each of the boards two
Tenons. 25 And *again* for the other
Side of the tabernacle's *brother*,

The north side, he made twenty boards

26 And their forty sockets of *hoards*
Of silver: two sockets for each
Under the boards *far as to reach*.

27 For the west side of the tent he
Made six boards *there to carry*. 28 He
Also made two boards for the two
Back corners of the tent *to do*.

29 And they were coupled at the foot
And coupled together and put
At the top by one ring. Thus he
Made both of the two corners *free*.

30 So there were eight boards and their
sockets,

Sixteen sockets of silver *pockets*
Two sockets under each board *there*,
Silver and white, shining and fair.

31 He made bars of acacia wood:
Five for the boards on one side good
Of the tent, 32 five bars for the boards
On the tent's other side *with cords*,
And five bars for the tent boards on
The far side westward *against dawn*.

33 And he made the middle bar pass
Through the boards from one end *en masse*
Unto the other, 34 overlaid
The boards with gold, and then he made
Their rings of gold holders for bars,
And overlaid with gold the bars.

Bind up my heart, Beloved, in linen shroud
And in sockets of silver stand a crowd
Of boards in rings and bars of gold,
And thus keep from all view and cold
The heart I give as Your abode. Stand west
And east, and south and north to show the
best

In covering from the sun and moon and
cloud.

Let nothing but a guiding star allowed

Peer in beneath the whitened veils to see
The burning candles and the shewbread be
Upon the tables of my chambered room.
And let encircling linen arms till doom
Be barrier to blowing sand and storm.
The desert nights enclosed by once more
warm.

35 And he made a veil of blue and
Of purple, and scarlet *thread*, fine
Woven linen, worked *with design*
Of cherubim artistically.

36 He made for it *and out of hand*
Four pillars of acacia *tree*,
And overlaid them *all* with gold,
Withal also their hooks of gold,
And cast four silver sockets there.

37 He made screen for the tent door too,
Of blue and purple, scarlet *too*,
And fine woven linen, made by
A weaver, 38 its five pillars *nigh*
With their hooks. And he overlaid
Their capitals and rings that *stayed*
With gold, five sockets bronze *were made*.

Exodus 37

1 Bezalel made the ark of wood,
Acacia wood *just as he should*,
Two and a half cubits *in length*,
A cubit and a half *for strength*
In width, and a cubit and half
In height. 2 He overlaid *the raff*
With pure gold inside and outside,
And made a gold moulding *in stride*
And all around. 3 He cast for it
Four rings of gold *to be set fit*
In its four corners: two rings on
One side, and two other rings on
The other side of it. 4 He made
Acacia wood poles overlaid
With gold. 5 And he put the poles in
The rings at the sides of the bin
To bear the ark. 6 He also made
The mercy seat of pure gold *paid*,
Two and a half cubits *in length*
A cubit and a half *in strength*
Of width. 7 He made two cherubim
Of beaten gold, and he made them
Of one piece at the two ends of
The mercy seat to stand above:
8 One cherub at one end on this
Side, and the other cherub's *bliss*

At the *other* end on that side.
 He made the cherubim to bide
 At the two ends *of* mercy seat.
 9 The cherubim spread out *their neat*
 Wings above, *and* covered the seat
 Of mercy with their wings. They faced
 One another, the faces placed
 Of cherubim toward mercy seat.

Idols made of the pagan god-flesh gold
 Are lawful, my Beloved, when they are told
 By You Yourself to do the thing.

Complaint

I bring, Beloved, not that I am a saint,
 But being more papal than pope himself,
 I note the prohibition on the shelf
 Of making such (unless the cherubin
 Are things not found in heaven above nor
 in
 The earth beneath or waters under earth.)
 And furthermore, they sit empowered with
 worth
 Precisely where the people prostrate
 praying.
 Do You, Beloved, hear what Your servant's
 saying?
 Prophetic word I take, but sometimes I
 Am crossed by what that word seems to
 imply.

10 The table of acacia wood
 He made two cubits long *for good*,
 A cubit in its width, and height
 A cubit and a half *and sleight*.
 11 He overlaid it with pure gold,
 And all around the top a mould.
 12 He also made a handbreadth frame
 All around it, and of the same
 Gold made a moulding around it.
 13 And he cast four gold rings for it,
 And put the rings on the four corners
 At its four legs *as its forewarners*.
 14 The rings were put close to the frame,
 As holders for the poles *by name*
 To bear the table. 15 And he made
 The acacia wood poles arrayed
 To bear the table, overlaid
 Them with gold. 16 He made of pure gold
 The utensils laid out and told
 Upon the table *there*: its dishes,
 Its cups *and* its bowls *as one wishes*,
 And its pitchers for pouring *cold*.

17 He also made of its pure gold
 The lampstand, of hammered work he
 Made the lampstand, its shaft to be,
 Its branches, bowls, its *fine* knobs, and
 Its flowers were of a piece *and brand*.
 18 And six branches came out beside:
 Three lampstand branches out one side,
 And three branches of the lampstand
 Out of the other side *and hand*.

19 There were three bowls made like
 almond

On one branch, with a *fine* knob honned
 And a flower, and three bowls made like
 Almond on the other branch *spike*,
 With a *fine* knob and flower, and so
 For the six branches that would go
 Out of the lampstand. 20 And upon
 The lampstand itself four bowls drawn
 Like almond, its knob and flower on.
 21 A knob under the *first* branch pair,
 A knob under the *second* pair,
 And a knob under the *third* pair,
 Made according to six *in all*
 Branches extending from *the ball*.
 22 Their knobs and their branches were of
 One piece, one hammered piece above,
 Of pure gold. 23 And he made its lamps
 In seven, its wick-trimmers' *damps*,
 And its trays of pure gold, 24 in all
 Of a talent of pure gold *tall*
 He made with its utensils all.

You give, Beloved, instructions for my life
 And temple, every detail of its strife
 And peace, each blossom, nut, and
 cunningly
 Engraved fruit, every bowl and faithfully
 Made box and table, altar, mould and trim.
 Of gold and purple all, and cherubim.
 You give exactly width and breadth of all,
 And tell for altar and table how tall.
 But for the lampstand You give only
 weight
 In gold, and no height for its mate and
 state.
 The height of my brightness and light
 depends
 On my free will, or that free will that bends
 To Your love: the height of my lamp gold
 rises
 More each day as the hammering apprises.

25 He made the incense altar of
 Acacia wood. Its length *was of*
 A cubit and its width was too,
 A square, and two cubits its height.
 Its horns were with it *one piece right*.
 26 He overlaid it with pure gold:
 Its top, its sides all around *told*,
 And its horns. He also made gold
 Moulding for it all around *bold*.
 27 He made two rings of gold for it
 Under its moulding, by its *fit*
 Two corners on both sides *of it*,
 As holders for the poles with which
 To carry it. 28 And *without stitch*
 He made the poles acacia wood,
 And overlaid them with gold *good*.
 29 He also made the holy oil
 Of the anointing *not to spoil*,
 And the pure incense of sweet spices,
 And by the perfumer's devices.

Beloved, let there be in my heart and way
 Altar of incense where my prayers each day
 Arise as sweet perfumes before Your face.
 Beloved, give me today that golden grace.
 Covered with golden rings to bear withal,
 Let that sweet altar be before my call.
 Some lift their golden rings to self's
 conceit,
 And some for idols in their church deceit,
 But purify the temple of my heart
 To bear with golden rings Your incense art.
 With oil and sweet perfume let my life be
 A prayer to You anointed faithfully,
 And let Your answer in the silence grow
 To be all sweetness in the things I know.

Exodus 38

1 He made the altar of burnt offering
 Acacia wood, five cubits *proffering*
 Its length and of five cubits wide,
 Square *also was it on each side*,
 And its height *was three cubits done*.
 2 He made on its four corners horns,
 The horns were with it *one piece spun*.
 With bronze he overlays, *adorns*.
 3 He made all the utensils for
 The altar: the pans, *what is more*,
 The shovels, basins, forks, firepans,
 All its bronze utensils by plans.
 4 And he made a grate of bronze netting
 For the altar *and not forgetting*,

Under its rim, midway from base.
 5 He cast four rings *upon the face*
 For the four corners of bronze grating,
 As holders for the poles instating.
 6 He made the poles acacia wood,
 And overlaid them with bronze *good*.
 7 Then he put the poles in the rings
 On the sides of the altar *springs*,
 With which to bear it. And he made
 The altar hollow, boards *inlaid*.
 8 He made the laver of bronze and
 Its base of bronze, from the bronze *hand*
 Mirrors of the women in serving
 Assembled at the door of meeting.

The courtyard of my life is made for two
 Activities in everything I do.
 Some actions are a sacrifice to You,
 And others purify the face in dew.
 My life consists in whirling on the floor
 Of slaughter ground before the meeting
 door.

I whirl from sacrifice and back again
 To wash my hands and face and feet and
 then
 Whirl on again in burning sacrifice,
 A glowing spark before Your paradise.
 The shining mirrors of bronze flash and
 play
 The lights of morning and the blaze of day,
 The evening colours and the dusty cloud
 That rises from my feet, a living shroud.

9 He made the court on the south side,
 The hangings of the court *were wide*
 Of fine woven linen, in length
 One hundred cubits. 10 There *for strength*
 Were twenty pillars for them, and
 With twenty bronze sockets' *demand*.
 The hooks of the pillars and their
 Bands *were silver*. 11 On the north share
 One hundred cubits *long the veils*
 With twenty pillars and their *pales*
 With twenty bronze sockets. The hooks
 Of the pillars and bands *were looks*
 Of silver. 12 And on the west side
 Hangings of fifty cubits wide,
 With ten pillars and sockets ten.
 The hooks of the pillars and then
 Their bands *were silver*. 13 For the east
 Side fifty cubits, *veils decreased*.
 14 The hangings of the one side *of*

*The gate fifteen cubits above
 With their three pillars, sockets three,
 15 And the same for the other three
 Of the court gate, on this side and
 On that hangings of fifteen spanned
 Cubits, with their three pillars and
 Their three sockets. 16 And all the veils
 Of the court all around in tails
 Were of fine woven linen scales.
 17 The sockets for the pillars bronze,
 The hooks of pillars, for by-gones,
 And their bands silver, overlay
 Of their tops was silver in pay,
 And all the pillars of the court
 Had bands of silver for the fort.
 18 The veil for the gate of the court
 Was woven of blue, purple sort,
 And scarlet and of linen fine
 Woven, and with the length in twine
 Of twenty cubits, and the height
 Along its width five cubits sight,
 Just like the hangings of the court.
 19 And there were four pillars in sort
 With their four sockets of bronze and
 Their silver hooks, and every band
 And overlay of their tops spanned
 With silver. 20 All the ten pegs of
 The tent and court around, above,
 Were made of bronze and made with love.*

The court is a dergah, a slaughtering floor,
 Surrounded by white linen and a door.
 Within this world enshrouded for my death
 I seek Your name, Beloved, from breath to
 breath.

Measured with whirling step and parted
 with
 Each silver capped column of wood and
 myth,
 The floor on which I stand, a slaughtered
 sheep,
 Has linen shrouds around me and to keep
 The way to heavenly sacrifice and tale.
 The courtyard is of linen built, not mail,
 And yet the rushing of the desert gale
 Against unpitied shrouds has no avail.
 Beloved, I seek Your name as I pass
 through
 The courtyard and its veils to come to You.

Week 23

21 This is the sum of the whole tent

Of testimony as it went
 And counted by commandment to
 Moses, for the work that should do
 The Levites by Ithamar's hand,
 Son of Aaron the priest to stand.
 22 Bezalel Uri's son, the son
 Of Hur, of the tribe and well done
 Of Judah, made all that YHWH had
 Commanded Moses as He bade.
 23 And with him was Aholiab
 The son of Ahisamach, swab
 Of the tribe of Dan, an engraver
 And a designer, and a weaver
 Of blue, and purple, scarlet thread,
 And of fine linen in good stead.
 24 And all the gold that was used in
 All the work of the holy bin,
 That is, the gold of the offering,
 Was twenty-nine talents to bring
 And seven hundred thirty shekels,
 According to sanctified shekels.
 25 And the silver from those who were
 Numbered of congregation's fer
 Was one hundred talents and one
 Thousand seven hundred and done
 Seventy-five shekels, according
 To sanctuary shekel hoarding,
 26 A bekah for each man, that is,
 Half a shekel, by holy weight,
 For every single one of his
 Included in the numbered state,
 From twenty years old and above,
 For six hundred three thousand love,
 And five hundred and fifty men.
 27 And from the hundred talents of
 Silver were cast the sockets of
 The sanctuary bases then
 For the veil: from one hundred of
 Talents one hundred sockets, each
 Socket a talent weight to each.
 28 Then from the one thousand and seven
 Hundred and seventy-five to heaven
 Of shekels he made pillar hooks,
 Overlaid their tops, and for looks
 Made bands for them. 29 The offering of
 Bronze was seventy talents love
 And two thousand four hundred shekels.
 30 And with it he made without speckles
 Sockets for the meeting tent door,
 The bronze altar, and the bronze shore
 Of grating for it, all the tools
 For the altar, 31 the socket stools

For the court all around, the bases
For the court gate, all pegs *and maces*
For the tent, and all the pegs for
The court around *from door to door*.

Four are the holy tasks and four professions
That enter in the four gates with
confessions.

The priest and the engraver each with skill,
Designer and the weaver fit the bill.
There ought to be a baker for the cakes,
Unless that's one task the priest's helper
takes.

There is no Sabbath shown unless
shewbread

Is changed upon the table at the head.
But that's a task unmentioned here because
It has no part in making of the straws.
Four gates keep the divine professions
going

From law to truth, love and awareness
showing.

Beloved, I see the sum of the tent's making,
And come within Your embraces
unshaking.

Exodus 39

1 Of blue, purple, and scarlet *thread*
They made garments of service *dread*,
For ministering in holy *place*,
And made the holy garments *trace*
For Aaron, as YHWH had commanded
Moses. 2 He made the ephod *banded*
Of gold, blue, purple, scarlet *thread*,
And of fine woven linen *spread*.
3 They beat the gold into thin sheets
And cut *it into* threads, *such feats*
To work *it in with* cloth of blue,
Purple, and scarlet *thread* to do
The fine linen *in* fine designs.
4 They made shoulder straps where it joins
Together, it was joined at both
Edges. 5 And the fine woven troth
Of his ephod that *was* on it
Was of the same craft *and was fit*,
Gold, blue, purple, and scarlet *thread*,
And of fine woven linen *spread*,
As YHWH had told Moses to do.
6 And they set onyx stones, *a few*
Enclosed in gold settings, engraved,
As signets are engraved, *and paved*
With the names of *all* Israel's sons.

7 He put them on the shoulder *duns*
Of the ephod, memorial stone
For Israel's sons, as YHWH *alone*
Had told Moses *to interpone*.

Who knows where that golden breastplate
is now

That carried memory stones upon its brow
For each of Israel's sons and their
descendants.

It may have since been turned into ear-
pendants.

More than two hundred fifty years ago
Onesimus made like breastplate for show
And no one now knows where its costly
stones

Are hidden with or without prior's bones.
Let me, Beloved, wear also on my heart
The memory of the sacred names and chart,
Not graved in stone that disappears with
time,

But whispered in a fleeting word and
rhyme,

Until Your name returns from breath to
breath

In timely syllable and shibboleth.

8 And he made the breastplate, woven
Finely like ephod's craft and in
Gold, blue, purple, and scarlet *thread*,
And of fine woven linen *spread*.

9 They made the breastplate square in two
Folded, a span its length came to
And a span its width folded over.

10 And they set in it *treasure trove*
Four rows of stones: a row with stones
Of sardius, topaz, *no bones*,

An emerald on the first row,
11 The second row, a turquoise *show*,

A sapphire, and a diamond *glow*,

12 The third row, a jacinth, an agate,
An amethyst, 13 and *not to drag it*

The fourth row, a beryl, an onyx,
And a jasper *the whole thing fix*.

Enclosed in gold settings mounted,
14 Twelve stones according to *the id*
And ego of Israel's twelve sons:

According to their names *and runs*,

A signet, each one with its own
Name by the twelve tribes *set alone*.

The sacred number twelve is caught in light

And precious stones forever man's delight.
The sacred names, both known and hidden
are

Presented in the glowing stones like star.
The many coloured faces sing their songs
Of many-coloured fashions, rights and
wrongs.

Beloved, the topaz and the diamond set
Beside the purple majesties that get
The amethyst and jasper shining there
Bind eye and mind to simple earth and air.
Therefore I jump into the rushing stream
That polishes the stones that glance and
gleam.

I name the secret twelve before I find
Your name is one and all for good and
kind.

15 And they made chains for the
breastplate

At the ends, like braided cords' *mate*
Of pure gold. 16 They also made two
Settings of gold and two gold rings,
And put the two rings on the two
Ends of the breastplate *as for kings*.
17 And they put the two braided chains
Of gold in the two rings *in lanes*
On the ends of the *gold* breastplate.
18 The two ends of the two chains mate
They braided, fastened in the two
Settings, put on the shoulder crew
Of the ephod in front, 19 made two
Rings of gold and put on the two
Ends of the breastplate, on its edge,
Which *was* upon the inward hedge
Of the ephod. 20 They also made
Two *other* gold rings where they stayed
On the two shoulder straps, beneath
The ephod toward its front *for wreath*,
Right at the seam above the fine
Woven band of ephod's *design*.
21 And they bound the breastplate by
means

Of its rings *set as go-betweens*
To the rings of the ephod by
A blue cord, so it would be *shy*
Above the finely woven band
Of the ephod, and that the *grand*
Breastplate would not be loosened from
The ephod, as YHWH had *in sum*
Said to Moses and by command.

Two braided chains of gold, Hasan,
Husayn,

Hold with two principles that well retain
All other names on earth for glory's reign.
Hasan accommodates to evil's power
And leaves to You, Beloved, to choose the
hour

Of Your deliverance, and so sets up
The first great way to cross usurper's cup.
Husayn rebels against usurper's crown
And shows the bloody path out of the town.
These two chains hold all true integrity,
And give the choice of action to the free.
Beloved, as I respond in frailty
To the usurper's mandate and his bill,
Teach me which chain to grasp for good or
ill.

22 He made the ephod robe of work
All of blue woven *without shirk*,

23 And opening in middle of
The robe, like opening above
A coat of mail, *with* woven binding
All round the opening *unwinding*,
So that it would not tear. 24 They made
On the hem of the robe *that stayed*
Pomegranates of blue, purple, and
Scarlet, and of fine woven *band*.
25 And they made bells of pure gold, and
Put bells between pomegranates on
Hem of the robe all round between
The pomegranates: 26 a bell upon
It and a pomegranate, then *seen*
A bell and a pomegranate, round
The hem of the robe to the *ground*
In which to do service, as YHWH
Commanded Moses *what to do*.

27 They made tunics, well woven of
Fine linen, for Aaron *above*
And for his sons, 28 a turban of
Fine linen, exquisite hats of
Fine linen, and short trousers of
Fine woven linen, 29 and a sash
Of fine woven linen with *splash*
Of blue, purple, and scarlet *thread*,
Made by a weaver, *and well spread*,
As YHWH commanded Moses to.
30 They made the plate of holy crown
Of pure gold, and wrote on a few
Words like a signet graven down:
Holiness to YHWH, 31 and they tied
To it a blue cord, fast abide

Above on the turban, as YHWH
Had commanded Moses *to do*.

Bells of gold and pomegranates of purple,
Blue and scarlet thread make the priest's
hem full.

I cannot help but wonder what sounds
make

The golden bells, such golden bells at
stake.

They say the golden bells let people know
The High Priest would not die nor fail to
show

From the most holy place when he went in
To make atonement for the last year's sin.
But in between the bells there also hang
The silent threaded fruits that never sang,
Inlaid with coloured stuff that shimmer
swing.

Beneath the light reflected on the wing
I can't help curious wonder, wondering
What fills the heart-core of that fruitless
ring.

32 All the work of the meeting tent
Was finished as Israel's folk went
According to all that YHWH told
Moses, so they did *brave and bold*.

33 And they brought to Moses the tent,
The tent and all its furnishment:
Its clasps, its boards, its bars, its pillars,
Its sockets, *and all of its fillers*,

34 The covering of ram skins dyed red,
The covering of badger skins *spread*,
And the veil of the covering,

35 The ark of the covenant's *wing*
With its poles, and the mercy seat,

36 The table, all its tools *complete*,
And the showbread, 37 the pure lampstand
With its lamps that in order stand,
All its utensils, and the oil

For lighting *and not for turmoil*,

38 The golden altar, and the oil,
For the anointing and incense
Sweet smelling, the screen *recompense*
For the tent door, 39 and the bronze grate

Of altar, grate, poles, and its plate,
The laver with its base, 40 the veils
Of the court, its pillars and *trails*
Of sockets, the screen for the gate
Of the court, its cords, and its pegs,
All the utensils *and their legs*

For the tent service, for the tent
Of meeting, 41 *and holy* garment
For service and to minister
In the holy *place: to prefer*
The holy clothes for Aaron, priest,
And his sons' garments *not the least*
To minister as priests. 42 By all
That YHWH told Moses to recall,
So Israel's folk did all the work.
43 Then Moses looked at all the work,
And indeed they had done as YHWH
Had commanded, to that were true,
And Moses blessed them for their due.

I bring the products of my life of prayer
And duty to Your golden heavenly stair
And lay them all in sacrifice to You,
Reluctant to bring my poor rags and few.
And as I wait beside the shining rungs
A sudden rising of the fiery tongues
Of glory strikes the ground of sacrifice
And turns the barren earth to paradise.
The weak and feeble breathings of my
praise

Turn into towers majestic that upraise
In Psalms and songs a house and throne
above

Where You deign to sit down and reign in
love.

My meagre sacrifice of love and tears
In Your hands becomes greater than
appears.

Exodus 40

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
2 "On the first day of first month *spread*
You shall set up the tent of meeting.
3 "You shall place there *without defeating*
The ark of covenant, and then
Veil off the ark *from sight of men*.
4 "You shall bring in the table and
Arrange the things that are *at hand*
To be set in order on it,
And you shall bring the lampstand *fit*
And light its lamps. 5 "You shall also
Set the altar of gold to glow
With the incense before the ark
Of testimony, and then park
The screen for the tent door *before*.
6 "Then you shall set before the door
Of the tent of meeting the altar
Of the burnt offering *and not falter*.

7 "And you shall set the laver there
 Between the tabernacle fair
 Of meeting and the altar, and
 Put water in it *there to stand*.
 8 "You shall set up the court around,
 And hang up the screen *to the ground*
 At the court gate. 9 "And you shall take
 Anointing oil, and *for its sake*
 Anoint the tabernacle and
 All that *is* in it, *on the sand*,
 And you shall sanctify it and
 All its utensils, holy band.
 10 "You shall anoint the altar of
 The burnt offering also *above*
 All its utensils, consecrate
 The altar to most holy state.
 11 "And you'll anoint the laver and
 Its base, and consecrate *the stand*.
 12 "Then you shall bring Aaron and his
 Sons up to where the tent door is,
 The tabernacle of meeting
 And wash with water *everything*.
 13 "You shall put the holy garments
 On Aaron, and *before the tents*
 Anoint him and consecrate him,
 That he may minister *not dim*
 To Me as priest. 14 "And you shall bring
 His sons and clothe them all with coats.
 15 "You shall anoint them *as they sing*,
 As you anointed *in his floats*
 Their father, that they may serve Me
 As priests, for their anointing shall
 Surely be priesthood eternal
 Throughout their generations' *sea*."

Beloved, I doubt not the wisdom divine
 That chose Aaron and even bent the vine
 Of his descendants for a priestly role.
 You set them out with baptisms of soul
 And inundations of oil everywhere.
 You clothe them with insignia of the fair.
 Well washed and polished, brushed and
 decked
 I do not doubt the whole regal effect
 Was to the good of soul and body of
 The folk that You deigned to pick out and
 love.
 But was it wise to promise to keep this
 Hierarchy of the blessed and blessed with
 bliss
 For generations untold but to come?

Where is the priesthood now and where's
 the rum?

16 Thus Moses did, according to
 All that YHWH had told him to do.
 17 It happened in the first month of
 The second year, the first *day* of
 The month, the tabernacle was
 Raised up. 18 So Moses was the cause
 Of raising up the tent with socket,
 And setting up its boards *and locket*,
 Putting in bars and raising pillars.
 19 And he spread out the tent *for fillers*
 Over the tabernacle and
 Put covering of the tent *in band*
 On top of it, by YHWH's command
 To Moses *in a desert land*.

Within the tabernacle beaten gold
 Unseen lies underneath the covering's fold.
 Embroidered cherubim forever dance
 Veiled from the curious eye and human
 glance.
 Towards heaven the sacred incense makes
 its way,
 But soon's enmeshed in linen overlay.
 No locks prevent, no thieving powers
 invent
 The unguessed treasure in a tattered tent.
 My prayers too go no higher than this
 room.
 Infinities of heavens stretch out to doom.
 No treasure from my heart meets any eye,
 While pageants of the universe go by.
 The heavens my praises reach are all
 within,
 All hidden under rams' and badgers' skin.

20 He took the testimony and
 Put *it* into the ark *to stand*,
 Put in the poles through the ark rings,
 And put the mercy seat *with wings*
 On top of the ark. 21 And he brought
 The ark in tent as he was taught,
 Hung up the veil of covering there,
 Divided off the ark *and where*
The tables of the covenant
Were placed to rule the firmament
 As YHWH had told Moses to do.
 22 He set the table up *on cue*
 In tabernacle of meeting,
 On the north side of the tent *wing*,

Outside the veil, 23 and he set bread
 In order on it before YHWH,
 As YHWH had told Moses and said.
 24 He set up the lampstand within
 The tabernacle of meeting,
 Across from the table *and bin*,
 On the south side of the tent *wing*,
 25 And he lit the lamps before YHWH,
 As YHWH had told Moses to do.
 26 He put the golden altar in
 The tabernacle of meeting
 In front of the veil, 27 and he burned
 Sweet incense on it, as *concerned*
 YHWH had told Moses *what* to do.
 28 He hung up the screen *at* the door
 Of the tabernacle *before*,
 29 And put the altar of burnt offering
Before the door of the tent *proffering*
 A place of meeting, and offered
 Upon it the burnt offering *cured*
 And the food offering, as YHWH had
 Commanded Moses, *a good lad*.
 30 He set the laver *there* between
 The tabernacle of meeting
 And the altar, and for washing,
 31 And Moses, Aaron, and were seen
 His sons washing their hands and feet
With water from it *as a treat*.
 32 Whenever they went in the tent
 Of meeting *there*, and when they went
 Near the altar, they washed, as YHWH
 Had commanded Moses to do.
 33 And he raised up the court around
 The tabernacle *on the ground*
 And the altar, and hung the screen
 Of the court gate *there to be seen*.
 So Moses finished the work *clean*.

Before I come before Your throne in prayer
 I also wash my hands and feet to spare
 Me from the soul impurity that comes
 Creeping across the landscape of my sums.
 But water cannot ever cleanse the soul,
 And as Your purity is my soul's goal,
 As I pass by the mirrored laver's sea,
 I pray You, my Beloved, that You cleanse
 me.

This slaughter ground that is my home a
 while

If for the offering of my self of guile
 And seeing in the washing mirrors here
 Reflections of Your divine grace and fear.

I enter in the dergah to meet You,
 Beloved, and wash to see what will ensue.

34 Then the cloud covered up the tent
 Of meeting, and the glory went
 From YHWH and filled up all the tent.
 35 And Moses was not able to
 Enter the tabernacle true
 For meeting, because the cloud rested
 Above it, and glory *invested*
 From YHWH had filled the *sacred* tent.
 36 When the cloud was taken up from
 Above the tent *to rise and come*,
 The children of Israel would go
 Onward in all their journeys *slow*.
 37 But if the cloud did not go up,
 They journeyed not till it went up.
 38 For the cloud of YHWH *was* above
 The tabernacle by day's *love*,
 And fire was over it by night,
 Before all the house and in sight
 Of Israel through their journeys' *plight*.

At morning light I look toward the cloud
 Of guidance You have dropped down in a
 crowd
 To lead my footsteps through the weary
 maze
 Of contemplative nights and busy days.
 Sometimes Your cloud bids me to stand me
 still,
 And other times gives me a task to fill,
 Sometimes it is a shade from blistering heat
 Of opposition to obedient feet,
 Sometimes it is a fiery lamp to show
 The way that my unwilling feet should go.
 Beloved, I look toward the cloud each day
 And pray that You will guide my
 wandering way
 Toward a fair and promised land afar
 Or toward its temple in this chambered star.

Leviticus

TWO themes began to emerge in the last
 half of the Book of Exodus, and in the
 Book of Leviticus they become dominant.
 Nearly every passage in Leviticus deals
 with one or both of the themes of purity
 and sacrifice. Doubtless there were
 variations in the details of the purity code

and the types of sacrifices that were needed or considered appropriate at different times in Bible history. The variations in detail suggest that, and in fact the sacrificial system and purity code of the Book of Ezekiel, for example, is in some areas quite different from that of the Books of Moses. The Book of Psalms questions the whole configuration. But the Book of Leviticus is a firm testimony to the importance given to these issues throughout the whole history of Biblical faith. Purity and sacrifice have been reduced to a minimum in Christianity, and with the loss of the temple they have been somewhat atrophied in Rabbinical Judaism. Samaritanism and Islam are in some sense more directly the heirs of the Book of Leviticus, even if there are some differences between the details of their practice and that of the Bible.

This is not to say that other issues are not dealt with in Leviticus. But all of these issues, including purification and sacrifice, are couched within the context of prophetic authority. Specifically Moses is portrayed as the human figure through whom God reveals the details of legislation appropriate to the specific audience under the Levitical priesthood. This focus on prophetic authority broadens the horizons of the book considerably, making it a foundational text. The Decalogue itself does not mention prophetic authority, or any other authority beyond that of parent, employer, owner, and God Himself. The Book of Leviticus, in introducing an additional level of authority is pivotal in the whole concept of canonical literature and its validity. This infuses the sometimes dry legislation with a greater urgency and a greater attraction. Although stories are few, the legislation itself opens windows not only on a particular faith society, but on the fascinating world of human nature. In that sense it is more human and intimate than the preceding books.

The very first verse opens with this most intimate relationship between God and a human being. God called to Moses. The divine Word comes with the verb *qara'*, the same from which the word Qur'an comes, and the same that refers to the practice of

cantillating Scripture. Quite literally, we are faced with divine songs addressed to a human being.

LEVITICUS upholds the simple fact

That without guidance few know how to
act,

But must be told in words by prophets who
Receive that blessed guidance straight from
You.

The Decalogue is clear about the needed,
But does not give details that should be
heeded

By those who are not sure about the clean
And the unclean. First one must learn to
make

The right distinctions and for the right's
sake

Before one can in true awareness know
The unity of all things in the show.

Things visible there are and things unseen.
The prophet sets the seen and done out
straight

And gives his glimpses of the inner gate.

Week 24 Leviticus 1

1 Now YHWH called to Moses, and spoke
To him from the tent of meeting,
Saying 2 "Now speak to Israel's folk,
And say to them, 'When any bring
An offering to YHWH, you'll bring
Your offering of the livestock,
And of the herd and of the flock.

First Genesis revealed that You are One,
And Exodus that You'd have justice done.

Now You call Moses for that which You
have

No need at all in therapy or salve.

You ask, Beloved, that folk give gifts to
You

Out of their need, of something it is true
You cannot use, who eat no flesh nor smell
The smoke of blood and incense at the bell.

You ask, Beloved, that people give Your
own,

But that of Yours the people can alone
Enjoy in feast: when it's put to Your taste,
It only ends in burning up the waste.

You ask, Beloved, I hasten now to give,
My gift to You alone makes me to live.

3 'And if his offering *is* a burnt
 Sacrifice of the herd *as learnt*,
 Let him offer a male without
 Blemish, he shall offer no doubt
 Of his own free will at the door
 Of the tent of meeting before
 YHWH. 4 'Then he shall put his hand on
 The head of the burnt offering *gone*,
 And it will be accepted on
 His own behalf and for to make
 An atonement and for his sake.
 5 'He shall kill the bull before YHWH,
 And the priests, Aaron's sons, shall do
 To bring the blood and sprinkle all
 The blood around on altar's *wall*
 That's *by* the tent of meeting door.
 6 'He'll skin the burnt offering *what's more*,
 And cut it in its pieces *there*.
 7 'The sons of Aaron the priest shall
 Put fire on the altar *for mall*,
 And lay the wood in order on
 The fire. 8 'The priests, sons' of Aaron,
 Shall lay the parts, the head, the fat
 In order on where the wood's at
 That's on the fire upon the altar,
 9 'But he shall wash it *and not falter*
 Its entrails and its legs with water.
 And the priest shall burn all *the slaughter*
 Upon the altar as a burnt
 Sacrifice, an offering *as learnt*
 Made by fire, a sweet aroma
 To YHWH *in His basilica*.

I lay me on the altar at Your door,
 Well-skinned and cut in husky pieces for
 The burning of the holocaust to You.
 I wait to rise a burning spark on cue.
 Upon the wood I'm laid out like the best
 In parts and head and fat, what bit they
 wrest
 From the dry flesh and tough with age and
 time.
 I'm laid out on the altar worth a dime.
 Washed for the sacrifice, I come clean-
 fleshed,
 Washed entrails and washed legs and all
 refreshed.
 Let my living and dying be to You,
 Beloved, a good aroma sweet and true
 Laid out in sacrifice upon the floor
 Of this world's faint and folly at the door.

10 'If his offering *is* of the flocks
 Of the sheep or of the goats' *locks*
 As a burnt sacrifice, he shall
 Bring a spotless male animal.
 11 'He shall kill it on the north side
 Of the altar before YHWH's *guide*,
 And the priests, Aaron's sons, its blood
 Shall sprinkle round the altar's *flood*.
 12 'And he shall cut it into pieces,
 With its head and its fat *increases*,
 And the priest shall lay them in pyre
 On the wood that *is* on the fire
 Upon the altar, 13 'but he shall
 Wash the entrails and the legs *sal*
 With water. Then the priest shall bring
It all and burn *it* on the altar,
 It's burnt sacrifice, *not to falter*,
 An offering made by fire, a sweet
 Aroma to YHWH *for a treat*.
 14 'And if the burnt sacrifice of
 His offering to YHWH *is made* of
 Birds, then he shall bring his offering
 Of turtledoves, young pigeon *thing*.
 15 'The priest shall bring it to the place
 Of slaughter, wring its head, and burn
It on the altar, its blood shall
 Be drained out *and in the canal*
 At the side of the altar *stern*.
 16 'And he shall remove its crop with
 Its feathers and cast it forthwith
 Beside the altar on the east,
 Into the place for ashes *ceased*.
 17 'Then he shall split it at its wings,
But not fully divide *the things*,
 And the priest shall burn it upon
 The altar, on the wood that's on
 The fire. It *is* a sacrifice,
 Burnt, made by fire *and to suffice*,
 To YHWH a sweet aroma *nice*.

While humming allouette so the priest
 Casts out beside the altar on the east,
 Into the place for ashes of deceased.
 Still I have wings to take flight and
 increased
 Desire to find a haven from the fire.
 I whirl and turn to and fro in desire.
 The fire upon the altar of my breast
 Is not to be quenched turning east or west,
 But only as I find my true refuge
 Within the divine heart, for it is huge.
 Beloved, I soar above the humming priest,

I tender my singed wings to glowering
beast,
And fall back to the earth, the earthen gate,
And find at last the inner heart and late.

Leviticus 2

1 'When anyone offers a grain
Offering to YHWH, *not to be vain*
His offering shall be *of* fine flour.
And he shall pour oil on *the dower*,
And put frankincense in its *power*.

You never did require the blood of lamb,
The life of pigeon nor the flesh of ram.
Your word "when any will" give of Your
own

Tempers each offering brought before Your
throne.

The gift is precious only for the choice,
The human will and heart as well as voice.
I have no blood nor lamb nor gift of mine,
I've no fine flour nor finely scented wine,
I have no oil nor fruit but from Your hand:
The offering of myself alone I stand.
Yet I am not my own to give or lend,
The only thing that I can do's intend.
Thanks be to You, Beloved, I do belong
To Whom I would give all my self and
song.

2 'He shall bring it to Aaron 's sons,
The priests, one of whom *in homespuns*
Shall take from it his handful of
Fine flour and oil as well as *glove*
Of frankincense. The priest shall burn
Memorial on altar *stern*,
An offering made by fire, a sweet
Aroma to YHWH *for a treat*.
3 'The rest of the grain offering *shall*
Be Aaron's and his sons' *for sal*.

It's most holy of offerings to
YHWH made by fire *and on their cue*.

4 'And if you bring as an offering
A grain offering baked in the *wing*
Of oven, *it shall be* without
Yeast cakes of fine flour mixed about
With oil, or unleavened wafers
Anointed with oil *for the fers*.

5 'But if your offering is a grain
Offering *baked* in a pan, *not slain*,
It shall be fine flour, *not to spoil*,
Unleavened *too*, and mixed with oil.

6 'You shall break it in pieces and
Pour oil on the grain offering's *stand*.
7 'And if your offering *is* a grain
Offering *baked* in a covered pan,
It shall be made fine flour *and sane*
With oil. 8 'You shall bring *to a man*
The grain offering that is made of
These things to YHWH, *mentioned above*.
And when it is presented to
The priest, then he shall bring it to
The altar. 9 'Then the priest shall take
From the grain offering *which shall make*
Memorial portion, and then burn
It on the altar. *It's a stern*
Offering made by fire, and a sweet
Aroma to YHWH. 10 'And *the treat*
That is left of the grain offering
Shall be Aaron's and his sons' *thing*.
It is most holy of gifts to
YHWH made by fire, *as offerings do*.

A handful of fine flour, a dap of oil,
And frankincense poured on me, wrapped
in foil,
And I become a lawful piece of flesh,
Worthy as gift to You, caught in the mesh
Of wispy veils about the universe,
Illusions of the power to bless and curse.
And so my piecrust and its sweetness burn
And burning cast a flame to light and learn.
Yet wheaten and the sweeten and the oil
Are only momentary spots of toil.
Empty as worlds the offerings turn to
smoke,
And silence reigns where all the heavens
spoke.
Nor word nor flesh can penetrate the veils,
But there's a dragon, phoenix that chews
nails.

11 'No grain offering which you bring to
YHWH shall be made with yeast, for you
Shall burn no leaven, no, nor honey
In any offering for YHWH's *money*
And made by fire. 12 'As for the offering
Of the firstfruits, you shall be proffering
Them to YHWH, but they shall not be
Burned on the altar for a *fee*
In sweet aroma. 13 'Every one
Of your grain offerings you'll have done
Seasoned with salt, you'll not allow
The salt of your God's pact somehow

To be lacking from your grain offering.
 You'll offer salt with every offering.
 14 'If you offer a grain offering
 Of your firstfruits to YHWH, the thing
 You'll offer for the grain offering
 Of your firstfruits the green grain ears
 Roasted on fire, grain threshed *arrears*
 From the full ears. 15 'And you shall place
 Oil on it, and lay on *a trace*
Of frankincense, it's grain offering.
 16 'The priest shall burn part of the thing
 Memorial, of its threshed out grain,
 And of its oil, and frankincense,
 As an offering made *to ordain*
 By fire to YHWH *in deference*.

Add salt to oil and frankincense, Beloved,
 Leave off the yeast and honey, my well-
 gloved,
 But pour instead in my fresh wounds Your
 salt,
 Instead of healing them with honey malt.
 Roast my heart in its salty breaths and tears
 And burn me far beyond my failing fears.
 Let burning in my heart not fail though I
 May find a narrow bed in which to die.
 Let neither life nor death quench scorching
 flame
 That burns for Your sweet presence and
 Your name.
 Beloved, I beg to be threshed out and set
 With oil and frankincense as soon as met,
 And bound with salt instead of yeast and
 honey,
 And flocked with poverty instead of
 money.

Leviticus 3

1 'When his offering's a sacrifice
 Of a peace offering *for device*,
 If he offers *it* of the herd,
 Whether male or female *concurred*,
 He shall offer it without *spot*
Or blemish before YHWH *as taught*.
 2 'And he'll lay his hand on the head
 Of his offering, kill it *instead*
At the door of the meeting tent,
 And Aaron's sons, the priests, consent
 To sprinkle the blood all around
 On the altar *where it is found*.
 3 'Then he'll offer from sacrifice
 Of the peace offering something nice

Made by fire to YHWH, and the fat
 That covers the entrails, all that
Which is on the entrails, 4 'the two
 Kidneys and the fat that *will do*
 On them by the flanks, and the lobe
 Of fat upon the liver *globe*
 Above the kidneys, he'll remove,
 5 'And Aaron's sons burn it *to prove*
 On the altar upon the burnt
 Sacrifice, which *is* on the *earnt*
 Wood that *is* on the fire, an offering
 Made by *the* fire, and a sweet *proffering*
 Aroma to YHWH *as behoove*.

O my Beloved, lay Your hand on my head!
 I'm just as worthy, no, as quadruped!
 Look not on any blemish in the brow,
 I'm not a yearling for the altar now,
 Though I am briefly aged and toughened by
 The salt and wind I've drunk from earth and
 sky.

Let kidney fat be burnt as well as cross
 On liver and my fatal skin's emboss.
 O my Beloved, lay Your hand on my head!
 I seek that warm hand as I'm tied and led
 By halter on the dergah floor's bedstead.
 It is no game of peach pit and of toss.
 There is a soul of sorts, eternal loss,
 Returning on the wheel to eat shewbread.

6 'If his offering as sacrifice
 Of peace offering to YHWH *suffice*,
Is of the flock, male or female,
 He'll offer without spot *or scale*.
 7 'If he offers a lamb as his
 Offering, then he shall bring as is
 Before YHWH. 8 'And he shall lay his
 Hand on the head of his offering,
 And kill it before the tent *wing*
Of meeting, and Aaron's sons shall
 Sprinkle its blood peripheral
 To all the altar. 9 'Then he shall
 Offer from the sacrifice of
 The peace offering, *described above*,
 As offering made by fire to YHWH,
 Its fat *and* the whole fat tail *too*
 Which he'll remove near the backbone.
 And the fat that covers *alone*
 The entrails and all the fat that
Is on the entrails, 10 'and *the fat*
Of the two kidneys and the fat
 That *is* on them by the flanks, and

The fatty lobe *attached in band*
 To the liver above the reins,
 He shall remove, 11 'the priest shall burn
Them on the altar food *to earn*,
 An offering made by fire to YHWH.
 12 'And if his offering *is* a goat,
 He shall offer it before YHWH.
 13 'He shall lay his hand *to devote*
 Upon its head, kill it before
 The tabernacle meeting *door*,
 And the sons of Aaron shall take
 And sprinkle its blood *for its sake*
 All around on the altar *stake*.
 14 'Then he shall offer from it his
 Offering, as an offering *which is*
 Made by fire to YHWH and the fat
 That covers entrails, all fat that
Is on the entrails, 15 'and the two
 Kidneys and the fat on them too,
 By the flanks, and the fatty lobe
 On liver above reins, he'll probe
 Removing it, 16 'and the priest shall
 Burn them on the altar *with sal*
As food, an offering made by fire
 For a sweet aroma's *desire*,
 And all the fat *is* YHWH's. 17 '*This shall*
Be everlasting statute through
 Your generations and where you
 May live, you shall eat neither fat
 Nor blood, *nor any such as that.*'"

If all the fat belongs, Beloved, to You,
 Thank God I have no mission work to do!
 All who are fat upon the earth, it's true,
 Bow down and worship for their food and
 You.

So all the fat is Yours, what wealth to know
 That fat is not just shameful things to show,
 But something that You love and covet so
 You ask us to burn fat and fat to go.
 All the fat is for You, then let it burn
 In smokeless fire in all the hearts that yearn
 For You, for Your words I have yet to
 learn.

All the fat is for You, that's most of us,
 Though some are slender, still there is the
 fuss

Of fat around the liver on the bus.

Leviticus 4

1 Now YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 2 "Speak to Israel's folk *whom you've led*,

Saying 'If a person does wrong
 Without intention all along
 Against any command of YHWH
In something he ought not to do,
 And does any of them, 3 'or if
 The anointed priest sins *at skiff*,
 Bringing guilt on the people, then
 Let him offer to YHWH for when
 His sin *is done* which he has sinned,
 A young bull without blemish *skinned*
 As a sin offering. 4 'He shall bring
 The bull to the meeting tent *wing*
 Door before YHWH, and lay his hand
 On the bull's head *faithfully*, and
 Kill the bull before YHWH. 5 'Then the
 Anointed priest shall take *in fee*
 Some of the bull's blood and bring it
 To the tent of meeting *and fit*.
 6 'The priest shall dip his finger in
 The blood and sprinkle some *for sin*
 Of the blood seven times before YHWH,
 Before the sanctuary veil.
 7 'The priest shall put some of it too,
 Blood on altar horns *to avail*
 Of the sweet incense before YHWH,
 Which is in meeting tent, and he
 Shall pour the rest of bull's blood free
 At the base of the altar of
 The burnt offering, *described above*,
 Which is at the meeting tent door.
 8 'He shall take from it all the fat
 Of the bull as sin offering, fat
 That covers the entrails and all
 The fat which *is* on entrails *call*,
 9 'The two kidneys and the fat that
Is on them by the flanks, and still
 The fatty lobe *attached for ill*
 To the liver above the reins,
 He shall remove, 10 'and as its *stains*
 Were taken from the bull *that met*
 Sacrifice of peace offering set,
 And the priest shall burn them upon
 The altar of burnt offering *gone*.
 11 'But the bull's hide and all its flesh,
 With its head and legs, and its *mesh*
 Of entrails and offal, 12 'the whole
 Bull he shall carry out the camp
 To a clean place, *not dank and damp*,
 Where the ashes are poured out, and
 Burn it on wood with fire *in hand*,
 Where the ashes are poured out it
 Shall be burned, *as is taught and fit*.

The sin of priest requires a bull, I say,
It's cheaper not to be a priest for pay.
That's one bad thing about the state we're in
Not having to kill livestock for our sin.
The priesthood is a tempting for the sums
That easily accrue for lack of tums.
The salary for telling folk You don't
Mean what You say is slick and great, and
won't

Stop when the price of steel goes down the
drain.

And yet being a rabbi's a job vain
For any Jewish boy. Let me sit still
In my poor slaughtered Christian's stock
and swill.

Beloved, I take You for my priest and herd,
I have neither lamb nor bull, neither bird.

13 'Now if the whole congregation
Of Israel sins, no intention,
And the thing is hidden from eyes
Of the assembly, *despite tries*,
And they've done *according to* YHWH's
Commandments what they should not
choose,

And are guilty, 14 'when the sin which
They have done comes out of the ditch,
Then the assembly shall offer
A young bull for the sin, confer
It before the tent of meeting.

15 'And the elders of the whole thing
Shall lay their hands on the bull's head
Before YHWH, the bull's blood be shed
Before YHWH. 16 'The anointed priest
Shall bring bull's blood, or some *at least*
To the tent of meeting. 17 'The priest
Shall dip his finger in the blood
And sprinkle *it* seven times *in flood*
Before YHWH, in front of the veil.
18 'And he shall put *for some avail*
Some of the blood on the horns to
The altar which *is* before YHWH,
Which *is* in the meeting tent, and
He'll pour rest of blood at the stand
Of the altar of burnt offering,
Which is at the meeting tent *wing*
Beside the door. 19 'And he shall take
All the fat from it, burn *the stake*
On the altar. 20 'And he shall do
With the bull just as he did too
With the bull as a sin offering,

Thus he shall do with everything.
So the priest shall make atonement
For them, it shall be *a present*,
And a forgiveness *for their sin*.
21 'He'll carry the bull *to the bin*
Outside the camp, and burn it like
He burned the first bull *in first strike*.
And it *shall be* a sin offering
For the assembly *as they sing*.

The weight of sin done by the priest is such
It is more weighty, or at least as much
As a sin done by all the folk at large,
Six hundred thousand count was the last
charge.

I can believe that such a thing is true,
When I look round to see what clergy do,
It may be just about six hundred mils
And more than what a common drunkard
spills.

I haven't found a priest or rabbi yet
But what agrees with mullah in his bet
That You care naught if sundry and the
sane

Ignore Your ten commandments in the rain.
Beloved, I am the bull spread out and
skinned

And cast outside the camp by those who
sinned.

22 'When a ruler has sinned, and done
Without intention *on the run*
By any of commandments *spoken*
By YHWH his Alohim *in token*
Which should not be done, and is guilty,
23 'Or if his sin *though still not wilty*
Which he has done once comes to light,
He shall bring as his offering's *right*
A kid of goats, male without spot.
24 'And he shall lay his hand *once caught*
On the head of the goat, and kill
It at the *very* place they kill
The burnt offering before YHWH *still*.
It *is* a sin offering. 25 'The priest
Shall take some of the blood *at least*
Of sin offering with finger put
On horns of burnt offerings' altar,
And pour its blood out at the foot
Of the *same* burnt offerings' altar.
26 'And he shall burn all its fat on
The altar, like the fat upon
The sacrifice of the peace offering.

So the priest shall make and be proffering
Atonement for him for his sin,
And it shall be forgiven him.

It takes a bull to make a priest's sin right.
A president can do with a good sight
Less with his little goat. That presupposes
The president admits it's not been roses
He brought to scent the air but sinful poses.
I've yet to see the president go free
Saying he'd made mistakes in drunken
spree.

Oh yes, a few are deposed when they fail
To line the greater lobby's gunny wale,
And for that their mistakes are trumpeted
In justification for what they did.
Hide Your face, my Beloved. I see You hid
It long ago, and so it seems for good.
In view of things, I really think You
should.

27 'If any of the common folk
Sins without meaning to go broke,
By any of YHWH's commandments
Which ought not to be done *for sense*,
And is guilty, 28 'or if his sin
Which he's committed comes out in
The wash, then he shall bring his offering
A kid of the goats, female proffering
Without a blemish, for his sin
Which he has committed *within*.
29 'And he shall lay his hand upon
The head of the sin offering *spawn*,
And kill the sin offering just where
The burnt offering's *also laid bare*.
30 'Then the priest shall take *some* of its
Blood with his finger, where it sits
On the horns of the altar of
Burnt offering, and pour all *the rest*
Of the blood that was marked above
At the base of the altar best.

31 'Then he shall remove all its fat,
As the fat is removed from that
Sacrifice of the peace offering,
And the priest shall *then* burn the thing
Upon the altar for a sweet
Aroma to YHWH *as is meet*.
So the priest shall make atonement
For him, for a forgiveness sent.
32 'If he will bring a lamb as his
Sin offering, he shall bring *as is*
A female without blemish *too*.

33 'Then he shall lay his hand *to do*
On the head of the sin offering,
And kill it as a sin offering
At the place where they kill the burnt
Offering. 34 'The priest shall take *as learnt*
Some of blood of the sin offering
With his finger, put on the horns
Of the burnt offering's altar bourns,
And pour all *the remaining* blood,
Poured out and running like a flood,
At the base of the altar. 35 'He
Shall remove all the fat *that be*,
As the fat of the lamb's removed
From the peace offering's sacrifice.
Then the priest shall burn it as nice
On the altar, according to
The offerings made by fire *and true*
To YHWH. And the priest shall so make
Atonement for *all* his sin's sake
That he has committed, and it
Shall be forgiven him *to acquit*.

A ruler's sins are sanctified by goat,
But with a male, whereas the common rote
Is satisfied with female. I don't know
What distinctions those matters show.
I'd think a female goat of greater worth
Because she gives milk and cheese in the
dearth,
Which means as I have oft suspected true
The common man is higher than the few
Who hold the power. Like priest his sin
demands
An offering of more value than the brands
Allotted to the ruler. Lesser state
Of sacrifice, though small, means that the
mate
Is thus forgiven cheaper because You
Note that the rulers don't know what they
do.

Leviticus 5

1 'If a person sins in hearing
The speaking of an oath *to bring*,
And *is* a witness, whether he
Has seen or known *the facts to be*,
If he does not tell, he bears guilt.
2 'Or if a person touches *silt*
Of any unclean thing, whether
The carcass of an unclean cur,
Or carcass of unclean livestock,
Or carcass of the unclean flock

Of creeping things, and he is not
 Aware of it, he shall be wrought
 Also unclean and guilty. 3 'Or
 If he touches the unclean spoor
 Of human, whatever unclean
 With which a man may have chagrin,
 And he is unaware of it,
 When he finds out, he is unfit.
 4 'Or if a person swears, speaking
 Thoughtlessly with *his* lips to *sing*
 Or do evil or to do good,
 Whatever that man may *or should*
 Pronounce by oath, and he is not
 Aware of it, when he's been taught,
 Then he'll be guilty in these *things*.
 5 'And it shall be, when in these things
 He is guilty, that he'll confess
 That he has sinned such *wickedness*,
 6 'And he shall bring for his trespass
 An offering to YHWH for *morass*
 Of his sin which he has committed,
 A female from the flock *and fitted*,
 A lamb or a kid of the goats
 As a sin offering *antidotes*.
 So the priest shall make atonement
 For him concerning his sin's *bent*.

I hereby bear witness, that I might not
 Be guilty of the thing that I've not sought.
 I tell all, make a sure confession of
 The tale of woe, also the tale of love.
 I bear witness to the red-handed dawn
 That stole from night its flock of pearls on
 fawn.

I give my testimony that the sun
 Rose on a new day before half begun.
 I bear witness that shimmering ice came
 out
 To dress the leafless trees in bride's
 redoubt.

I testify that You, Beloved, looked past
 The crystal air and caught up my heart fast
 Before my sleepy eyes could make the
 break
 Between the day and night for white
 thread's sake.

7 'If he is not able to bring
 A lamb, then he *instead* shall bring
 To YHWH, for his trespass which he
 Has transgressed, two turtledoves *free*
 Or two young pigeons: one as sin

Offering and the other as *in*
 A burnt offering. 8 'And he shall bring
 Them to the priest, who sin offering
 Shall offer first, and he shall wring
 Off its head from its neck, but shall
 Not divide *it* symmetrical.
 9 'Then he shall sprinkle of the blood
 Of the sin offering *in a flood*
 On the side of the altar, and
 The rest of the blood shall *not stand*
 But be drained out beside the base
 Of the altar, sin offering's *place*.
 10 'He shall offer the second *bird*
 As a burnt offering by *God's* word.
 So the priest shall make atonement
 On his behalf for trespassment
 Which he has committed, and it
 Shall be forgiven him *to wit*.
 11 'But if he is not able to
 Bring two turtledoves, even two
 Young pigeons, then he who sinned shall
 Bring for his offering *prodigal*
 One-tenth of an ephah of flour,
 Fine flour as a sin offering's *power*.
 He shall put no oil on it, nor
 Shall he put frankincense what's more,
 For it is a sin offering's *store*.
 12 'Then he shall bring it to the priest,
 And the priest shall take *the increased*,
 A handful of it as a portion,
 Memorial and *not an extortion*,
 To burn *it* on the altar as
 Offerings made by the fire as has
 Been specified for YHWH. It is
 A sin offering *and so is His*.
 13 'The priest shall make atonement for
 Him, for his sin *before his door*
 That he's committed in any
 Of these matters, and it shall be
 Forgiven him. *The rest* shall be
 The priest's as a grain offering's *fee*. '''

Who claims that only blood can cleanse
 from sin
 Has not read all the words that's written in.
 Blood cleanses only sins committed by
 The wealthy in their turn to leap and fly.
 The most of us in poverty need none,
 A little flour alone fulfills the sun.
 But I admit a poverty beyond
 Even the sprig of wheat and golden wand.
 What does the empty-handed bring to You

But Your own in his emptiness and due?
I plead my guilt but bring nor blood nor
grape
To ratify forgiveness before ape.
Beloved, if Your grace is not equal to
My sin, then I still have my faith in You.

14 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
15 "If a person commits *instead*
A trespass, without intent sins
In regard to the holy *bins*
Of YHWH, then he shall bring to YHWH
As his trespass offering *in rue*
A ram without spot from the flocks,
Along the rank and river docks,
With your evaluation in
Shekels of silver *by the gin*
According to the shekel of
The sanctuary, as *above*
A trespass offering. 16 "And he shall
Make restitution *capital*
For the harm that he has done in
Regard to the holy thing's *spin*,
And shall add one-fifth to it and
Give it to the priest *out of hand*.
So the priest shall make atonement
For him with the ram *that is bent*
To the trespass offering, and it
Shall be forgiven him *as fit*.
17 "If a person sin, and commit
Any of these forbidden things
To be done by the commandings
Of YHWH, though he does not know *it*,
Yet he is guilty and shall bear
His iniquity *as is fair*.
18 "And he shall bring the priest a ram
Without blemish from the flock's lamb,
With your evaluation, as
A trespass offering *as he has*.
So the priest shall make atonement
For him for he was ignorant
In what he erred and did not know,
And it shall be forgiven him *so*.
19 "It is a trespass offering, who
Has surely trespassed against YHWH."

A fifth is what repentant ones bring to
The restitution of the thing that's due.
I know that most think that a fifth is what
A whiskey bottle holds in mournful squat,
But that is not the intent of man's life
Unfortunately spent in worthless strife.

I lay the ready wares of group and store
Aside, aside and even out the door.
Let me not deprive any of his load
Since I lack even fifths to greet the goad.
An honest measure let me always seek
As I come from my days to end of week.
Beloved, that measure, being of Your own,
Let me share with those who are poor,
alone.

Week 25 Leviticus 6

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
2 "If a person sins and is led
To commit trespass against YHWH
By lying to his neighbour *due*
About what was delivered him
For safekeeping, or of a *dim*
Pledge, or about a robbery,
Or if he has extortingly
Dealt with his neighbour, 3 "or if he
Has found what was lost and *still* lies
About it, and swears in false guise,
In any one of these things that
A man may do in which sin sat,
4 "Then it shall be, because he has
Sinned and is guilty, then whereas
He shall restore what he has stolen,
Or the thing which he has made swollen
With his extortion, or what was
Delivered to him *as he does*
For safekeeping, or the lost thing
Which he found *lying under wing*,
5 "Or all that about which he has
Sworn falsely. He shall restore as
To its full value, add fifth part
More to it, *and* give it for *start*
To whomsoever it belongs,
On the day of his offering *songs*
For his trespass. 6 "And he shall bring
His trespass offering to YHWH's *wing*,
A ram without a blemish from
The flock, with your valuing sum,
As a trespass offering, to priest.
7 "So the priest shall make an *increased*
Atonement for him before YHWH,
And he shall be forgiven for few
Or many of these things that he
May have done and trespassingly."

Extortion is the favourite, I say,
Of many sellers on the market day.
If Torah had been written in this time

I'll bet it could have mentioned some such
crime

As advertisement makes on pension plan
And on the young and on the elder man.
To lie, swear falsely, extort the last cent
Is what in prohibition here is meant.
Make me, Belovèd, satisfied to eat
The lentil and the bread without the meat,
Until all faces are turned to the sweet
And only face, the divine face of YHWH,
And humankind is one, not great and few,
And You alone rule all hearts on the street.

8 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, waylaying,

9 "Command Aaron and his sons, saying

'This *is* the law of burnt offering:

The burnt offering *shall be a thing*

On the hearth on altar all night

Until morning, the fire bright

Of the altar shall be kept burning

Upon it. 10 'And the priest, *not spurning*,

Shall put on his linen garment,

And linen trousers *without rent*

He shall put on his body, and

Take up the ashes *in command*

Of the burnt offering which the fire

Has consumed on the altar *wire*,

And he shall put them there beside

The altar *where they shall abide*.

11 'Then he shall take off his garments,

Put other garments *without rents*,

And carry the ashes outside

The camp to a clean place *and wide*.

12 'And the fire on the altar shall

Be kept burning *and eternal*,

It shall not be put out. The priest

Shall burn wood on it as the east

Brings dawn, and lay the burnt offering

In order upon everything,

And he shall burn on it the fat

Of the peace offerings *and all that*.

13 'A fire shall always be burning

On altar, not extinguishing.

I sleep more than the half of every night,

Ignoring the pure call to fire a light

And recite the Qur'an by mercy seat.

I do sleep more, Belovèd, than may be

meet.

Yet on the altar of my heart there burns

An offering to Your faith that ever learns

To seek with burning breath Your face and
name

Beyond all other seekings and their shame.

The entrails and the fat that court my bed,

The wood and ordered fire about my head,

All raise a Psalm of praise and plaint and

dread

Confession of repentant heart instead

Of any grand petitions to Your room.

Let my fat burn for You until my doom.

14 'This *is* the law of grain offering:

The sons of Aaron surely bring

It on the altar before YHWH.

15 'He'll take from it his handful *due*

Of the fine flour of offered grain,

With its oil, and all the *germane*

Frankincense which *is* on the grain

Offering, and shall burn *it* on

The altar a sweet scent upon,

As a memorial to YHWH.

16 'And the remainder of it *due*

Aaron and his sons shall eat *too*,

With unleavened bread it shall be

Eaten in a holy place *free*,

In the court of the tent of meeting

They shall eat it *at their own seating*.

17 'It shall not be baked with *its* yeast.

I have given it *as at least*

Their portion of My offerings made

By fire, it *is* most holy aid,

Like the sin offering and trespass

Offering. 18 'All the males *who raise kvass*

Among the children of Aaron

May eat it so long as the sun

Rises on your generation,

Concerning offerings made by fire

To YHWH. Everyone with desire

To touch them must be holy *sire*."

19 And YHWH spoke to Moses, saying

20 "This Aaron and his sons' offering

They shall offer to YHWH, the day

When he's anointed: one-tenth of

An ephah of fine flour *for love*

As daily grain offering, half of

It in the morning and half of

It at night. 21 "It shall be made in

A pan with oil. *When mixed in bin*,

You shall bring it in. The baked pieces

Of the grain offering *it releases*

You shall offer *for* a sweet scent

To YHWH. 22 "The priest among his sons,

Who is anointed *when he went*,
In his place, shall its *benisons*
Offer, a statute everlasting
To YHWH, completely burned *forecasting*.
23 "Every grain offering for the priest
Shall be completely burned *till ceased*.
It shall not be eaten *for fasting*."

For this too, My Beloved, I shall dispense
With the priesthood, because of the
expense
And waste of burning flour that could be
used
By starving populace by priests abused.
How times have changed! The distribution
of
Food seems to be no longer thing of love,
If ever it were such a case. No doubt
It always was for duty in the bout.
And now it is for profit and for gain,
And politics and machinations' reign.
The mystic's answer is disarming though,
That bread and sacrifice in spirit show
And not in tangibles. Beloved, I come
With heartfelt hunger as well as the crumb.

24 And YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
25 "Tell Aaron and his sons, saying
'This *is* the law of sin offering:
In the place where the burnt offering
Is killed, the sin offering shall be
Killed before YHWH. It's most holy.
26 'The priest who offers it for sin
Shall eat it. In a holy *bin*
Place it shall be eaten, and in
The courtyard of the meeting tent.
27 'Everyone who touches its *spent*
Flesh must be holy. And when its
Blood is sprinkled on garment *knits*,
You shall wash that on which it's been
Sprinkled, in a holy place *seen*.
28 'But the earthen vessel in which
It's boiled shall be broken *to ditch*.
And if it is boiled in bronze pot,
It shall be both scoured and then *got*
And rinsed in water. 29 'All the males
Among the priests may eat its *tales*.
It is most holy. 30 'But no sin
Offering from which *any within*
Of the blood is brought to the tent
Of meeting, to make atonement
In the holy *place*, shall be eaten.

It shall be burned in fire *to sweeten*.

Another reason I reject the priest
Is that his statutes everlasting ceased
Not to make the distinction between male
And female when it comes to eating hale.
The priest and sons eat in the holy place
While wife and daughter, to save priestly
face,
Eat where they can or will as long as race
For holiness is left to manly grace.
The male tool is clearly needed for
Both propagation and for urine's store.
It neither aids nor hinders faith's domain,
So segregation of the two's not sane.
Beloved, the heavenly bread of spirit comes
To every mouth that knows to do its sums.

Leviticus 7

1 'So *is* the trespass offering's law,
It is most holy, *filled with awe*,
2 'Where they slay the burnt offering they
Shall trespass offering also slay.
And he shall sprinkle all around
Upon the altar its blood *found*.
3 'And he shall offer from it all
Its fat, the fat tail and the *caul*
Of fat that covers the entrails,
4 'The two kidneys, *it never fails*,
And the fat on them by the flanks,
And the fat on the liver's *ranks*
Above the kidneys, he'll remove,
5 'And the priest shall burn them *to prove*
An offering on the altar made
By fire to YHWH, *and not delayed*.
It is a trespass offering *slayed*.
6 'Every male among the priests may
Eat it, and eat it when they stay
In holy place. It *is* most holy.
7 'The trespass offering *and not lowly*
Is like the sin offering, *there's one*
Law for them both *how they are done*:
The priest who makes with it atonement
Shall have *it and without postponement*.
8 'The priest who offers anyone's
Burnt offering, that priest's *horizons*
Shall include for himself the skin
Of the burnt offering *without sin*
Which he has offered. 9 'Also all
Grain offerings baked *beyond recall*
In the oven and all prepared
In covered pan, or in one spared

A cover, shall be the priest's who
Offers it, *for it is his due.*

10 'Every grain offering, *whether* mixed
With oil, or dry, *however fixed,*
Shall belong to all Aaron's sons,
To one *as much* as other ones.

With all the trespassing that goes on now,
I'd hate to be a priest and kill the cow.
Imagine all the skins I'd have in tow,
And what a pile to sit and watch it grow.
What's to be done with all the skins, I say,
That are the priestly portion every day?
A man can only wear so many skins
Without them weighing down his once bare
shins.

Lay off for skins! We do not need more
veils
To hide us from Your glance before which
pales
The face and hand caught in the cookie jar.
Unveil us, my Beloved, here where we are,
And I'll retrieve the grain and give the toll
If that is what shall keep the slumbered
soul.

11 'This *is* the peace offerings' law of
The sacrifice which he *in love*
Shall offer to YHWH. 12 'And if he
Offers it for thanksgiving *spree,*
Then he shall offer sacrifice
Of thanksgiving *other things nice:*
Unleavened cakes and mixed with oil,
Unleavened wafers soaked in oil,
Or cakes of blended flour with oil.
13 'Besides the cakes, *as* his offering
He shall offer leavened bread's *ring*
With sacrifice of thanksgiving
Of his peace offering. 14 'And from it
He shall offer one cake, *as fit,*
From each offering *as a* heave offering
To YHWH. It shall belong *for proffering*
To the priest who sprinkles the blood
Of the peace offering *out in flood.*
15 'The flesh of the sacrifice of
His peace offering for thanks *and love*
Shall be eaten the same day it
Is offered. He shall not see fit
To leave till morn any of it.
16 'But if the sacrifice of his
Offering *is* a vow or then is
A voluntary offering, it

Shall be eaten the same day *writ*
That he offers his sacrifice,
But on the next day what suffice
Of the remainder of it too
May be eaten *by all the crew,*
17 'The remainder of the flesh of
The sacrifice on third day shove
To be *all* burned up in the fire.
18 'And if *any* of the flesh of
The sacrifice of peace *and love*
Offering *that's left* is eaten on
The third day, *even though at dawn,*
It shall not be accepted, nor
Shall it be imputed *before*
To his *account,* but it shall be
Abomination *for his fee*
Who offers it, and the one who
Eats of it shall be guilty *too.*
19 'The flesh that touches unclean thing
Shall not be eaten *offering.*
It shall be burned with fire. And as
For the *clean* flesh, then each who has
Been clean may eat of it. 20 'But one
Who eats the flesh of offering done
For the peace offering that *belongs*
To YHWH, while he is unclean, that
Shall be cut off where his folk's at.
21 'Moreover the person to touch
Any unclean thing, human *such,*
An unclean animal, or any
Abominable unclean *penny,*
And then who eats the sacrifice,
Flesh of the peace offering *precise,*
That *belongs* to YHWH, that one shall
Be cut off from his arsenal."
22 And YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
23 "Speak to Israel's children, saying
'You shall not eat of any fat,
Of ox or sheep or goat *or that.*
24 'And the fat of an animal
That dies a *death that's natural,*
And the fat of what is torn by
Wild beasts, may be used *on the sly*
In any other way, but you
Shall by no means eat of its *rue.*
25 'For whosoever eats the fat
Of animal of which men give
In offering made by fire to YHWH,
The person who eats *it* shall live
No longer with his folk *and crew.*
26 'Moreover you shall not eat blood
In any of your dwellings, *blood*

Of bird or beast. 27 'Whoever eats
Any blood, then that person meets
Being cut off from his folk's *treats*.'" 28 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
29 "Speak to Israel's children, saying
'He who offers the sacrifice
Of his peace offering to YHWH *nice*
Shall bring his offering to YHWH from
The sacrifices that have come
From his peace offering. 30 'His own hands
Shall bring the offerings *by commands*
Made by fire to YHWH, and the fat
With the breast he shall bring, and that
The breast may be waved *as a wave*
Offering before YHWH. 31 'And the *brave*
Priest shall burn the fat on the *place*
Of the altar, but the breast *ace*
Shall be Aaron's and his sons' *own*.
32 'Also the right thigh you'll dispense
For the priest *as a heave offering*
From the sacrifices you bring
Of your peace offerings. 33 'He among
The sons of Aaron, who has strung
The blood of the peace offering and
The fat, shall have the right thigh for
His part. 34 'For the breast *as before*
Of the wave offering and the thigh
Of the heave offering have I
Taken from Israel's folk, *and from*
The sacrifices of their peace
Offerings, and I have given *increase*
Of them to Aaron the priest and
To his sons *and to have in hand*
From the children of Israel by
A statute forever *and aye*.'" 35 This *is* the consecrated part

Let me, Beloved, not eat the sodden flesh
Of sacrifices made a day ago,
Beloved, let my thanksgiving be fresh.
I take my peace for this one day, and so
I depend on Your grace from day to day
As I seek to follow in the right way.
Let me, Beloved, not save the sacrifice,
But eat my fill, and eating it, eat twice,
Rather than put away the sweetness of
This day to eat tomorrow this day's love.
Let my praise of the day contain my all
And let me having slept hear one more call
To come with empty hand of yesterday
Bearing new sacrifices of peace's sway.

For Aaron and his sons *to start*,
From offerings made by fire to YHWH,
The day they were presented to
Minister to YHWH as priests. 36 YHWH
Commanded this be given them
From the children of Israel's *hem*,
On the day He anointed them,
A statute forever throughout
Their generations *without doubt*.
37 This *is* the law of burnt offering,
The grain offering, the sin offering,
The trespass offering, consecrations,
And sacrifice of peace offering,
38 Which YHWH commanded *in their*
stations
To Moses on Mount Sinai, on
The day when He gave *benison*
Commanding then to Israel's folk
To offer their offerings *as spoke*
YHWH in the wilderness *before*
Mount Sinai on the desert floor.

I wait here at the mountain foot to hear
Your voice, Beloved, and hold Your
message dear.

The sacrifices You demand but serve
To feed human body and soul, reserve
But blood and fat to burn, and so discern
What is not good for human tongue to
touch.

You demand little, my Beloved, not much.
My sacrifice down to my very breath
Feeds life in me and keeps me from that
death

That soon or late stalks every creature
thing.

My sacrifice, if I but stand and sing,
Feeds me, not You, and yet I come to bring
To You my love and hope and sacrifice
And pray some share for You alone suffice.

Leviticus 8

1 YHWH spoke to Moses, and told him,
2 "Take Aaron and his sons with him,
And the garments, anointing oil,
A bull as the sin offering's *spoil*,
Two rams, and a basket of bread,
3 "Unleavened, and gather the *said*
Congregation all together
At meeting tent door *to confer*."
4 So Moses did as YHWH commanded
Him, congregation *as demanded*

Was gathered together at tent
 Of meeting door. 5 And Moses *went*
 And said to the congregation,
 "This *is* what YHWH commands be done."
 6 Then Moses brought Aaron and his
 Sons, and washed them with water *fizz*.
 7 And he put the tunic on him,
 Girded him with the sash *with vim*,
 And *vigour* clothed him with the robe,
 Put ephod on him to englobe
 Him with the finely woven band
 Of the ephod, and with it spanned
The ephod on him. 8 Then he put
 The breastplate on him, and he put
 The Urim and the Thummim in
 The breastplate *showing thick and thin*.

The High Priest has upon his burning breast
 A load which cannot give his sorrow rest.
 He carries gold and precious stones for fire,
 Twelve names upon the tables of desire.
 The Urim and the Thummim, fire and
 cloud,
 Realities reveal and truths enshroud.
 What natural law engraved on human heart,
 What spark divine achieves its greater part!
 Let lovely twelve enshrined before my face
 Sip of the sacrifice of wine by grace.
 Let fire and cloud on stone lead me on still
 To precious fountains of Eloah's will.
 You awful, universal One reveal
 Reality upon my breast of steel.

9 And he put turban on his head.
 Also on the turban, in front,
 He put the golden plate, as wont,
 The holy crown, as YHWH had said
 To Moses. 10 Also Moses took
 Anointing oil, and every nook
 Of tent and all within it oiled
 And consecrated them *unspoiled*.
 11 He sprinkled some of it upon
 The altar seven times *begone*,
 Anointed the altar and all
 Its utensils, laver and stall,
 To consecrate them. 12 And he poured
 Anointing oil *out of a gourd*
 On Aaron's head anointing him,
 To consecrate him. 13 Then *to trim*
 Moses brought Aaron's sons and put
 Tunics on them, *from head to foot*,
 Girded them with sashes, and put

Hats on them, as YHWH had commanded
 Moses *to do and not left stranded*.

Anoint my head with oil, Beloved, and I
 Shall wear Your turban, and not be too shy.
 Ed Elwall felt the turban light enough
 To wear it in Wolverhampton, though
 tough.

I wonder if he so appeared in court
 When taken for his blasphemy, in short
 For interrupting sermon and the priest
 And saying You are not three in the least,
 But one and only one by high decree
 Of the first of commandments for the free.
 With turban I pronounce that You are one,
 With sash I submit as Your servant won,
 With oil I sacrifice myself to You,
 Beloved, in everything I say and do.

14 And he brought the bull for the sin
 Offering. Aaron and sons *to win*
 Laid their hands on the head of bull
 For the sin offering, 15 *dutiful*
 Moses killed *it*. Then he took blood,
 And put *some* on the horns *in flood*
 Of the altar and all around
 With his finger, and cleansed *the ground*
 Of the altar. He poured the blood
 At the base of the altar, and
 Consecrated it to make stand
 Atonement for it. 16 Then he took
 All the fat on entrails, and shook
 The fatty lobe *on* liver, and
 The two kidneys with their fat *band*,
 And Moses burned *them* on the altar.
 17 But bull, skin, flesh, offal, no falter,
 He burned with fire outside the camp,
 As YHWH commanded Moses *vamp*.
 18 Then he brought the ram as the burnt
 Offering, and Aaron and sons learnt
 To lay their hands on head of ram,
 19 And Moses killed *it with one slam*.
 Then he sprinkled the blood around
 All on the altar, *not the ground*.
 20 And he cut the ram into pieces,
 And Moses burned the head, the pieces,
 And fat. 21 Then he washed the entrails
 And the legs in water, *no fails*.
 And Moses burned the whole ram on
 The altar, a burnt sacrifice
 For a sweet aroma *till dawn*,
 An offering made by fire *and nice*

To YHWH, as YHWH commanded Moses.
 22 He brought the second ram *that closes*,
 The ram of consecration. Then
 Aaron and his sons laid *like men*
 Their hands on the head of the ram,
 23 And Moses killed *it with one slam*.
 Also he took *some* of its blood
 And put it on the tip *or bud*
 Of Aaron's right ear, on the thumb
 Of his right hand, and *then to come*
 On the big toe of his right foot.
 24 Then he brought Aaron's sons and put,
 Did Moses, *some* of the blood on
 The tips of their right ears, upon
 The thumbs of their right hands, and on
 The big toes of their right feet, and
 Moses sprinkled the blood *at hand*
 All around on the altar. 25 Then
 He took the fat and the fat tail,
 All the fat that *was on entrail*,
 The fatty lobe *attached like wen*
 To the liver, the two kidneys
 And their fat, right thigh, *if you please*,
 26 And from the basket of the bread
 Unleavened that was before YHWH
 He took one yeastless cake, the said
 Cake of bread *spread with oil as due*,
 And one wafer, and put *them* on
 The fat and on the right thigh *drawn*,
 27 And he put all in Aaron's hands
 And *also* in Aaron's sons' hands,
 And waved them *as* a wave offering
 Before YHWH. 28 Moses took each thing
 From their hands and burned on the altar,
 On the burnt offering *without falter*.
 They *were* consecration offerings
 For the sweet aroma *it brings*.
 That *was* an offering made by fire
 To YHWH. 29 And Moses did acquire
 Breast and waved it *there* as a wave
 Offering before YHWH *as His slave*.
 It was Moses' part of the ram
 Of consecration oriflamme,
Just as YHWH had commanded Moses.
 30 Then Moses took *some, as discloses*,
 Of the anointing oil and some
 Of the blood which *was* on the *thumb*
Of the altar, and sprinkled *it*
 On Aaron, on his garments *fit*,
 On his sons, on the garments of
 His sons with him, *as shown above*,
 And consecrated Aaron, and

His garments, his sons *out of hand*,
 And garments of his sons *to stand*.

Put no blood on the tip of my right ear,
 Beloved, nor on my thumb and toe for fear
 That I shall follow after heathen gifts
 Of sacrifice such as sweet Christian lifts.
 The covenant is ratified with meal,
 And all meals that taste sweet in desert seal
 The promise with a sacrifice and slaughter.
 That does not mean that Your son or your
 daughter

Like Canaanite must get the axe before
 You lay grace and salvation at the door.
 I understand the reason for the blood
 On ear-tip, but I do not love the flood
 Of Ashtoreth at mass and in the grail.
 You are enough in grace to lift the veil.

31 And Moses said to Aaron and
 His sons, "Boil the flesh *at the hand*
Of the door of the tent of meeting,
 And eat it there with bread *at seating*,
 That's in the basket consecrated
 For offerings *there*, as I have stated,
 Saying 'Aaron and his sons shall
 Eat it *and not be prodigal*.'

32 "What remains of the flesh and of
 The bread you shall burn *as above*
 With fire. 33 "And you shall not go out
 Of meeting tent door *without doubt*
For seven days, until the days
 Of consecration *and delays*
 Are ended. And for seven days
 He shall consecrate you. 34 "As he
 Has done this day, *so* YHWH will see
 That it is done to make for you
 Atonement. 35 "And so therefore you
 Shall stay *at* the door of the tent
 Of meeting day and night forespent
 For seven days, and keep the charge
 Of YHWH, so that you may *at large*
 Not die, for so I've been commanded."
 36 So Aaron and his sons *remanded*
 Did all the things that YHWH had said
 And by the hand of Moses led.

Ah, my Beloved, and seven days within
 Your house alone and without any sin!
 Let me to take the consecration now
 And have the gold and turban on my brow!
 I shall spend seven days within the shade

Of those white linen arms that finely made
 A refuge from the sun and cloud and all
 The burning desert sand that must appal.
 A doorkeeper perhaps, but if not that
 Let me at least wait and serve and get fat.
 I frolic with the sons of Aaron still,
 Who eat the scentless bread and take the
 pill.

Let me not die before I've been within
 Your house alone and without any sin!

Week 26 Leviticus 9

1 It happened on the eighth day that
 Moses called Aaron *where he's at*
 And his sons and the elders of
 Israel. 2 And he said to *above*
 Aaron, "Take for yourself a young
 Bull as a sin offering and sung,
 And a ram as a burnt offering,
 Without blemish, *also to sing*
 And offer *them* before YHWH. 3 "And
 To children of Israel's command
 You shall speak, saying "Take a kid
 Of the goats as sin offering's *bid*,
 And a calf and a lamb, *both of*
 The first year, without blemish, *love*,
 As a burnt offering, 4 'also bull
 And a ram as peace offerings *full*,
 To sacrifice before YHWH, and
 A grain offering mixed with oil *stand*,
 For today YHWH appears to you." 5
 So they brought what Moses *as due*
 Commanded before meeting tent.
 And all the congregation drew
 Near and stood before where YHWH *went*.
 6 Then Moses said "This *is* the thing
 Which YHWH commanded you to bring,
 And the glory of YHWH appears
 To you." 7 Moses said *without tears*
 To Aaron, "Go to the altar,
 Offer your sin offering, refer
 Your burnt offering, make atonement
 For yourself and the people *sent*.
 Offer the offering of the folk,
 Make their atonement as YHWH spoke."

With all the animals and bleating sheep
 And goats and oxen neighing, I can't sleep.
 What use is all this bringing to the tent
 Such beasts to slay and bleed and be
 content?

I love not flesh nor steak to fill my broth,

Nor do I demand such when I am wroth.
 The priesthood reeks, it seems, with
 flowing blood,

And this is holy atonement in cud.
 Like You, Beloved, I'm weary of the tune
 Of sacrifice to You, or sun or moon.
 There's no good thing will come of this, I
 swear,

I feel it in my bones and in the air.
 I step into the dergah, slip and fall
 On all the blood splashed there upon the
 wall.

8 Aaron therefore went to the altar,
 Killed the sin offering calf, *no falter*,
 Which *was* for himself. 9 Then the sons
 Of Aaron brought the blood *that runs*
 To him, he dipped his finger in
 The blood, and put *it* on the fin
 Of the horns of the altar, and
 Poured the blood at the altar's *hand*
 At the base. 10 But as for the fat,
 The kidneys, and the ridge of fat
 From the liver of the sin offering
 He burned on the altar, and proffering
 As YHWH had commanded Moses.
 11 *But* the flesh and the hide *of this*
 He burned with fire outside the camp.
 12 And he killed the burnt offering *damp*,
 And Aaron's sons gave him the blood,
 Which he sprinkled all *in a flood*
 Round on the altar. 13 Then they gave
 The burnt offering to him *to save*
 With its pieces and head, and he
 Burned *them* on the altar. 14 And he
 Washed the entrails and the legs, and
 Burned *them* with the burnt offering *bland*
 On the altar. 15 Then he brought out
 The people's offering, *without doubt*,
 And took the goat, which *was* the sin
 Offering for the people *within*,
 And killed and offered it for sin,
 Like the first one. 16 And then he brought
 The burnt offering offered as taught.
 17 Then he brought the grain offering, took
 A handful of it, and then shook
 And burned *it* on the altar, tossed
 Beside the morning holocaust.
 18 He also killed the bull and ram
 As peace offerings in sacrifice,
 Which *were* for the folk *without sham*.
 And Aaron's sons gave him the blood,

Which he sprinkled all round in flood
 On the altar, 19 and as for fat
 From the bull and the ram and that
 Fatty tail, what covers and yet
 The kidneys, and the fats that get
 On the liver, 20 they put the fat
 On the breasts. Then he burned the fat
 On the altar, 21 but the breasts and
 The right thigh Aaron waved *in hand*
 As a wave offering before YHWH,
 As Moses commanded *to do*.
 22 Then Aaron lifted up his hand
 Toward the people, blessed them, and
 Came down from offering the sin offering,
 The burnt offering, and the peace offering.

Here's confirmation of the magic trick:
 A blessing's done by raising, thin or thick,
 A hand above the people. Bless me now,
 Beloved, there is no priest nor slaughtered
 cow.

That's where, I guess, the gold-clad priests
 learned how.

They go beyond the text in making crosses,
 When Aaron only raised a hand for losses.
 Such priests come down also from the high
 altar

And making sacrifices without falter
 For sin, for burnt offering, and last for
 peace.

They stove the meat and substituted fleece
 Of human flesh in bread and wine's
 increase.

Let each bring his own sacrifice and meet
 A hand raised up in blessing on the street.

23 And Moses and Aaron went in
 The tent of meeting *without sin*,
 And came out and blessed *all* the folk.
 Then YHWH's glory before them broke
 Out to all the people, 24 and fire
 Came out from before YHWH's *attire*
 And consumed the burnt offering and
 The fat on the altar *at hand*.
 When all the people saw, they shouted
 And fell on their faces *redoubted*.

I thought the raised hand was a trick
 indeed,

But that was nothing to the show and creed
 Of Your appearing in a fire and cloud
 And breaking out consuming by the crowd.

The feat of meat that caught on fire was
 such
 The people shouted in surprise, then touch
 The earth with foreheads to escape the
 bright
 And burning fire that showed them what
 was right.
 What glory broke out from the pair of
 brothers
 Upon the people, all the sons of mothers?
 Who knows? But glory is a thing to covet,
 And I seek glory before others shove it.
 Beloved, set glory in my silent cell
 Where I in contemplation of You dwell.

Leviticus 10

1 Then Nadab and Abihu, sons
 Of Aaron, each took his censer
 And put fire in it, incense buns,
 And offered profane fire *to stir*
 Before YHWH, which thing He had not
 Commanded them. 2 So fire went out
 From YHWH and burned them, and they
 died

Before YHWH, *sin could not abide*.

3 And Moses said to Aaron, "This
 Is what YHWH spoke, *and not amiss*,
 'By those who come near Me I must
 Be held as holy, *not as dust*,
 And glorified by all the people.'
 So Aaron said nor church nor steeple.

The deaf and blind ask but one question
 here.

Is glory sanctified in more than fear?
 In four-fold rising pitches Moses speaks
 What in one word all the creation seeks.
 This, this it is. The rest is for the rabble,
 Vain explanations above vainer babble.
 Such vanity when set to Your own tune
 Becomes the gate to an eternal noon.
 Such words on words must sometime come
 to rest

And thus lead into glories, what is best.
 The sons of Aaron die in drunkenness.
 The prohibition says he must not bless.
 Bewildered by the wisdom of release,
 The High Priest chooses now to hold his
 peace.

4 And then Moses called Mishael,
 Elzaphan, sons of Uzziel

The uncle of Aaron , and said
 To them, "Come near, carry *the dead*
 Your brothers from before the tent
 Out of the camp." 5 And so they went
 Near and carried them by the cloak
 Out of the camp, as Moses spoke.
 6 And Moses said to Aaron, and
 To Eleazar, Ithamar, sons,
 "Do not uncover, *understand*,
 Your heads nor tear your clothes *in runs*,
 Lest you die, and wrath come upon
 All of the people. Let be on
 Your brothers, all of Israel's room,
 To wail the burning and *the doom*
 Which YHWH has kindled *in the gloom*.
 7 "You shall not go out from the door
 Of the tent of the meeting, for
 You would die, since anointing oil
 Of YHWH *is on you for your toil*."
 And they acted according to
 The word of Moses, *what to do*.
 8 Then YHWH spoke to Aaron, saying
 9 "Do not drink intoxicating
 Drink or wine, you, nor your sons too
 With you, when you enter into
 The tent of meeting, lest you die.
It shall be a statute forever
Stopped from your generations *never*,
 10 "That you may distinguish between
 Holy, unholy, clean, unclean,
 11 "And that you may teach the children
 Of Israel all the statutes when
 YHWH has spoken to them by hand
 Of Moses *to give His command*."

For four things alcohol disqualifies.
 It first disqualifies for prayer and sacrifice,
 And then for knowing what is holy and
 What is unholy, then to understand
 What is unclean and clean. The ones who
 taste
 The poison draught and then make awful
 haste
 To tell another what is right and wrong
 Based on Your divine law or on a song
 Must err and cannot by their reason say
 The true thing and the just. This simple
 way
 Determines quickly what usurper takes
 Authority in church and state and makes
 A theatre and fraud of truth. I hide
 My face, Beloved, may You alone abide.

12 And Moses spoke to Aaron, and
 To Eleazar his son and
 Ithamar, *also* his son who
 Were left, "Take the grain offering *stew*
 That remains of the offerings made
 By fire to YHWH, and eat arrayed
 Without yeast there beside the altar,
 For it's most holy *without falter*.
 13 "You shall eat it in holy place,
 Because it *is* your due and *grace*
 And your sons' due, of sacrifice
 Made by fire to YHWH *to suffice*,
 For so I have been commanded.
 14 "The breast of the wave offering *slid*
 And the thigh of heave offering you
 Shall eat in a clean place, *both* you,
 And your sons, and your daughters too,
 For *they are* your due and your *grace*
 And your sons' due, *which are in place*
 Given from the peace offerings' part
 Of Israel's children *from the heart*.
 15 "The thigh of the heave offering and
 The breast of wave offering *in hand*
 They shall bring with the offerings of
 Fat made by fire, to offer *love*
 As a wave offering before YHWH.
 And it shall be yours and the due
 Of your sons' with you, by a law
 Forever, as YHWH is in awe."

The thing is too complex, I trow, for those
 Who are in sorrow for their brothers' close.
 What thigh is burnt and what is eaten wears
 A choice too delicate to put on airs.
 Trade torched breast for scorched thigh and
 wheat for wave
 And no one near the tent knows what to
 save.
 The fat and lean perch on the altar fire
 Before the brazen mirrors to admire
 The run of mill and flood of blood that
 blooms
 Before the veils of blue and shining rooms.
 Let sons and daughters of the stricken
 priest
 Come to a clean and holy place to feast
 While I, Beloved, burn in the blazing flame
 Of love and ecstasy before Your name.

16 Then Moses made careful inquiry
 About the sin offering goat wiry,

And it was burnt, so he was mad
 At Eleazar and *the sad*
 Ithamar, sons of Aaron *who*
Were left, saying 17 "Why did you do
 This and not eat what was your due
 Of the sin offering in a place
 Holy, since it's most holy too,
 And *Alohim* has given it you
 To bear the guilt *before His face*
 Of all the congregation, to
 Make an atonement for them by
 YHWH? 18 "See! Its blood *to gratify*
 Was not brought in the holy *place*,
 Indeed you should have eaten it
 In a holy *place*, by my writ."
 19 And Aaron said to Moses, "Look,
 This day they've offered *it and took*
 Their sin offering, burnt offering *too*
 Before YHWH, and such things *in rue*
 Have happened to me! *If I'd* eaten
 The sin offering today *unbeaten*,
 Would it have been accepted by
 The sight of YHWH *up in the sky?*"
 20 So when Moses heard *him say that*,
 He was contented *where he sat*.

Aaron can take the death of drunken boys,
 But on the same day those who change
 their ploys
 To be of all a sudden priest and slayer
 Ought not to be upbraided in their prayer
 Though it is wrong. Some days must be
 spent in
 Learning the ins and outs of priestly sin.
 Meek Moses, knowing laws and frills to
 full
 Has too much in the pail to make a pull.
 Yet Aaron mourns unworthy drunken crew
 Struck so fast they did not know what to
 do.
 I bring strange fire and inept steps to You,
 Beloved, and yet I find Your face is true.
 Keep me beyond the holy blood and meat
 Where meeting You alone is all my treat.

Leviticus 11

1 Now YHWH spoke to Moses and to
 Aaron, saying to them, 2 "Speak to
 The children of Israel, and say
 'These *are* the animals to slay
 For food among all beasts that stray
 Upon the earth. 3 'Among the beasts,

Whatever divides hoof *and pieced*,
 Having cloven hooves *and* the cud
 Chewing, that eat *without the blood*.
 4 'Nevertheless these you shall not
 Eat among those that chew the cud
 Or those that have cloven hooves' lot:
 The camel, though it chews the cud
 But does not have cloven hooves, is
 Unclean to you, 5 'the rock hyrax,
 Because it chews the cud *of his*
 But does not have the cloven tracks,
Is unclean to you, 6 'so the hare,
 Because it chews the cud *right fair*
 But does not have cloven hooves, *it*
Is unclean to you *and unfit*,
 7 'And the swine, though the hoof dividing,
 Having cloven hooves, yet deriding
 To chew the cud's unclean to you.
 8 'Their flesh you shall not eat, eschew
 To touch their carcasses, for they
Are unclean to you *in the way*.

The holy Qur'an gives in grace to eat
 The camel and its flesh for desert treat.
 The Arab woodlands when this word was
 spoken
 Budded and bloomed, but now with only
 token
 Of foliage all the land is bare with stone.
 The camel crosses its dry reach alone.
 And so You give the desert sons their sweet
 To eat the flesh of camels and broiled meat.
 But every other rabbit and swine still
 Fall under the command Thou shalt not
 kill.
 I kill no rabbit and no swine, nor touch
 Their carcasses, nor eat their flesh as much.
 Let others, my Beloved, eat and be merry.
 I rest my case on the sweet Black Sea
 cherry.

9 'These you may eat of all that *swim*
 In the water, what *seraphim*
 In the water have fins and scales,
 Whether in the seas *with the whales*
 Or in the rivers, you may eat.
 10 'But all in the seas *that have feet*,
 Or in the rivers that do not
 Have fins and scales, all that are taught
 To move in the water or any
 Living thing which *is among many*
 In the water, they *are* to you

Abomination's *barbecue*.

11 'They shall be an abomination
To you, you shall not eat *a ration*
Of their flesh, but you shall regard
Their carcasses as *a bad card*
And an abomination *so*.

12 'Whatever in the waters go
Without fins or scales, that *shall show*
You an abomination's *row*.

13 'And these you shall regard among
The birds abomination wrung,
They shall not be eaten *at all*,
They *are* abomination's *fall*:
The eagle, and the vulture, and
The buzzard, 14 '*and* the kite in brand,
The falcon after its kind too,
15 'Every raven and for its due,
16 'The ostrich, the short-eared owl *too*,
The sea gull, and the hawk with relative,
17 'The little owl, *also compellative*
The fisher owl, and the screech owl,
18 'The white owl, the jackdaw *for fowl*,
And carrion vulture, 19 '*and* the stork,
The heron and its kind *like pork*,
The hoopoe, and the bat *on fork*.

Such birds as do not flap their wings when
flying

Are not man's meat when slaughtered or
when dying.

The bat makes an exception and for which
I do not open mouth though wings in hitch
Flap in the night. A shame indeed to kill
The gallant eagle flying on the hill.

The stupid chicken is another breed,
And killing such is not like killing steed.
And yet, Beloved, I find the chicken's sail
Compels the heart as well as peacock's tail.
I shall obey and eat, if I fulfil
Your just command, and yet the ostrich still
Seems greater sin on those who bear the
knife

To take away that noble bird's dear life.

20 'All flying insects that creep on
All fours shall be abomination
To you. 21 'Yet these *within their station*
You may eat of insect *and spawn*
Flying that creeps on *all its* fours:
Those which have jointed legs *in scores*
Above their feet with which to leap
Upon the earth. 22 'These you may *heap*

In piles to eat: the locust after
Its kind, destroying locust's *laughter*
After its kind, the cricket and
Its relative, and the grasshopper
After its kind. 23 'But every *popper*
Of other flying insects which
Have four feet *shall be in the ditch*
Abomination in your hand.

How few eat locusts though You say the
word.

I know why after one thing that occurred.
My daughter cantillated from the book
Of Your sweet law one day. A locust took
Its way along the railing and the step,
To stop frenetic hopping's vim and pep
And stayed to listen to the style and tune.
In beauty and in pleasure it was soon
A-basking by the raspberry vines and door.
As long as she stayed there to sing the
score

The locust settled on the step to hear.
When she was silent then it turned its ear
Back to its own and hopped away again.
Beloved, the locust hears better than men.

24 'By these you shall become unclean,
Whoever touches, *though unseen*,
The carcass of any of them
Shall be unclean till evening's *hem*.

25 'Who bears their carcasses away
Shall wash his clothes and unclean stay
Until the very close of day.

26 '*The carcass* of any beast which
Divides the foot, but *in the glitch*
Is not cloven-hoofed or does not
Chew cud's unclean to you *as taught*.

All who touch it shall be unclean.

27 'And whatever goes on the green
Upon its paws, among all kinds
Of animals that go *as finds*

On fours, those *are* unclean to you.
Whoever touches *in the queue*
Any such carcass is unclean

Until evening. 28 'Whoever's *seen*
Bearing *such* carcass shall wash his
Clothes and be unclean till it is
Evening. *It is* unclean to you.

29 'These also *are* unclean to you
Among the creeping things *a-creeping*
Upon the earth: the mole, the *reaping*
Mouse, and the large lizard and kind,

The unclean and between the clean,
And between *every* beast that may
Be eaten and the beasts that stay
Uneaten *in the holy way.*'''

You sent Your prophets in the world to
show
What is unclean and what clean on the go,
And what is holy and unholy by
Their treatment of Your holy Word and
high.
Without prophets, these days we're
democratic,
Make no distinction among the aquatic,
Between clean and unclean cellar to attic,
But treat each reigning rat with rectitudes
Deserving of the holiest of dudes.
I flee to You, Beloved, and to Your Word
Revealing what is clean and not the turd,
To know what is the holy, and so find
What's truly human in a world gone blind,
And there my heart and soul unspoiled are
stirred.

Week 27 Leviticus 12

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
2 "Speak to folk of Israel, saying
'If a woman has conceived, and
Borne a male child, then she shall stand
Unclean for seven days, as in
The days of her usual spin
She shall be unclean. 3 'And upon
The eighth day the flesh of foreskin
Shall be circumcised *after dawn*.
4 'She shall continue then in blood
Of purifying for the bud
Of thirty-three days, she'll not touch
The hallowed thing, nor come as such
Into the sanctuary till
The days for purity fulfil.
5 'But if she bears a female child,
Then she shall be unclean or soiled
Two weeks, as in her usual way
And she shall continue to stay
In blood till *her* purity pay
For sixty-five days and a day.
6 'When the days of her purity
Are filled, whether for son or *wee*
Daughter, she shall bring to the priest
A lamb of the first year as *feast*
Of a burnt offering, and a young
Pigeon or turtledove, *neck wrung*,

As a sin offering, to the door
Of meeting tent *to make the score*.
7 'Then he shall offer it before
YHWH, and make atonement for her.
And she shall be clean *as it were*
From the flow of her blood. And this
Is law for her who has *in bliss*
Borne male or female. 8 'And if she
Is not able to bring in fee
A lamb, then she may bring along
Two turtledoves or *for a song*
Two young pigeons, one as a burnt
Offering, the other as *was learnt*
A sin offering. So the priest shall
Make atonement *uxorial*
For her, and she'll be one clean gal.''''

For male the time to purity is won
In forty days with circumcision done.
Instead of circumcision the girl child
Is given forty more and unbuggled.
I bring a pigeon instead of a lamb,
Since a poor dervish is all that I am.
For forty days I chant the forty Psalms
And wait for glory here beneath the palms.
My mother Wisdom still bleeds from my
birth
And crouches in her labour on the earth.
Unclean, Beloved, I come to You in turn
To let the sacrifice and sin gift burn.
Though eighty days require the female
right,
I reach for ninety and stay in Your sight.

Leviticus 13

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses and to
Aaron, saying 2 "When a man's due
To have a swelling on the skin
Of his body, a scab therein,
Or a bright spot, and it becomes
On the skin of his body *bums*
Like a leprous sore, then he shall
Be brought to Aaron *pastoral*
And priest or to one of his sons
The priests. 3 "The priest shall check *his*
buns,
The sore on the skin of the body,
And if the hair on the sore *gaudy*
Has turned white, and the sore appears
To be deeper than skin adheres
On his body, it's leprous sore.
Then the priest shall examine more

And pronounce him unclean. 4 "But if
The bright spot *is* white on *the skiff*
Of skin of his body, and does
Not appear deeper than it was
On skin, and its hair has not turned
White, then the priest, *for what he's*
learned,

Shall isolate for seven days
The one who has sores *on his stays*.
5 "And the priest shall examine him
On the seventh day *when grown dim*,
And indeed *if* the sore appears
To be as it was, *for all fears*,
And the sore has not spread on skin,
Then the priest shall again put in
Isolation seven days more.
6 "Then the priest shall look at the sore
Again on the seventh day, and
Indeed *if* the sore has faded,
And the sore has not spread *its lid*
Upon the skin, then the priest shall
Pronounce him clean *and capital*,
It *is only* a scab, and he
Shall wash his clothes and clean shall be.

I come to Your tent door to find Your face,
And find instead I enter judgement place.
For blemish I am sent out on the week
To see how days of discourse spot my
cheek.

For seven days I roam the naked world
Set in ward from Your presence and
uncurled.

I roam to pass the time until I may
Return to You upon the seventh day.
I pray to find with You the Sabbath
blessing

Binding up wounds, pouring on them a
dressing

Of wine and oil to sacrifice my fame.
I come again, reciting Your sweet name.
Beloved, if I am leprous or one clean,
It is all one, once seventh day is seen.

7 "But if the scab should be at all
Spread on the skin, after the call
Seen by the priest for his cleansing,
He'll once more be seen by the priest.

8 "And *if again* priest sees that thing
Of scab has indeed spread at least
Upon the skin, then the priest shall
Pronounce him unclean *physical*.

It *is* a leprosy. 9 "And when
The leprous sore appears on men,
Then they shall be brought to the priest.
10 "And the priest shall check out *at least*,
And indeed *if* the swelling on
The skin *is* white, *at dusk or dawn*,
And it has turned the hair white *too*,
And *there's* a spot of raw flesh too
There in the swelling, 11 "it's an old
Leprosy on body skin *cold*.
The priest shall pronounce him unclean,
And not keep him from being seen,
For *he is already* unclean.

12 "And if the leprosy breaks out
All over the skin, *without doubt*,
And leprosy's on all the skin
Of *one who has* the sore therein,
From his head to his foot, wherever
The priest looks, 13 "then the priest *as*
clever
Shall consider, and indeed *if*
The leprosy *in such a jiff*
Has covered all his body, he
Shall pronounce *him* clean *with* the sore.
It's turned all white, he's clean *in corps*.

14 "But when raw flesh appears on him,
He shall be unclean *life and limb*.

15 "And the priest shall check out the raw
Flesh and pronounce him *by the law*
To be unclean, *because* the raw
Flesh *is* unclean. It's leprosy.

16 "Or if the raw flesh comes to be
Changed and turns white again, he shall
Come to the priest *original*.

17 "And the priest shall examine him,
And indeed *if* the sore *once dim*
Has turned white, then the priest shall say
That he is clean of the sore's sway.

White skin appears to be here in this law
Result of irreparable faux-pas.
The leprosy has run its course until
No regimen nor quarantine fit bill.
Despite my native Indian ancestry
I am the white sheep of my family,
With skin as white and leprous as the snow
That covers the ground where I live and
grow.

I thank You, my Beloved, that such a fate
That cannot be repaired by milk or mate,
Is by Your law declared both fit and clean,
So that I may walk out and still be seen.

Whether comely and black or rated white,
Beloved, let me be clean here in Your
sight.

18 "And if the body has produced
A boil in the skin, and *reduced*
It is healed, 19 "and in the place of
The boil there comes a white above
In swelling or a bright spot of
Reddish-white, then it shall be shown
To the priest, 20 "and *if*, when the *lone*
Priest sees it, it indeed *appears*
Deeper than the skin *when it clears*,
And its hair has turned white, the priest
Shall pronounce him unclean, at least
It is a leprous sore which has
Broken out of the boil *whereas*.
21 "But if the priest examines it,
And indeed no white hairs in it
Appear, and it is not deeper
Than the skin, but has light colour,
Then the priest shall isolate him
Seven days, 22 "and then if the skim
Should at all spread over the skin,
Then the *good* priest shall *without sin*
Pronounce him unclean. It's a sore
That's leprous. 23 "But if the bright spot
Stays in one place, not spread *a dot*,
It is the scar of the boil, and
The priest shall call him clean *at hand*.

Look not upon the white hairs on my hand!
My hairs are white from start and so they
stand!

Your law is given in the desert mark
And made for those whose hairs were
grown out dark.

For that it is, Beloved, You speak again
To send the holy Qur'an among men,
So that the laws once made particular
Shall be addressed once more spectacular
And made commanding all the universe.
And yet I do not think Your Torah worse
For being sung upon the desert sand.
My black hairs, few they were, have met
the band,

Turned grey to find a common delight in
The white ones growing clean and without
sin.

24 "Or if the body receives burn
On its skin by fire, *weak or stern*,

And the raw *flesh* of the burn starts
To be a bright spot, *or in parts*
Reddish-white or white, 25 "then the priest
Shall look at it, and *at the least*
If the hair of the bright spot's turned
White *where the skin had once been*
burned,

And it appears deeper than skin,
It's leprosy appearing in
The burn. Therefore the priest shall say
He is unclean, leprous sore's *sway*.
26 "But if the priest examines it,
And indeed *there are* no hairs *fit*
To be called white in the bright spot,
And it's not deeper than *a dot*
Upon the skin, but became light,
Then the priest shall keep him in sight
For seven days. 27 "And the priest shall
Check him out *soul and physical*
The seventh day. If it's at all
Spread on the skin, the priest shall call
Him unclean. It's a leprous sore.
28 "But if the bright spot stays *in store*
In one place, *and* has not spread out
Upon the skin, but faded out,
It is a swelling from the burn.
The priest shall call him *stem and stern*
Clean, for it's the scar from the burn.

I'm scarred, Beloved, from the burns I
receive

From coming to You in the burning weave
Of Your love's flame. I run into the game
And like the moth am burned before Your
name.

Look not upon the burnt flesh where I live,
Nor on the paltry offering that I give.
Look not on righteous deeds, Beloved,
abhor

The failures of good deeds upon my floor.
Instead cast me again into the fire
Of Your love's burning and my sole desire,
And when I come out with my burns
unbound

Look on unholy flesh and call it sound.
So in my fire and leprosy I take
Another sip for burning loving's sake.

29 "If man or woman has a sore
On head or in the beard *what's more*,
30 "Then the priest shall look at the sore,
And indeed if it's deeper than

The skin, *and if in it you can*
See thin and yellow hair, the priest
Shall pronounce him unclean *released*.
It is a scaly leprosy

Of the head or beard *you can see*.
31 "But if the priest looks at the sore
With scales, and indeed it's not more
Deep than the skin, and *there's* no black
Hair in it, then the priest shall keep
Him in ward *to both wake and sleep*
For seven days. 32 "And on the *last*
And seventh day the priest shall cast
A look upon the sore, indeed

If the scale has not spread *with speed*,
And there's no yellow hair in it,
And the scale does not seem to fit
Deeper than the skin, 33 "he shall shave
Himself, but the scale he'll not shave.
And the priest shall keep him in ward
With the scale seven more days *bored*.
34 "On the seventh day the priest shall
Check out the scale *and corporal*,
And indeed *if* the scale has not
Spread on the skin *in other spot*,
And does not appear deeper than
The skin, the priest shall call *the man*
Clean, then he'll wash his clothes and be
Clean. 35 "But if the scale at all be
Spread over the skin after he
Is cleansed, 36 "then the priest shall check
him,

And indeed *if* the scale, *though dim*,
Has spread over the skin, the priest
Need not seek yellow hair *increased*,
He *is* unclean. 37 "But if the scale
Appears to be unchanged, and hale
And black hair has grown up in it,
The scale has healed, *the man is fit*,
He's clean, the priest shall call him fit.

You think of everything, Beloved, You do.
Your holy law relates to hat and shoe
And everything between. You even note
The case of when a woman's bearded coat
Contains a sore, and what to do and when.
Thus You take count of women, not just
men.

If in the infancy of human race
You show such gallantry, mercy and grace,
Surely now that we've baked and dried a
while

And come near to perfection, You still
smile,
Unless, of course, the things this race has
done
Have tried Your patience now beyond the
sun.
Beloved, I flee to You from good and fair
As from the evil shadows everywhere.

38 "If a man or woman has bright
Spots on skin of the body, white
Bright spots, 39 "then the priest shall look,
and

Indeed *if* the bright spots *at hand*
Upon the body skin *are* dull
White, it is a white spot *and null*
That grows on the skin. He *is* clean.
40 "As for the man whose hair's come out
From off his head, and without doubt
He's bald, *but he is* clean. 41 "He whose
Hair's fallen from his forehead, *news*
Is he's bald on the forehead, *but*
He's clean. 42 "And if there is *somewhat*
On the bald head or bald forehead
A reddish-white sore, it *is said*
To be a leprous breaking out
On his bald head or *as a sprout*
On his bald forehead. 43 "Then the priest
Shall check it out, and *if the least*
Swelling of the sore's reddish-white
On his bald head or on *the light*
Of his bald forehead, as the looks
Of leprosy *as shown in books*
Upon the body skin, 44 "then he
Is leprous and unclean, he'll be
Pronounced unclean by priest, his sore
Is on his head. 45 "Do not ignore
The leper on whom the sore's *found*,
His clothes shall be torn, head unbound,
And he shall cover up his mouth,
Cry, 'Unclean! Unclean!' *north and south*.
46 "He shall be unclean, all the days
He has the sore he'll be unclean.
He *is* unclean, shall live unseen,
Alone, his dwelling *in the ways*
Outside the camp *where no one strays*.

The dhikr or remembrance of the one
Confirmed with leprosy's beneath the sun
Or in the rain to cry when he goes out
"Unclean, unclean" as he walks round
about.

I thank You, my Beloved, though I am
bald,
Uncleanness is not on that matter called.
Yet I too have the words of recitation
From week to week upon my Sabbath
ration.
I call Your names, I sing the cantillation
Of Torah and Qur'an for a brief hour.
I add to those sweet words remembrance
sour
To call since I'm a dervish dog to run.
"Unclean, unclean" I bark at every bush
And slink away from glittering crowds that
push.

47 "Also, if a garment has plague
Of leprosy in it, *though vague*
On woollen garment or on cloak
Of linen, 48 "whether *it be spoke*
In warp or woof of linen or
Of wool, whether in or before
Leather or anything made of
Leather, 49 "and if the plague *above*
Is greenish or reddish upon
The garment or in leather *drawn*,
Whether in the warp or in woof,
Or in anything else made *proof*
Of leather, it's a leprous plague
And shall be shown the priest *not vague*.
50 "The priest shall check the plague and
keep

In ward the plague thing seven days.
51 "And he shall check the plague and peep
At it on the seventh of days.
If the plague has spread in the cloth,
Either in warp or woof, *no moth*,
In the leather *or* anything
Made of leather *in fall or spring*,
The plague's an active leprosy.
It is unclean for all to see.
52 "He shall therefore burn that garment
In which is the plague *or its scent*,
Whether warp or woof, or in wool
Or in linen, or any full
Of leather, for it *is* an active
Leprosy, *it shall be dettractive*
And burned in fire. 53 "But if the priest
Examines *it*, finds not increased
The plague upon the garment spread,
Either in warp or woof *with dread*,
Or anything made of leather,
54 "Then the priest shall command confer

That they should wash what has the plague,
And he shall keep in a ward *vague*
Another seven days. 55 "The priest
Shall look at the plague when they've
ceased

Its washing, and if it's not changed
The colour of the plague, though ranged
No further spreading, it's unclean,
And you shall burn *to contravene*
It in the fire, consuming still
Damage outside or in *the fill*.

56 "If the priest checks and finds it fade
After the plague washing is made,
Then he shall tear it out of place,
Whether out of the warp or trace
Out of the woof, or leather *fine*.
57 "If it appears again in twine,
Either in warp or woof, or in
Anything made of leather skin,
It *is* a spreading *plague*, you'll burn
With fire what the plague *blights in turn*.
58 "And if you wash the garment *too*,
Either warp or woof, *to be true*,
Or what is made of leather skin,
If the plague's disappeared within,
Then it shall be washed once again,
And shall be clean *before all men*.
59 "This *is* the law of leprous plague
In a garment *not to be vague*
Of wool or linen, either in
The warp or woof, or any skin,
To call clean or unclean therein."

My wife's father when asked to take a cur
And bury it by those who lost its fur,
Returned from funeral with dog-skin gloves
And so he lost the neighbour's heart and
loves.

Is there a law for dog-skin leprosy,
Or does all dog-skin lack in purity?
I come to dergah to be slaughtered now,
A dervish dog from bare foot to my brow.
Beloved, as You wash my skin for the
grave,

Do not fear to flay off fur from Your slave.
Let this be destiny glorious and great,
To become dog-skin muffler be my fate.
Beloved, put on Your dog-skin mittens
when
Dispensing heavenly blessings to all men.

Week 28 Leviticus 14

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses and said
 2 "This shall be the law of the *led*
 Leper for the day of his healing.
 He shall be brought to the priest dealing.
 The priest shall go out of the camp,
 And the priest shall check out the scamp,
 And indeed, *if the leprosy*
 Is healed in the leper, 4 "then he
 Shall command to take for him who
 Is to be cleansed of clean birds two
 Alive, and cedar wood, and scarlet,
 And hyssop *weed to cleanse the starlet.*
 5 "And the priest shall command that one
 Of the birds to be killed *and done*
 In an earthen vessel above
 Running water. 6 "And as for of
 The living bird, he shall take it,
 The cedar wood and the scarlet
 And hyssop, and dip them along
 With the live bird, *kicking and strong,*
 In the blood of the bird killed over
 The running water *without clover.*
 7 "And he shall sprinkle seven times
 On him who's to be cleansed from *grimes*
 Of leprosy, and shall pronounce
 Him clean, and the living bird bounce
 Out loose into the open field.
 8 "He who is to be cleansed shall yield
 His clothes to be washed, and shave off
 All his hair, and wash *in a trough*
 Of water, that he may be clean.
 After that he shall *then be seen*
 Come once again into the camp,
 And shall stay outside his tent *ramp*
 Seven days. 9 "But on seventh day
 He'll shave all the hair from toupet
 And his beard and his eyebrows too,
 All hair shave off *and through and*
through.
 He'll wash his clothes and wash his body
 In water, be clean and not soddy.

The Qalandar who shaves his head and
 beard
 With eyebrows cut on public square looks
 weird.
 Yet ancient is the law of purity
 That counsels him to shave his vanity.
 Lone dervish, rare sight in the modern
 world,
 Whose only thought is for a flag unfurled
 In duty to You, my Beloved unknown!

So many hearts have since been turned to
 stone
 By magic wands of advertizing glitz.
 Shaved and unseeing those, the dervish sits.
 Shave not my head alone for purity,
 But also mind and heart of all I see
 That is not praise and worship given You.
 Shave off the dross of everything I do.

"And on the eighth day he shall take
 Two male lambs, unblemished *steak,*
 One unblemished ewe lamb of first
 Year, three-tenths of fine flour immersed
 In oil as a grain offering, and
 One log of oil. 11 "At the priest's hand
 Who makes *him* clean shall the man be
 Presented who's to be made *free*
 And clean, and those things, before
 YHWH,

At door of meeting tent on cue.
 12 "And the priest shall take one male lamb
 And offer it as trespass *ram*
 In offering, and the log of oil,
 And wave them *as a waving coil,*
 An offering before YHWH. 13 "Then he
 Shall kill the lamb in place where he
 Kills the sin offering and the burnt
 Offering, in a holy place *learnt,*
 For as the sin offering's the priest's,
 So *is the trespass offering feasts.*
 It *is* most holy. 14 "And the priest
 Shall take *some* of the blood increased
 Of the trespass offering, and shall
 Put *it on the tip radial*
 Of the right ear of him who is
 To be cleansed, on the thumb of his
 Right hand, and on the big toe of
 His right foot. 15 "And the priest *above*
 Shall take *some* of the log of oil,
 And pour *it out into the coil*
 Of the palm of his own left hand.
 16 "Then the priest shall dip his right *grand*
 Finger in the oil in left hand,
 And shall sprinkle *some* of the oil
 With his finger seven times before
 YHWH. 17 "And the rest of the oil more
 In his hand, the priest shall put *some*
 On the tip of the right ear *corps*
 Of him who's to be cleansed, on thumb
 Of his right hand, and on the big
 Toe of his right foot, on the *swig*
 Of blood of the trespass offering.

18 "The rest of the oil that *might cling*
 To the priest's hand he shall put on
 The head of him who's cleansed *anon*.
 So the priest shall make atonement
 For him before YHWH *as he's sent*.
 19 "Then the priest shall offer the sin
 Offering, and make atonement in
 Him who is to be cleansed from his
 Uncleaness. Afterward he is
 To kill the burnt offering. 20 "The priest
 Shall offer the burnt offering *feast*
 And the grain offering on the altar.
 So the priest shall *and without falter*
 Make atonement for him, and he
 Shall be clean *in his purity*.

The priest shall sprinkle the blood seven
 times
 To make for purity in ancient climes.
 And what the dog has licked at first with
 soil
 The man will wash with sand instead of oil
 And seven times rinse in the water's flood
 And so once more do without cleansing
 blood.
 The sacrifice is not so much to say
 What You require in blood and flesh for
 pay,
 But as a limitation on the folk
 Insisting that by slaying in one stroke
 Their covenant with You is ratified.
 Comparison's right here to take my pride
 In offering and to leave the local bent.
 Without dog dish I sit within my tent.

21 "But if he *is* poor and cannot
 Afford it, then he'll take a shot
 At one male lamb *as* a trespass
 Offering to be waved, to compass
 Atonement for him, one-tenth *of*
An ephah of fine flour *above*
 Mixed with oil as a grain offering,
 A log of oil, 22 "and two *of spring*
 Turtledoves or two young pigeons,
 Such as he's able *without tons*
Of wealth to afford: one shall be
 A sin offering, the other *fee*
 A burnt offering. 23 "He shall bring them
 To the priest on the eighth day's *hem*
 For his cleansing, and to the door
 Of meeting tent, before YHWH's *score*.
 24 "And the priest shall take the lamb of

The trespass offering, the log of
 Oil, and the priest shall wave them *as*
 A wave offering for YHWH *has*.
 25 "Then he shall kill the lamb offering
 Of trespass, and the priest shall bring
Some of the blood of the trespass
 Offering and put *it* on the tip
 Of the right ear of him who's *trip*
 Is to be cleansed, and on the thumb
 Of his right hand, and on the *drum*
 Of the big toe of his right foot.
 26 "And then the priest some oil shall put
 Into the palm of his left hand.
 27 "The priest shall sprinkle with his *grand*
 Right finger *some* of the oil that
Is in his own left palm *and flat*
 Seven times before YHWH. 28 "The priest
 Shall put *some* of the oil *decreased*
 That's in his hand on the tip of
 The right ear of the one *above*
 Who's to be cleansed, and on the thumb
 Of the right hand, and *then put some*
 On the big toe of his right foot,
 On the place where the blood was put
 Of the trespass offering. 29 "The rest
 Of the oil that's in the priest's *pressed*
 Hand he shall put on head of him
 Who is to be cleansed, to make *trim*
 Atonement for him before YHWH.
 30 "And he shall offer one of two
 Turtledoves or young pigeons, such
 As he can afford, 31 "and as much
 As he is able to afford,
 The one *as* a sin offering *scored*,
 The other *as* a burnt offering,
 And along with the grain offering.
 So the priest shall make atonement
 For him who's to be cleansed *and sent*
 Before YHWH. 32 "So this *is* the law
For one who had a leprous sore,
 Who can't afford the usual store."

Your law, Beloved, is always different
 And with a lesser demand to be spent
 When applied to the poor, the lone dervish:
 When others bring two lambs, he brings a
 dish.
 When others bow and prostrate on the
 ground,
 I leave off two prostrations where I'm
 found,

And pray the traveller's prayer, for I am
bound,
I'm just a stranger here, and travelling
round.
When others pay out alms and cleanse their
way
By giving of their store in silver pay,
I hold out beggar's hand where others stay,
And take instead of gold Karbela's clay.
Though law is also made for dervish dog,
Beloved, I am still unclean in my fog.

33 And YHWH spoke to Moses and said
To Aaron *also*, 34 "When you're led
Into the land of Canaan, which
I give you as possession *rich*,
And I put the leprous plague in
A house in the land you dwell in,
35 "And he who owns the house comes and
Tells the priest, saying 'There's some brand
Of plague in the house as it seems,'
36 "Then the priest shall command the
teams
To empty the house, before priest
Goes in to check if plague's increased,
That all that's in the house may not
Be made unclean *by what is sought*,
And afterward the priest shall go
In to check out the house *and know*.

The lords and judges indeed took my house
And emptied it of wood and straw and
mouse,
So that the table set for glass and gold
Had to be taken out and timely sold.
The lords and judges here are always bold.
I truly prefer moose and deer and grouse.
It was no spot of red or green gave way
To steal my earthly treasures in their day,
But just the greed of those who make the
laws
And those who find excuse if not a cause.
But You, Beloved, have blessed the humble
hut
More than the palace lost to whom and
what.
I thank You that the cool earth and the
spring
Are here to hear my heart and my tongue
sing.

37 "And he shall look around for plague,

And indeed *if* the plague's *not vague*
Upon the walls of the house with
Ingrained streaks, green or reddish kith,
Which seem to be deep in the wall,
38 "Then the priest shall go out of stall
To the door of the house, and shut
Up seven days the house *or hut*.
39 "And the priest shall come again on
The seventh day and look *at dawn*,
And indeed *if* the plague has spread
On the house walls *in green or red*,
40 "Then the priest shall command that
they
Take away the stones in which *stay*
The plagues, and they shall cast them in
An unclean place outside town bin.
41 "And he shall cause the house to be
Scraped inside, all around, and free
The dust that they scrape off to pour
Out in an unclean place and store
Outside the city. 42 "Then they'll take
Other stones and put for their sake
In the place of *those* stones, and he
Shall take other mortar freely
And plaster the house. 43 "Now if plague
Comes back and breaks out *on the leg*
Of the house, after he has taken
Away the stones *to be forsaken*,
After he has scraped down *the wall*
Of the house, after it is all
Plastered, 44 "then the priest shall come
look,
And indeed *if* the plague then took
And spread in the house, it *must be*
In the house active leprosy.
It *is* unclean. 45 "And he shall break
Down the house, *and no pity take*,
Its stones, its timber, all the plaster
Of the house, and he'll carry *faster*
Outside the city to unclean
Place. 46 "Moreover he who is seen
To enter house at all while it
Is shut, shall be unclean, *unfit*,
Until evening. 47 "And he who lies
Down in the house, *not to despise*,
Shall wash his clothes, and he who eats
In the house shall wash his clothes' *sheets*.

I should be glad that only land and gold
Have been taken away from house and
fold.

They might have broken down the house as
well,
Indeed they tried to do the thing a spell,
And left it leaning toward the lilac spring.
The stone foundations crack to find a sling.
But it was heathen priest who found the
straw

To keep the wall well heated without thaw.
The role of priest from century to date
Changes from helper to turner of fate.
Beloved, I flee the modern and plagued
store

Of houses where the mildew eats the floor.
Beloved, I eat and sleep within Your heart
Until the foe retrieves me with his dart.

48 "But if the priest comes in to see,
And indeed plague's not spread to be
In the house after the house was
Plastered, then the priest, *as he does*,
Shall declare the house clean, because
The plague is healed. 49 "And he shall
take,

To cleanse the house, two birds, and *stake*
Of cedar wood, scarlet, and *sprig*
Of hyssop. 50 "Then he'll *in a jig*
Kill one of the birds in a clay
Pot over running water's way,
51 "And he shall take the cedar wood,
The hyssop, the scarlet, and *good*
The living bird, and dip them in
The blood of the slain bird *in bin*
And in the running water, and
Sprinkle on the house seven times.

52 "And he shall cleanse the house *at hand*
With the blood of the bird *and slimes*
And running water and the living
Bird, with the cedar wood, the *sprig*
Of hyssop, and the scarlet *rig*,
All things in sacrifice they're giving.
53 "Then he shall let the living bird
Go free outside the city, *stirred*
And in the open field, and make
Atonement for the house's sake,
And it shall be clean *in a word*.

54 "This *is* the law for any sore
That's leprous and for scale, *what's more*,
55 "For the leprosy of a cloak
And of a house, 56 "and for a *soak*
Swelling and a scab and bright dot,
57 "To teach when *it is* clean and not.
This *is* the law of leprous spot."

The leprosy's a talent of the skin
Of body, coat or house that I live in.
With scarlet, hyssop, cedar wood and blood
The curse is driven off as in a flood.
Four gates of air, earth, fire and troubled
sea

In seven shakes reveal Your love to me.
I take the living bird within my soul
In bosom before Sultan as my goal
And grant submission to Your will and
truth

Before the court and swear it all forsooth.
But when the smoke and blood and
sacrifice

Of hyssop and of cedar in a trice
Are gone, I let the living pigeon go
To fly away across the fields and blow.

Leviticus 15

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses and said
Also to Aaron , 2 "Speak a *shred*
To Israel's folk, and say to them:
'When any man has an, ahem,
A discharge from his body, his
Discharge *is* unclean, *so it is*.
3 'And this shall be his uncleanness
In regard to his discharge mess
Whether his body runs with his
Discharge, or his body then is
Stopped up by his discharge, it *is*
His uncleanness. 4 'Every bed is
Unclean on which he comes to lie
Who has the discharge by and by,
And everything on which he sits
Shall be unclean, *what he emits*.
5 'And whoever touches his bed
Shall wash his clothes and bathe full-fled
In water, and be unclean till
The evening. 6 'He who sits *for nil*
On anything on which he who
Has the discharge sat shall come to
Wash his clothes and bathe in some clean
Water, and be unclean as seen
Until the evening. 7 'And he who
Touches the body of him who
Has the discharge shall wash his clothes
And bathe in water, and like those
Be unclean until evening. 8 'If
He who has the discharge in tiff
Spits on him who is clean, then he
Shall wash his clothes and bathe in water,

And be unclean till evening *slaughter*.
 9 'Any saddle on which he who
 Has the discharge rides shall be too
 Unclean. 10 'Whoever touches what
 Was under him shall be *unwrought*,
 Unclean until the evening. He
 Who carries *anything in fee*
Of those things shall wash his clothes and
 Bathe in water *and out of hand*,
 And be unclean till evening *stand*.
 11 'And whomever the one who has
 The discharge touches, and he has
 Not rinsed his hands in water, he
 Shall wash his clothes and bathe and be
 In water, and be unclean till
 The evening, *that will fit the bill*.
 12 'The vessel of earth that he who
 Has the discharge touches shall do
 To be broken, and every plate
 Of wood shall be rinsed in a rate
 Of water. 13 'And when he who has
 A discharge is cleansed of his jazz
 Then he shall count for himself days
 In number seven for his ways
 Of cleansing, wash his clothes, and bathe
 His body in running and swathe
 Water, and then he shall be clean.
 14 'On the eighth day he shall take for
 Himself two of turtledoves or
 Two young pigeons, and come before
 YHWH, to the tent of meeting's door,
 And give them to the priest. 15 'The priest
 Shall offer them, one *as a feast*
Sin offering and the other *as*
A burnt offering. Then the priest has
 Made atonement for him to YHWH
 Because of his discharge *and goo*.
 16 'If any man has an emission
 Of semen, then he'll wash his bun
 And all his body in water,
 And be unclean till eve occur.
 17 'And any garment, any skin
 Of leather on which there has been
 His semen, it shall be washed in
 Water, and be unclean till eve.
 18 'Also, when one lies to conceive
 With a man, and *there is* emission
 Of semen, then in their condition
 They shall bathe in water, and be
 Unclean until the eve's decree.

The rate of purity for illness and

For normal emissions might quite well
 stand
 Comparison with rites of purity
 As they are done today for You to see.
 The concepts and the practices remain
 Startlingly similar through years and gain.
 Beloved, I wash both hand and cover but
 Remain unclean in Your sight if for what
 The issue of my heart and tongue reveal
 To be the stony reserves that I feel
 Are too much mine to sacrifice to You.
 Once turtledoves sufficed, pigeon or two,
 But now I bring myself entire to stand
 As sacrifice before Your tent and hand.

19 'If a woman has a discharge,
And the discharge from her body
 Is blood, she shall not go at large
 But be set apart seven *wee*
 Days, and whoever touches her
 Shall be unclean till eve *occur*.
 20 'Everything that she lies upon
 During her impurity gone
 Shall be unclean, also each scene
 That she sits on shall be unclean.
 21 'Whoever then touches her bed
 Shall wash his clothes and bathe full-fled
 In water, and be unclean till
 The evening *come and fill the bill*.
 22 'And he who touches anything
 That she sat on *from bed to spring*
 Shall wash his clothes and bathe in water,
 And be unclean till evening *slaughter*.
 23 'If *anything* is on *her* bed
 Or on a place where she sits dread,
 When he touches it, he shall be
 Unclean until evening's *decree*.
 24 'And if any man lies with her
 So her impurity refer
 To him, he shall be unclean for
 Seven days, and every bed *score*
 On which he lies shall be unclean.
 25 'If a woman has discharge seen
 Of blood for many days, but not
 At the time of her *normal plot*
 Impurity, or if it runs
 Beyond her *usual time of shuns*,
 All days of her unclean discharge
 Shall be as the days of her *large*
And customary uncleanness.
 She *shall be* unclean *for address*.
 26 'And every bed on which she lies

All the days her discharges rise
 Shall be to her as bed of her
 Impurity, and where impure
 She sits shall be unclean for sure,
 As the uncleanness of impure.
 27 'Whoever then touches those things
 Shall be unclean, he'll wash in springs
 His clothes and bathe in water *too*,
 And be unclean till evening *dew*.
 28 'But if she is cleansed of discharge,
 Then she shall count her seven *large*
 Days, and after that she'll be clean.
 29 'And on the eighth day *when it's seen*
 She'll take herself two turtledoves
 Or two young pigeons, and *in gloves*
 Bring them to the priest, to the door
 Of tent of meeting. 30 'Then *in store*
 The priest shall offer the one *as*
 A sin offering, the other *as*
 A burnt offering, and the priest shall
 Make atonement *purifical*
 For her before YHWH for discharge
 Of her uncleanness *and at large*.
 31 'Thus you shall separate the folk
 Of Israel from their unclean *croak*,
 Lest they die in their uncleanness
 When they defile My tent's address
 That *is* among them. 32 'This *is* law
 For one who has a discharge *raw*,
 And *for him* who emits semen
 And is unclean thereby *of men*,
 33 'Also for her who's indisposed
 Because an impure thing disclosed,
 And for one who has a discharge,
 Either man or woman *at large*,
 And for him who lies with her who
 Is unclean, *all these things they'll do.*'''

For the uncleanness regular of men
 And women, there is washing once again.
 But for the illness and exceptional
 There is avoidance of the bed and sal
 For seven days. Belovèd, so I'm bound
 From week to week I find I am unsound,
 Avoided by the populace and pure
 Upon an unclean place upon the ground.
 I seek the waters cool and presence sure
 Where You, Belovèd, remake earth and
 abound

In six days for the rising of the wind.
 But I'm not even sure that I have sinned.
 My customary discharge of complaint

May be the way of every soul that's saint.

Week 29 Leviticus 16

1 Now YHWH spoke to Moses after
 The death of the two sons that were
 Of Aaron , when they offered *vain*
And profane fire before YHWH's *reign*,
 And died, 2 and then YHWH said to Moses
Of Aaron and what he proposes,
 "Tell Aaron your brother not to
 Come at *just* any time into
 The holy *place* inside the veiling,
 Before the mercy seat availing
 Which *is* on the ark, lest he die,
 For I'll appear in cloud there by
 The mercy seat. 3 "Thus Aaron shall
 Come into holy *capital*
 With a young bull's blood as a sin
 Offering, and *of a ram akin*
 As a burnt offering. 4 "He shall put
 The holy linen tunic *foot*
To head, linen trousers upon
 His body, he shall be full drawn
 With a linen sash, and with turban,
 Made of linen *and yet suburban*,
 He'll be attired, and these *are* holy
 Garments, therefore he'll wash his *lowly*
 Body in water, put them on.

I wash myself and put the clothing on
 That is demanded for atonement's dawn.
 A high priest of the last year's swallow's
 nest,

I seek to do my duty with the rest.
 I enter the sanctum of pine and fir
 And tramp across the lichens that once
 were

Dry in the summer scattering of sun,
 But are now wet since spring thaws have
 begun.

I search the holy hill for mercy seat
 And shining presence of divine retreat,
 And find a snowy path to fit the bill,
 While all around me hymnodies are still.
 The fast and froth have passed me, and
 affliction
 Of soul is stilled beneath my firm
 conviction.

5 "And he shall take from congregation
 Of Israel's folk two kids *in ration*
 Of the goats as a sin offering,

And one ram as a burnt offering.
 6 "Aaron shall offer the bull as
 A sin offering, which himself has,
 And make atonement for himself
 And for his house, *human and elf*.
 7 "He shall take the two goats, present
 Them before YHWH *at* door of tent
 Of meeting. 8 "Then Aaron shall cast
 Lots for the two goats: one lot *passed*
 For YHWH, and then the other lot
 For the scapegoat *tied on the spot*.
 9 "And Aaron shall bring the goat on
 Which YHWH's lot fell *when it was drawn*,
 And offer it *as* a sin offering.
 10 "But the goat on which the lot proffering
 Fell to be the scapegoat shall be
 Presented alive before *Me*,
 YHWH, to make atonement upon,
And to let it go scapegoat on
 Into the wilderness. 11 "And Aaron
 Shall bring the bull of sin to share in
 The offering, which is for himself,
 And make atonement for himself
 And for his house, and kill the bull
 As the sin offering for his *halter*
 12 "Then he shall take a censer full
 Of burning coals of fire from altar
 Before YHWH, with his hands full of
 Sweet incense beaten fine *above*,
 And bring *it all* inside the veil.
 13 "And he shall put the incense tale
 On the fire before YHWH, so that
 The cloud of incense *where it's at*
 May cover the mercy seat that
 Is on the testimony, lest
 He die. 14 "He shall take *of the best*
 Of the bull's blood and sprinkle *it*
 With his finger *where it may fit*
 Upon the mercy seat on east
 And before mercy seat increased
 He shall sprinkle some of the blood
 With his finger seven times *in flood*.

Beloved, choose me for the scapegoat set
 free

To wander in the wilderness and be
 Hidden from sight of men and in the glare
 Of Your own presence shining everywhere.
 Beloved, choose me by every quirk of fate
 That chances purchase from the dawn and
 late,
 And set me once before the holy tent

A day when the shekinah bore its scent.
 Beloved, choose me like any other goat
 To stand before the tablets that You wrote
 For Moses in his judgements what to quote.
 Beloved, choose me of any two You find
 Among the spotless and the lame and blind,
 And make me one with You, and be so
 kind.

15 "Then he shall *come to* kill the goat
 Of the sin offering, which *he wrote*
 For the people, and bring its blood
 Inside the veil, do with that blood
 As he did with the blood of bull,
 And sprinkle on mercy seat full
 And before the mercy seat *too*.

16 "So he shall make atonement to
 The holy *place*, because of what
 Is unclean that Israel's folk *got*,
 And because of their transgressions,
 For all their sins *without home-runs*,
 And so he shall do for the tent
 Of meeting which remains present
 Among them in the middle of
 Their uncleanness *mentioned above*.

17 "There shall be no man in the tent
 Of meeting when he goes to make
 Atonement in the holy *wake*,
 Until he comes out, that he may
 Make atonement *and in that way*
 For himself, for his household, and
 For all Israel's assembled band.

18 "And he shall go out to the altar
 That is before YHWH, and *not falter*
 To make atonement for it, and
 Shall take some of bull's blood *in hand*
 And some of the blood of the goat,
 And put it on the horns *remote*
 Of the altar and all around.

19 "Then he shall sprinkle some blood
found
 On it with his finger seven times,
 Cleanse it, and consecrate *its grimes*
 From Israel's folk's uncleanly *crimes*.

Sprinkle my blood, Beloved, and seven
 times
 Upon the altar horns and for my crimes
 Upon the mercy seat where You stand fast
 Above the cherubim who seem to last,
 Because they're made of gold and don't
 decay

The way You and I do along the way,
 Who have no body made of gold, but clay.
 Sprinkle my blood, Beloved, on mercy seat
 That I may find in You a mercy's treat,
 And bear my blood upon the altar horns
 Up high enough to miss my feet and corns.
 I prance in circle sacrifice and prayer
 With my life-blood upon my shirt and hair
 And find Your footsteps dancing
 everywhere.

20 "And when he has made an end of
 Atoning for the holy cove,
 The tabernacle of meeting,
 And the altar, then he shall bring
 The live goat. 21 "Aaron shall lay both
 His hands on the head *for an oath*
 Of the live goat, confess on it
 All of Israel's folk's sins *to wit*,
 Where all of their transgressions *sit*,
 Concerning all their sins, to put
 Them on the head *and not the foot*
 Of the goat, and send *it* away
 Into the wilderness *to stay*
 By the hand of a man well fit.
 22 "The goat shall bear on itself all
 Their iniquities *and in thrall*
 To an uninhabited land,
 And he'll release the goat in hand
 Into the wilderness *to stand*.
 23 "Aaron shall come into the tent
 Of meeting, shall take off garment
 Of linen which he had put on
 When he went in the holy *drawn*,
 And shall leave them there. 24 "And he
 shall
 Wash body with water *withal*
 In a holy place, put on his
 Garments, come out and offer his
 Burnt offering and the burnt one
 Of the people, and then make done
 Atonement for himself and folk.
 25 "The fat of the sin offering stoke
 Upon the altar. 26 "And he who
 Released the goat as scapegoat due
 Shall wash his clothes and bathe his body
 In water, *then come in the soddy*,
 And afterward come back to camp.
 27 "The bull *for the sin offering's lamp*
 And the goat *for the sin offering*,
 Whose blood was atonement to bring
 In the holy *place*, shall be brought

Outside the camp where they'll be caught
 Up in the fire, their skins, their flesh,
 And also offal, *not too fresh*.
 28 "He who burns them shall wash his
 clothes
 And bathe his body in the *rose*
Of water, and afterward he
 May come into the camp *freely*.

He who sets me free in the wilderness
 Must also pause to cleanse him from the
 mess.
 Indeed, I am set in that woeful place
 By many hands who would not see my
 face,
 And so defiled they turn to mark their time
 In a world governed by their crime in
 rhyme.
 It is my fate, God-given fate before
 Your gracious face and before Your tent
 door
 To be the beast by which men are defiled
 Who cannot walk a desert and be mild.
 For such to sacrifice another must
 Be the sole way to rise up from the dust.
 Beloved, I seek no rising here at all,
 But in the blanching desert hear Your call.

29 "This shall be a statute always
 For you, in the seventh month's days,
 On the tenth of the month, afflict
 Your souls, and do no work you've picked,
Whether a native of your own
 Country or a stranger alone
 Who dwells among you. 30 "On that day
The priest shall make atonement stay
 For you, to cleanse you, *that* you may
 Be clean from all sins before YHWH.
 31 "It's a sabbath of rest for you,
 And you'll afflict your souls as due
 Always by law. 32 "And the priest, who
 Is anointed and consecrated
 To minister as priest *as fated*
 In his father's stead, then shall make
 Atonement, and linen clothes take,
 Upon himself the holy cloak,
 33 "Then he shall make atonement's *stroke*
 For the holy temple, and he
 Shall make atonement *faithfully*
 For the tent of meeting and for
 The altar, *from ceiling to floor*,
 And he shall make atonement for

The priests, the congregation's folk.
34 "This shall be an everlasting
Statute for you, to make the thing
In atonement for Israel's folk,
For all their sins, and once a year."
He did as YHWH told Moses' *ear*.

The tenth day of the first month I return
Afflicting my soul on the rocky burn.
It is a Sabbath of rest for my soul,
Who has not thirsted on the last atoll.
It is a fast, if fast affliction be,
To make a sorrowing and memory
Of every sacrifice of self unknown
And represented in Karbela's bone.
The tenth day of the first month I atone
If atonement can rend the sky apart
To bring down rain from brass and fill with
art

A leaden field beneath the holy feet.
Give, my Beloved, to all such souls to eat,
And if not rain, at least a freezing sleet.

Leviticus 17

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
2 "Speak to Aaron, to his sons *bred*,
And say to all of Israel's folk,
'This *is* the thing of which YHWH spoke,
Commanding, 3 "Whatever man of
The house of Israel who *for love*
Kills ox or lamb or goat within
The camp, or who kills *it for sin*
Outside the camp, 4 "and does not bring
It to the door of meeting tent
To offer to YHWH as offering
Before YHWH's tabernacle *spent*,
The guilt of bloodshed be imputed
To that man, he's shed blood *disputed*,
And that man shall be cut off from
Among his people, 5 "to the sum
That Israel's folk may bring to yield
Their sacrifice from open field,
That they may bring them to YHWH at
The door of meeting tent where sat
The priest, and offer them *as peace*
Offerings to YHWH *for their release*.
6 "And the priest shall sprinkle the blood
On the altar of YHWH *in flood*
At the door of the meeting tent,
And burn the fat for a sweet scent
To YHWH. 7 "And they shall no more
offer

Their sacrifice, to demons proffer,
After whom they have played the whore.
This shall be statute evermore
For them throughout their generations."
8 "Also you'll say *for their elations*,
'Whatever man of Israel's house,
Or of the strangers, *mouse or grouse*,
Who live among you, who is *nice*
To offer a burnt sacrifice,
9 'And does not bring it to the door
Of the meeting tent *and its store*,
To offer it to YHWH, that man
Shall be cut off from his folk's *plan*.

I understand, Beloved, that You require
The folk to burn each goat in sacred fire
And in one place, because the fields
abound
In every kind of satyr of the ground
And every god and goddess to be found,
All of whom thirst to steal the glory sound
That's due to You alone, divinely gowned.
That's why, Beloved, You tell the ancient
race

To sacrifice their goats in that one place.
And that's why, though a desert goat
myself,

And living among satyr and sweet elf,
I come to spill my blood upon the gate
Of fire and love in the place where You
wait

Though it is in another store and state.

10 'And whoever of Israel's folk,
Or any stranger or the bloke
Who lives among you, and who eats
Any blood, I'll for his deceits
Set My face against that one who
Eats blood, and will cut him off from
Among his people, *he's a bum*.
11 'For the life of the flesh *is* in
The blood, and I've given it *for sin*
To you upon the altar to
Make atonement for your souls' due,
For it *is* the blood *shed that* makes
Atonement for *your* souls *and sakes*.'
12 "Therefore I said to Israel's folk,
'No one among you shall eat *stroke*
Of blood, nor shall any stranger
Who dwells with you eat blood's *liqueur*.'
13 "Whatever man of Israel's folk,
Or of the strangers, any bloke,

Who lives among you, and who hunts
 And catches any beast or *runts*
Of bird that may be eaten, he
 Shall pour out its blood in the lea
 And cover it with dust, 14 "for *it's*
 The life of all flesh *where it sits*.
 Its blood sustains its life, therefore
 I said to Israel's folk what's more,
 'You'll eat no blood of any flesh,
 For in its blood's life of all flesh.
 And who eats it shall be cut off.'
 15 "And every person *not to scoff*
 Who eats what died or what was torn,
 Your own land's native or one born
 A stranger, he shall both wash his
 Clothes and bathe in water that is,
 And be unclean till evening's seen,
 And only then he shall be clean.
 16 "But if he does not wash *them* or
 Bathe his body, his guilt's the more."

The Christian wield apparently's allowed
 To sip the blood of pigged and ducked and
 cowed,

And thus makes such exception to this rule
 That the onlooker's looked on as a fool.
 I eat no blood of him that's died and torn,
 Nor of the man who was of virgin born,
 And so I shall not be cut off from them
 Who are the stranger, nor from sacred gem.
 Beloved, let me bear this law to the grave
 And thus be in my blood Your humble
 slave
 And keep the blood for You that other's
 gave.
 Beloved, let me eat no forbidden thing,
 Not that such law's the most important
 thing,
 But that my voice shall still know how to
 sing.

Leviticus 18

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 2 "Speak to Israel's children *well-bred*,
 And say to them I'm YHWH your God.
 3 'According to the way they plod
 In Egypt's land, where you have lived,
 You shall not do, and negatived
 Also are ways of Canaan's land,
 Where I am bringing you *to stand*,
 You'll not do so, nor shall you walk
 In their ordinances *or talk*.

4 'You shall observe My judgements and
 Keep My ordinances *in hand*,
 To walk in them: for I *am* YHWH
 Your God. 5 'You'll therefore keep *and do*
 My statutes and judgements, for who
 Does so, shall live by them: I'm YHWH.

Between the land of Egypt and the land
 Of Christian Canaan I come to a stand.
 Beloved, Islam and Rome cast lots to be
 The ruler of this soul that's been set free
 In loving grace from You. So let me walk
 Not in the pagan way, nor let me balk
 At following, Beloved, Your chosen will.
 I drink the running waters from Your still
 To find no clouding wine, but clearing
 draught

Of law that teaches my steps divine craft
 Unknown to Egypt's mullahs and the seat
 Where popes and gurus hand out trick or
 treat.

Beloved, I lay hold of Your law's demand
 And pray that I may live here in Your land.

6 'None of you shall approach to one
 Who is near of kin to him, *run*
 To uncover his nakedness:
 I'm YHWH. 7 'Your father's nakedness
 Or nakedness of mother you
 Shall not uncover, *what you do*,
 She *is* your mother, you shall not
 Uncover her nakedness aught.
 8 'Nakedness of your father's wife
 You shall not uncover *for life*,
 It *is* your father's nakedness.
 9 'Your sister's nakedness undress,
 The daughter of your father, or
 The daughter of your mother's *store*,
Whether born at home or elsewhere,
 Their nakedness you shall beware.
 10 'The nakedness of your son's daughter
 Or your daughter's daughter you've sought
 her,
 Their nakedness you'll not reveal,
 For theirs *is* your own nakedness.
 11 'Your father's wife's daughter's undress,
 Begotten by your father, she
Is your sister, you shall not be
 One to reveal her nakedness.
 12 'You shall not uncover the feel
 Of your father's sister, she's near
 Of kin to your father *and dear*.

13 'You shall not uncover the sweat
Of your mother's sister *and pet*,
For she's your mother's near of kin.
14 'You shall not uncover *for sin*
Your father's brother's naked *shin*.
You shall not approach to his wife,
She *is* your aunt, *for peace or strife*.
15 'You shall not uncover the skin
Of your daughter-in-law, she's in
Marriage to your son, so you'll not
Uncover her bare *garden plot*.
16 'You shall not uncover the bare
Of your own brother's wife to *share*,
It *is* your brother's nakedness.
17 'You shall not uncover the dress
Of a woman and her daughter,
Nor shall you take her son's daughter
Or her daughter's daughter to wife,
To uncover her naked *rife*.
They *are the* near of kin to her.
It's wickedness *so to incur*.
18 'Nor shall you take a woman as
A rival as her sister has,
To uncover her nakedness
While other is alive *to bless*.

Beloved, incest You have condemned
aloud
And spoken clearly to the lusty crowd.
The limitations that You hereby state
Give ample room for gusty marriage fate.
Few there be that may not be undressed for
The hopes behind the sweetened bedroom
door.

Polygamy itself is limited
Only by having sisters on the grid.
I wonder that any should seal their grate
By wishing Your law did not aggravate.
By giving freedom to rise, slay and eat.
You give men rope to hang and cook their
meat.

Let me, Beloved, as I traverse Your load,
Walk faster and straighter than pressing
goad.

19 'Also you shall not approach to
A woman to reveal her due
When she's in her impurity.
20 'And you shall not lie carnally
With your neighbour's wife, to defile
Yourself with her *in pleasure vile*.
21 'And you shall not let any of

Your descendants pass through *for love*
The fire to Molech, nor shall you
Profane the name of God: I'm YHWH.
22 'You shall not lie with any male
As with a woman, it's not hale.
23 'Nor shall you mate with any beast,
To defile yourself with at least.
Nor shall a woman stand before
A beast to mate with it, a whore.
24 'Do not defile yourselves with any
Of these things, for by all these many
Nations are defiled, which I am casting
Out before you *and so lambasting*.
25 'For the land is defiled, therefore
I visit their sins and outpour
Punishment upon it, the land
Vomits its dwellers out of hand.
26 'You shall therefore keep My statutes
And My judgements, and *in disputes*
Not commit these abominations,
Either any of your own nation's
Or any stranger in your stations.
27 'For all of these abominations
The people of the land have done,
Who *were* before you *in the sun*,
And thus the land's defiled, *undone*,
28 'Lest the land vomit you too when
You also defile it, as then
It vomited out the nations
That *were* before you *under suns*.
29 'For whoever commits any
Of these abominations free,
The persons who commit *them* shall
Be cut off from their folk and sal.
30 'Therefore you shall keep My statute,
So that *you* don't commit *like brute*
Any of these vile customs that
Were committed before you *sat*,
That you do not defile yourselves
By them: I'm YHWH your God *who*
delves.'"

A naughty lot we are upon the sand
Of this unlucky star and world and land,
Who find our lusts require a violence
That goes beyond both charisma and sense.
So many holy songs and ways entice
The soul with practices of sacrifice
To evils that I flee to You alone
To find my solace in Your songs of stone.
The land indeed still spews forth
defilement

And leaps to greet the cleansing sun that
sent
Its rays to burn the lust from ground and
tree.
A naughty lot we are when we're set free.
Beloved, I look for Your nobility
Upon a street accursed with excrement.

Week 30 Leviticus 19

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
2 "Speak to all Israel's folk well-bred,
And say to them 'You shall be holy,
For I YHWH your God *too am* holy.
3 'Every one of you shall revere
His mother and his father *dear*,
And keep My Sabbaths: I *am* YHWH
Your Alohim *and I am true*.

In one breath You, Beloved, command the
two
Things positive in Decalogue to do:
Honour to mom and dad and minding of
The Sabbath in Your honour and Your
love.
You do not say how best to honour those
Who were the implements by whom You
chose
To bring me in the world. You do not state
What work I ought to put off from the slate
On Sabbath day. Perhaps the task released
Is what might find the honour had
decreased
To parents. On the other hand it may
Be the best honour of the week astray
That I can give my parents is the way
I mind to keep holy the seventh day.

4 'Do not turn to idols, nor make
For yourselves moulded gods *at stake*:
For I *am* YHWH your Alohim.
5 'And if you offer *as in dream*
A sacrifice of peace offering
To YHWH, you shall your offering bring
Of your own free will. 6 'It shall be
Eaten the same day you bring *it*,
And on the next day, what is fit
To remain until the third day,
It shall be burned in fire away.
7 'And if it is eaten at all
On the third day, *beyond recall*
It is an abomination,
And to be accepted by none.

8 'Therefore *everyone* who eats it
Shall bear his wickedness *as fit*,
Because he has profaned the holy
Of YHWH, and that person shall *wholly*
Be cut off from his people *then*.
9 'When you reap harvest of your land,
You shall not wholly reap *again*
The corners of your field *in hand*,
Nor shall you gather of your spoil
The gleanings. 10 'And you shall not toil
To glean your vineyard, nor shall you
Gather *each* grape of vineyard due,
You shall leave them for the poor and
Stranger and outcast in the land:
I *am* YHWH your Alohim *YHWH*.

You take three things away from mouth of
those
Who have the wealth to slaughter food and
clothes.
Two days alone the fresh meat may be
taken
As food and then the rest of it's forsaken.
The corners of the field and all the small
Clusters of grapes are given out to all
Who have nor flocks nor fields nor
vineyard there
But are reliant on Your direct care.
Ha! Direct care there's not, it seems to me:
Some go directly to the land for scree,
And other's to the mercy of the lord.
Instead of with fruit, poor are met with
sword
As like as not. Beloved, I come to You
Expecting nothing but the word and cue.

11 'You shall not steal, nor deal falsely,
Nor lie to one another, *see*.
12 'And you shall not swear by My name
Falsely, nor shall you profane name
Of your Alohim: I *am* YHWH.
13 'You shall not cheat your neighbour's
due,
Nor rob *him*. The wages of him
Who is hired shall not remain *dim*
With you all night until morning.
14 'You shall not curse the deaf, nor string
A stumbling block before the blind,
But fear your God: I'm YHWH *and kind*.
15 'You shall do no injustice in
Judgement, to make the poor to win
Through partiality, nor yet

Honour the mighty man well set.
In righteousness you'll judge your
neighbour.

16 'You shall not go about *to labour*
As a talebearer to your folk,
Nor shall you take a stand for broke
Against the life of your neighbour:
I am YHWH. 17 'You shall not hate your
Brother in your heart. You'll rebuke
Your neighbour, and not bear the fluke
Of sin because of him. 18 'You'll not
Take vengeance, nor bear any plot
Of grudge against the children of
Your people, but you'll surely love
Your neighbour as yourself: *I'm* YHWH,
And so I tell you what to do.

You it was who first said, Beloved, the true
Saying to love the neighbour as the self.
They lie who say Jesus invented that,
And also lie who say that he has sat
On earth as God Almighty in Your seat.
Here's proof the traitors are the ones who
cheat.

There is no sovereign God at all but You,
While men worship men, stone, and sun
and elf.

None can love other as the self but he
Who sees not in the other two or three
But only one Self who's reflected in
The many selves You've mirrored without
sin.

Beloved, may I see every self alone
As Self that's one and sitting on Your
throne.

19 'You shall keep My statutes. You'll not
Let your livestock breed in the lot
With other kinds. You shall not sow
Your field with mixed seed *and to grow.*
Nor shall a garment of mixed wool
And linen come upon you *full.*

20 'Who lies carnally with a lady
Who *is* betrothed to a man *shady*
To be a concubine, and who
Has not at all been redeemed *true*
Nor given her freedom, for this
There shall be scourging, *but amiss*
They'll not be put to death, because
She was not free *from human claws.*
21 'And he'll bring his trespass offering
To YHWH, to tent door of meeting,

A ram as a trespass offering.
22 'The priest shall make atonement for
Him with the ram *he's brought in store*
For trespass offering before YHWH
For his sin which thing he would do,
And the sin which he has committed
Shall be forgiven him, remitted.

Three things You give, Beloved, to be a
sign
That no man has the right to wine and dine
And then sleep with the wives of other
men:

These three are mixing of livestock again
Of two kinds into one, of sowing seed
Of diverse kinds in one field out of greed,
And making warp and woof of different
thread,
Of linen and the wool of fine sheep bred.
Who keep to these three signs are reminded
To stay out of the neighbour's plot and bed.
For fornication scourging is the rate,
But for the other three, crimes that are
great,
You only give a warning and no lash.
Their fate's a thunderclap and lightning
flash.

23 'And when you come into the land,
And have planted *on every hand*
All kinds of trees for food, then you
Shall count their fruit *in revenue*
As the uncircumcised. Three years
It shall be as uncircumcised
To you, not eaten *joy or tears.*

24 'But in the fourth year all comprised
Of its fruit shall be holy, and
A praise to YHWH *on every hand.*

25 'And in the fifth year you may eat
Its fruit, that it may yield in meat
To you increased: *I'm* YHWH your God.

26 'You shall not eat *upon the sod*
Food with the blood, nor shall you make
Divining or soothsayer's sake.

27 'You shall not shave around the sides
Of your head, nor shall you *for guides*
Disfigure edges of your beard.

28 'You shall not make any *things sheared,*
Cuttings in your flesh for the dead,
Nor tattoo any marks *of dread*
On you: *I'm* YHWH, *as I have said.*

29 'Don't prostitute your daughter, to

Cause her to be a harlot's crew,
Lest the land fall in harlotry,
The land full of iniquity.

Five signs there be that warn against the
slaughter
And sin of prostituting one's own daughter.
These are to eat the fruit uncircumcised
And blood, to seek the counsel unrevised
Of diviner and soothsayer, and then
To cut the hair and beard in patterned wen
In honour of the sun-god and the moon,
To tattoo to their honour on the skin,
And cut away the flesh, which is a sin,
In mourning for the dead. All these are
done

With no more punishment beneath the sun
Than that the land by them is once more
filled

With wickedness beneath the tinsel gild.
Beloved, keep me from shaving and right
soon.

30 'You'll keep My Sabbaths and reverence
My sanctuary: I'm YHWH *hence*.

The holy place that You have chosen now
Upon which to place Your name anyhow
Is the house built in Bacca's far-off vale.
I cannot find its shadow in the pale
Of every weekly Sabbath that You give.
I only turn toward its lines to live,
And bow upon the earth in sacred joy
To find one God gives one place to employ
As sign that You are one for all the earth
And every son and angel that is worth
The breath to breathe Your holy name in
prayer.

And so I spent my Sabbaths, though not
there,

In reverence for the holy Kaaba and
The holy One who walks upon its sand.

31 'Give no regard to mediums'
Familiar spirits *and their bums*,
Do not seek after them, to be
Defiled by them: I'm YHWH, *you see*,
Your Alohim *above decree*.

Some blow on knots and others seek the
blood
Of entrails and their patterns in the flood,

The falling of the tesbih and the point
Of birds in flocks and branches out of joint.
Some follow the stock market and the news
To see what shall come in the world of
views.

I turn to You, Beloved, from time and
place,

And know there is no future for the race,
No past of sin and degradation here,
But only Your face and its love and fear.
Let me not be defiled by hope of gain
Or by the politics of sun and rain,
But let me trust my doing and my thoughts
To You alone by foreign garden plots.

32 'You shall rise before the grey head
And honour the old man *abed*,

And fear your elder judge: I'm YHWH.

33 'And if a stranger dwells with you
In your land, you'll not mistreat him.

34 'The stranger who dwells on your rim
Shall be to you as one born there
Among you, and you'll love him fair
As yourself, for you were stranger
In Egypt's land, and foreigner:
For I *am* YHWH your Alohim.

35 'You shall do no injustice, scheme
In judgement, in measuring length,
Or weight, or volume *in its strength*.

36 'You shall have honest scales and
weights,

An honest ephah, hin that rates:
For I *am* YHWH your Alohim,
Who brought you out of the regime
Of Egypt. 37 'Therefore you'll observe
All My statutes and *you shall serve*
All My judgements, and you shall do
Them faithfully, for I *am* YHWH."

Justice is for the weak and old and for
The stranger as well as the rich at door.
Who loves the other as his own dear soul
Can see no ways distinguishing the goal
By wealth or race or any other measure
That some may hold to be a hidden
treasure.

My hidden treasure is in You alone
Who are not made of any flesh or bone,
And so reside within the humble heart
Of poor as well as wealthy in their part.
Let me refrain from ancient Egypt's way
Of measuring the greed and empty tray,

But lay hold on what's under Egypt's sun
Today in loving ways that things are done.

Leviticus 20

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
2 "Again, you'll say to the well-bred
Of Israel, 'Who of Israel's folk,
Or of the strangers who convoke
In Israel, who gives *any* of
His descendants to Molech's *love*,
He shall surely be put to death.

The land's people *and with one breath*
Shall stone him with stones. 3 'I will set
My face against that man, and yet
Will cut him off from his folk, for
He's given to Molech the whore
His sons, to defile My holy
And profane My good name, *you see*.

4 'And if the people of the land
Should turn a blind eye or a hand
From the man, when he gives his sons
To Molech, not to kill such ones,
5 'Then I will set My face hard on
That man, also against his spawn,
And I'll cut him off from his folk,
And all who prostitute themselves
With him to commit whoredom's yoke
In Molech's *sacrifice to elves*.

6 'And the one who turns to the spell
Of medium and familiar tell,
To prostitute himself with them,
I will set My face against them
And cut him off from his folk too.

7 'Consecrate yourselves therefore, *do*,
And be holy, for I *am* YHWH
Your Alohim. 8 'And you shall keep
My statutes, and perform the heap:
I *am* YHWH who sanctifies you.

9 'For everyone who curses his
Father or mother surely is
To be put to death, he has cursed
His father or his mother *worst*,
His blood *shall be* upon him *versed*.

Your comment on the law to honour dad
And mom is that such parents should be
bad
Who sacrifice their children for their sins.
The father who does such things never
wins.

I see it is a curse to say of You
That You gave Your son as sacrifice due,

As well as dastardly a lie to boss
To say Your son died on a seemingly cross.
The fact is You accept no sacrifice
Of human blood on altar nor with spice.
The sacrifice You wish is living and
With broken heart to observe Your
command.

Who curse You with that word will come
to die

For their iniquity and for their lie.

10 'One who commits adultery
With *another* man's wife, *then he*
Who commits adultery with
His neighbour's wife, *both kin and kith*,
Adulterer and adulteress,
Shall surely be put to death's *press*.

11 'The man who lies with father's wife
Has laid bare his own father's life,
Both of them shall be put to death.
Their blood *shall be* on their own breath.

12 'If a man and daughter-in-law
Lie carnally *with claw and paw*,
Both of them shall be put to death.
They've done perversion *like MacBeth*.
Their blood *shall be* upon them too.

13 'If a man lies with male as he
Lies with a woman *all to see*,
Both of them have done a vile thing,
They shall surely be slain *by sling*.
Their blood *shall be* upon them too.

14 'If a man marries a woman
And her mother, it's wicked done.
They shall be burned with fire, both he
And they, that there may be no *free*
Wickedness among you. 15 'If one
Mates with a beast, *for what he's done*,
He shall surely be put to death,
And you'll kill the beast *Ashtoreth*.

16 'If a woman comes to a beast
To mate with it, you'll kill *at least*
The woman and the beast, they'll be
Surely put to death *for their spree*.
Their blood *shall be* upon them too.

17 'If a man takes his sister *true*,
His father's daughter or as well
His mother's daughter, *clientele*
To see her nakedness and she
Enjoys his naked body free,
It *is* a wicked thing, and they
Shall be cut off in sight *that day*
From their people, he has laid bare

His sister's nakedness, he'll bear
 His guilt. 18 'If a man lies with some
 Woman during her monthly rum
 And uncovers her nakedness,
 He has exposed her flow's address,
 And she's laid bare her blood's flow too,
 Both of them shall be cut off due
 From their folk. 19 'You shall not lay bare
 Your mother's sister's naked share,
 Father's sister, they're near of kin,
 Therefore they shall bear guilt and sin.
 20 'If a man lies with uncle's wife,
 He has laid bare his uncle's life.
 They shall bear their sin, they shall die
 Childless *and never wonder why*.
 21 'If a man takes his brother's wife,
 It is an unclean thing, for he
 Has laid bare his brother's debris.
 They shall be childless *for their fee*.

Participating in the sacrifice
 Is the equivalent of every vice
 Of incest, Ashtoreth and Moloch's price
 Is lying in the groves and under tree
 To spend one's seed in heathen harlotry.
 The seed unborn is given to sacred rite
 Of lust in temple or out in plain sight.
 The born seed's placed upon the glowing
 arms
 Of heathen idol heated to alarms,
 Where in its agony the child is lost.
 The agonies of children's sacrifice
 Are replayed in the horrors and the vice
 Of faith and the establishment of church.
 If that's faith, Beloved, leave me in the
 lurch.

22 'You shall therefore keep all of My
 Statutes and all My judgements, *try*
 And perform them, that the land where
 I'm bringing you to live in *there*
 May not vomit you out *and spare*.
 23 'And you shall not walk in statutes
 Of the nation which I'm *for brutes*
 Casting out before you, for they
 Commit all these things *every day*,
 And therefore I abhor their *sway*.
 24 'But I have said to you, "You shall
 Inherit their land *capital*,
 And I'll give it to you to hold,
 Land flowing milk and honey's *gold*."
 I am YHWH your God, who has made

Difference between you and their trade.
 25 'You shall therefore distinguish twixt
 Clean animals and unclean mixed,
 Between unclean birds and the clean,
 And you shall not make yourselves *mean*,
 Abominable by beast or bird,
 Or any kind of living turd
 That creeps on the ground, which I've
 stirred
 Distinct from you as the unclean.
 26 'And you shall be holy to Me,
 For I *am* YHWH *and am* holy,
 And separated you from folk
 That you should be Mine *to convoke*.
 27 'A man or a woman who is
 A medium, or who has his
 Familiar spirits, shall surely
 Be put to death, they'll stone them *free*
 With stones, their blood *shall surely be*
 Upon themselves *eternally*.'"

Consorting with familiar spirits or
 Consulting mediums opens the door
 It seems to eating things a man should not.
 The clean and the unclean are here well
 taught.
 And eating the unclean leads to the crime
 Of incest et alias in its time.
 Preserve me from these three idolatries,
 Beloved, and I shall turn from all of these
 To find my nourishment in You alone,
 My god in nothing made of flesh or stone,
 My hope for future in the present good,
 And all my love in Your words as I should.
 Your breath creates the monolith of being
 That disappears again before my seeing.

Week 31 Leviticus 21

1 And YHWH said to Moses, "Speak to
 The priests, the sons of Aaron , do
 And say to them, 'None shall defile
 Himself for the dead rank and file,
 2 'Except for his relatives who
 Are nearest to him: mother *true*,
 Father, son, his daughter, and brother,
 3 'His virgin sister is another
 Who's near to him, who has had no
 Husband, for her he too may go
 To defile himself. 4 'But he shall
 Not defile himself, principal
 Among his people, to profane
 Himself. 5 'They shall *also* refrain

From making any bald *place* on
 Their heads, nor shall lift razor on
 The edges of their beards nor make
 Any cuttings in their flesh. 6 'They
 Shall be holy in their God's way
 And not profane for God's name's sake,
 For they offer the offerings of
 YHWH made by fire *and in His love*,
And the bread of their God, therefore
 They shall be holy *evermore*.
 7 'They shall not take for wife a whore
 Or any woman defiled, nor
 Shall they take a woman divorced
 From her husband, for *he's performed*
 Holy to his God. 8 'So therefore
 You shall consecrate him, for he
 Offers the bread of your God, he
 Shall be holy to you, for I
 YHWH, who sanctify you hereby
Am holy. 9 'The daughter of priest,
 If she profanes herself decreased
 By playing the whore, she profanes
 Her father, let her feel the pains
 To be burned with fire *for her gains*.

The priests are not allowed to wash the
 dead.

My grandmother was one of those who fed
 Herself by washing bodies for the free
 And in their time more fine and finicky.
 She said she did not mind. She read the

Book

So much she must have known such
 washing shook

One's purity. Effect of poverty
 No doubt suffices for a girl to take
 A job that she can get, short of the make.
 That old profession for the daughter of
 Entails the worst of punishments above,
 Burning to death. That has been saved of
 late

For only great protagonists of hate:
 The heretic against the Church and State.

10 '*He who is* the high priest among
 His brothers, on whose head was slung
 Anointing oil, and who is set
 Apart to wear the garments *met*,
 Shall not uncover his head *yet*
 Nor tear his clothes, 11 'nor shall he go
 Near any dead body, nor *slow*
 To defile himself for his father

Or his mother, 12 'nor shall he *rather*
 Go out of the sanctuary,
 Nor profane the sanctuary
 Of his God, for the consecration
 Of the anointing oil's *elation*
 Of his Alohim *is* on him:
 I *am* YHWH. 13 'And he shall be *prim*
 To take wife in virginity.
 14 'A widow or a divorcee
 Or a defiled woman *or* harlot,
 These he shall not marry *for scarlet*,
 But he shall take a virgin of
 His own people *as wife to love*.
 15 'He'll not profane posterity
 Among his people, for I'm *He*
 YHWH that *truly* makes him holy."

You want the high priest's wife to be in
 state

Of her virginity when she takes mate.
 The usefulness of that appears too late,
 Because she is not virgin wife so long
 That it is worthy of the praiseful song.
 Another crime, Beloved, You perpetrate
 By not requiring that the priest himself
 Is virgin and not satyr, or an elf.
 It's interesting You make no rude
 distinction

Between the widow and divorced
 extinction,
 And defiled and harlot, all four for You
 Are all a part of one and equal crew.
 In that, Beloved, You are a modern goat,
 And have no Christian values down by
 rote.

16 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 17 "Speak to Aaron, saying 'No head
 Of your descendants in *the coming*
 Generations, who has *a humming*
 Defect, may approach to offer
 The bread of his Alohim's *spur*.
 18 'For any man who has defect
 Shall not approach, a man *abject*
In blindness or lame, who has marred
Face or any *limb* too long *scarred*,
 19 'A man who has a broken foot
 Or broken hand, 20 'or one that's put
 To be a hunchback or a dwarf,
 Or *one* who has *upon the wharf*
 A defect in his eye, or skin,
 Or scab, or is a eunuch *jinn*.

21 'No man of the descendants of Aaron the priest, who has *above* Defect, shall come near to endure The offerings made by fire to YHWH. He has a defect, he'll not come Near to offer the bread *in sum* Of his God. 22 'He may eat the bread Of his God, *both* the most holy And the holy, 23 'only not he Shall go near the veil or approach The altar, because he has *reproach* Of a defect, lest he profane My sanctuaries *with his stain*, For I YHWH sanctify *the fane*.'" 24 And Moses told *it* to Aaron And his sons, and to everyone Of Israel's folk *from dame to son*.

The failure to note degree of importance Shows Christianity to lack in hortense. Your oneness they shall disregard indeed, And fail to keep the Sabbath in their creed, And while they have no licence from Your chair

To have a priest at all, they do ring fair To choose their priests without a broken hand,

And if a man, to have at his command His reproductive tool provisioned fit, Whole and uncircumcized in fact to wit. Ah, mint and anise, mint and anise cure No ills nor errors in the church, that's sure. Beloved, to oppress the weak is their strength,

And that is something does not change at length.

Leviticus 22

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, saying 2 "Speak to Aaron and his sons' *string*, That they must separate themselves From the holy things *on the shelves* Of the children of Israel, That they do not profane *as well* My holy name *by what they brew* To consecrate to Me: I'm YHWH. 3 "Say to them, 'Whoever of you And all your descendants and through Your generations, who goes near The holy things which the folk *fear* Of Israel to offer to YHWH, While he has uncleanness *undue*

Upon him, that person shall be Cut off from My presence: I'm *He*, YHWH. 4 'Whatever man of descendant Of Aaron, who's leper *dependant* Or has a discharge, shall not eat The holy offerings *for a treat* Until he's clean. Whoever touches Anything made unclean *by clutches* Of a corpse, or a man who's had An emission of semen *glad*, 5 'Or whoever touches any Creeping thing and by the which he Would be made unclean, or any Person by whom he would become Unclean, whatever is the sum Of his uncleanness, 6 'the person Who has touched any such thing done Shall be unclean until evening, And shall not eat holy *offering* Unless he wash body with water. 7 'And when the sun goes *to its slaughter* He shall be clean, and afterward He may eat the holy *reward*, Because it *is* his food. 8 'What dies Or is torn he'll not eat *for flies*, To defile himself with it: I Am YHWH. 9 'They shall therefore keep My Ordinance, lest they sin and die If they profane it: I YHWH am The one who does sanctify them.

Semen, dead bodies, pus and creeping thing Defile by touch, Beloved, unless a spring Of water be found to wash in withal. And yet with body clean, the soul hears call To purify its ways before the sight Of You who only know the wrong and right.

With hands unwashed and feet still stained with dirt

I look toward Your divine throne alert And seek the purifying fire that burns Away the dross from my soul's gulls and terns.

The tops are cured by sun and wind and rain,

While root remains in filth and common pain.

Yet still the rotten bed of pond appears To feed the water lily's upward rears.

10 'No outsider shall eat the holy,
 One who dwells with the priest, hired lowly
 Servant, shall not eat holy things.
 11 'But if the priest buys with gold *rings*
 A person, he may eat, and one
 Who is born in his house begun
 May eat his food. 12 'If the priest's
 daughter
 Is married to an outside wrougter,
 She may not eat holy offerings.
 13 'But if the priest's daughter's a widow
 Or is divorced, and has no kiddo,
 And has returned to father's house
 As in her youth, *then like a mouse*
 She may eat her father's food, but
 No outsider shall take a cut.
 14 'And if a man eats holy *thing*
 Not on purpose, then he shall bring
 Holy *replacement* to the priest,
 And add one-fifth to it *at least*.
 15 'They'll not profane holy *offerings*
 Of which a man of Israel brings,
 Which they offer to YHWH, 16 'or let
 Them bear the guilt of trespass yet
 When they eat their holy *offerings*,
 For I YHWH sanctify their things.'"

Both widow and divorced daughter of
 priest
 Am I, and childless in the way increased
 Of virtue, with no offering of my own,
 I come undone, Beloved, before Your
 throne.
 I bear my guilt with stained and soiled
 dress
 And lay my heart and soul at Your address.
 Once more as in my childhood I can taste
 The holy bread after my eating waste.
 My breath is feeding on the holy thing,
 There is no way to avoid golden ring,
 And so I bring with each breath my intent
 To give the one-fifth recompense for spent.
 The only way to come out of my debt
 Is to return to Your house and banquet.

17 And YHWH then spoke to Moses,
 saying
 18 "Speak to Aaron and his sons *praying*,
 And to all the children of Israel,
 And tell them, 'Who of house of Israel,
 Or of the foreigners in Israel,
 Who offers sacrifice for any

Of his vows or for any *penny*
 Of his freewill offerings, which they
 Offer to YHWH burnt offering's way,
 19 'You shall offer of your own free
 Will a male no deformity
 From the cattle, from the sheep, or
 From the goats. 20 'Whatever *in store*
 Has a defect, you shall not offer,
 For it shall not be fit to proffer
 On your behalf. 21 'And whoever
 Offers a sacrifice *to stir*
 A peace offering to YHWH, fulfilling
 A vow, or an offering freewilling
 From the cattle or from the sheep,
 It must be perfect for to keep,
 There shall be no defect in it.
 22 'Those blind or broken, maimed unfit,
 Or have ulcer on skin or scabs,
 You shall not offer for YHWH's *grabs*,
 Nor make an offering by fire of
 Them on the altar for YHWH's *love*.
 23 'Either a bull or lamb that has
 Any limb too long or such as
 Is too short you may offer *as*
 A freewill offering, but for vow
 It's not accepted anyhow.
 24 'You shall not offer to YHWH what
 Is bruised or crushed, or torn or cut,
 Nor shall you make *such* in your land.
 25 'Nor even from a stranger's hand
 Shall you offer any of these
 As the bread of your God *to please*,
 Because their corruption's in them,
 And defects *are also* in them.
 They'll not be accepted for you."
 26 And YHWH spoke to Moses what's
 true,
 Saying 27 "When a bull or a sheep
 Or a goat is born, it shall keep
 Seven days with its mother, then
 From the eighth day thereafter's when
 It shall be accepted as offering
 Made by a fire to YHWH *for proffering*.
 28 "If it's a cow or ewe, do not
 Kill both her and her young *on spot*
 On the same day. 29 "And when you offer
 A sacrifice thanksgiving's proffer
 To YHWH, offer *it* of your own
 Free will. 30 "On the same day alone
 It shall be eaten, you shall leave
 None of it until morning *cleave*:
 I am YHWH. 31 "Therefore you shall keep

My commandments, perform, *not weep*,
I am YHWH. 32 "You shall not profane
My holy name, but I'll retain
My hallowed *state* among the folk
Of Israel, I am YHWH who *spoke*
To sanctify you, 33 "who brought you
Out of the land of Egypt's *rue*,
To be your God: *for I am YHWH.*"

A stranger and a foreigner I offer
My freewill offering of myself, a doffer.
Unfortunately gifts without defect
Are given from Your hand alone, reflect.
Command me not to give an offering pure
And undeformed, the human soul is sure
To sacrifice the perfect to the sweet,
And thus deform the curving horn and
bleat.

But this I promise, as beneath the veils
I sit in bark unknowing where it sails,
That I shall keep each kid with mother till
The Sabbath has made rounds upon the hill.
It is Your Self that separates from mother
And tells the soul the lie it is another.

Leviticus 23

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
2 "Tell the folk of Israel a thing,
And say to them, 'The feasts of YHWH,
Which you shall proclaim holy due
In convocations, *are* these feasts
Of mine. 3 'Six days do work *like beasts*,
But seventh day's a Sabbath of
Solemn rest, holy gathered love.
You shall do no work *on it's score*,
It is YHWH's Sabbath in your door.

The Sabbath, weekly Sabbath, You set
down
Within the Decalogue and for a crown
On Sinai, for a crown, at least its gate
Let to Your sovereignty and ruling state.
Rule me from the throne where You sit in
fire,
The throne of Sabbath over all desire.
And in that rule let my pounding soul rest
Who's found in You its nourishment and
test.
For six days I shall work like beast of
labour
And satisfy both wife and child and
neighbour,

But on the seventh day I lay down saber.
And so my soul transcends both space and
time
While toiling at the mill and for a dime,
The Sabbath is the rung on which I climb.

Six days shall work be done, and yet
I have no work at all to do.
None need my labours nor my sweat,
My talents held as small and few.
Exempt from the dear Lord's command,
I need not lend my hand to plough,
But like blind Milton merely stand,
Let others have the what and how.
Dear God, look on the unemployed
As well as on the convocation.
Give us too Sabbath, who enjoyed
Throughout the week unpaid vacation.
Redeem the mosque and synagogue,
And churches filled with active men,
The factories, towns and trucks that clog
The roads both there and back again.
Bless them their worship and their work,
Bless them their well-earned right to rest,
But bless who have no task to shirk
And yet love Sabbath and its quest.
With neither work nor worship I
Must meet Your coming here below.
Alone, my solitary eye
Awaits at home the Sabbath glow.

4 'And these *are* the feasts of YHWH set,
Holy convocations which yet
You shall proclaim appointed times.
5 'On the fourteenth *day* of the first
Month between evenings *as rehearsed*
Is YHWH's Passover. 6 'And upon
The fifteenth day *at the next dawn*
Of the same month *arrives* the feast
To YHWH of bread baked without yeast,
Seven days you must eat your bread
Without yeast in it, *not a shred*.
7 'On the first day you'll have a holy
Convocation, you'll do no lowly
Work on it. 8 'But you'll offer an
Offering made by fire by YHWH's plan
For seven days, the seventh day's
A gathering of holy praise,
You'll do no tasks.'" 9 And YHWH spoke
to
Moses, saying 10 "Speak now unto
The children of Israel, and say

To them, 'When you come in the way
Of the land which I give to you,
And reap its harvest, so then you
Shall bring a sheaf of the firstfruits
Of your harvest to the priest's *boots*.

11 'He shall wave the sheaf before YHWH,
To be accepted what you do,
The day after the Sabbath's passed
The priest shall wave it *there at last*.

12 'And you shall offer on that day,
When you wave the sheaf *the right way*,
A male lamb of the first year, and
Without a blemish, by command
As a burnt offering to YHWH.

13 'And its grain offering *shall be* two
Tenths *of an ephah* of fine flour
And mixed with oil, an offering *hour*
Made by fire to YHWH, for sweet scent,
And its drink offering *shall be meant*
Of grape juice, one-fourth of a hin.

14 'You shall eat neither bread nor *kin*
Of parched grain nor fresh grain until
The same day that you shall fulfil
An offering to your God, *it shall*
Be a statute and eternal
Throughout your generations in
All the places which you dwell in.

The Passover and days without yeast bread
Are clearly dated at the times You said.
The day for the wave sheaf I must allow
Has no date given in the year for now.
It is attached to Sabbath and the yield
Of every green and planted barley field,
Or what grain is firstfruits. This is the point
Where all faiths come apart and out of
joint.

We all know that we eat the sprouting seed,
But few know when it comes to time of
need

To fast from parched grain and to fast from
fresh
Until the wave-sheaf meets its human flesh.
Beloved, I flee to You in sacrifice
For all the days and all virtue and vice.

15 'And you shall count for yourselves
from

The day after the Sabbath, from
The day that you brought the sheaf of
The wave offering as told above,
Seven Sabbaths shall be completed.

16 'Count fifty days to the day meted
After the seventh Sabbath, then
You shall offer a new corn offering
To YHWH. 17 'You'll bring from your
house proffering

Two wave *measures* two-tenths *of ephah*.
They shall be of fine flour, *and briefer*,
They shall be baked with yeast. *They are*
The firstfruits to YHWH *in a jar*.

18 'And you shall offer with the bread
Seven lambs of the first year *fed*,
Without blemish, and one young bull,
And two rams, they shall be *the full*
Burnt offering to YHWH, with their corn
Offering and their drink offerings borne,
An offering made by fire for sweet
Aroma to YHWH *for a treat*.

19 'Then you shall sacrifice one kid
Of the goats as sin offering's *bid*,
And two male lambs of the first year
As a peace offering to appear.

The day of Khidr, the occulted man,
Is marked by counting in the spring by
plan,
And bringing offerings to beat the band.
May Enoch and Elijah come to stand
Beside the painted tomb of Saat Kuresh
To view the people sacrificing fresh
Meat of the little goats in boiling pots.
Before You, my Beloved, all stand in lots.
They celebrate their weddings, drink their
brew

And lie down in their dreaming love for
You,
Met from the early morning and the dew,
Plunged in the slighting river for a pew.
I taste the day anew and hear the strings
Of baghlama plucked under angel wings.

20 'The priest shall wave them with the
bread
Of the firstfruits *as* wave sheaf led
Before YHWH, with the two lambs, they
Shall be holy to YHWH *that day*
For the priest. 21 'And you shall proclaim
On the same day *that it's the same*,
Your holy convocation, you
Shall do no work, a statute *true*
Forever in all your dwellings
Throughout your generations' *rings*.

22 'When you shall reap your land's
harvest,
You shall not wholly reap the *best*
Corners of your field when you reap,
Nor shall you gather *in to keep*
The gleanings from your harvest, you
Shall leave them for the poor and few,
The stranger: I your God *am* YHWH."

The awkward questioner stands to make
clear

When the fifty days ought to start the year,
And further whether fifty adds thereto
To make a hundred days and not a few.
And so the wrangling for the almanac
Distracts us from giving the poor a snack,
Which was the culmination of this law
Before which we stand with and without
awe.

Beloved, give me the harvest in its time
And keep me from the common mill and
crime

Of eating all my store and coming late
To hand a crust to humble and to great.
And I shall count the weeks of earthly
climb

Into the splendour of divine estate.

23 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
24 "Speak to Israel's folk, and saying
'In the seventh month, on the first
Day of the month, you'll have *immersed*
A Sabbath, a memorial of
Blowing of trumpets, gathering of
Sacredness. 25 'You shall do no work,
And you shall offer *and not shirk*
An offering made by fire to YHWH."

26 And YHWH spoke to Moses *his due*,
Saying 27 "Also the tenth *day* of
This seventh month *shall be* day of
Atonement, it shall be a holy
Convocation for you, you'll lowly
Afflict your souls, and offer an
Offering made in fire by YHWH's plan.
28 "And you shall do no work that day,
For it *is* the atonement day,
To make atonement for you *there*
Before YHWH your Alohim's *care*.

29 "For any person who is not
Afflicted on that same day taught
Shall be cut off from his people.

30 "And any person to annul

It by work on that day, that one
I will destroy from his folk *done*.

31 "You shall do no manner of work,
Eternal statute through your *lurk*
Of generations where you live.

32 "It's Sabbath for you and to give
A rest, and you'll afflict your souls,
On the ninth of the month as tolls
The evening, from evening till eve,
You'll celebrate Sabbath's reprieve."

Although the year move back ten days or
so,
And some count years by fall or spring so
slow,

And heathens watch the winter take a step
And mark that for the first of every prep,
I flee to You to know the roundelay
Of seasons from year down to Sabbath's
way.

The evening marks the start of the new day.
There's no word to confound and mix the
true,

Although some start their days at night
when few

Are still awake to give the welcome to
The blessing from Your hand to eat and do.
And some start days at morning dawn and
light,

But I, Beloved, begin my days with night
Of prayer and rest after the waning light.

33 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
34 "Speak to Israel's folk, *go ahead*,
'The fifteenth day of this seventh
Month *shall be also like the tenth*

A feast of booths *for* seven days
To YHWH. 35 'On the first day a holy
Convocation, you'll do no *lowly*
Work. 36 'Upon seven days you'll offer
An offering made by fire and *proffer*
To YHWH, on the eighth day you'll make
A holy convocation wake,

And you shall offer offering made
By fire to YHWH, a sacred stayed
Assembly, *and* you'll do no work.

37 'These *are* the feasts of YHWH *to clerk*
Which you shall proclaim to be holy
Convocations, to offer wholly
An offering made by fire to YHWH,
A burnt offering and corn *to chew*,
A sacrifice and drink offerings,

Everything in its day that brings
 38 'Besides the sabbaths of YHWH, and
 Besides your gifts, and all your vows,
 Besides all your free will allows
 Of offerings which you give to YHWH.
 39 'Also on the fifteenth day and
 Of the seventh month, *by command*,
 When you have gathered in the fruit
 Of the land, you shall keep *to boot*
 The feast of YHWH for seven days,
 On the first day a sabbath *stays*,
 And on the eighth day sabbath *rest*.
 40 'And you'll take for yourselves *the best*
 On the first day the fruit of good (*Citrus*
medica)

Trees, and the branches of palms stood,
 The boughs of leafy trees, and willows
 Of the brook, and *like armadillos*
 You shall rejoice before YHWH your
 Alohim for seven days *more*.
 41 'You shall keep it a feast to YHWH
 For seven days in the year *too*.
It shall be a statute forever
 In your generations *and clever*.
 In seventh month you'll celebrate
 It 42 'and you'll live in booths *in state*
 For seven days, all native-born
 Israelites shall live in booths' *thorn*,
 43 'That your generations may know
 That I made Israel's folk *below*
 To live in booths when I brought them
 Out of the land of Egypt's hem:
I am YHWH and your Alohim."
 44 So Moses declared, *it would seem*,
 To Israel's folk *what they should do*
 On all the *yearly* feasts of YHWH.

The weekly Sabbath starts this law and
 makes
 The week the time unit that the year takes
 To describe in its round of season and
 Month feasty days and times of Your
 command
 To recognize that You control the land
 And bring from it the bread that all may
 eat.
 Beloved, I take your monthly, yearly treat
 With thanks that You have shown at last
 your feet.
 I sit with You in brush booth and partake
 Of sacrificial kid and chicken steak,
 And fatten up my bones on date and pear

And all the tasty herbs that fill their ware.
 With You, Beloved, I take my pleasant
 meal
 And drink the rich wines in Your hand to
 heal.

Leviticus 24

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 2 "Command Israel's people to tread
 Bringing to you pure oil of pressed
 Olives for the light, to make dressed
 The lamps to burn continually.
 3 "Outside veil of testimony,
 In the tabernacle of meeting,
 Aaron shall be in charge of seating
 It from evening until morning
 Before YHWH and continuing,
 A statute for all generations.
 4 "He'll be in charge of regulations
 Of lamps on the pure *gold* lampstand
 Before YHWH by eternal hand.
 5 "And you shall take fine flour and bake
 Twelve cakes with it, two-tenths each cake.
 6 "You shall set them out in two rows,
 Six in a row, on the pure *gold*
 Table before YHWH *where it shows*.
 7 "And you shall put pure and unfold
 Frankincense on *each* row, that it
 May be on the bread to remit
 Memorial, an offering made
 By fire to YHWH *for where it stayed*.
 8 "Every Sabbath he'll set it out
 In order before YHWH about
 Continually from Israel's folk
 By everlasting pact invoke.
 9 "And it shall be for Aaron and
 His sons, to eat it *by command*
 In holy place, for it's most holy
 To him from the offerings *not lowly*
 Of YHWH and always made by fire,
 By a perpetual statute *spire*."

It may be every shepherd dreams of eating
 From tables, not from lunch spread on the
 ground.
 So David was not missed from King Saul's
 seating
 Whenever first of the month would come
 round.
 Now tables are the thing, and made of gold
 If may be to please populace and king,

And decked with frankincense and bread
 twelfefold
 To smell and taste as good as anything.
 While day to day it may seem life grows
 stale
 And turns from perfume toward the
 crumbling crust,
 Behind its ordinary, shimmering veil,
 Beneath its weekly gathering of dust,
 Each Sabbath day the board again is
 spread.
 Each Sabbath day's the smell of fresh-
 baked bread.

Throughout the week the priest awaits
 The dawn of Sabbath day
 When angels standing at the gates
 Shall turn their guard away.
 And as the hosts toward heaven climb
 They meet descending there
 The changing guard who take their time
 Upon the golden stair.
 And as the angels linger on
 Exchanging news of earth
 For word of heaven's eternal dawn,
 Exchanging truth for mirth,
 The old shewbread unguarded lies,
 The new comes into view.
 And so the priest eats what his eyes
 Throughout the week pursue.
 For even manna cannot vie,
 Nor with which kings are fed,
 For taste and savour satisfy,
 Like week-old Sabbath bread.
 Let me, O Lord, remember then
 The Sabbath portion now,
 And taste its blessing once again,
 And so renew my vow.
 Let faith and truth throughout the week
 On my heart's altar stay,
 That I may ever daily seek
 The taste of Sabbath day.

10 An Israelitish woman's son
 Whose father *was* an Egyptian,
 Went out among the children of
 Israel, and this Israelite son
 And a man of Israel above
 In camp with one another strove.
 11 And the Israelite woman's son
 Blasphemed the Name and cursed when
 done,

And they brought him to Moses' seat.
 His mother's name *was* Shelomith
 The daughter of Dibri, and tribe
 Of Dan. 12 They put him in proscribe,
 That the mind of YHWH might be shown
 To them. 13 YHWH told Moses *alone*,
 Saying 14 "Take him outside the camp
 For cursing, then let every scamp
 Who heard lay their hands on his head,
 And let all the assembly dread
 Stone him. 15 "Then you shall speak to
 folk

Of Israel, saying 'Who invoke
 In curses his Alohims shall
 Bear his sin. 16 'And who prodigal
 Blasphemes the name of YHWH shall
 surely

Be put to death, all the folk early
 Shall certainly stone him, the stranger
 As well as him born as a *ranger*
 In the land, who blasphemers the Name
He shall be put to death *for shame*.

17 'Whoever kills any man shall
 Surely be put in death's *canal*.

18 'Whoever kills an animal
 Shall make it good, a beast for beast.

19 'If a man causes damage done
 Upon his neighbour, as he's done,

So shall it be done unto him,
 20 'Fracture for fracture, eye for *dim*

Eye, tooth for tooth, as he has caused
 Damage to man, so shall it *paused*

Be done to him. 21 'Whoever kills
 A beast shall restore it, who kills

A man shall be put to death though.
 22 'You shall have the same law to go

For stranger and for one from your
 Own country, for I *am* YHWH your

Alohims'" 23 Then Moses spoke to
 The children of Israel to do,

And they took him outside the camp
 For cursing, and they stoned the scamp.

So the children of Israel did
 As YHWH commanded Moses' *bid*.

This comment on the Decalogue's
 command

To reverence Your name gets out of hand.
 That is the way of justice everywhere:

A bully baits the foreigner to share
 A cup and then flashes the sign of hate
 Or merely patronizing his estate,

And that son of Egyptian, or of late
 Gypsy or what you will with dark skin or
 With light, rises to hit back at the score.
 It's hitting back that is defined by law
 As outside right behaviour with a claw.
 Was not Your name profaned when full-
 blood man
 Cast his despising on the half-cast clan?
 You should have said to Moses what You
 saw.

Week 32 Leviticus 25

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses upon
 Mount Sinai, saying 2 "To the drawn
 Children of Israel, speak and say
 To them, 'When you come in the way
 To the land which I give to you,
 The land shall keep Sabbath to YHWH.
 3 'For six years you shall sow your field,
 And six years you shall prune the yield
 Of your vineyard, and gather fruit,
 4 'But in the seventh year compute
 There shall be a Sabbath of rest
 For the land, a Sabbath invest
 To YHWH. You shall neither sow field
 Nor prune your vineyard *of its yield*.
 5 'What grows of its own accord of
 Your harvest you shall not reap *dove*,
 Nor gather the grapes of your vine,
 Untended vine, *for it's a shrine*,
 A year of rest for the land's *mine*.
 6 'And the land's Sabbath *produce* shall
 Be food for you *not prodigal*:
 For you, your male and female slave,
 Your hired man, and the stranger *grave*
 Who dwells with you, 7 'for your livestock
 And the beasts in your land *and flock*
 All its produce shall be for crock.

My field produces neither grape nor corn
 Despite six years successively at rest.
 I've neither ploughed nor planted, both
 hawthorn
 And plum are unpruned. I have done my
 best.
 Now I shall keep commandment to the
 letter
 And harvest nothing that the seventh year
 May of its own accord produce that's better
 Than what I haven't touched of seed and
 ear.
 Too long, too eagerly I've kept the Sabbath

Both of life's weeks and of its harvest
 seasons.
 Too rich, each day and year its blessings
 grabbeth
 And turns them all to Sabbaths without
 reasons.
 My fallow fields, while I write rhymed
 epistles,
 Produce each year a crop of purple thistles.

8 'Seven Sabbaths of years you'll count,
 Seven times seven years' amount,
 And the time of seven Sabbaths' years
 Shall be to you forty-nine years.
 9 'Then you shall cause the trumpet of
 The Jubilee to sound *above*
 On the seventh month's *second week*
 On the tenth *day*, day *when they seek*
 Atonement, you shall make the trumpet
 To sound through all your land *like*
 strumpet.
 10 'And you'll consecrate the *next year*,
 The fiftieth year, and proclaim
 Liberty throughout *all the frame*
Of the land to all its dwellers,
 It shall be Jubilee for fers,
 And each of you'll return to his
 Possession, and each of you is
 To return to his own family.
 11 'So that fiftieth year shall be
 A Jubilee to you, in it
 You'll neither sow nor reap a bit
 Of what grows of its own accord,
 Nor gather *the grapes* of your horde
 Untended vine. 12 'It's Jubilee,
 And to you it shall be holy,
 You shall eat its yield from the field.
 13 'In this year of Jubilee's *shield*,
 Each of you shall return to his
 Possession. 14 'And if you sell whiz
 Of anything to your neighbour
 Or buy from your neighbour's labour,
 You'll not oppress the other's *peer*.
 15 'According to number of year
 After the Jubilee you'll buy
The land from your neighbour, and by
 The number of years of crops he
 Shall sell to you. 16 'Accordingly
 By number of years you'll increase
 Its price, and by the years' decrease
 You shall diminish from its price,
 For he sells to you by the number

Of crops *you'll get and by the lumber.*

Your pasture is well-watered and it wears
A necklace by the gate of blackberry vines.
The house looks like it's built for
millionaires.

Your mountain has good stocks of oaks and
pines.

In summer I'd be wary of the cows
While I was picking berries by the way.
In fall I'd keep an eye out where deer
browse

While gathering walnuts. Now, what do
you say?

At any other time I couldn't buy
A place like this no more than I could own
The silver sea, the air, the sun or sky.
But now is the last day of lend and loan.
Tomorrow starts the year of Jubilee.
For two cents will you sell this field to me?

17 'Therefore you shall not oppress one
Another, but you'll fear the one
Who is your God, for I *am* YHWH
Your Alohim. 18 'And as for you,
You shall observe My statutes and
Keep My judgements, and by them stand
And you'll live safely in the land.
19 'And then the land will yield its fruit,
And you'll eat filled and safe to boot.

This time I don't complain of violence
Done in the street for lust or greed despite
The law. Now I deplore the fraudulence
Of institutions which should serve the right.
The promise is that those who keep Your
word

And follow what You say that people
should,

Instead of plodding in the bleating herd,
Will live in safety and enjoy the good.
But now we find a country where the law
Encourages its citizens to strike
The children of the few who stand in awe
Of Your commandments and the law alike.
Curse, Lord, this land and those who dwell
therein

And let them fry in hell for all their sin.

20 'And if you say "What shall we eat
In seventh year, since we'll retreat
From sowing and gathering the yield?"

21 'Then I'll command blessing on *field*
For you in the sixth year, and it
Will bring forth produce requisite
For three years. 22 'And you shall sow in
The eighth year, and eat old yield in
It till the ninth year, and until
Its harvest comes, you'll eat *your fill*
Of the old *harvest without sin.*

Command indeed, Beloved, a blessing on
My field to grow corn, grapes and
thistledawn.

Command the sun to share the colours of
The leaf in bud and then the leaf in love.

Command the noon on harvest from the
share

Of snapdragons and foxgloves on the row
That covers up the drain line with its grow,
And on the lilacs spreading by the well,
And on the roses trailing fruit and spell
About the feet of useless apple trees.

Command three years in one and one to
please

Both cherry and the pippin on the breeze.
Command indeed, Beloved, my quiet heart
To find You always harvesting my part.

23 'The land shall not be sold for good,
For the land's Mine, for you *have stood*
As strangers *on it*, guests with Me.

24 'And in all the land of your fee
You'll grant redemption of the land.

25 'If one of your brothers *in hand*
Becomes poor, and has sold his loom,
And his redeeming kin in room
Comes to redeem it, then he may
Redeem what his brother gave way.

26 'Or if the man has no one to
Redeem, but he himself *in due*
Time becomes able to redeem,

27 'Then let him count the years *in stream*
Since its sale, and restore the rest
To the man to whom he thought best
To sell it, that he may return

To his possession. 28 'But *in turn*
If he's not able to have *it*
Restored to himself, the outfit
That was sold shall remain in hand
Of him who bought it *by command*
Until the year of Jubilee,
And in the Jubilee let be
Released, and he shall return to

His own possession. 29 'If *in lieu*
 A man sells a house in a walled
 City, then he may have recalled
 It within a whole year after
 It is sold, *within* a full year
 He may redeem it. 30 'But if it
 Is not redeemed within permit
 Of the space of a full year, then
 The house in the walled city's ken
 Shall permanently be his own
 Who bought it, generations flown,
 It shall not be released when comes
 The Jubilee. 31 '*Aside from slums*
 The houses of villages which
 Have no wall around them *or ditch*
 Shall be counted as country fields,
 They may be redeemed with their yields,
 And be released in Jubilee.
 32 'But the cities of the Levites,
And houses in their cities' rights,
 The Levites may redeem in time.
 33 'And if a man purchase a *prime*
 House from the Levites, then the flat
 That was sold in the city at
 His possession shall be released
 In Jubilee, for the houses
 In Levite cities, they are his
 Possession among Israel.
 34 'But the field of the common well
 Of their cities may not be sold,
 For it *is* their perpetual hold.
 35 'If one of your brothers becomes
 Poor, and falls into straightened sums
 Among you, then you shall help him,
 Like a stranger or guest *with vim*,
 That he may live with you. 36 'Take no
 Usury or interest from him,
 But fear your God, that your brother
 May live with you *and not suffer*.
 37 'You shall not lend him your money
 For usury, nor grocery
 Lend at a profit. 38 'I *am* YHWH
 Your Alohim, and who brought you
 Out of the land of Egypt, to
 Give to you Canaan's land to plod
And I alone to be your God.

You make the human bird alive to be
 As territorial as well as free.
 This new and redolent society
 Gives up the clanly land for freedom to

Work everywhere the world shall lead him
 through.
 To bind another in such service is
 It seems the best thing one can find for his,
 And to be bound to such is promise of
 Career in specialty with hand in glove.
 To stay and dabble on ancestral land
 Is the last thing we want who would be
 grand.
 Two generations since the will was there,
 But even that was dispossessing share.
 I flee to digging on the ditch's strand.
 39 'And if *one of* your brothers by
 You becomes poor, and *not to die*
 Sells himself to you, you shall not
 Compel him to serve in slave's lot.
 40 'As a hired servant *and* a guest
 He shall be with you, *and* serve best
 Until the year of Jubilee.
 41 'And *then* he shall depart and free
 From you, he and his children too,
 And go back to his own family.
 He'll return to his fathers' lot.
 42 'For they *are* My servants I've brought
 Out of the land of Egypt, they
 Shall not be sold as slaves *a day*.
 43 'You'll not rule over him with rigour,
 But you shall fear your God *with vigour*.
 44 'And as for your male and female
 Slaves whom you may have from the sale
 Of nations that are around you,
 From them you may buy slaves for you
 Male and female. 45 'Moreover you
 May buy the children of the strangers
 Who live among you *out of dangers*,
 And their families who are with you,
 Which they beget in your land too,
 And they shall be your property.
 46 'And you may take them as in fee
 For your children after you, to
 Inherit *them as* a possession,
 They'll be your permanent accession.
 But regarding your brothers, folk
 Of Israel, you shall put no yoke
 To rule with vigour over them.
 47 'Now if a sojourner pro tem
 Or stranger close to you gets rich,
 And your brother near him in switch
 Gets poor, and sells himself to him,
 A stranger *or* guest interim
 And close to you, or to a member

Of stranger's family *remember*,
 48 'After he's sold he may again
 Be redeemed by one of the men
 Of his brothers to redeem him,
 49 'Or his uncle or uncle's limb
 May redeem him, or *anyone*
 Who's near of kin to him begun
 In his family may redeem
 Him, or if he has able scheme
 He may redeem himself. 50 'Thus he
 Shall reckon with him who paid fee,
 The price of his release shall be
 According to number of years,
 From the year he was sold *arrears*
 To him till year of Jubilee,
It shall be according to time
 Of a hired servant for his climb.
 51 'If *there are* still many years *left*,
 According to them he enfeoffed
 Shall repay his redemption price
 From the money *by the advice*
 With which he was bought. 52 'And if there
 Remain but a few years *in share*
 Until the year of Jubilee,
 Then he shall reckon with his fee,
And according to his years he
 Shall repay him redemption price.
 53 'He shall be with him as a yearly
 And hired servant, and not nearly
 With rigour shall he rule by right
 Over him *only* in your sight.
 54 'And if in these *years* he is not
 Redeemed, then he'll return to lot
 In the year of the Jubilee,
 He and his children with him *free*.
 55 'For the children of Israel *are*
 Servants to Me, they *are* My *star*
 Servants whom I brought out of sod
 Of Egypt: I *am* YHWH your God.

Instead of redemption to freedom at
 The end of fifty years from where we sat,
 We now get charities at sixty-five,
 And still remain a servant of the hive.
 Ah, my Beloved, come back with Jubilee,
 I thirst for Jubilees to be set free
 From all the taxes that go into war
 To find more oil before we run ashore.
 I have no brother who can give the price
 Of my redemption from the strangle vice
 Of good and evil on a foreign strand.
 And neither do I have ancestral land

When I can be free under my fig tree.
 Ah yes, I too long for the Jubilee.

Leviticus 26

1 'You shall not make idols for your
 Selves, neither a carved image nor
 A *sacred* pillar shall you rear
 Up for yourselves, nor shall you *fear*
 An engraved stone set by your land,
 To bow down to it *in the land*,
 For I *am* YHWH your Alohim.
 2 You shall keep My Sabbaths and deem
 My sanctuary holy for
 I'm YHWH your God for evermore.

The graven image and the church of stone
 Make boundaries for God in time and
 space.
 For that they are forbidden, not alone
 For form and beauty, artifice and grace.
 The painted basalt face for all its charm
 Is but a mask to hide me from Your gaze.
 Cathedral walls may do me little harm
 But cut me off from heaven's seventh days.
 There is no roof nor creed however humble
 But shuts out light of sky and wonderment
 And leaves my feet in confidence to
 stumble
 Which might in faith have made the grand
 ascent.
 Each Sabbath prayer in poverty of mime
 Unites in vast democracies of time.

Week 33

3 'If you walk in My statutes and
 Keep My commandments, and put hand
 To perform them, 4 then I will give
 You rain in its season *to live*,
 The land shall yield its produce, trees
 Of the field shall yield fruit *to please*.

They usually say please don't walk on the
 grass,
 And that's because some people like to
 think
 In negatives, and they are those alas
 Who are the scientists, or like to drink,
 Or victims of some other mental illness.
 By contrast You say if you please then
 walk,
 Which is, for heart disease, a step on
 stillness,

And doing is much better than the talk.
 Your statute is a ten-step ring-around-
 The-rosie, good enough to take the place
 Of May Day and St. John's Day out of
 bound
 Where men stomp and the women drop
 their lace.
 But primitives were right in their
 mischance
 That rain depends on how well people
 dance.

5 Your threshing shall last till the time
 Of vintage, and the vintage *clime*
 Shall last till the time of sowing,
 You'll eat your bread and everything
 To the full, and live in your land
 In safety *and on every hand*.

If there's so much to harvest that the
 canning
 Takes all my days until it's time to plant,
 My lazy streak rebels against Your
 planning
 And feels Your blessings are extravagant.
 And if the vintage lasts until we sow,
 It seems that most of it will turn to wine,
 And in that case the blessing's overflow
 Is worthy more of drunken Philistine.
 I'm temperate and lazy, it is true,
 But bread and safety meet with my
 approval,
 Although with bread alone one may not do,
 And safety sometimes means someone's
 removal.
 The pity is that safety and fresh bread
 Are the religion of the overfed.

6 I'll give peace in the land, and you
 Shall lie down, and none will make *you*
 Afraid, I will rid the land of
 Evil beasts, and the sword *above*
 Will not go through your land. 7 You will
 Chase enemies, *all yours of ill*
 And they shall fall down by the sword
 Before you. 8 Five of you *as lord*
 Shall chase a hundred, and of you
 A hundred shall put *all in queue*
 Ten thousand to flight, as they do
 Your enemies without a clue
 Shall fall by the sword before you.

Some people think that peace is when the
 world
 Goes on a May Day celebration, drinks,
 Enjoys parades of flashing thighs and
 twirled
 Batons, toots horns, and lays a curse and
 jinx
 On those who rarely scatter flowers and
 those
 Who make war and not love. No need to
 think
 About preserving freedom since one pose
 Now fits the soul of everyone like pink,
 And freedom, outside marketing, is quaint
 And cunning aberration with no rights.
 There used to be pretence of no complaint
 Of dying for one's freedom in the fights,
 And peace meant thrilling to a rebel yell
 And five men chasing hundreds into hell.

9 'For I will look on you with favour
 And make you fruitful, *though not slaver*,
 And multiply you and confirm
 My promise with you *to discern*.
 10 You shall eat the old harvest, and
 Clear out the old from the new stand.
 11 I'll set My tabernacle by
 You, and My soul shall not decry
 You. 12 I will walk among you and
 Be your Alohims *in the land*,
 And you shall be My folk in hand.

Raccoon or porcupine tracks by the tent
 Or tabernacle, word the Good Book uses,
 Suffice to set my inborn mystic bent
 A-shudder and a-tingle with the Muses.
 For that experience people travel miles
 And even carry packs on portages.
 My signs of wildness do not come in piles
 And magic sights appear in shortages.
 The unseen walking round the place
 arouses
 Excitement, awe and sometimes even fear.
 It banishes the mundane from our houses,
 Turns water into wine when the coast's
 clear.
 It's unexpected, at least heretofore,
 To find at morning Your tracks by the door.

13 I *am* YHWH your God, who brought
 you
 Out of Egypt's land, and that *you*

Should not be their slaves, I have broken
 The bands of your yoke, *as I've spoken*,
 Made walk upright in what you do.
 14 'But if you do not obey Me,
 And don't observe all *faithfully*
 Doing these commandments, 15 and if
 You despise My statutes *as stiff*,
 Or if your soul abhors the way
 Of My judgements, so that you stay
 Your hand from doing what I say,
But break My covenant *one day*,
 16 I also will do this to you:
 I'll even appoint terror to
 Be over you, wasting disease
 And fever which shall take what sees
 The eye and cause sorrow of heart.
 And you shall sow your seed *apart*
 In vain, for your foes shall eat it.
 17 I'll set My face, against you pit,
 And you shall be defeated by
 Your enemies, those who defy
 You shall reign over you, and you
 Shall flee when no one pursues you.
 18 'And after all this, if you do
 Not obey Me, I'll punish you
 Seven times more for *all* your sins.
 19 I'll break the pride of all your wins,
 I'll make your skies like iron, your earth
 Like bronze. 20 And your strength shall be
 worth
 A vain thing, for your land shall not
 Yield its produce, nor shall the *hot*
 Trees of the land yield up their fruit.
 21 'Then, if you will act wrong to boot
 Against Me, and not willing to
 Obey Me, I will bring on you
 Seven times more plagues, for your sins.
 22 I'll also send wild beasts *in skins*
 Among you, which shall rob you of
 Your children, livestock, *that you love*,
 And make you few in number, and
 Your highways desolate *in land*.
 23 'And if by these things you are not
 Reformed by Me, but walk untaught
 By Me, 24 then I also will walk
 Contrary to you, and I'll *mock*
And punish you yet seven times
 For your sins *and for all your crimes*.
 25 And I'll bring a sword against you
 That will execute vengeance due
 And of the covenant, when you
 Are gathered within your cities

I'll send pestilences *like fleas*
 Among you, and you'll be given to
 The hand of *your* enemy *true*.
 26 When I have cut off your supply
 Of bread, ten women shall bake pie
 In one oven, and they shall bring
 Back your bread by weight *and by ring*,
 And you shall eat unsatisfied.
 27 'And after all this, if you do
 Not obey Me, but walk untrue
 To Me, 28 then I also will walk
 Against you in fury *and frock*,
 And I, even I, will chastise
 You seven times for your sins' wise.
 29 You'll eat the flesh of your *own* sons,
 Your daughters' flesh you'll eat *with buns*.
 30 And I will destroy your high places,
 Cut down your incense altars' *traces*,
 And cast your carcasses upon
 The dead forms of your idols' *spawn*,
 And My soul shall abhor you *too*.
 31 I'll lay your cities waste *that grew*
 And bring your sanctuaries to
 Desolation, and I will not
 Smell the scent of the sweets you brought.
 32 I'll bring the land to desolation,
 And your foes who live in the nation
 Shall be astonished at it. 33 I
 Will scatter you among the cry
 Of nations and draw out a sword
 After you, your land shall be scored
 With desolate and cities' waste.
 34 Then the land shall enjoy its rest
 As long as it lies desolate
 And you *are* in your foes' estate,
 The land shall lie enjoying rest.
 35 As long as *it* lies desolate
 It shall rest, for the time it did
 Not rest on your Sabbaths, *but hid*,
 When you lived in it *and not late*.

Do tell that plagues and wars and
 desolations
 Result from negligence of fallow land
 And failure to perform good crop rotations.
 Insightful theory of a master-hand
 Suggests that worn-out land at last rebels
 And punishes its occupants for greed.
 No human quite believes the judgement
 bells,
 And yet exchanges quality for speed.

The way to wealth is paved with leisure
hours
Strewn ordered and precise through years
of toil,
And pauses to appreciate spring flowers,
And prayers in honour of respectful soil.
Land Sabbath's a first warning of our fate.
Stand off a day, and penance comes too
late.

36 'And as for those of you who are
Left, I will send faintness to jar
Their hearts in the lands of their foes,
The sound when a shaken leaf goes
Shall cause them to flee, they shall flee
As though fleeing from sword's *army*,
And they shall fall when none pursues.
37 They shall stumble over their dues,
As it were before a sword, when
No one pursues, and you shall gain
No *strength* to stand before the main
Of your foes. 38 You shall perish there
Among the nations *without care*,
And the land of your enemies
Shall eat you up *as when they please*.

The direst threat is not that we are eaten
By earth. That's but the fate of everyone,
Save that one sect that still cannot be
beaten,
Whose dead are set in towers beneath the
sun,
A banquet for the vultures. No, the threat
Lies in the fact the land at last to eat us
Is not our own, though pricked with violet
And fern, but theirs who have come to
defeat us.
They lie in peace who fertilize the field
From which their children's children take
their food.
But souls lie anguished, fretful and
unhealed
Who lie beneath the roots of devils' brood.
Lord, give me Sabbath rest beneath a plot
Where live the grateful for the thread
they've got.

39 And those of you who may be left
Shall waste away in sins bereft
In the land of your enemies,
In their fathers' iniquities,

Which are with them, they'll waste *and*
freeze.

40 'But if they confess their sins and
The sins done at their fathers' hand,
With their unfaithfulness in which
They were unfaithful to My *pitch*,
And that they also have walked in
Ways contrary to Me *in sin*,
41 And I also have walked contrary
To them and have brought them to bury
In the land of their enemies,
If their uncircumcised hearts please
To be humbled, accept their guilt,
42 Then I will remember My built
Covenant with Jacob, and My
Covenant with Isaac and My
Covenant with Abraham I
Will remember, I'll remember
The land and every cursed *fer*.
43 The land also shall be left empty
By them, *with nothing there to tempt you*,
And will enjoy its Sabbaths while
It lies desolate without *smile*,
They will accept their guilt, because
They despised My judgements *and laws*,
Because their soul abhorred My laws.
44 Yet for all that, when they are in
Their enemies' land *for their sin*,
I shall not cast them out, away,
Nor shall I abhor them *that day*,
Utterly to destroy their way,
And break My covenant with them,
For I *am* YHWH their God *and gem*.
45 But for their sake I will remember
Their fathers' covenant *like ember*,
Whom I brought out of Egypt's land
In sight of the nations, that I
Might be their God: for it is I
Who am YHWH.'" 46 These *are* the
statutes
And judgements and laws' attributes
Which YHWH made between Himself and
The folk of Israel *on the sand*
Of Mount Sinai by Moses' hand.

I'm mostly European in my stock,
Though redskin does play havoc with the
block,
And half the time that uncouth barbarity
Shows in my speech or at least thought set
free
To ramble through the dark syllabary

Of Indian words. I have no pedigree
To Jacob or to Ishmael or their sons.
Yet I remain to seek the benisons
Of those who walk Your statutes to home-
runs.

Remember then, not fathers and their gains,
But that I too seek You in forest lanes
And in the by-ways furthest from the strife,
And find you in the greyest autumn rains
And after winter in eternal life.

Leviticus 27

1 Now YHWH spoke to Moses, and said

2 "Speak to Israel's folk *overspread*,
And say to them, 'When a man sets

Apart by consecration debts,
Persons to YHWH, according to

Your valuation, 3 'if your due
Is of a male from twenty years
Old up to sixty years, *no sneers*,

Your valuation shall be fifty
Shekels of silver, by the gift
Of sanctuary. 4 'If female,

Then your valuation *like sale*
Shall be thirty shekels, 5 'and if
From five years old up to a *stiff*

Twenty years old, then your value
For a male shall be twenty due,
And for a female ten shekels,

6 'And if from a month old *it tells*
Up to five years old, your value
For a male shall be five shekels

Of silver, and for a female
Your valuation then must trail
To three shekels of silver, 7 'and

If it's from sixty years old and
Above, if *it is* a male, then
Your valuation shall for men

Be fifteen shekels, for female
Ten shekels. 8 'But if his regale
Is too poor to pay your value,

Then he'll appear before the priest,
And the priest shall set value due
For him, according to decreased

Ability of him who vowed,
The priest shall value him *allowed*.
9 'If *it's* an animal that men

May bring as offering to YHWH, then
All that *one* gives to YHWH shall be
Holy. 10 'He shall not exchange fee

In substitution good for bad
Or bad for good, if he's *the lad*

To exchange animal at all
For another beast by the call,
Then both it and the one exchanged
For it shall be holy *arranged*.

11 'If *it's* an unclean beast which they
Don't offer as a sacrifice

To YHWH, then he shall bring away
The beast before the priest *suffice*,

12 'And the priest shall set its value,
Whether it's good or bad, as you,
The priest, value it, so let be.

13 'But if he will at all *be free*

To redeem it, then he must add

One-fifth to the value you had.

Even in matriarchies woman's weight
In payment for the crime of slaughter hate
Is only half the price valued for men.
It's only in the civilized and fine
West where the wealthy pay to wine and
dine

And then bed young girls of a specimen,
That price of woman reaches to the prime.
Equality for women is a crime,

Or must be so construed before it's met
In the society we have to get.
Perhaps You don't believe we've got so far

As to see figures in each model star.
Beloved, I add one-fifth in value to
The sacrifice of myself now to You.

14 'When a man consecrates his house
Holy to YHWH, then priest *not mouse*
Shall set a value for it, if
It's good or bad, as in a jiff
The priest evaluates, so be.

15 'If he who consecrates to be
Holy redeems his house, then he
Must add one-fifth of the money
Of your set value, and it is

His own. 16 'If a man part of his
Inherited field dedicates
To YHWH, then your set value rates
According to its seed, a homer
Of barley seed *to the aroma*

Of fifty silver shekels. 17 'If
He consecrates his field *or cliff*

From the year of the Jubilee,
By the set value that you see
It shall stand full price. 18 'And if he
Consecrates after Jubilee,
Then the priest shall reckon to him

The money due his field *with vim*
 According to the years remaining
 Till year of Jubilee, and it
 Shall be deducted as befit
 From your evaluation *kit*.
 19 'If he who dedicates the field
 Wishes to redeem the field's yield,
 Then he must add one-fifth the money
 Of your evaluation's sunny,
 And it shall be his own again.
 20 'But if he does not want *the glen*,
 To redeem the field, or if he
 Has sold another man the field,
 Redeemed it shall not surely be,
 21 'But as for the said field *and yield*,
 When it's released in Jubilee,
 Shall be holy to YHWH, as field
 Devoted to the priest's possession.
 22 'And if a man *in his confession*
 Consecrates to YHWH a field which
 He's bought, which is not his possession,
 23 'Then the priest shall reckon the field
 To him in worth of valuation,
 Up to the year *and to the station*
 Of Jubilee, and he shall give
 Your valuation on that day
 Holy to YHWH, *and so shall live*.
 24 'In year of Jubilee that way
 The field shall return to him from
 Whom it was bought, and so in sum
 To the one whose land was possession.
 25 'And all your valuations' session
 Shall be by sanctuary shekel
 And twenty gerahs to the shekel.

The cycles of economy are squared
 To suit territorial demands bared.
 Each year the droppings dote upon the load
 A little less, and so the greedy goad
 Loses its bite and we are forced to share.
 The only problem with the law You dare
 To list here is that no one will improve
 Upon its doing for fear of the groove.
 One said if You preserve the fowl of air
 And lily of the field within Your care,
 Then surely You will bless the homely state
 Of him who goes on pilgrimage with mate,
 And finds along the way a root or grove
 Laid up with fruit and berry in its trove.

26 'But the firstborn of every beast,
 Which is YHWH's firstborn *and increased*,

No man shall consecrate, be ox
 Or sheep, *for it is YHWH's own flocks*.
 27 'And if *it is* an unclean beast,
 Then he'll redeem *it* by your *priest*
 Evaluation, and shall add
 One-fifth to it, or if it's had
 Not for redemption, it shall be
 Sold at your set value and fee.
 28 'Nevertheless no consecrated
 Thing that a man devotes *elated*
 To YHWH of all that he has, man
 Or beast, or field *owned by his clan*,
 Shall be sold or redeemed, each one
 Devoted's most holy to YHWH.
 29 'No person under ban *undone*,
 Who may come under sentence to
 Destruction among men, shall be
 Redeemed, *but he* shall surely be
 Put to death. 30 'And all the tithe of
 The land, *whether* of the seed of
 The land *or* of the fruit of tree,
Is YHWH's, to YHWH *it is* holy.
 31 'If a man will at all redeem
Any of his tithes, he shall scheme
 To add one-fifth to it, *the cream*.
 32 'And concerning the tithe of herd
 Or flock, of whatever goes stirred
 Under the rod, the tenth one shall
 Be holy to YHWH *eternal*.
 33 'He shall not inquire whether it
 Is good or bad, nor exchange fit,
 And if he exchange it at all,
 Then both it and residual
 Exchanged for it shall be holy,
 Redeemed it surely shall not be.'" 34 These *are* the commandments which
 YHWH

Commanded Moses for the cue
 Of Israel's folk on Mount Sinai,
A straight rule for to measure by.

I'm the firstborn, Beloved, and yet the last,
 So do not break my neck or take the mast
 Of money from my bank to redeem soul.
 Though I'm an ass, I do not take a toll.
 As firstborn I am holy, so be true
 I tell myself to self, also to You.
 I am the firstborn and the last and so
 In my own self I fill the prophet's low
 And strange word that the first shall come
 to be

The last and the last on the trumpet tree

Shall be the first, and so it is with me.
I'm the firstborn, and yet the last to know
The shadow of Your spirit's come and go:
I step out in the quiet from the show.

Numbers

THE refusal of the people to hear any more direct revelation of God that is described in Exodus 20:18 naturally leads to the establishment of prophethood on a new level. God does not leave humankind without revelation, even though they refuse to hear His voice directly. In the Book of Leviticus, God speaks to the people through Moses as a prophet. But Moses' role goes beyond that of merely transmitting the message of God to the people. He acts as a divinely appointed leader. The principle of divinely appointed leadership naturally arises from that of prophet.

The Book of Numbers is a series of stories examining the conditions of divinely appointed leadership. Unlike David, whose charisma inspired absolute loyalty, Moses' personality naturally inspired suspicion. Therefore he was constantly forced against the wall by questions of his authority. All of the narratives in the Book of Numbers follow this theme of divinely appointed guidance in one way or another: the appointment of each tribe in its place, its leaders and their roles, the priesthood in relation to the Levites, the stories of power struggles, and the stories of the need for intervention beyond the law in such matters as female inheritance. The book comes to a peak in Moses' prayer that there should be a divinely appointed leader after him.

It is fitting, considering the major theme of the book as divinely appointed guidance, that two of the three enigmatic references in the Torah to the figure of Ali are found in the Book of Numbers. These occur in Numbers 21:17 and 24:6.

It is also in connexion with the principle of divinely appointed leadership that the idea of divine incarnation arises. Most of Christianity for more than a millennium and a half has been under the pall of

considering a man to be God Almighty. The same excess has plagued Shi'ism, where Ali in some sects has long been considered an incarnation of God as well. The Book of Numbers pre-empt's this misconception by stating clearly in 23:19, "El God is not a man, that He should lie, nor son of man..."

THE Book of Genesis makes out that You Are One alone, and Exodus is true Expounding on Your justice in its wake. Leviticus is made for prophets' sake. But Numbers follows prophets with a call That You, Beloved, set divine guide for all To follow, and not to despise, reject, As many did in the pages select. Make me true also, my Beloved, to him Who stands invisible but is not dim In giving guidance to the faithful few Who love Your word and know Your word is true.

As Moses prayed You might send out a man

To lead the sheep, I follow as I can.

Week 34 Numbers 1

1 And now YHWH spoke to Moses in The Wilderness of Sinai, in The tent of meeting, the first *day* Of second month, and in the *way* Of second year after that they Had come out of Egypt's land, saying
2 "Take a census of all the *praying* Congregation of Israel's folk, By their families, and *also* by Their fathers' houses, also by The number of their names, each male Apart, 3 "From twenty years avail And above that, all who *can* go To war in Israel *not slow*. You and Aaron shall number them By their armies *in stratagem*.

The motives people have for counting men Are various and varied, starting out With Moses counting every citizen Unblushingly for military clout. They graduated then from outright stealing To counting up the populace for tax. Than fighting, manners and some shady dealing

Were easier and furnished fewer tracks.
 With curiosity, pure science, we
 Went on with no more motive than
 statistics
 And feigning shock when finds were
 readily
 Applied to atom bombs and their ballistics.
 Full circle comes, the object can't be
 missed.
 Man counts to count the fingers of his fist.

4 "And with you there shall be a man
 From every tribe, (*Reuben to Dan*)
 Each one head of his father's house.
 5 "These are names of men (*but not spouse*)
 Who shall stand with you: from Reuben,
 Elizur son of Shedeur, then
 6 "From Simeon, Shelumiel
 The son of Zurishaddai well,
 7 "From Judah, Nahshon who's the son
 Of Amminadab, *just begun*,
 8 "From Issachar, Nethanel son
 Of Zuar, 9 "and from Zebulun,
 Eliab the son of Helon,
 10 "And from the sons of Joseph: from
 Ephraim, Elishama come
 Of Ammihud, from Manasseh,
 Gamaliel *one who holds sway*
As son of Pedahzur, 11 "and from
 Benjamin, Abidan the son
 Of Gideoni, 12 "from Dan one
 Ahiezer who is the son
 Of Ammishaddai, 13 "from Asher,
 Pagiel son of Ocran's *care*,
 14 "From Gad, Eliasaph the son
 Of Deuel, 15 "from Naphtali one
 Ahira the son of Enan."
 16 These *were* chosen *and man for man*
 From assembly, leaders of their
 Fathers' tribes, heads of *every chair*
Of divisions in Israel's care.

The children of four wives come in the
 gates:
 The first the sons of Leah in their states
 Of divine law, Leah a wild cow bred
 Was lovelier than what some folk have
 said.
 Law is distasteful and obedience
 Considered low apocalyptic sense
 And hardly worth the mystic's higher sight.
 The second come the sons of Rachel loved

And such are popular and sweetly gloved.
 But love is brief, at least in Rachel's street,
 Beautiful but shrewish, yet loved as meet.
 The comfort of old age for Israel was
 In Leah who with age made love of laws.
 Beloved, full circle is the thing that's right.

The four sons of the slave wives at the end
 Come in no order of mother or friend,
 Nor in the order of their birth or ways:
 The order is the wonder of their days.
 Dan son of Bilhah is the first each way,
 Judgement born of the simple, foolish drey.
 But then the last is taken, Blessedness,
 Though son of Zilpah's drop, small to
 confess.
 The third, though later to be born is Gad,
 The hope of Zilpah's troop in what she had.
 The last is Bilhah's wrestling to be free,
 As Naphtali remains beloved of me,
 I know the end is not a peaceful crown,
 But battle and a march against the town.

17 Then Moses and Aaron took these
 Men who had been mentioned *to please*
 By name, 18 and they assembled all
 The congregation *at one call*
 Together on the first *day* of
 The second month, and they *for love*
 Recited their ancestry by
 Families, by their fathers' houses,
 According as the numbers lie
 Of names, from twenty years in biz
 And above, each one for himself.
 19 As YHWH commanded Moses, so
 He numbered them *in row on row*
 In wilderness of Sinai's *toe*.
 20 Now the children of Reuben, *who*
Was Israel's oldest son *and true*,
 Their genealogies by their
 Families, by their fathers' house *share*,
 According to the number of
 Names, every male for his own love,
 From twenty years old and above,
 All who *could* go to war: 21 those who
 Were numbered of the tribe of Reu-
 Ben *were* forty-six thousand five
 Hundred *men all strong and alive*.
 22 From the children of Simeon,
 Their genealogies *are done*
 By their families, by their fathers'
 House, of those who were numbered *fers*,

According to number of names,
 Every male for himself and claims,
 From twenty years old and above,
 All who *could* go to war *and shove*:
 23 Those who were numbered of the tribe
 Of Simeon *were* fifty-nine
 Thousand three hundred *by the scribe*.
 24 From the children of Gad *in fine*,
 Their genealogies by their
 Families, by their fathers' house *share*,
 According to number of names,
 From twenty years old and above,
 All who *could* go to war *for aims*:
 25 Those who were numbered of the tribe
 Of Gad *were* forty-five thousand
 Six hundred fifty *without bribe*.
 26 From the children at Judah's *hand*,
 Their genealogies as strict
 As their families *would depict*,
 By their fathers' house, according
 To the number of names *that sing*,
 From twenty years old and above,
 All who *could* go to war *with glove*:
 27 Those who were numbered of the tribe
 Of Judah *were* seventy-four
 Thousand six hundred *without jibe*
And without a single man more.
 28 From the children of Issachar,
 Their genealogies *so far*
 By their families, by fathers' house,
 According to number of spouse
 For names, from twenty years old and
 Above, all who *under command*
Could go to war: 29 those who were
 numbered
 Of Issachar's tribe *unencumbered*,
Were fifty-four thousand and four
 Hundred. 30 From the children in store
 Of Zebulon, lists of descent
 By their families *and where they went*,
 By their fathers' house, according
 To the number of names *that wing*,
 From twenty years old and above,
 All who *could* go to war *and shove*:
 31 Those who were numbered of the tribe
 Of Zebulon *and by the scribe*
Were fifty-seven thousand four
 Hundred. 32 From the sons at the door
 Of Joseph, children of Ephraim,
 Their lists of descent *come from him*
 By their families, by fathers' house,
 By number of names *without spouse*,

From twenty years old and above,
 All who *could* go to war *for love*:
 33 Those who were numbered of the tribe
 Of Ephraim *as diatribe*
Were forty thousand five hundred.
 34 From children that Manasseh did,
 Their lists of descent by families,
 By their fathers' house, *as they please*,
 According to number of names,
 From twenty years old and above,
 All who *could* go to *keep war's claims*:
 35 And all those who were numbered of
 The tribe of Manasseh *counted*
 Thirty-two thousand two hundred.
 36 From the children of Benjamin,
 Their lists of descent by their *thin*
 Families, by their fathers' house, by
 The number of their names *that vie*,
 From twenty years old and above,
 All who *could* war *instead of dove*:
 37 Those who were numbered of the tribe
 Of Benjamin *were* thirty-five
 Thousand four hundred *men alive*.
 38 From the children of Dan *subscribe*,
 Their genealogies by their
 Families, by their fathers' share,
 According to number of name,
 From twenty years above the same,
 All who *were able to subscribe*
 To war 39 were numbered of the tribe
 Of Dan sixty-two thousand and
 Seven hundred. 40 Folk from the hand
 Of Asher, their lists of descent
 By their families, by fathers' tent,
 According to number of names,
 From twenty years old up to claims
 Above, all who *were able to*
 Go to war: 41 and all of those who
 Were numbered of Asher's *own* tribe,
 Forty-one thousand five hundred.
 42 From children of Naphtali's *tribe*,
 Their lists of descent *by the bid*
Of their families, by fathers' house,
 By number of names *without spouse*,
 From twenty years old and above,
 All who *could* go to war *to shove*:
 43 Those who were numbered of the tribe
 Of Naphtali *both man and scribe*:
 Fifty-three thousand four hundred.

Gad is advanced in the list of the brave
 Behind Simeon, though he's son of slave.

Beloved, I see the profane advanced far
Upon the thrones of this world and this star,
The low-born in terms of their sense and
worth

In compassion, morality on earth.
Advance me not, though Gad despite the
name

His mother bears, lowly but not in shame,
Is well deserving of the praise that runs
With being one of Jacob's righteous sons.
I rather stay here at the end of spite
And wrestle with my Naphtalian night.
It's not in dawn and daylight comes the
guide,

But in the darkness leading stars don't hide.

44 These are the ones who were numbered,
Whom Moses and Aaron numbered,
With the leaders of Israel, twelve
Men, each one showing how to delve
Of his father's house. 45 So all who
Were numbered of Israel's accrue,
By their fathers' houses, and from
Twenty years old, above *in sum*,
All who *were able to go to*
War in Israel, 46 all who were numbered
Were six hundred *and unencumbered*
Three thousand five hundred fifty.
47 But the Levites were not to be
Numbered among them by the tribe
Of their fathers, 48 YHWH to inscribe
Had spoken to Moses, saying
49 "Only the tribe of Levi's *spring*
You shall not number, nor take count
Of them in Israel's folk's amount,
50 "But you shall set the Levites over
The tent of testimony, over
All its furnishings, over all
Things that belong to it *by call*,
They'll carry the tent and all its
Furnishings, they'll tend where it sits
And camp around the tent. 51 "And when
The tabernacle is to go
Forward, the Levites shall *unpen*
The tent and take it down *from show*,
And when the tent is to be set
Up, the Levites shall be cadet.
The outsider who comes near shall
Be put to death *as prodigal*.

The idle curious are criminals.

We're civilized when we suspend their
sentence.

They never looked in on devotionals
In forthright days without bitter repentance.
Unholy eyes must never see the gold
That bears the oil and bread of mystic
prayer.

Unholy hands touch not what can't be sold
For any price or purchased anywhere.
The wages of democracy is death
To heads and spirits that rise higher than
The ridgepole of the tent. The sacred breath
Departs. We're left with prayer book and
tin can.

Some sip the wine and rue the day it grew.
Some sip the wine and know what thing is
true.

52 "The children of Israel shall pitch
Their tents, everyone by his ditch,
Everyone by his own standard,
According to their armies *card*,
53 "But the Levites shall camp around
The tent of testimony's *ground*,
That there may be no wrath upon
The congregation of the *dawn*
Of Israel's folk, and the Levites
Shall keep charge of the tent of lights."
54 Thus Israel's folk did, according
To all YHWH told Moses to sing.

Numbers 2

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses and *brother*
Aaron, saying 2 "All and another
Of Israel's folk shall camp by his
Own standard, where the emblem is
Of his father's house, they shall camp
Away from tent of meeting's ramp.
3 "On the east side, toward the rising
Of the sun, those who're not despising
The standard of Judah's forces
Shall camp according to armies,
And Nahshon Amminadab's son
The leader of Judah's folk won."
4 And his army was numbered at
Seventy-four thousand *up to bat*
And six hundred. 5 "Those who camp next
To him *shall be* the tribe *perplexed*
Of Issachar, and Nethanel
The son of Zuar *who shall dwell*
As leader of Issachar's folk."
6 And his army came to convoke

Fifty-four thousand four hundred.
 7 "Then *comes* the tribe of Zebulon,
 Eliab son of Helon's *bid*
To be the leader of the folk
 Of Zebulon." 8 And he bespoke
 A host counted at fifty-seven
 Thousand four hundred *up to heaven*.
 9 "All who were numbered by their hosts
 Of forces and with Judah's coasts,
 One hundred eighty-six thousand
 Four hundred, these move first command.

The sacred dance beginning at the east
 With Judah, Issachar, and as the least
 Zebulon, turns to find Your hidden face
 Beneath the veilings of the holy place.
 With back to sun, Judah bows toward the
 veil
 And brings the holy law out of the pale.
 The eastern gate where You reveal Your
 will
 Is brightened by their footsteps sounding
 still
 Upon the sacred, silent desert air
 And on the pebbled sands and everywhere
 The hills look on eternally and bare.
 Beloved, I follow in the ancient traces
 Left by obedience of feet and faces
 Led in their steps by Your eternal graces.

10 "On the south side *is* the standard
 Of the forces in Reuben's ward
 According to their armies, and
 Reuben's folk's leader there shall stand
 Elizur son of Shedeur." 11 And
 His host was numbered forty-six
 Thousand five hundred. 12 "Those whose
 tricks
 Camp next to him *shall be* the tribe
 Of Simeon, and *without jibe*
 The leader of Simeon's folk
 Is Shelumiel son of *bloke*
Named Zurishaddai." 13 And his host
 Was counted at fifty-nine *boast*
 In thousands and three hundred's *toast*.
 14 "Then *comes* the tribe of Gad, and chef
 Of Gad's folk *is* Eliasaph
 The son of Reuel." 15 And his host
 Counted at forty-five thousand
 Six hundred and fifty *to boast*.
 16 "All who were numbered *by command*
 According to their armies and

The forces with Reuben, up to
 One hundred fifty-one thousand
 Four hundred and fifty, not few
 They'll break camp second *by command*.
 17 "And the tent of meeting shall move
 Out with the camp of Levites' groove
 And in the middle of the camps,
 As they camp, so they'll hit the ramps,
 Everyone in his place, and by
 Their standards *flying in the sky*.

I follow Simeon southward to find
 The blazing sun upon my opened mind
 Still shivering beneath the golden glare
 Of loves flooding, budding the south gate
 there.
 Reuben takes the first steps, the last is Gad,
 And so the crowds move on, joyful and
 glad.
 Each in his place beneath the standards
 flown,
 The armies march or camp around Your
 throne.
 The silence of my forest makes me think
 That I sit here alone with food and drink,
 And yet the armies of the Lord that were
 Are vast in thousands that make my heart
 stir
 To know I'm not alone in my prostration
 Before You, my Beloved, You have a
 nation.

18 "On the west side *shall be* the flag
 Of the forces with Ephraim's *tag*
 According to their armies, and
 The leader of Ephraim's folk's band
Shall be Elishama the son
 Of Ammihud, *who's not a Hun*."
 19 And his army was numbered at
 Forty thousand five hundred *flat*.
 20 "Next to him *comes* Manasseh's band,
 And leader of Manasseh's folk
Shall be Gamaliel son at hand
 Of Pedahzur, *a handy bloke*."
 21 And his host reached to thirty-two
 Thousand two hundred, *not a few*.

Joseph and Benjamin are in the west,
 Dressed in a coloured cloak, embroidered
 vest.
 Their dancing feet raise dust against the sun

That caught them all red-footed before
done.

Joseph and Benjamin, cherished for their
Own loving hearts and for their mother fair,
Are set against the praise of Judah's row,
And after Reuben's failed to hope and
show.

Beloved, I too would take my place so near
The holy of holies and the ark dear,
Which also lies upon the western end
Of sacred tent. My praises I too send
Toward the golden throne where You abide
Above the tables of Your law and hide.

22 "Then *comes* the tribe of Benjamin,
And Benjamin's folk's leading jinn,
Abidan son of Gideon."

23 And his army's counted to be
Thirty-five thousand four hundred.

24 "All who were numbered by their bid
According to their hosts of forces
With Ephraim, (*not counting horses*),
One hundred and eight thousand one
Hundred, they shall be the third done
To break camp. 25 "The standard of forces
Shall be according to their hosts,
And the leader of Dan's folk's boasts
Shall be Ahiezer the son
Of Ammishaddai *when he's done*."

26 And his army was numbered at
Sixty-two thousand and a flat
Seven hundred. 27 "Those who camp next
To him *shall be* the tribe of *vexed*

Asher, and leader of the folk
Of Asher *shall be* Pagiel *woke*
The son of Ocran." 28 And his host
Was counted forty-one at most
In thousands and five hundred *men*.
29 "Then *comes* the tribe of Naphtali,
And leader of Naphtali's den
Is Ahira son of Enan."

30 And his host counted *to a man*
Fifty-three thousand four hundred.

31 "All those who were numbered *and fed*
Of the forces with Dan to heaven,
Were one hundred and fifty-seven
Thousand six hundred, and they shall
Break camp last, with their standards mall."

32 These *are* the ones who were numbered
Of the children of Israel *heard*
By their fathers' houses, all who

Were numbered by their armies due
Six hundred and three thousand five
Hundred and fifty *men alive*.

33 But the Levites were not numbered
Among the folk of Israel *heard*,
Just as YHWH told Moses to do.

34 Israel's folk did according to
All that YHWH told Moses to do,
So they camped by their standards and
They broke camp, each one by command
In his family, according to
Their fathers' houses *and on cue*.

Dan, Asher, Naphtali who northward wend
Their way, bring contrasts as their feet
contend.

Naphtali is a struggle there between
Dan and Asher, who clash upon the green.
Dan is the judgement, Asher blessedness:
How can these two camp in one place and
dress?

Your judgement, my Beloved, is not
destroying

The faces of the meek who in You joying
Encircle the throne of Your mercy set.
That's why justice and blessing are found
yet

Together at the end of the world's dance.
They walk both hand in hand, not in a
trance,

But in the fair reality that You
Extend mercy with justice as You do.

Numbers 3

1 Now these *are* the records of Aaron
And Moses when YHWH spoke *to share*
on

With Moses on Mount Sinai. 2 And
These *are* the names of, *right off-hand*,
The sons of Aaron: Nadab, who
Is the firstborn, and Abihu,
Eleazar, and Ithamar.

3 These *are* the names of every star
Son of Aaron, anointed priests,
Whom he consecrated *at least*
To minister as priests. 4 Nadab
And Abihu had died by *stab*
Of YHWH when they offered profane
Fire before YHWH upon the plain
Before Sinai, and they had no
Children, so Eleazar and
Ithamar ministered *below*

As priests in Aaron 's presence for
 He was their father *on that score*.
 5 And YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
 6 "Bring the tribe of Levi near, and
 Present them before Aaron 's hand,
Who is the priest, that they may sing
And serve him. 7 "And they shall attend
 To his needs and the needs amend
 Of the whole congregation that
 Stands where the tent of meeting's at.
 8 "Also they shall attend to all
 The furnishings of meeting hall,
 And to the needs of Israel's folk,
 To do the tent work *at a stroke*.
 9 "And you shall give the Levites to
 Aaron and his sons, *they're to do*
 Entirely for him from among
 The children of Israel *unsung*.
 10 "So you shall set Aaron and his
 Sons, and they'll take care of their biz,
 But the stranger who shall approach
 Shall be put to death *like a roach*."
 11 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
 12 "Now indeed, I Myself will bring
 The Levites from among the folk
 Of Israel in place of bloke
 First born among Israel's folk,
 Therefore the Levites shall be Mine,
 13 "Because all the firstborn *are* Mine.
 On the day that I struck down all
 The firstborn in Egypt's land's *thrall*,
 I sanctified to Myself all
 The firstborn in Israel *by call*,
 Both man and beast, they shall be Mine:
I am YHWH and alone divine."

You tell the people what to do, one thing
 Or then another, sometimes with the ring
 Of arbitrary statutes multiplied.
 But often You end what You say beside
 With proclamation that You're only
 YHWH.

Like dogs we look upon the finger You
 Use to point to Your unity and think
 The detail of the law is on the brink.
 Nothing has meaning otherwise than that
 It reaffirms Your wearing of one hat.
 The firstborn's Yours to say that You are
 one,

And every human action that is done
 By Your command buries idolatry.

That's why the firstborn is both sold and
 free.

14 YHWH spoke to Moses at Sinai
 And in the desert saying *why*,
 15 "Count the children of Levi by
 Their fathers' houses, and by their
 Families, you shall count every *heir*
And male from a month old and up."
 16 So Moses counted them *that sup*
 By the word of YHWH, as commanded.
 17 These were the sons of Levi branded
 By their names: Gershon, Kohath, and
 Merari. 18 And these *are the brand*
 Names of the sons of Gershon by
 Their families: Libni, Shimei.
 19 And the sons of Kohath by their
 Families: Amram, Izechar,
 Hebron, and Uzziel. 20 And sons
 Of Merari by family runs:
 Mahli and Mushi. So are these
 By fathers' house Levites' families.
 21 From Gershon *came* the family
 Of the Libnites and family
 Of the Shimites, these *were* families
 Of Gershonites. 22 Those who were
 counted

According to number amounted
 Of all the males from a month old
 And above, those counted all told
 Seven thousand five hundred *bold*.
 23 The families of the Gershonites
 Were to camp behind the tent sites
 To westward. 24 And the leader of
 The fathers' house of Gershonites
 Was Eliasaph the son of
 Lael. 25 The duties *and the rights*
 Of the children of Gershon in
 The tent of meeting, in one bin
 The tabernacle, tent with cover,
 The tent of meeting's screen to hover
 About the door, 26 and the screen for
 The courtyard *and its open* door,
 The hangings of the court around
 The tent and altar *on the ground*,
 And their cords, according to all
 The work around their therewithal.
 27 From Kohath *came* the family
 Of the Amramites, family
 Of the Izharites, family
 Of Hebronites, and family
 Of the Uzzielites, these *are*

The Kohathites' families' *star*.
 28 According to the number of
 All the males, from a month old *love*
 And up, *there were* eight thousand six
 Hundred keeping charge of the tricks
 Of the holy place and its sticks.
 29 The families of Kohath kids
 Were to camp on the south side *bids*
 Of the tent. 30 And the leader of
 The fathers' house of families of
 Kohathites was Elizaphan
 The son of Uzziel, *good man*.
 31 Their duty *included* the ark,
 The table, the lampstand, *the park*
Of the altars, the sanctuary
 Utensils all which they would carry
 On ministry, the screen, and all
 The work included therewithal.
 32 And Eleazar son of Aaron
 The priest *was to be* chief to bear on
 The leaders of all the Levites,
 Keeping holy place oversights.
 33 From Merari *came* the family
 Of the Mahlites and the family
 Of the Mushites, these the families
 Of Merari. 34 And those who please
 To be counted, according to
 The number of all the male *crew*
 From a month old and above *led*,
Were six thousand two hundred *fed*.
 35 The leader of the fathers' house
 Of the families *and every spouse*
 Of Merari was Zuriel
Who was the son of Abihail,
 These *were* to camp on the north side
 Of the tabernacle *tent ride*.
 36 And the children of Merari
 Had as their appointed duty
 The boards of the tent and its bars,
 Its pillars, its sockets, and jars,
 All the work relating to them,
 37 And the pillars of the court hem,
 With their sockets, their pegs, and cords.
 38 Moreover those the camp affords
 Before the tent on the east side,
 Before the tabernacle tried,
Are Moses, Aaron, and his sons,
 Keeping charge of holy place *buns*,
 To meet the needs of Israel's folk,
 But the stranger who dared approach
 Was to be put to death *like roach*.
 39 All who were counted of Levites,

Whom Moses and Aaron *on sites*
 Counted at the command of YHWH,
 By their families, all males too,
 From a month old and onward up,
Were twenty-two thousand *of tup*.

Your dwelling, my Beloved, is all
 surrounded
 With hundreds of officials and unbounded
 To scour and carry, keep and police all
 The corridors that hide Your praise with
 pall.

An unclean stranger I may be to You
 And certainly to them, for what I do,
 Despite my circumcision and the way
 I recite Your bright law by night and day.
 The civil servant's civil to some folk
 Who have the pedigree and tinselled cloak,
 But such a dervish dog as I they'd choke
 If I had lived then to put stick in spoke.
 I rush to You, Beloved, and penetrate
 Defences, pierced to die upon the gate.

40 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Count all
 The firstborn males of Israel's folk
 From a month old and above *brawl*,
 And find out all their names invoke.
 41 "And you'll take the Levites for Me,
 I *am* YHWH, instead of one wee
 Among all the firstborn of folk
 Of Israel, also the livestock
 Of the Levites instead of all
 The firstborn livestock in the stall
 Of the children of Israel."

42 So Moses counted all firstborn
 Among children of Israel *sworn*,
 As YHWH commanded him. 43 And all
 The firstborn males, according to
 The number of names *what and who*
 From a month old and above, of
 Those who were numbered in their *love*,
 Were twenty-two thousand and two
 Hundred and seventy-three. 44 Then
 YHWH

Spoke to Moses, saying 45 "Now take
 The Levites instead of the wake
 Of firstborn among Israel's folk,
 And the livestock of the Levites
 Instead of their livestock in stoke.
 The Levites shall be Mine: I'm YHWH.
 46 "And as for the redemption *rights*
 Of the two hundred seventy-three

Of the firstborn of Israel's free
 Children, who are more than the count
 Of the Levites, 47 "you'll take amount
 Of five shekels for each one there,
 You'll take *it* in the shekel share
 Of sanctuary, the shekel
 Of twenty gerahs. 48 "And you'll tell
 The money, with which the excess
 Number of them's redeemed in care
 Of Aaron's and his sons' *witness*."
 49 So Moses took redemption money
 From all those who were over runny
 Above the number of redeemed
 By the Levites. 50 *And so it seemed*
 From the firstborn of Israel's folk
 He took the money, *at one stroke*
 One thousand three hundred and yet
 Sixty-five *shekels*, by the set
 Count of the sanctuary. 51 And
 Moses gave their money in hand
 For their redemption to Aaron
 And his sons, according to *dawn*
Of the word of YHWH, as YHWH said
 To Moses, *so he did as led*.

The natural priesthood of the Lord it seems
 Is the firstborn, Isaac and Ishmael's dreams.
 Redemption of the firstborn must take
 place
 Before You Yourself can make change in
 face.
 So who gives right to Rome,
 Constantinople
 To set up priest without redeeming pople?
 Since Aaron is no longer taking shekel,
 Who appears as a priest is really speckle.
 Each firstborn is Your own, Your priest
 today,
 And has the duty to teach all Your way,
 Your law and covenant, Your love and
 word
 Until the younger hearers' hearts are stirred.
 Why else is the word "elder" once
 preferred?
 Beloved, I bow to Your will where I stay.

The second son or youngest son is known
 To be the choice since Seth and Abel
 grown.
 The family priesthood is a thing in air:
 To compromise we choose a pope with
 care.

Though I am not the second son I am
 Both first and last, fit sacrificial lamb.
 All competition for the leadership
 Resolves in Moses' harsh creatorship,
 Harsh seen by the opponent in the field,
 Yet opportunity wounds to be healed.
 Moses himself is here to represent
 Authority of the last son and sent.
 Aaron's accepted only through his prayer
 That God might touch his tongue and so be
 fair.

Numbers 4

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses and Aaron,
 Saying 2 "Take census to declare on
 The sons of Kohath from among
 The children of Levi *unsung*,
 By their families, by fathers' house,
 3 "From thirty years old (don't count
 spouse)
 And above, even up to fifty
 Years old, all who enter the *nifty*
 Service to do the work within
 The tent of meeting *without sin*.
 4 "This *is* the service of the sons
 Of Kohath in meeting tent runs,
 About the most holy things, 5 "when
 The camp prepares to journey, then
 Aaron and his sons shall come, and
 They'll take the covering veil *by hand*
 And cover ark of testimony
 With it. 6 "Then they'll not put a phony
 But covering of badger skins, and
 Spread over *that* a cloth to stand
 All made of blue, and they'll run in
 Its poles. 7 "On the table *or bin*
 Of showbread they shall spread a blue
 Cloth, and put on it dishes *few*,
 The pans, the bowls, and pitchers for
 Pouring, and the showbread before
 Shall be upon it. 8 "They shall spread
 Over them a scarlet cloth red,
 And cover the same with a cover
 Of badger skins, and they shall hover
 Inserting its poles. 9 "And they'll take
 A blue cloth and cover the stake
 Of lampstand of the light, with lamps,
 Its wick-trimmers, its trays *for damps*,
 And all its oil vessels, with which
 They service it *and in a pitch*.
 10 "Then they shall put it with all its
 Utensils in its covering kits

Of badger skins, and put *it* on
 A carrying beam. 11 "Over upon
 The golden altar they shall spread
 A blue cloth, and cover it shed
 With a cover of badger skins,
 And they'll insert its poles *as pins*.
 12 "Then all utensils they shall take
 For service with which they shall make
 Ministry in the sanctuary,
 Put *them* in a blue cloth, and bury
 Them with cover of badger skins,
 And put *them* onto carrying pins.
 13 "Also they shall remove the ashes
 From the altar, and spread *like sashes*
 A purple cloth over the whole.
 14 "They shall put on it *in its role*
 All its tools with which they serve there,
 The firepans, forks, the shovels *bare*,
 The basins, all the altar tools,
 And they shall spread on it *by rules*
 A covering of badger skins,
 And insert its poles *and its pins*.

Though badger skin and purple have their
 place,
 A blue cloth is found everywhere they race.
 A blue cloth covers every holy thing
 From prying eyes, from those who dance
 and sing.
 The golden altar and the bread and table,
 Each bowl and pitcher, as with blue they're
 able.
 The sons of Kohath come with blue to hide
 The lamp extinguished on the tent's south
 side.
 Beloved, in me too there's a holy sound,
 The I-ness where Your lovely name is
 found,
 And that thing too is covered from the eye
 Of the disdainful, those who sing and
 dance,
 With coverings of blue beneath the cry
 Reflecting on the veils the passing glance.

15 "And when Aaron and his sons shall
 Have finished covering integral
 The sanctuary and all its
 Furnishings of its holy kits,
 When the camp is set up to go,
 Then the sons of Kohath shall show
 To carry *it*, but they shall not
 Touch any holy thing *untaught*,

Lest they die. These *are* the things in
 The tent of meeting *without sin*
 Which the sons of Kohath shall bear.
 16 "Appointed task of Eleazar
 The son of Aaron the priest *is*
 The oil for the light, and for *his*
 Sweet incense, the daily grain offering,
 Anointing oil, as well as proffering
 The oversight of all the tent,
 Of all that *is* in it *and spent*,
 The sanctuary and its tools."

Some are appointed to the holy task
 Of bearing things holy and golden, mask
 And bone, structure and hidden wooden
 frame.

Some are appointed to recite Your name.
 Some are appointed to the work and press
 Of making oil for light and for the guess
 Of incense for the daily offering,
 And as they work they dance around and
 sing,
 Anointing with such oil each holy thing
 That has such need or love or daily claim.
 Some are appointed to recite Your name.
 Beloved, I have no task given to me
 In bearing heavy holy things to see,
 In bringing oil, I only love Your name.

17 Then YHWH spoke to Moses *these*
rules
 And to Aaron, saying 18 "Do not
 Cut off the tribe of families *taught*
 Of Kohathites from the Levites,
 19 "But do this as regards their *rights*,
 That they may live and not die when
 They approach the most holy den:
 Aaron and his sons shall go in
 And appoint each of them to win
 His service and his task. 20 "But they
 Shall not go in to watch the way
 The holy things are being covered,
 Lest they die *there where they have*
hovered."

Beloved, I do not seek to touch the thing
 That is beneath Your holy, covering wing,
 I do not seek a vision of the gold
 That fills Your holy temple built of old,
 And yet I seek a deeper sight than those
 That filled with fear the ones who bore the
 clothes.

The holy things I pass as something crass,
The instruments of priest and public gas.
Instead I rush like moth into the fire,
Blaze up for just a moment on the pyre,
And then die sacrifice upon the dergah
floor.

Death in the gold's not enough, I need
more.

Beloved, beyond touching and seeing I
Join You in One so that my self may die.

Week 35

21 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
22 "Take also census of the sons
Of Gershon, by their fathers' runs,
By their families. 23 "From thirty years
Old and above, to fifty years
Old, you shall count them, all who go

In to perform the service *show*,
To do the work in meeting tent.

24 "This *is* the service of descent
Families of the Gershonites,
In serving and carrying *rights*:

25 "They'll carry curtains of the tent

And meeting tabernacle vent,
Its cover, and cover of skins

Of badger that upon it *wins*,

The screen for the door of the tent

Of meeting, 26 "the screen for the door

Of the gate of the court *before*,

The hangings of the court around

The tent and altar, and their cords,

All the furnishings for the hordes

Of their service and all that's made

For these things: so shall they be played.

27 "Aaron and his sons shall assign

All the service of the sons *fine*

Of Gershonites, all their tasks and

All their service. And you'll command

To them all their tasks as their duty.

28 "This *is* the service *in its beauty*

Of the families of the sons of

Gershon in the meeting tent's *love*.

And their duties *shall be* beneath

The hand of Ithamar's bequeath,

The son of Aaron and the priest.

29 "As for sons of Merari, least

You'll count them by families *increased*

And by their fathers' house *and feast*.

30 "From thirty years old and above,

Even to fifty years old, *love*,

You'll number them, each one who goes

Into the service *on his toes*

To do the work of meeting tent.

31 "And this *is* what they must be sent

To carry as all their service

For the tent of meeting *in bliss*:

The boards of the tent, bars and pillars,

Its sockets, 32 "as well as the pillars

Around the court with their sockets,

Pegs, and cords, with their furnishings

And all their service, *and such things*,

And you shall assign *to each ferry*

By name the items he must carry.

33 "Such tasks for families of the sons

Of Merari, as all the ones

In service for the meeting tent,

Under hand of Ithamar went

The son of Aaron the priest *sent*."

A Gershonite or Merarite am I,

Beloved, who stand beneath the open sky.

Wherever I go I carry along

Boards with their sockets so no one may
wrong

The burden of Your name, I carry veils

To spread across the flying, fleeing sails

Of those who claim to seek You in the plot

Of faiths enjoined by gurus seen and
taught.

I have no faith nor message but Your name,

Divided not, singular in my shame.

I am the gadfly to prevent their finding

The truth they hope to see in golden
binding.

I veil the right from every searching sight

And lead astray the faltering steps in night.

34 And Moses, Aaron, and the leaders

Of the assembly counted *headers*

Of Kohath's sons by their families

And by their fathers' house *to please*,

35 From thirty years old and above,

Even to fifty years old, *love*,

To everyone who came to task

For work in meeting tent *to bask*,

36 And those who were counted by their

Families were two thousand *to share*

With seven hundred and fifty.

37 These *were* the ones who were *nifty*

And counted of the families of

The Kohathites, all who above

Might serve in the meeting tent, whom,

Moses and bro Aaron *for room*

Counted according to command
 Of YHWH and by Moses, his hand.
 38 And those who were counted of sons
 Of Gershon, by their families' *runs*
 And by their fathers' house *for love*,
 39 From thirty years old and above,
 Even to fifty years old, each
 Who entered in the work *to preach*
 In the tabernacle of meeting,
 40 Those who were counted by the reach
 Of their families, fathers' house' seating,
 Were two thousand six hundred thirty.
 41 These *are* the ones counted assertive
 Of the families of Gershon's sons,
 Of all who might serve in the runs
 Of tabernacle of meeting,
 Whom Moses and Aaron counting
 According to YHWH's commandment.
 42 Those of families *who were meant*
 Of the sons of Merari counted,
 By their families, *and amounted*
 By their fathers' house, 43 from thirty
 Years old and above, *not dirty*,
 Even to fifty years old, all
 Who entered the service for call
 To work in the meeting tent's wall,
 44 Those by their families counted
 Were three thousand two hundred *led*.
 45 These *are* the ones who were counted
 Of families of Merari's sons,
 Whom Moses and Aaron *by tons*
 Counted according to YHWH's word,
 By the hand of Moses *and stirred*.
 46 All who were numbered of Levites,
 Whom Moses, Aaron, *acolytes*,
 Leaders of Israel counted, by
 Their families and also by
 Their fathers' houses, 47 from thirty
 Years old and above, *to furtive*
And up to fifty years old, all
 Who came to do the work *by call*
 Of service and the work of bearing
 Burdens in the meeting tent caring,
 48 Those who were counted came to eight
 Thousand five hundred and eighty.
 49 According to the command's *weight*
 Of YHWH they were counted to be
 By the hand of Moses, each one
 According to his service done
 And according to his own task,
 Thus were they counted, *tin and cask*,
 As YHWH told Moses *how to ask*.

It is a slavery and a mockery
 Of right and of those who would stand up
 free
 To work slaving forty hours a week or
 More for forty years then be put in store.
 The work life should begin at age of thirty,
 And then for twenty years let hands be
 dirty.
 Instead of work as life's identity
 In some profession for eternity,
 Let fifty years be spent in eating, sleeping
 And all about the lightened dergah
 creeping.
 Six days, perhaps, are given to men's work,
 But only score of three score ten to shirk
 One's being like the lily of the field,
 A swallow who does not spin silken yield.

Numbers 5

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
 2 "Command Israel's folk *on the wing*
 That they put out of the camp each
 Leper, everyone who in reach
 Has a discharge, and who becomes
 Defiled by a corpse, *all such bums*.
 3 "You shall put out both male, female,
 You shall put them outside *the pale*
Of the camp, that they not defile
 Their camps where I live, *rank and file*."
 4 So Israel's folk did, put them out
 Of the camp, as YHWH spoke *in shout*
 To Moses, so Israel's folk did.
 5 Then YHWH spoke to Moses to bid,
 6 "Speak to Israel's folk, 'When a man
 Or woman commits sin *or ban*
 That men commit unfaithfulness
 Against YHWH, and that one *confess*
Or is shown guilty, 7 'then he shall
 Confess the sin which prodigal
 He has committed. He shall make
 A restitution for trespass
 In full, plus one-fifth of *the stake*
 And give *it* to the one he's wronged.
 8 'But if the man has no alas
 Relative to whom it belonged
 For restitution to be made
 For the wrong then the wrong's relayed
 In restitution to YHWH for
 The priest, in an addition more
 To the ram of atonement by
 Which atonement for him is nigh.

9 'Every offering of holy thing
Of Israel's folk, and which they bring
To the priest, shall be his, 10 'and each
Man's holy things are in his reach,
Whatever any man shall give
The priest shall be for him to live."

The one-fifth restitution is a thing
That from beginning was the tune to sing.
In different times the one-fifth offering
Has been due to a slightly different score.
Your law, Beloved, accommodates the
floor.

As time and place change, so the
application
Of Your word may receive a different
station.

But always the one-fifth is due at last,
To wronged man claimant or the priest
gone past,
Or to the prophet or the prophet's daughter.
Your law is always fast and clear as water.
I bring the one-fifth in my hand to fast
And pray a blessing on the progeny
Of Moses, David, Muhammad, Ali.

11 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and
saying

12 "Speak to Israel's folk for their swaying,
'If any man's wife goes astray
And acts unfaithfully *one day*
Toward him, 13 'and a man with her
Lies carnally, *as may occur*,
And it is hidden from the eyes
Of her husband, *who would despise*,
And it's concealed that she's defiled
Herself, no witness *but the child*
Against her, nor was ever caught,
14 'If spirit of jealousy wrought
Comes on him and he gets jealous
Of his wife, who *in all the fuss*
Defiled herself, or if the spirit
Of jealousy comes on to fear it,
And he gets jealous of his wife,
Although she's not *in all her life*
Defiled herself, 15 'then the man shall
Bring his wife to the priest's cabal.
He'll bring the offering that's required
For her, one-tenth ephah *acquired*
Of barley meal, he'll pour no oil
Nor frankincense on it *to spoil*,
Because it's a meat offering of

Jealousy, an offering for *love*
Remembering, for bringing such sin
To remembrance. 16 'The priest within
Shall bring her near, and set her there
Before YHWH. 17 'The priest shall take
care

With holy water in a pot
Of earth, and take some of the *caught*
Dust that is upon the tent floor
And put *it* in the water's *store*.

Not now, but in the ancient time and place,
A woman could be brought before the face
Of priest for her unfaithfulness' disgrace,
Without proof or witness or her confession,
But only on account of man's obsession.
But even then the thing would not bear oil
Or frankincense, but only basic toil,
And holy water, holy, what is that?
And how does water become holy fat?
Consensus says its blessing of the priest,
But there's no valid priesthood, now it's
ceased,

Except that every loved of You is one,
A priest and king is every mother's son.
Without the holy water, trial's done.

18 'The priest shall stand the wife before
YHWH, uncover the woman's head,
And put the offering for mind read
In her hands, which *is* meat offering
Of jealousy, and the priestling
Shall have in his hand the bitter
Water that brings a curse *on her*.

Och, hardly any text in all the Book
Of revelation wherever you look
From Genesis up to Suratul-Nas
Speaks of head cover for lady and lass.
In passing here this rarity appears,
That women have head covered for their
fears.

One witness hardly suffices to bring
A legal verdict or two on the thing,
Especially when I see that the veil
Is lifted once she comes within Your pale.
This practice is tradition for Islam
And Judaism, and the Christian's balm.
If we scratch hard enough the sacred scroll
Will lend a voice to those who take their
toll.

19 "The priest shall put her under oath,
 And say to the woman *with growth*,
 "If no man has lain with you, and
 If you have not gone out of hand
 To uncleanness under husband,
 Be free from this bitter water
 That brings the curse *that I infer*.
 20 "But if you have then gone astray
 Under your husband's *power and sway*,
 And if you have defiled yourself
 And some man or some other elf
 Besides your husband's lain with you,"
 21 "The priest shall put wife under oath
 Of the curse, and he shall say loath
 To the woman, "YHWH make you curse
 And oath among your people, worse
 When YHWH makes your thigh rot and
 your
 Belly swell, 22 "and may this water
 That causes the curse go into
 Your stomach, and *also make you*
And your belly swell and thigh rot."
 The wife shall say "Amen," *or not*.

The trial by fire and dunking of the witch
 Does work according to the proper stitch
 In ethnographical account, but then
 It only works with the encultured men.
 The difference between the trial by fire
 And water, and that of Your Word's desire,
 Is dusty water does not burn nor drown.
 If magic incantation of renown
 Fails as technique, at least the test will
 show

No more than belly-ache unless dust glow.
 Innocent till proven guilty's Your will
 And that must fit the jealous husband's bill.
 Beloved, I drink Your dust and water well,
 And fall beneath Your jealousy and spell.

23 "Then the priest shall write in a book
 These curses, and scrape *them with hook*
 Into the bitter water. 24 'He
 Shall make the woman drink freely
 Of the bitter water that brings
 A curse, and the water that brings
 The curse shall go in her, be bitter.
 25 "The priest shall take *from jealous sitter*
 The grain offering from the wife's hand,
 Shall wave the offering before YHWH,
 And bring it to the altar's *band*,
 26 'And the priest shall take *residue*,

A handful of the offering, as
 Its portion that memorial has,
 And burn *it* on the altar, and
 After that make the wife in hand
 To drink the water. 27 'When he's made
 Her drink the water's *lemonaid*,
 Then it shall be, if she's defiled
 Herself, behaved *to get a child*
 Unfaithfully toward her man,
 That the water that brings a curse
 Will enter her *and do her worse*
And become bitter, and her paunch
 Will swell, her thigh will rot *and raunch*,
 And the wife will become a curse
 Among her people *for the worse*.

The rustic Arab and the literate
 Of dervish may lay on the polished plate
 A scattering of letters scraped off from
 The parchment where they did the magic
 sum.

And setting up the incantation right
 Is something still done in the dark of night.
 The fevered hope and desperation's hate
 Still drive well-reasoned people to their
 fate.

But writing and scraping of spells is not
 A thing I had expected in Your spot.
 I write no spell nor drink it in Your game,
 Except to breath and whisper Your sweet
 name,
 And so I eat and drink that writing bare,
 And fill my heart with incantation rare.

28 'But if the woman's not defiled
 Herself, and is clean, *though she's wild*.
 She shall be free and may conceive
 Children. 29 'This *is the law's reprieve*
 Of jealousy, when a wife, *while*
 Under her husband, shall defile
 Herself having gone astray, 30 'or
 When spirit of jealousy bore
 Into a man, and he becomes
 Jealous of his wife *in her sums*,
 Then he shall stand the wife before
 YHWH, and the priest shall bring the store
 Of all this law upon her. 31 'Then
 The man shall be free from his yen
 And his iniquity, but that
 Wife shall bear her guilt where she sat."

Your Book even when dealing with the heart
 And jealousy on men and women's part,
 It touched most deeply by conception's art
 And the right of the child to know who be
 Her father in the jungle and the sea.
 I'd say You did not feel, Beloved, the care
 That humans have about their love and share,
 Except You also cry aloud in pain
 And jealousy to see the veilings stain
 And find Your own loved searching out in vain
 The idols that transverse Your heart for gain.
 Let me not be unfaithful, My Beloved,
 In this world of the taken and the shoved,
 But bask each day in Your gentle love's rain.

Numbers 6

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 2 "Speak to Israel's folk, have them led,
 'When either man or woman bring
 Consecrating an offering
 To take the vow of Nazirite,
 To separate himself *for right*
 To YHWH, 3 'he shall separate from
 Wine and *such* drink *that tricks the sum*,
 He shall drink neither vinegar
 Made from wine nor of vinegar
 Made from *such* drink, neither shall drink
 Any grape juice, nor *in his kink*
 Eat fresh grapes or raisins. 4 'Each day
 Of his vowed time he'll *in no way*
 Eat anything produced by vine,
 From seed to skin. 5 'He shall resign
 All the days of distinction's vow
 Not to pass razor anyhow
 Upon his head, until the days
 Are fulfilled for which he conveys
 To separate himself to YHWH,
 He shall be holy *then* he'll let
 The locks of his head's hair long get.
 6 'All the days that he separates
 Himself to YHWH *in holy states*
 He shall not go near a dead body.
 7 'He'll not make himself unclean, *shoddy*,
 Even for his *own* father or
 His mother, for his brother or
 His sister, when they die, because
 His separation to God's *laws*

Is on his head. 8 'All the days of
 His separation's holy *love*
 Shall be to YHWH. 9 'And if someone
 Dies suddenly beside his *bun*,
 And defiles consecrated head,
 Then he shall shave his head *as said*
 On the day of his cleansing, on
 The seventh day he'll shave it gone.
 10 'Then it's on the eighth day he brings
 Two turtledoves or two young *things*
As pigeons to the priest, and to
 The tent of meeting's door *for stew*,
 11 'And the priest shall offer one as
 A sin offering *the* other as
 A burnt offering, make atonement
 For him, because he sinned and went
 In to the corpse, he'll sanctify
 His head that same day *going by*.
 12 'He'll consecrate to YHWH the days
 Of separation, and then bring
 A male lamb in its first year *plays*
 And as a trespass offering,
 But the former days shall be lost,
 Because his separation's *tossed*,
 It was defiled. 13 'Now this *is* law
 Of Nazirite *to be in awe*:
 When the days of his separation
 Are fulfilled, *with his reparation*,
 He shall be brought to the tent door
 Of meeting 14 'To present before
 It his offering to YHWH: one male
 Lamb in its first year without *fail*
Or blemish as a burnt offering,
 One ewe lamb in its first, yearling
 Without blemish as sin offering,
 One ram without blemish as peace
 Offering, 15 'a basket *to release*
 Unleavened bread, cakes of fine flour
 Mixed with oil, unleavened, *unsour*
 Wafers anointed with oil, and
 Their grain offering *by My command*
 With their drink offerings. 16 'Then the
 priest
 Shall bring *them* before YHWH *increased*
 And offer his sin offering and
 His burnt offering, 17 'and he shall offer
 The ram as sacrifice to proffer
 A peace offering to YHWH, and led
 With basket of unleavened bread,
 The priest shall also offer its
 Grain offering and drink offering *kits*.
 18 'And then the Nazirite shall shave

His consecrated head *like slave*
 At the meeting tent door, and shall
 Take the hair from his consacral
 Head and put *it* upon the fire
 Under the peace sacrifice pyre.
 19 'And the priest shall take the boiled
 shoulder
 Of the ram, one yeastless cake bolder
 From the basket, and one yeastless
 Wafer, and put *for faithfulness*
 Upon the hands of Nazirite
 After he's shaved his pate aright,
 20 'And the priest shall wave them as wave
 Offering before YHWH, *after shave*,
 They *are* holy for the priest, *too*,
 Together with the breast *that's due*
 Of the wave offering and the thigh
 Of the heave offering. By and by,
 The Nazirite may drink grape juice.'
 21 'This is Nazirite law's *produce*,
 When one vows to YHWH offering
 For his separation *to sing*,
 And besides that, whatever more
 His hand is able to provide,
 According to the vow he swore,
 So he must in all things abide
 In his separation reside."

Consecrations and sacrifices and
 Shavings it takes to bring a man to stand
 Pure, clear in mind without the bitter stain
 Of alcohol upon a pickled brain.
 The Qalandar too shaves his holy head
 And stands outside with basket full of
 bread.

Beloved, as You are holy, so too I
 And every mother's son that breathes a sigh
 Must separate himself upon a day
 To carry out the promised holy way.
 I trow it was as easy then as now
 To keep an unintoxicated brow.
 Religion is an empty ceremony
 To help keep Your commandments, not be
 phony.

22 And YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
 23 "Speak to Aaron and sons, saying
 'This is the way that you shall bless
 Israel's folk. Tell them *and not guess*,
 24 "YHWH bless you and keep you, 25
 YHWH make
 His face shine on you *for your sake*,

And be gracious to you, 26 YHWH lift
 Up His visage on you, and gift
 You peace *or Islam without shame*."
 27 "And so they shall then put My name
 On Israel's folk, I'll bless their *fame*."

In giving peace of Islam to the folk
 You carry out the blessing You bespoke.
 The blessing lies within the sighing breath
 That sings the threefold YHWH before
 soul's death.

The blessing's in six promises well kept
 While people woke and worked, lay down
 and slept.

Bless, keep, and shine, and give abundant
 grace,

And so in peace abide beneath Your face.
 Beloved, I seek Your blessing, keeping,
 shining

Upon the dergah floor without repining.
 I bask and breathe within Your grace and
 stand

Determined in the peace of Islam's land.
 Submitted to Your will in nine-fold theme,
 I whirl and break the veils that only seem.

Numbers 7

1 It happened, when Moses had done
 Setting up the tent *under sun*,
 That he anointed, consecrated
 It and all its furnishings *stated*,
 And the altar and all its tools,
 So he anointed them *in pools*
 And consecrated them *in dread*.

2 The leaders of Israel, each head
 Of their fathers' houses, who *were*
 The leaders of the tribes, over
 Those who were numbered, made offering.
 3 And they each one brought their offering
 Before YHWH, six covered carts and
 Twelve oxen, a cart *in the hand*
 Of every two of leaders' band,
 And for each one an ox, and they
 Presented them by tent *that day*.

4 Then YHWH spoke to Moses to say,
 5 "Accept *these* from them, that they may
 Be used in doing meeting tent
 Work, and you shall give them *as meant*
 To the Levites, *to every man*
 According as his service can."
 6 So Moses took the carts and oxen,
 And gave them to the Levites *coxswain*.

7 Two carts and four oxen he gave
 To the sons of Gershon *as slave*,
 According to their service, 8 and
 Four carts and eight oxen *in hand*
 He gave to the sons of Merari,
 According to their service *carry*,
 Under the hand of Ithamar
 The son of Aaron the priest's *fer*.
 9 But to the sons of Kohath he
 Gave none, because theirs *was* the fee
 Of service of the holy things,
Which they carried on shoulder wings.

Justice is not that every man be treated
 Exactly as the other with meal meted.
 For one the oxen and the carts to own,
 For others only shoes to cushion bone.
 Each gets from You the things he hazards
 most,
 And in the end there is no room for boast.
 According to their service, each man finds
 A gift divine behind the veils and blinds.
 I grasp my own and run to meet Your call
 And stumbling sometimes, and about to
 fall,
 I still win what was always mine to live,
 Astounded at Your common lot to give.
 Beloved, my shoulders have no wings to
 bear,
 But still I find Your givings everywhere.

10 The leaders offered dedication
 For the altar when *in its station*
 It was anointed, so the chiefs
 Offered their offerings' *reliefs*
 Before the altar. 11 For YHWH said
 To Moses, "They shall offer *bread*,
 Their offering, one chief every day,
 For altar dedication's sway."
 12 And the one who offered his offering
 On the first day *was* Nahshon proffering,
 The son of Amminadab, from
 The tribe of Judah overcome.
 13 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 14 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 15 and one young bull,

One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 16 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 17 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* the offering of Nahshon
 Who was Amminadab's *own* son.

Those Christians seem to think that faith is
 but
 Remembering sins and covering them in
 blood,
 Religion is the mass and offering what
 Was on the cross and what is in the bud
 Of bread and wine, so sweetly bread and
 wine.
 Besides the kid for sin, old-fashioned
 Moses
 Describes at least two dozen things that
 shine
 Far brighter in the list that God imposes.
 A silver charger and a golden spoon
 Show that my prayer is more than asking
 pardon.
 There was an offering not inopportune
 Before dear Eve and Adam left the garden.
 Lord, let my peace and praise be as five
 rams
 In weight, two oxen and ten goats and
 lambs.

18 On the second day Nethanel
 The son of Zuar, chief as well
 Of Issachar, presented *swell*.
 19 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 20 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 21 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 22 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 23 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* offering of Nethanel
 The son of Zuar. 24 On the bell

Of the third day Eliab son
 Of Helon, chief of Zebulun.
 25 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 26 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 27 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 28 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 29 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* Eliab's offering, son
 Of Helon. 30 On the fourth day done
 Elizur the son of Shedeur,
 Chief of Reuben, *presented sure*.
 31 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 32 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 33 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 34 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 35 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* the offering of Elizur
 The son of Shedeur *and no miser*.
 36 On the fifth day Shelumiel,
 Zurishaddai's son, chief as well
 Of Simeon's folk, *presented spell*.
 37 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 38 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 39 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,

40 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 41 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* Shelumiel's offering,
 The son of Zurishaddai's *ring*.
 42 On the sixth day Eliasaph son
 Of Deuel, chief of Gad's folk *spun*.
 43 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 44 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 45 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 46 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 47 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* Eliasaph's offering,
 The son of Deuel *on a string*.
 48 On the seventh day Elishama
 The son of Ammihud, *no blamer*,
But the chief of Ephraim's folk *came here*.
 49 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 50 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 51 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 52 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 53 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* offering of Elishama
 The son of Ammihud, *no blamer*.
 54 On the eighth day Gamaliel
 The son of Pedahzur came well
 As chief of Manasseh's folk's *del*.
 55 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal

Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 56 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 57 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 58 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 59 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This was Gamaliel's offering,
 The son of Pedahzur *and ring*.
 60 On the ninth day Abidan son
 Of Gideoni, chief *when done*
 Of Benjamin's folk *hit the sun*.
 61 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 62 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 63 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 64 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 65 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* the offering of Abidan
 The son Gideoni *might hide in*.
 66 On the tenth day Ahiezer
 The son Ammishaddai's did bear,
 The chief of Dan's folk came *to swear*.
 67 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 68 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 69 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 70 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 71 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* Ahiezer's offering

The son of Ammishaddai's *ring*.
 72 On the eleventh day Pagiel
 The son of Ocran, all the while
 The chief of Asher's folk a pile.
 73 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 74 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 75 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 76 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 77 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* the offering of Pagiel
 The son of Ocran, and his pile.
 78 On the twelfth day Ahira son
 Of Enan, who was chief well done
 Of Naphtali's folk had begun.
 79 His offering *was* one silver plate,
 One hundred and thirty in weight,
 Of seventy shekels a bowl
 Of silver by the temple goal
 Of shekel, and both of them full
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *to pull*
 As a grain offering, 80 one gold pan
 Of ten *shekels gargantuan*,
 Full of incense, 81 and one young bull,
 One ram, and one male yearling lamb,
 As a burnt offering *anagram*,
 82 One goat kid as a sin offering,
 83 For sacrifice of peace offering:
 Two oxen, five rams, five male goats,
 And five male yearling lambs in coats.
 This *was* Ahira's offering due,
 The son of Enan, *last of crew*.
 84 This *was* the dedication for
 The altar from the leaders' score
 Of Israel, when it was anointed:
 Twelve silver platters, twelve appointed
 Silver bowls, and twelve gold pans.
 85 Each silver platter *weighed in spans*
Of shekels one hundred and thirty
 And each bowl seventy, *not dirty*.
 The silver of the vessels *weighed*
 In all two thousand four hundred,
 According to the shekel spent

Within the sanctuary tent.
 86 The twelve gold pans full of incense
Weighed ten *shekels* apiece, in pence
 According to the shekel weight
 Of sanctuary *and of state*,
 All the gold of the pans *weighed* one
 Hundred and twenty *shekels done*.
 87 All the oxen for the burnt offering
Were twelve young bulls, and twelve rams
proffering,
 Twelve male lambs yearling, with their
 grain
 Offering, and the goats' kids *in train*
 As a sin offering twelve. 88 And all
 The oxen for peace offerings' call
 In sacrifice were twenty-four
 Bulls, the rams sixty, and not more
 Than sixty male goats, and the lambs
 In their first year sixty *from dams*.
 This *was* the dedication *offering*
 For the altar after the proffering
 Of its anointing. 89 When Moses
 Went to the meeting tent to bless
 And speak with Him, he heard the voice
 Of One speaking to him *by choice*
 From above the mercy seat that
Was on the ark where witness sat,
 From between the two cherubim,
 And thus it was He spoke to him.

As every chief among the twelve brought to
 Your altar, my Beloved, the offerings due,
 And every offering brought was just the
 same,

So every offering glorified Your name.
 Of one command and one light are they all
 Who respond to the divine summons call
 To be Imams and leaders of the world.
 The twelve in time and place have aye
 unfurled
 The same flag of divine proof and of
 power.

Each brings his own incense to last an hour,
 The fragrance of the same sweet love and
 truth.

In humble desert tent, acacia booth,
 Or in the mirrored temple built on mount,
 Or in the inner tent, they have one count.

Week 36 Numbers 8

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 2 "Speak to Aaron, and have him led,

"When you arrange the lamps, the lamps
 Seven *in number with their damp*
 Give light in front of the lampstand."
 3 And Aaron did so, *by command*
 He arranged the lamps to face toward
 The front of the lampstand, as *Lord*
 YHWH commanded Moses. 4 Now this
 Craft of the lampstand's *edifice*
Was hammered gold, from its shaft to
 Its flowers it *was* hammered construe.
 According to the pattern which
 YHWH had shown Moses *on the pitch*,
 So he made the lampstand thereto.

Let the lamp that shines in my inner cave
 Where I alone seek out its light and brave,
 Be beaten from the gold of love and fire
 That is the meat and drink of Your desire.
 Let shaft and flowers be spun high in the
 room
 That hides my fragile faith from public
 doom.

I know that pattern that You once revealed
 To Moses on the mount, I know its yield,
 I know its sapphire gleamings and its hard
 And shining plates, and yet the honour
 guard

Of precious words is written on my heart:
 I read them in the shining lights apart
 That glimmer from the lampstand in that
 place,
 Hidden from all the world but not Your
 face.

5 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 6 "Take Levites from among *well-fed*
 Folk of Israel and cleanse them *right*.

7 "Thus you shall do to them in rite:
 Douse water of purification
 On them, and let them each location
 On all their body shave, and let
 Them wash their clothes, *and not forget*,
 And *so* make themselves clean. 8 "Then let
 Them take a young bull with its grain
 Offering of fine flour mixed *again*
 With oil, and you shall take another
 Young bull as sin offering *to brother*.

The only ones who shave the whole body
 Today, it seems, in answer to Your plea,
 Are Qalandars who roam Your fair earth's
 land,

Alone, unnoticed by the sultan's band.
Without Levite, each firstborn is remanded
To take the role that You then once
commanded,

And so the Qalandar with faith in hand
Wanders about the cities and the roads
With little on his back of other loads
Than what he can remember, what he
knows

Of Your revealing from the mountain
shows.

He meets new Sinais everywhere he goes.
Beloved, look down on hairy me and see
The heart of Qalandar, alone and free.

9 "And you shall bring the Levites here
Before the meeting tent appear,
And you shall gather them together,
The whole assembly *of a feather*,
Of Israel's folk. 10 "So you shall bring
The Levites before YHWH *on wing*,
And the children of Israel shall
Lay their hands on the Levites' *pal*,
11 "And Aaron shall offer Levites
Before YHWH, *like wave offering rites*
From the children of Israel,
That they may perform the work *well*
Of YHWH. 12 "Then the Levites shall lay
Their hands on the heads of the *gay*
Young bulls, and you shall offer one
As a sin offering *as done*
And the other as a burnt offering
To YHWH, to make atonement *proffering*
For the Levites. 13 "And you shall stand
The Levites before Aaron's *band*,
Him and his sons, and then offer
Them *like a wave offering to stir*
YHWH. 14 "Thus you'll separate Levites
From among Israel's folk *by rights*,
And *all* the Levites shall be Mine.
15 "After that the Levites shall join
Into meeting tent service fine.
So you shall cleanse and offer them,
Like a wave offering at the hem.

With burnt offering You separated then
The Levites from all such existing men.
The offering of a bull might seem to vie
With taurobolium upon the sly.
The offering is a gauge of faithfulness,
The common meal of parties that confess
A contract solemn and a promise kept.

The modern reader sees who wailed and
wept
With rantings, dancings, cuttings of the
flesh

As something on the same order and fresh.
The human sacrifice that Christians pose
Makes older things collapse before the
nose.

Beloved, I join with You in promised meal
Confirming that You and I make a deal.

16 "For they *are* wholly given to Me
From among Israel's children free,
I have taken them for Myself
Instead of all who open *shelf*
Of the womb, the firstborn of all
The children of Israel *by call*.

17 "For all of the firstborn among
The children of Israel *were sung*
As Mine own, both the man and beast,
On the day that I struck *at least*
All the firstborn in Egypt's land
I sanctified Myself their *band*.

18 "I have taken Levites instead
Of all the firstborn of the bred
Children of Israel. 19 "And I have
Given the Levites as gift *suave*
To Aaron and his sons among
The children of Israel *unsung*,
To do the work for Israel's folk
In tent of meeting *at a stroke*,
To make atonement for the folk
Of Israel, that there be no plague
Among Israel's folk, *clear or vague*,
When the children of Israel come
Near sanctuary *with their sum*."

20 Thus Moses and Aaron and all
The assembly of Israel's call
Did to the Levites, according
To all that YHWH said commanding
Moses concerning the Levites,
So Israel's folk did for their *rights*.
21 And Levites purified themselves
And washed their clothes *upon their*
shelves,

Then Aaron presented them, *like*
A wave offering before YHWH's *strike*,
And Aaron made atonement for
Them to cleanse them *each, all the more*.

22 After that the Levites went in
To do their work *and without sin*
In the meeting tent before Aaron

And his sons, as YHWH once did swear on
 Moses concerning the Levites,
 So they did to them *for their rights*.
 23 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 24 "This is what *is* for Levites' spread:
 From twenty-five years old and up
 One may enter to bear the cup
 Of service in the meeting tent,
 Its work *and all its labours spent*,
 25 "And at the age of fifty years
 They must cease doing work *for fears*,
 And shall work no more *in arears*.
 26 "They may minister with their brothers
 In meeting tent to help the others,
 But they *themselves* shall do no work.
 Thus you shall do *and not to shirk*
 To the Levites regarding work."

The Levites get to work for five more years
 Than do the priest, such justice raises fears.
 Ought not all workers catch the same
 amount

And all come to a common, saving count?
 Ah no, it seems each ministry atones
 For what it takes from energy and bones.
 The priest requires five years of youthful
 scopes

To learn the legal lessons of his ropes.
 Only at thirty can he tell the times
 Distinguishing between the rights and
 crimes.

The aged come to lend a helping hand,
 But not hand so much as the right
 command,

Knowing how things ought to be done they
 spell

The knots their children could not tie up
 well.

Numbers 9

1 Now YHWH spoke to Moses within
 The wilderness of Sinai's *spin*,
 In the first month of second year
 After they'd come from Egypt's *fear*,
 Saying 2 "Let folk of Israel keep
 The Passover when I say *peep*."

3 "On this month's fourteenth day, at
 twilight,

You shall keep it appointed skylight,
 According to all its rites and
 Rituals you shall keep command."

4 So Moses said to Israel's folk

To keep Passover *as God spoke*.

5 And they kept the Passover on
 Fourteenth day of the first month *drawn*,
 At twilight, in the wilderness
 Of Sinai, by all the address
 That YHWH commanded to Moses,
 So did the folk of Israel do.

6 Now there were *then certain* men who
 Were defiled by a human corpse,
 So they could not, *because it warps*,
 Keep the Passover on that day,
 And they came to Moses to say,
 And spoke to Aaron in that way.

7 And those men said to him, "We are
 Defiled by a human corpse *scar*."

Why are we kept from presenting
 The offering of YHWH at its wing
 Of time appointed among folk
 Of Israel?" 8 And Moses spoke
 To them, "Stand still, that I may hear
 What YHWH will command for your *fear*."

Who touch and bathe the body of the dead
 Must purify themselves and so be led,
 And so they will not keep the feast that
 You

Command upon the Prophet's word to do.
 The year was made upon Your own
 command,

And in its cycle by prophetic hand
 In every age there are such feasts that turn
 The minds of men from moon and sun that
 burn

To know that You are one, to You return
 All faces that a body may discern.
 I turn to You from day to day and year
 To year as long as I have to appear,
 And find beyond the wax and wane of tide
 That You are always standing at my side.

9 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, saying

10 "Speak to Israel's folk, saying
 'If anyone of you or your
 Posterity is unclean for
 A corpse, or *is* far away on
 A journey, he may still keep *drawn*
 YHWH's Passover. 11 'On fourteenth day
 Of second month, at twilight, they

May keep it. They shall eat it with
 Unleavened bread and bitter withe.

12 'They shall leave none of it until
 Morning, nor break one of its still

Bones. According to all the laws
 Of Passover they'll keep its cause.
 13 'But the man who's clean and is not
 On a journey, and still does not
 Keep the Passover, that same one
 Shall be cut off from among son
 Of his people, because he did
 Not bring the offering that YHWH did
 Appoint to its time, that man shall
 Bear his sin. 14 'And if stranger dwell
 Among you, to keep YHWH's Passover,
 He must do so according to
 The rite of Passover moreover
 And according to its law due,
 You shall have single ordinance,
 Both for the stranger and the grants
 Of native born in land *to dance*.'" "

The Passover occurs upon the day
 Of the month that the divine, sovereign
 way
 Demands, the evening of the fourteenth
 night.
 To miss the first month brings into the sight
 The second month, so none may go astray.
 Prophetic feasts may oft be set aside
 And postponed for trip with or without
 guide,
 But meeting You is not subject to such,
 For every Sabbath comes to say as much
 And is not tallied on the day to come
 But has to make only the seventh sum.
 And coming of Your breath and holy touch
 Is never set off to a future date:
 I am here on this day and here I wait.

15 Now on the day the tent was set
 Up, the covering cloud the tent met,
 The tent of testimony, from
 Evening until morning it's come
 Above the tabernacle like
 Appearance of a fire *to strike*.
 16 So it was always, the cloud covered
 It *by day*, and appearance *hovered*
With fire by night. 17 But when the cloud
 Was taken up *above the crowd*
And from the tent, after that then
 The folk of Israel would unpen
 And journey, and in the place where
 The cloud settled, Israel's folk there
 Would pitch their tents. 18 At the
 command

Of YHWH Israel's folk would stand
 To journey, and at the command
 Of YHWH they would encamp, as long
 As the cloud stayed above the *throng*
And tabernacle they remained
 Camped. 19 Even when the cloud
 refrained,

Continued long, many days there
 Above the tabernacle where
 The folk of Israel kept the charge
 Of YHWH, did not journey at large.
 20 So it was, when the cloud stood fast
 Above the tabernacle past
 A few days: according to word
 Of YHWH they would remain unstirred,
 And according to YHWH's command
 They would journey. 21 So it was, when
 The cloud remained only from eve
 Until the morning: and then when
 The cloud was taken up to leave
 In the morning, then they would journey,
 Whether by day or night's *attorney*,
 Whenever cloud was taken up,
 They would journey *for the world cup*.

22 *Whether it was* two days, or yet,
 A month, or year the cloud was set
 Above the tabernacle stamped,
 The folk of Israel'd stay encamped
 And not journey, but when it was
 Taken up, they'd journey *abuzz*.
 23 At the command of YHWH they stayed
 Encamped, and at YHWH's *word* relayed
 They journeyed, kept the charge of
 YHWH,
 At the command of YHWH and made
 By the hand of Moses *to do*.

Moses is the appointed guide and true,
 And yet the one that really guides is You.
 Each morning on awaking all looked out
 To see the cloud above the tent about,
 And if it rose and moved then with a shout
 Or silent acquiescence, everyone
 Got ready to take journey under sun.
 So day by day Your guidance went above
 The word of Moses toward the land of love.
 I too each morning look to You alone
 To see if I shall remain in the bone
 Or take my flight to other world and zone.
 Beloved, I look to You for cloud and light
 To lead me through the forest and the night.

Numbers 10

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
2 "Make two silver trumpets to sing
For yourself, you shall make them of
Hammered work, you shall use *in love*
Trumpets for calling the assembly
And for directing movement *trembly*
Of the camps. 3 "When they blow them
both,

All the assembly *that's not sloth*
Shall gather to you at the door
Of meeting tent *to hear the score.*

4 "But if they blow *only one*, then
The leaders, the heads of the men,
Divisions of Israel, shall come
Gathered to you *to hear the sum.*

By silver trumpets Your divine guide, proof
Commands the people not to be aloof.

He blows the one to summon leading men,
He blows them both to find the folk again
To gather all before the royal tent
Where hides the bright shekinah from You
sent.

The leading ones hear only one clear sound
And know where they should gather on the
ground.

But all the people hear a symphony,
An interval of two notes blown sweetly.
Who knows if a third or a fourth was heard,
Or if the voice was of the quavering bird
Whose music is beyond the call of ear
To analyse according to the peer.

5 "When you sound the advance, the camps
That lie on the east side *of damps*
Shall then begin their journey *out.*

6 "When you sound the advance *with shout*
The second time, then the camps lying
On the south side *without defying*
Shall start their journey, they shall sound
The call for them to start their round.

7 "When the assembly is to be
Gathered together, you'll decree
To blow, but not sound the advance.

8 "The sons of Aaron, *in their dance*,
The priests, shall blow the trumpets, and
These shall be to you as command,
Forever through your generations.

9 "When you go to war in your stations
Against the enemy oppressing
You, then you shall sound an addressing

Alarm with the trumpets, and you
Will be remembered before YHWH
Your God, and you will be saved from
Your enemies *before they come.*

10 "Also in the day of your gladness,
In your appointed feasts *not sadness*,
And at the start of your months, you
Shall blow the trumpets *with their cue*
Over your burnt offerings and over
The sacrifices of moreover
Your peace offerings, and they shall be
Memorial for you and Me
Before your God: for I am YHWH
Your God *who sees all that you do.*"

Although each eye can see the blessed
cloud

That guides by day and night, the trump
aloud

Must sound before the footsteps can
advance.

Obedience is order in the dance,
Despite the showing of the right and wrong
To every eye awaiting in the throng.

No one is called to run out all alone
To find the path to water from the stone.
Even when Your cloud of light and fire
come

You still rely upon appointed's sum.
Beloved, let me not run beyond the course
Of Your will upon golden ass or horse.
I wait for the call of Your sent, Beloved,
Stand coated, hatted and well leather-
gloved.

11 It happened on the twentieth *day*
Of the second month, in the sway
Of second year, the cloud was taken
From testimony tent unshaken.

12 And the children of Israel set
Out from Sinai's wilderness' sweat
On their journeys, then the cloud set
Down in the wilderness of Paran.

13 So they started out *not to err on*
For the first time according to
The commandment *given* by YHWH
And by the hand of Moses *come.*

14 The standard of the camp *in sum*
Of Judah's folk set out first by
Their armies, over their army
Was Nahshon Amminadab's son.

15 Over the army of the one

Tribe of Issachar's folk *was one*
 Nethanel the son of Zuar. 16 And
 Over the army by command
 Of the tribe of Zebulon's folk
Was Eliab son of Helon.
 17 Then the tent of the meeting broke
 Camp, and all the sons of Gershon
 And the sons of Merari set
 Out, carrying the tabernacle.
 18 The standard of Reuben's camp set
 Out according to armies' tackle,
 Over their army Elizur
 Who was the son of Shedeur.

The command was set forth that when the
 cloud
 Should rise from tent, then all would be
 allowed
 To strike their tents and set off toward the
 land
 Of promise, of milk and the honey band.
 And yet a full year passed without a motion
 Of the cloud on the tent for magic potion.
 Each morning both the righteous and the
 dumb
 Got up to see if sign to move had come,
 And each at evening lay him down to sleep
 As patiently as any farmer's sheep.
 I thank You, my Beloved, I wait no sign
 To get up and be marching to the fine.
 I thank You that my patience is not tried
 A year before I start to make a stride.

19 Over the army of the tribe
 Of Simeon's folk *we might describe*
 Shelumiel Zurishaddai's son.
 20 And over the army begun
 By the tribe of the folk of Gad
Was Eliasaph Deuel's son.
 21 The Kohathites set out *not sad*
 To carry the holy things after.
 The tent would be prepared *to rafter*
 For their arrival. 22 And the flag
 Of the camp of Ephraim's ragtag
 Set out according to armies,
 Over their army *set to please*,
 Elishama Ammihud's son.
 23 Over the army of the tribe
 Of Manasseh's folk *was the scribe*
 Gamaliel Pedahzur's son.
 24 And over the army of tribe
 Of Benjamin's folk Abidan

The son of Gideoni, *man*.
 25 And then the standard of the camp
 Of the children of Dan, revamp
 In the rear guard of all the folk
 Set out by their armies *in stroke*,
 Over their army *was* Ahiezer
 Who was son of Ammishaddai, *sir*.
 26 Over the army of the tribe
 Of Asher's folk *we may describe*
 Pagiel the son of Ocran.
 27 And over the army of tribe
 Of Naphtali Ahira, *man*
 And the *foremost* son of Enan.
 28 Thus *was* the order of the march
 Of Israel's folk *and not to parch*,
 According to their armies, when
 They began their journey *as men*.

The order that the lads heard when the
 march
 Was made in clockwise circuit of the arch,
 Which shows them leaving circle in the
 way
 Counter to the sun at the start of day.
 I also rise after the year's reproach
 To whirl against the daylight and the coach,
 With feet bare on the shadow of the plain
 Where sacrifices are still made amain.
 Follow the leader, whirling like the sun,
 I step out on the dergah till I'm done.
 Beloved, I hear the trumpet and the drum
 And wending through the crowds, to You I
 come.
 My creaking bones and tendons feel the
 weight
 Of unaccustomed footsteps to Your gate.

29 Now Moses said to Hobab son
 Of Reuel the Midianite *gun*,
 And Moses's father-in-law,
 "We're setting out for place of awe
 Of which YHWH said 'I'll give it you.'
 Come with us, we'll treat you well, YHWH
 Has promised good things to Israel."
 30 And he told him, "I'll not go *well*,
 But I'll depart to my *own* land
 And to my relatives *at hand*."
 31 So *Moses* said "Please do not leave,
 Since you know how to camp and weave
 In wilderness, and you can be
 Our eyes. 32 "And it shall *surely* be,
 If you go with us, it shall be

That whatever good YHWH will do
 To us, the same we'll do to you."
 33 So they departed from the mount
 Of YHWH in trip of three days' count,
 And the ark of the covenant
 Of YHWH went before them *puissant*
 For the three days' journey, to search
 Out a resting place for their perch.
 34 And the cloud of YHWH *was* above
 Them by day when they went out of
 The camp. 35 So it was, whenever
 Ark set out, Moses would aver,
 "Rise up, O YHWH! And let Your foes
 Be scattered, and let all of those
 Who hate You flee before You." 36 And
 When it rested, he made command,
 "Return, O YHWH, to myriads of
 The folk of Israel *whom You love*."

Moses dared to command You in his song
 As though without his voice You might do
 wrong,
 And yet he himself needed Reuel's advice
 How to get from Sinai to Paradise.
 So I say "Rise up" and "Return" to You
 By recitation of Your name of YHWH,
 And see the cloud and ark before my door,
 And kiss the threshold as I did before.
 Three days I seek a resting place to be
 Where only You and I each other see,
 And as I seek I find Your leading round
 Is best of all the criers to be found.
 Beloved, I turn my back on Goshen's
 ground
 And follow You, Beloved, invisibly.

Numbers 11

1 Now *when* the people complained, it
 Displeased YHWH, for YHWH had heard
 it,
 And His wrath was aroused, the fire
 Of YHWH burned among their desire,
 And consumed *some* in the outskirts
 Of the camp. 2 Then *in dire deserts*
 The people cried out to Moses,
 And when Moses prayed YHWH for this,
 The fire was quenched. 3 And so he called
 The name of the place Taberah,
 Because the fire of YHWH *appalled*
 Had burned among their *camera*.

Here my complaint, Beloved, I enter fire

And seek Your love above all my desire.
 I wrinkle dying in the sweet abode
 Of fire upon the fringes of the mode.
 No company share with me my retreat,
 No battalion joins me with treading feet
 Around the outskirts of the temple stair.
 Look, I'm the only one who's dancing there.
 Who come out from the floors of the noon
 prayer
 Look in disgust to see my ecstasy
 Go up in smoke before the summer tree.
 Beloved, burn me to nothing is my will,
 And I shall have but You upon my bill,
 You only, my Beloved, eternally.

4 Now the mixed multitude who were
 Among them yielded lustier
 To hankering, so Israel's folk
 Also wept once more and then spoke,
 "Who'll give us meat to eat? 5 "We mind
 The fish we ate in Egypt lined,
 The cucumbers, melons, the leeks,
 The onions, and garlic *for weeks*,
 6 "But now our whole being *is* dried
 Up, *there's* nothing at all beside
 This manna *before* our eyes!" 7 Now
 The manna *was* like anyhow
 Coriander seed, its colour like
 The colour of bdellium *strike*.
 8 The people went about and gathered
It, ground *it* on millstones or tethered,
 Beat *it* in the mortar, cooked *it*
 In pans, and made them cakes of it,
 And its taste was like taste of pasty
 Prepared with oil, *but not too hasty*.
 9 And when the dew fell on the camp
 At night, manna fell on it *damp*.
 10 Then Moses heard the people weeping
 Throughout their families, each keeping
 At the door of his tent, the wrath
 Of YHWH went on the great warpath,
 And Moses also was displeased.
 11 So Moses said to YHWH *uneased*,
 "Why have You afflicted Your slave?
 And why have I not found the brave
 Favour in Your sight, that You have
 Laid the burden *and half the salve*
 Of all these people on my *breast*?
 12 "Did I conceive these people *best*?
 Did I beget them, that You should
 Say to me, 'Carry as you could
 Them in your bosom, as a guard

Carries a nursing child *well-starred*,
 To the land You swore to their fathers?
 13 "Where am I to get meat, *such bothers*,
 To give all these people? For they
 Weep all over me, saying 'Nay,
 Give us meat, we may eat *today*.'
 14 "I am not able to bear all
 These people alone, for the call
 Of the burden's too great for me.
 15 "If You treat me so and suchly,
 Please kill me here and now, if I
 Have found favour before Your eye,
 And do not let me continue
 To see wretchedness before You."

The cry eternal goes toward the sky,
 Give meat to eat, we cannot live on pie.
 Did You create the veils of human sum
 To laugh at the irrational and dumb
 That we espouse so eagerly before
 We will sniff daintily to find the door
 To manna? Yes or no, I think I know
 Your humour glows beneath the clowning
 toe
 Upon the footstool of the earth below.
 Just tap Your foot a bit and we will show
 You why we prefer garlic to the fare
 You would grant us to season everywhere.
 If manna were addicting, I would eat
 The stuff each day I found it as a treat.

16 YHWH said to Moses "Gather to
 Me seventy men elders *and true*
 Of Israel, whom you know to
 Be elders of the people and
 Officers over Israel's band,
 Bring them before the meeting tent,
 That they may stand with you present.
 17 "Then I will come down and I'll talk
 With you there. I will take a *stalk*
 Of the spirit that's upon you
 And put *the same* upon them too,
 And they shall bear the burden of
 The people with you, in the shove,
 That you may not bear *it* yourself
 Alone *without the help of elf*.
 18 "Then you shall say unto the folk,
 'Consecrate yourselves, *go for broke*,
 For on tomorrow you shall eat
 Meat, for you've wept to have *the treat*
 In hearing of YHWH, saying "Who
 Will give us meat to eat *a few*?"

For *it was* well with us in land
 Of Egypt." Therefore YHWH *by hand*
 Will give you meat, and you shall eat.
 19 'You shall eat, not one day *the treat*,
 Nor two days, nor five days, nor ten,
 Nor twenty days, 20 'but *till you ken*
 A whole month, and until it comes
 Out of your nostrils, in your gums
 Loathsome to you, since you've despised
 YHWH who's among you *well apprised*,
 And have wept before Him, and said
 "Why did we leave Egyptian bread?""
 21 And Moses said "The people whom
 I *am* among *are in their room*
 Six hundred thousand men on foot,
 Yet You have said 'I shall now put
 Before them meat, that they may eat
 For a whole month, *it's such a feat*.'
 22 "Shall flocks and herds be slaughtered
 for
 Them, to provide enough in store?
 Or shall all the fish of the sea
 Be gathered together to be
 Provision enough for their spree?"
 23 And YHWH said to Moses, "Has
 YHWH's
 Arm been shortened? Now you'll not lose
 To see if what I say's a plot
 To happen to you *all* or not."

You give, Beloved, to every one that prays
 The gift of poison and death, which he
 stays
 With hope and thanks to get in hand from
 You.
 You know better what I need than I do.
 I ask for no meat, ask for nothing true,
 But willingly eat manna with the dew.
 Avoiding every slaughter at the door,
 I let the knife go rusty in the store,
 And rest my lazy bones from every chore
 But gathering the morning manna from
 The stony ground upon which it has come.
 It looks like frost I know, it looks like snow
 That in the night in silence came to glow
 Upon the granite slopes in touch and go.

24 And Moses went out, told the folk
 The words of YHWH, and *what He spoke*
 And he gathered the seventy men
 Of the folk's elders, placed *again*
 Them all around the meeting tent.

25 Then YHWH came down in the cloud
sent,

And spoke to him, and took the spirit
That *was* upon him *and to fear it,*
And placed *the same* upon the *men,*
The seventy elders, and again,
It happened, when the spirit rested
Upon them, that they were invested
To prophesy, although they did
Not *do so* again *while they hid.*
26 But two men had remained in camp:
The name of one *was* Eldad, scamp,
And the name of the other was
Medad. And also spirit was
Resting on them, who *were* among
Those mentioned, but who had not strung
Out to the tabernacle, yet
They prophesied in the camp set.
27 And a young man ran up to tell
Moses, and said "Eldad as well
As Medad are prophesying
In the camp *where no man should sing.*"

28 So Joshua the son of Nun, *who*
Was Moses' servant, *helper too,*
Of his choice men, answered and said
"Moses my lord, forbid instead!"
29 Then Moses said to him, "Are you
Zealous for my sake? Oh, that all
YHWH's folk were prophets *at the call,*
That YHWH would put His spirit too
On them!" 30 And Moses returned to
Camp, he and Israel's elders too.

The book of Numbers carefully outlines
The demarcations and hidden landmines
In knowing how to step around the plot
Of the authority that You have wrought
On earth among humans and what they've
got.

Who tries to take the seat of Moses may
Be put down in the heavy, sacred fray,
But who refuses to go up to take
The spirit gifts before the public stake
But hides within his chamber well-confined
Is greatly vindicated out of mind.
Though some may criticize my single load
Reciting all alone Your names' abode,
I drink Your spirit here and where
bestowed.

31 Now a spirit went out from YHWH,
And it brought quail from the sea too

And let *them* fall around the camp,
A day's journey *without a lamp*
On this side and about a day's
Journey on to the other *haze,*
And all around the camp, about
Two cubits deep above the clout.
32 And the people stayed up all day,
All night, and then all the next day,
And gathered up the quail *to slay,*
He who gathered least gathered ten
Homers, and they spread *them again*
Out for themselves around the camp.
33 But while the meat *was* still in clump
Between their teeth, and before chewed,
The wrath of YHWH aroused *in feud*
Against the people, and YHWH struck
The folk with a very great muck.
34 So he called the name of that place
Kibroth Hattaavah, of their race
They buried there all in the dust
Who had weakly yielded to lust.
35 From Kibroth Hattaavah the folk
Moved to Hazeroth, and awoke
To camp at Hazeroth *and croak.*

The people I have seen who claim Your
spirit
Falls on them in their ecstasies or near it
Give proof in falling on the floor in trance,
Or sweeping round the room in hideous
dance,
Or babbling nonsense in the tongue it
seems
Of Canaan, heaven, or nightmarish dreams.
This is original to say the least
That Your spirit when come moves bird or
beast
Into the line of slaughter and of lust.
Your spirit gives to every human dust
By which we make salvation or our doom.
Let Your spirit fall in my quiet room
And I shall move or stand still as I must.

Numbers 12

1 Then Miriam and Aaron spoke
Against Moses because the bloke
Had married a woman that came
From Ethiopia *in name,*
He had married a woman who
Wore an Ethiopian *shoe.*
2 So they said "Has YHWH indeed spoken
Only through Moses *for a token?*"

Has He not spoken through us too?"
And YHWH heard *that the thing was true*.
3 Now the man Moses *he was* meek,
More than all men who *showed a beak*
Upon the face of *all* the earth,
Such a man was Moses in worth.

In fault or purpose, my Beloved, You chose
Moses to wear representative clothes.
You made the meekest of men Your caliph
Who had in charismatic charm no whiff.
If no one followed him, the fault was Yours
For choosing one who could not inspire
bores

To Your obedience. If You had taken
Instead a Pharaoh or a pop star shaking,
The crowd would have been wild to do his
will.

But even brother and sister wax shrill
That Moses has no push or shove to fill
The shoes of divine guide in heaven or
earth.

Your choosing Moses was a thing not
worth,
I'd say, so many deaths for one man's birth.

Watch this, Beloved, the purpose of the
pair

Is to depose inheritance of heir.
But instead of saying the man's not fit
Because of lack of aplomb and of wit,
They take advantage of perennial bloom
Of racist outrage to make out the room
Of their political ambition's blight.
They say that Moses took a nigger wife
And so he ought to step down from the
right

Of ruling white folks with a hand of strife.
But watch again! Racist philosophy
Is shaped in terms of bright democracy:
All by whom You have spoken in the race
Are equal, so give me Moses's place.

4 And said YHWH suddenly to *him*,
To Moses, Aaron, and Miriam,
"Come out, you three, before the tent
Of tabernacle!" The three went.
5 Then YHWH came down in pillar cloud
And stood *in* the tent door *in shroud*,
And called Aaron and Miriam. And
They both went forward *by command*.
6 Then He said "Hear now My words: if

There is a prophet in your skiff,
I, YHWH, make Myself known to him
In a vision, I speak to him
In a dream. 7 Not so with My servant
Moses, he's faithful and he's fervent
In all My house. 8 I speak with him
Face to face, even plainly *trim*,
And not in dark sayings, and he
Sees the form of YHWH, *which is Me*.
Why then were you not frightened to
Speak against My slave Moses *true*?"
9 The anger of YHWH was aroused
Against them, He departed *housed*.

You give the reason Moses' role is great
And unique not because You chose his fate
Or because he's appointed to the task
But because when the futile critics ask
It turns out You speak to him face to face.
Ah yes, indeed the face to face in grace
Is all authority in heaven and earth.
That's why I seek, Beloved, Your face of
worth.

In every cloud of fire and light I trace
The hidden features and divine repair.
In every seam of granite, lichen crusted,
I see the lines of divine natures dusted.
Beloved, the newly sprung crocus tears out
The snow veils and You finely peer about.

10 And when the cloud departed from
Above the tabernacle *some*,
Then suddenly Miriam's *become*
One leprous, *and as white as snow*.
Then Aaron turned toward Miriam's *show*,
And there she was, a leper. 11 So
Aaron said to Moses, "My lord!
Please do not lay *this sin by sword*
On us, in which we've foolishly
Done and in which sinning have we
Sinned. 12 "Please do not let her now be
As one dead, whose flesh half consumed
Is coming from his mother's womb!"

Hold on, Beloved, let's get this right.
When Aaron sins, the woman gets the
blight.

Did not both Aaron and Miriam unfold
Dissatisfaction for Your being bold
In letting Moses take to wife a wench
His family thought did not fit the bench?

And if then both, then why lay blame on
 one?
 And if on one, why is the woman done?
 Male chauvinism's one thing, but when
 You
 Evince the same in a divine to do,
 It's too much for political correctness
 And for race and sex corrective selectness.
 Beloved, shame on Your judgement
 cavalier!
 Give Aaron too leprosy on his ear!

13 So Moses cried out to YHWH, saying
 "Please heal her, O El God, I'm praying!"
 14 Then YHWH said to Moses, "If her
 Father had but spit on *the fur*
Of her face, would she not be shamed
 Seven days? Let her be *so blamed*
And shut out of the camp seven days,
 And afterward received *from daze*."
 15 So Miriam was shut out of camp
 Seven days *long, and in the damp*
 The people did not journey till
 Miriam was brought back, *paid her bill*.
 16 And afterward the people moved
 From Hazeroth and camped *reproved*
 In Paran's desert *by the hill*.

Humanity is often in a state
 Of surprising compassion before fate.
 That's why, Beloved, I guess You made at
 all
 The universe, the earth, and on that ball
 The human witness to Your grace, though
 small.
 We're capable, though all unfairly in it,
 To have compassion once we do begin it.
 Justice would say that they should wait of
 any
 Who had been put outside the camp for
 penny.
 I wonder, did You lift the cloud to lead
 The people on their way to follow feed,
 Or did You acquiesce to their fond need
 To wait for Miriam on the tortured mead?
 Sometimes we recompense our human
 greed.

Week 37 Numbers 13

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 2 "Send men to spy out the land's spread
 Of Canaan, which I'm giving to

The children of Israel, on cue
 From each tribe of their fathers you
 Shall send a man, each one a leader
 Among them, *of My word a heeder*."
 3 And Moses sent them *as requested*
 From desert of Paran, *where rested*,
 According to command of YHWH,
 All of them men who *were* heads *true*
 Of the children of Israel.
 4 Now these *were* their names *known full*
well:

From the tribe of Reuben, Shammua
 The son of Zaccur, 5 and *not fewer*,
 From the tribe of Simeon, Shaphat
 The son of Hori, 6 and from that
 Tribe of Judah, Caleb the son
 Of Jephunneh, 7 and from the *won*
 Tribe of Issachar, Igal son
 Of Joseph, 8 from the tribe *well done*
 Of Ephraim, Hoshea son
 Of Nun, 9 from tribe of Benjamin,
 Palti the son of Raphu, 10 from
 The tribe of Zebulun, had come
 Gaddiel son of Sodi, 11 from
 The tribe of Joseph, *that is*, from
 The tribe of Manasseh, Gaddi
 The son of Susi, 12 and from by
 The tribe of Dan, Ammiel son
 Of Gemalli, 13 from the tribe of
 Asher, Sethur who's the son of
 Michael, 14 from tribe of Naphtali,
 Nahbi who's the son of Vophsi,
 15 From the tribe of Gad, Geuel the son
 Of Machi. 16 These *are* the names done
 Of men whom Moses sent to spy
 Out the land. Moses called Hoshea
 Son of Nun, Joshua, *obeyer*.

If Moses had called others of these men
 By such pregnant names, things might have
 gone then
 Another course. For YHWH will save's a
 name
 To guide to faith and trust, though not
 enflame.

No doubt the new name for Hoshea made
 His heart on fire, no less, to make the grade
 Believe that You were always there to save.
 But what about Gaddi and Gemalli,
 They had to watch the grand events pass by
 Without encouragement of new names and
 New hopes of coming to the promised land.

Beloved, call me by any name of slave
And I shall be like Joshua the brave,
And not come down at last to Sethur's
grave.

17 Then Moses sent them to spy out
The land of Canaan *without doubt*,
And said to them, "Go up this *way*
Into the south, *follow the way*
Up to the mountains, 18 "and see what
The land is like: whether the rut
Of folk who live in it *are* strong
Or weak, few or many *along*,
19 "Whether the land they live in's good
Or bad, whether the cities' *hood*
They inhabit *is* like camps or
Strongholds, 20 "if the land's rich or poor,
And whether there are forests there
Or not. Be of good courage, fair.
And bring some of fruit of the land."
And the time *was* the season *stand*
Of first ripe grapes *to take in hand*.

If Moses knew by Joshua's name that
You would save the folk wherever they sat,
Then why did he need detailed spying on
The strength and number of the foe at
dawn?

Or was it that the first ripe grapes contrived
To tempt his tongue before he had arrived
From desert manna to the fruited plain?
If none had gone to spy, I'd see the gain.
If the twelve had refused to take the trip
As too hard on their feet, I think the slip
Might have been well forgiven. Let me
bear

No burdens other than must meet the air,
And You will find me, my Beloved, about
The business of Your calling and Your
shout.

21 So they went up and spied the land
From Wilderness of Zin's command
As far as Rehob, near entrance
Of Hamath, *they spied at a glance*.
22 They went up through the south and
came
To Hebron, Ahiman, Sheshai,
And Talmai, sons of Anak's fame
Were there. Now Hebron was built by
Seven years before Zoan in Egypt.
23 Then they came in the valley crypt

Of Eshcol, and there cut a branch
With one cluster of grapes *on ranch*,
They carried it between two men
On a pole, also *brought again*
Some of the pomegranates and figs.
24 The place was called *among the rigs*
The Valley of Eshcol, because
Of the cluster which the men's *claws*
Of Israel cut down there. 25 And they
Returned from spying out the lay
Of the land after forty day.

I'd think a cluster of grapes such as that
Would be missed by both guard dog and
house cat.
A spy should be less noticeable, no?
But these men were for forty day not slow
To gaze upon the promised and to go
From south to north to find both sun and
snow.

I too for forty days lift up my eyes
On high to look and find Your paradise,
And as I see the light of verdure here
Among the pines and firs methinks appear
The gleams of Eshcol's grapes, both ripe
and sweet.

I take one grape, a single grape for treat,
And cut the fruit in forty pieces till
My comrades feast on them and get their
fill.

26 And they departed and came back
To Moses and Aaron *in track*
And all the congregation of
The children of Israel above
In Wilderness of Paran, at
Kadesh, they brought to them that sat
Back word and to all the assembly,
And showed them the land's fruit, *all*
trembly.

27 Then they told him, and said "We went
To the land into which you sent
Us. It truly flows with milk and
Honey, and this *is* its fruit *canned*.
28 "Nevertheless the people who
Live in the land *are* strong, *it's true*,
The cities *are* fortified *and*
Very large, moreover we saw
The sons of Anak *and their maw*.
29 "Amalekites live in the land
Of the south, the Hittites, and band
Of Jebusites, and Amorites

Live in the mountains, Canaanites
 Live by the sea and on the banks
 Of the Jordan *and in their ranks.*"
 30 Then Caleb quieted the folk
 Before Moses, and said "*By smoke,*
 Let us go up at once and take
 Possession, for we have the stake
 To overcome it." 31 But the men
 Who had gone up with him again
 Said "We are not able to go
 Up against the people, for *show*
 They *are* stronger than we." 32 And they
 Gave the folk of Israel to say
 A bad report of the land which
 They had spied out, and *in a pitch*
 They said "The land through which we've
 gone

As spies *is* a land that its spawn
 Devours, and all the folk whom we
 Saw in it *are* men of degree.
 33 "There we saw the giants, the sons
 Of Anak came from giants' *buns,*
 And we were like grasshoppers in
 Our own eyes, and so we were in
 Their sight *from tower and gate and bin."*

Ah, there's excuse for faith and failure of
 Both Joshua and the ten out of love.
 But Caleb, lovely Caleb, had no name
 New with hope, yet he rose to make the
 claim

That forty dancing through a paradise
 Could lay hold on Your strength and so
 dance twice.

There's nothing of reward, promise or hope
 To bind Caleb with an ecstatic rope.
 He reaches up and out of law's thin air
 Grasps what no other man or dance could
 share.

Beloved, like Caleb let me too go free
 To whirl about grapes of eternity,
 And then return and despise all the fears
 That shade and veil the dance of forty
 years.

Numbers 14

1 All the assembly lifted up
 Their voices and cried *in their cup,*
 And the people wept *all* that night.
 2 And all of Israel's folk *in sight*
 Complained against Moses and Aaron,
 And the whole congregation *barren*

Said to them, "If only we'd died
 In the land of Egypt!" *They sighed,*
 "Or if only in wilderness
 We'd kicked the bucket before this!
 3 "Why has YHWH brought us to this land
 To fall by sword *in our foes' hand,*
 That our wives and children should be
 Victims? Would it not better be
 For us to return to Egypt?"
 4 They said to each other *tight-lipped,*
 "Let's take a guide back to Egypt."

Slavery's so sweet, so sweet to look back
 on,

A time when no choices greeted the dawn
 And no regrets for failures met the night.
 A sore back and the lash rather than bite
 Of conscience and duty a man can bear.
 How many turn back to Egyptian care!
 The comfort of unthinking labour and
 Rewards is tempting in most every land.
 But only in Sinai's desert can be
 A man or woman once her own and free.
 Beloved, give me no plot along the Nile
 To be a mummy for eternal while,
 I'd rather for a moment shake beneath
 Your speech that echoes on a barren heath.

5 And then Moses and Aaron fell
 On their faces before *the hell*
Of the assembly of the folk
 Of the children of Israel.

6 But Joshua son of Nun, *good bloke,*
 And Caleb son of Jephunneh,
 Among those who had spied the way
 Of the land, tore their clothes, 7 and they
 Spoke to all the assembly of
 Israel's folk, saying "*Land of love*
 We passed through to spy out *is* good
 As any land can be or could.

8 "If YHWH delights in us, then He
 Will bring us into this land *free*
 And give it to us, 'a land which
 Flows with milk and honey *like pitch.*'

9 "Only don't rebel against YHWH,
 Nor fear the folk of the land's due,
 For they're our bread, their protection
 Is departed from them *and done,*
 And YHWH *is* with us. Do not fear."
 10 And all the congregation sheer
 Said to stone them with stones. Then
 YHWH's

Glory appeared before the mews
Of meeting tent before the swell
Of the children of Israel.

I might go up into the pulpit dressed
In torn clothes instead of my silken best.
I might tell everyone I think they're wrong
To reject Decalogue for other song.
I might preach up the glories I have seen
Of Canaan as I mumble on the green
And whirl to the sound of Your word
supreme,
And cry aloud that haven's not a dream.
I might rend coat and veils and show the
true
And lovely courts of dervish dance and do.
But when, Beloved, the people stand to
stone
Me while we scatter here before Your
throne,
Will You appear in glory seen to save,
Or will You let them send me to the grave?

11 Then YHWH said to Moses, "How long
Will these people reject My *song*?
How long will they not believe Me,
With all the signs which I've made see
Among them? 12 "I will strike them by
Plague and disinherit their pie,
And I will make of you a nation
Greater and stronger than their ration."
13 And then Moses said unto YHWH,
"The Egyptians will hear *it too*,
For by Your mighty arm have You
Brought these people up from among
Them, 14 "and they will tell *it unstrung*
Unto the dwellers of this land.
They have heard that You, YHWH, *will*
stand
Among these people, that You, YHWH,
Are seen face to face and Your cloud
Stands above them, and You in shroud
Of cloud pillar go on in might
By day and one of fire by night.
15 "Now *if* You kill these people as
One man, then each nation that has
Heard of Your fame will speak, and say
16 'Because YHWH was not *in His way*
Able to bring this people to
The land which He swore to give to
Them, therefore He killed them along
In the desert.' 17 "And now, I pray,

Let the power of my Lord *in song*
Be great, just as You've spoken, saying
18 'YHWH's longsuffering and not
gainsaying

His mercy, and iniquity
And transgression forgiving *free*,
But He by no means clears *guilty*,
Visiting the iniquity
Of fathers on the children to
The third and fourth *that come to do*.'
19 "Pardon this folk's iniquity,
I pray, according to the greatness
Of Your mercy, as *not in lateness*
You have forgiven *anyhow*
This folk from Egypt until now."

The argument that Moses uses is
Unutterably low, flat, without fizz.
He thinks that You will change Your mind
because
Some folk might misinterpret what Your
paws
Are capable or not of doing right.
He says they'll say that You're afraid to
fight.
Before I look in contempt on his word
Coming after his heart and bone were
stirred
By Sinai's thunders, let me contemplate
My own lack of faith even in this state
Of having heard the same song sung to me
As once echoed from Sinai's bush and tree.
Beloved, the weakness of the flesh remains
As long as You set I-ness in men's brains.

20 Then YHWH said "I have pardoned by
Your word, 21 "but truly, and as I
Live, all the earth shall be filled by
The glory of YHWH by and by,
22 "Because all these men who have seen
My glory and the signs *between*
Which I did in Egypt and in
The wilderness, *despite their sin*,
And have put Me to the test now
These ten times *running anyhow*,
And have not listened to My voice,
23 "They certainly shall not *by choice*
See the land of which I swore to
Their fathers, nor shall any do
Of those who rejected Me see it.
24 "But My servant Caleb shall be it,
Because he has a different spirit

In him and has followed *or near it*
Me fully, I will bring into
The land where he went, and his due
Descendants shall inherit it.

25 "But Amalekites and the fit
Of Canaanites live in the vale,
Tomorrow move out and turn tail
Into the wilderness by way
Of the Red Sea, *is what I say.*"

26 And YHWH spoke to Moses and Aaron,
Saying 27 "How long *then shall I bear on*
With this evil congregation
Who complain against Me *when done?*
I have heard the complaints which make
The folk of Israel for My sake.

You say that You have pardoned, yet the
death
You threaten is but postponed for the
breath

Of forty years. The argument remains
That You did not bring them into the plains
Of Palestine, but let the people park
Under the desert stars and in the dark.
You did not quash at all the cunning fears
Of Moses that Your strength melted in
tears.

The people still said You could not and still
After the pardon You punished the hill.
Beloved, I flee to hearing of Your word
Despite my trembling at Sinai's cloud
spurred.

Let my complaint be rather that Your voice
Is smaller than my seeking and my choice.

28 "Say to them, 'As I live' says YHWH,
'Just as you've spoken, so I'll do:

29 'The carcasses of those of you
Who've complained against Me shall fall
In this wilderness, of you all
Who were numbered, according to
Your whole number, from twenty years
Old and above. 30 'Except for *tears*
Caleb the son of Jephunneh
And Joshua the son of Nun,
You shall by no means go the way
To enter the land *under sun*
Which I swore I'd make you live in.

31 'But your little ones, whom *in sin*
You said would be victims, I'll bring
In, and they'll know the land *on wing*
Which you've despised. 32 'But *as for* you,

Your carcasses shall fall *in due*
Time in this wilderness. 33 'And your
Sons shall be shepherds here before
The wilderness for forty years,
And bear the brunt of *all your fears*
And infidelity, until
Your carcasses *fall to fulfil*,
Consumed upon the desert *hill*.
34 'According to the number of
The days in which you spied *for love*
The land, for forty days, for each
Day you shall bear your guilt one year,
That's forty years, and you shall hear
My rejection. 35 'I YHWH have spoken
This, I will surely make this token
To all this evil congregation
Who are gathered *in conflagration*
Together against Me. In this
Desert they'll be consumed amiss,
And there they'll die *in the abyss.*"

Let no complaint now pass my lips, though
I
Whirl in the desert and beneath the sky
For forty years of heat and frost and thirst:
Let no complaint from my parched borders
burst.

Beloved, the shaggy moon that wears away
Returns in a fortnight and to the day,
And so my breath that hovers on the gloom
Inspires anew my inner chambered room.
Beloved, the circuit of the risen sun
Look back upon my prayer prostrations
done,

The wind that in the heavy darkness sweeps
Dies in the glow my faithful vigil keeps.
The generations turning bear my dust
To patience as long as the turning must.

36 And the men whom Moses sent to
Spy out the land, who returned to
Make all the assembly complain
Against him by bringing a bad
Report of the land which he had,
37 Those men who brought the bad report
About the land, *all* died athwart
The plague before YHWH, *to be short*.
38 But Joshua the son of Nun
And Caleb who's Jephunneh's son
Remained alive, of the men who
Went to spy out the land, *so few*.
39 Then Moses told these words to all

The children of Israel's *call*,
 And the people mourned greatly, *too*.
 40 And they rose early in the morn
 And went up to the top *with scorn*
 Of the mountain, saying "Here we
 Are, and we will go up to *see*
 The place which YHWH has promised, for
 We have sinned, *what we did before!*"
 41 And Moses said "Now why do you
 Transgress again command of YHWH?
 For this will not succeed. 42 "Do not
 Go up, lest you're in defeat taught
 By enemies, for YHWH *is* not
 Among you. 43 "For Amalekites
 And Canaanites *are* there before you,
 And you shall fall and the sword *score you*,
 Because you've turned away from YHWH,
 YHWH will no *longer* be with you."
 44 But they presumed to go up to
 The mountaintop, nevertheless,
 Neither the ark of covenant
 Of YHWH nor Moses went *to bless*
 Departing from the camp's *address*.
 45 Then came down the Amalekites
 And *with them came* the Canaanites
 Who lived in the mount to attack,
 As far as Hormah drove them back.

Three things were lacking from the brave
 who went
 To take the land that You had only lent
 To Canaanite. Not lacking were the heart,
 Sincerity, courage to act the part,
 Or even sentiments of love to You.
 Their faith was strong in what they had to
 do.
 There only lacked three things, the first was
 that
 They failed in their obeying pitapat,
 They lacked the presence of the one You
 sent
 As prophet and divine guide where they
 went,
 And last they lacked ark of the covenant
 Containing the tables of divine law,
 The ten words writ on stone by no man's
 claw.
 Beloved, I flee to these three in my awe.

Numbers 15

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 2 "Speak to the folk of Israel *spread*,

And say to them, 'When you have come
 Into your land or dwellingdom,
 Which I am giving you, 3 'and you
 Make an offering by fire to YHWH,
 A burnt offering or sacrifice,
 To fulfil a vow or bespice
 A freewill offering or in your
 Appointed feasts, to make it for
 A sweet scent to YHWH, from the herd
 Or the flock, 4 'then he who *is heard*
 To present his offering to YHWH
 Shall bring a grain offering *in due*
 Of one-tenth of an *ephah* of
 Fine flour mixed with one-fourth above
 Of a hin of oil, 5 'and one-fourth
 Of a hin of grape juice poured forth
 As a drink offering you shall make
 Ready with burnt offering for sake
 Of sacrifice, and for each lamb.
 6 'Or you shall prepare for a ram
 As a grain offering two-tenths of
 An *ephah* of fine flour to *shove*
 And mix with one-third of a hin
 Of oil, 7 'and as drink offering *bin*
 You shall offer one-third of hin
 Of grape juice as sweet scent to YHWH.
 8 'And when you prepare *once to do*
 A young bull as a burnt offering,
 Or as a sacrifice *to sing*
 Fulfilment of a vow, or as
 A peace offering to *what* YHWH *has*,
 9 'Then shall be offered with the young
 Bull a grain offering *unsung*
 Of three-tenths of an *ephah* of
 Fine flour mixed with half a hin of
 Oil, 10 'and you shall bring as the drink
 Offering half a hin of grape *pink*
 As an offering made by fire, sweet
 Aroma to YHWH *at His feet*.

The olive oil and flour with grape juice are
 Enough to keep hunger away from bar.
 Make peace for me, Beloved, and feed my
 soul
 With such sweet things that are the
 offering's goal.
 The boiling and the roasting meat's a treat
 Of things in luxury I need not eat
 Except by Your command, Beloved of all,
 And in prostration to the favoured call.
 An offering made by fire in a sweet scent
 Is what I bring to dergah of desire,

And on the slaughtering floor my footsteps
went
Softly like goat footsteps into the fire.
Beloved, I welcome all the sacrifice
That scatters on the fragrant earth in trice.

11 'Thus it shall be done for each young
Bull, *also* for each ram, or *tongue*
Of lamb or young goat. 12 'According
To the number that you would bring,
So you shall do with everyone
According to their number *done*.
13 'All who are native-born shall do
These things in this manner, for to
Present an offering made by fire,
A sweet aroma for YHWH's *choir*.
14 'And if a stranger dwells with you,
Or whoever's among you through
Out your generations, and would
Present an offering made by *wood*
Fire, a sweet aroma to YHWH,
Just as you do, so shall he do.
15 'One ordinance *shall be* for you
Of the assembly and unto
The stranger who dwells *there with you*,
An ordinance forever through
Out your generations, as you
Are, so shall the stranger be too
Before YHWH. 16 'One law and one way
Shall be for you and for the *stray*
Stranger who dwells with you.'" 17 Again
YHWH spoke to Moses, saying then,
18 "Speak to the children of Israel,
And say to them 'When you come dwell
In the land to which I bring you,
19 'Then it will be, and when you do
Eat of the bread of the land, that
You shall offer up *where you sat*
A heave offering to YHWH. 20 'You shall
Offer up cake *angelical*
And of the first of your ground meal
As a heave offering, as a *seal*
Heave offering of the threshing floor,
So shall you offer up *the store*.
21 'Of the first of your ground meal you
Shall give a heave offering to YHWH,
Offering your generations through.

As far as I know I'm not of descent
Of any of the Jewish tribes that went
Across the desert to find sacrifice.
But You say my desires alone suffice.

I eagerly like Isaac once ascend
The stony altar, take the lash and bend
My body and my soul upon the staves
Of fragrance wood and wait the pounding
waves
Of the knife blade. Instead of running
blood
I hear Your voice penetrating the flood
To resurrect me to live on the floor
Of this world's dergah, whirling on the
shore.
Beloved, if tidal wave of love repeat,
I shall rush forward and never retreat.

22 'If you sin not by intention,
And do not observe all this run
Of commandments which YHWH has
spoken
To Moses, 23 'all that YHWH *in token*
Has commanded you by the hand
Of Moses, from the day's command
By YHWH and onward throughout your
Generations, 24 'then *as before*
It will be, if it is not done
On purpose, without benison
Of the assembly, that the whole
Congregation shall *then enrol*
To offer one young bull as burnt
Offering, as sweet aroma earnt
For YHWH, with its grain offering and
Its drink offering by the command,
And one kid of the goats as sin
Offering. 25 'So the priest shall do in
Atonement for the whole crowd of
The children of Israel *for love*,
And it shall be forgiven them,
For it was not by stratagem,
They shall bring their offering to be
An offering made by fire *freely*
To YHWH, and their sin offering be-
Fore YHWH, for unintended sin.
26 'It shall be forgiven then in
The whole assembly of the folk
Of Israel and the stranger bloke
Who dwells among them, because all
The people *did it* not with gall.
27 'And if a person sins on purpose,
Then he shall bring *not to usurp us*
A female goat in its first year
As a sin offering to appear.
28 'So the priest shall make atonement
For the person who has not meant

To sin, when he sins not on purpose
Before YHWH, *and not to extirp us*,
But make atonement for him, and
It shall be forgiven *in hand*.

What grace You here provide, Beloved, for
those

Who purposefully turn aside and close
Their eyes to Your reality, impose
Upon the soul destructive ways and woes.
Who sins on purpose just as one who fails
Without intention to rend the dark veils
Has sacrifice accepted when he comes
To his repentance and to count his sums.
Beloved, I know not which of sacrifice
I ought to bind, from which to take a slice,
For, though the veils that hide Your face
now part,

And I see all the treasures of Your heart,
My own intentions still remain obscured.
I turn relying on Your blessed Word.

29 'You shall have one law for him who
Sins without intention, *it's true*

For him who is native-born *too*
Among the children of Israel

And for the stranger who might dwell
Among them *in town, plain or fell*.

30 'But the person who does *a thing*
Presumptuously *in the ring*,
Whether he's native-born or stranger,
That one brings on reproach *from danger*
On YHWH, and he shall be cut off
From among his people *to scoff*.

31 'Because he has despised the word
Of YHWH, and *also* has preferred
To break His commandment, that one
Shall be completely cut off *son*,
His guilt *shall be* upon his *bun*.'''

I praised Your name the stranger has the
right

And privilege of offering in Your sight.
But privilege entails assuming too
Obedience to commandments right and
true.

Of course there is sweet Christian who
would do

With sacrifice of Christ to let him off
Obedience to blaspheme and to scoff
With trinities and eating the unclean

Which must be all right when with thankful
mien

A body shoves pork in the man machine.
Beloved, let me not take the one and leave
The other, but be careful to receive
Both sacrifice and obeying command
And so live as stranger in promised land.

32 And while the folk of Israel were
In the desert, *it did occur*
They found a man who gathered sticks
Upon the Sabbath day *for tricks*.

33 And those who found him gathering
sticks

Brought him to Moses and Aaron,
And to every assembly's son.

34 They put him under guard, because
It had not been explained *in laws*
What should be done to him. 35 Then

YHWH

Said to Moses, "The man is due
Surely to be put to his death,
All the assembly shall stone him
With stones outside the camp, *how grim*."

36 So, as YHWH commanded Moses,
The congregation *came to this*
And brought him outside the camp and
Stoned him with stones *by human hand*,
And so he died *by God's command*.

The preachers preach that faith is not the
law,

And none need stand before Your throne in
awe,

But rather be victorious and scream
Pop hymns instead of obeying Your dream.
They preach aloud Your law cannot be kept
By human hand no matter how one wept.
If I follow the crowd of Baal and priest,
And church and mosque and New Age
crumble beast,

I must accept that I cannot nor need
To obey You instead of recite creed.
And here's a man who proves the point they
make,

A man who died a martyr for truth's sake,
A man faithful to pope and church and
trick,

Who knew he just had to pick up that stick.

37 Again YHWH spoke to Moses, saying
38 "Speak to the folk of Israel *staying*:

Tell them to make tassels upon
 The edges of their garments *drawn*
 Throughout their generations, and
 To put a blue thread in the *band*
Of tassels on the corners there.
 39 "And you shall have the tassel *bare*,
 That you may look upon it and
 Remember all and each command
 Of YHWH and do them, and that you
May not follow the harlotry
 To which your own heart *would go free*,
 To which your own eyes are inclined,
 40 "And that you may always take mind
 And do all My commandments, and
 Be holy for your God *to stand*.
 41 "I *am* YHWH your God, who brought
 you
 Out of the land of Egypt's *crew*,
 To be your God: I'm your God YHWH."

Maybe sweet Christian preachers tell it
 right
 That nobody can obey You on sight.
 It may indeed be humanly, outright
 Impossible to keep Your law and do
 The simple things, Beloved, You ask us to.
 I wonder if in all their so-called trying
 To keep or not to keep Your law while
 lying,
 Any of them have made a point to set
 A blue thread on his blanket, so to get
 Reminder to observe Your commandment.
 It does not seem quite fair to raise the scent
 Of Your law being not just what it meant,
 If they've not tried at least the blue string
 trick
 To remember to obey thin or thick.

Week 38 Numbers 16

1 Now Korah the son of Izhar,
 The son of Kohath, son *and star*
 Of Levi, with Dathan and one
 Abiram Eliab's, sons, one
 The son of Peleth, Reuben's sons,
 Took *men*, 2 and they rose on their buns
 Before Moses with Israel's folk
 Two hundred fifty leaders' stroke
 From the assembly, representing
 The congregation unrelenting,
 Men of renown. 3 They gathered there
 Together against Moses heir
 And Aaron, and said to them, "You

Take too much on yourselves to do,
 For all the congregation's holy,
 Each of them, *thin or roly-poly*,
 And YHWH's among them. Why then do
 You exalt yourselves above *true*
Assembly of the folk of YHWH?"
 4 So when Moses heard *it*, he fell
 On his face, 5 and he spoke to *tell*
 Korah and all his company,
 Saying "Tomorrow morn early
 YHWH will show who *is* His and *who*
Is holy, and will cause *him* to
 Come near to Him. That one whom He
 Chooses He will cause to come near
 To Him. 6 "Do this: take censers here,
 Korah and all your company,
 7 "Put fire in them and put incense
 In them before YHWH *in your tents*
 Tomorrow, and it shall be *that*
 The man whom YHWH chooses *thereat*
Is the holy one. *You take* too
 Much on yourselves, you Levi's sons!"
 8 Then Moses said to Korah, "Hear
 Now, you sons of Levi *and fear*:
 9 "Is it a small thing here for you
 That God of Israel's benisons
 Have separated you among
 Israel's assembly *and unsung*
 To bring you near to Himself, to
 Do the work of the tent of YHWH,
 And to stand before the folk to
 Serve them, 10 "and that He has brought
 you
 Near *to Himself*, you and all your
 Brothers, the sons of Levi's *score*,
 With you? And do you seek also
 The priesthood? 11 "Therefore you all go
 In company *and* against YHWH
 Gathered together. And what *do*
 You complain against Aaron true?"

Beloved, note well that Korah makes
 appeal
 To priesthood of believers while the spiel
 Of Moses is to state that Korah's band
 Is also an elite, though lower strand,
 Being Levites below the priestly caste.
 It's always an elite set at half mast
 That defends democratic principles
 While fomenting rebellion in the woools.
 What smarts is that their elitist of parts
 Is lower than the priesthood in their hearts.

Self always seeks to return to You when
It wakens to plurality of men.
Let me not seek such lower levels of
Men's status, but bury in divine love.

12 And Moses sent to call Dathan
And Abiram Eliab's sons,
But they said "*Just forget it, man,*
We will not come up *off our buns!*
13 "*Is it a small thing that you've brought*
Us up out of a land that's fraught
With flowing milk and honey, just
To kill us in the desert dust,
That you should keep acting the prince
Over us? 14 "Moreover your stints
Have not brought us into a land
Flowing with milk and honey's *strand*,
Nor given us inheritance
Of fields and vineyards *where to dance*.
Will you put out eyes of these men?
We will not come up *to you then!*"
15 Then Moses was very angry,
And said to YHWH, "Do not be free
To respect their offering. I've not
Taken one donkey from their plot,
Nor have I hurt one of them here."
16 And Moses told Korah, "Appear
Tomorrow, you and every peer
Be present before YHWH, you and
They, as well Aaron *be on hand*.
17 "Let each take his censer and put
Incense in it, and each *on foot*
Bring his censer, come before YHWH,
Two hundred fifty censers' *cue*,
Both you and Aaron , every censer
To find out which of you's pretencer."
18 So every man took censer up,
Put fire in it, incense on *cup*,
And stood at the door of the tent
Of meeting, and with Moses went
Aaron. 19 And Korah gathered all
The congregation great and small
Against them at the door of tent
Of meeting. Then the glory sent
From YHWH appeared to all the folk.
20 To Moses and Aaron YHWH spoke,
Saying 21 "Remove you in one stroke
From among this assembly, that
I may consume them where they sat."
22 Then they fell on their faces, and
Said "O El El God *of command*,
The God of spirits of all flesh,

Shall one man sin, and You be fresh
In anger with all who're at hand?"

At first Moses was angry for a thing
That struck his honour, shot him in the
wing,
And then You Yourself, my Beloved, took
issue
With the same folk that simpered in their
tissue.
You were so angry even Moses had
To interfere. Beloved, are You so bad?
By the sweet faith we all cherish today
Moses' behaviour and Yours were a way
And out of line. Teach me to be less cross
Than You were with these people at a loss.
I understand Your feelings, though, when
men
Become religious leaders once again.
I wonder You don't once more blow Your
top,
Except that their vile deed will never stop.

23 So YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
24 "Speak to the congregation spread,
Saying 'Get away from the tents
Of Korah, Dathan, Abiram.'"
25 Then Moses arose and went hence
To *both* Dathan and Abiram,
And the elders of Israel came
After him. 26 And he spoke *in blame*
To the assembly, saying "Now
Depart from their tents, disavow
These wicked men! Touch nothing of
Theirs, lest you be consumed in shove
Of all their sins." 27 So they got out
From around the tents of *devout*
Korah, Dathan, Abiram, and
Dathan and Abiram did stand
At the door of their tents, with wives,
Their sons, and their little folks' lives.
28 And Moses said "By this you'll know
That YHWH has sent me on the go
To do all these works, for *I've not*
Done them of my own will *untaught*.
29 "If these men die a natural death
Like all men, or if they have breath
In common fate of all men, *then*
YHWH has not sent me, *but these men*.
30 "But if YHWH creates a new thing,
And the earth opens mouth to sting
And swallows them up with all that

Belongs to them, and they go flat
 Down alive into the pit, then
 You will understand that these men
 Have rejected YHWH." 31 It occurred,
 As he finished speaking this word,
 That the ground split apart for them,
 32 And the earth beneath opened hem
 And mouth and swallowed them all up,
 With their households, *plate, bowl and cup*,
 And all the men with Korah, and
 With all *their goods on every hand*.
 33 So they and all those with them went
 Down alive into the pit *bent*,
 The earth closed over them, and they
 Perished from the people *that day*.
 34 Then all Israel who *were* around
 Them fled at their cry *and the sound*,
 For they said "Lest the earth us too
 Swallow *alive for what we do!*"

I seek no claims to leadership above
 The ones that You've appointed in Your
 love,
 Nor do I seek the pageant of the way
 Of priestcraft or of Levite for my pay.
 Yet I too stand at my tent door and look
 Toward the opening of stone like book,
 And finding my reward plunging into
 The gate of earth in my longing for You.
 You are not far to find, nearer than breath,
 And yet a gasping longing beyond death.
 No moment is too brief not to reveal
 The pang that every soul and self must feel
 To return to Your face and there be blind
 For nothing more availing me to find.

35 And a fire came out from YHWH and
 Consumed two hundred fifty's band
 Who were offering incense. 36 Then
 YHWH
 Spoke to Moses, saying 37 "Tell *true*
 Eleazar, Aaron's son, priest,
 To pick up the censers released
 Out of the blaze, for they are holy,
 And scatter the fire somewhere lowly.
 38 "The censers of these men who sinned
 Against their own souls, let be binned
 And hammered into plates to cover
 The altar *whereupon I hover*.
 Because they gave them before YHWH,
 Therefore they are holy *and true*,
 And they shall be a sign unto

The children of Israel *to do*."
 39 So Eleazar the priest took
 The bronze censers, which every crook
 Who was burned up had presented,
 And they were hammered out *in grid*
 As altar covering, 40 *to be for*
 Memorial to Israel's store
 That no outsider, who *is* not
 A descendant of Aaron got,
 Should come near to offer incense
 Before YHWH, that in his defence
 He might not become like Korah
 And his companions, just as YHWH
 Had said to him through Moses' *law*.

Beloved, You turn the chalice of rebellion's
 wine
 To mirrors for reflecting soul as fine
 As was the fired desire that in them burned
 Until the prophet and commander spurned
 Their brave attempts to step into his place.
 Ostensibly rejection of the face
 Came from Your will. It's written in Your
 bill,
 And so it must have been Your sacred will.
 See here, I feign at least belief. My call
 Is generally against the righteous wall
 Of whomever wields censer and the
 sceptre,
 A single figure or two of the epter.
 I support Moses, since he's in the past,
 And is no longer ruler here to last.

41 On the next day all the folk of
 The children of Israel above
 Murmured against Moses and Aaron,
 Saying "You have killed the forbearing
 Of YHWH." 42 Now it happened again,
 When the assembly gathered then
 Against Moses and Aaron, they
 Turned toward the tent of meeting's way,
 And suddenly the cloud went out
 And covered it, and all about
 The glory of YHWH appeared there.
 43 Then Moses and Aaron came there
 Before the tent of meeting door.
 44 And YHWH spoke to Moses *before*,
 Saying 45 "Get away from among
 This congregation *and unsung*,
 So I'll consume them in a flash."
 And they fell on their faces *crash*.
 46 So Moses said to Aaron, "Take

A censer and put fire in wake
 From the altar, and put incense,
 And take it quickly to the tents
 Of the assembly there to make
 Atonement for them *and their sake*,
 For wrath has gone out from YHWH and
 The plague has begun *in the band*."
 47 Then Aaron took *it* by command
 Of Moses, and then ran into
 The midst of the assembly due,
 And already the plague began
 Among the people *to a man*.
 So he put in the incense and
 Made atonement for the folk's band.
 48 And he stood there between the dead
 And the living, stopped the plague's stead.
 49 Now those who died in the plague were
 Fourteen thousand *and to infer*
 Seven hundred more, and beside
 Those who in Korah's event died.
 50 So Aaron returned to Moses
 At door of meeting edifice,
 For the plague had stopped *before this*.

Who would support the underdog are cast
 Away in all the plagues from first to last.
 Nothing has changed, and those who win
 are those

Who write not only history but morceaux
 Of revelation. Beloved, where's the book
 Of Your revealing to the ones who took
 The battering of the rulers in the land.
 Even Moses himself beneath the hand
 Of princess of Egypt was not exempt
 From the elite despite a shepherd kempt.
 The small ones always interpose to say
 The prophet killed Your own one
 treacherous day.

Does certainty come with the plague and
 crown?

Beloved, I go to meet You on the town.

Numbers 17

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 2 "Speak to Israel's children *and bred*,
 And get from them a rod from each
 Father's house, all their leaders reach
 According to their fathers' lines,
 Twelve rods. Write each man's name
designs
 On his rod. 3 "And you shall write Aaron's
 Name on the rod of Levi's share-ins.

For there shall be one rod for *each*
 Head of *each* father's house *to reach*.
 4 "Then you shall place them in the tent
 Of meeting where the covenant
 Is placed and where I meet with you.
 5 "And it shall be the rod *will do*
 Of the man whom I choose will blossom,
 Thus I will rid Myself *and toss them*,
 Of the complaints of Israel's folk,
 Which they made against you *and spoke*."
 6 So Moses spoke to Israel's folk,
 And each of their leaders gave him
 A rod apiece, *tackle and trim*,
 For each leader according to
 Their fathers' houses, *not a few*,
 Twelve rods, and the rod of Aaron
 Was among their rods *for the fun*.
 7 And Moses placed the rods before
 YHWH in the tent of witness' *store*.

In one night almond withe might come to
 bloom

If it were set in water and warm room.
 Perhaps Aaron has carefully prepared
 The way by choosing a rod he's well cared.
 The powerful propose the toast and say
 What they propose is in the divine way.
 If Korah's friends might choose the test I
 trow

That Korah's friends might win the rate
 somehow.

There is no sure and certain proof that You
 Have chosen and picked one among the
 few.

Beloved, a doubting Thomas I look on
 The evening preparations for the dawn.
 The only certainty is that You are
 Among these constellations greatest star.

8 Now it happened on the next day
 That Moses went into the way
 Of the tent of witness, indeed,
 The rod of Aaron, of the seed
 Of Levi, had sprouted and put
 Forth buds, had produced blossoms' *foot*
 And yielded ripe almonds *at last*.
 9 Then Moses brought out *to the mast*
 All the rods from before YHWH to
 All the children of Israel's view,
 And they looked, and each man took his
 Rod. 10 And YHWH said to Moses' *quiz*,
 "Bring Aaron's rod back, place before

The testimony, kept in store
 As a sign against the revolt
 Of rebels, that you may *unbolt*
 Their complaints from Me, lest they die."
 11 Thus did Moses, just by YHWH's cry
 Commanding him, and so he did.
 12 So the children of Israel *hid*
 And spoke to Moses, saying "Surely
 We die, we perish, perish *poorly!*
 13 "Whoever even comes near by
 Tabernacle of YHWH must die.
 Then shall we all utterly die?"

The promise was the rod should blossom
 there.
 If only blossoms had appeared from air,
 I might have found excuse. Beloved, not
 fair!
 You force the thing and leave no room for
 doubt,
 My favourite word, and my excuse to pout.
 But You grow more than blossom, leaf and
 bud.
 You set ripe almonds on the rod and stud
 It with all four things at one hour in time.
 I do not blame the people for their mime
 And plaint to perish. Even with some glue,
 Where would they get the wherewithal to
 do,
 If sleight of hand were in the trick and
 clue?
 Beloved, I rebel not against Your popes,
 Your gurus, mullahs, fakirs with their
 ropes.

Numbers 18

1 And so YHWH said to Aaron, "You
 And your sons and your father's due
 With you shall bear iniquity
Related to sanctuary,
 And you and your sons with you shall
 Bear iniquity *destinal*
With your priesthood. 2 "And also bring
 With you your brothers of the swing
 Of Levi, the tribe of your father,
 That they may be joined with you *rather*
 And serve you while you and your sons
Are with you before witness runs
 Of tabernacle. 3 "They'll attend
 To your needs and all the needs *denuded*
 In tabernacle, but they shall
 Not come near any article

Of sanctuary and the altar,
 Lest they die, and you also *falter*.
 4 "They shall be joined with you, attend
 To the needs of the meeting tent,
 For all the work of the tent bend,
 But outsider shall not be sent
 Near you. 5 "And you shall attend to
 The duties of the holy true
 And duties of the altar, that
 There *may* be no more wrath *that sat*
 On Israel's folk. 6 "Indeed, Myself
 I have taken your brothers out,
 The Levites and from *off the shelf*
 Among Israel's folk *without doubt*,
They are a gift to you, given by
 YHWH, to do the work *without sigh*
 Of the tent of the meeting place.
 7 "Therefore you and your sons *of race*
 With you shall attend to your place
 Of priesthood for each thing to be
 At the altar, behind *the tee*
Of the veil, and you all shall serve.
 I give your priesthood *not to swerve*,
 As a gift for service, but each
 Outsider who comes near *to preach*
 Shall be put to death *for his breach*."

The priesthood's not so great a thing to gain
 It seems since the priest does not serve in
 vain
 But bears the sin of every one who comes
 To tent of witness where to lay his sums.
 The concept of both purity and soiled
 Is foreign to the church where I have toiled,
 But is the thing that separates both men
 And women from the beasts and birds
 again,
 Unless raccoon and friends know to the
 price
 Of washing things to last and make them
 nice.
 Without the knowledge of clean and
 unclean,
 No understandings found on Scripture
 scene.
 They search in vain for meaning and are
 lost
 Who think it's all about morals and bossed.

8 And YHWH spoke to Aaron "Here, I
 Myself have also given you hie
 Of My heave offerings, all the gifts

Of holiness that Israel lifts,
 I've given them to you as a portion
 And to your sons *without extortion*,
 And as continuing ordinance.
 9 "This shall be yours in holy stance
Reserved out of the holocaust:
 Every offering of theirs *not lost*,
 Every grain offering and each sin
 Offering, trespass offering brought in
 To Me, *shall be* most holy for
 You and your sons *forevermore*.
 10 "In a most holy *place* you'll eat,
 Each male shall eat *it for a treat*.
 It shall be holy to you, *meet*.
 11 "This also *is* yours: *from the heave*
 Offering of their gift, with all *leave*
 The wave offerings of Israel's folk,
 I've given them to you *to convoke*,
 And your sons and daughters with you,
 As ordinance forever *true*.
 Everyone who is clean in your
 House may eat it, *but not before*.
 12 "All the best of the oil, the best
 Of the new grape juice and *the rest*,
 The grain, their firstfruits which they offer
 To YHWH, to you I've given and proffer.
 13 "Whatever first ripe fruit is in
 Their land, which they bring to the bin
 Of YHWH, shall be yours. Everyone
 Who is clean in your house has won
 A portion of it. 14 "Each devoted
 Thing in Israel is yours *promoted*.
 15 "Everything that first opens womb
 Of all flesh, which they bring to room
 Of YHWH, whether man or beast, shall
 Be yours, but the firstborn *and pal*
 Of man you shall surely redeem,
 And the firstborn of beasts *that seem*
 Unclean you shall redeem. 16 "And those
 Redeemed of the devoted things
 You shall redeem *upon the strings*
 When one month old, according to
 Your valuation, for five *true*
 Shekels of silver, according
 To the shekel of *resorting*
 To the temple, twenty *gerahs*.
 17 "But the firstborn *by all the laws*
 Of a cow, the firstborn of sheep,
 Or the firstborn of goat *to keep*
 You shall not redeem, *they are holy*.
 You shall sprinkle of their blood lowly
 Upon the altar, burn their fat

As an offering made where they're at
 By fire for a sweet scent to YHWH.
 18 "And their flesh shall revert to you,
 Just as the wave breast and the right
 Thigh are yours. 19 "All the *ones in sight*
Of the heave offerings, holy things,
 Which the folk of Israel brings
 To offer to YHWH, I've given you
 And your sons and daughters with you
 As ordinance forever *true*,
 It's covenant of salt forever
 Before YHWH with you *not to sever*
 And your descendants with you *too*."

The Canaanite was sure the world would
 fail
 Without the burnt offering of every male
 Who was first from the womb in birth.
 The first son was offered to gods in worth,
 And such an offering saved the world from
 woe.
 It's worth one soul to achieve such a show.
 No way to set aside such a torment
 By saying You accept no human spent
 For blood. No, You, Beloved, were wiser
 far
 In saying humans are like ass for star,
 And being unclean of their sort could not
 Be sacrificed like sheep and goat in cot.
 For their uncleanness You redeemed the lot
 And let no Canaanite come near the plot.

20 Then YHWH said to Aaron, "You shall
 Have no inheritance *banal*
 In their land, nor shall you have any
 Portion among them, *not a penny*,
 I *am* your portion, heritage
 Among Israel's folk *age to age*.
 21 "Indeed, I've given to Levi's folk
 All the tithes *that* in Israel *spoke*
 As inheritance in return
 For the work they perform *and burn*,
 The tent of meeting's work *not spurn*.
 22 "Hereafter Israel's folk shall not
 Come near the tent of meeting plot
 Lest they bear sin and die *on spot*.
 23 "But the Levites shall do the work
 Of tent of meeting *and not shirk*,
 And they shall bear iniquity,
 Statute forever, through the sea
 Of generations, that among
 Children of Israel *they unsung*

Shall have no heritage at all.

24 "For tithes of Israel's folk, though small,
Which they offer up *as* a heave
Offering to YHWH, I've given leave
To the Levites as heritage,
Therefore I've said to them in gauge,
'Among Israel's folk they shall have
No heritage *in stall to calve*.'"

25 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said

26 "Speak thus to the Levites *well bred*,
And say to them, 'When you take from
The folk of Israel the tithes' sum
Which I have given you from them
As your inheritance *and hem*,
Then you shall offer up a heave
Offering of it to YHWH, receive
A tenth of the tithe. 27 'And your heave
Offering shall be reckoned to you
As though *it were* the grain of *true*
Threshing floor and as fullness of
The winepress. 28 'Thus you shall *in glove*
Also offer heave offering to
YHWH from all your tithes, those which
you

Receive from Israel's folk, and you
Shall give heave offering of YHWH from
It to Aaron the priest *to come*.

29 'Of all your gifts you'll offer up
Every heave offering due *in cup*
To YHWH, from all the best of them,
The consecrated part of them.'

30 "Therefore you shall say to them, 'When
You've lifted up the best from men,
Then *the rest* shall accounted be
To the Levites as produce *free*
Of threshing floor and as produce
Of the winepress *and for its use*.

31 'You may eat it in any place,
You and your households *in your race*,
For it *is* your reward for your
Work in the tent of meeting door.

32 'And you shall bear no sin for it,
When you've lifted the best of it.
But you shall not profane the holy
Gifts of Israel, lest you die *lowly*.'"

The priest in ancient time, and Aaron's son
Had no inheritance of farm when done,
But landless had to eat the charity
Of Israel's tithes and offerings given in fee.
You were, Beloved, their portion and their
right

Who slaughtered sacrifice morning and
night.

I too come with my living body's gift
To bring in sacrifice, heave offering lift
To Your name in remembrance of the light.
As such a priest I have nor do desire
The acreages of the court and squire,
Nor houses rising up before my sight.
Beloved, be You my portion also here,
As I am Yours in what I do appear.

Week 39 Numbers 19

1 Now YHWH spoke to Moses and Aaron,
Saying 2 "This ordinance *to swear on*
Of the law which YHWH has commanded,
Saying 'Speak where Israel's folk landed,
That they bring you red heifer *that*
Is without blemish, in which *bat*
There's no defect *and* on which yoke
Has never come. 3 'You shall give it
To Eleazar the priest *fit*,
That he may take it out the camp,
And it shall be slaughtered *for stamp*
Before him, 4 'and Eleazar, priest,
Shall take some of its blood *at least*
With his finger, and sprinkle some
Of its blood seven times *in sum*
Directly in front of the tent
Of meeting. 5 'Then the heifer spent
Shall be burned in his sight: its hide,
Its flesh, its blood, offal *beside*
Shall be burned. 6 'And the priest shall take
Cedar wood and hyssop *to make*,
And scarlet, and cast *them* into
The midst of the fire burning *due*
The heifer. 7 'Then the priest shall wash
His clothes, shall bathe in water *slosh*,
And afterward he'll come into
The camp, the priest shall be unto
Evening unclean. 8 'And the one who
Burns it shall wash his clothes in water,
Bathe in water, *after the slaughter*,
And be unclean till evening *come*.
9 'Then a man *who is clean in sum*
Shall gather up the ashes of
The heifer, and store *them above*
Outside the camp in a clean place,
And they shall be kept for a race
Of all the congregation of
The children of Israel for water
Of purification, *this slaughter*
Is for purifying from sin.

10 'And the one who gathers *in bin*
The ashes of the heifer shall
Wash his clothes, and hygienical
Be unclean until evening come.
It shall be a statute to plumb
The ages unto Israel's folk
And to the stranger *and the bloke*
Who dwells among them *to provoke*.

No one has found, perhaps, red heifer now
That has not borne in vain the brandished
plough.

So ashes lack to make the purity,
No holy water is found here in fee.
We seek in vain the cleansing flood this
time,
And bow reluctantly beneath the rhyme.
The preacher and the pope in this fair day
Is so far from purifications' way
They see no problem in the defiled sway
Of impure spirit raising anthems' pay,
So long as love and feeling love abounds.
We proceed all about the temple grounds.
Beloved, I flee to You from ashes and
Ashless waters of false faith on each hand.

11 'He who touches the dead body
Of anyone unclean shall be
For seven days. 12 'He'll purify
Himself with water *on the sly*
On the third day and then upon
The seventh day, *then he at dawn*
Will be clean. But if he does not
Purify himself on the third
Day and on the seventh day wrought,
He will not be clean *of the turd*.
13 'Whoever touches the body
Of anyone who's died *for free*,
And does not purify himself,
Defiles the tabernacle *shelf*
Of YHWH. That person shall be cut
Off from Israel, *no and or but*.
He'll be unclean, because the water
Of purification *and slaughter*
Was not sprinkled on him, and his
Uncleanness *is* still on his *biz*.
14 'This *is* the law when a man dies
In a tent: all who *answering cries*
Come in the tent and all who *are*
In the tent shall be unclean *far*
As seven days, 15 'and every bowl
That's open, without cover *roll*

Fastened on it, *is* unclean *too*.
16 'Whoever in the open *dew*
Field touches one who's slain by sword
Or who has died, or bone *abhorred*
Of a man, or a grave, shall be
Unclean for seven days, *then free*.
17 'And for an unclean *person* they
Shall take some of the ashes *grey*
Of the heifer burnt for cleansing
From sin, and running water *spring*
Shall be put on them in a bowl.
18 'A clean person shall take *the whole*
Hyssop and dip *it* in the water,
Sprinkle *it* on the tent *that caught her*,
On all the vessels, on the folk
Who were there, or on one to stroke
Above, the slain, the dead, or grave.
19 'The clean *person* shall *so behave*
To sprinkle the unclean on third
Day and on seventh day *deferred*,
And on the seventh day he shall
Purify himself *corporal*,
Wash his clothes, and in water bathe,
And at eve he'll be clean *as wraith*.
20 'But the man who is unclean and
Does not purify him *by hand*,
That person shall be cut off from
Among the congregation's sum,
Because he has defiled the *tent*
Of sanctuary for YHWH *meant*.
The purifying water has
Not been sprinkled on him, so as
He *is* unclean. 21 'It shall be thus
Perpetual statute *and fuss*
For them. He who sprinkles the spring
Of purifying water's thing
Shall wash his clothes, and he who touches
The purifying water's clutches
Shall be unclean till evening come.
22 'Whatever the unclean *in sum*
Touches shall be unclean, the one
Who touches *it is* unclean *done*
Until the setting of the sun."

In ancient days perhaps there were unclean
And clean to segregate by the tent screen.
But now there are just unclean in the pen
And cleanness is a thing that misses men.
None look to You, Beloved, but dervish
dog,
Unclean by Your creation and incog.
The unclean dervish dog lifts up a voice

To bay Your holy name, Your name of
 choice,
 And in that baying cannot help but lay
 A curse upon the pomp of churchly pray.
 I do not curse in hate but merely in
 The unclean way I sing against its sin
 As I recite the syllables of law
 Once chanted by Yourself in Sinai's awe.

Numbers 20

1 The children of Israel, the whole
 Assembly, came *body and soul*
 Into the Wilderness of Zin
 In the first month, *to take a spin*
 The people stayed in Kadesh, and
 Miriam died there and *in that land*
 Was buried. 2 Now there was no water
 For the assembly, *son or daughter*,
 So they gathered together there
 Against Moses and Aaron's *care*.
 3 The people contended and spoke
 With Moses, saying "If the stroke
 Had only killed us when our brothers
 Died before YHWH *and their own*
mothers!

4 "Why have you brought up the assembly
 Of YHWH into this desert *trembly*,
 That we and our animals should
 Die here? 5 "And why have you seen good
 To make us come out of *the land*
Of Egypt, to bring evil *hand*
 Upon us in this place *we stand?*
 It's not a place of grain or figs
 Or vines or pomegranates, nor *swigs*
Of any water here to drink."

6 So Moses and Aaron *to think*
 Went from the presence of the folk
 To the door of the meeting tent,
 And they fell down *as by a stroke*
 On their faces. YHWH's glory went
 Before them. 7 And then YHWH spoke to
 Moses, saying 8 "Take the rod, you
 And your brother Aaron gather
 The congregation together.
 Speak to the rock before their eyes,
 And it will yield water *supplies*,
 Thus you shall bring water for them
 Out of the rock, *ad hominem*
 Give drink both to the congregation
 And to their animals *a ration."*
 9 So Moses took the rod from there
 Before YHWH by His command's care.

10 And Moses and Aaron gathered
 The assembly *to hear the word*
 Together *there* before the rock,
 And he said to them, "Hear, take stock,
 You rebels! Must we bring water
 For you out of this rock *and stir?"*
 11 Then Moses lifted his hand and
 Struck the rock twice *against command*,
 With his rod, and water came out
 Abundantly, and *with a shout*
 The congregation and their beasts
All drank the water as in feasts.
 12 Then YHWH spoke to Moses and
 Aaron,
 "Because you did not in faith share on
 Me, to hallow Me in the eyes
 Of Israel's folk, *but to despise*,
 Therefore you shall not bring this folk
 Into the land of which I spoke.
 13 This was water of Meribah,
 Because Israel's folk *without awe*
 Contended with YHWH, and He was
 Hallowed in them *for what He does*.

Beloved, You do not seem to realize
 What it was like to lose a mother wise
 In Israel when Miriam died, how hot
 The desert wind felt, like a boiling pot
 Gone dry, and all the disappointments of
 Rebellions quelched, consequent loss of
 love,
 And thirst. You do not seem to know at all
 What it was like to be pushed to the wall,
 Or You would have had patience with the
 pair
 That struck the rock, and with the people's
 share.
 Is situation no excuse for what
 Men do in their illusions, cloistered, shut
 From seeing the light of reality?
 Beloved, judge once more between Me and
 me.

14 Now Moses sent messengers from
 Kadesh to the king of Edom.
 "Thus says your brother Israel,
 'Of all our hardships you know well,
 15 'How our fathers went to Egypt,
 And we lived in Egypt *slave clipped*
 A long time, and Egyptians did
 Afflict us and our fathers' *bid*.
 16 'When we cried out to YHWH, He heard

Our voice and sent Angel *preferred*
 And brought us up out of Egypt,
 Now here we are *to where we've slipped*
 In Kadesh, a city upon
 The edge of your border *toward dawn*.
 17 'Please let us pass through your country.
 We will not pass through *any free*
 Fields or vineyards, nor will we drink
 Water from wells, we'll only slink
 Along the king's highway, we will
 Not turn aside to the right *hill*
 Nor to the left side either till
 We have passed through your *sacred hill*."
 18 Then Edom said to him, "You shall
 Not pass through my *land prodigal*,
 Lest I come out to *fight with* you
 With the sword." 19 So Israel's folk said
 To him, "We'll go by highway led,
 And if I or my livestock drink
 Any of your water *from sink*,
 Then I will pay for it, let me
 Only pass through on foot for free."
 20 Then he said "You shall not pass
 through."
 So Edom came to fight them too
 With many men and a strong hand.
 21 Thus Edom refused through his land
 To give Israel the right of way,
 So Israel from him turned away.

Who fly from Egypt and slavery to right
 Of kings and civilized and welcome night
 To wander in the desert and alone
 Under Your care without the cherished
 bone
 Of faint idolatry must meet the cast
 Of hate from even brother in the blast.
 Who fly from raucous wail and heathen
 dance
 To bow before the still small voice's lance
 Must also face the arrow of the strong
 In favour of the beating drums of wrong.
 Beloved, I turn from Egypt and the leek
 And mind my steps with Moses, a man
 meek,
 And trip at Esau's punishment's blockade.
 In You alone my foot and mind are stayed.

22 Then the folk of Israel, the whole
 Assembly, journeyed from *the toll*
Of Kadesh and came to Mount Hor.
 23 And YHWH spoke to Moses *before*

And Aaron in Mount Hor beside
 The border of Edom's land's *ride*,
 Saying 24 "Aaron shall be gathered
 To his people *and be interred*,
 For he shall not enter the land
 Which I have given *by mighty hand*
 To the children of Israel,
 Since you did at my word rebel
 There one time at Meribah's well.
 25 "Take Aaron and Eleazar
 His son, and bring them up to *star*
On Mount Hor, 26 "and strip Aaron of
 His garments and put them on *love*
 Eleazar his son, for Aaron
 Shall be gathered *to folk*, die thereon."
 27 So Moses did just as YHWH said,
 And they went up to Mount Hor *led*
 In all the congregation's sight.
 28 Moses stripped Aaron of his *right*
And garments and put them upon
 Eleazar his son, Aaron
 Died there on the top of the mount.
 Then Moses came down from the mount
 With Eleazar. 29 Now when all
 The congregation saw that Aaron
 Was dead, all Israel's house took care on
 To mourn full thirty days for Aaron .

My poor rebellious soul that strikes the
 rock
 Before the people dazed with sinful shock
 Climbs up the mountain one more time to
 see
 The clouds open into infinity.
 I let the prophet take my breastplate off
 My weary shoulders' hangings, and the
 scroff
 Of sinewed neck taut in the sun and heat
 Bows in submission at the prophet's feet.
 The little deaths of breath and silently
 Remembering Your names are hardly fee
 Preparing for the grand death when it
 comes.
 At that moment at last I know its sums.
 Beloved, I leave my jewels to another,
 As I return to dust and the earth mother.

Numbers 21

1 The king of Arad, Canaanite,
 Who lived in the south *out of sight*,
 Heard that Israel was coming on
 The road to Atharim *at dawn*,

Then he fought against Israel and
Took *some* of them prisoners *in hand*.
2 So Israel made a vow to YHWH,
And said "If You will be so true
To deliver this folk into
My hand, then I will utterly
Destroy *then* their every city."
3 And YHWH listened to Israel's voice
And delivered up *to their choice*
The Canaanites, and they destroyed
Them utterly and *so enjoyed*
Destroying their every city.
So the name of that place was called
Hormah for what happened appalled.
4 Then they journeyed from Mount Hor by
The way of the Red Sea, to try
To go around the land of Edom,
And the soul of folk *seeking freedom*
Became discouraged on the way.
5 And so the people spoke again
Against Alohim and in vain
Against Moses, "Why have you brought
Us up out of Egypt *unsought*
To die *here* in the wilderness?
For *there is* no food *here to bless*
And no water, and our soul loathes
This worthless bread *in manna's clothes*."
6 So YHWH sent fiery serpents there
Among the people, and *with care*
They bit the folk, and many died
Of Israel's people *on the side*.
7 Therefore the people came and said
To Moses, "We have sinned, been led
To speak against YHWH and you too,
Pray to YHWH that He take away
The serpents from us *in the way*."
So Moses prayed for the folk. 8 Then
YHWH said to Moses *for the men*,
"Make fiery *serpent*, and set it
On a pole, and *there it shall sit*
So everyone who's bitten, when
He looks at it, shall live *again*."
9 So Moses made a bronze serpent,
And put it on a pole *of tent*,
And so it was, if a serpent
Had bitten anyone, when he
Turned to the bronze serpent to see,
He lived, *healed, well and comfortably*.

I wonder if it was exactly wise
To put a brazen serpent before eyes
Of people tempted by idolatry.

Beloved, you made a mistake as I see.
After that day the folk was ready to
Bow down to every image of a few.
As time went on Messiah spoke a word
About the lifted serpent that occurred,
And since that time sweet Christians have
 blurred
The difference, Beloved, twixt him and
You.
The serpent in the way could bite a heel
To make a body sick and die for real.
The image on the pole by bare contrast
Could kill the soul with idol worship fast.

Wait, O Beloved, I would not sing like him
Who refused to bow before Adam's hymn.
Your oneness and divinity reach me
By way of reason and by way I see
Of Your command. The heathen choose to
 take
Truth for their own benighted wisdom's
 sake.
Prostration for Iblis in reason's light
Is for You, my Beloved, alone in sight.
Instead I set aside the god I make
Of You and turn away from Satan's rake.
I prostrate not from reason in the pay
Of my own wisdom granted on a day,
But in obedience to Your command.
And so I bow to brass beneath Your hand.

10 The folk of Israel now moved on
And camped in Oboth *until dawn*.
11 And they journeyed from Oboth and
Camped at Ije Abarim's *stand*,
In the desert before Moab,
Toward the sunrise *at a stab*.
12 From there they removed and
 encamped,
In valley of Zered *they tramped*.
13 From there they removed and encamped
On the other side of Arnon,
In the wilderness that goes on
From border of the Amorites,
For Arnon's Moab's border *rights*,
Between Moab and Amorites.
14 Therefore it is said in the Book
Of the Wars of YHWH *if you look*,
"Waheb in Suphah, where are brooks
Of the Arnon, 15 and slope of brooks
That reaches to dwelling of Ar,
And lies on Moab's border far."

16 From there *they went* to Beer, the well
 Where YHWH said to Moses *a spell*,
 "Gather the folk together, I
 Shall give them water *by and by*."
 17 Then Israel sang this song "Ali
Exalted one's a well to see!"
 All of you sing to him *freely*.
 18 The well the leaders sank, dug by
 The nation's *best* nobles, and by
 The lawgiver, and with their staves.
 And from the wilderness *and graves*,
They go to Mattanah, 19 and from
 Mattanah to Nahaliel *come*,
 From Nahaliel to Bamoth,
 20 And from Bamoth, the valley's *growth*
 That *is* in Moab's land, to top
 Of Pisgah which looks down to stop
 Upon the wasteland's *behemoth*.

The well of Kauthar, my Beloved, is soon
 Exposed to Paradise, its trees and boon.
 The nobles of the nation dug in search
 Of it from desert palm to northern birch,
 The leaders sank it deep to find their worth,
 And Moses, long before dear Ali's birth,
 Sang in the Law the praises due to him
 That You appointed from the desert rim
 Of Ghadir. So the people sang in omen
 And prophecy so loud and clear that no
 man
 Could gainsay guidance set by God alone
 And sure as carved, engraved in granite
 stone.
 I sing this song, O my Beloved, to You:
 Ali exalted is a well and true.

21 And Israel sent messengers to
 Sihon king of Amorites' *due*,
 Saying 22 "Let me pass through your land.
 We will not turn aside *to stand*
 In fields or vineyards, we'll not drink
 Water from wells, and we shall think
 To go by the king's highway till
 We've passed through your land *at our*
will."
 23 But Sihon would not allow that
 Israel should pass through his land's *fat*.
 So Sihon gathered all his folk
 Together and went in *one stroke*
 Against Israel in wilderness,
 And came to Jahaz in *full dress*
 And fought against Israel's *address*.

24 But Israel defeated him
 With the mouth of the sword *and grim*,
 And took possession of his land
 From the Arnon to Jabbok's *strand*,
 As far as the folk of Ammon,
 For on Ammon's border was drawn
 Fortifications' *paragon*.
 25 So Israel took all these cities,
 And Israel lived there *as they please*
 In all the Amorite cities,
 In Heshbon and its boundaries.
 26 For Heshbon was the city of
 Sihon king of Amorites' *love*,
 Who had fought against former king
 Of Moab, and taken in string
 All his land from his hand as far
 As *the brooks of the Arnon are*.
 27 Therefore those who speak in proverbs
 Say "Come to Heshbon *and suburbs*,
 Let it be built, let Sihon's city
 Be repaired, *and on it take pity*.
 28 "For fire went out from Heshbon and
 A flame from Sihon's city's *strand*,
 It consumed Ar of Moab and
 The lords of Arnon's heights *in band*.
 29 Woe to you, Moab! You have perished,
 O people that Chemosh *had cherished!*
 He's given his sons as fugitives,
 And daughters where the captive lives,
 To Sihon king of Amorites.
 30 "But we have shot at their *delights*,
 Heshbon's destroyed to Dibon's *way*.
 Then we laid waste *all Nophah's sway*,
 Which *reaches* to Medeba's *brae*."
 31 Thus Israel lived upon the land
 Of Amorites. 32 Then Moses manned
 Spies out to Jazer, and they took
 Its villages and drove out hook
 And halter all the Amorites
 Who *were* there *and lived on those sites*.
 33 And they turned and went up by way
 To Bashan. So Og king *that day*
 Of Bashan went out against them,
 He and all his folk *by the hem*,
 To battle at Edrei. 34 Then YHWH
 Said to Moses, "Do not fear him,
 For I have delivered his crew
 Into your hand, with all his *grim*
 People and his land, and you shall
 Do to him as you, prodigial,
 Did to Sihon Amorites' king,
 Who lived at Heshbon *by the spring*."

35 So they defeated him, his sons,
And all his people *by their tons*,
Until there was none left to him,
And took his land away from him.

If Ali is a well, he is also
Commander of the faithful armies' show.
Who sing of Ali and the blessed flow
Of Kauthar must sing also songs of war.
The enemy will always come before
Those who seek divine guidance on the
path.

Divine guidance arouses kingly wrath,
Republican as well if truth be told.
That's why Israel en route had to be bold.
Who slew Og king of Bashan lived to bear
Children to take his place in wear and tear,
And Bashan's fat cows in their luxury
Repeated sins of Ammon under tree.
Beloved, let me not live to have soul sold.

Numbers 22

1 Then the children of Israel moved,
And camped in the plains of *what proved*
To be Moab, on Jordan's banks
Across from Jericho in ranks.

Week 40

2 Now Balak the son of Zippor
Saw all Israel had done *and more*
Unto the Amorites. 3 And he
With Moab was exceedingly
Afraid of the people because
They *were many and with sharp claws*,
And Moab was sick with *their dread*
Because of Israel's folk ahead.
4 So Moab told the elders of
Midian, "Now this band's come to *shove*
And will lick up all around us,
As an ox licks up the field's grass."
And Balak the son of Zippor
Was king upon Moabites' shore
At that time. 5 So he sent runners
To Balaam the son of *the spurs*
Of Beor at Pethor, that's near
The land's river where sons appear
Of Ammon, to call him, saying
"Behold, a people's come *on wing*
From Egypt. See, they cover all
The face of the earth in *their sprawl*,
And are settling here next to me!
6 "Therefore please come at once and see

And curse this people for me, for
They *are* too mighty for my *shore*.
Perhaps I can gain their defeat
Drive them from the land in retreat,
For I know that he whom you bless
Is blessed, and he whom you *confess*
A curse is cursed." 7 So Moab's old
Ones and elders of Midian *bold*
Departed with diviner's fee
In hand, and they *in company*
Came to Balaam and spoke to him
The words of Balak, *king and grim*.
8 And he told them, "Lodge here tonight,
And I'll bring back word in your sight,
As YHWH speaks to me *of the right*."
So the princes of Moab stayed
With Balaam. 9 Alohim arrayed
Came to Balaam and said "Who *are*
These men with you, *come from afar*?"
10 So Balaam said to Alohim,
"Balak the son of Zippor's *dream*,
King of Moab, has sent to me,
Saying 11 'Look, a people's *gone free*
From Egypt, they cover the face
Of the earth. Come now *to this place*,
And curse them for me, perhaps I
Shall be able to overpower
Them and drive them out *in an hour*.'" 12 And Alohim told Balaam why,
"You shall not go with them, and you
Shall not curse the folk *on his cue*,
For they *are* blessed." 13 So Balaam rose
In the morning, *put on his clothes*,
And said to the princes of Balak,
"Go back to your land *and to Gaelic*,
For YHWH has refused to give me
Permission to go on your *spree*."
14 And the princes of Moab rose
And went to Balak to expose,
"Balaam refused to come with us
For what reason contrarious."

Beloved, the people make complaint that
You
Are always wordless when You're spoken
to
And silent partner when it comes to prayer.
Our feigned petitions rise on empty air.
It's not in callous disregard, it seems,
That You address the folk only in dreams
Of symbolized fate, unfragrant, radiant
views,

But rarely in well-spoken entre-nous.
 It's that You know beforehand by the plot
 That trust in human beings is a shot
 Into a cloudy night. What use to speak
 To Balaam, prophet, or the other weak
 In faith and sight? If there were really
 chance
 I'd listen, You would doubtless sing and
 dance.

15 Balak again sent princes, more
 Numerous and excelsior.
 16 And they came to Balaam and said
 To him, "Thus says Balak *our head*,
 The son of Zippor, 'Please let nought
 Hinder you from coming as sought,
 17 'For I'll certainly honour you
 Greatly, and I will do what you
 Say to me. Therefore please to come,
 Curse this folk for me *for the worse*.'"
 18 Then Balaam answered and said to
 The servants of Balak, "Though you
 Gave me his house full of ado
 In silver and gold, I could not
 Go beyond the word that YHWH's taught,
 My God, to do the less or more.
 19 "You also stay now please therefore,
 Here tonight, that I may know what
 More YHWH will say to me *in plot*."
 20 And Alohim came to Balaam
 At night and gave him cryptogram,
 "If the men come to call you, rise
And go with them, but don't despise
 The word which I speak to you, but
 That you shall do." 21 So Balaam got
 Up in the morning, saddled ass,
 Went with Moab's princes alas.

The gold and silver could not move the
 man
 To plot destruction, speak curses and plan
 The downfall of the righteous, but the hope
 Of honours from the reigning king and
 pope
 Moved him right well to hear Your word to
 go
 And make a spectacle of himself if not
 show.
 The wise raccoon and wily raven, crow
 Know that the sparkling trinket and its
 glow
 Is worth the taking, but all they are slow

To pocket pride, to rush to meet applause
 And raise a monarch's welcome to their
 claws.
 At least gold does not tarnish, while the
 straws
 Of kingly honour are an empty dream.
 Wake up, my soul and Balaam, to what
 seem.

22 Then Alohim's anger was roused
 Because he went *girt, clad and bloused*,
 And the Angel of YHWH took stand
 In the way as a foe in hand
 Against him. And he rode his ass,
 Two servants with him *in first class*.
 23 The donkey saw the Angel of
 YHWH standing in the way above
 And with his drawn sword in his hand,
 And the donkey turned countermand
 Out of the way and went into
 The field. Balaam struck ballyhoo
 The donkey for to turn her back
 Onto the road *and in the track*.

Beloved, let me not pray to you for sense
 Once You've given final word's ornaments.
 Let me not ask if image cannot hold
 A grace for me despite what You have told.
 Let me not ask if Sunday's just as good
 A day to observe when the Sabbath should
 Be clear enough from Decalogue and
 Script.
 Beloved, let me not return to Egypt
 And Babylon, because my lust would take
 The way of advertisement's public wake.
 You told the prophet what to do and why,
 And he answered with a rebellious sigh,
 And so You commanded a word to death.
 I need no grants from You beyond my
 breath.

24 Then the Angel of YHWH stood in
 A narrow path *as straight as sin*
 Between the vineyards, *with a wall*
 On this side and a wall *to fall*
 On that side. 25 And when the ass saw
 The Angel of YHWH, she *in awe*
 Pushed herself against the wall and
 Crushed Balaam's foot against the stand,
 So he struck her again *forsooth*.
 26 The Angel of YHWH went *in truth*
 Further, and stood in narrow place

Where there *was* no way to retrace
Either to the right hand or left.
27 And when the donkey saw the heft
Of the Angel of YHWH, she lay
Down under Balaam *in the way*,
So Balaam's anger was aroused,
And he struck the donkey entoused
With his staff. 28 Then YHWH opened
mouth

Of the donkey *from north to south*,
And she said to Balaam, "What have
I done to you *like Turk or Slav*,
That you have struck me these three
times?"

29 And Balaam told the ass in rhymes,
"Because you have abused me, I
Wish there were a sword in my try,
For now I'd kill you, you would die!"

30 So the donkey said to Balaam,
"Am I not your donkey, I am,
On which you've ridden, ever since
I became yours, till this day's *wince*?
Was I ever disposed to do
This to you?" And he said "No, true."

31 Then YHWH opened up Balaam's eyes,
And he saw YHWH's Angel arise
To stand in the way with his sword
Drawn in his hand, and he *was floored*
And bowed his head, fell flat on face.

32 And the Angel of YHWH *in grace*
Said to him, "Why've you struck your ass
These three times *in the rocky pass*?

Indeed, I have come out to stand
Against you, for *your way in hand*
Is perverse before me. 33 "The ass
Saw me and turned aside *to pass*
From me these three times. If she had
Not turned aside from me, *it's sad*,
Surely I'd also have killed you
By now, and let her live *and stew*."

34 Balaam said to Angel of YHWH,
"I've sinned, for I did not know you
Stood in the way against me. So
Therefore, if it displease You so,
I will turn back." 35 Angel of YHWH
Said to Balaam, "Go with the men,
But only word I speak to you,
That shall you *come to speak again*."
So Balaam went with Balak's princes,
Despite his ankle and his wincses.

Like Eve before the serpent in the park

Balaam was not surprised to hear the bark
Of donkey speaking human-sounding
tongue.

Beloved, no one takes note with due
surprise

Before what You create for human eyes.
Our vision's fastened on the lowest rung.
Not marvelling creation's wild affuse,
I and my fellows heap on it abuse
Born of impatience. Let me walk a while
Beneath the twitter of the angels' style
Of song and speech, until such words as
teach

Come to my ears and understanding's
reach.

Let me, if prophets are, be taught by ass
To admire sterling hays and purple grass.

36 Now when Balak heard that Balaam
Was coming, he *in oriflamme*
Went out to meet him at the city
Of Moab, which *is* on the *gritty*
Border at the Arnon, frontier
Of the country. 37 Then Balak said

To Balaam *in offended ear*,
"Did I not earnestly send to
You, calling urgently for you?
Why did you not come then to me?
Am I not able and greatly
To honour you?" 38 And Balaam said
To Balak, "Look, I've come to you!
Now, have I any power *when led*
To say anything *here* at all?

The word that Alohim *by call*
Puts in my mouth, that I must speak."

39 So Balaam went with Balak bleak,
And they came to Kirjath Huzoth.

40 Then Balak offered oxen *both*
And sheep, and he sent to Balaam
And to the princes in the scam.

41 So it was the next day, that *grim*
Balak took Balaam and brought him
Up to the high places of Baal,
That from there he might see the vale
Spread out with the folk before him.

Your prophet pretends that only Your word
Guides him on the road to avoid the turd.
I too suppose the Decalogue You spoke
Is rooted in my soul and like the oak.
Beloved, let me not love the yesterday

And think thereby I'm walking in Your way.

Let my choice of Your law and grace be done

Each morning once again beneath the sun.
Let me not follow every heathen run
Delusioned that I am Your right hand gun.
Who bows in Sabbath beauty may awake
To walk out on a Sunday for the sake
Of crass reward and honour at the stake.
Faith easily reduces to a pun.

Numbers 23

1 Then Balaam said to Balak, "Build
Seven altars for me here *filled*,
Prepare for me seven bulls and
Seven rams." 2 And *at the command*
Balak did just as Balaam spoke,
And Balak and Balaam *in yoke*
Offered on altars bulls and rams.
3 Then Balaam told Balak *for scams*,
"Stand by your burnt offering, and I
Will go, perhaps YHWH will come by
To meet me, and whatever He
Shows me I will tell you *freely*."
So he went to a lonely height.
4 And Alohim met Balaam's *sight*,
And he said to Him, "I've prepared
The seven altars, and I've aired
In offering on *each* altar bull
And ram." 5 Then YHWH put a word *full*
In Balaam's mouth, and said "Return
To Balak, and thus you shall *learn*
To speak." 6 So he returned to him,
And there he was, standing *and grim*
By his burnt offering, he and all
The princes of Moab *by call*.

I too seek oracle devout and neat
But circumambulation of my feet
In seven turns such as brought down the
walls,
In seven dips as Naaman's heart appals,
In seven sacrificial prostrations
As Prophet Elijah rejects and shuns
The very Baal that hears folk's benisons.
Without bull and without the fat of ram,
But in the humble faith of Abraham,
I turn to You, Beloved, and seven-fold
Make my praise and petition loud and bold
To echo and re-echo on the cold
Dark stones my inner chamber rises on,

Burnished silver and gold upon the dawn.

7 And he took up his oracle
And said *in oratorical*

"Balak the king of Moab's brought
Me from Aram, from *where he sought*
The mountains of the east. 'Come, curse
Jacob for me, and come *not worse*,
Denounce Israel!' 8 'How shall I curse
Whom El God has not cursed? And how
Shall I denounce *whom* YHWH has *now*
Not denounced? 9 For from the top of
The rocks I see him, and *above*
From the hills I look at him, there!
A lone people dwelling *in air*,
Not reckoning itself among
The nations. 10 'Who can count the *sung*
Dust of Jacob, or number one
Fourth of Israel *when counting's done*?
Let me die the death of the good,
And let my end be like his would!"

11 Then Balak said to Balaam, "What
Have you done me? I took you but
To curse my enemies, and look,
You've blessed *them* well as you *mistook!*"
12 So he answered and said "Must I
Not take heed to speak what YHWH's *cry*
Has put in my mouth *for the book*?"
13 Then Balak said to him, "Please come
With me to where you'll see them from,
But you shall see the outer part
Of them alone, and shall not start
To see them all, curse them for me
From there *throughout eternity*."
14 So he brought him *up* to the field
Of Zophim, to Pisgah's top *shield*,
And built *him* seven altars' *yield*,
And offered a bull and a ram
On *each* altar to *serve the scam*.

15 And he said to Balak, "Stand here
By your burnt offering *without fear*
While I meet *with YHWH* over there."
16 Then YHWH met Balaam, put a thing
In his mouth, and said "Go *and sing*
To Balak, and thus you shall speak."
17 So he came to him standing sleek
By his burnt offering, and the chiefs
Of Moab were with him *for fiefs*.
And Balak said to him, "What's YHWH
Spoken?" 18 Then he took up his *cue*
In oracle and said "Arise,
Balak, and hear, *do not despise!*

Listen to me, son of Zippor!
19 "El God *is* not a man, that He
Should lie, nor son of man before,
That He should repent. And has He
Said, and will He not do? Or does
He speak not to make good *His cause*?

Beloved, God is not man nor son of man,
Then Son of Man's not God, do what we
can.

Let son of man dressed in my flesh and
bone

To You, in love who are One God alone,
Turn and return from breath to breath to
seek

The sounding of Your name week upon
week.

Though I might lie and just as soon repent
Let me return to where the roses went,
Bathe in the pristine Truth that for Your
sake

The scintillating pools of Kauthar make.
Then being son of man I shall at last
Make all but You within me an outcast,
And rise from air to earth to eat the nut
Instead of grape and plum in forties cut.

20 Indeed, I've been told *now* to bless,
He has blessed, and I *must confess*
I cannot reverse *what He's said*.

21 "He has not found a sinful spread
In Jacob, nor has He seen sin
In Israel. YHWH is with him
A judge exalted, and the shout
Of a king's among them *about*.

22 El God brings them out of Egypt,
He has strength like a wild ox *ripped*.

23 "For no sorcery *can prevail*
Against Jacob, nor divination
Against Israel, *a righteous nation*.

It now must be said *without fail*
Of Jacob and of Israel,
'Oh, what has been wrought by God El!'

24 Behold, a people rises like
A lioness, and lifts to strike
Like a lion, it shall not lie
Down until it devours *well-nigh*
The prey, and drinks blood of the slain."

25 Then Balak spoke *and in this vein*
To Balaam, "Neither curse at all,
Nor bless them at all *from the wall!*"

26 So Balaam answered and said to

Balak, "Did I not say to you,
'All that YHWH speaks, that I must do?'"

27 Then Balak said to Balaam, "Please
Come, I'll take you *under the trees*
In that place, perhaps it will please
Alohim that you may curse there
For me the folk of Israel fair."

28 So Balak took Balaam up to
The top of Peor, that looks due
Across the desert *for his cue*.

29 Then Balaam said to Balak, "Build
For me here seven altars filled
For me with seven bulls and rams."

30 And Balak did by Balaam's scams
And offered a bull and a ram
On *every* altar *for Balaam*.

If at first I don't succeed often I
Follow my Taoist, quietist reply
To float with the stream as though it's Your
will.

Such laziness I find will fit the till.
Yet I might take a lesson from the monk
Who casts his spells again when lack of
spunk

Foils his attempts at cursing from the trunk.
Let me be as assiduous as he
Is in his cursing for a favoured fee
As I step out with blessings given free.
Both stepping out and blessing may be far
From what I would do with a single star,
But my Beloved, I sacrifice my floating
If You will lend an oar for greater boating.

Numbers 24

1 When Balaam saw that it pleased YHWH
To bless Israel, he did not do
As at the other times, to seek
To use magic *upon the peak*,
But turned toward the wilderness.

2 And Balaam raised his eyes *to bless*,
To see Israel encamped by tribe,
Spirit of Alohim imbibe.

3 Then he took up his oracle
And said "The utterance in full
Of Balaam the son of Beor,
The utterance of the man for
Whom eyes are opened, 4 utterance
Of him who hears the words *in trance*
Of El, who sees the vision of
The Almighty, who falls *in love*,
With eyes wide open: 5 'How lovely

Are your tents, O Jacob! *And free*
 Your dwellings, O Israel! 6 Ali
 Shall be like valleys that spread out,
 Like gardens by the riverside,
 Like aloes planted *without doubt*
 By YHWH, like cedars on the tide
 Of waters. 7 He shall pour out from
 His buckets waters, his seed *come*
Like many waters, his king shall
 Be higher than Agag's *cabal*,
 Exalted, his kingdom *stands fast*.
 8 From Egypt El brings him to last,
 He has strength like a wild ox, he
 Shall consume nations, enemy,
 He'll break their bones and pierce with
 arrow.
 9 He bows down *willing at the harrow*,
 He lies down as a lion, and
 As a lion, who'll make him stand?
 Blessed *is* the one who blesses you,
 And cursed *is* he who curses you."

When Balaam turned his sight from Israel
 To gaze out on the desert without well,
 You spoke through him in prophecy to tell
 The triumphs and the virtues of Ali.
 From Pisgah I too look out on the sea
 Of troubled nations gathered toward the
 flood
 Of the Euphrates, see the curse and blood,
 And yet beyond the dryness of men's fate,
 I see the luscious waters of the gate
 Of Kauthar and the hand that raises cup
 Filled to the brim, and still he holds it up.
 The lion crouches, and You bid me bless
 His name, and so I raise in righteousness
 Once more confession of his royal state.

10 Then Balak's anger was aroused
 Against Balaam *come in to browse*,
 He struck his hands together, and
 Balak told Balaam *on the strand*,
 "I called you *here* to curse my foes,
 And look, you bountifully disclose
 Blessings three times upon them *here*!
 11 "Now therefore, flee to your own bier.
 I said I'd greatly honour you,
 But truly you are kept by YHWH
 From honour." 12 So Balaam said to
 Balak, "Did I not also speak
 To your messengers sent to seek
 Me, saying 13 'If Balak should give

Me his house full of silver *sieve*
 And gold, I could not go beyond
 The word of YHWH, to *wave a wand*
 For good or bad of my own will.
 What YHWH says, that I must speak *still*?"

Beloved, how many are the righteous ones
 Who speak like Balak, when they hear my
 puns.
 They see my humble works and wares and
 say
 That You have kept all honour from my
 way.
 Such honour I do not require or relish,
 Methinks the praise smacks of born to be
 hellish.

I take the beauties of the heathen art
 Posing as worship with angelic part
 And hide them with the treasures of my
 heart,
 And yet know that the ranging crystal hall
 Filled with the light and sound of dancing
 ball
 Encrusts an empty splendour that is filled
 Only when You at last come to be billed.
 Beyond the choirs I lift a slender call.

14 "And now, indeed, I'm going to
 My people. Come, I'll apprise you
 Of what this folk will surely do
 To your folk in the latter days."
 15 So he took up his song of praise
 And said "Balaam son of Beor
 Gives utterance, and word before,
 A man whose eyes are open still,
 16 The utterance of him who will
 Hear the words of El God, and holds
 The knowledge the Most High enfolds,
Who sees the vision of Almighty,
Who falls down, with eyes open, sighty:

The further man removes from Your
 employ,
 Despite the sounds and visions to enjoy,
 The more remarkable phenomena
 Accompany his exercises' awe.
 With heart and mind untrue, the prophet
 gropes
 Toward the fulfilment of his vain hopes
 With trances and with falling down to hold
 Communion with You in splendour untold.
 Eye open and abiding light and gloom

He steadily marches towards his doom.
Beloved, let my heart be true to Your own
As I come without visions to Your throne
And hear only the silence there alone,
Eyes closed or open to my flesh and bone.

17 "I see him, but not now, I look
At him, but not near *like a book*,
A star shall come from Jacob and
A sceptre rise in Israel's hand
To batter and crush Moab's brow,
And destroy all the sons of row.

18 "And Edom shall be thing possessed
And Seir also, his foes confessed,
Shall be an heirloom taken while
Israel does valiantly *in style*.
19 Out of Jacob one shall possess
Dominion, and destroy the mess
Of the city." 20 Then he looked on
Amalek, and he took the drawn
Up oracle and said "The king
Amalek *was* first *one to sing*
Among the nations, but *shall be*
Last till he perish utterly."

21 Then he looked on the Kenites, and
He took up his oracle and
Said "Firm is your dwelling place, and
Your nest is set upon the rock,
22 Nevertheless Kain shall *in shock*
Be burned. How long until Asshur
Carries you away captive *cur?*"

23 He took his oracle and said
"Alas! Who shall live *and be led*
When El God does this? 24 But ships from
The coasts of Cyprus *when they come*
Shall afflict Asshur and afflict
Eber, and so shall *derelict*
Until he perishes *relict*."

25 So Balaam rose and went his way,
Returning to his place that day,
And Balak also went his way.

Beloved, the star in Jacob once came down
To bless with his presence Bethlehem's
town,
And Edom's ruler held the sceptre then
And came to slay many the sons of men.
Who curses must at Your command bring
blessing,
And while the kings draw back from their
confessing,
Your will is done at last in guidance met,

Ali and Jesus find a common set
In prophecies wrest from unwilling tongue
Of Balaam as he fails to reach the rung
Next set before the scaling of his foot.
Beloved, again I beg that You might put
A ship from Cyprus to bear greater news
That stars have turned to suns to burn the
pews.

Numbers 25

1 Now Israel stayed in *that place called*
Acacia Grove, and were enthralled
By harlotry with the females
Of Moab. 2 And they set their sails
To invite the people to share
In sacrifices of their *rare*
Gods, and the people ate and bowed
Down to their gods *in evil shroud*.
3 So Israel was joined to the Baal
Of Peor, and the wrathful *veil*
Of YHWH was roused against Israel.
4 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Take all
The leaders of the people, *call*
And hang offenders before YHWH,
Out in the sun, *beneath the dew*,
That the fiery anger of YHWH
May turn away from Israel."
5 Moses told Israel's judges well,
"Every one of you kill his men
Who were joined to Baal Peor's *den*."

The righteous knew that Balaam spoke for
You,
So when they saw him in the heathen pew
Of Baal Peor, they thought it the right
church,
Not knowing how he'd leave them in the
lurch.
There's no safety in following the lead
Of those known to be right in lofty creed
And stamped with the approval of Your
seed.

One has to add to doctrine righteous deed.
The doctrine of Baal Peor being God
Is the ecumenical way they trod,
Which false theology could only spout
A fornicating dance with heathen doubt.
Beloved, let me not open door and shout
A welcome to the passing crown and clout.

6 Behold, one of Israelite folk
Came and presented at a stroke

To his brothers a Midianite
 Woman before Moses in sight
 Of all the congregation of
 The children of Israel above,
 Who wept before meeting tent door.
 7 Now when Phinehas *heard the score*,
 The son of Eleazar, son
 Of Aaron the priest, saw *it done*,
 He rose among the congregation
 And took a javelin *for ration*
 In his hand, 8 and followed the man
 Of Israel into the tent *span*
 And thrust both of them through, the man
 Of Israel, and the woman through
 Her body. So the plague was through
 And stopped among Israelite folk.
 9 And those who died in the plague's stroke
 Were twenty-four thousand of bloke.

Preserve me, my Beloved, from the tv
 Evangelists who worship and have glee
 From making love to blasted trinity
 By day, and by night are the slaves to Pats,
 Marthas and Maries. Rare it is with cats
 That one son of a priest enters the door
 Of brothel to pin rabbits to the floor.
 Where was his mercy? He was not a
 preacher
 Of grace for goddess and the one to reach
 her.
 I'm truly in a rabid quandary:
 Each face reveals the oneness of Your plea,
 And yet he thrust a javelin to breach her
 And the guy she had brought to bow before
 The Baals and images at the church door.

Who says that righteous indignation will
 Suffice to justify the bitter pill,
 Committing violence against the hill
 Of wickedness, should stop to read the
 word
 Once more and hear what thing really
 occurred.

No one rose to attack the evil crowd
 Or even say a mocking word aloud
 Against idolatry and fornication,
 No one at all among the holy nation,
 Until You gave through Moses the
 command

To the officers to raise slaying hand.
 Outrage is not enough, nor appeal to
 Justice or law, none has the right that slew

Until commanded by Moses and You.

Week 41

10 Then YHWH spoke to Moses and said
 11 "Phinehas Eleazar's son *led*,
 The son of Aaron the priest's turned
 Back My wrath from Israel *that burned*,
 Since he was zealous with My zeal
 Among them, so I did not *feel*
Compelled to consume Israel's folk
 In My zeal *and before one stroke*.
 12 "Therefore say 'Indeed, I give him
 My covenant of peace *not dim*,
 13 'And it shall be to him and his
 Descendants after him which is
 Agreement of priesthood forever,
 Because he was zealous *to sever*
 For his Alohim, came to make
 Atonement for Israel's folk's sake."
 14 Now the name of the Israelite
 Who was killed with the Midianite
 Woman, *was* Zimri Salu's son,
 Leader in house of Simeon.
 15 And the Midianite woman's name
 Who was killed *to her people's shame*
Was Cozbi Zur's daughter, and he
Was head of Midianite family.

How many righteous ones in the good book
 Are passed by with a mention and a look
 But no name stated for posterity
 To cherish in a golden memory.
 Yet these two wretches are well stocked
 and labelled
 With genealogy and well enabled
 To last three thousand years in recitation.
 What use is my uttering contemplation?
 I sing again the lovely Hebrew words
 That join the twitterings of angel birds
 And wonder once again that You are there
 Behind the evil things that people share.
 Is there no sin so great before Your face
 That You cannot make of the thing a grace?

16 Then YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
 17 "Harass the Midianites *instead*,
 Attack them, 18 "for they harassed you
 With their schemes by seducing you
 In the matter of Peor and
 In the matter at Cozbi's hand,
 The daughter of Midianite chief,
 Their sister, who was killed *in grief*

In the day of the plague because
Of Peor *according to laws.*"

The theory of just war is taken from
The fact that You command the battle sum
In cases where aggressors would seduce
Your faithful with compromise and with
truce

To see behind each god and image One
Who is Creator of the stars and sun.
But theory of just war today is found
By the descendants of those who were
bound

To make an ecumenical club free
For every form of sweet idolatry.
The theory of just war requires the lot
To follow not Your words' commanding
plot,
But what seems in the interests of the
strong,
Who unite the crowds with a raucous song.

Numbers 26

1 And it happened, after the plague,
That YHWH spoke to Moses *not vague*
And Eleazar Aaron's son
The priest, saying *for census done*,
2 "Take a census of all the folk
In Israel's congregation's *stoke*
From twenty years old and above,
By their fathers' houses *and love*,
All able to go to the war
In Israel *to settle score.*"

3 Moses and Eleazar the priest
Spoke with them in the plains *released*
From Moab by the Jordan spread,
Across from Jericho, he said

4 "From twenty years old and on up,
Just as YHWH commanded *stirrup*
To Moses and Israel's folk who
Came out of Egypt's land in crew."

I'm thinking, my Beloved, about the guy
In Israel who was a bit too shy
To go to war for fear that Moses' word
Conflicted with the Decalogue preferred,
In which You say "Thou shalt not kill"
though stirred

By patriotic sentiments and rife
Hot feelings supporting religious life.
If Moses had the right to command arms
At Your command, do not the great alarms

That spur rightly or wrongly president
And congress override what any meant
In conscientious objection to war?
I doubt it. Men are too much trained to gore
To follow right for wrong now as before.

5 Reuben *was* firstborn of Israel.
The children of Reuben *to tell*
Were: of Hanoch, the family
Of Hanochites, *of Pallu*, the
Family of the Palluites,
6 *Of Hezron then*, the Hezronites,
Of Carmi, family of Carmites.
7 These *then are all* the families
Of Reubenites: those *by degrees*
Who were numbered of them *were bred*
Forty-three thousand seven hundred
And thirty. 8 The son of Pallu
Was Eliab. 9 The sons come through
Eliab *were* Nemuel, and
Dathan, and Abiram *to stand*.
These *are* Dathan and Abiram,
Representing the people's ham
Against Moses and Aaron in
The company of Korah's *sin*,
When they contended against YHWH,
10 And the earth opened its mouth lieu
And swallowed them up *all* together
With Korah when that group *in tether*
Died, and when the fire devoured two
Hundred and fifty men, and they
Became a sign. 11 And yet that day
Korah's children *God* did not slay.

Ah my Beloved! How glad I am to see
That You are gracious and full of mercy!
You promised to visit the evil of
The fathers on the children that they love
For generations three or four as such
Contenders to be better than You much
Declare in proof that You're less loving
than
They are themselves down to the final man.
But now I see that Korah's children felt
No touch of wrath upon them for the welt
Their father caused. The Decalogue takes
issue
With the thought that sinner's children are
fichu
Because their parents' sins cast on their
name
A shadow of reproach, punishment, shame.

12 The sons of Simeon according
 To their families *were affording*:
Of Nemuel, *all* the Nemuelites,
Of Jamin, of the Jaminites,
Of Jachin, of the Jachinites,
 13 *Of* Zerah, family of Zarhites,
Of Shaul, family of the Shaulites.
 14 These *are* families of Simeonites:
 Twenty-two thousand two hundred.
 15 The sons of Gad according bred
 In their families *were*: *of* Zephon,
 Family of Zephonites *upon*,
Of Haggi, family of Haggites,
Of Shuni, family of Shunites,
 16 *Of* Ozni, family of Oznites,
Of Eri, family of Erites,
 17 *Of* Arod, of the Arodites,
Of Areli, the Arelites.
 18 These *are* the families of the sons
 Of Gad according to the ones
 Who were numbered of them *in tons*:
 Forty thousand five hundred. 19 Sons
 Of Judah *were* Er and Onan,
 Er and Onan died *to a man*
 In the land of Canaan. 20 The sons
 Of Judah by their families were:
Of Shelah, the family *to stir*
Of Shelanites, *of* Perez, and
 The family at Parzites' command,
Of Zerah, family of Zarhites.
 21 And the sons of Perez *by rights*
 Were: *of* Hezron, the family
 Of the Hezronites, *and to be*
Of Hamul, of the Hamulites.
 22 These *are* the families *by rights*
 Of Judah by those who were bred
 Seventy-six thousand five hundred.

Er and Onan for dying in their sleep
 Missed out on Egypt and such things to
 weep
 As their more righteous kin went through to
 peep.
 You make a grace of punishment, I see,
 Beloved, who set life and knowledge in
 tree.
 Er and Onan are famous for exploit
 With wife or without, cunning and adroit,
 While what they really did and wanted is
 Forgotten in the titillation's fizz.

They wanted name and fame for them
 alone
 Instead of for their brother as a clone.
 Not sex but proud ambition rules the world,
 And iron hearts instead of hair well curled.
 And even saints are not exempt, but hurled.

23 The sons of Issachar by their
 Families *were*: *of* Tola, the share
 Of Tolaites, of Puah, all
 The family at Punites' call,
 24 *Of* Jashub, of the Jashubites,
Of Shimron, of the Shimronites.
 25 These *are* families of Issachar
 According to those who *in star*
 Were numbered of them: sixty-four
 Thousand three hundred *men of war*.

Four sons remind me of the four gates'
 share,
 Although their names do not lead
 anywhere.
 What interests me is that Tola for gate
 Of law is not forgotten in estate
 Of the next brother, who names his first son
 After the uncle. What had Tola done
 To deserve that display of lovingness?
 You do not say. A brother does confess
 To idolize his elder in the name
 He gives his son, and that son gives it fame.
 The offspring of the second gate gives
 praise
 To gate of law rather than changing ways.
 The gate of love gives birth to one to judge
 The people by the law and not by fudge.

26 The sons of Zebulon by their
 Families *were*: of Sered, the share
 Of Sardites, of Elon, family
 Of Elonites, at Jahleel's *see*,
 The family of Jahleelites' *tree*.
 27 These *are* the families that have come
 Of the Zebulonites in sum
 By those who were numbered of them:
 Sixty thousand five hundred *stem*.

Why did the father Zebulon give names
 So trusting and so positive of claims?
 Deliverance, strong oak, and wait on God:
 These were the names he gave when he
 was shod
 With refugee status in Palestine,

Before descending to Egyptian mine,
Before the rise of the Red Sea, before
The conquest of the promised earthly score.
Why did Zebulun see living such light
That nothing in the world seemed to be
plight?

He was his mother's youngest, smallest son.
His mother was the weak-eyed, hated one.
Where did his faithful constancy come
from
To bless You with family compendium?

28 The sons of Joseph according
To their families *in their ring*,
By Manasseh and Ephraim,
Were: 29 The sons of Manasseh's *rim*:

Of Machir, of the Machirites,
And Machir produced in his rights
Gilead, of Gilead, family

Of Gileadites. 30 These *are to see*
The sons of Gilead: *of Jeezer*,

The family of Jeezerites *stir*,

Of Helek, of the Helekites,

31 *Of* Asriel, the Asrielites,
Of Shechem, of the Shechemites,

32 *Of* Shemida, the family

Of Shemidaites, *of the see*

Of Hephher, *all* the family

Of Hephherites. 33 Zelophehad

Who was the son of Hephher had

No sons, but daughters, and the names

Of Zelophehad's daughter *dames*

Were Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, and

Milcah, and Tirzah *out of hand*.

34 These *are* families of Manasseh,

And those who were numbered that way
Fifty-two thousand seven hundred.

The culture of Your Scriptures seems to be
Confronted by a problem when we see
A man have only daughters to his glee.
The patriarchal wish and wash runs deep
So that even You Yourself hardly keep
A clear view of the fact that women can
Do everything that can be done by man
Where tool's not needed, except this one
thing.

She cannot grow a beard worthy of king.
Some peoples living also under eye
Divine contrive to let the women try.
The consequences are not dire at all.
If land go to son from father or fall

From mother to daughter, let not appal.

35 These *are* the sons of Ephraim *bred*
According to their families:

Of Shuthelah, the family's

Of Shuthalhites, of Becher comes

The family of Bachrites *in sums*,

Of Tahan, of the Tahanites.

36 And these *are all* Shuthelah's sons:

Of Eran, the family that runs

The Eranites. 37 These *are* families

Of Ephraim's sons by family trees:

Thirty-two thousand five hundred.

These *are* the sons of Joseph *bred*

According to their families' *stead*.

It's strange to see that Becher's a man free:

In Genesis the fellow seems to be

The son of Benjamin, but here it's clear

He is one come to Ephraim to cheer.

Perhaps this is a name more popular

Than any other common kind of star.

Abu Becher, whether one heaven-sent,

At least gives vent to fame's

aggrandizement.

Of late renown is Sheikh Becher a wonder

Who can move water without hand or

thunder

From full to empty jug by power of

Reciting Psalms of David and in love

Qur'an and Gospel out of sight and hand.

Beloved, bless such camels in every land.

38 The sons of Benjamin by their

Families were: of Bela, the share

Of Belaites, in Ashbel's *care*,

The family of the Ashbelites,

Of Ahiham, Ahihamites,

39 Of Shupham, *all* the Shuphamites,

Of Hupham, all the Huphamites.

40 And the sons of Bela were Ard

And Naaman: the family *starred*

Of the Ardites, of Naaman's *rights*,

The family of the Naamites.

41 These *are* the sons of Benjamin

According to their families' *bin*,

And those who were numbered *and fed*:

Forty-five thousand six hundred.

If Bela's such a lovely name, almost

Like You, Beloved, and yet its meaning's
boast

Is but destruction. Hidden from my view
 There is a darker side it seems to You.
 Destruction, yet, of all illusions' guile
 Comes from the vastly turnings of Your
 smile.
 My lowly self turns whirling from the
 flame
 That would destroy my hopes of flattering
 game,
 And with my turning I return to You.
 I flee in fear from Your destruction's due
 And in my fleeing find refuge again
 In that Rock which is comfort to all men,
 Beneath the shadow and the light brought
 bare
 Upon my self by Self found everywhere.

42 These *are* the sons of Dan by their
 Families: of Shuham *and his share*,
 The family of the Shuhamites.
 These *are* the families of Dan
 According to their families' *scan*.
 43 All the families of Shuhamites,
 According to those numbered *said*:
 Sixty-four thousand four hundred.

Hushim in Genesis, and Shuham here,
 How did haste and boil turn depressed with
 fear?
 The son of judgement, hastily when done
 Is often lost in regrets having won
 The battle without knowledge of the right.
 But judgement taught by You is always
 bright.
 Beloved, let judgement bear no fruit at all
 In my soul, though criteria may call
 Me to turn fast away from every bench
 Where sit in justice wiggled gentry and
 wench.
 Let me not judge in haste of any man
 And I shall leave judgement to You who
 can.
 Let Hushim and Shuham go on to bear
 The brunt of justice in the gate of air.

44 The sons of Asher according
 To their families *were in ring*:
 Of Jimna, family of Jimnites,
 Of Jesui, of the Jesuites,
 Of Beriah, the Beriites.
 45 Of the sons of Beriah: *first*
 Of Heber, *who was not the worst*

The family of the Heberites,
 Of Malchiel, Malchielites.
 46 And the name of Asher's daughter
Was Serah. 47 And these families *were*
 Of the sons of Asher by those
 Who were numbered *and whom God*
chose:
 Fifty-three thousand four hundred.
 48 The sons that Naphtali *had bred*:
 According to their families' *rights*:
 Of Jahzeel, family Jahzeelites,
 Of Guni, family of Gunites,
 49 Of Jezer, of the Jezerites,
 Of Shillem, of the Shillemites.
 50 These *are* Naphtali's families
 According to their family trees,
 And those who were numbered and bred,
 Forty-five thousand four hundred.
 51 These *are* those numbered of Israel:
 Six hundred and one thousand *spell*
 Seven hundred and thirty *tell*.

Of Jacob's twelve sons only one is said
 To have a daughter besides his sons bred.
 Serah, abundance, is in Asher's crew
 Perhaps the source of what gladness he
 knew.
 The blessed Asher is blessed since his
 crown
 Is garnished with a daughter's sweet
 renown.
 Beloved, Your Scriptures are filled with the
 means
 By which men have captured both sights
 and scenes,
 But through the lines the deeper jewels
 shine
 To show that daughters are a kinder wine.
 Let me be among Jacob's sons the last,
 The second son of Zilpa, who was cast
 To happiness because his daughter came
 To trace his name in Numbers by her fame.

52 Then YHWH spoke to Moses and said
 53 "To these *all* the land shall be spread
 As an inheritance, and by
 The number of the names *that lie*.
 54 "To a large *tribe* you shall give great
 Inheritance, and to its mate
 That's small you'll give a smaller rate.
 Each shall be given inheritance
 By their numbers *able to dance*.

55 "Let land be divided by lot,
 They'll inherit each in their plot
 According to their own tribe's name
 And by their fathers *and their fame*.
 56 "According to possession's lot
 Shall be divided to the great
 And to the smaller in estate."

The distribution of land You propose
 Smells more of communism than a rose.
 Do You not know, Beloved, democracy
 Demands that land be held by those who
 see

The greater sums of money in account,
 Rather than divided accordingly
 As use is needed and the mere amount
 Of mouths to feed? The theory is that those
 Who hoard wealth when they gain the land
 will give

Jobs to the poor and thus help them to live,
 Who're not able to run things on their own.
 I guess You're unfamiliar, on Your throne
 With democratic process. Beloved, You
 Are all the heritage I can accrue.

57 And these *are* those Levites counted
 According to their families' *bid*:
 Of Gershon, of the Gershonites,
 Of Kohath, of the Kohathites,
 Of Merari, the Merarites.

58 These *are* the families of Levites:
 The family of the Libnites,
 The family of the Hebronites,
 The family of the Mahlites,
 The family of the Mushites,
 And family of the Korathites.
 Kohath begat Amram *in life*.

59 And so the name of Amram's wife
 Was Jochebed, and Levi's daughter,
 Who was born beside Egypt's *water*
 To Levi, and to Amram she
 Bore Aaron and Moses to be
 Brothers to their sister *in glee*,
 To Miriam. 60 To Aaron were
 Born Nadab and Abihu, fer
 Eleazar and Ithamar.

61 And Nadab and Abihu died
 When they offered profane, *untried*
 Fire before YHWH. 62 Now those who
 were
 Numbered of them in number were
 Twenty-three thousand, every male

From a month old and above tale,
 For they were not numbered among
 The other folk of Israel *sung*,
 Because there was no heritage
 Given to them *from age to age*
 Among Israel's *farmer and sage*.

When Aaron named his sons, he did in
 hope.

Nadab in liberality to cope
 With brother Abihu, a counsellor
 Well able to suggest expedient score
 In dire contingency, as when the fire
 Might go out on the altar and conspire
 To find the best solutions then. No doubt
 Indeed Aaron with such names meant to
 flout

Egypt's sacred conventions, but the plan
 Did not take in consideration man
 Remaining in his character when times
 Change. None will relinquish his metred
 rhymes.

Beloved, I bear my hopes upon my breast
 To see them dissipate upon the quest.

63 These *are* those who were numbered by
 Moses and Eleazar's *try*,
 The priest he was who numbered them,
 Israel's folk in the plains *by hem*
 Of Moab by the Jordan, *near*
 To Jericho. 64 But in the steer
 Of those counted, there was not one
 Who was counted in counting done
 By Moses and the priest Aaron
 When they counted each Israel's son
 In the wilderness of Sinai.

65 For YHWH'd said of them, "They shall
 die
 Surely here in the wilderness."
 So there was not left man *to bless*
 Of them, except Caleb the son
 Of Jephunneh and Joshua one
 Who was *it seems* the son of Nun.

You carried out Your threat indeed, and yet
 The bearing out to doom is not such threat
 That time alone could not fulfil to letter.
 You could not find more willing an abettor.
 They would have died in time, Beloved, I
 throw
 If they had been faithful and righteous
 bough.

Both good and evil all alike run to
The grave whether in desert or in dew.
The miracle is not Your punishment
But that two had survived what You'd not
sent.

Though I may die in wilderness or plain,
I shall not find my life or death a gain
Or punishment, Beloved, instead I vie
Like Caleb to wonder beyond the sky.

Numbers 27

1 Zelophehad's daughters arrived,
He was Hephher's son *who'd survived*,
The son of Gilead, the son
Of Machir, who's the son of one
Manasseh, from the families of
Manasseh son of Joseph's *love*,
And these *were* the names of his daughters:
Mahlah, Noah (*not of the waters*),
Hoglah, Milcah, and Tirzah. 2 And
They stood before Moses *at hand*,
Before Eleazar the priest,
Before the leaders *great to least*
And all the congregation there,
By doorway of meeting tent *bare*,
Saying 3 "Our father died *at last*
In the desert, but he was cast
Not in the company of those
Who came together to oppose
YHWH, in company with Korah,
But he died in his own sin's *awe*,
Without sons. 4 "Why should father's name
Be removed from his family's *fame*
Because he had no son? Give us
Possession with our father's muss."

If You are just and have brought guidance
to
Your prophets and divine guides without
rue,
Then why does weak woman need to
entreat
For justice while the men get their free
meat?
Your law ought to remark and first of all
The ones likely to be betrayed by call
Of overriding, thoughtless creatures' fall.
Instead You make provision for female
Only when her clamours come to avail.
For shame, Beloved, politically correct
Is not I hope the weaker sex' neglect!
If You are just, and so by definition,

I question You to bring You to admission
That even women have rights and ambition.

5 So Moses brought their case before
YHWH. 6 And YHWH spoke to Moses'
store,

Saying 7 "Zelophehad's daughters
Speak *what is right, as it occurs*,
You shall surely give them *as heir*
Possession with their father's fare,
And cause the heritage of their
Father to pass into their care.

8 "And you shall speak to Israel's folk,
Saying 'If any man *or bloke*
Dies and has no son, then you shall
Cause his possession *nominal*
To pass to his daughter. 9 'If he
Has no daughter, then you'll in fee
Give his inheritance *in train*
To his brothers *who may remain*.
10 'If he has no brothers, then you
Shall give inheritance *that's due*
To his father's brothers. 11 'And if
His father has no brothers *stiff*,
Then you shall give inheritance
To his closest kin *in the dance*,
And he shall have it for his own.'"
And it shall be to Israel *sewn*
A statute of judgement, just this
As YHWH commanded to Moses.

Alright, You come through on the side of
justice
When pushed into the corner, come to trust
us.

And yet a woman has inheritance
If there are no brother to sing and dance.
A look at the Qur'an shows with good sense
You came to change Your mind, and no
pretence.

But even there the sister's share is half
That of her brother's, who was born to
laugh.

Beloved, the application of the wealth
In this world You created in Your stealth
Is never just, it seems to heart of man,
And if not man, at least to female clan.
In quandary I dedicate my prayer
To seeking justice, justice in the air.

Beloved, brotherless daughter in the Book

Was sent beforehand to judge whom
mistook
Divine law in desire to flay on hook
The Prophet's daughter, lovely Fatima.
The prophecy is there to see with awe.
Who refuses to see in divine law
The rights of orphaned Fatima will find
The punishment cast on injustice blind.
That is result of refusing to look
At what was written in a hidden nook
Of early revelation. I desire
To cantillate with all my ardent fire
Both Moses and Muhammad on the pyre.

12 Now YHWH said to Moses "Go up
Into this Mount Abarim's *cup*,
And see the land which I have given
To Israel's folk *for them to live in*.
13 "And when you've seen it, you also
Shall be gathered to your folk's tow,
As Aaron your brother before you.
14 "For in the Wilderness of Zin,
During the strife of people's sin,
You rebelled against what to floor you
I had commanded sanctifying
Me at the waters, *not defying*,
Before their eyes." These waters *are*
Of Meribah, at Kadesh' bar
In desert of Zin *under star*.

From Pisgah I too, my Beloved, survey
The heavenly heritage that will be mine
Once I have passed the strait and narrow
way
That death to self offers in golden wine.
I look upon a further shore and gate
Until I realize my harboured fate.
I need not live to find a new plateau,
I need not struggle to be on the go.
It is enough with feet upon the ground
That on the mountain peak my vision's
found
The way from You to You is shorter than
The distance between eyebrows on a man.
Beloved, I sink into the dark unknowing
Refreshed by every sip of my ingoing.

15 Then Moses spoke to YHWH and said
16 "Let YHWH, the God of spirits *led*
Of all flesh, set a man to rule
The congregation *from his stool*,
17 "Who may go out before them and

Go in before them *by command*,
Who may lead them out and bring in,
That YHWH's assembly may not sin
Like sheep without a shepherd *pin*."

Beloved, the prayer of Moses, peace on
him,
Illuminates a world of kings and dim.
There is a man whose rule is sent by You,
And only he can lead the good and true.
Without his guidance all men are like sheep
And gone astray, yet in their dark hearts
keep
Illusion that all ways lead up to heaven.
Yet all ways, seventy, forty, twelve or
seven,
All ways that lead, lead outward from the
park
And end outside infinities of dark.
The guidance sent from You leads to no
place
Since all men must stand here before Your
face.
The search of rule and church is all in vain,
Since Self by self is found in sun and rain.

18 And YHWH said to Moses "Take one
Joshua *who's* the son of Nun
With you, a man in whom's the spirit,
And lay your hand on him *or near it*,
19 "Set him before Eleazar
The priest and before every star
Of the assembly *where you are*,
And ordain him in all their sight.
20 "And you shall give *some* of your right
Of power to him, that all the folk
Of Israel's children *to a bloke*
May be obedient *at his stroke*.
21 "He'll stand before Eleazar
The priest, who shall inquire *afar*
Before YHWH for him by judgement
Of the Urim. At his word *sent*
They shall go out, and at his word
They shall come in *though they be stirred*,
He and all Israel's folk with him,
All the assembly, *stock and trim*."
22 So Moses did as YHWH commanded.
He took Joshua, set him *banded*
Before Eleazar the priest
And before every man and beast.
23 And he laid his hands on him and
Ordained him, just like YHWH's command

By Moses and by Moses' hand.

There's too much laying on of hands, I
 throw,
With all the elegant priests anyhow
That lead the world into the broad way of
Warfare in justice' name, and war in love
Of order and good will to those who feel
The same quivers of elation and zeal.
Lay hands not suddenly on me, I fear
That I too am too quick to take up gear
And go out if not at the lead at least
Among the regiments in gory feast.
The one to lead to battle must be taught
By You himself, or else be one that's
 caught
In the illusions of doing the right
When he goes to the battle and the fight.

Numbers 28

1 Now YHWH spoke to Moses and said
2 "Command the folk of Israel *led*,
And say to them, 'My offering,
My food for My offerings *to bring*
By fire as a sweet aroma
To Me, you shall take care in awe
To offer to Me at their time
Appointed.' 3 "And you'll say *in rhyme*
To them, 'This *is* the offering made
By fire which you shall offer *paid*
To YHWH: two male lambs in their first
Year without blemish, *not the worst*,
And day by day, as routine burnt
Offering. 4 'The one lamb *as you've learnt*
You shall offer at morning *light*,
The other lamb before the night.
5 'And one-tenth of ephah of fine
Flour as grain offering *without wine*
Mixed with one-fourth of hin of oil
Pressed *from the olive and with toil*.
6 'It is a routine offering burnt,
Ordained at Mount Sinai and *learnt*
For a sweet aroma, and made
An offering by fire to YHWH *paid*.
7 'And its drink offering *shall be* one
Fourth of a hin for each lamb *done*,
In a holy *place* you shall pour
Out the drink to YHWH as the *score*
Of offering. 8 'The other lamb you
Shall offer in the evening *too*,
As the morning grain offering and
Its drink offering *by My command*,

You shall offer *it* as an offering
Made by fire, to YHWH a sweet proffering.

Each day, and day by day, and morning
 light
I come to prostrate soul before the sight
Of Your throne heaved against the vasty
 sky
And worship Your face above where I lie.
Each night, and night by night, I come to
 spend
My empty offering of myself and lend
My flour and wine in radiance to Your
 hand
Upon the altar where You always stand.
Each night and day I take on tongue the
 sweet
Names of Your worth and give myself the
 treat.
Your offerings are for me no fasting though
I may not taste a nut or olive grow,
And yet, Beloved, the daily round reveals
The sips and breaths the nightly spirit
 steals.

9 'And on the Sabbath day two lambs
In their first year, without *the scams*
Of blemish, and two-tenths of fine
Flour as grain offering, mixed *to dine*
With oil, with its drink offering *done*,
10 'This *is* the burnt offering *that's spun*
For every Sabbath, and besides
The routine burnt offering *that hides*
With its drink offering *where it bides*.

The daily offerings sent abroad
 The incense of their prayer,
And let be known that Jacob's God
 Was sovereign everywhere.
The people took a double share
 Of Friday's bounteous feast,
And so the Sabbath offering's fare
 Was doubled and increased.
The centuries saw the Sabbath blessed
 And crowned with gold and Psalms
Until the temple spires were dressed
 In myrtle leaves and palms.
Richly arrayed she begged no alms,
 Our princess and our queen,
Perfumed in aloes and balms,
 She stood bright and serene.
But on a day when poverty

Struck down the temple bars,
 She dressed in ash and charity
 And slept beneath the stars.
 No offerings graced her tables' feast,
 No incense gathered high,
 The great had fallen to the least,
 And all the world passed by.
 On Sabbath mornings while the cool
 Still kissed Madina's street,
 The Prophet found the vestibule
 Of Quba's mosque was sweet.
 And there he laid a double prayer
 Each Sabbath, though his hands
 And feet were bare, his heart was there
 In offering on the sands.
 I also come with empty hands
 To greet the Sabbath queen
 And see her poverty and bands
 Against the libertine.
 And like the Prophet long ago,
 I long to bring my gift,
 Though I have nothing here to show,
 No sacrifice to lift.
 But like the Prophet at his prayer
 I doubly prostrate bow,
 The offering of the desert air
 To Sabbath's God somehow.

11 'On your months' first days you'll
 present
 A burnt offering to YHWH *and spent*:
 Two young bulls, one ram, seven lambs
 In their first year, without *the shams*
 Of blemish, 12 'three-tenths of fine flour
 As a grain offering, mixed *an hour*
 With oil, for each bull, two-tenths *more*
 Of fine flour as grain offering's *score*,
 And mixed with oil, for the one ram,
 13 'And one-tenth of fine flour *to slam*,
 And mixed with oil, as grain offering
 For each lamb, as burnt *in the ring*
 An offering of sweet scent, offering
 Made by fire to YHWH. 14 'Drink offering
 Shall be half a hin of grape juice
 For a bull, one-third *for its use*
 Of a hin for a ram, and one
 Fourth of a hin for a lamb *done*,
 This *is* the burnt offering for each
 Month throughout months of yearly reach.
 15 'Also one kid among the goats
 As a sin offering to YHWH *floats*
 To be offered, besides the one

Routine burnt offering *and when done*
 Its drink offering under the sun.

The first day of the month is just as hard
 To recognize as Sabbath day for bard.
 Some calculate a calendar to follow
 Approximately when the moon is hollow.
 Some sight the moon itself, and some
 contract
 With scientific instrument the fact.
 The calendar of Jubilees also
 Raises more questions than it makes me
 know.
 Yet I come to Your throne in fire and glow
 From day to week to month that You may
 show
 Me what my sacrifice for that day be
 Until I learn the way I ought to see.
 Beloved, the moon is large upon the lake,
 But You are much nearer and for my sake.

16 'When the first month's fourteenth day's
 come,
It is the Passover of YHWH.
 17 'And on the fifteenth day *in sum*
 Of this month *is* the feast to do
 Of yeastless bread eaten for days
 Numbered as seven in their ways.
 18 'On the first day *you'll have* a holy
 Assembly, you'll do no work lowly.
 19 'You shall present an offering made
 By fire as a burnt offering *paid*
 To YHWH: two young bulls, and one ram,
 And seven yearling lambs *from dam*.
 Be sure they are without blemish.
 20 'Their grain offering shall be *a dish*
 Of fine flour mixed with oil *I wish*:
 Three-tenths you shall offer for bull,
 And two-tenths for a ram *in full*,
 21 'You shall offer one-tenth for each
 Of the seven lambs, 22 'also one *peach*
 Of a goat *as* sin offering made
 As an atonement for you *paid*.
 23 'You shall offer these *there* besides
 The burnt offering *that always hides*
 In the morning, which *is* routine
 Burnt offering. 24 'In this manner *seen*
 You'll offer the food of offering
 Made by fire daily for *the ring*
 Of seven days, as a sweet scent
 To YHWH, it shall be offered, *spent*
 Besides the routine burnt offering

And its drink offering *where it went*.
25 'And on the seventh day you'll make
A holy convocation's *wake*.
You shall do no routine work *then*.

When out of Palestine some people take
Two days for the Passover if mistake
There be in days. One's sure to count at
least.
The same refuse to offer goat or other
beast,

Despite the fact it doesn't take a priest
Or temple to carry out proper feast,
As long as bread and biscuits all lack yeast.
The Copts follow the Jewish round to start
The year in Autumn, and so do their part
To keep the calendar ambiguous
As Scripture itself maintains counting fuss.
Beloved, I flee to You from cake and bread
Made of self-rising flour by which I'm fed,
And wait along the pasture to be led.

26 'Also on the firstfruits' day, when
You bring a new grain offering to
YHWH at your *Feast of Weeks*, then you
Shall have a holy convocation.
You'll do no daily work *in ration*.
27 'You shall present a burnt offering
As a sweet scent to YHWH *to bring*
Two young bulls, one ram, seven lambs
In their first year, 28 'and with their *drams*
Of grain offering of fine flour mixed
With oil: three-tenths for each bull *fixed*,
Two-tenths for the one ram, 29 'and one
Tenth for each of the seven lambs *done*,
30 'One kid of the goats, for to make
Atonement for you *and your sake*.
31 'Be sure they are without blemish.
You shall present *them* with their *dish*
Of drink offerings, besides routine
Burnt offering with grain offering *seen*.

Who point to offerings met in Christ for
blood
And say there's no remission without flood
Of crimson, like the heathen of old time
Who slaughtered son or daughter for a
dime
To make the crops grow or create success
On setting of the city gate's address,
Don't seem to notice that all is not red

With blood, but there is flour and oil
instead,
And sometimes, but not always, salt and
wine.
The bloody and the bloodless do combine.
Burn with the grain and fat, Beloved, my
heart
And self set out for You, and every part.
Atonement is complete when You are one
And there is no other beneath the sun.

Numbers 29

1 'And in the seventh month, upon
First of the month *perhaps at dawn*,
You'll have a holy convocation.
You'll do no customary *ration*
Of work. For you it is a day
Of blowing the trumpets. 2 'You'll offer
A burnt offering as a sweet proffer
To YHWH: one young bull, and one ram,
And seven head of yearling lamb,
Without blemish. 3 'Offering of grain
Shall be fine flour mixed with a *strain*
Of oil: of three-tenths for the bull,
Two-tenths for the ram, *and to pull*
4 'One-tenth for each of seven lambs,
5 'Also one kid of goatly *rams*
As a sin offering, for to make
Atonement for you *and your sake*,
6 'Besides the burnt offering with its
Grain offering for first day *that fits*
In the month, then the regular
Burnt offering with its grain offer,
And their drink offerings, by command,
As a sweet scent, offering in hand
Made by fire to YHWH *where He sits*.
7 'When the tenth of seventh month's come
You'll have holy concordium.
You shall afflict your souls and not
Do any work. 8 'You shall have brought
A burnt offering to YHWH *as* sweet
Scent: one young bull, one ram *for treat*,
And seven lambs in their first heat.
Be sure they are without blemish.
9 'Grain offering *of* fine flour *in dish*
Mixed with oil: three-tenths for the bull,
Two-tenths for the one ram *in full*,
10 'And one-tenth for each of the seven
Lambs, 11 'also one kid *under heaven*
Of the goats *as* a sin offering,
Besides the sin offering *to bring*
For atonement, the routine burnt

Offering with its grain offering *learnt*,
And all of their drink offerings *earn*t.

The trumpets blow for coming solemn day
Of fasting and viewing the soul's dark way,
For sacrifice, atonement and the slaughter
That sends the chosen out and without
water

Into the wilderness. In memory
Of Isaac on the mount Passover's free
And points to Christ in woeful prophecy.
In memory of Ishmael trumpets sound,
And point to future time and the dry ground
When Hussain and his own went out alone.
You have a sacrifice, Beloved, and now,
Whether the dead or living, on Your brow
The hope and hopelessness reflect the sun
And tide the moon until all life is one.

12 'On the seventh month's fifteenth day
You'll have a holy meeting day.

You shall do then no routine work,
And keep a feast *and not to shirk*
To YHWH *for all of seven days*.

13 'You shall present burnt offering's
praise,

An offering made by fire as sweet
Aroma to YHWH *for a treat*:
Thirteen young bulls, *and then* two rams,
And at last fourteen yearling lambs.
They shall be without blemish *too*.

14 'Their grain offering *in residue*
Shall be of fine flour mixed with oil:
Three-tenths for each *in the turmoil*
Of thirteen bulls, two-tenths for each
Of the two rams, 15 'and one-tenth's *reach*
For each of the fourteen lambs *there*,

16 'Also one kid of the goats *fair*
As a sin offering, besides those
Routine burnt offerings, *what it chose*
As its grain offering, and its drink

Offering. 17 'On the second day's *brink*
Bring twelve young bulls, two rams,
fourteen

Lambs in their first year without lien,
18 'And their grain offering and their drink
Offerings for the bulls, for the rams,
And for the lambs, their weights *in drams*,
According to the ordinance,
19 'And one kid of the goats *to dance*
As a sin offering, and beside
The routine burnt offering *to bide*

With its grain offering, and their drink
Offerings. 20 'And on the third day's *brink*
Eleven bulls, two rams, fourteen
Lambs in their first year without lien,
21 'And their grain offering and their drink
Offerings for the bulls, for the rams,
And for the lambs, by weight *in drams*,
According to the ordinance,
22 'And one *kid of the goats to dance*
As a sin offering, and beside
The routine burnt offering *to bide*,
Its grain offering, also its drink
Offering. 23 'And on the fourth day's *brink*
Bring ten bulls, two rams, *and* fourteen
Lambs in their first year, without lien,
24 'And their grain offering and their drink
Offerings for the bulls, for the rams,
And for the lambs, by weight *in drams*,
According to the ordinance,
25 'And one kid of the goats *to dance*
As a sin offering, *and* beside
The routine burnt offering *to bide*,
Its grain offering, also its drink
Offering. 26 'And on the fifth day's *brink*
Bring nine bulls, two rams, *and* fourteen
Lambs in their first year without lien,
27 'And their grain offering and their drink
Offerings for the bulls, for the rams,
And for the lambs, by weight *in drams*,
According to the ordinance,
28 'And one *kid of the goats to dance*
As a sin offering, *and* beside
The routine burnt offering *to bide*,
Its grain offering, also its drink
Offering. 29 'And on the sixth day's *brink*
Bring eight bulls, two rams, *and* fourteen
Lambs in their first year without lien,
30 'And their grain offering and their drink
Offerings for the bulls, for the rams,
And for the lambs, by weight *in drams*,
According to the ordinance,
31 'And one kid of the goats *to dance*
As a sin offering, and beside
The routine burnt offering *to bide*,
Its grain offering, also its drink
Offering. 32 'On the seventh day's *brink*
Bring seven bulls, two rams, *and* fourteen
Lambs in their first year without lien,
33 'And their grain offering and their drink
Offerings for the bulls, for the rams,
And for the lambs, by weight *in drams*,
According to the ordinance,

34 'And one *kid of the goats to dance*
 As a sin offering, and beside
 The routine burnt offering *to bide*,
 Its grain offering, also its drink
 Offering. 35 'And on the eighth day's *brink*
 You'll have a sacred assembly,
 Not work unnecessarily.

36 'You shall present a burnt offering,
 An offering made by fire *to cling*
 As a sweet scent to YHWH: one bull,
 One ram, and seven lambs in full,
 In their first year without blemish,

37 'And their grain offering *in its dish*
 And their drink offerings for the bull,
 For the ram, and for the lambs, by
 Their number *and to qualify*
 According to the ordinance,

38 'And one *kid of the goat to dance*
 As a sin offering, and beside
 The routine burnt offering *to bide*,
 Its grain offering, also its drink
 Offering. 39 'These things you'll come to
 sink

To YHWH at your appointed feasts
 Besides your vowed offerings *of beasts*
 And your freewill offerings, as your
 Burnt offerings and your grain *in store*
 For offerings, as your drink offerings
 And *also for* your peace offerings."

40 So Moses told to Israel's folk
 Everything, and just as YHWH spoke,
 Commanded Moses to invoke.

Each day of tabernacles sees the number
 Of bulls to sacrifice decrease to slumber
 On scintillating sparks towards the sky.
 The last feast of the year, I wonder why,
 Unless as festive days each going by
 Increase my knowing of the sacrifice
 I make of self to Self increasing price
 Means that the offerings of beast decrease
 As needless with my own ego's decease.
 The days swirl round and round with cakes
 and wine
 While visions of lush palms replace the
 pine
 And fir and birch about my cabin door.
 I whirl in ecstasy along the floor
 From worn and weathered wood to marble
 shore.

Numbers 30

1 Then Moses spoke to the tribes' heads
 Concerning Israel's folk *in spreads*,
 Saying "This *is* the thing which YHWH
 Has commanded for you to do.

Week 42

2 "If a man makes a vow to YHWH,
 Or swears an oath to bind him to
 Some agreement, he shall not break
 His word, he shall do for the sake
 Of all that proceeds from his mouth.

Let me make no vows of my self to You!
 What can my self imagined ever do?
 Instead let that Self that arises here
 In cantillation overcome my fear
 And make sweet vows of promises to clear
 The morning grey with crimson on a tear,
 While I-ness grows from dawn to full

bright day,
 And self like dew on lady's mantle stay
 Until their offerings of diamonds melt.
 I watch what disappearing morning felt.
 Let me make no vows here who am the
 breath
 Of fleeting morning and the single death
 Of bird cherry bloom before solstice run.
 Make vows Yourself, Beloved, above the
 sun.

3 "Or if a woman comes and voweth
 To YHWH, and binds *herself* by some
 Promise in father's house *to come*,
 While in her youth, 4 "and if he hears,
 Her father does, her vow *with fears*
 And the agreement by which she
 Has bound herself *in promise fee*,
 And her father just holds his tongue,
 Then all her vows shall stand *as sung*,
 And every promise with which she
 Has bound herself shall stand *in fee*.
 5 "But if her father overrules
 Her on the day he hears *her tools*,
 Then none of her vows in promise
 By which she's bound herself *amiss*
 Shall stand, and YHWH will release her,
 Since her father overruled her.

If a young girl stand up to make a vow
 And her father is silent at the how,
 Then the vow's binding. Some would have
 the thing

Pass that if father sells the girl on wing
And she's been cowed to silence, what he
makes

In contract on her part precedence takes
Over her will unstated. Shyness seems
To be excuse to overwhelm her dreams.
Curse every father, brother, husband who
Engages a maid without her word due.
Beloved, though I am shy before Your
throne

I speak to give my will to You alone.
Let no tradition false nor vain repair
To comparisons block the golden stair.

6 "If indeed she takes a husband,
While bound by her vows or *in hand*
By a rash utterance from lip
By which she bound herself *in grip*,

7 "And her husband hears *it*, and makes
No response to her *for his stakes*
On the day that he hears, then her
Vows shall stand *just as they occur*,
And her agreements by which she
Bound herself shall *all stand in fee*.

8 "But if her husband overrules
Her on the day he hears *the schools*,
He shall make void her vow which she
Took and what she said in decree
With her lips, and by which she bound
Herself, and YHWH will release her.

9 "Also any vow that occur
By a widow or one divorced
By which she's bound herself forced
Shall stand against her. 10 "If she vowed
In her husband's house *as allowed*,

Or bound herself by agreement
With an oath, 11 "and her husband lent
Ear to *it*, and made no response
To her not overturning wants,
Then all her vows shall stand, and all
Agreement by which she made call
Shall stand. 12 "But if her husband truly
Made them void on the day heard *duly*,
Then whatever proceeded from
Her lips concerning her vows' sum
Or concerning agreement binding
Her, it shall not stand *in her finding*,
Her husband has made them *all void*,
And YHWH will release her *employed*.

13 "Every vow and each binding oath
To afflict her soul, her man troth
May confirm it, or make it void.

14 "If her husband makes no response
To her as long as the day jaunts,
Then he confirms all her vows or
All the agreements made before,
He confirms them, because he made
No answer to her on parade
When he heard *them*. 15 "But if he does
Make them void after hearing buzz,
Then he *it is* shall bear her guilt."

16 These *are* the statutes *with their tilt*
Which YHWH commanded Moses, twixt
A man and his wife, and *unmixed*
Between a father and his daughter
In her youth when her father's got her.

If You were just, Beloved, I seem to think
A wife could void a husband's vow with
pink.

What a man swears to's just as foolish
crime

As what a woman thinks is worth a dime.
Let every spouse revoke the solemn vow,
And every mother her son's backward bow.
What human lips confess in fond intentions
Is never worth its doings or its mentions.
What's done is lowly, what is praised is
less,

Despite the human fondness to confess.
Make void my vows, Beloved, and play the
part

Of father and husband before I start.
My rash utterings give rein to desire
To whirl in sacrifice and then expire.

Numbers 31

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses and said

2 "Take vengeance on Midianites *bred*
For Israel's folk. Afterward you
Shall be gathered to your folk *true*."

3 So Moses spoke to the folk, saying
"Arm some of yourselves for the slaying,
And go against the Midianites
To take vengeance upon YHWH's *rights*
On Midian. 4 "A thousand from
Each tribe of all the tribes shall come,
And Israel you shall send to war."

5 There were recruited from before
Israel divisions one thousand
From tribe armed for war, twelve thousand
In all. 6 Then Moses sent them to
The war, one thousand from *each* tribe,
He sent them to the war to do

With Phinehas the son *and scribe*
Of Eleazar *reigning* priest,
With the holy things *at the least*
And signal trumpets in his hand
To go before and give command.

A just war it seems is a war that You,
Beloved, command to make the battle true.
Yet I doubt that the king that sets command
Today is acting by Your divine hand.
Perhaps I should doubt even prophet Moses
If I were among those armies he chose us.
Doubt, doubt the breaking of the Decalogue
Until revealing light dispel the fog!
Few doubt the right to kill the wakened foe
That spreads out on the plains in battle
show,

And just as few are ready for the slaughter
Of self through self's illusion on the water.
Who grasp mirages with tenacious grip
Still with impunity divine blood sip.

7 And they warred with the Midianites,
Just as YHWH commanded *by rights*
Moses, and they killed all the males.
8 They killed the kings of Midian,
The lofty kings of Midian,
With those who were killed in assaults,
Evi, Rekem, Zur, and Hur, and
Reba, the five kings that command
Midian. And Balaam the son
Of Beor they also had killed
With the sword *once they had begun.*
9 And Israel's children *battle-thrilled*
Took the women of Midian
Captive, with their children *by plan,*
And took as spoil all of their herds,
All their flocks, all their goods *and birds.*
10 All the cities they also burned
With fire all of the cities earned
Where they lived, and also their forts.
11 And they took all the spoil *of courts*
And all the booty, man and beast.
12 Then they brought the captives *to feast,*
The booty, and the spoil *along*
To Moses, Eleazar's *song,*
The priest, and to the congregation
Of the people of Israel's *nation,*
To encampment in Moab's plains
By the Jordan, *across the mains*
From Jericho in expectation.

The family of Moses' wife was caught
Between two camps of relatives who
fought,
And both found on each side the divine
word

Was graven for a prophet and heart stirred.
Nothing arouses the blood-spilling wail
Like true prophets turned back to meet the
veil

Succumbing to idolatry. The gale
Sweeps all before, but saves the first
female

That helped insinuate idolatry.
One follows honour, one the lust of gold,
Another finds a woman makes him bold,
But higher still I climb without my
knowing

That I depart from You in where I'm going
By showing pity to the weak and glowing.

13 And Moses along with the priest
Eleazar, all the *increased*
Leaders of the assembly, went
To meet them outside the camp's *tent.*
14 But Moses was wroth with the men
Who led the army, *once again*
With captains over thousands and
Captains over hundreds *in hand,*
Who'd come from the battle *command.*
15 And Moses said to them, "Have you
Kept all the women live *in crew?*
16 "Look, these *women* caused Israel's
sons,

Through the counsel of Balaam's cuns,
To trespass against YHWH in what
Happened in Peor *at the glut,*
And there occurred a plague among
YHWH's congregation, *and it stung.*
17 "Now therefore, kill you every male
Among the little ones *for sale,*
And kill every woman who's known
A man with intimacy *grown.*
18 "But keep alive for yourselves all
The young girls who've not known *the call.*
19 "And as for you, remain outside
The camp seven days *and to hide,*
Whoever has killed any thane,
And whoever has touched the slain,
Purify yourselves and those caught
On third day and on seventh *sought.*
20 "Purify every garment and
Everything made of leather *band,*

Every woven of goats' *hair*, and
Everything made of wood to *stand*."

Ach, three days outside camp, seven at
most
Serve to cleanse every soldier's winning
boast
Of having killed a pagan whore at hand.
A fie upon both wrath and on command.
And yet, Beloved, I seek indeed to kill
The shadow figures that weaken my will
To set aside all craven image still
And bow to You alone below the hill.
Let me stay three days in the forest damp
Or seven days walking around the camp,
But let me then be clean from every whiff
Of god concepts and carved, stony chuff.
I draw back from touching the gods I've
slain
And wash my woollen belt, wash not in
vain.

21 Then Eleazar the priest said
To the men of war who'd been led
Into the battle, "This command
Of the law which YHWH *by the hand*
Of Moses gave *you is for sin*:
22 "The gold, silver, bronze, iron, the tin,
And the lead only, 23 "everything
That can endure the fire *and sing*,
You shall put through the fire, and it
Shall be clean, purified and fit
With purifying water's *mit*.
But all that cannot last the fire
You'll put through water *and require*.
24 "And you shall wash your clothes upon
The seventh day, be clean *at dawn*,
And afterward you may come in
The camp once more *and without sin*."

Baptism of water and fire set free
The soldiers' from their false iniquity.
They've killed civilians by prophet's
command
And scattered idols' whoredoms from the
land,
And brought back for themselves and
brothers all
The precious things that idols can recall.
To set gold to the fire and silk to cold
Water's enough to purify the bold

From coveting the sculpted and the
wrought.
Beloved, cleanse me from every evil
thought
By water and by fire, and yet I still
Crave cleansing from the coveting and kill.
What cannot go through fire and what must
shrink
In water, set that thing upon the brink.

25 Now YHWH spoke to Moses and said
26 "Count up the plunder that was spread,
Of man and beast, you and the priest
Eleazar and *unpoliced*
Chief fathers of the congregation,
27 "And divide the plunder in *ration*,
In two parts, between those who took
Part in the war, who went to fight,
And all the congregation's *right*.
28 "And levy a tribute for YHWH
On the men of war who *in crew*
Went out to battle: one of each
Five hundred of the human *peach*,
The cattle, donkeys, and the sheep,
29 "Take from their half, and give *to keep*
To Eleazar the priest as
A heave donation that YHWH *has*.
30 "And from the half of Israel's folk
You'll take one of each fifty *spoke*,
Drawn from the human beings and
The cattle, and the donkeys, and
The sheep, from all the livestock, and
Give them to the Levites who keep
Charge of the tent of YHWH *and sweep*."
31 Moses and Eleazar priest
Did as YHWH commanded *at least*
To Moses. 32 The booty remaining
From the plunder, which the men *straining*
At war had taken, was *remaining*
At six hundred and seventy-five
Thousand sheep *all captured alive*,
33 And seventy-two thousand *head*
Of cattle, 34 sixty-one *instead*
Thousand of donkeys, 35 thirty-two
Thousand persons in all *the crew*,
Of women who had not known man.
36 And the half, the portion *in ban*
For those who had gone out to war,
Was in number three hundred *more*,
Thirty-seven thousand five hundred
Sheep, 37 and what is YHWH's tribute *fed*
Of the sheep was six hundred and

Seventy-five *and by command*.
 38 The cattle thirty-six thousand,
 Of which YHWH's tribute's seventy-two.
 39 The donkeys *were in thousands due*
 Thirty thousand five hundred *true*
 Of which in tribute were for YHWH
 Sixty-one. 40 The persons *involved*
Were sixteen thousand, which resolved
 To thirty-two persons for YHWH
 In tribute. 41 Moses gave the *whole*
 Tribute *which was* YHWH's offering *goal*
 To Eleazar the priest's holding,
 As YHWH told Moses *without scolding*.
 42 And from the half of Israel's folk,
 Which Moses divided *the stroke*
 From the men who fought, 43 now the half
 Belonging to *the rod and staff*
 Of the assembly was *in number*
 Three hundred thirty-seven of
 Thousands five hundred *as above*
 Of sheep *they'd taken to encumber*,
 44 Thirty-six thousand cattle, and
 45 Thirty thousand five hundred *hand*
Of donkeys, 46 and sixteen thousand
 Persons, 47 and from Israel's sons' half
 Moses took one of fifty's *staff*,
 Drawn from *both* man and beast, and gave
 Them to the Levites *to be slave*,
 Who kept charge of YHWH's tent, as
 YHWH
 Commanded Moses *what to do*.

I wonder if they baptized all the sheep
 And oxen and donkeys they took to keep,
 And all the virgin ladies and their daughters
 Who could not bear the fire, but went
 through waters?
 Suspicion covers every bit of booty
 That Moses and the Levites took in duty.
 Beloved, I come not to be critical,
 I do not question what You do or shall.
 It's just that mind grows numb beneath the
 skull
 Of donkeys braying till the senses dull.
 Since I am neither soldier nor a priest,
 I have no portion in the bounty's feast.
 While the great and the salaried take share,
 I wander a poor dervish, eating air.

48 The generals of the army,
 The captains of thousands *to see*
 And captains of hundreds, came near

To Moses, 49 and spoke in his ear,
 "Your servants have taken a count
 Of the men of war under mount,
 And not a man of us is missing.
 50 "Therefore we've brought an offering
kissing

For YHWH, what every man found of
 Ornaments of gold's *hoarded love*:
 Armlets and bracelets, signet rings
 Earrings and necklaces, *what sings*
 To make atonement for ourselves
 Before YHWH *and not before elves*."

51 So Moses and Eleazar
 The priest received the gold *by far*
 From them, and all the ornaments
 Fashioned *and engraved as presents*.
 52 And all the gold of the offering
 That they offered to YHWH, *to bring*
 From the captains of thousands and
 Captains of hundreds *at their hand*,
 Was sixteen thousand *and what's more*
 Seven hundred fifty shekels' *store*.

53 The men of war had taken spoil,
 Every man for himself *and toil*.

54 And Moses and Eleazar
 The priest received the gold *by far*
 From the captains of thousands and
 Of hundreds, and brought it *to stand*
 In the tent of meeting to be
 Memorial for them to see,
 Israel's folk before YHWH's *decree*.

Oh, dear, unselfish captains with their loads
 Of gold to share with prophet without
 modes!

What must be done with wealth brought to
 the town

To give to those in charge, those of
 renown?

Moses redeems his name and glorious
 crown

By posting all the profits in the tent
 To be memorial of where they went.
 Today I think the dividend would find
 A quicker route to lining the unblind.
 Faith set a precedent in desert bloom
 That ought to shine out to the brim of
 doom.

Beloved, rain blessings down on Moses'
 cast,
 And give him fame and family to last,

While pope and counsellor's procession
passed.

Numbers 32

1 Now the children of Reuben and
The children of Gad *in their band*
Had a very great herd of stock,
And when they saw the land *and rock*
Of Jazer and of Gilead,
That indeed the region's not bad
As place for livestock, 2 folk of Gad
And of Reuben came and spoke to
Moses, to Eleazar too,
The priest, and to the leaders of
The congregation *set above*,
Saying 3 "Ataroth, Dibon, and
Jazer, Nimrah, Heshbon *at hand*,
Elealeh, Shebam, Nebo, and
Beon, 4 "the country which YHWH spoiled
Before Israel's assembly *foiled*,
Is a land for livestock, and your
Servants have livestock *sent before*."
5 Therefore they said "If we have found
Favour in your sight, let this ground
Be given to your servants for
Possession. Do not take us over
The Jordan, *but leave us to clover*."
6 And Moses said to Gad's tribe and
To the children at Reuben's *hand*
"Shall your brothers go to war while
You sit here? 7 "Why will you beguile
The heart of Israel's folk from going
Into the land of YHWH's *own showing*
To give them? 8 "Thus your fathers did
When I sent them away *and hid*
From Kadesh Barnea to see
The land. 9 "For when they went to be
In the Valley of Eshcol and
Saw the land to disheartened stand
Beguiling Israel's children's heart,
So that they did not for *their part*
Go in the land which YHWH had given
Them, 10 "so YHWH's anger was
unshriven
Aroused that day, He swore an oath,
Saying 11 'Surely none of the *growth*
Of men who came up from Egypt,
From twenty years old to the crypt,
Shall see the land of which I swore
To Abraham, Isaac, *what's more*
To Jacob, because they have not
Wholly followed Me *as I taught*,

12 'Except Caleb the son born to
Jephunneh, the Kenizzite true,
And Joshua the son of Nun,
For they've wholly followed YHWH's *run*.'
13 "YHWH's anger was aroused upon
Israel, He made them wander on
In the desert for forty years,
Until the generation's *tears*
That had done evil in the sight
Of YHWH was gone, *passed from the light*.
14 "And look! You have risen instead
Of your fathers, a brood and bred
Of sinful men, to increase still
More the fierce anger of YHWH's *will*
Against Israel. 15 "For if you turn
Away from following Him *and spurn*,
He will once again leave them in
The desert, and you will begin
To destroy all these folks *for sin*."

If I had any petition to make
To Moses for myself or others' sake,
I think I would think twice or even thrice
About appearing without sacrifice.
A brood of vipers is a hard word and
A harsh accusing to hear where I stand.
But Moses is a prophet, let him speak.
Though he was wrong, that will not make
him weak.
Give me the patience to bear the harsh
word
Of accusation my behaviour's stirred
Against my true intention and my deed.
But at the same time, I'll not quench my
need
To curse the ones I see breaking Your law
Whatever may hide in their hearts and
claw.

16 Then they came near to him and said
"We will build sheepfolds here *instead*
For our livestock, and cities for
Our little ones, 17 "but we implore
To arm ourselves, ready *to go*
Before Israel's folk *to the show*
Until we've brought them to their place,
And our little ones will *have space*
To live here in the cities' forts
For fear of the land's folk and sports.
18 "We will not return to our homes
Until each one of them that roams
Of Israel's sons has received his

Inheritance *to sit and fizz.*

19 "For we will not inherit there
With them upon the other *share*
And side of Jordan and beyond,
Because our heritage has spawned
To us on this the eastern side
Of the Jordan *where we reside.*"

I'd have remarked on Moses' lack of tact.
But these men keep their temper and to
fact.

Yet stubbornly they refuse to depart
From the land that has captured every
heart.

Beloved, You leave the personality
Of every self in Self to guarantee
The splendours of creation in the act.
Some love the rolling hills, some desert
tract,
Some Jordan's plain, and some the flooding
Nile.

If prophet is not patient with the smile
A man bears for the glades of his own
share,

You, my Beloved, bend to meet with the
fair

That loves his land. There are such men as
I
Whose roots are in the caravan saray.

20 Then Moses said to them, "If you
Do this thing, if you will *be true*
To arm yourselves *here* before YHWH
For the war, 21 "and all your armed men
Cross over the Jordan *again*
Before YHWH until He has driven
Out His foes from *the land they live in*
Before Him, 22 "and the land's subdued
Before YHWH, then after *renewed*
You may return and be blameless
Before YHWH and Israel's *address*,
And this land shall be your possession
Before YHWH *and for your confession*.
23 "But if you do not do so, then
Take note, you've sinned against YHWH's
yen,

And know your sin will find you out.

24 "Build cities for your children *stout*,
And folds for your sheep, and do what
Has come from your mouths *not unshut.*"

Moses becomes amusing in his state,

And even on reflection must show hate
And cursing for the angels of the Lord
Who button on cuirass and flaming sword
To help a brother find his hall and field.
Moses simply cannot politely yield.
If, if, he cries and waves his hands around,
Maintaining his own prophecy and ground.
No wonder he could not awaken love
And loyalty but only murmured shove.
You support Moses in his quirks and rant
Because there is no other on the slant
To lead the people out of Egypt's cant.
The populace will follow shirt and pant.

25 And the children of Gad and those
Of Reuben spoke as Moses chose,
Saying "Your servants *here* will do
As my lord *Moses* tells them to.
26 "Our little ones, our wives, our flocks,
And all our livestock *in their walks*
Will be there in the cities of
Gilead, 27 "but your servants, love,
Will cross over with every man
Armed for war, *according to plan*,
Before YHWH to battle *and war*,
Just as my lord says *on that score.*"

They're dead, they're all dead those who
would rebel

Or even stand up to Moses in hell.
The living answer Moses' cursing spell
With "my lord Moses" and a bow and
scrape.

Whether the master wear a divine cape
Or one of his own fashioning and shape,
All alike demand subservience that's due
Position as chief of a crowd or few.
Subservience is required in the way,
But is a fault unless a man can sway
The right amount of greed and cruelty
And lust his peer group expects of the free.
Beloved, each crowd has personality
To which each must conform or lose the
day.

28 So Moses gave command about
Them to Eleazar the *stout*
Priest, and to Joshua the son
Of Nun, and to the chiefs *when done*,
The fathers of the tribes *of all*
The sons of Israel *by call*.

29 And Moses said to them, "If Gad

And Reuben's children are not sad
 To cross the Jordan *here* with you,
 And every man armed *with the crew*
 For battle *and war* before YHWH,
 And the land's subdued before you,
 Then you shall give to them the land
 Of Gilead for plot as planned.
 30 "But if they do not cross with you,
 And armed, they shall have plot and stew
 Among you there in Canaan's land."
 31 Then the children of Gad in band
 And the children of Reuben said
 In answer, "Just as YHWH has said
 To your servants, so we will do.
 32 "We'll cross over armed before YHWH
 Into the land of Canaan *true*,
 But the possession of our plot
Is with us on this side *as sought*
 Of the Jordan." 33 So Moses gave
 To the children of Gad *the wave*,
 To the children of Reuben, and
 To half of tribe Manasseh's band,
 The son of Joseph, the kingdom
 Of Sihon, Amorites' king's sum
 And the kingdom of Og the king
 Of Bashan, the land with its thing
 Of *strong* cities within its flanks,
 The cities with surrounding banks.
 34 And then the children of Gad built
 Dibon and Ataroth *with silt*
 And Aroer, 35 Atroth and Shopan
 And Jazer and Jogbehah's *land*,
 36 Beth Nimrah also Beth Haran,
 Fortified cities, and sheepfolds.
 37 And the children that Reuben holds
 Built Heshbon and Elealeh and
 Kirjathaim, 38 and Nebo and
 Baal Meon, *their* names being changed
 And Shibmah, and they gave *and ranged*
Other names to the cities which
 They built *other side of the ditch*.
 39 And the children of Machir son
 Of Manasseh went *on the run*
 To Gilead and took it, and
 Dispossessed the Amorites' band
 Who *were* in it. 40 So Moses gave
 Gilead to Machir *to save*
 The son of Manasseh, and he
 Lived in it *satisfied and free*.
 41 Also Jair son of Manasseh
 Went and took its small towns *in spe*,
 And called the *small towns* Havoth Jair.

42 Then Nobah went and took *as fair*
 Kenath and its villages *there*,
 And he called it Nobah *by name*,
 After his own name *and his fame*.

The cows, the cows of Bashan mark the
 plot.
 I too would love the cows in luscious spot,
 Their brown flecks glistening on the white
 along
 The paths they take through field and wood
 and song.
 No wonder Gad and Reuben thought that
 way,
 As well as half the tribe of Manasseh.
 The lowing of the mothers and the calves,
 The springing of the heifers, beats by
 halves
 The rocky ascent up from Jericho
 Toward Jerusalem and on the go.
 Beloved, Creator of the bulls and cows
 Of Bashan, look at shining horns and brows
 And tell me if Your heart does not rise up
 To sing and take to lip a joyous cup.

Week 43 Numbers 33

1 These *are* the journeys of the folk
 Of Israel, who went out *on stroke*
 Of Egypt's land by their armies
 At Moses' and Aaron's decrees.
 2 Moses recorded where they started
 Each time on journey they departed
 At the command of YHWH. And these
Are their journeys according to
 The places of departure's cue.
 3 They left from Rameses in the first
 Month, on the fifteenth day of first
 Month, on the day after Passover
 The children of Israel *stove her*,
 Went out with boldness in the sight
 Of all the Egyptians *alight*.
 4 For the Egyptians were engaged
 With burying all *their* firstborn,
 Whom YHWH had killed of them *with*
scorn.
 Also on their gods YHWH *enraged*
 Had executed judgements *gauged*.
 5 Then the children of Israel moved
 From Rameses and camped where it proved
 To be Succoth. 6 And they departed
 From Succoth and camped *not down-*
hearted

At Etham, which *is* on the edge
Of the wilderness *privilege*.

Beloved, to leave my slavery I must
Leave also home in the Egyptian dust.
From house and salary I am turned out
To live in simple shelters made of stout
Palm leaves or tents of skins. Nomadic
coast

Becomes my changing homeland and I
move

My succoth to Etham, from desert groove
To sea-bound shore. I flee my slavery
Of men and bosses to find I'm not free
From self until I give myself to Thee.
I turn from the Egyptian first-born gods
And follow in the tracks my donkey plods.
I make short shrift of the Egyptian wealth
I bring with me as I step out in stealth.

7 They moved from Etham and turned back
To Pi Hahiroth *at the slack*,
Which *is* eastward from Baal Zephon,
And they camped near Migdol *as drawn*.

8 They left from before Hahiroth
And passed through the midst *of the growth*
Of sea into the wilderness,
Went three days' journey's *for address*
In the wilderness of Etham,
And camped by Marah's *monogram*.

Beloved, they all accuse me with their
craft,
They looked with scorn at me and then they
laughed.

"Do not spoil life with bitterness, be gay,"
The preachers seeing my wounds had to
say.

It's lack of faith and fortitude, and worse,
It's lacking in maturity to curse.
But I say, my Beloved, that those who live
In Hahiroth's sweet meadows fail to give
Due distance between Egypt and their
souls,
And staying there must fail of all the goals.
For having passed Baal Zephon, lord of
dark,

And Migdol, fearsome tower in the park,
To settle for an hour in Marah's march,
I'm closer to the Promised Land and arch.

9 They moved from Marah and came to

Elim, and at Elim *did spew*
Twelve springs of water and about
Them seventy palms *like a shout*,
So they camped there. 10 Then they
removed

From Elim and camped by the *grooved*
Red Sea. 11 They removed from the Red
Sea and camped in the desert dread
Of Sin. 12 They journeyed from the *dry*
Wilderness of Sin and camped by
Dophkah. 13 They left Dophkah and
camped

At Alush. 14 They moved from *the*
cramped

Alush and camped at Rephidim,
Where there was no water *to swim*
Or for the people *there* to drink.

My bitterness, Beloved, is once made
sweet,

Not by the psycho-machination's feat,
But coming to Elim where Your trees grow
In cool oasis where the twelve springs
flow.

My bitterness is foiled, Beloved, to find
The breezes of the Red Sea on my mind,
And crushed by the determined pace I set
Through the harsh desert of Sin where I
met

The cattle of Dophkah that wandered wild
In Alush's stark rantings unbeguiled.
It's only bitter march that can bring rest,
True rest in Rephidim's secluded vest.
Beloved, I find Your secrets where I stand
And look in knowing wonder on the land.

15 They left Rephidim *at the brink*
And camped in Sinai wilderness.

16 They moved from Sinai wilderness
And camped at Kibroth Hattaavah.

17 They went from Kibroth Hattaavah
And camped at Hazeroth. 18 They left
Hazeroth and camped at Rithmah.

19 They went from Rithmah *unenfeoffed*
And camped at Rimmon Perez *then*.

20 They left Rimmon Perez *like men*
And *then* they camped at Libnah *numb*.

Who camp by Libnah's blanched colours
have learned
Of Sinai, heard Your voice, and yet have
earned

Your guidance to survive the graves of lust
At Kibroth Hattaavah, the courts of dust
Where Miriam doubted Moses' zeal for
You.

They've smelled the broom of Rithmah and
the dew

Of many mornings wakened to their
prayers.

Who camp by Libnah's whitewashed tombs
and cares

Have seen the pomegranate of the breach
Of covenant and humbled each to each

To be made white by penitence and blood.

But even whiteness can be just a flood

Of spiked hypocrisy before the doom.

But some are white for having found Your
room.

21 They moved from Libnah and camped at
Rissah. 22 They journeyed from *the flat*
Of Rissah to Kehelathah.

23 They went from Kehelathah and
Camped at Mount Shepher, *stood in awe*.

24 They moved from Mount Shepher to
stand

At Haradah. 25 They moved from there
In Haradah and camped *with care*

At Makheloth. 26 They made their path
From Makheloth towards Tahath.

27 They left Tahath and camped *at night*

At Terah. 28 They moved from Terah
And encamped *at last* at Mithkah.

29 They went from Mithkah *out of sight*
And then encamped at Hashmonah.

30 They departed from Hashmonah
And camped at Moseroth. 31 They went

From Moseroth and camped *where sent*

At Bene Jaakan. 32 They moved from
Bene Jaakan till they had come

To encamp at Hor Hagidgad.

33 They departed Hor Hagidgad

And camped at Jotbathah. 34 They moved

From Jotbathah, camped unimproved

At Abronah. 35 They departed

From Abronah until they hid

At Ezion Geber. 36 They moved from

Ezion Geber and camped when come

To the desert of Zin, known by

The name of Kadesh. 37 They passed by

Kadesh and camped at Mount Hor's hand,

On the boundary of Edom's land.

Desert of thorn or sacred purifying,

I come to You, Beloved, nothing defying.

The Grecian urns or facing profiles choose

To make the good or take the bad and lose.

The glass is always half full for the one

And half empty for those in life who're
done.

I skip the exercise, I do not bear

The pessimistic weight, I do not share

The optimistic feel, I do not care

For pains and pleasures, thorns or holy
water.

I come into the dergah for the slaughter,

See desert bloom, inhale tortured perfume

And love the very heat and hearth and air:

With cantillated miracles meet doom.

38 Then Aaron the priest went up to
Mount Hor at the command of YHWH,

And died there in the fortieth year

After sons of Israel appear

To have come out of Egypt's land,

On the first of the fifth month's *stand*.

39 Aaron *was* one hundred and twenty

Three years old when he died *in plenty*

On Mount Hor. 40 Now the king of Arad,

The Canaanite, who lived in *arid*

South in the land of Canaan, heard

Of Israel's folk's coming *and stirred*.

The shock of Aaron's death made Israel
skittish.

They fled from Arad when the king got
fittish.

Beloved, I look toward the mountain peaks
Where Aaron's death occurred, and see the

streaks

Of crimson sunset overlay the slopes

With pinks and purples. As I hold my
hopes

Up to inspection of the setting sun,

I wonder how many such days have run

In shimmering introspection since the man

Climbed Hor to meet his God in final

death.

Did anything prepare him for the trip?

I doubt it did, despite the daily sip

Of life-restoring words. Then life released.

Hor may be any mountain name increased.

41 So they departed from Mount Hor

And camped at Zalmonah *in corps*.

42 They departed from Zalmonah
 And camped at Punon. 43 They withdraw
 From Punon to camp at Oboth.
 44 They left Oboth and were not loath
 To camp at Ije Abarim,
 At Moab's border it would seem.
 45 They departed from Ijim and
 Camped at Dibon Gad *by command*.
 46 They moved from Dibon Gad and
 camped
 At Almon Diblathaim *vamped*.
 47 They moved from Almon Diblathaim
 And camped in the mountains some time
 Of Abarim, before Nebo.
 48 They went away from the mountains
 Of Abarim and in the plains
 Of Moab they camped by Jordan,
Across from Jericho a span.
 49 They camped by the Jordan, from Beth
 Jesimoth as far as the *breath*
 Abel Acacia Grove on plains
 Of Moab *under suns and rains*.

So near the heights of Promised Land the
 names
 Of the 'campments show no exalted claims.
 The expectation at the Red Sea brink
 Might be to enter where the angels drink
 The nectar of the gods while glory-
 crowned.
 But shedding all illusions to the ground
 From stage to stage becomes more isolated,
 Deserted and apart from golden fated.
 Zalmonah's shades to Oboth's water-skins
 Imply the blistering heat of sun and shins
 Barked on the barren rocks of Ijem's way,
 And head baked in the glaring eye of day.
 The road to heaven is paved with march
 and digs,
 No more comfort than double cake of figs.

50 Now YHWH spoke to Moses in plains
 Of Moab by the Jordan's *steam*,
Across from Jericho, and said
 51 "Speak to the sons of Israel,
 And say to them, 'When you have well
 Crossed the Jordan into the land
 Of Canaan, 52 'then you shall take hand
 To drive out all inhabitants
 Of the land from before your *glance*,
 Destroy all their engraved stones, and
 Destroy their moulded images,

And demolish their high places,
 53 'And you shall dispossess the land
 And live in it, for I have given
 You the land to possess *and live in*.

The command is not strange device to those
 Alone who followed Moses when You
 chose.
 You still expect the one who hears Your
 voice
 To destroy all idolatry by choice
 That comes within his power. The graven
 stone,
 The grove where resound tap, rattle and
 tone
 Of heathen worship in frenetic dance:
 All these remain to be destroyed with
 glance
 From every life that's consecrated to
 The dergah's living sacrifice to You.
 You give the earth to the meek and poor for
 A place to live and cantillate the score
 Of Your names in a pure and slender
 sound,
 While dragons fall down broken to the
 ground.

54 'And you'll divide the land by lot
 As an inheritance *well sought*
 Among your families, to those
 Of greater size you'll give what rose
 In larger heritage, and to
 The smaller you shall give on cue
 A smaller heritage, and then
 What falls by lot to each unpen.
 You shall inherit by the tribes
 Of your fathers *as it prescribes*.
 55 'But if *and when* you do not drive
 Out the inhabitants *of hive*
 From the land before you, then it
 Shall be that those whom you've left fit
Shall be irritants in your eyes
 And thorns in your sides, *no disguise*,
 And they shall harass you as long
 As you live in the land *with wrong*.
 56 'Moreover it shall be *that* I
 Will do to you as I would try
 To do to them *to make them fly*."

I have experienced the irritant
 In eye that's granted by inhabitant

Of the land from which my attempts to
drive
Idolatry were not destined to thrive.
I have felt thorns and their harassment too
In everything I do or try to do.
My shout of outrage and my quiet foil
Provide only new fields for them to spoil.
Beloved, give me the ways and screens to
go
In victory against the threatening foe.
Help me to pluck the thorn out of my breast
And bind my wounds so I may meet the
test.
Crowd out idolatry from my heart's room
With Your crown jewels or let me meet my
doom.

Number 34

1 Then YHWH spoke to Moses and said
2 'Command the folk of Israel led,
And say to them, 'When you come to
The land of Canaan, this *is true*
The land that shall fall unto you
As an inheritance, the land
Of Canaan to its furthest hand.
3 'Your southern border shall be from
The wilderness of Zin to come
Along the border of Edom,
Your southern border shall extend
Eastward until the Salt Sea's end,
4 'Your border shall turn from the side
On the south slope of Akrabbim,
Continue to Zin *in its pride*,
And be on the south of *the trim*
Kadesh Barnea, then it shall
Go on to Hazar Addar's *hall*,
Arriving at Azmon *to call*,
5 'The border shall turn from Azmon
To the stream of Egypt *to run*,
And it shall end beside the sea.
6 'As for the western border's *fee*,
You shall have the Great Sea to be
A border, *and this too* shall be
Your western border. 7 'And this shall
Be your northern border *to call*:
From the Great Sea you shall mark out
Your *border* line to Mount Hor's *route*,
8 'From Mount Hor you shall mark it out
To entrance of Hamath, then turn
Toward Zedad, 9 'the border *stern*
Shall proceed to Ziphron, and it
Shall end at Hazar Enan *fit*.

This shall be your northern extent.

While whirling through the four gates on
the mount
I turn northward to find the cherished fount
Of Hamath's hot springs where awareness
true
Of Your creating essence meets the dew.
From Zedad's siding on the north I turn
Toward the handsome top of Ziphron's
burn
To find Hazar Enan, village of springs.
As I look out upon a world of things,
I see behind their beauties hidden ones
Ruling and serving under moons and suns,
Bearing in melon alabaster jar
Refreshing sips of juices squeezed from
star
Hung ripe and red and yellow on the tree
Of life born by the whirling company.

10 'You shall mark out your eastern bent
From Hazar Enan to Shepham,
11 'The border shall go from Shepham
To Riblah on east side of Ain,
The border shall go down *the plain*
And reach the eastern side of sea
Of Chinnereth, 12 'the border *free*
Shall go down along Jordan's *run*,
And it shall end at the Salt Sea.
This shall be your land all about."
13 And Moses commanded the *stout*
Sons of Israel, telling the plot,
"This *is* the land which you by lot
Shall inherit, which YHWH's commanded
To give to the nine tribes *remanded*
And to the half-tribe. 14 "For the tribe
Of the sons of Reuben ascribe
To the house of their fathers' *pride*,
And the tribe of the sons of Gad
By the house of their fathers' *side*,
Have received *heritage to add*,
And the half-tribe of Manasseh
Has received heritage this day.
15 "The two tribes and the half-tribe well
Received their inheritance spell
On this side of the Jordan's *sighs*,
Jericho eastward, toward sunrise."

From Shepham to Riblah upon the east
I naked come to find the fertile feast.
Who enter on the dergah floor to turn

In sacred dance to the ecstatic burn
Of love to You, Beloved, may live to learn
That like the Prophet Jeremiah's eye
Put out because he needs must testify,
The beauty of the world may darken fast
For those in the footpath who choose to
last.

Not that the art and music fail to thrill
The soul to know Your oneness and Your
will,
But that the darkened heart may set a stone
Before the dancing feet by zephyrs blown.
The blinded eye may see Your image still.

16 And YHWH spoke to Moses, and said
17 "These *are* the names of the men led
To divide the land among you
As an inheritance *and due*:
Eleazar the priest and one
Named Joshua the son of Nun.

18 "And you shall take of every tribe
One leader the land to subscribe
For the inheritance. 19 "These names
Are of the men: from the tribe's claims
Of Judah, Caleb who's the son
Of Jephunneh, 20 "from the tribe *won*
Of the children of Simeon,
Shemuel son of Ammihud,
21 "From the tribe of Benjamin *good*,
Elidad son of Chislon who
22 "*Was* a leader from the tribe *true*
Of the children of Dan, Bukki
Of Joseph, the son of Jogli,
23 "A chief of the tribe Manasseh,
Hanniel son and Ephod's *stay*,
24 "And a chief from tribe Ephraim,
Kemuel the son of Shiphtan,
25 "A chief from the tribe Zebulun,
Son of Parnach, Elizaphan,
26 "A chief from the tribe Issachar,
Paltiel Azzan's son *and star*,
27 "A chief from the tribe of Asher,
Ahihud *who was* son *and fer*
Of Shelomi, 28 "and a chief from
The tribe of Naphtali *to come*,
Pedahel son of Ammihud."

29 These *are* the ones YHWH's command
could

Rely upon to divide lot
Of heritage among the sought
Children of Israel in the land
Of Canaan *where they came to stand*.

Let Your lots fall upon me as I stand
Before Your chosen twelve before the land.
Too many would come to appoint a man
To be the chief of every caravan.
From every tribe a chief divinely sought
In clear light of day or in occult draught
Has come to give Your guidance on the
earth.

Let me always follow the chief of worth.
Not the elected and not those whose wealth
Has made them leaders of the world by
stealth,

But Your pure ones reveal Your word to
me

Without the grandstand and the company.
Beloved, I follow in the steps of twelve,
And leave the pathways of the fox to
shelve.

Numbers 35

1 And YHWH spoke to Moses upon
The plains of Moab by the *drawn*
Jordan *across from* Jericho,
Saying 2 "Command *then on the go*
The sons of Israel that they give
The Levites cities where to live
From the inheritance of their
Possession, and you'll *also* share
With the Levites of common land
Around the cities *where they stand*.
3 "They'll have the cities to live in,
And their common land shall be *bin*
For their cattle, and for their herds,
And for all their beasts *with their turds*.
4 "The cities' common land which you
Shall give the Levites *as their due*
Shall extend from the city wall
Outward a thousand cubits' fall.

The Levites were scattered among the
tribes

Not so it would be easier to take bribes,
Nor yet in punishment as Genesis might
show,

But for convenience of their come and go
In service to the people and the tent
Where You, Beloved, look on the value
spent.

The Levites were scattered and yet were
given

Cities and lands for their cattle to live in,

Which only proves even theocracy
Demands its priests to have economy
And farm their wealth like every Dick and
Harry,
And not just live like royals and be merry.
So every bishop ought to earn his keep
With ox and donkey to husband his heap.

5 "And you shall measure *all around*
Outside the city *on the ground*
Upon the east side two thousand
Cubits, and on the south side's hand
Two thousand cubits, on the west
Side two thousand cubits *at best*,
And on the north side two thousand
Cubits. And the city *shall stand*
In the middle. This shall belong
To them as common land *and strong*
For the cities. 6 "And now among
The cities which you'll set unstrung
For the Levites *you shall appoint*
Six cities of refuge *in joint*,
To which a manslayer may flee.
And to these you shall add to be
Forty-two cities. 7 "So in all
The cities you'll give to the call
Of the Levites *are* forty-eight,
These *you shall give* common estate.
8 "And the cities which you will give
Shall be from the possession *sieve*
Of Israel's folk, and from the larger
Tribes you shall give many *on charger*,
And from the smaller you shall give
But few where they may come to live.
Each shall give some of its cities
To the Levites, by the decree's
Proportion of inheritance
That each receives *in song and dance*."

The priestly cities also must include
The place of refuge for the killer dude
Who in his carelessness cuffed out a life,
If he did not do so from hate or strife.
As I stand on the fringes of the fray,
It seems a weary mite to draw a ray
Between a killing that was done in sport
And one not done on purpose in the fort.
The end results are death in every case
And the same loss to family and grace.
Perhaps that's why You let avenging rood
Pass on the careless killer unpursued
If he steps out a foot beyond the bent

Of priestly city, field or cattle tent.

9 Then YHWH spoke to Moses and said
10 "Speak to the sons of Israel *wed*,
And say to them, 'When you have crossed
The Jordan into Canaan's *frost*,
11 'Then you'll appoint cities to be
Cities of refuge for your *fee*,
That the manslayer who kills a soul
By accident may flee *the toll*.
12 'They shall be cities of refuge
For you from the avenger's *stooge*,
That the manslayer may not die
Until he stands before the try
Of the assembly in judgement.
13 'And of the cities which you lent,
You'll have six cities of refuge.
14 'You shall appoint three cities *huge*
On this side of the Jordan *flood*,
And three cities you'll set *in bud*
In Canaan's land, *and they* will be
Cities of refuge *where to flee*.
15 'And these six cities *all* shall be
For refuge for *all* Israel's folk,
And for the stranger, and the bloke
Who stays among them, anyone
Who kills a person that was done
By accident may flee *and run*.
16 'But if he strikes him with a *spade*
Of iron, so that he dies *unmade*,
He *is* a murderer, and shall
Surely be put in death's *canal*.
17 'And if he strikes him with a stone
In the hand, by which *one alone*
Could die, and he does die, then he's
A murderer, before he flees
He surely shall be put to death.
18 'Or *if* he strikes him with a tool
Of wood in hand which *by the rule*
Might cause death, and the one does die,
He *is* a murderer thereby,
He surely shall be put to death.

The death sentence upon the killer seems
To conflict with what Decalogue's word
gleams.
Yet it is clear that slaying of the slayer
Is to prevent further loss to the player.
Who once kills may as well kill friend or
brother,
And better of two evils is to smother
That risk in getting rid of one instead

Of waiting for ten more hit in the head.
I see the wisdom when theocracy
Is true and well-guided in Your mercy,
But not when countries are ruled by the oil
That greases every palm come in to spoil.
Your Word is poorly taken justifying
The killing all around I see and dying.

19 'The avenger of blood himself
Shall kill the murderer, *not elf*,
When he meets him, he'll put him down.
20 'If he pushes him out of hate
Or, while he's lying there in wait,
Throws something at him so he dies,
21 'Or in hatred strikes by surprise
With his hand so that someone dies,
The one who struck *him* shall be put
To a sure death, *both hand and foot*.
He *is* a murderer, and when
The avenger of blood meets then
He'll put the murderer to death.
22 'However, if he pushes him
Suddenly without hate made dim,
Or casts something at him without
Lying in wait, 23 '*or without doubt*
Uses a stone, by which a man
Could die, throwing *it without plan*
At him without seeing, so that
He dies, while he was not foe fat
Or seeking his harm, 24 'then the folk
In congregation judge the bloke
Between the slayer and the one
Who would avenge blood *on the run*
According to these judgements *done*.
25 'So the assembly shall save slayer
From hand of avenging blood payer,
And the assembly shall return
Him to refuge city *to learn*
Where he had fled, and he'll remain
There until the death of the main
High priest anointed with the oil.
26 'But if the slayer *to his spoil*
At any time goes outside led
Of the limits of where he fled
To the city of refuge, 27 'and
The avenger of blood *at hand*
Finds him outside the city line
Of refuge, and the blood avenger
Kills the manslayer, the avenger
Shall not be guilty of *his* blood,
28 'Because he should have stayed *the stud*
In his city of refuge till

The death of the high priest fulfil.
But after death of the high priest
The manslayer may go released
To the land of his heritage.
29 'And these shall be from age to age
A statute of judgement to you
In all your dwellings *what to do*.
30 'Whoever kills a person, then
The slayer shall be put to death
On the eye-witnesses *of men*,
But one witness does not *suffice*
For the death sentence in a trice.

Preserve me, my Beloved, from the sad
state
Of being an avenger to the hate
That killed a brother of my own at hand.
You see, Beloved, I live upon a land
Where lynchings have fallen in disrepute
And citizen action simply won't suit.
If You had seen justice done here and now
You must have laid Your hand to sword
and plow.
Who touch Your hem with love still lie
beneath
The thraldom of democracy's bequeath
Of power lobbies and those who compel
With wealth the come and go, the ebb and
swell.
Preserve me, my Beloved, from peace and
law
That do not hold Your messenger in awe.

31 'Moreover you shall take no ransom
For the life of a slayer handsome
Who *is* guilty of death, but he
Shall surely be put in death's *tree*.
32 'And you shall take no ransom for
Him who has fled to city door
For refuge, that he may return
To live in the land *and not burn*
Before the death of the *high* priest.
33 'So you shall not pollute the *least*
Of the land where you *are*, for blood
Defiles the land, and *like a flood*
No atonement can be made for
The land, for the blood that before
Is shed on it, except by blood
Of him who shed it. 34 'Therefore scud,
Do not defile the land which you
Inhabit, and where I live too,
For I YHWH live among the folk

Of Israel, *the One who spoke.*"

The Torah accepts no ransom at all
For the death sentence or its just recall.
In those days it was true no doubt that You
Spoke to the divine guide appointed true
And revealed the just reward of each one
Who claimed to be a Jewish mother's son.
But law was turned to farce in Babylon
By elders who in lust hid from the sun.
Therefore in grace You brought to light the
gift

Of the Qur'an in which there is no rift
In granting ransom for the killer's toll.
May such grace always bind the human
soul.

Divine grace alone can cleanse evil stain
Upon the ground in sacrificial rain.

Numbers 36

1 Now the chief fathers of the tribes
Of the children of Gilead's *vibes*
The son of Machir, and the son
Of Manasseh, *once they've begun*,
Of the families of Joseph's sons,
Came near and spoke *without their guns*
Before Moses, before the leaders,
The chief fathers of Israel's seeders.
2 And they said "YHWH commanded my
Lord *Moses* to give land as by
Inheritance in lot to folk
Of Israel, and *at one stroke*
My lord was told by YHWH to give
Inheritance *that does not live*
Of our brother Zelophehad
To his daughters *for good or bad*.
3 "Now if they're married to one of
The sons of the *other* tribes' *glove*
Of Israel's sons, then their share will
Be taken from our fathers' till,
And it will be added upon
The share of the tribe where they've gone
To marry, so it will be taken
From the lot of our own forsaken.
4 "And when Israel's sons' Jubilee
Comes, then their heritage in fee
Will be added to the tribe's share
Into which they marry *and bear*,
So their inheritance will be
Taken away *eternally*
From the inheritance in tribe
Of our fathers to *circumscribe.*"

The daughters of Zelophehad were glad
To bring an issue not to stay unclad
With property because their poor old dad
Had no sons to ensure his wealth and fame.
You gave support to those glad girls and
claim.

Now the tribe's sons come in to join the
sport

For fear their land will go to some cohort
Outside their bounds. Beloved, ten words
sufficed

For You to tell the world justice was
priced.

It's humans need a constant bickering
To decide who should have the golden
thing.

I'll wager that the issue never came
To settlement, but each new answer given
Provided merely more where men have
striven.

5 Then Moses told Israel's sons by
The word of YHWH to testify
"What the tribe of Joseph's son speaks
Is right. 6 "This *is* what YHWH's word
seeks

Concerning Zelophehad's daughters,
Saying 'Let them marry the wroughters
Whom they think best, but they may marry
Only within their father's very
Tribe and family.' 7 "So heritage
Of Israel's folk *from age to age*
Shall not change hands from tribe to tribe,
For every one who does subscribe
To Israel's folk shall keep the plot
Of the tribe of his fathers *taught*.

8 "And every daughter who possesses
Inheritance in any *messes*
Of a tribe of Israel's folk shall
Be wife of one collateral
Family of her father's tribe, so
The folk of Israel each may go
To hold the heritage in tow
Of his *own* fathers. 9 "And thus no
Inheritance shall change hands from
Tribe to another, but each come
To every tribe of Israel's folk
Shall stay where its allotment broke."
10 As YHWH commanded Moses, so
Did daughters of Zelophehad,
11 Mahlah, Tirzah, Hoglah, and Noe,

And Milcah, of Zelophehad,
The daughters were married to sons
Of their father's brothers, *which stuns*.

12 They were married into families
Of Manasseh's children *to please*
The son of Joseph, and their plot
Remained in the tribe *and the lot*
Of their father's family *brought*.

13 These the commandments and
judgements
Which YHWH commanded *sacraments*
To Israel's folk by Moses' hand
In the plains of Moab by land
Of the Jordan, *from Jericho,*
Near the land that YHWH would bestow.

The statutes may be done, the word recited,
But there is left the world of men indicted.
Divine guidance takes flight from here to
be

A beacon of justice and love's fair tree.
Beloved, let me submit with humble grace
Before Your divine guide, although no face
Appear before my sight. I know the voice,
I have heard its sweet words to hold its
choice

Remembrances upon my daily prayer.
Add guidance to the gift of gate in air
That patience might command the hand to
hold

Only the dervish's account and told.
The Jordan flow upon my tiny plot
And water all the lentils I have got.

Deuteronomy

THE Books of Moses describe the process of revelation in five steps, and the division into five books roughly corresponds to the five areas of emphasis to be noted: the oneness of God, divine justice, revelation through prophets, divine guidance, and finally the subject of the last and fifth Book of Moses, human responsibility before the divine message.

The book consists of an extended sermon on the part of Moses, in which he recapitulates the events of the Exodus and the revelation of divine law, warning the people of their responsibility to obey God. The whole tenor of the book portrays

blessings on those who obey and catastrophe and judgement on those who do not.

Both Muslims and Christians find the most interesting verse in the book to be 18:18, the former applying it to Muhammad, and the latter to Jesus. The Islamic view is largely fortuitous, and there is little in the text that clearly refers to Muhammad. The Christian view, by contrast, is simply silly. After all of the arguments are presented, one fact demolishes the whole structure. Christians generally believe that Jesus is God, God the Son, the second person of the Trinity. That is the most important thing about Jesus for Christians, unless it be his vicarious sacrificial death on the cross. No Christian believes that Moses was or is God, nor that he died on a cross for their sins. In the two central points of faith, Jesus and Moses differ. If the text of Deuteronomy refers to Jesus, then he is not God and he did not die on the cross. One just cannot have it both ways. In point of fact, the text and context seem best to refer to Joshua, who came in Moses' place and led the people into the promised land. Of course it may refer, in a secondary sense, to either Muhammad or Jesus, or both, if one is willing to ignore some clear differences between Moses and these later figures. This is a good example of how religious traditions get away with poor Scriptural interpretation, merely on the weight of their numbers and influence.

The Books of Moses are not particularly good sources of prophecy for either Jesus or Muhammad. But Deuteronomy, like the three preceding books, is filled with legislative matters of great interest. The food laws of Leviticus 11 are mirrored in Deuteronomy 14. Both Jews and Muslims still find them binding in general.

Again and again idolatry is excoriated in Deuteronomy, and the oneness of God proclaimed. The central text on the divine oneness is found in 6:4,5 and this text is a part of the Jewish daily prayers. The Samaritans emphasis 32:3,4 for the same belief and practice. These recapitulations of the divine unity appear again and again in the book in the context of warning against

idolatry. Thus the Books of Moses enfold the central premise of revealed faith, the acknowledgement that God is one and one only, in the absolute sense, and accepts no rivals nor associates. The book comes to a culmination, with the wedding of these two principles of divine oneness and divine judgement in the grand passage near the end of the book, 32:39,40. In verse 41 this becomes the theme of joy for the Gentiles, thus expanding the ethnic focus of the Books of Moses to a universal faith, one for all people.

THE Book of Genesis establishes
That You alone are God among the fizz
Of claimants to Your throne, while Exodus
Proves You alone are just among the fuss
Of rival justices. Leviticus
Proves prophecy to enhance and apply
The law that You proclaimed on Mount
Sinai.

The subject of the Book of Numbers was
That divine guidance enlightens Your laws.
The golden chain of revelation takes
Its final link in the last book that makes
Responsibility to revelation
The subject of Your judgement and Your
station.

Punish me with Your love as my own
ration.

Week 44 Deuteronomy 1

1 These *are* the words which Moses spoke
To all Israel *upon a stroke*
On this side of the Jordan in
The wilderness, and in the plain
Opposite Suph, between Paran,
Tophel, Laban, Hazeroth, and
Dizahab. 2 Eleven days' *stand*
From Horeb by way of Mount Seir
To Kadesh Barnea, *no fear*.
3 Now it happened in fortieth year,
In the eleventh month, on first
Of the month, Moses blessed and cursed
In speech to Israel's sons by all
That YHWH had given him to call
Commandments to them, 4 after he
Had killed Sihon king of the *free*
Amorites, who lived in Heshbon,
And Og *who was* king of Bashan,
Who lived by Ashtoreth and swore

In Edrei. 5 And then on this *fore*
Side of the Jordan in the land
Of Moab, Moses took in hand
To explain this law, saying *grand*,
6 "YHWH our God spoke to us beside
Horeb, saying 'You've come to bide
Long enough at this mountainside.
7 'Turn and take your journey, and go
Where Amoritic mountains show,
To the adjacency in plain,
In mountains and in lowland *vane*,
In the south and on the seacoast,
To the land of Canaanites *boast*
And Lebanon, as far as where
The great river Euphrates *bear*.
8 'See, I have set the land before
You, go in and possess, *restore*
The land which YHWH your fathers swore,
To Abraham, Isaac, Jacob,
To give to them and all the *hub*
Of their descendants after them,
In generations head to hem.'

I too, Beloved, have taken forty years
On a fortnight's journey because of fears.
I too have stopped along the golden way
To complain of the stony path by day
And of the frost and darkness of the night.
I've balked at pillar of cloud and pillar of
light.

And still I stop to hear Your prophet's word
Spoken in blessing and curse undeterred.
I take the bread of life from prophet's hand
Dripping with blood of two kings of the
land
And bow to Your wisdom and Your
command.

I lay aside the lovely Ashtoreth
That Bashan's Og worshipped beneath the
swath
Of groves that fluttered on deserted wrath.

9 "And I spoke to you at that time,
Saying 'I alone cannot *rhyme*
To bear you. 10 'YHWH your Alohim
Has multiplied you, *as we deem*,
And here you *are* today, as stars
Of heaven in multitude *bazaars*.
11 'May YHWH God of your fathers make
You a thousand times more to take
Than you are, and bless you as He
Has promised you. 12 'How can I be

Alone bearing your problems and
 Your burdens and complaints *in hand*?
 13 'Choose wise, and understanding, and
 Knowledgeable men from among
 Your tribes, and I will make them *sprung*
 Heads over you.' 14 "And you answered
 Me and said *the following word*:
 'The thing you have told *us* to do
 Is good.' 15 "So I took the heads *true*
 Of your tribes, knowledgeable men
 And wise, and made them heads *again*
 Over you, leaders of thousands,
 Leaders of hundreds *by commands*,
 Leaders of fifties, chiefs of tens,
 And officers for your tribes' *kens*.

The myriads of the fifties and the tens
 And chiefs of thousand thousand citizens
 Bewilder the poor brain that prays alone
 Below the pines and firs, beside the stone.
 Beloved, breathe on me that same blessing
 now

That You gave to the multitude somehow
 To multiply their numbers and their faith
 A thousand times. My company's a wraith,
 And I am bound on Sabbaths that I find
 That two or three together are combined
 And rarely more. Yet You in promise kept
 Are here beside the one who sang and
 wept.

And yet I pray for blessing come on me
 To go beyond a Sabbath trinity.

16 "Then I commanded your judges
 At that time, saying 'Hear *cases*
 Between your brothers, and judge right
 Between a man and *in his sight*
 His brother or the stranger who
 Is with him. 17 'You shall not make do
 With partiality to judge,
 You shall hear the small *and not fudge*
 As well as the great, you shall not
 Be afraid of any man's plot,
 For the judgement *is* God's *own lot*.
 The case that is too hard for you,
 Bring to me, and I'll hear its *due*.'
 18 "And I commanded you that time
 All the things you should do *in mime*.

The cases that are too hard, who's to say?
 My reading of Your Word leaves me to
 pray

Until the case is clear, no doubt Your own
 Occulted guide is whispering what I'm
 shown.

Let him return and take the golden stair
 That joins my inner chamber with the air,
 And prostrate by my side where I repair
 Into the fine and chosen room I share.
 I shall indeed bring to Your prophet sent,
 To Moses or Muhammad in the tent,
 Any case that I fail to penetrate
 With judgement and the clear Word's
 instigate.

Beloved, there is no judge of human mind
 Who is impartial, still I shall be kind.

19 "So we departed from Horeb,
 And went through all that vastly web
 Of terrible desert which you
 Saw on the way to *their debut*
 In the mountains of Amorites,
 As YHWH our Alohim recites
 Command to us. Then we came to
 Kadesh Barnea. 20 "And I said
 To you, 'You have come to be led
 To the mountains of Amorites,
 Which YHWH our Alohim delights
 To give us. 21 'YHWH your Alohim
 Has set the land before your *dream*,
 Go up *and* take *it*, as YHWH God
 Of your fathers has spoken *prod*
 To you, do not fear, be downhearted.'
 22 "And everyone of you then started
 To come near me and said 'Let's send
 Men before us, and let them tend
 To searching out the land for us,
 And bring back word we may discuss
 Of the way by which we should go,
 And of the cities we should know.'
 23 "The plan pleased me well, so I took
 Twelve of your men, from each tribe's nook
 One man. 24 "And they left and went up
 Into the mountains *like a tup*,
 And came to the vale of Eshcol,
 And spied it out *both part and whole*.

Ha! This prophet and divine guide reveals
 The lacking of the knowledge that he feels.
 When in their unbelief the people crowed
 To send out spies to seal the proffered road,
 He was well pleased. But when the two
 tribes came
 Along with half of Manasseh, the blame

Was fast to fall from Moses' lip to spare,
Although their motive was both good and fair.

In broken vessels, my Beloved, You hide
Your messages of faith at eventide.
The gnarling of my roots shows battered heart,

And yet imperfectly I do my part.
Like Moses I rely on what I know,
Yet often have to let the knowing go.

25 "They also took *some* of the fruit
Of the land in their hands *to boot*
And brought *it* down to us, and they
Brought back word to us *in the way*,
Saying '*It's* a good land that YHWH
Our Alohim gives to our crew.'

26 "Nevertheless you would not go
Up, but rebelled against the mot
Of YHWH your Alohim, 27 "and you
Complained in your tents, and said 'Since
YHWH hates us, He has *made us wince*
To bring us out of Egypt's land
To deliver us in the hand
Of Amorites, to destroy us.

28 'Where can we go *victorious*?
Our brothers discouraged our hearts,
Saying "The people *in their parts*
Are greater and taller than we,
The cities *are* great and *greatly*
Fortified, moreover have we
Seen the sons of the Anakim."

The wilderness the world makes in my
view
Is made up of two messages and true.
The one is that beside my hand and foot
The glories of the promised land are put
For my delight and for my nourishment.
The other is that giants have been sent
To darken happy days with sentiment.
I may choose to live in the shadow of
The foe or in the shining light of love,
Depending on which way my face in
turned.

The one is always held, the other spurned.
Beloved, renew the lessons I have learned,
And if You must, make sun rise in the west,
But turn my viewing from the worst to best.

29 "Then I said to you, 'Do not dream
Of terrors, do not fear their *beam*.

30 'YHWH your Alohim, who precedes
You, He will fight in all your needs,
According to all He did for
You in Egypt *and on your score*,
Before your eyes, 31 'and in the wild
Places where you saw *reconciled*
How YHWH your Alohim bare you,
As a man carries his son *true*,
In all the way that you went till
You came to this place *by His will*.'
32 "Yet for all that, you'd not believe
YHWH your Alohim *for reprieve*,
33 "Who went in the way before you
To search out a *smooth* place for you
To pitch your tents, and to show you
The way you should go, in the fire
By night and in the cloud's *desire*
By day. 34 "And YHWH heard *evil* sound
Of your words, and was angry found,
And took an oath, saying 35 'Surely
Not one of these men of this *tree*
Of evil generation see
That good land of which I *once* swore
To give to your fathers *before*,
36 'Except Caleb Jephunneh's son,
He shall see it *before he's done*,
And to him and his children I
Shall give the land he went to spy,
Because he wholly followed YHWH.'
37 "YHWH was also angry *it's true*
With me for your sakes, saying 'You
Also shall not go in there, 38 'but
Joshua son of Nun *rebut*,
Who stands before you, he shall go
In there. Encourage him *to show*,
For he shall cause Israel to know
Inheritance *and apropos*.
39 'Moreover your little ones and
Your children, who you say will stand
Victims, who today have no proof
Of good and evil, *not aloof*
They'll go in there, to them I'll give
It, and they shall hold it *and live*.

Was it You, my Beloved, who smoothed
the way
Before the folk complaining every day
About the heat and cold, the lack of food
And drinking water for their famished
brood?

Despite the guiding cloud by day, at night

The cloud of flickering fire and shining
light,
They did not see that Your hand smoothed
the road
Of hurtful things, and everywhere
bestowed
Your blessings on their travelling and load.
I too have dwelling in the wilderness,
Among the rocky ways, where birches
dress
In green in summer, in the winter white.
Do You smooth my way also out of sight?
I trust in You, Beloved, love and confess.

40 'But *as for* you, turn and take your
Journey into the desert store
By the way of the Red Sea's *door*.'
41 "Then you answered and said to me,
'We have sinned against YHWH, *now* we
Will go up and fight, just as YHWH
Our Alohim told us to do.'
And when all of you had put on
Your weapons of war *and at dawn*
You were ready to scale the mount,
42 "Then YHWH said to me, 'Give account
To them, "Do not go up nor fight,
For I'm not with your blatherskite,
Lest you be defeated in sight
Of your foes.'" 43 "So I spoke to you,
Yet you would not listen *and do*,
But rebelled against charge of YHWH,
And presumptuously went into
The mountain. 44 "And the Amorites
Who lived in that mountain's *delights*
Came out against you and chased you
As bees do, and drove you back from
Seir to Hormah *from whence you'd come*.
45 "Then you returned and wept before
YHWH, but YHWH would not listen *more*
To your voice nor give ear to you.
46 "So you remained in Kadesh *pent*
Many days, all the days you spent.

What can I say, Beloved, about the way
The folk rebelled, refusing on one day
To go into the glories of Your land
And come before Your throne that day to
stand?

It is a thing that I know very well, this trait
So human it seems to come a day late.
But pretence of obedience on Sunday
To do what was required the day before

Is just another wicked way to say
Rebellion is the human heart's own store.
Who weep for bees' attack between the
pews
Get no answers from You for what they
choose.
Beloved, I come in as soon as Your right
Hand raises giving precious signal light.

Deuteronomy 2

1 "Then we turned and journeyed into
The desert by the Red Sea's *view*,
As YHWH spoke to me, and we skirted
Mount Seir for many days *asserted*.
2 "And YHWH spoke to me, saying 3 'You
Have gone around this mountain too
Long, turn towards the north. 4 'Command
The folk, saying "You'll pass the land
Of your brothers, and Esau's sons,
Who live in Seir, and they're the ones
Who'll be afraid of you. Therefore
Watch yourselves carefully *in store*.
5 "Do not meddle with them, for I
Will not give you their land *to spy*,
No, not so much as one footstep,
Because I have given *with pep*
Mount Seir to Esau as possession.
6 "You shall buy food *as a concession*
From them with money, that you may
Eat, and you'll also buy *for pay*
Water from them with money, that
You may drink water *on the flat*.

Since agriculture took over the store
Of gathering from nature's fields and floor,
Most men have understood to eat one must
Pay silver or work oneself in the dust.
Now You Yourself, Beloved, make water
such
As is not free to every tongue to touch,
But is always to be owned and to buy.
To drink is not a right under the sky.
When fresh air also as it seems becomes
A luxury, it too will have its sums.
Beloved, methinks You bow too freely to
What men do and what men may seek to
do.

7 "For YHWH your God has blessed you in
All your hand's work *that's without sin*.
He knows your trudging through this great
Wilderness. These forty years' *rate*

YHWH your God *has been* with you, you
Have lacked nothing *in what you do.*'''

I whirl upon the mountain of a land
Not my own, where I as a stranger stand
And look across a wilderness of great
Islands and lakes, and as appears my fate
I whirl and whirl, though not a step of
ground

Belonging to Esau is to be found
In my possession. Still a stranger here
I keep whirling without fatigue or fear.
Tell me not, my Beloved, to go a bit
More northward, I would surely have a fit!
Or step off into treeless tundras where
The ptarmigan lies with the polar bear.
Let forty years turn on my turning round
And I shall fly up to the sizzling sound.

8 "And when we passed beyond our
brothers,
The sons of Esau, *and none others*,
Who live in Seir, far from the road
Of the plain, far from Elath's *load*
And Ezion Geber, we turned
And passed by way of desert *spurned*
Of Moab. 9 "Then YHWH said to me,
'Do not harass Moab, nor be
Contending with them in warfare,
For I'll not give you *some* of their
Land *as* possession, because I
Have given Ar to the small fry
Of Lot *as* a possession *too.*'''
10 The Emim had lived there times past,
A people as great and forecast
As many and as tall as *those*
Called Anakim. 11 And so they chose
To regard them as giants, like
The Anakim, but in the strike
The Moabites called them Emim.
12 The Horites once lived in Seir's *dream*,
But the children of Esau came
To dispossess them *to their shame*
And destroyed them from before them,
And lived in their place *to contemn*,
Just as Israel did to the land
Of their possession by YHWH's hand.

Some think that You, Beloved, have only
one
Chosen people and righteous under sun.
But every folk that follows after prophet

Sent by Your grace and never does get off
it

Is chosen, loved, and given room to live
Upon the green sward and contemplative.
Esau and Lot are still found on the plot
Where they first learned and laughed and
loved and sought

Your will, Beloved, and chose to follow it.
I pass by mosque and synagogue well lit,
And churches without steeples but still fit,
And see the faithful few in solitude
Bow down to find Your grace beyond the
feud

Of factions joining hands for benefit.

13 "Now rise and cross over the vale
Of the Zered.' So we crossed hale
Over the valley of Zered.

14 "And the time we took coming led
From Kadesh Barnea until
We crossed over the vale and hill
To Zered *was* thirty-eight years,
Till the generation of *fears*,
The men of war were consumed from
The midst of the encampment *come*,
Just as YHWH had sworn to their *sum*.

15 "Indeed YHWH's hand was against
them,

To destroy them *from crown to hem*
From the midst of the camp until
They were consumed *and had their fill*.

16 "So it was, when all men of war
Had succumbed from the people's store,
17 "That YHWH spoke to me, saying *more*,
18 'This very day you will cross over
At Ar, Moab's frontier of clover.

19 'And *when* you come near Ammon's
folk,

Do not harass or give a poke,
For I'll not give you of the land
Of Ammon's folk to hold in hand,
Because I've given it to Lot's own
Descendants as a plot to own.''''

The generation that followed the spies
Who deceived the people with cunning lies
Were all consumed. Indeed, Beloved, no
need

Compelled You to consume them from
their seed.

Time was enough to bring them to their
death,

And time takes also righteous from their
breath.

Life's punishment enough for every sin,
And reward great enough to rejoice in.
Let live and live is welcome counsel given
To desert folk who've lived and marched
and striven.

Let die and die is no command at all
Since everyone must follow the clear call
To walk a while and wait upon the sod,
And then appear before the face of God.

20 That was too held as giants' land
Since giants used to live at hand.

Ammonites call them Zamzummim,
21 A people as great *it would seem*
Many and tall as Anakim.

But YHWH destroyed them before them,
And they threw them out from their hem
And lived there instead, 22 just as He
Had done for Esau's sons *freely*,
Who lived in Seir, when He destroyed
The Horites before them *employed*.
They threw them out to live instead,
Even to this day. 23 The Avim,
Who lived in villages *ahead*
As far as Gaza, Caphtorim,
Who came from Caphtor, destroyed them
Inheriting their diadem.

The people follow one by one upon
The earth to stay awhile and wait for dawn.
The Word claims for their sins they were
thrown out

To give another folk the chance to doubt.
The names live on to witness to their shame
While one by one the others take their
claim.

Beloved, I doubt the principle is true
That manifest destiny comes from You.
The innocent and brave sometimes are lost
To the invader who flies at the cost.
The violent also each have their day
And seem successful in relentless way.
The guiding hand invisible seems weak
To those who fall beneath the swords that
speak.

24 "Rise, take your journey, and cross over
The Arnon river, *every drover*.
Look, I have given into your hand
Sihon the Amorite *and band*,

King of Heshbon, and all his land.

Begin to keep *it*, and engage
Him in the battle *to his rage*.
25 'This day I will begin to put
The dread and fear of you on foot
Of nations under the whole sky,
Who shall hear the report you *vie*,
And shall tremble and be in toil
Because of you *and what you spoil*.'

26 "And I sent messengers out from
The Wilderness of Kedemoth
To Sihon king of Heshbon *come*,
With words of peace, saying *to both*,
27 'Let me pass through your land, and I
Will keep only to the road, I
Will turn neither to right nor left.
28 'You'll sell me food *and without theft*
For money, that I may eat, give
Me water for money *to live*,
That I may drink, only let me
Pass through on foot, 29 'just as the *free*
Sons of Esau who live in Seir
And Moabites who did appear
In Ar did for me, till I cross
The Jordan to the land which *boss*
YHWH our Alohim gives to us.'

30 "But Sihon king of Heshbon would
Not let us pass through *land for good*,
For YHWH your Alohim was there
To harden his spirit and bare
His obstinate heart, that He might
Deliver him into your might,
As *it is* this day. 31 "And YHWH said
To me, 'See, I've begun instead
To give Sihon and his land over
To you, *to the sheep and the drover*.
Begin to hold *it*, that you may
Inherit his land *in one day*.'

Beloved, there many be who hold the fort
And guard the way, many of every sort,
Who would refuse my passing as I whirl
Despite the fact I pay for every curl.
A Sihon sits on every seat of power
And wields a sceptre for what seems an
hour

Perhaps to You, but what is generations
In terms of humankind and human nations.
I do not ask that You give me their land,
Nor do I ask for bread and water's stand.
The prayer's enough, Jesus said daily bread.
I ask for draughts from the Kauthar instead.

When one stands with the shining bowl of
green,
Then I shall know Sihon's gone from the
scene.

32 "Then Sihon and all his folk came
Out against us to fight *in shame*
At Jahaz. 33 "And YHWH our God gave
Him over to us like a slave,
So we defeated him, his sons,
And all his people *on their buns*.
34 "We took all his cities that time,
And utterly destroyed the prime
Men, women, and little ones there
In every city, everywhere
We left remaining none. 35 "We took
Only the livestock *of the crook*
As plunder for ourselves, with spoil
Of the cities *to pay our toil*.
36 "From Aror, upon the bank
Of River Arnon, and *the rank*
Of the city in the ravine,
As far as Gilead *is seen*,
There was not one city too strong
For us, YHWH our God was along
To give them all to us. 37 "Only
You did not go near the land's lea
Of Ammon's folk, nor anywhere
Along the River Jabbok there,
Or to the cities of the hills,
Or wherever YHWH our God wills
That we not go *to lay land bare*.

I guess You had Your reasons when You
swept
Sihon and his folk from the land they kept.
Beloved, I wonder though about the spoil.
Not only men and women met the coil
Of death at the hand of Your chosen race.
The children too were sacrificed in place.
They only kept the cattle live and sound.
I've always thought a cow a likely round,
And calves especially are a favourite beast.
I take exception to the bulls because
One cannot trust what they might do with
claws.
In India cows are better than the people.
I've sympathy with that if not with steeple.
Are some folks born to be wicked
increased?

Deuteronomy 3

1 "Then we turned and went up the road
To Bashan, Og king of the load
Of Bashan came out against us,
He and all his people to fuss,
To battle at Edrei. 2 "And YHWH
Said to me, 'Do not fear him, do,
For I've delivered him *to you*,
And all his people and his land
Into your hand, and you shall stand
To do to him as you did to
Sihon king of the Amorites,
Who lived at Heshbon *in their rights*.'
3 "So YHWH our God also delivered
Into our hands Og *lily-livered*
King of Bashan, with all his folk,
And we attacked until he woke
With no survivors left *to soak*.
4 "And we took all his cities then,
There was not a city *of men*
We did not take away from them:
Sixty cities, and all the hem
Of Argob's region, reign of Og
In Bashan *ranging like a dog*.
5 "All these cities *were* fortified
With high walls, gates, and bars, beside
A multitude of country towns.
6 "We completely wiped off their frowns,
As we did to king of Heshbon,
Completely destroying Sihon,
The men, women, and children of
Every city *mentioned above*.
7 "But all the livestock and the spoil
Of the cities we took as toil
Of booty for ourselves *to keep*.
8 "And at that time we took the *sweep*
Of land from the hand of two kings
Of Amorites on this side's wings
Of Jordan, from the brook Arnon
Clear up to the mount *called Hermon*
9 "The Sidonians call Hermon
Sirion, and the Amorites
Call it Senir, 10 "and all the lights
Of the cities of the plain, all
Gilead, and all Bashan *call*,
As far as Salcah and Edrei,
Cities of Og's kingdom in Bashan.
11 "For only Og the king of Bashan
Remained remnant of giants' nation.
Indeed his bedstead *to portray*
Was an iron bedstead. *Is it not*
In Rabbah of Ammon's folk's plot?
Nine cubits *is* its length and four

Cubits its width, by standard score.

The age of iron it seems progressed so far
That Og had an iron bedstead and cigar.
Those days iron was used mostly on the run
As weapons in the months of war and fun.
Both power and wealth are hidden in the
fact

That Og had an iron bedstead not compact,
But nine arm-lengths in length and four
such wide.

Today the milling run have king-sized beds
Some just as long and all wider beside.
I guess that gives them wealth and power
as heads.

My lakeside hermitage has cots of wood
Which I guess means I'm less than any
should

Be in this day and stage of iron hearts
And hands and heads, and painted plastic
carts.

12 "And this land we held at that time,
From Aroer, beside the clime
Of River Arnon, and the half
Of the mountains of Gilead
And its cities, I gave in staff
To sons of Reuben and of Gad.

13 "The rest of Gilead, and all
Bashan, the kingdom of Og's *call*,
I gave to half Manasseh's tribe.
All that Argob's land does describe,
With all Bashan, was called the land
Of giants. 14 "Jair the son *at hand*
Of Manasseh took all the land
Of Argob, as far as the border
Of the Geshurites and the *hoarder*
Maachathites, and called Bashan by
His own name, Havoth Jair, till now.

15 "Also I gave Gilead *in vow*
To Machir. 16 "To the Reubenites
And the Gadites from Gilead's heights
I gave as far as Arnon's brook,
The middle of the river took
To be *the* border, as far as
The River Jabbok, *and that has*
The border of Ammon's folk there,
17 "The plain also, the border where
It goes by Jordan from the lake
Chinnereth as far as the wake
East of the Salt Sea, there below
The slopes of Pisgah *as they show*.

18 "Then I commanded you that time,
Saying 'YHWH your God's given prime
Land to you to possess. All you
Men of valour shall cross on cue
And armed before your brothers, who
Are the sons of Israel. 19 'But your
Wives, your little ones, also your
Livestock (I know you have much cattle)
Shall stay in cities *while you battle*
Which I have given you, 20 'until
YHWH has given rest to fulfil
Your brothers as to you, and they
Also possess the land which they
Receive of YHWH your God beyond
The Jordan. Then you may abscond
Each to his own possession which
I've given you *this side the ditch*.'

The grand vicissitudes of Israel's folk
Through invasions, captivities and stroke
Contrast with peaceful Ammon, who's still
there
And constant after four thousand years'
care

And more, and safe within his given land,
And still faithful to You, Beloved, to stand
On proclamations there's no god but God
In skies above or on the desert sod.
Bless Ammon for his faithful witness here,
Bless Jordan that his faith is crystal clear,
And bless the ruins of the cities old
Where Your name for the centuries was
told.

The desert and the flame and kingly right
Still shine below Your heavens and Your
night.

21 "And I commanded Joshua
At that time, saying 'Your eyes draw
All that YHWH your God's done to these
Two kings, so will YHWH do to *freeze*
All the kingdoms through which you pass.
22 'You must not fear them *or their class*,
For YHWH your Alohim Himself
Fights for you *against man and elf*.'

You fight for Your people the promised
way
So they need not compel commandment's
sway
Prohibiting the taking of a life

By stealth or through warfare and wanton
strife.

Ah promise sweet! But what about the
times

When Huguenot was slaughtered for his
crimes

And Covenanter chased into the fells
Where he fell victim to the Catholic hells?
Say of the Old Believers in their rights,
Andreas Fischer's folk, and the delights
Of war and torture to the marshland masses
Who could not hide behind the burning
grasses.

The Exodus was once, again, again
The innocent wonder and wonder when.

Week 45

23 "I pleaded with YHWH at that time,
Saying 24 'O Lord YHWH, You in rhyme
Have begun to show Your servant
Your greatness and Your mighty vent,
For what god *is* in heaven or earth
Who can do *anything of worth*
Like Your works and Your mighty *deeds*?

25 'I pray, let me cross *here with speeds*
And see the good land over there
Beyond the Jordan, pleasant share
Of mountains, and of Lebanon.'

26 "But YHWH was angry with my *bun*
On your account, and would not hear.
So YHWH said to me, 'That's enough!
Don't speak of this thing in My ear.

27 'Go up to Pisgah's peak in rough,
And lift your eyes toward the west,
The north, the south, the east, and test
It with your eyes, for you shall not
Cross over Jordan at this spot.

28 'But command Joshua, and give
Him courage and the strength *to live*,
For he shall go before this folk,
And he shall cause them *as I spoke*
To inherit the land you see.'

29 "We stayed in opposite valley
Across from Beth Peor's *levee*.

Grave Kelpius had hoped to be transported
Alive to the skies where angels cavorted,
And so did even my grandmamma when
She realized Christ had not come again
As she lay on her deathbed disappointed.
So hope the great and holy, the anointed.
I also hope from day to day to see

The visions of the homeland from the tree
Atop my Pisgahs where I take my guard
And pray that You will glorify the shard.
My visions also show a shining land
And one where no night comes to still the
hand,

But You are ever fresh within the soul
To bound the sea and shore with waited
toll.

Deuteronomy 4

1 "Now, Israel, listen to the laws
And judgements which I teach your pa's
To keep, that you may learn to live,
And go in and take what He'll give
Of the land, which YHWH Alohim
Of your fathers gives you *for scheme*.

2 "You shall not add to the word which
I command you, nor take *a stitch*
From it, that you may keep the law
Of YHWH your Alohim *in awe*
Which I command you. 3 "Your eyes saw
What YHWH did at Baal Peor,
For YHWH your Alohim before
Destroyed among you all the men
Who followed Baal of Peor's *yen*.

Let none presume I add a tittle to
Your law, Beloved, in these lines not a few
That I place between doggerel paraphrase
Of what Your law would gracefully
appraise.

Let none presume I've come here to
subtract

A Massoretic sign, I've left intact
The text, I only babble, babble on
My shadowy responses to Your dawn.
I listen to the Hebrew words arise
In simple singing lays toward the skies
And love You but the more because of
those

Too human words by which, Beloved, You
chose

To share with humankind Your heart of
love.

I wonder what You had been thinking of.

4 "But you who held to YHWH your God
Are alive today *on the sod*,
Every one of you. 5 "Surely I
Have taught you statutes *by the by*
And judgements, just as YHWH my God

Commanded me *by reed and rod*,
 That you should act according to
Them in the land which you go to
 Possess. 6 "Therefore be careful to
 Observe *them*, for this is your sense
 And understanding in presence
 Of the peoples who'll hear all these
 Statutes, and then they say *with ease*,
 'Surely this great nation *is* wise,
 A *truly* understanding folk.'
 7 "For what *other* great nation *spoke*
 That has Alohims *so* near it,
 As YHWH our God *has made us fit*
To be near us, for whatever
 We may call upon Him *to stir*?

Nation indeed! What nation now exists
 Either beneath the sun or in the mists
 Of new obscurity the modern world
 Grants to those who miss media unfurled,
 That keeps Your word? No single
 congregation,
 Much less a country or denomination,
 Sets heart on even Your ten words alone.
 Ah me, the world is made of graven stone!
 No wonder You with divine, astute care
 Tell that rare nation to remember their
 Promises to observe Your statutes' share.
 To read Your law is sweetness in the
 mouth,
 But when the meat comes pushing out the
 south,
 Rare is the soul that does not find it bare.

8 "And what great nation *is there* that
 Has *such* statutes and righteous *mat*
Of judgements as in all this law
 Which I set before you this day?
 9 "Only keep yourself in His awe,
 And diligently keep your way,
 Lest you forget the things your eyes
 Have seen, and lest they *meet demise*
 Departing from your heart to be
 All the days that your life *will see*.
 And teach them to your children and
 Your children's children *by command*,
 10 "Of the day you stood before YHWH
 Your God in Horeb, and when YHWH
 Said to me, 'Bring the folk to Me,
 And I will let them hear *and see*
 My words, that they may learn to fear
 Me all the days they shall appear

Upon the earth, and *that* they may
 Teach their children *in the right way*.'
 11 "And then it was that you came near
 And stood at the foot of the sheer
 Mountain, and the mountain with fire
 Burned to the sky up higher and higher,
 With shadow, cloud, and thick darkness.
 12 "And YHWH spoke to your *ear to bless*
 Out of the fire. You heard the sound
 Of the words, but saw no form *round*,
 You only *heard* a voice 13 "declare
 To you His covenant *and share*
 Which He commanded you to do,
 The ten commandments, *laws so few*,
 And He wrote them on two tablets
 Of stone, *if anyone forgets*.

It seems I too stand in the shadow of
 That mount and look on it in awe and love.
 I teach my children as though I had been
 In that vast throng to hear of right and sin.
 Perhaps I was in womb or loin of one
 Who became my progenitor when done.
 Who knows so well his genealogy?
 I know but less of what my eye can see
 Of You: no form meets form within the
 fire,
 No vision of Your being my desire.
 You are not in the thunder nor the flash
 Of lightning that comes on me in a crash.
 The still small voice in cantillation taught
 Becomes Your dwelling audible in thought.

14 "And YHWH commanded me that time
 To teach *in melody and rhyme*
 You statutes and judgements, that you
 Might observe them *and always do*
Them in the land which you cross to
 Possess. 15 "Take careful heed, for you
 Saw no form when YHWH spoke to you
 At Horeb out the midst of fire,
 16 "Lest you act corruptly, desire
 To make for yourselves *graven god*,
 A carved image in form *and prod*
 Of any figure: likeness of
 Male or female, 17 "the likeness of
 Any beast that's on earth *below*
 Or like a winged bird that may go
 Flying along the air above,
 18 "The likenesses of things that creep
 On the ground or likeness of deep
 Water fish there beneath the earth.

19 "And *take heed*, lest you *in your mirth*
Lift your eyes to the sky, and see
The sun, the moon, and stars *go free*,
All the host of the sky, you feel
Driven to worship them *a deal*
And serve them, which YHWH your God's
given

To all the folks under all heaven
As heritage. 20 "But YHWH has taken
You and brought you out *unforsaken*
Of the iron furnace, and out of
Egypt, to be His folk of love,
And His inheritance, as you
Are this day. 21 "Furthermore was YHWH
Angry with me and for your sakes,
And swore that I *for my mistakes*
Would not cross over Jordan's *stream*,
And I'd not enter that good land,
The one that YHWH your Alohim
Is giving you to have in hand.

I cannot make an image of Your form,
Beloved, because Sinai in thunder storm
Gave no clue of Yourself, yet this I know
There is no male nor female that can show,
The theriomorphic images relate
Nothing at all about You or Your fate.
No fish, no sun can fill the temple place
With form to model image to Your face.
Yet You are real beyond the formal weight
Of any of the things that You create.
More person and not less than those I think
Are persons most godly upon the brink.
Beloved, no thing can show comparison
With You because You are uniquely one.

22 "But I must die here in this land,
I must not cross, by His command,
Over the Jordan, but you shall
Cross over and take that good land.
23 "Take heed to yourselves, lest you shall
Forget the covenant of YHWH
Your God which He has made with you,
And make for yourselves a carved image
In the form of anything's *scrimmage*
Which YHWH your God's forbidden you.
24 "For YHWH your God's consuming fire,
And jealous El. 25 "When you desire
To beget children and their sons
Have grown old in the land *by tons*,
And act corruptly and they make
A carved image for the form's sake

Of anything, and do what's wrong
In the sight of YHWH your God *strong*
To provoke Him to anger, 26 "I
Call heaven and earth to witness by
You this day, that you soon will fly
Wholly from the land which you cross
Over the Jordan *without loss*
To possess, you will not prolong
Your days in it, but end your song.

You warned the people all along to make
No image or likenesses for Your sake.
Yet by the centuries that measure life
The institutions that arose in strife
Make images both in paint and in wood
And stone to express You as though they
could.
The churches and the mosques together
take
Theologies and so in concepts stake
More images than heathens in their wake.
Such images cannot be cut by knife
Or melted down to dross by their midwife.
How shall I shake corruption of that kind
From off the polished surface of my mind?
Beloved, You must lay hold and play the
fife.

27 "And YHWH will scatter you among
The nations, and you will *unstrung*
Be left few in number among
The nations where YHWH will drive you.
28 "And there you will serve gods *for*
YHWH,

The work of men's hands, wood and stone,
Which neither see nor hear *a tone*
Nor eat nor smell. 29 "But from there you
Will seek YHWH your God, and you will
Find *Him* if you seek Him *to fill*
With all your heart and all your soul.
30 "When you are in distress *or toll*,
And all these things come upon you
In the latter days, when you turn
To YHWH your God and *do not spurn*
His voice but obey, 31 'because YHWH
Your God *is* a merciful El,
He will not forsake you nor *well*
Destroy you, nor forget the pact
Of your fathers He swore *in fact*
To them. 32 "For ask now of the days
That are past and before your *plays*,
Since the day Alohim created

Man on the earth *and then instated*,
And *ask* from one end of the sky
To the other, whether great *try*
Like this has happened, or *the* like
Has been heard *on the sea or pike*.

Does this mean that You see and hear and
smell?
And yet You have no form that I can tell.
Without the need of eye You trace the
spell,
Without the need of ear You hear the bell.
Without the need of tongue You speak right
well
Above the thunders and the lightning's
knell.
Beloved, among the scattered I take flight
To find Your being above sun and light,
Beneath the depth of darkness of the night.
Beloved, among the scattered, I, Hittite,
Like Uriah and Zohar, join the fight,
Bowing to You, God of the free Semite,
And so my Celtic soul joys in Your might,
And comes to take its place in divine sight.

33 "Did *any* people *ever* hear
The voice of Alohim speak clear
Out of the midst of fire, as you
Have heard, and live *to tell the due*?
34 "Or did Alohim *ever* try
To go *and* take Himself a nation
From the midst of *another* nation,
By trials, signs, wonders, war, by might
And by an outstretched arm *in sight*,
And by great terrors, according
To all that YHWH your God did bring
For you in Egypt to your eyes?
35 "To you it was shown to be wise
And know that YHWH Himself is God,
There is none other besides Him.
36 "Out of heaven He was *not dim*
But let you hear His voice, that He
Might teach you, and upon earth He
Showed you His great fire, and you heard
His words out of the midst *inured*
Of fire. 37 "Since He loved your parents,
Therefore He chose their descendants
After them, and He brought you out
Of Egypt with His *seen* presence,
And with His mighty power *stout*,
38 "Driving out from before you nations
Greater and mightier in their *stations*

Than you, to bring you in, to give
You their land *as* a place to live,
As it is this day. 39 "Therefore know
This day, and in your heart bestow,
That YHWH Himself is Alohim
In heaven above and on the *gleam*
Of earth beneath, *there is no other*.
40 "You shall therefore keep *with your*
brother

His statutes and His commandments
Which I command you *common sense*
Today, that it may go well both
With you and with your children's *oath*
After you, and you may prolong
Your days in the land *of your song*
Which YHWH your God is giving you
For all time *where to live and do*."

Granted, Beloved, it was a thing unique
That You Yourself came down to take a
peek
At the atrocities Egyptians did
That year, to whom and what, and where
they hid.

And granted also You never spoke out
With thunder and lightning and with a
shout

Except on Sinai when You gave the ten.
But is that uniqueness blessing to men?
I myself would find more to thank You for
If You had led more people to the shore
Of freedom from oppression. Every state
Has those it freely crushes in the gate.
Why don't you speak again and raise a hand
To help the downtrodden in every land?

41 Then Moses set apart three cities
On this side of the Jordan *gritties*,
Toward the rising of the sun,
42 That the manslayer *when he's done*
Might flee there, one who kills his
neighbour,
But not on purpose nor with labour,
Without hating him in time past,
And that by fleeing to one *cast*
Of these cities, then he might live:
43 Bezer there in the wilderness
On the plateau for Reubenites,
Ramoth in Gilead to give
To the Gadites *a place to bless*,
And Golan in Bashan *in sights*
Of children of the Manassites.

Three cities on the river's other side
 Show Your concern for those who must
 abide
 Outside the land of Canaan. With respect,
 That shows this law is riddled with neglect
 For those who live on other continents.
 The way it is, it cannot make good sense
 Outside of Palestine. I do not say
 This in a mean or criticizing way,
 But rather to praise You that You design
 To make a local application fine
 Of Your will and Your law. I praise Your
 name
 That guidance is not limited to fame,
 But in villages and in times far flung
 There are still ways and means Your name
 is sung.

44 Now this *is* the law which Moses
 Set before Israel's folk *like kiss*.
 45 These *are* the testimonies and
 The statutes, and the judgements' *strand*
 Which Moses spoke to Israel's folk
 After they came from Egypt's *stroke*,
 46 On this side of the Jordan and
 In the vale opposite the land
 Of Beth Peor, and in the land
 Of Sihon king of Amorites,
 Who lived at Heshbon, whom *in fights*
 Moses and Israel's folk defeated
 After they came from Egypt *heated*.
 47 They took possession of his land
 And the land of Og king of Bashan,
 Two kings of Amoritic nation,
 Who *were* on this side of the Jordan,
 Toward sun's rising from the ford on
 48 From Aroer, there on the bank
 Of where the River Arnon *sank*,
 Up to Mount Sion (that is, Hermon),
 49 And all the plain toward the dawn
 From Jordan as far as the Sea
 Of the Arabah, *on the lee*
 Below the slopes of Pisgah's *knee*.

Deuteronomy 5

1 And Moses called all Israel, and
 Said to them "Hear, O Israel's *band*,
 The statutes and judgements which I
 Speak in your hearing *by the by*
 Today, that you may learn them and
 Be careful to observe them. 2 "YHWH

Our Alohim made promise true
 With us in Horeb. 3 "YHWH did not
 Make this covenant with our *sought*
 Fathers, but with us, those who *are*
 Here today, all of us who *are*
 Alive. 4 "YHWH talked with you face to
 Face on the mountain from where you
 Saw the fire. 5 "I stood between YHWH
 And you at that time, to declare
 To you the word of YHWH *and fair*,
 For you were afraid of the fire,
 And you did not climb the mount higher.

Beloved, Moses proclaims the covenant
 Was made with those who stood before his
 tent
 That day, and yet the most of them had not
 Been born when You came down to say
 Your lot.

My soul arises in joy at these words.
 It's likely no one today who eats curds
 And whey was not in the same way present
 At Sinai. Every son today must be
 Descendant of someone who stood there
 free:
 A Jew from tribe of Judah, or another
 From the ten tribes lost in the world to
 smother
 But really raised from the genetic pool
 That makes world's population something
 cool,
 Or from the mixed multitude for a brother.

He said 6 'I *am* YHWH your God who
 Brought you out of Egyptian *crew*,
 Out of the house of bondage. 7 'You
 Shall have no other gods before Me,
But always, every day adore Me.

When Moses recapitulates in sermon
 The ten commandments for the folk, not
 mermen,
 He starts with what You said on Mount
 Sinai:

"There is no god at all, at all but I."
 Whether a local message from Your heart,
 Or the expression of Your law at start
 Eternal and a universal word,
 The beginning is what remained and stirred
 All souls with consciousness, that You are
 One
 And only God eternal beyond sun.

Though I was not brought out of Egypt's
plot,
I still rise to the joy that You are not
A local deity, one person's vision,
But One now and forever, no revision.

8 'You'll not make for yourself carved
image,
Or any likeness *at the scrimmage*
Of anything in heaven above,
Or that's in the earth *that you love*
Beneath, or that's in water under
The earth, 9 you shall not bow, *by thunder*,
Down to them nor serve them. For I,
YHWH your God, *am jealous and sly*
El God, laying iniquity
Of the fathers on children's fee
No further than to third and fourth
Generations of those gone forth
In hate to Me, 10 but showing mercy
To thousands *in the controversy*,
To those who love Me and who keep
My commandments *faithful as sheep*.

Some say You chose a nation, only one,
Called Israel, and made that one Your son,
But I see here that mercy will extend
To everyone, no matter foe or friend,
Who love You and who keep Your holy
law.

Hittite or Celt, I join myself in awe
To You, Beloved, in love and my intention
To keep Your commands and without
prevention.

Though earth seems filled with violence, I
trust

Your promise is still good upon the dust
To limit all effects of evil to
Not more than generations three or few,
And every act of goodness multiply
Beyond the power of humankind to spy.

11 'You shall not take the name of YHWH
Your God in vain *in what you do*,
For YHWH will not hold *him* guiltless
Who takes His name in vain *to bless*.

I take Your name, Beloved, on song and lip
And reciting repeat it from the ship
Of my return confessing and repenting
To find Your burning love still unrelenting.
Let me not take Your name in vain nor lift

My soul to You for hope of grant or gift,
But only to increase Your praise in all
Things here created on the earthly ball.
Let me take Your name without any guilt,
So let my wicked deeds perish and wilt,
And only blessing and service receive
The power to go on living and relieve
The hopelessness that illusion's dark night
Would sweep upon a soul and a soul's
sight.

12 'Observe the Sabbath day, to keep
It holy, as YHWH your God *deep*
Commanded you. 13 Six days you shall
Labour and do all your *banal*
Work, 14 but the seventh day's the Sabbath
Of YHWH your God. *And so it grabbeth*
You not to do work: you, your son,
Nor your daughter, nor servant *Hun*,
Nor your maid, nor your ox, nor donkey,
Nor any of your cattle *honkey*,
Nor any stranger who's within
Your gates, that your servant *in bin*
And your maid may rest as you do.

15 And remember that you were too
A slave in Egypt's land, and YHWH
Your God brought you out from there by
A mighty hand and *warning cry*
And outstretched arm, and therefore
YHWH

Your God commanded you to keep
The Sabbath day *like faithful sheep*.

The Sabbath has a cosmic light to give,
But that's not all the light one has to live.
Although it is the gauge of grand creation,
It's also gauge of the single salvation
That Israel found from Egypt's
contemplation.

With meanings crossed and multiplied, it
goes

In shadow and in light through all the flows
Of human fate and mercenary woes.

Sign of creation, sign of Exodus,
The Sabbath still comes down without a
fuss,

But silently to bear a witness true
To every soul of the great work You do
Not only for a great folk and a nation,
But also to the lowly ones in station.

16 'Honour your father and your mother,

As YHWH your God's commanded you,
That your days may be long *with brother*,
And that it may be well with you
In the land which YHWH your God *true*
Gives you. 17 'You shall not kill *at all*.
18 'You'll not go in adultery's thrall.
19 'You shall not steal. 20 'You shall not
bear

False witness against neighbour *fair*.
21 'You'll not covet your neighbour's wife,
And not covet his house *for strife*,
His field, his servant, nor his maid,
His ox, his donkey, or *waylaid*
Anything that's your neighbour's *paid*.'

Who would find that the Decalogue is void
Because it differs here from that enjoyed
In Book of Exodus, do well to note
That this is but a free and noble quote,
And does not at all pretend to be what
Exactly You said on the tablets shut.
Therefore Moses says "As YHWH your
God has

Commanded you." That ought to well serve
as
An indication that quotation's free.
The same goes for Jesus' quoting freely
To mention only these last words and clear.
The implication's not, it would appear,
That he would abrogate all of the rest.
Deluded people still attempt their best.

22 "These words YHWH spoke to all of
you
Assembled, in the mountain coup
And from the middle of the fire,
The cloud, and the thick darkness' *ire*,
With loud voice, and then He added
No more. And He wrote them *in grid*
On two tablets of stone and gave
Them to me *who was as His slave*.

I note well that You spoke so all could
hear,
And with loud voice in each mother's son's
ear.

You did not add nor did you subtract from
What You spoke on the mountain and in
sum.

You wrote it all down on tablets of stone,
Two tablets with six sides each in the cone,

So that on twelve sides all the words were
written,
With every trait well graved and finely
bitten.

The hearing and the seeing of Your word
Was clear enough that two million inured
Could well bear witness of the things they
heard

With nothing to make disagreement there.
Beloved, I find Your words not only fair,
But marvellous in every part and share,
So nothing in the bright world can
compare.

23 "So it was, when you heard the voice
From the midst of the darkness *choice*,
While the mountain burned with the fire,
That you came near me *with desire*,
All the heads of your tribes and your
Elders. 24 "And you told me the score:
'Surely YHWH our Alohims shown
Us His glory and greatness *known*,
And we have heard His voice from fire.
We've seen this day that God *is higher*
And speaks with man, yet he *still* lives.
25 'Now why should we die *fugitives*?

For this great fire will consume us,
If we hear the voice *thunderous*
Of YHWH our God anymore *here*,
Then we shall die *and all in fear*.
26 'For who *is there* of all flesh who
Has heard the voice of Alohims
The Living speaking from the *cue*
In middle of the fire to seem,
As we *have*, and lived? 27 'You go near
And hear everything *in your ear*
That YHWH our Alohims may say,
And tell us everything *one day*
That YHWH our Alohims tells you,
And we will hear and we will do.'

28 "Then YHWH heard the voice of your
words

When you spoke to me, *frightened birds*,
And YHWH said to me 'I have heard
The voice of this *frail* people's word
Which they have spoken to you. They
Are right *in* all they've had to say.

29 'Oh, that they always had such heart
In them that they would fear My *part*
And keep all My commandments' *art*,
That it might be well with them and
With their children for time to stand!

30 'Go and say to them, "Return to Your tents then." 31 'But now as for you, Stand here by Me, and I will speak To you all the commands *you seek*, The statutes, and the judgements you Shall teach them, that they may observe *Them* in the land which I shall serve Them to possess.' 32 "Therefore you shall Be careful to *be punctual*

To do as YHWH your Alohim Has commanded you, do not deem To turn aside to the right hand Or to the left *from His command*.

33 "You'll walk in all the ways which YHWH

Your Alohim's commanded you, That you may live and *it may be* Well with you, and *that* you may see Your days prolong in the land you Shall possess *gear and trim and crew*.

Beloved, though I was not among the few Who stood at Jordan to see what You do And hear Your words in law and comfort and

In blessing and in curse upon command, Though I am not descended from that crew Nor bear the name of Israelite and true, Still I would that there might be in me too A heart to keep Your law and faithfully Obey Your ten commandments as one free Who knows no will nor way but Yours alone.

I set aside the gods of light and stone, The idol carved in massive plastic ware As well as idols that are made in air. Oh that such heart in me might come to bear!

Deuteronomy 6

1 "Now this *is* the commandment, *and These are* the statutes *by command* And judgements YHWH your Alohim Has commanded to be your dream, That you may keep *them* in the land Which you are crossing over to Hold and have for keeps, 2 "and that you May fear YHWH your Alohim, to Keep all His statutes and commands Which I command you *on the sands*, You and your son and your grandson, All the days of your life *till done*,

And that your days may still prolong.

3 "So hear, O Israel, *the song* And be careful to keep *it long*, That it may be well with you, and That you may increase and be grand As YHWH God of your fathers planned And promised to you such a land Flowing milk and honey along.

I hear, Beloved, though Israel's not my name,

I hear Your song in cantillation's fame, I hear Your words repeated and recited In sounds that must illuminate benighted Recesses of my soul. Beloved, I hear.

I hear and hearing I would come as near To You as You Yourself have come to me. Closer than heart vein, closer than the tree That arcs between the eyes to set me free From sight and faith. I hear, Beloved, Your game

And rush to Youward and make out my claim

To nothing by Your Youness without shame.

And so I sip the milk and honey dressed In nectars sweet, refreshing, and twice blessed.

4 "Hear, Prince of God! YHWH's Alohim, Our Judge exalted and supreme, YHWH *is* One, *not three in a dream*.

5 And you'll love YHWH your Alohim With all your heart and all your soul And all your might *for self control*.

Beloved, I thank you for undeserved name Of Israel in Prince of God's fair claim. I thank you that You are the Judge supreme And called Allah, Aloah, Alohim. But greater gift has never entered mind Than the mere oneness of Your being's kind.

Though names are full and fancy and find place

To make a stumbling block for every race As well as road to find Your divine face, You are one, one alone beyond all time. You are one in both rhythm and the rhyme. And being one instead of two or three Love is perfected impartiality.

How many angels still dance on the dime!

6 "And these words which I command you
Today shall be in your heart's *way*.

7 "You shall teach them diligently
To your children, and talk *freely*
Of them when you sit in your house,
When you walk by the way *or grouse*,
When you lie down, and when you rise.

8 "You shall bind them as a sign *wise*
Upon your hand, and they shall be
As frontlets between where you see.

9 "You shall write them on the doorposts
Of your house and on your gateposts.

10 "So it shall be, when YHWH your God
Brings you into the land *and sod*
Of which He swore your fathers *wake up*,
To Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob,

To give you large and fancy cities
Which you did not build, *more the pities*,

11 "And houses full of all good things,
Which you did not fill, *but their kings*,
And wells hewn out you did not dig,
Vineyards and olive trees which sprig
You did not plant, when you have eaten

And are satisfied, 12 "*then unbeaten*,
Beware, lest you forget YHWH who
Brought you out of Egyptian land,
From house of bondage's command
To love, serve and obey anew.

13 "You shall fear YHWH your God and
serve,

And in His name take oaths' *reserve*.

14 "You'll not go after other gods,
The gods of the folk *and their rods*
Who are all around you 15 'for YHWH
Your God's a jealous El with you,
Lest YHWH your God's wrath be aroused
Against you and destroy you from
The face of the earth *whence you come*.

16 "You'll not tempt YHWH your God as
you
Tempted *Him* in Massah *with crew*.

If I had to eat only what I plant
I might have to sit starving and not rant
As I do now with belly full and great
Beads of fat shining on my balding pate.
Vineyard and olive You promised the
crowd

Who put away false gods and the allowed
By public sentiment and scientific
College of Baalian studies that's terrific.

I eat what I did not plant in my plot,
The milkweed and the dandelion as taught,
The nettle, lady's mantle and a score
Of other things unplanted what is more.
Oh yes, the best of all, lamb's quarter
chopped
And cooked and seasoned well before I
stopped.

17 "You'll diligently keep the laws
Of YHWH your God *in every clause*,
His testimonies, and statutes
Which He has set for your pursuits.

18 "And you shall do *what's* right and good
In the sight of YHWH, *as you should*,
That it may be well with you, and
That you may go possess the land
Of goodness which YHWH swore to your
Fathers, 19 "to cast out all of your
Enemies from before you, as
YHWH has spoken, *indeed He has*.

What good fortune met those who stood to
hear

The word on Jordan's banks, perhaps with
fear.

You promise to cast out the enemy.
Wherever I look in the place I flee
I find that no one is cast out for me.
Perhaps that only means idolater
That flourishes today to raid the fer
Is not my enemy at all, but friend.
Who knows, Beloved, what You will bill
and send?

It's better far, I trow, to have no foe
Than see them cast out from you head and
toe.

So I look not on that good fortune spent
On ancient people when and where they
went.

20 "When your son asks in time to come,
Saying 'What *is the meaning's sum*
Of the testimonies, statutes,
And the judgements *along with suits*
Which YHWH our God's commanded
you?'

21 "Then you shall say to your son true
'We were slaves of Egyptian Pharaoh,
And YHWH brought us out *from the*
narrow

Of Egypt with a mighty hand,

22 'And YHWH showed signs and wonders
too

Before our eyes, great and severe,
Against Egypt *they did appear*,
And Pharaoh, all his house and crew.
23 'Then He brought us up out from there,
That He might bring us in, to share
With us the land of which He swore
To our fathers. 24 'And YHWH *of yore*
Commanded us to observe all
These statutes, to fear YHWH our God,
For our good always *at His call*,
That He might preserve on the sod
All us alive, as on this day.
25 'Then it will be a righteous way
For us, if we are careful to
Observe all these commandments *true*
Before YHWH our God, as He has
Commanded us, indeed He has.'

Perhaps I've not been saved as they once
were.

I notice people still keep coughing fur
To tell me I need saving. Still I think
That Egypt's a fine place to buy a drink,
And the Nile on an evening is a blessing
In quietness below the tombs confessing
Three thousand years of life and barter on
The market and the field now fresh at
dawn.

They still pick up their chickens in the way
The painted pyramidal pictures say.
Perhaps the soft and kindly speech reveals
Idolatry is gone and the time heals.
In any case, Beloved, I meet You fair
In Egypt on the crowded streets and bare.

Deuteronomy 7

1 "When YHWH your God brings you into
The land which you go to possess,
And has cast out nations for you,
The Hittites, Girgashites, *the mess*
Of Amorites and Canaanites
And Perizzites and the Hivites
And Jebusites, all seven nations
Greater and mightier *in their stations*
Than you, 2 "and when YHWH your God
gives
Them over to you, *as He lives*,
You'll conquer them *and* utterly
Destroy them. You shall make no *free*
Treaty with them nor show mercy.

3 "Nor shall you marry them. You'll not
Give daughter to their son *besot*,
Nor take their daughter for your son.
4 "For they'll turn your sons *once begun*
Away from following Me, to serve
Other gods, YHWH's wrath will not swerve
From against you in quick destruction.
5 "But thus you'll deal with their seduction:
You shall destroy their altars, and
Break down their *sacred pillars' stand*,
And cut down their wood images,
Burn with fire their carved images.

I once took down a cross where I had right
Of jurisdiction in the public sight,
And found it did not help my humble
plight,
But raised a storm of protest in the night.
I never had the courage to go in
And slay the living statues for their sin,
And crush their marble bones to score and
dust.

I must amend my ways, I truly must.
The problem is You do not make a land
Secure today for those who keep command
To letter and to spirit and in hand
Take up the bludgeon to strike down the
great.
And so I must, like Daniel, bow to fate
And answer to a heathen name and state.

6 "For you're a holy folk to YHWH
Your God, YHWH your God's chosen you
To be a people for Himself,
A special treasure *on the shelf*
Above all the folk on the earth.
7 "YHWH did not set His love *for worth*
On you nor choose you because you
Were more in number than a few
Of any other people, you
Were least of all folks, 8 "but because
YHWH has loved you, and *yet* because
He would keep the oath which He swore
To your fathers *on every score*,
YHWH's brought you out with mighty
hand,
And redeemed you from house *and land*
Of bondage, and from Pharaoh's hand,
The king of Egypt. 9 "Therefore know
That YHWH your God, He's Alohim,
The faithful El God who will show
That He keeps covenant and *stream*

Of mercy over generations
 In thousands with those who love Him
 And keep His statutes *to the brim*,
 10 "And He repays those who hate Him
 To their face, to destroy them. He
 Will not be slack with him who's free
 In hate to Him, He will repay
 Him to his face. 11 "Therefore you'll *stay*
 To keep the commandment, the laws,
 And the judgements *in every clause*
 Which I command to you today,
 To observe them *in every way*.

Not having been brought out of Egypt's
 land
 I still know that You're God on every hand.
 There is no breath of wind but whispers
 fine
 Your name of Huu beyond the golden
 shrine.
 While some may bow before the public tale
 Because its sight is great and shining mail,
 I bow to the unseen and whispered one
 Who is only God when all's said and done.
 Because I know that You are God alone,
 Supreme Reality harder than stone,
 And softer than the voice of hummingbird,
 Therefore my heart again once more is
 stirred
 To follow Your commandments to the
 word,
 Even if that makes me to be a drone.

Week 46

12 "Then it shall come to pass, because
 You listen to these judgements' *laws*,
 And keep and do them, that YHWH your
 God will keep with you covenant
 And the mercy of which He swore
 To your fathers *by desert tent*.
 13 "And He will love you and bless you
 And multiply you, He'll be true
 Also to bless fruit of your womb
 And the fruit of your land *and room*,
 Your grain and your new grape juice and
 Your oil, the increase *on your land*
 Of cattle and your flocks' offspring,
 In the land to which He did bring
 You as to your fathers He swore.
 14 "You shall be blessed above *and more*
 Than all peoples, there shall not be
 A male or female barrenly

Among you or among your stock.
 15 "And YHWH will take away in dock
 All your sickness, and will afflict
 You with none of the grossly tricked
 Diseases of Egypt which you
 Have known, but will lay *them* on all
 Those who hate you *and wish you'd fall*.

The plague most visible for disease on
 The land of Egypt, if myself have drawn
 The right conclusion, is the dying they
 Suffer for what they get when they essay
 To swim in the polluted Nile. Bilharzy
 Is not confined indeed to feeling darcy
 In Egypt, but is found in tropical
 Waters around the world. Is this banal
 Or Your response to those on whom You
 lay
 The grand diseases of Egypt for pay?
 If Israel was separated from
 Contaminated waters when they come
 From Egypt, was their health not then
 The natural effect of being men?

16 "And you shall destroy all the folk
 Whom YHWH your Alohim once spoke
 To deliver over to you,
 Your eye shall have no pity *due*
 On them, nor shall you serve their gods,
 For that's your snare *upon the sods*.

Beloved, let me not serve the other gods
 That ruled the ones You determined were
 clods.

Let me not pity Baal and just because
 The sun evaporating lakes is laws
 Both natural and sane for making rain.
 Baal's but scientific and not vain.
 Still I retain the countrified approach
 And say that You, Beloved, though not in
 coach

Upon the roads of heaven, still bring dew
 And rain on earth by what You love and
 do.

Supreme Reality well fits the bill
 Until I see personality will
 Not disappear behind the longer words.
 Human defining is just for the birds.

17 "If you should say within your heart,
 'These nations have a greater part
 Than I, how can I put them out?'

18 "You shall not be afraid *nor doubt*,
 You shall remember well what YHWH
 Your God did to Pharaoh and to
 All Egypt: 19 "The great trials which your
 Eyes saw, the signs and wonders' *score*,
 The mighty hand and outstretched arm,
 By which YHWH your God *without harm*
To you brought you out. So shall YHWH
 Your God do to all the folk whom
 You fear *will lead you into doom*.
 20 "Moreover YHWH your God will send
 The hornet among them to tend
 Those who are left, who hide from you,
 Till they're destroyed. 21 "You shall not be
 Afraid of them, for YHWH your God,
 The great and awesome El's with you.
 22 "And YHWH your God will
wonderfully
 Drive out those nations *with a rod*
 Before you little at a time,
 You'll not be able to destroy
 Them at once *in a single climb*,
 Lest the beasts of the field employ
 To be *too* numerous for you.
 23 "But YHWH your God will give to you
These peoples, and inflict defeat
 Upon them until they retreat.
 24 "And He will deliver their kings
 Into your hand, and you'll destroy
 Their name from under heaven's *things*,
 No one shall be able *with ploy*
 To stand against you until you
 Have destroyed them *and all their crew*.
 25 "You shall burn the carved images
 Of their gods with fire *that rages*,
 You'll not covet silver or gold
 On them, nor take *it* in your hold,
 Lest you be snared by it, for it
Is abomination *unfit*
 To YHWH your God. 26 "Nor shall you
 bring
 Any abomination's *thing*
 Into your house, lest you be doomed
 To a destruction *as presumed*.
 You'll wholly detest and abhor
 The accursed *idol* evermore.

Beloved, I call the hornets down in swarm
 On every church decked out with idols
 warm
 Or cool to touch, and every synagogue
 If such exist where images may clog

The sacred aisles, and every temple where
 Stone idols and the nightly rodents share
 The food of sacrifice. Beloved I call
 The hornets, yes, the hornets to the ball
 And banquet of the Lamb. If I lift up
 A hand against idolatry my cup
 Will surely overflow with prison time.
 I can destroy idolatry in rhyme
 And go no further. That's why in my lurch
 I call down graceful hornets on the church.

Deuteronomy 8

1 "Every command which I command
 You today you must understand
 To be careful to observe it,
 That you may live and multiply,
 And go in and possess the land
 Of which YHWH swore *to make a gift*
To your fathers come by and by.
 2 "And you shall remember that YHWH
 Your God led you all the way through
 These forty years in wilderness,
 To humble you, test you, *and bless*,
 To know what *was* within your heart,
 Whether you would keep for your part
 His commandments or not. 3 "So He
 Humbled you, let you hungrily
 Wander, and fed you with *the free*
 Manna which you did not know nor
 Did your fathers know *on that score*,
 That He might make you know that man
 Shall not live by mere bread by plan,
 But man lives by every *word* that
 Proceeds from YHWH's mouth *where He*
sat.
 4 "Your clothing did not wear out, nor
 Did your foot hurt forty years' score.
 5 "You should know in your heart that as
 A man chastens the son he has,
 So YHWH your God chastens you too.
 6 "Therefore you shall keep *as your due*
 The commandments of your God YHWH,
 To walk in His ways and fear Him.
 7 "For YHWH your God, *who is not grim*,
 Is bringing you to a good land,
 A land of brooks of water *spanned*,
 Of fountains and springs, that flow out
 Of valleys and hills *with a shout*,
 8 "A land of wheat, barley, of vines
 And fig trees where pomegranate *shines*,
 A land of olive oil and honey,
 9 "A land in which you *without money*

Will eat bread without scarcity,
In which you will lack nothing *free*,
A land whose stones *are* iron and out
Of whose hills copper's dug about.

Beloved, though my clothes wear out on
my back,

It's true that without money I've no lack,
But as a poor dervish I take my due
In replacements from the flea market's
queue.

My passage through the wilderness of fine
And futuristic houses was the wine
To show You whether I would be true to
The commandments that You told me to
do.

The glut of manna wasted on the dew
Was sent to show me that Your providence
Was revelation that Your words made
sense.

My mouth runs with honey and olive oil
Despite my wandering lack of honest toil.
My hands and feet wrinkle the summer
soil.

10 "When you have eaten and are full,
Then you shall bless YHWH your God's
pull

For the good land He's given you.

11 "Beware you do not forget YHWH
Your God, not keeping His commands,
His judgements, and His statute *bands*
Which I command to you today
To tell you how to walk the way,

12 "Lest *when* you've eaten and are full,
And have built houses beautiful
And live *in them*, 13 "*and when* your herds
And your flocks multiply *like birds*,

And your silver and gold increased,
And all you have grows great from least,
14 "And when your heart is lifted up,
And you forget YHWH your God's *cup*

Who brought you out of Egypt's land,
From the house of bondage *to stand*,
15 "Who led you through that great and
grand

Terror of wilderness, *in which*
Were fiery serpents *in the ditch*
And scorpions and thirsty land
Where there was no water, who brought
Water for you out of the taught
Flint rock, 16 "who fed you in the way

Of the desert with manna *spray*,
Of which your fathers did not know,
That He might humble you and show
By testing you, to do you good
In the end *to do as you should*,
17 "Then you say in your heart, 'My power
And my own hand's might in this hour
Have gained me this wealth *in a shower*.'

Indeed, Beloved, I do not forget eating
Despite the rush of people, time and
meeting,

Nor do I fail to pause upon the sill
Of Sabbath if not other times to fill
My heart and tongue and voice with
blessing of

Your names found hidden in all that I love.
I say my power and might have done the
this

And that in my life filled with pain and
bliss,

But there is no myness that is not Yours
Who work Your will in all the sacred
doors.

The blessing of Your name and calling Huu
Is never far from my breath and my stew.
I tread the serpents and the dry ground's
strength

To find food unknown to my fathers'
length.

18 "And you'll remember YHWH your
God,

For *it is* He who *on the sod*
Gives you the power to get *your* wealth,
That He may establish *in stealth*
His covenant which He swore to
Your fathers, as this day *with you*.

19 "Then it shall be by any means,
If you forget YHWH your God's *scenes*,
And follow other gods, and serve
Them and worship them *on a swerve*,
I witness against you this day
That you'll surely perish *and pay*.

20 "As the nations which YHWH destroys
Before you, so you *and your joys*
Shall perish, because you would not
Be obedient to the voice *taught*
Of YHWH your God *sought or unsought*.

If I remember or if I forget,

Your words are clear that You have surely
set
My heart to perform to my sodden tongue
Remembrance of Your names on ladder's
rung
And never to forget what You command
To those who live and breathe upon the
land.

Remembering, forgetting not the tale
That rises from my graceless, tuneless wail,
Builds You a temple that must sure avail
Against the gods the nations do not fail
To find and serve with public celebration.
Beloved, let me not be one of that nation,
That I might not be destroyed in the void
Of wordlessness, remembrances destroyed.

Deuteronomy 9

1 "Hear, O Israel: You *are* to cross
Over Jordan today, and toss
Yourselves to dispossess the nations
Greater and mightier *in their stations*
Than you yourself, and cities great
And fortified up to the gate
Of heaven, 2 "a people great and tall,
The sons of Anakim *not small*,
Whom you know, and of *whom* you heard
'Who can stand before the son's *turd*
Of Anak?' 3 "Therefore understand
Today that YHWH your God's *at hand*,
And He who goes over before
You *is* consuming fire *in store*.
He will destroy them and bring them
Down before you, *in stratagem*
You shall drive them out and destroy
Them quickly, as YHWH has *with joy*
Said to you. 4 "Do not think in heart,
After YHWH your God's *famous part*
To cast them out before you, saying
'Because of my righteousness *staying*
YHWH has brought me in to possess
This land', but *it's* the wickedness
Of these nations *that* YHWH is driving
Them out before you *in their striving*.
5 "*It's* not because your righteousness
Or uprightness of heart *to bless*
Is great that you go to possess
Their land, but *it's* for wickedness
Of these nations *that* YHWH your God
Drives them out from before your *rod*,
And that He may fulfil the word

Which YHWH swore to your fathers
spurred,
To Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.
6 "Therefore *now* understand *and wake up*
That YHWH your God's not giving you
This good land to possess since you
Are righteous, for you *are* stiff-necked
A people *stubborn to neglect*.

O my Beloved, I know that You step down
Into the dry bed of the Jordan brown
Before me as a great consuming fire.
Turn once again to me is my desire
And burn away the dross of my own will,
Delusive figments that attend me still,
And purge me of idolatry as I
Set on the land of Canaan eager eye.
If You destroy in Canaan every stone
That's worshipped, even every tinkling
bone
That casts a spell and prophecy on night,
Then You may burn the willing and the
light
Sacrifice of my rising spark before
The crossing of the Jordan and the gore.

Beloved, if not for righteousness You gave
The land of Canaan to the former slave,
But for the punishment of those who there
Bowed knee to Baal and took a faithful
care
To observe that the rain came from the sun
Bearing upon the sea and clouds to run,
Do You relate to me with the same fate?
The lands of love You bring me to are
great,
But not taken from those who bow in state,
Nor do they deprive any of the wealth
They have gained honestly or by their
stealth.
No one is punished by the table spread
Where You and I together are well fed,
And who knows whether righteousness is
bread?

7 "Remember! And do not forget
How you provoked YHWH your God *set*
To wrath there in the wilderness.
From the day that you left the land
Of Egypt *under Moses' hand*
Until you came into this place,
You've been rebellious to YHWH's face.

8 "Also in Horeb you provoked
 YHWH to wrath, so YHWH nearly croaked
 With anger to have destroyed you.
 9 "When I went up the mountain to
 Receive the tablets of stone *due*,
 The tablets of the covenant
 Which YHWH made with you *to present*,
 I stayed on the mount forty days
 And forty nights. I did not graze
 Nor drink water *before sunset*.
 10 "Then YHWH delivered me to get
 Two tablets of stone written by
 Alohim's finger *on the sly*,
 And on them *were* all the words which
 YHWH had spoken to you *in pitch*
 On the mountain and from the fire
 In the day of assembly's choir.

Ah my Beloved, like Moses I have fasted
 The forty days as long as I too lasted,
 And I too climbed a lonely mountain here
 While fleeing from both happiness and
 fear,
 And I too heard Your voice in cantillation
 Recite the Decalogue to Your own nation,
 And I too stretched out willing hands to
 touch
 The sapphire tablets on which written much
 Was there to fill my heart with gratitude
 That You revealed Your will as well as
 food.
 Forgive, Beloved, that daily in Your sight
 I forget my remembering to recite
 The shining words. I every day anew
 And as the first time bathe myself in You.

Remember! You said to the crowd that day,
 And blamed them for the craven, callous
 way
 They had provoked you in the desert land.
 Yet these were only children of that band
 That stood by Sinai's mount to hear Your
 voice.
 Do You hold children to account for
 choice?
 I think not. And if so, then all are bound
 To the remembering of thunder's sound
 On Sinai, though not present on the ground.
 And all are among those who provoked
 You.
 Ah my Beloved, I must accept my due.
 I too forget Your word despite the times

I recite it each day, each week in rhymes.
 Forgive my provoking in times past, do.

11 "It came to pass then at the end
 Of forty days and nights *to spend*,
 That YHWH gave me the tablets two
 Of stone, of covenant *to do*.
 12 "Then YHWH said to me, 'Get up, go
 Down quickly from here, behold, lo
 Your people whom you brought out of
 Egypt corruptly lost their love,
 They have quickly turned aside from
 The way which I told them to come,
 And made themselves image in mould,
 A molten idol *made of gold*.'
 13 "Furthermore YHWH spoke to me,
 saying

'I've seen this people *without slaying*,
 And truly they're a stiff-necked lot.
 14 'Let Me alone, that I may plot
 Their destruction now, I may blot
 Out their name from beneath the sky,
 And I'll make of you by and by
 A nation mightier and great,
 Than they *are in their sinful state*.'
 15 "So I turned and came down the mount,
 And the mountain burned like a fount
 Of fire, and the two tablets of
 The covenant *of your God's love*
 Were in my two hands. 16 "And I looked,
 And indeed, you had sinned *and cooked*
 Against YHWH your God, and had made
 For yourselves a molten calf *strayed*!
 You had turned aside quickly from
 The way which YHWH told you to come.

Because the sun-disk set between the horns
 Of bovine in the late Egyptian bourns
 Seemed so like worship of You, my
 Beloved,
 The people thought it right to take
 unloved
 The same symbols again. It was not gold
 They worshipped nor the calf of old,
 But the god that stood there behind the
 light,
 So like the god of cloud of fire by night.
 What's wrong with dancing to a catchy tune
 And frolicking in honour of the June?
 If You Yourself cannot distinguish twixt
 Idolatry and merely symbol fixed,
 Who am I then to set up shrine or thought

Beyond the command You Yourself have wrought?

17 "I took the two tablets and threw
Them out of my two hands *at you*
And broke them *there* before your eyes.
18 "And I fell down before YHWH's *eyes*,
As at the first, forty days and
Forty nights, I ate not *in hand*
Bread nor drank water, because your
Sin which you committed *was sore*
In doing wickedly in sight
Of YHWH, to provoke Him *with right*
To anger. 19 "For I was afraid
Of the anger and hot *dismayed*
Displeasure with which YHWH was made
Angry with you, to destroy you.
But YHWH listened to my prayer's hue
At that time also. 20 "And YHWH was
Very angry with Aaron 's *claws*
And would have destroyed him, so I
Prayed for Aaron also *foreby*.

The very elect and priest by Your hand
Was fooled to think the ecumenic stand
Was right, and so accepted golden band
And the rock music of the heathen land
As part and parcel of the worship due
To You alone, Beloved, with pagan cue.
The right and duty of the voice raised high
In intercession is a thing and cry
That You, Beloved, love to hear in my
prayer.
And so I plead upon the desert air
For every heathen church and synagogue
As well as mosque and the retiring bog.
Who prays for all prays for his own soul
best
And finds the path to You and to Your rest.

21 "Then I took your sin, and the calf
Which you had made *too wrong by half*,
And burned it with fire and crushed it
And ground it very small *and fit*,
Until it was as fine as dust,
Into the brook I threw its dust,
The brook that came down from the mount.
22 "Also at Taberah, Massah
And Kibroth *which is* Hattaavah
You provoked YHWH to wrath. 23
"Likewise,
When YHWH sent you *up to arise*

From Kadesh Barnea *to count*,
Saying 'Go up, possess the land
Which I have given you *in hand*,'
Then you rebelled against command
Of YHWH your God, and you did not
Believe Him nor obey His plot.

If only the rebellious heart could take
The purging that the gold and silver make
By grinding and by casting in the fire.
But human hearts are hardened by desire
And fear, and so despite the vision here
At Sinai, still I hesitate and stand,
And such a stopping before Your command
Is a rebellion on the borderland
Of glory. Even glory at my face
Of Sinai dark and burning in its grace
Is not enough to sink rebellion down.
I lay a hand unthinking on Your crown,
Such are the veils that shadow earth and all.
And then I hear again Your anguished call.

24 "You've been rebellious against YHWH
From the first day that I knew you.
25 "Thus I prostrated before YHWH,
Forty days and forty nights I
Kept prostrating, because YHWH's cry
Had said that He would destroy you.
26 "Therefore I prayed to YHWH, and said
'O Lord YHWH, don't destroy Your led
People and Your inheritance
Whom You have redeemed through the
stance
Of Your greatness, whom You have
brought
Out of Egypt mightily wrought.
27 'Remember Your slaves, Abraham,
Isaac, and Jacob *for a lamb*,
Do not look on the stubbornness
Of this people, or wickedness
Or their sin, 28 'lest the land from which
You brought us should say *at the pitch*,
"Because YHWH could not bring them out
To the land He'd promised *with shout*,
And because He hated them, He
Has brought them out to kill them, *see*,
In the desert." 29 'Yet *they're* Your folk,
Inheritance, of whom You spoke
To bring them out by mighty power
And by Your outstretched arm *an hour*.'

Who fast the forty days prostrate in prayer

And intercede for the world everywhere.
 That is the task of dervish early, late
 To bow in intercession at the gate.
 Who fast the forty days remember those
 Who early on in hope and faith once chose
 Your faith, the faith of Abraham and still
 Of Isaac, Ishmael, Jacob and the bill
 Of David whose voice called the songbirds
 down
 To sing Your praises in the field and town.
 No matter what You do, Beloved, I know
 The late and early will have place to go,
 And words to replicate against Your show,
 Meet it with smiling face or even frown.

Deuteronomy 10

1 "At that time YHWH said to me, 'Hew
 For yourself two tablets *on cue*
 Of stone like the first, and come up
 To Me on the mountain *to sup*
 And make yourself an ark of wood.
 2 'And I will write the words I should
 On the tablets, the same that were
 On the first tablets, which you broke,
 And you shall put them *not to stir*
 In the ark.' 3 "So I made *in stroke*
 An ark of acacia wood, hewed
 Two tablets of stone like the first,
 And went up the mountain imbued
 With the two tablets *as I durst*.

Not only tables of stone that were broken
 Had to be replaced but also in token
 The ark of acacia wood hewed and laid
 With gold below angelic colonnade.
 But now the gold is missing, at a stroke
 Of divine wrath, gold's set apart like coke.
 A simple wooden box replaces what
 Could be turned to idolatry by slut.
 The breathless, sexless, undevouring flesh
 Of divine gold that cannot drink the fresh
 Water is shut out from divine grace' store.
 Its untarnishing eternity's score
 Is meaningless, dumb and sightless and free
 Of hearing the twisting cacophony.

4 "And He wrote on the tablets by
 The first writing *still in the sky*,
 The ten commandments, which YHWH'd
 spoken
 To you in the mount *as a token*
 From the midst of the fire the day

Of the assembly, and YHWH's way
 Was to give them to me. 5 "I turned
 And came down from the mountain *burned*,
 And put the tablets in the ark
 Which I had made, and there they park,
 Just as YHWH had commanded me."
 6 Now Israel's folk essayed to flee
 From Bene Jaakan's springs to go
 To Moserah, where Aaron died,
 And where he was buried *in show*,
 And Eleazar his son *tried*
 Ministered as priest in his stead.
 7 From there they journeyed on *as led*
 To Gudgodah, and from that place
 Went to Jotbathah, land where race
 Rivers of water. 8 At that time
 YHWH separated *from the crime*
 The tribe of Levi set to bear
 The ark of covenant of YHWH,
 To stand before YHWH to serve there
 And bless in His name as they do
 To this day. 9 Therefore Levi's got
 No portion nor a country plot
 With his brothers, YHWH *is* his lot,
 Just as YHWH your God promised him.
 10 "As at the first time *on the limb*,
 I stayed in the mountain forty
 Days and forty nights, YHWH heard me
 Also at that time, *and* YHWH chose
 Not to destroy you *or dispose*.
 11 "YHWH said to me 'Get up, begin
 Your trip before the folk *to win*,
 That they may enter and possess
 The land which I swore to address
 To their fathers to give to them,
Hills, valleys all from head to hem.'

Some say the second law You wrote again
 Upon the tablets for women and men
 Was different, a burning law, because
 They could not accept of Your gracious
 laws.
 Such is not so. Here it is written fast
 The second table was just like the last.
 But Levi is set out after their claim
 To honour despite golden calf Your name,
 To honour still and evermore the same.
 The difference is that You trust men less,
 And leave them not to hear and read and
 guess,
 But set apart a few to recite more

And more Your blessed name against the
score
Of heathendom in sparkling and chaste
dress.

12 "And now, Israel, what does YHWH
Your Alohim require of you,
But to fear YHWH your God, to walk
In all His ways and love His stock,
Serve YHWH your God with all your heart,
With all your soul, 13 "*and for your part*
To keep the commandments of YHWH
And His statutes *in what you do*
Which I commanded you today
For your good *and for your mainstay?*
14 "Lo heaven and highest heavens belong
To YHWH your God, *also the song*
Of the earth with all that's in it.
15 "YHWH delighted only in fit,
Your fathers, to love them, and He
Chose their descendants *faithfully*
After them, you above all folk,
As it is this day, as He spoke.
16 "So circumcise your heart's foreskin,
And be stiff-necked no more *in sin.*

Beloved, You do require a thing of men,
To fear You and keep Your
commandments when
All others say the thing to do is find
A church that's right, or in a greater bind,
A banquet and a eucharist in state
That has the real presence and the fate
Of gods a-dying and arising up
To meet the pagan ritual and cup
In bread and wine. Beloved, You do require
According to Your word humble desire
To meet You, yes, in every drink and meal
That You provide for men and women's
weal,
But more and ever that I shall obey
What You command in love and duty's
way.

17 "For YHWH your God *is* God of gods
And Lord of lords, great El whose rods
Are mighty and awesome, who shows
No partiality's foreclose
Nor takes a bribe. 18 "In justice He
Regards the fatherless and the
Widow, and loves the stranger *there,*
Giving him food and clothes *to wear.*

19 "Therefore love the stranger, for you
Were strangers in Egypt's land's *crew.*

True faith is not the sharing of a crust
Or sip of wine in churches of no dust,
But in the sharing of a real must
With fatherless and widow in their need
And foreigner and refugee whose lead
Has put them in a far off and strange land.
True faith is not performing the command
Of rite and ritual but jousting bribe
That benefits the kin or wealthy tribe
Against the right and justice of the poor
Or those who might be strangers, yet are
sure
Their case is firm. Beloved, give me the
true
Faith in the things that I am called to do.

20 "You shall fear YHWH your God, you'll
serve
Him, and from Him you shall not swerve,
But hold fast, take oaths in His name.
21 "He *is* your praise, and He's your *fame,*
God, who has done for you these great
And awesome things which your eyes sate.
22 "Your fathers went down to Egypt
Seventy persons in there *slipped,*
Now YHWH your Alohim has made
You as stars of the sky's parade.

I doubt not You, Beloved, are praise
enough
For likes of me, for I am surely tough.
I doubt not I am called to be Your slave
Of love and hold fast down unto the grave
To serve You and do whatever You say.
But shall I take an oath upon Your name?
Indeed, my calling is one and the same,
To come and recite Your name on the score
Of evenings taught to dhikr at the door.
I take Your name in part upon my lips
And whirl about the dergah, flailing hips,
And know that no oath sworn on heaven or
earth
Is of the slightest mercenary worth.
My breath goes forth each moment of the
dearth.

Deuteronomy 11

1 "Therefore you shall love YHWH your
God,

And keep His charge, His statutes' prod,
His judgements, and His commandments
Always *and ever for a fence*.

2 "And know today that *I do not*
Speak with your children, who *untaught*
Have not known and who have not seen
The chastening of YHWH your God's
spleen,

His greatness and His mighty hand
And His outstretched arm *on the land*,
3 "His signs and His acts which He did
In the midst of Egyptian *bid*,
To Pharaoh king of Egypt, and
To all *the people in his* land,
4 "What He did to Egypt's army,
To their horses and chariots:
He made waters of the Red Sea
Overflow them as *in their plots*
They pursued you, and YHWH's destroyed
Them to this day, 5 "what He employed
For you in the desert until
You came to this place *by His will*,
6 "And what He did to Dathan and
Abiram sons of Eliab,
The son of Reuben *by his hand*:
How the earth opened its mouth's *scab*
And swallowed them up, their households,
Their tents, and all their substance *moulds*
That *was* in their possession, in
The midst of all Israel for sin
7 "But your eyes have seen every great
Act of YHWH which He did *in state*.

Indeed, Beloved, as I recite the Book
My eyes see Your acts everywhere I look.
I see the plagues fall on Egyptian horde,
I see the glint of spear, the flash of sword.
Indeed, Beloved, as visions come to view,
My ears hear also of the things You do.
I hear the rumble of the moving earth
That opens to swallow the folk at birth
Of rebellion against Your kingly throne.
Indeed, Beloved, I hear and see Your own.
Though generations separate my soul
From ancient deeds and ancient hand and
goal,
My cantillation turns time and place out
To find You everywhere without a shout.

8 "Therefore you shall keep each command
That I set today in your hand,
That you may be strong, and go in

And possess the land *without sin*
Which you cross over to possess,
9 "And that you may prolong *your* days
In the land which YHWH did address
To give your fathers to *possess*,
To them and their descendants, 'land
Flowing with milk and honey *planned*.'
10 "For the land which you go to gain
Is not like land of Egypt's *plain*
From which you have come, where you
sowed

Your seed, watered by foot, and mowed
As a garden, 11 "but the land which
You cross over to hold *in hitch*
Is a land of valleys and hills,
Which drinks water *come down in rills*
From the rain of the skies, 12 "a land
For which YHWH your God cares *with*
hand,
The eyes of YHWH your God always
Are on it, from the year's first days
To the very end of the year.

The fruit of cantillation and my seeing
And hearing is that with my entire being
I obey Your commands and with delight.
That is the result of hearing and sight.
As I move from Egypt, where human hand
And foot bring the fresh water on the land
To a place where Your eye from day to day
Brings on the waters for those who obey,
I trust not in the scientific tale
That rain's due to evaporation's Baal,
But recognize behind the matter's cloak
Your hands divine that all the steamers
stoke.

The hills are barren beneath eye of sun
Whose godship is a vain thing on the run.

13 'And it shall be that *in your fear*
If you earnestly obey My
Commandments, *the statutes* which I
Command you today, to love YHWH
Your God and serve Him *as you do*
With all your heart and all your soul,
14 'Then I will give *to you* the rain
For your land in its season's *toll*,
The early rain and latter rain,
That you may gather in your grain,
Your new grape juice, also your oil.
15 'And I will send grass *on the soil*
Upon your fields for your livestock,

That you may eat filled *to the dock.*'

16 "Take heed to yourselves, lest your heart
Be deceived, and you turn *your part*
Aside and serve other gods and
Worship them, 17 "lest YHWH's wrath's
command

Be roused against you, and He shut
Up the skies so there'll be no glut
Of rain, and the land yield no grain,
And you perish *without the rain*
Quickly from the good land which YHWH
In His bounty is giving you.

The Arab set in Canaan and to stand
There while the folk of Israel must demand
The right to find Jerusalem awhile,
Awaited the rain with a humble smile,
Believing in Your unity and yet
The desert crouched around his tent to get
Him and his children and his flocks and
herds

As dinner for vultures and other birds.
The colonists who made the desert bloom
Did not wait in their faith, but hand on
loom

Wove their own fate and hope until the
doom.

Does this mean worship's not the only thing
That brings rain on the people and the king,
But also hard work in the field and room?

18 "Therefore you shall lay up these words
Of mine in your heart and your soul,
And in your intention and goal,
And bind them as a sign *to birds*
On your hand, so that they shall be
As frontlets between where you see.

19 "You'll teach them to your progeny,
Speaking of them when you sit in
Your house, when you walk peregrine,
When you lie down, and when you rise.

20 "And you shall write them *in devise*
On the doorposts of house and gate,

21 "That your days and your children's rate
Of days may truly multiply
In the land of which YHWH swore by
To your fathers to give their worth,
Like days of heavens above the earth.

22 "For if you carefully keep all
These commandments which I recall
Commanding you to do, to love
YHWH your God, to walk *as above*

In all His ways, and to hold fast
To Him, 23 "then YHWH will *surely* cast
Out all these nations before you,
And you will dispossess them too,
Greater and mightier folk than you.

24 "Every place on which your foot's sole
Treads shall be yours: from desert hole
And Lebanon, and from the flood,
The River Euphrates, to stud
The western sea, shall be your land.

25 "No man shall be able to stand
Against you, YHWH your God will put
The dread of you, fear of your *foot*
Upon all the land where you tread,
Even as to you He has said.

By power of cantillation of Your word,
Remembrance of Your name, all things are
stirred.

The wicked and idolatrous are ground
To powder and cast out not to be found.
Commandment contemplated and then kept
Brings joy to the fields where the widow
wept.

I humbly wait upon the dergah floor
To hear remembrance singing more and
more,

But do not see the dread of me arise
Upon the face of wicked ones and eyes.
Instead my voice goes up in slender song
To tell You of the striving and the wrong
That governs all the world. And yet I see
Behind the veils a hand to set soul free.

Week 47

26 "Indeed, today I set before
You blessing and a curse in store:

27 "The blessing for if you obey
YHWH your God's commandments this
day

Which I command you, 28 "and the curse,
If you *have chosen of the worse*,
And do not obey the commands
Of YHWH your God, but turn *in bands*
Aside from the way I command
You this day, to go after band
Of other gods which you've not known.

29 "Now it shall be, *as it was shown*,
When YHWH your God has brought you in
To the land which you go to win,
That you shall put the blessing on
Mount Gerizim and the curse on

Mount Ebal. 30 "*And are they not on*
The other side of the Jordan,
Toward the west, the setting sun,
In the land of the Canaanites
Who live in the plain and in sights
Of Gilgal, by the terebinth
Trees of Moreh in *labyrinth*?

31 "For you will cross over the *flood*
Of Jordan and go in *like stud*
To take the land which YHWH your God
Is giving you *with power and rod*,
And you will keep it and live there.
32 "And you'll be careful to observe
All the statutes and judgements' *curve*
Which I set before you today.

When You, Beloved, commanded blessing
on
The mountains facing the night and the
dawn,
Did You dream then the commandment
would be
The scandal to divide a people free?
The Jew and the Samaritan still fight
At least in words to know who has the
right,
And which mountain is set for cursing and
Which mount for blessings raining on the
land.
A poor dervish I take my whirling round
And raise a hand to heaven, one to the
ground,
And let fall blessings everywhere I'm
bound,
Both on Ebal and Gerizim until
You come, Beloved, at last to foot the bill.
As I dance I am waiting for that sound.

Deuteronomy 12

1 "These *are* the statutes and judgements
Which you shall be *in all events*
Careful to observe in the land
Which YHWH God of your fathers' hand
Is giving you to *hold and keep*,
All the days that you live *and sleep*
Upon the earth. 2 "You'll utterly
Destroy all the places *you see*
Where nations which you'll dispossess
Served their gods in *their wickedness*,
On the high mountains and on hills
And under every green tree's *rills*.
3 "You shall destroy their altars, break

Their *sacred* pillars, every stake
Of their wooden images burn
With fire, you shall cut down *and spurn*
The carved images of their gods
And destroy their names from their clods.
4 "You shall not worship YHWH your God
With such things as image and rod.

Beloved, I lay my microcosmos bare
So that You can see all the idols there,
And pluck them from the green hills where
they stand
And destroy every image in my land.
Each pillar, stake and wooden pole that
grows
Upon the hills of eyebrows and my nose
Take down and with them all take down the
word
And thought idolatrous, each evil bird
Inhabiting the caves and chambers where
I bow my heart and soul in secret prayer.
I shall not worship false gods nor shall I
Disarmingly answer and make reply
That by these images I worship You.
I set aside the many and the few.

5 "But you shall seek the place where
YHWH
Your God chooses, out of your few
Tribes, to put His name for His place
Of dwelling, and there you shall pace.
6 "There you shall take your burnt
offerings,
Your sacrifices, tithes *and things*,
The heave offerings within your hand,
Your vowed offerings, your freewill stand
To offer, and the firstborn of
Your herds and flocks, *all that you love*.
7 "And there shall you eat before YHWH
Your God, and you shall rejoice *true*
In all to which you've put your hand,
You and your households, *every band*,
In which YHWH your God has blessed
you.

The place You choose, indeed, and I find
here
That many places are held dear with fear:
Shiloh, Sion and Gerizim, and more
As far as Rome and Lourdes, the shore
Of the Red Sea to Mecca, and the plain
Of Anatolia, where not in vain

I too have sought the cool repose where
 rest
 Remains of Hajji Bektash with the best.
 The place You choose, indeed, though the
 threshold
 Of house built on one storey where the bold
 Of sheep and chickens share the cherished
 nest.
 The Kaaba is the stone where You are
 guest,
 No matter what sun rise upon its crest,
 No matter where it lies boughten or sold.

8 "You shall not at all do as we
 Are doing here today, just see
 How every man does what is right
 In his own eyes and in his sight,
 9 "For as yet you've not come to rest
 In the inheritance and nest
 Which YHWH your God is giving you.
 10 "But *when* you cross over the *dew*
Of Jordan and live in the land
 Which YHWH your God gives *from His*
hand

To you to inherit *and stand*,
 And He gives you rest from all your
 Foes round about *like sand on shore*,
 So that you live in safety, 11 "then
 There will be the place where *for men*
 YHWH your God chooses and to make
 His name abide *there for His sake*.
 There you shall bring all I command:
 Your burnt offerings, sacrifice *band*,
 Your tithes, the heave offerings in hand,
 And all your choice offerings to stand
 Which you vow to YHWH. 12 "You'll
 rejoice
 Before YHWH your God *with your voice*,
 You and your sons and daughters *too*,
 Your servants and maids, and the crew
 Of Levites who're within your gates,
 Since they have no part nor estates
 With you. 13 "Take heed to yourself that
 You do not offer your burnt *pat*
 Offerings in every place you see,
 14 "But in the place of YHWH's decree,
 In one of your tribes, there you'll offer
 Your burnt offerings, and there you'll
 proffer
 All that I command you to do.
 15 "However, you may slaughter *too*
 And eat meat within all your gates,

What your heart desires *in your plates*,
 According to the blessing of
 YHWH your God which He's given in love,
 The unclean and the clean may eat
 Of it, of the gazelle *for treat*
 And the deer alike. 16 "Only you
 Shall not eat the blood, nor shall you
 Pour it on the earth like water.
 17 "You may not eat within your gates
 The tithe of your grain or *to stir*
 Your new grape juice or your oil *grates*,
 Of the firstborn of your herd or
 Your flock, of any of your *score*
Of offerings which you vow, of your
 Freewill offerings, or of the heave
 Offering of your hand *by My leave*.
 18 "But you must eat them before YHWH
 Your God in the *right* place which YHWH
 Your God chooses, you and your son
 And your daughter, your servant won
 And your maid, and the Levite who
Is in your gates, and you'll rejoice
 Before YHWH your God *with your voice*
 In all to which you put your hands.
 19 "Take heed to yourself *in your lands*
 That you do not forsake Levite
 As long as you live in your right.

Beloved, there is no now appointed State
 Theocracy, and so You relegate
 Us back to doing as they once did then,
 Without the direct guidance of pure men,
 But by the justice of each eye that reads
 The revelation and applies to needs.
 "As we are doing here today" was spoken
 At time when there was even Moses' token
 For the authority. What only lacked
 Was entrance to the promised land
 unsacked.
 Today there is no land and yet no leader
 Upon a throne to be lawful impedier.
 That's why I flee again and again to
 Your Word, to love of Your sent guides
 and true.

20 "When YHWH your God enlarges your
 Border as He's promised *before*,
 And you say 'Let me eat some meat,'
 Because you long to eat meat's *treat*,
 You may eat as much meat as your
 Heart desires. 21 "If the place *before*
 Where YHWH your God chooses to put

His name is too far for your *foot*,
 Then you may slaughter from your herd
 And from your flock which *undeterred*
 YHWH's given you, just as I've told
 You, and you may eat in your *bold*
 Gates as much as your heart desires.
 22 "Just as the gazelle and the *choirs*
Of deer are eaten, so you may
 Eat them, the unclean *in the way*
 And the clean alike may eat them.
 23 "Only be sure *by stratagem*
 That you do not eat of the blood,
 For the blood *is* the life *in bud*,
 You may not eat the life with meat.
 24 "You shall not eat it *as a treat*,
 You shall pour it on earth like water.
 25 "You shall not eat it *in the slaughter*,
 That it may go well with you and
 Your children after your *command*,
 When you do *what is* right in sight
 Of YHWH. 26 "Only the holy right
 Of things which you have, and your vowed
 Offerings, you shall take and go *bowed*
 To the place which YHWH chooses it.
 27 "And you shall offer your burnt *fit*
 Offerings, and the meat and the blood,
 On the altar of YHWH your God,
 And then your sacrifices' blood
 Shall be poured out *upon the sod*
 Of the altar of YHWH your God,
 And you shall eat the meat. 28 "Observe
 And obey all these words, *don't swerve*,
 Which I command you, that it may
 Go well with you and your *mainstay*,
 Your children after you forever,
 When you do *what is* good and clever
 In sight of YHWH your Alohim.
 29 "And then when YHWH your Alohim
 Cuts off from before you the nations
 Which you go to take from their rations,
 You displace them, live in their land,
 30 "Take heed to yourself that your hand
 Be not ensnared to follow them,
 After they are destroyed from hem
 Before you, and that you do not
 Inquire after their gods *to plot*,
 Saying 'How did these nations serve
 Their gods? I'll also have the nerve
 To do the same.' 31 "You shall not bow
 In worship to YHWH your God *now*
 In that way, for every foul thing
 To YHWH which He hates they take wing

To do to their gods, for they burn
 Even their sons and daughters turn
 In the fire to their gods *to earn*.

If Mecca is too far a place to go,
 Jerusalem behind the golden glow
 Of fortress walls, the ship to Jedda slow,
 Then You promise that where the threshold
 stands

Is place enough for Your presence'
 commands.

Beloved, I sleep upon the Kaaba floor
 All the days of my earthly life and more,
 And rest upon the bosom that contains
 The universe in all its shining lanes.
 There is no minute in which I find not
 Your presence in my breath though I forgot
 To whisper Your names dear and full of
 grace.

Though I live far from every sacred place,
 I live and move before Your hand and face.

32 "Whatever I *may* command you,
 Be careful to observe and do,
 You shall not add to it nor take
 Away from it *for your own sake*.

Beloved, I hear the Hebrew words like
 stones

Resounding in my ears and heart and
 bones,

I hear the Gospel melody right true,
 And pause to recite the Qur'an anew.
 Do not think, my Beloved, my scratchings
 here

Are more than my soul sighs to find You
 near.

I do not dream my words translate Your
 own,

Nor more than in dim reflections atone.
 If I add loving sighs to the Book read,
 Let it not be to add to counsel fed,
 But only to distract me from the flow
 Of illusions that always come and go
 Before the sights and sounds of heaven and
 earth

That make Your words by contrast of all
 worth.

Deuteronomy 13

1 "If comes among you prophet or
 A dreamer of dreams *on that score*,

And he gives you a sign or wonder,
 2 "And the sign or wonder *like thunder*
 Does come to pass, of which he spoke
 To you, saying *when he awoke*,
 'Let us go after other gods'
 Which you have not known as man plods
 'And let us serve them,' 3 "you shall not
 Listen to that prophet's words' plot
 Or to that dreamer of dreams *sought*,
 For YHWH your God is testing you
 To know whether you will be *true*
In love to YHWH your God with all
Your heart and soul to hear His call.

Hear, hear, Beloved! This text that's never
 quoted!

The one men like is the one over-roted,
 That says if prophecy made does come
 true,

It is a sign the prophet's come from You.
 But when You say that miracle and sign
 When serving men's idolatry just fine
 Is not an evidence that they're divine,
 The world will turn away from warning
 word.

If only for a miracle a turd
 Is edible to those whose stomach craves
 The gods defined in rows to command
 slaves.

The one and absolute criterion
 Is that there is no god at all by sun
 But You alone, the undefined, the One.

4 "You shall walk after YHWH your God
 And fear Him, and keep *every prod*
Of His commandments and obey
His voice, and you shall every day
Serve Him and hold fast to His way.
 5 "But that prophet or that one that
 Dreams dreams shall be put *where he sat*
 To death, because he's spoken for
 To turn *you* away from YHWH's *door*,
 Your God, who brought you from the land
 Of Egypt and redeemed your *hand*
 From house of bondage, to entice
 You from the way *which should suffice*
As YHWH your Alohim told you
 To walk. So you shall put away
 The evil from the place you stay.

In this place where each man does what is
 right

In his own eyes, or follows every sprite
 That claims honour of king, bishop or pope,
 Your commandment relieves me of all
 hope.

I cannot kill the many who preach on
 That You are three or more at night and
 dawn

And hidden in the idols of all races
 And in the faiths astray in public places.
 The preaching of idolatry is heard
 In every pulpit of great and absurd.
 But I can kill the preacher in my heart
 By turning from the falsehoods from the
 start

And cleaving to You alone and Your word
 That from its sounds has my heart fired and
 stirred.

6 "If your brother, son of your mother,
 Your son or your daughter, *or other*,
 The wife of your bosom, or friend
 Whom your very soul would defend,
 Secretly entices you, saying
 'Let's go where other gods are playing,'
 Which you have not known, neither you
 Nor your fathers, 7 "gods of the crew
 Of folk which *are* all around you,
 Near to you or far off from you,
 From *one* end of the earth unto
 The *other* end of the world's view,
 8 "You'll not consent to him or listen,
 Nor shall your eye with pity glisten,
 Nor shall you spare him or conceal,
 9 "But you shall surely make him feel
 The sting of death, your hand shall be
 The first against him to agree
 To put him to death, afterward
 The hand of all the people *stirred*.
 10 "And you shall stone that one with
 stones

Until he dies *and so atones*,
 Because he sought to entice you
 Away from your Alohim YHWH,
 Who brought you out of Egypt's land,
 From the house of bondage *to stand*.
 11 "So all Israel shall hear and fear,
 And not again do such *a smear*
 Of wickedness as this by you.

Indeed, Beloved, the influence of
 neighbour

Is strong against faith in You and Your labour.

The love of kith and kin entices all
To follow Baal and Ashtoreth's fond call.
I turn with will and lust from the enticing
Of friendship and love for the care and splicing

Of idols into one, and as one claiming
To be You in spite of their constant blaming

That what You once said is no longer true,
And there's no law from You for what I do.
Beloved, I stone with stones the words that tend

To take me from Sinai to go and wend
My way among the sirens of the street
Where Jew, Christian, and Muslim come to meet.

12 "If you hear in one of your cities,
Which YHWH your God gives your committees

To live in, someone saying 13 'Men
Corrupted have gone out again
From among you to seduce men
Inhabitants of their city,
Saying "Let us *now* go and see
How to serve other gods'" which you
Have not known, 14 "then you shall renew
Inquiry, search out, and ask well.
And *if* indeed *it's* true to tell

And certain *that* such evil thing
Was done by your *poor man or king*,
15 "You shall surely strike *all* the dwellers
Of that city from roofs to cellars,
With the mouth of the sword, wholly
Destroying it, all that's in it
And its livestock, with the sword's mouth.
16 "And you'll gather its plunder *fit*

Into the middle of the street,
And wholly burn *form north to south*
With fire the city and complete
With all its plunder, YHWH's your God.
It shall be a heap *on the sod*
Forever, and not built again.

17 "So none of the accursed of men
Shall remain in your hand *again*,
That YHWH may turn from His fierce wrath

And show you mercy *on your path*,
Having compassion on you and
Multiply you *like the sea's sand*,

Just as He to your fathers swore,
18 "Because you've listened to the score
Of voice of YHWH your Alohim,
To keep all His commandments' *theme*
Which I command to you today,
To do *what's* right in the eyes' way
Of YHWH your Alohim *and Stay*.

You command folks to kill the cattle too
Because their master was accustomed to
Bow down to the false gods of Canaan's land.

Such condemnation I can understand
To fall on heathen perpetrators who
Are consenting adults as goes the word.
But what about the cattle and the bird?
Their only sin was being fattened for
The altars of the goddesses in store.
They should not bear the punishment of late

That fell upon their owners in just hate.
I pray for grace upon the bestial tribe
Condemned because it could become a bribe

To get Your folk to commit diatribe.

Deuteronomy 14

1 "You're the children of YHWH your God,

You shall not cut yourselves *with prod*
Nor shave the front of your head for
The dead. 2 "For you're a holy *store*
Of people to YHWH your God, and
YHWH has chosen you *out of hand*
To be a people for Himself,
A special treasure *over elf*,
Above all peoples who *are* on
The face of the earth, *dark and dawn*.

The heathen practices to cut and shave
Expressed respect for goddesses by slave.
Avoiding such made people loved and true,
Chosen by You for what they know and do.
There are still those who shave the head in fear

Of sun and moon upon the monkly bier,
And thus partake of Canaanite rejoicing
In her divinities with fairly voicing.
I flee from every grand establishment
That follows what the ancient cuttings sent
Of scientific mouthings of great things

Before the thrones who set themselves as
kings.
Beloved, You are my treasure though I see
None of the speculation's trinity.

3 "You shall not eat any foul thing.

4 "These *are* the beasts which you may
bring

To eat: the ox, the sheep, the goat,
5 "The deer, gazelle, roe deer, wild goat,
The mountain goat, the antelope,
And mountain sheep *upon the slope*.

6 "You may eat every beast that sports
Cloven hooves, having *in cohorts*
The hoof split in two parts, *that* chews
The cud, among the beasts *for stews*.

7 "Nevertheless, of those that chew
The cud or have cloven hooves *cue*,
You shall not eat, *such ones as* these:
Camel, hare *with or without fleas*,
And the rock hyrax, for they chew
The cud but do not have the due
In cloven hooves, they *are* unclean
For you. 8 "Also the swine's unclean
For you, because it's hooves are cloven,
Yet *does not chew* the cud *for roving*,

You shall not eat their flesh or touch
Their dead carcasses *for as much*.

9 "These you may eat of all that *are*
In the waters: eat without bar
All that have both their fins and scales.

10 "And whatever does not have fins
And scales you shall not eat *from pails*,
It is unclean for you *for sins*.

11 "All clean birds you may eat. 12 "But
these

You shall not *even* eat *with cheese*:

The eagle, vulture, buzzard, and
13 "The red kite, falcon *over land*,
And kites by their kinds, 14 "every raven
After its kind, 15 "the ostrich *haven*,
The short-eared owl, the seagull, and
The hawk after their kinds, *wings spanned*,
16 "The little owl, screech owl, white owl,
17 "The jackdaw, and the carrion fowl,
The fisher owl, 18 "the stork, the heron
After its kind *since it's not barren*,
And hoopoe and the bat. 19 "Also
All creeping things that fly *and go*
Are unclean for you, they shall not
Be eaten. 20 "Eat all clean birds *got*.
21 "You'll not eat what dies *of itself*,

You may give it to alien *elf*
Within your gates, that he may eat,
Or sell to foreigner *for treat*,
For you *are* holy folk to YHWH
Your Alohim. And you shall not
Boil a young goat in *the same pot*
With its own mother's milk *to chew*.

Except for the reluctant grace to eat
The camel, the Qur'an performs the feat
Of making the same rules for human fare.
How to eat such without the killing there
That's forbidden in Decalogue for shame?
Conditions that allow it without blame
Are those after the Flood when Noah came
Out on an earth destroyed, and as we now
Look on an earth destroyed by water's
plough,
When health and life require it, we may
taste,
Beloved, what's in Your providence, no
waste.
But life of pigs and dogs is sacred still
Unless a real famine hit the hill.
I'm satisfied with lentils on the bill.

22 "You shall truly tithe all increase
Of your grain that the fields release
Each year. 23 "And you shall eat before
YHWH your God, in the place *and store*
Where He chooses to make His name
Abide, the tithe of your grain's *fame*
And your new grape juice and your oil,
Of the firstborn of your herds' *toil*
And your flocks, that you'll learn to fear
YHWH your God *who is* always *near*.

24 "But if the journey is too long
For you to carry *with a song*,
If the place where YHWH your God
chooses

To put His name's too far and loses,
When YHWH your God has blessed you,
25 "then

You'll exchange for money again,
Take the *tithe* money in your hand,
And go to the place *and the stand*
Which YHWH your God chooses. 26 "And
you

Shall spend that money *that is due*
For whatever your heart desires:
For oxen or sheep, for grape juice
Or the like drink, as heart may choose,

You shall eat there *beside the fires*
Before YHWH your God, and rejoice,
You and your household *in your choice*.

The like drink that You mention here is
clearly

Intoxicant, and so I ask sincerely
If you give some permission here to drink
What I am hoping is not what I think.
The worshipful use of liquor I see
Among the faithful Turkish Alevis
Who in their rites in reverence lay them
down

From whirling and from drinking without
frown

To dream of You and of Your loving grace
And rise up in their turning to Your face.
Bless them, Beloved, and they are in their
place,

And bless me also, where I take no sip
Beyond the very words that pass Your lip.
They lie, but I whirl on with hand on hip.

27 "You shall not forsake the Levite
Who's in your gates, for he's no right
Nor inheritance with your *might*.

28 "At the end of *every* third year
You shall bring out the tithe of gear
Produced that year and store *it* up
Within your gates. 29 "And the Levite,
Because he has no part nor cup
With you, and the stranger *though slight*,
And the fatherless and the widow
Who *are* within your gates, *or kiddo*,
May come and eat, be satisfied,
That YHWH your God has well supplied
To bless you in all your hand's work
Which you do *without fail or shirk*.

Fathers and grandfathers today have right
To lands and cattle here beneath Your
sight,

And no more in the temple does Levite
Stand to eat shewbread or kindle the light.
Today the portion still goes to the just
And living sons of one father of dust,
Who quietly restore Your laws and state
Before both the humble and civil great.
In praise of such who come here in Your
name

I raise a song with the twelve honoured
claim,

And lay in their account the portion now
To fatherless and widow where I bow.
Beloved, take from my hand what is Your
own

And eat and drink with me upon the stone.

Deuteronomy 15

1 "At the end of *each* seven years
You shall grant a release *arrears*
Of debts. 2 "And this *is* release form:
Every creditor who *in swarm*
Has lent *something* to his neighbour
Shall release *it*, he shall not order
It from of his neighbour or his brother,
Because it's called *by one and other*
YHWH's release. 3 "Of a foreigner
You may require *it*, but you shall
Give up your claim to the banal
Owed by your brother, 4 "except when
There may be no poor among men,
For YHWH will greatly bless you in
The land which YHWH your God *for win*
Is giving you to possess *as*
Inheritance, *and so He has*.

5 "Only if you straitly obey
The voice of YHWH Alohims' way,
Observe with care all these commands
Which I command you *here* today.

6 "For YHWH your Alohims takes stands
To bless you as He promised you,
You'll lend to many nations, true,
But you shall not borrow *a cent*,
You'll reign over many a tent,
But they shall not reign over you.

I do reign over kings and presidents,
Not by a sword or power, but by the sense
I have that they lack to submit to all
The words You once on Sinai at the call
Gave to the world and humankind to
preach.

I live and reign in every word You teach.
I borrow from the heathen neither tent
Nor silver for the way my fathers went.
Instead I turn to You, Beloved, and go
According to the love that You bestow.
I follow You past all the tattered vines
Of pride and popery and the designs
That turn to Babylon and Egypt's gods.
I graze contentedly on lentil pods.

7 "If there's among you a poor man

Of your brothers, within your land
And gates which YHWH your God gives
you,

You shall not harden your heart nor
Shut your hand from your brother poor,
8 "But you shall open your hand wide
To him and willingly decide
To lend him enough for his need,
Whatever he might need *indeed*.

9 "Beware lest there be wicked thought
In your heart, saying *in a plot*,
'The seventh year, year of release,
Is soon,' and your eye *without peace*
Be evil against your poor brother
And you give him nothing, *but smother*,
And he cry out to YHWH 'gainst you,
And it become sin among you.

10 "You'll surely give to him, your heart
Should not be grieved because *of part*
You give to him, because for this
Thing YHWH your Alohims will bless
You in all your works and in all
To which you put your hand *in call*.

11 "The poor are always in the land,
That's why I say this word's command,
'You'll open your hand to your brother,
To your poor and your needy *other*,
Who are abiding in your land.'

Samaritan may know when seventh year's
come.

From Israel's time we've lost the certain
sum,

And Jesus and Muhammad when they
spoke

To reveal secrets underneath the oak,
Did not breathe word of when to seal the
chest

And when to brighten hearts with free
request.

They spoke of jubilee, but that I fear
Has been lost from the present day and
year,

At least since Abu Bekr changed the dates.
I turn to You, Beloved, from where one
waits

On creditor to open hand and gates,
And from the usury of banks and states.
Indeed the poor and needy still abound
And long for seven years upon the ground.

12 "If your brother, a Hebrew man,

Or a Hebrew woman *as can*,

Is sold to you and serves six years,
Then when the seventh year appears
You shall let him go free from you.

13 "And when you send him out from you,
You'll not let him go empty-handed,
14 "You'll give him freely from your flock,
And from your threshing floor *remanded*,
And from your winepress *and your stock*.
From what YHWH's blessed you, you shall
give

To him. 15 "You shall *where you may live*
Remember that you were a slave
In Egypt's land *to make your grave*,
And YHWH your Alohims redeemed
You, therefore I *as it has seemed*
Command you this thing on this day.

16 "And if it happens he will say
To you, 'I will not go away
From you,' because he loves you and
Your house, since he prospers *at hand*
With you, 17 "then you shall take an awl
And thrust *it* through his ear withal
Into the door, and he shall be
Your servant and eternally.

Also to your female servant
You shall do likewise *or repent*.

18 "It shall not seem hard to you when
You send him away free again,
For he's been worth a double hired
Worker working six years untired.
Then YHWH your Alohims will bless
You in all you do and address.

The celibate in Balim Sultan's pool
Who pierced his ear for love was not a fool,
But read Your word and then took him the
awl

And nailed him to the doorpost of the hall
Beside the kitchen where Hajji Bektash
Dipped up with sacred dipper the gulash.
Though I remain in wedlock and take none
Of silver in my ear when I have done,
I still recall the hymns in silence now
As I stand by the alabaster how
Remembering the many who whirled here
Before Your face and singing their songs
clear.

Beloved, I do in a symbolic way
Pierce my ear with Your words to keep
today.

19 "All the firstborn males that come from
 Your herd and your flock you *in sum*
 Shall sanctify to YHWH your God,
 You shall do no work *on the sod*
 With any firstborn of your herd,
 Nor shear your flock's firstborn occurred.
 20 "You and all your household shall eat
 Before YHWH your God *as a treat*
 Year by year in the place which YHWH
 Chooses. 21 "But if there is a *true*
 Defect in it, *as lame or blind*
Or has serious defect combined,
 You shall not sacrifice it to
 YHWH your God, *whatever you do*.
 22 "You may eat it within your gates,
 The unclean and the clean *of mates*
 Alike, as a gazelle or deer.
 23 "Only you shall not eat its *mere*
 Blood, you shall pour it on the ground
 Like water *where it may be found*.

The people where I live claim that they
 pour
 The blood upon the ground and leave the
 gore.

It's vain excuse for slaughtering in sin
 And eating like a cannibal with grin.
 All things are pure if only we give thanks
 Says every archbishop among the tanks.
 But killing what You did not give
 command

To kill or slaughtering without the band
 Of legislation shows there's no remorse
 For the great and illegal soul's divorce
 From Your law and Your word of love to
 men

That none shall kill and live to kill again.
 I pour my soul and blood upon the floor
 Of dergah in a sacrifice in store.

Deuteronomy 16

1 "Observe the month of green ears, keep
 Passover to YHWH your God *steep*,
 For in the month of green ears YHWH
 Your God brought you from Egypt's *crew*
 By night. 2 "Therefore you shall give due
 Sacrifice of Passover to
 YHWH your God, from the flock and herd,
 In the place where YHWH says the word
 To put His name. 3 "You shall eat no
 Leavened bread with it *on the go*,
 For seven days you shall eat *your* bread

Without yeast, affliction's *retread*
 For you came in haste from the land
 Of Egypt, that you may in hand
 Recall the day when you came out
 Of Egypt's land your life throughout.

The new year of the spring begins the
 round
 Of yearly festivals upon the ground.
 The third week that begins after the spring
 Equinox starts the Passover on wing.
 I set aside the leavening of bread
 That is contained in what the people said
 About Your law, all the traditions fed,
 And lay hand on the pure manna of led
 And set leaders whose power, authority
 Comes from Your own appointment for a
 fee.

From Abraham and Moses I take song,
 From David, Jesus, Muhammad know
 wrong
 From right and so a taste of crusty slice
 Of yeastless bread, Your own words will
 suffice.

4 "And no yeast shall be seen among
 You in your territory *hung*
 For seven days, nor shall the meat
 You sacrifice first day's retreat
 Remain the night till morning *come*.

5 "You may not sacrifice the *sum*
Of the Passover within any
 Of your gates *even for a penny*
 Which YHWH your God gives you, 6 "but
 at

The place where YHWH your God *has sat*
 Choosing to make His name abide,
 There you shall sacrifice the *tide*
Of Passover between nightfalls,
 At the going down of the sun,
 At the *very* time *it recalls*
 You came out of Egypt *and won*.

Yeastless, Beloved, You sit in secret places
 To make Your name known to all human
 faces.

The Kaaba of the threshold and the heart
 Redeems the decadence of Mecca's part
 And old Jerusalem's rebellious ire.
 You sit, Beloved, upon throne of desire
 And see before You altars where the pyre
 Ascends in song and sacrifice to You

From those who whirl about Your hand to
do
According to Your holy, expressed will.
I lend my heart and soul and self and still
Find caverns of new sacrifice to fill
Your treasure house with living stones to
seat
Your name again and once again repeat.

7 "And you shall roast and eat *it* in
The place YHWH your God would begin
To choose, and in the morning you
Shall turn, go to your tents *anew*.
8 "Six days you'll eat unleavened bread,
And on the seventh *to be fed*
A sacred assembly to YHWH
Your Alohim, and you shall do
No work. 9 "You shall count seven weeks
For yourself, start to count the weeks
In seven from the *time* you start
To put the sickle to the grain.
10 "Then you shall keep the feast *apart*
Of weeks to YHWH your God with gain
Of freewill offering from your hand,
Which you shall give *by His command*
Just as YHWH your God blesses you.
11 "You shall rejoice then before YHWH
Your God, you and your son and your
Daughter, your male servant and your
Female servant, the Levite who
Is within your gates, strangers too
And the orphan and widow who
Are among you, at the place where
YHWH your God chooses to make there
His name abide. 12 "And you'll recall
That you were slave in Egypt's *thrall*,
And you shall be careful to keep
These statutes *here without a peep*.

I have no grain nor sickle for the reaping
Of barley by command of the sun's
keeping.
I've never been a slave in Egypt's land
And yet at the summer's threshold I stand
To praise You, my Beloved, for earth's
produce
In grain and mushroom and in apple juice,
And hope my standing constitutes a truce.
My land bears more the sweet concocted
weed
Whose leaf and stem are eaten more than
seed,

The horseradish and its forbidden root,
Sweet peas, nasturtiums and nettle to boot
To eat with my potatoes, and the smile
Of lady's mantel and the bitter bile
Of dandelion, satisfied the while.

13 "You shall observe the feast of booths
For seven days, *because it smooths*
When you have gathered from your floor
Of threshing, from your winepress' *door*.
14 "And you shall rejoice in your feast,
You, your son and daughter, *at least*,
Your male servant and maid, Levite,
The stranger *who may be in sight*,
And orphan and the widow, who
Are in your gates *for what they do*.

The tabernacles have always been set
For the maturing of the boys to get
A hold on their adulthood, though in vain,
The forest is a hiding place of pain.
But resurrections from that childly death
Meet every generation with new breath.
Though desert has long since replaced the
wood,
The feasting still goes on as ever should.
Forgotten are the reconciling fates
That once met boys along with boyhood
mates
To steal a march on time. Long since the
law
Has made the feast a time of solemn awe
Beneath the sound of joying in the song
Of Your word, my Beloved, to keep from
wrong.

15 "For seven days you'll keep a feast
Sacredly to YHWH your God *leased*
In the place which YHWH chooses, for
YHWH your God will bless you *and store*
In all your produce and in all
The work that in your hands *may fall*,
So that you surely shall rejoice.
16 "Three times a year *to lift their voice*
All your males shall appear before
YHWH your God in the place which He
Chooses: at the feast of the store
Of yeastless bread, at the feast of
Weeks, and also at the feast of
Booths, and they shall not come to see
Before YHWH empty-handedly.
17 "Every man *shall give* as he can,

According to the blessed plan
Of YHWH your Alohim which He
Has given you *abundantly*.

Ah my Beloved, I do come here with hand
Empty despite Your glorious command.
For all is Yours and nothing can be given
As gift to You even after I've striven
To earn my lot and bread upon the sod.
At last there's nothing left me here but God.
And yet I come before Your throne of state
Invited to a filled cup and full plate.
In sacred thought and joy I sit me down
To eat and drink in the celestial town,
A-quiver with the eager plot to find
A greater spot and nourishment of mind.
I find that You provide all things upon
The table and the temple I sit on.

Week 48

18 "Judges and officers you'll set
In all your gates *they can be met*,
Which YHWH your Alohim gives you,
According to your tribes *and crew*,
To judge with justice *all* the folk.
19 "Then you shall not pervert *the yoke*
Of justice, and you shall not show
Partiality, nor take a bribe,
For a bribe blinds the eyes *to know*
Of the wise and twists righteous words.
20 "You'll follow what *for all the birds*
Is altogether just, that you
May live and hold the land which YHWH
Your God *this day* is giving you.
21 "You shall not plant you any tree,
As a wooden image to be
Near the altar you build yourself
To YHWH your Alohim, *not elf*.
22 "You shall not set up sacred pillar,
Which YHWH your God hates *more than*
killer.

I live in a land where idolatry
Is established by the state and gentry.
It is a place where every jinn and elf
Has become god before Your Godly Self.
And yet, Beloved, there is but rarely tree
Set up at May Day or upon the lea
Of summer solstice to turn to in prayer.
The growing forests spread out
everywhere,

And raise their own anthems of praise to
You
While waiting for the lumber razing crew.
For now it's not the living tree we've bred
To worship when all things are done and
said,
It's rather trees cut up to make a sale
Entices folk to worship at the grail.

Deuteronomy 17

1 "You shall not sacrifice to YHWH
Your God a bull or sheep *or two*
Which has a blemish *or* defect,
For that's detestable reflect
On YHWH your God. 2 "If there is found
Among you, within any bound
Of your gates which YHWH your God
gives,
A man or a woman who lives
Wickedly in the sight of YHWH
Your God, in transgressing the due
Covenant, 3 "who has gone and served
Other gods and worshipped them, swerved
Either the sun or moon or any
Of the host of heaven *for penny*,
Which I have not commanded *you*,
4 "And it is told to you, and you
Hear *of it*, then you shall inquire
Diligently. If *there is fire*
Where the smoke's seen and it is true,
And certain that such evil grew
In Israel, 5 "then you shall bring
Out to your gates that *wicked thing*,
Man or woman who has committed
That wicked thing, and *unremitted*
Shall stone to death that man or wife
With stones, *and you shall take their life*.
6 "Whoever is deserving death
Shall be put to death on the breath
Of witness from couple or three,
He shall not on testimony
Of one witness be put to death.
7 "The hands of witnesses shall be
The first against him *in their fee*
To put him to death, afterward
The hands of all the people stirred.
So you shall put away the bad
From among you *that makes you sad*.

The bull of self I sacrifice to You,
But may there be no blemish in the cru.
Who ask before Your law why this or that,

And what is wrong with something where I
 sat,
 Know not that rules are there not only for
 The good they may do humankind but more
 To tell the pure and make the body fresh
 And without blemish in the soul and flesh
 So that the sacrifice to You when made
 Is not just hopes and honours in the trade
 But blemishless a praise to Your sweet
 name
 And nothing in the way of blot or blame.
 Beloved, the sheep I bring to You is my
 Own self, the blemish is the thing to cry.

8 "If a thing comes up that's too hard
 For you to judge *as is ill-starred*,
 Between degrees of guilt for blood,
 Between one judgement *in the bud*
 Or another, or between one
 Punishment or another *done*,
 Matters of controversy in
 Your gates, then you shall take a spin
 To the place which YHWH your God
 chooses.

9 "And you'll come to the priest who loses,
 The Levites, also to the judge
There in those days, and *not to fudge*
Inquire of them, they shall pronounce
 Upon you the sentence to pounce.

10 "You'll do according to the sentence
 Which they pronounce *and their*
commentence
 Upon you in that place which YHWH
 Chooses. You'll be careful to do
 By all of what they order you.

11 "According to the sentence of
 The law in which they teach you of,
 According to the judgement which
 They tell you, you'll do *at the pitch*,
 You shall not turn aside *to* right
 Hand or *to* the left from the bright
 Verdict which they pronounce on you.

12 "Now the man who acts on his cue
 And will not heed the priest who stands
 To minister there before YHWH
 Your God, or the judge *by commands*,
 That man shall die. So you shall put
 Away evil from Israel's *foot*.

13 "And all the folk shall hear and fear,
 And no longer play by the ear.

These words were spoken on the blessed
 brink
 Of Jordan's river, there before the sink
 Of people into the idolatry
 That prophets later railed against freely.
 These words were truly optimistic things,
 For rarely have there been both priests and
 kings
 As well as elders who supported well
 The words You spoke on Sinai for a spell.
 It's every man for himself, You know that,
 Because You see the wealthy and the fat
 Take more of everything than is their share
 And protect it with law and the hot air
 Of politicians elected to bear
 The interests of such lobbies everywhere.

14 "When you come to the land which
 YHWH
 Your Alohim is giving you,
 And possess it and live in it,
 And say 'I will set a king *fit*
 Over me like all the folk that
 Around me *in their livings sat*,'

15 "You shall surely set a king over
 You YHWH your God chooses *for drover*,
One from among your brothers you
 Shall set as a king over you,
 You may not set a foreigner
 Over you, who's not your brother.

16 "But he shall not multiply for
 Himself horses *and by the score*,
 Nor cause the folk to go back to
 Egypt to multiply horse crew,
 For YHWH *your God* has said to you,
 'You'll not return that way again.'

17 "Neither shall he multiply *yen*
For wives for himself, lest his heart
 Turn away, nor take for his part
 Great loads of silver and of gold.

18 "Also it shall be, when he's bold
 To sit on the throne of his realm,
 That he shall write himself *at helm*
 A copy of this law in book,
 From *where* the priests and Levites *look*.

19 "And it shall be with him, and he
 Shall read it all the days' *decree*
 Of his life, that he may learn fear
 Of YHWH his Alohim, not veer
 But be careful to observe all
 The words that this law *may recall*
 And these statutes, 20 "that his heart may

Not rise above his brothers' sway,
That he may never turn aside
From the commandment *to abide*
On the right hand or *on* the left,
And that he may *not be bereft*
But prolong *his* days in his realm,
He and his sons at Israel's helm.

The limitation that You put on kings
Is something they ignore for golden rings.
They must not have wealth, must not
multiply
Treaties with foreigners, that's what imply
The marriages that treaties ratify.
They must not have horses, that is, they
must
Not build up military means and trust.
They must be chosen by You and to be
No foreigner to those they royally
Rule, and what's more important finally,
They must rule by this law alone and free.
Such a man is no king at all, I see,
But servant of a people proclaimed free.
I bow, Beloved, to You and in the dust.

Deuteronomy 18

1 "The priests, the Levites, all the tribe
Of Levi, *and all they describe*,
Shall have no land inheritance
With Israel *to give offence*,
They'll eat the offerings of YHWH
Made by fire, and His portion *due*.
2 "So they'll have no inheritance
Among their brothers *where they prance*,
For YHWH is their inheritance,
As He said to them. 3 "And this shall
Be the priest's due from the people,
From those who offer sacrifice,
Whether bull or sheep, *something nice*:
They'll give the shoulder to the priest,
The cheeks, and the stomach *for feast*.
4 "The firstfruits of your grain and your
New grape juice and your oil *before*,
And the first fleece of your sheep, you
Shall give to him. 5 "Because that YHWH
Your Alohims chosen him out
Of all your tribes to stand and shout
The name of YHWH, him and his sons
Forever. 6 "If a Levite comes
From any of your gates, from where
He dwells among all Israel,
And comes there with all the desire

Of his mind to the place *to tell*
Which YHWH chooses, 7 "then he may
serve

In the name of YHWH his God's verve,
As all his brother Levites *do*,
Who stand there *serving* before YHWH.
8 "They shall have equal parts to eat,
Besides what comes from sale of meat.

The Levite came to be the priestly caste
For many reasons, but none of which last.
Simeon and Levi were dispersed among
The tribes for a foul deed of which was
sung.

The punishment for one was turned to
blessing

Because of good deeds and the right
confessing.

But Abraham's faith made the basic rule
The father of the family was the school
To transmit Your words in the children's
way.

In practice it seems mothers hold the sway.
One can't depend on Levites in this day
And cage. Beloved, be my Levite and share
My meat and drink upon the silver stair
That goes between the earth and varied air.

9 "When you come into the land which
YHWH your God gives you *to be rich*,
You'll not follow abominations
Acquired from any of those nations.

10 "There shall not be found among you
Any who makes his son or daughter
Pass through the fire *of heathen slaughter*,
Or practices witchcraft *and brew*,

Or a soothsayer, or one who

Interprets omens, or a warlock,

11 "Or one who conjures spells *by forelock*,
Or medium, or spiritist,

Or one who calls the dead *uprist*.

12 "For all who do these things *untrue*
Are abomination to YHWH,

And because of abominations

Like these YHWH your God *takes their*
rations

And drives them out from before you.

13 "You shall be blameless before YHWH
Your Alohims *in what you do*.

14 "For these nations you'll dispossess
Listened to soothsayers *confess*
And diviners, but as for you,

YHWH your God's not set such for you.

Desire to know the future is a game
That's played by anyone at all for blame.
The very breath of life that You give me
Teaches that I depend inerrantly
For breath to breath on that sweet kiss of
life
That comes from Your lips in the midst of
strife
Or in the quiet calm or storm of sleep.
The future is a thing you alone keep.
The oracle of God that all men fear,
The universal secret all hold dear,
Is not the revelation of the day
To come or whether harvest's in the way,
But that great oracle that You pronounced
On Sinai on a day and hour announced.

15 "YHWH your God will raise up for you
A prophet like me from among
Your brothers, *Joshua unsung*.
Him you shall hear, 16 "according to
All that you have desired of YHWH
Your God in Horeb in the day
Of the assembly, come to say,
'Let me not hear again the voice
Of YHWH my Alohim *by choice*,
Nor let me see this great fire more,
Lest I die *fallen on the shore*.'

17 "And YHWH said to me 'What they've
spoken
Is good. 18 'I will raise them a token
Of prophet like you from among
Their brothers, *Joshua unsung*,
And will put My words in His mouth,
And he'll speak to them, *north and south*,
All that I shall command him to.
19 'And it shall be *that* who will not
Hear My words, which he speaks *as taught*
In My name, of him I'll require.
20 'But the prophet who would desire
To speak a word in My name, which
I have not commanded *in stitch*
For him to speak, or who speaks in
The name of other gods *for sin*,
That prophet shall die *in the din*.'
21 "And if you say in your heart 'How
Shall we know the word which YHWH's
brow
Has not spoken?' 22 "when prophets speak
In the name of YHWH, if they're weak

And the thing does not come to pass
Or happen, *but turns out as crass*,
That *is* the thing that YHWH's not spoken,
The prophet's own heart has awoken
To speak the thing presumptuously,
You'll not fear his *ability*.

This word was spoken to reveal the time
When Joshua should come in Moses' stead.
The people now wish to find room for
crime
And quarrel by seeking to have it read
For Christ or for Muhammad to exclusion
Of any other and so cause confusion.
Beloved, I read the words of them all three
And find Your revelation faithfully
Expressed to the folk to whom they
revealed
The glories of Your grace and famous
shield.

I seek no quarrel with the faithful who
Desire to see the prophets now that You
Sent after Moses to be in the queue
Of those who speak the truth, for such are
few.

Deuteronomy 19

1 "When YHWH your God's cut off the
nations
Whose land YHWH your God gives you
rations
And you drive them away and live
In their cities, *hard to forgive*,
And in their houses, 2 "you shall set
Apart three cities that you'll get
In the land which YHWH your God's
giving
You to possess *and have your living*.
3 "You shall prepare for yourself roads,
And divide your land in three loads
Which YHWH your God is giving you
To inherit, that any crew
Of manslayers may flee thereto.
4 "And this *is* the case of the one,
A manslayer, who flees *with gun*
There, that he may live: One who kills
His neighbour without guile or ills,
Not having hated him in past
5 "As when *one* goes out in the woods
With his neighbour to cut *and cast*
Timber, and his hand *filled with goods*
Swings a stroke with the axe to cut

Down the tree, and the head *unshut*
 Slips from the handle, flies and strikes
 His neighbour so he dies for spikes,
 He shall flee to one of these towns
 And live, 6 "lest the avenger frowns
 For blood, while his anger is hot,
 Pursue the manslayer *in plot*
 And overtake him, since the way
 Is long, and kill him *the same day*,
 Though he *was* not deserving death,
 Since he had not hated the *breath*
Of the victim in the time past.
 7 "Therefore I command you at last,
 Saying 'You shall set three towns off
 For yourself, *a place not to scoff.*'

It's clear some laws were made for
 Palestine
 And not for all the world enjoying fine.
 For some are limited to those conditions
 That set off Palestine by its partitions.
 And yet I find the temporary law
 A comfort for the needy in the claw
 Of the avenger that comes out today
 In every kind of country in the way.
 There's no place set aside for safety here,
 And all are at the mercy of the peer.
 Beloved, I flee to You from every fear
 Since I know there's no trusting the
 mandate
 Of those who sit for preying at the gate.
 In Your compassion I don't go astray.

8 "Now if YHWH your Alohim grants
 Enlargements to your farms' advance,
 As He swore to your fathers, and
 Gives you the land promised in hand
 To give to your fathers, 9 "and if
 You keep all these commandments *stiff*
 And do them, which I command you
 Today *and always*, to love YHWH
 Your Alohim and always walk
 In His ways, then you shall add stock
 Of three more cities for yourself
 Besides these three, 10 "lest *not for elf*
 Innocent blood be shed amid
 Your land which YHWH your God will bid
 To give you *as inheritance*,
 And *so* the guilt of bloodshed prance
 On you. 11 "But if anyone hates
 His neighbour, lies in wait in gates,
 Rises against him and strikes down,

So that he dies, flees to one town
 Of these cities, 12 "the elders of
 His city shall send *hand in glove*
 And bring him from there, and deliver
 Him over to the hand of giver
 Of blood vengeance, that he may die.
 13 "Your eye shall not pity him sly,
 But you shall put away *the guilt*
Of innocent blood from the silt
Of Israel, that it may go
 Well with you *and with all your show*.

How many people here hold it is right
 To kill and kill again for vengeance' sight,
 Or for any reason that fits the bill
 As long as no one knows who came to kill.
 Beloved, look on a world that's soaked in
 blood
 And covered with the guilt running like
 flood,
 And give another vision to the folk
 That price of oil is not worth life of bloke.
 Who now take in hand to cut at a stroke
 The guilty make a difference and clear
 Between the rich and those poor who
 appear
 Before the courts of justice and to hear
 Their sentence bought with ever less regard
 For what is true and right, and what is
 barred.

14 "You'll not remove neighbour's
 landmark,
 Which men of old have set in park,
 In your inheritance which you
 Will inherit in the land *due*
 That YHWH your God is giving you.
 15 "One witness shall not rise to speak
 Against a man concerning cheek
 Of any iniquity or
 Any sin that he sets to chore,
 By mouth of two at least or three
 Witnesses the thing shall decree.
 16 "If a false witness rises up
 Against any man *at his cup*
 To testify against him wrong,
 17 "Then both men in the struggle long
 Shall stand before YHWH, before those
 Priests and judges who *on their toes*
 Serve in those days. 18 "And they shall
 make
 Careful inquiry for the sake,

And indeed, *if* the witness *turn*
Out to be in false witness' route,
 Who's testified falsely about
 His brother, 19 "then you'll do to him
 As he thought to have done *as grim*
 To his brother, so you shall put
 Away the evil from your *foot*.
 20 "And those remaining shall hear and
 Fear, and hereafter not lift hand
 Again for such evil on land.
 21 "Your eye shall not pity, but life
Shall be for a life *in the strife*,
 Eye for eye, tooth for tooth, and hand
 For hand, foot for foot *in the land*.

My first reaction to the word of pity
 Was that such is not found in any city.
 But surely that is how the people sway
 Their sense of justice upon any day.
 Without the truth investigated some
 Are demonized and condemned with the
 scum,
 And others, who are guilty, are
 whitewashed
 To be acclaimed by every crowd that
 joshed.
 The sentiments and worked upon are what
 Become criteria for judgement shut.
 Acquittal belongs to the innocent
 Who are also hated by sight and scent.
 Beloved, acquit me for my faith in You,
 And I'll acquit You for the things You do.

Deuteronomy 20

1 "When you go out to war with foe,
 And see horses and chariots *go*,
 And crowds more numerous than you,
 Don't be afraid of them and stew,
 For YHWH your God *is* with you, who
 Brought you up from Egypt's land too.
 2 "So it shall be, when you are on
 The brink of battle, let priest draw
 Near and speak to the people *dear*.
 3 "And he shall say to them then, 'Hear,
 O Israel, today you are
 On brink of battle with your star
 Enemies. Do not let your heart
 Be faint, do not be afraid, and
 Do not tremble *upon the land*
 Or be terrified of the band,
 4 'For YHWH your God *is* He who goes
 With you, to fight for you your foes,

To save you.' 5 "Then the officers
 Shall speak to the people *and fers*,
 Saying 'What man *is there* who's built
 A new house and has not instilt
 Its dedication? Let him go
 And return to his house *and show*,
 Lest he die in the battle and
 Another man take house in hand.
 6 'Also what man *is there* who's planted
 A vineyard and has not been granted
 To eat of it? Let him go and
 Return to his house, lest he stand
 To die in battle and another
 Man eat of it *instead of brother*.
 7 'And what man *is there* who's engaged
 To a woman and not yet paged
 To marry her? Let him go and
 Return to his house, lest he stand
 To die in battle and another
 Man marry her *instead of brother*.'
 8 "The officers shall speak on yet
 To the people, and say 'What pet
Is fearful and fainthearted? Let
 Him go and return to his house,
 Lest the heart of his brother *mouse*
 Faint like his heart.' 9 "So it shall be,
 When officers have finished free
 Speaking to the people, that they
 Shall make captains of hosts to lead
 The people *as far as they need*.

Forbidden is the battle to the one
 Who has new house and garden and begun
 To court a new wife, or the one that fears.
 These laws if kept would avoid many tears.
 But think, Beloved, of Hittite named Uriah,
 Who seemed to think he was himself
 messiah
 Or that the army could not do without
 His mustering to go to battle shout.
 He forfeited a wife so that he might
 Further his own career as man to fight,
 And then was sorry that another took
 Her in his place, although he had forsook.
 No matter what You say in Your decree,
 A man will find a way to sit on scree.

10 "When you go near a city to
 Fight against it, then proclaim due
 Offer of peace. 11 "And it shall be
 If they accept peace offer's plea,
 And open to you, all the folk

Found in it shall be placed in stroke
Of tribute to you, and serve you.
12 "Now if *they* won't make peace with
you,

But make war against you, then you
Shall besiege it. 13 "And when YHWH
your

Alohim brings it to your door,
Delivering it into your hands,
You shall strike every male's bands
In it with the mouth of the sword.

14 "But the women, the little horde,
The livestock, and all in the city,
All its spoil, you shall plunder pity
For yourself, and you'll eat the plunder
Of the foe which YHWH your God's
thunder

Gives you. 15 "Thus you shall do to all
The cities *which are* a far call
From you, *which are* not of the towns
Of these nations. 16 "But of the towns
Of these peoples which YHWH your God
Gives you *as* an inheritance,
You shall let nothing *under rod*
That breathes remain alive *to prance*,
17 "But you shall utterly destroy
Them: the Hittite and the *dark ploy*
Of Amorite and Canaanite
And Perizzite and the Hivite
And Jebusite, as YHWH your God
Has commanded you, 18 "lest they prod
You to do according to all
Their abominations which call
Them to their gods, and so you sin
Against YHWH your God *in the bin*.

19 "When you besiege a city for
A long time, while yet making war
Against it to take it, you shall
Not destroy any trees at all
By wielding an ax against them,
If you can eat the fruit of them,
Do not cut them down for the yield
Of the siege, for trees of the field
Are man's *food*. 20 "Only trees which you
Know *are* not trees for food may you
Destroy and cut down for to build
Scaffolds against the city filled
With war with you, till it is stilled.

You made a plan of conquest for the folk
To go against the world and at a stroke

Make them their servants to worship You
too,

Or else destroy them for their sinful due
And for resistance to the righteous hand.
So You would make them a marauding
band.

Beloved, I see the plan repeated over
By those who claim that You are their own
drover,

And yet who do not even conform to
The ten commandments, though they are so
few.

I might support a plan to force the world
To obey Your divine law once unfurled
On Sinai in ten words of light and life.
But there is no such engine of right strife.

Deuteronomy 21

1 "If *one* is found slain, lying in
The field in the land which to win
YHWH your Alohim's giving you
To possess, *and* it's not known who
Killed him, 2 "then your elders and your
Judges shall go out and measure
From the slain man to nearest town.
3 "And it shall be the town's renown
Elders nearest to the slain man
Will take a heifer which in span
Has not been worked *and* which has not
Pulled with a yoke. 4 "The elders sought
Of that city shall bring the beast
Down to a valley with at least
Flowing water, which is not ploughed
Nor sown, and they shall break the *vowed*
Heifer's neck there within the vale.
5 "Then the priests, sons of Levi's male,
Shall come near, for YHWH your God's
veil

Has chosen them to serve and bless
In the name of YHWH *and confess*,
By their word every controversy
And every assault shall find *mercy*.
6 "And all the elders of that town
Nearest to the slain *man's* *renown*
Shall wash their hands over the beast
Whose neck was broken *by the priest*
In the valley. 7 "Then they'll respond
And say 'Our hands did not abscond
With this blood, nor did our eyes see.
8 'Provide atonement, O YHWH, free
For Your people Israel, whom You
Have redeemed, and do not lay to

Your people Israel innocent
Blood.' It shall provide atonement
On their behalf and for the blood.
9 "So you shall put away the *flood*
Of guilt of innocent shed blood
From among you and when you do
What is right in the sight of YHWH.

I do not see the folk today assume
Responsibility for the slain room.
Instead it makes a tidy note to peek
At in the paper, entertainment week.
The ground is well defiled by generations
Who cared but little for the contemplations
Of death beyond provided titillations.
The innocent heifer's broken neck seems
But little comfort for the bloody dreams
Of killing, but that gesture must repair
What nothing can where there's no life to
spare.
When shall man learn that divine life
abounds
In every creature who has I and sounds?
Beloved I flee from self to Self from
grounds.

Week 49

10 "When you go out to war with foes,
And YHWH your God delivers those
Into your hand as captives taken,
11 "And you see among unmistakable
Captives a beautiful female,
And desire her as a wife's tale,
12 "Then you shall bring her to your house,
And she shall shave her head (*for louse?*)
And trim her nails. 13 "And she shall put
Her captive clothes from off *her foot*,
Remain in your house there to mourn
Her father and mother *forlorn*
A full month, after that you may
Go in to her and be her *stay*
And husband, and she'll be your wife.
14 "And it shall be, if you have *strife*
And no delight in her, then you
Shall set her free, but surely you
Shall not sell her for money, you
Shall not treat her with cruelty,
Because you've humbled her *for free*.

The captive wife is made the first thing to
Observe the Sabbath with her nails that
grew

And with her head. A month is all it takes
To make her saint for all her heathen
wakes.
Vouchsafed for life among the dead and
dying
Who defied You with their rebellious
vying,
If she turns out still to be pagan bold,
Then even then the wench cannot be sold,
But must go free for having been the wife
Of hero soldier, one who saved her life.
Your law seems brutish to my clever ways
Who's lived in tranquil quiet all my days.
Beloved, guard humankind from taking this
Word and using it in warfare amiss.

15 "If a man has two wives, one loved
And the other unloved, *ungloved*,
And they have borne him sons, *the two*,
Both the loved and the unloved *crew*,
And *if* the firstborn son is hers
Who is unloved, 16 "then on the spurs
That he bequeaths his gear and trim
To his sons, *that* he trust not whim
To bestow firstborn status on
The son of the loved wife when drawn
In preference to the son of
The unloved, the *true* firstborn *love*.
17 "But he shall acknowledge the son
Of the unloved wife *as* the one
Firstborn by giving him a share
Of double portion of his ware,
For he's beginning of his strength,
The right's his of firstborn *at length*.

The king of Jordan kept Your Book in view
When he made elder son king in his due.
Beloved, bless every man that takes to
heart
Your commandments, if only in the part,
And give him health and store to the extent
That he bowed to Your law and where he
went.
When Israel slept with other gods in times
Past there were always those who knew no
crimes
But quietly spent providence to find
Justice and righteousness come from Your
mind.
The world seeks high parade and pompous
stand,
But better than these are the lingering band

That without fanfare makes its righteous
way
In following Your law and what You say.

18 "If a man has a stubborn son
And rebellious who'll not when done
Obey father's and mother's voice,
And *who*, when they've chastened for
choice,
Will not listen to them, 19 "then his
Father and his mother shall whizz
Him off to the elders of his
City, to his city's gate there.
20 "And they shall tell the elders *fair*
Of his city, 'This son of ours
Is stubborn and *beyond our powers*,
Rebellious, he will not obey
Our voice, *do anything we say*,
But is a glutton and a drunk.'
21 "Then all his city's men *with spunk*
Shall stone the boy to death with stones,
So you shall put away the *groans*
Of evil from among your *folk*,
And all Israel shall hear *the stroke*
And fear. 22 "If a man has committed
A sin deserving death *outwitted*,
And he is put to death, and you
Hang him on a tree *in the dew*,
23 "His body shall not stay the night
Upon the tree, but you'll do right
To bury him that day, so that
You don't defile the land where at
YHWH your Alohim gives to you
As an inheritance and due,
For he who's hanged *upon a tree*
Is cursed of Alohim *freely*.

The choice is between two, I trow, for
those
Who would abide intoxicants they chose.
If liquor is free to be had, then all
Whose genes bring them to alcoholic fall
Must be destroyed from off the face of
earth.
Failing that then the best thing and of worth
Is to prohibit the forbidden ware
And let no man at all drink of his share.
But land of drunks is not alternative
To chose, and yet the countries where we
live
Allow the drunken maniacal way
To terrorize both night and light of day.

Kill drunkards all, or forbid the dry wine
And let the government teetotal dine.

Deuteronomy 22

1 "You shall not see your brother's ox
Or his sheep go astray *from flocks*,
And hide yourself from them, you shall
Certainly bring *the prodigal*
Back to your brother. 2 "And if your
Brother *is* not near you *in store*,
Or if you do not know him, then
You'll bring it to your own house, when
It shall remain with you until
Your brother seeks it *at his will*,
Then you shall restore it to him.
3 "You'll do the same with donkey *dim*,
And so shall you do with his cloak,
With any lost thing *of the yoke*
Of your brother, which he has lost
And you have found *out to your cost*,
You shall do likewise, but you must
Not hide yourself. 4 "You shall not *lust*
Seeing your brother's donkey or
His ox fall down along the shore,
And hide yourself from them, you must
Help him lift *them up from the dust*.

If Sunnite method of analogy
Is worth the cost, then lifting up donkey
Implies also that when I meet a car
Standing beside the road with a flat tyre,
It's time for me by law to stop and help
The stranded victim and possibly whelp.
Such neighbourly ways of doing things
now
Are voluntary shows of thoughtful brow.
One breaks no law today in whizzing past,
If one asks the lawmaker set to last
By the illegal system that elects
The popular instead of just selects.
If justice were called for the legislature
Could just rely on Torah's nomenclature?

5 "A woman shall not wear a thing
Pertaining to a man *or king*,
Nor shall a man ever be seen
In clothing of woman *or queen*,
For all are outrage who do so
Before YHWH Alohim's *hello*.

It is not Your intent, I guess, to make
A fashion clear for man and woman's sake,

But rather to propose that every dress
 Distinguish clearly sexual address.
 Indeed, it is a human right, I trow,
 To know if the on-comer is a frau
 Or man, without the task of peering close
 And thus infringing on the intimate.
 To sneer at laws of dress gives just a dose
 To think one has the right to sit in state
 Without limits of person and private.
 In Palestine I guess woman and man
 Both wore a dress, and yet within the span
 Of knowing which was which. I think I
 can.

6 "If a bird's nest happens to be
 Before you in the way or tree
 Or on the ground, with young ones or
 Eggs, with dam sitting on the score
 Of young or on the eggs, you'll not
 Take the dam with the young on spot,
 7 "You'll surely let the mother go,
 And take the young for your own show,
 That it may be well with you and
 You may lengthen days *in the land*.

Command is not to take the egg or young,
 And leave the mother, but command on
 tongue
 Is not to take both mother and the lot.
 The intent is to leave nature a spot
 For her continuing to weave her plot.
 By reason or analogy the word
 Is to preserve the future of the bird
 As well as every other creature heard.
 The verse of conservation in two lines
 Sounds like the sweetness of the finest
 wines.
 Though humankind in hunger and in fear
 May take a twig and fruit without a tear,
 Still even in his need duty replies
 That nature too have place beneath the
 skies.

8 "When you build a new house, then you
 Shall make a parapet for *view*
About your roof, that you may not
 Bring guilt of bloodshed on *the lot*
Of your household if one should fall.

Beloved, You command me and
 humankind
 To take precaution for safety designed.

It is a duty, not a choice to make
 Provision and forethought for safety's sake.
 The mystic prayer that rises in Your will
 Finds health in reason to resound on hill
 And make the action of the human hand
 Appropriate to that reality
 That plays upon the sea and on the sand
 With waverings and rushings on the lea.
 To leave a danger for another soul
 In building or in taking up the toll
 Of life in drinking bout, all these are wrong
 That merely focus on the dance and song.

9 "You shall not sow your vineyard *will*
 With different kinds of seed, lest yield
 Of the seed which you've sown *in field*
 And the fruit of your vineyard be
 Defiled. 10 "You shall not plough *freely*
 With ox and donkey both together.
 11 "You shall not wear a garment whether
 Of different sorts, *such as both* wool
 And linen mixed to *push and pull*.
 12 "You shall make tassels on the four
 Corners of the cloak that you wore.

Mix not the seed, the beast, the cloth in
 plot.
 Three laws of similarity in thought
 Precede the law of tassels on the four
 Wings of the cloak instruct in something
 more.
 The four gates rise from these words as
 they come
 And the four tassels make the four gates'
 sum.
 The seed is law, the beast the gate of love,
 And warp and woof awareness of above.
 Reality is never to be seen,
 And must have a reminder on the green,
 That illusion's marks always tell the sheen.
 Reminder be not only strands of wool,
 But everything that makes a good world
 full.
 Beloved, You are the One of my heart's
 pull.

13 "If a man takes a wife, and goes
 In to her, and detests her *flows*,
 14 "And charges her with shameful act,
 And brings a bad name on her *sacked*,
 And says 'I took this woman, and
 When I came to her *for a band*

I found she *was* not a virgin,'
15 "Then the father and mother win
With the young woman when they take
And bring out for the virgin's sake
Evidence of virginity
To the elders of the city
At the gate *and for all to see*.

Ah my Beloved! It is indeed a shame
To bring a bloody cloth out as a claim
Before the elders of the city set
To titter at the evidence of Bett.
For shame that such a law might need to
be.

I'd think faithfulness, not virginity
Would be a man's plausible expectation.
But fair enough, let purity arise
And sit enthroned before the shameful
eyes.

I'd merely like a test that shows as well
What the boy's been doing twixt earth and
hell,
To keep himself from sickness and the
spell.

I have no evidence of chastity
Since You with each breath come to ravish
me.

16 "And the young woman's father shall
Say to the elders, 'I gave gal
To this man as wife, and he hates
Her. 17 'Now he's charged her and relates
Shameful behaviour, saying "I
Found your daughter not spotless by,"
And yet these *are* my daughter's proofs
Of her virginity, *his goofs*.'

And they shall spread the cloth before
The elders at the city *door*.

18 "Then the elders of that city
Shall take that man, punish freely,
19 "And they shall fine him one hundred
Of silver and give *them full fed*
To the father of the young girl,
Because he has been playing churl
To bring a bad name on a girl
Of Israel. And she shall be
His wife, he cannot divorce her
All his days *till his death occur*.

I'd think the girl would like to be free from
The fetters of such marriage to a bum.
But there's no sense in other people's tastes,

And trying to find such results in wastes
Of time and energy. So let her be
The churl's consort and for eternity.
The hundred of silver I think would lead
The fathers to be careful of the breed,
And watch like hawk preserving scent of
deed

In order to cash in on fresh young seed.
What other punishment the young man gets
Seems rather unclear as the wording sets.
Perhaps it is as much as they think due
Who sit in judgement in the city's pew.

20 "But if the thing is true, *and sight*
Of virgin chastity's not right
For the young woman, 21 "then they'll
bring

Out the young woman at the swing
Of the door of her father's home,
And the men who her city roam
Shall stone her to the death with stones,
Because she's sung disgraceful tones
In Israel, to play the harlot
In her father's house *like a starlet*.
So you shall put away the wrong
From among you *and from your song*.

I'd think the reputation would get round
Before he ever married her or found
A reason to shame her once vows were
made.

Who play the harlot in father's house paid
Become notorious by man and maid.
But if he will to put an end to such
He can marry her and then put the touch
On her before the council of the old,
The ones no doubt who first had her for
bold.

But put away the wrong, indeed, I hope
That might be every city's way to grope.
Where I live such is done as each confesses
By whatever each adult party guesses
Is right and feels good as each one
undresses.

22 "If a man ever is found lying
With a woman married *and sighing*
To a husband, then both of them
Shall die, the man that *lifted hem*
To lie with the woman, as well
As the woman, so you shall spell
Away evil from Israel.

The punishment for the unfaithful wife
Is not just to take away wretched life
From her, but also from the man she
spoiled

Or who enticed her in the trap uncoiled.
Not one without the other as I read,
So courts who pass a judgement and with
speed

On woman only do not keep Your law.
They only have male vengeance in their
awe.

I plead the case of every woman caught
By pregnancy, which is no witness sought,
For by that last expedient the Christ
Himself would be a victim of the spliced,
And blessed virgin Mary killed before
She had a chance to even up the score.

23 "If a young woman *who's* a virgin
Is betrothed to a husband *urging*,
And a man finds her in the city
And lies with her *and has no pity*,
24 "Then you shall bring both of them out
To the gate of that city *stout*,
And you shall stone them to death there
With stones, the young woman *as fair*
Because she did not cry aloud
In the city *and in the crowd*,
And the man because he had ploughed
His neighbour's wife, so you shall put
Away the evil from your foot.

In case of rape the only thing to do
Is cry aloud, yet in perverseness' pew
I ask what shall be case if man have knife
Or broken bottle to threaten the life
And strongly urge her not to make a sound?
Then even in the city there is found
An innocence not crying out or weeping.
Beloved, in faith I follow, not in peeping
Behind the veils of wisdom You are
keeping.

My doubting sighs are but the gifts of love
I send You whether beneath or above.
The cobblestones shine with the glint of
light
Amphiboles bare to the sun in sight.
The black grains are the brightest of the
right.

25 "If a man finds betrothed a lass

In the fields, and the man is crass
To force her and lies with her there,
Then only the man *for his share*
Who lay with her shall die. 26 "But you
Shall do nothing to the lass true,
There's in the young woman no sin
For death, for as when one begin
To rise against his neighbour and
Kills him, even so's this *in hand*.

A problem's in this text, a problem great.
First of all it accepts analogy
As valid of proof for a verdict's state,
And as a problem there is secondly,
There is a case when a man meets his fate
For the adulterous act and the girl's free,
A case that hardly anyone might see
Among the courts of shariat. With this
One text injustice attributes in bliss
To both the Sunnite and Shi'ite who kiss.
I flee to You, Beloved, from every sect
That runs to injustice of the elect,
And know that one soul stands before Your
word

Clear-eyed without the clergy and absurd.

27 "For he found her there in the field,
And the betrothed lass would not yield
But cried out, and *there was* no one
To save her. 28 "If a man *undone*
Finds a young woman *who is still*
A virgin, who's not engaged *rill*,
And he seizes and lies with her,
And they are found out *in the stir*,
29 "Then the man who lay with her shall
Give to the lass's pa's corral
Fifty of silver, and she'll be
His wife because he's *cravenly*
Humbled her, and he shall not be
Permitted to divorce her all
His days *upon the city wall*.

Note well, Beloved, how Your law's greater
mercy
Surpasses that of Puritanly curse.
The only punishment that You lay down
On sex premarital is marriage crown
With no right to divorce. The clergyman
Of churchly traditions hands down that ban
On every marriage that he sanctifies,
And right to divorces staunchly denies,
Unless it's divorce for unfaithfulness.

But that requires no divorce I would guess,
Since for that death's the sentence You
confess.

The only valid divorce is the one
In which unfaithfulness was never done!
Beloved, I flee from verdicts that have
won.

30 "A man shall not take father's wife,
Nor enter father's bed *for strife*.

Mother and step-mother are out of bounds
To every father's son upon the grounds.
The Reubenitic sin I must confess
Requires perversion beyond my address.
But what about the case of young widow
Who has no closer kith to make the show
Than the stepson of father without brother
To raise up for her husband one or other
Of children to his name? The levirate
Of nearest relative has limitations.
Yet it is kept with sacred indications,
I wonder it's not made a universal
Despite the fall of the folk and dispersal.
I stop beside the gate to contemplate
The veiling of the human face and where
It leads in lust beneath the golden stair.

Deuteronomy 23

1 "He who has lost his testicles
By crushing or by mutilation
Shall not enter conventicles
Of YHWH. 2 "One of illegal station
In birth shall not enter the crowd
Of YHWH, not even is allowed
To the tenth generation none
To enter the assembly done
To YHWH. 3 "An Ammonite or one
Moabite shall not enter YHWH's
Assembly, even though they choose
To the tenth generation none
Of his *descendants* shall come in
The assembly of YHWH *for sin*
Forever, 4 "because they did not
Meet you with bread and water *sought*
On the road when you came up from
Egypt, and because they were gum
To hire against you Beor's son
Balaam from Pethor *where the sun*
Rises on Mesopotamia,
To curse you and *lead from the law*.

A serious thing it is to lead away
From worship of You the only to sway
The universe, the round of night and day,
Creator of the great and small, the clay
Of sparrows, the crow and the twit of finch,
The green of moss spreading out inch by
inch,

The mountain ash from white to green to
red,

The polliwogs that swarm in pools unfed
By any stream at corner of my house,
The nibbling practices of the field mouse.
Beloved, a serious thing it is to see
The divine graces and yet fail to be
In awe of You alone beneath the throne,
Upon the summer grasses newly mown.

5 "Nevertheless YHWH your God would
Not listen to Balaam *for good*,
But YHWH your God turned the curse to
A blessing for you, because YHWH
Your Alohim *truly* loves you.

6 "You shall not seek their peace nor their
Prosperity all your days *fair*
Forever. 7 "You shall not abhor
An Edomite, for he *is* your
Brother. And you shall not abhor
An Egyptian, because you were
An alien in his land *for bur*.

8 "The children of third generation
Born to them may come *with elation*
Into the assembly of YHWH,
Who brings you here with promise true.

Enslavement was a sin worth punishment
Of generations three and be content,
While the sin of Peor required vengeance
Not only of young Phineas's lance,
But of ten generations at a glance
Even when they engaged in repentance.
Beloved, keep me from Peor's sin and all
Idolatry of Balaam's fateful call
To consider the God that made the ball
The same as Baal and Ashtoreth's cow stall.
Let rather the three-generations' fear
Of the gods of Oxford Street plant my bier,
Than the die of the trinities I see
Revered in chapel and the grand abbey.

9 "When the army goes out to fight
Your enemies, then keep your right
From every wicked thing *in sight*.

10 "If there is any man among
 You who becomes unclean by dung
 Occurring in the night, then he
 Shall go outside the camp *a wee*,
 He shall not come inside the camp.
 11 "But it shall be, when evening *damp*
 Comes, that he'll wash with water, and
 When the sun sets, he may take stand
 To come into the camp. 12 "Also
 You shall have a place where to go
 Outside the camp, 13 "and you shall keep
 An implement among your things,
 And when you sit outside, dig deep
 And cover your filthy droppings.
 14 "For YHWH your God walks in your
 camp,
 To save you and give *like a stamp*
 Your enemies over to you,
 So keep your camp holy *and new*,
 That He may see no unclean thing
 Among you and turn from your *swing*.

Beloved, I understand Your feet of flame
 Are sullied if they touch the stinking shame
 Of excrement, but now the practice is
 To flush the stuff away with whirl and fizz.
 Do You require still implement to hoe
 Away a pit for excrements to go?
 Or can a follower of Yours now toe
 The line to water-closet and feel fine?
 Such questions may seem beneath Your
 consent,
 But men are supercilious in event.
 At least I leave no thing uncovered where
 Your foot might slip and find unsoughten
 share,
 But let You in my chamber sweet and bare
 And keep You, my Beloved, encloistered
 there.

15 "You shall not give back to his master
 The slave who's escaped and run faster
 Than his master to you *in flight*.
 16 "He may live with you in your sight,
 In the place which he chooses *states*
And there within one of your gates,
 Where it seems best to him, you'll not
 Oppress him. 17 "There shall be no *sot*
Ritual harlot on the spot
 Among Israel's daughters, or one
 Perverted of Israelite son.

In days gone past my forebears on
 plantation
 Hid in the sugar cellar's trepidation
 The fugitive that fled to Canada
 Escaping the new fugitive slave law.
 It seems that law despite the pulpit wrath
 That maintained it was a Hamitic path
 To serve the brook of Japheth in his tents
 Without remuneration of ten cents,
 Was that if slave escaped one should not
 send
 Him back to master but keep as a friend.
 How did Your preachers explain this text
 then
 To satisfaction of women and men?
 They had to know it, since the one to come
 About dogs was well known to every bum.

18 "You shall not bring such harlot's wages
 Or fee of *sacred temple pages*
That hump like dogs to the house of
 YHWH your God *in pretended love*
 For any vowed offering, for both
 Of these *are* an atrocious wroth
 To YHWH your Alohim above.

The Southern Baptists I know still recoil
 At harlot's wages and refuse to soil
 Their hands by taking payment for a dog
 To be sold from their litter apologue.
 The sense is misconstrued, I say right well.
 The harlot and the dog in Israel
 Were functionaries on the temple mounts
 Of Baal and Ashtoreth for their accounts.
 The sexy priests and priestesses today
 Who are their counterparts in their own
 way
 Are those who sing and shout with hips that
 sway
 Inviting crowds to drink the blood and eat
 The body of the dying god for feat
 To resurrect at Easter as is meet.

19 "You'll not charge interest to your
 brother,
 Interest on money, food *or* other
 That's lent out at interest to him.
 20 "To a stranger you may charge *dim*
 Interest, but to your brother you
 Shall not charge interest, so that YHWH
 Your God may bless you in all to
 Which you set your hand *and to do*

In the land which you're coming to
 To enter and possess *accrue*.
 It's clear that charging interest in the end
 Results in war, no other ways amend.
 The one who worships You alone as God
 Has right to charge polytheist a clod
 If he knows that the thing will end in war,
 And is ready to fight the further shore,
 And swell Your kingdom by the further
 stand
 Of taking cities to tribute for land.
 But without such theocracy to sell,
 No usury has right to thrive and dwell.
 I flee to You, Beloved, from usury
 And from the strife that comes from
 banker's fee.
 Let every hand find his own property
 And eat the produce of his hand for free.

21 "But when you make a vow to YHWH
 Your God, you shall not delay to
 Pay it, for YHWH your Alohim
 Will surely require to redeem
 It of you, and it would be sin
 To you. 22 "But if you abstain in
 Vowing, it shall not be a sin
 To you. 23 "That which has gone from lip
 You shall keep and perform *the trip*,
 For you of free will vowed to YHWH
 Your Alohim what promise *due*
 You have made with your mouth *to do*.

Beloved, keep me from every vow of lip
 And give me grace to mind my tongue and
 skip
 The promises unneeded by my ship.
 What promises are there but that would
 hold
 Another from his own by choice and bold?
 Who promises but to escape the cold
 Of neighbour for profit come in to scold?
 I vow to my own self, Beloved, that I
 Shall not vow anything beneath the sky
 But that You are precious to my blind eye
 That cannot penetrate the veil and sash.
 Let every other promising be clash.
 I stay myself aloof and keep my cash.
 On You and You alone I can rely.

24 "When you come to vineyard of
 neighbour,
 You may eat your fill at your labour

Of grapes, but you shall not put *any*
 Into container *for a penny*.

25 "When you come in your neighbour's
 corn,
 Standing grain, you may pluck ears *shorn*
 With your hand, but you'll not use sickle
 On your neighbour's standing corn fickle.

The right of every man is to stretch hand
 Upon the fruit of field and take a stand
 To mouth and stomach while he's on the
 land.

It's only berry basket that's condemned
 In the white vineyard behind a wall
 hemmed.

When I was but a child the oranges grew
 Along the wayside where we would drive
 through,
 And all who wished could stop to taste the
 fresh
 Fruit from the tree if none were brought in
 mesh

Away to taste another time and day.
 Such is not found, I think, now on that way,
 Because some took advantage of the spill.
 That's how the government foots every bill.
 For one wrong deprive all of rights to fill.

Deuteronomy 24

1 "When a man takes a wife and marries,
 And it happens that that wife carries
 No favour in his eyes because
 He's found in her some unclean flaws,
 And he writes her bill of divorce,
 And puts *it* in her hand perforce,
 And sends her out of his house *void*,
 2 "When she's departed *unemployed*
 From his house, and goes to become
 Another man's *wife*, 3 "*if* the bum,
 The latter husband hates her too
 And writes her a bill of divorce,
 Puts *it* in her hand *when he's through*,
 And sends her out of house *and home*,
 Or if the latter husband's course
 Is to die, who took under dome
 As his wife, 4 "*then* her former man
 Who divorced her must not make plan
 To take her back to be his wife
 After she's been defiled *for strife*,
 For that's atrocious before YHWH,
 And you shall not bring sin on you
 And upon the country which YHWH

Your God inheritance gives you.

Here is the basic law and the law just
That says a woman must not go for lust
Back to a husband that's divorced for trust
After she's been married to other men.
Islamic law once stated's quite reversed,
And says a woman must remarry first
Before she can go back to the first man.
A misapplying of the first words can
Result in contradictions in the way.
Divorce not my heart from Your own and
do

Not send my spirit from outside Your view.
But keep my soul and self bared to Your
sight
Though I am blinded by the shimmering
night,
Groping forever in the dim starlight.

5 "When a man's taken a new wife,
He shall not go out to the strife
Or be charged with any affair,
He shall be free at home one year,
And bring gladness to his wife's share
Whom he has taken *without tear*.

6 "No man shall take the lower or
The upper millstone in pledge, for
He takes *one's* living in pledge *score*.

7 "If a man is found kidnapping
Any of his brothers *in string*
Of Israel's children, and mistreating
Him or sells him, then that defeating
Kidnapper shall die, and you'll put
Away the evil from your *foot*.

8 "Then take heed in any outbreak
Of leprosy but *for your sake*
You carefully observe and do
According to all that is due,
That priests, the Levites, shall teach you,
Just as I commanded, *so* you
Shall be careful to do. 9 "Recall
What YHWH your God did at the fall
Of Miriam on the way when you
Came out of Egypt. 10 "When you lend
Your brother anything *to spend*,
You shall not go into his home
To get his pledge *from loom or loam*.

The ATF men who rush in I guess
Have not read this verse where You do
confess

The sacredness of house and home and
bless

The privacy to keep one's door closed still
Even when valid comers come for bill.
Justice is always served best when men will
Remember Your word and obey it till
All faces gather before Your one face
And judgement is met at the mercy place.
I flee to You, Beloved, from every ill
And from every attempting to fulfil
Justice upon the basis of the part
A man sees natural within veiled heart.
Perennially the pagan good must start.

11 "You shall stand outside, and the man
To whom you lend shall bring as can
The pledge out to you. 12 "If the man
Is poor, you shall not keep his pledge
Overnight. 13 "You in any edge
Shall return the pledge to him when
The sun goes down, that he again
May sleep in his own garment and
Bless you, and it shall be command
Of righteousness to you before
YHWH your God *now and evermore*.

The perfect man is one indeed who may
Work early for his bread from day to day,
And take that single share his own for pay
And then lie down to rest upon the cloak
He wore throughout the day by field and
oak.

Such poverty is not a virtue, but
It often resides where the world has shut
The honest and the just to live a part.
Such poverty when honest to the heart
Is greater than the one who lends the cart
And keeps the pledge till evening in his
hand.

This verse opens a great and glorious land
Beyond the veils to see what sparkling gem
Is sewn on human being at his hem.

14 "You'll not oppress a hired servant
Who is poor and needy *and scant*,
Whether one of your brothers or
One of the strangers who's *in store*
In your land and within your gates.
15 "Each day you shall give *him* his rates,
And not let sun go down on it,
For he's poor and sets heart on it,
Lest he cry against you to YHWH,

And it shall be a sin to you.

How many cry in this world now I know
Not, nor do I know what the pompous show
Of faith in the establishment bestow
To make the poor content to plough the
row.

I know that every cry that rises up
To You to beg that You might fill the cup
Seems vain because the drought goes on
and on

And generations meet it with the spawn.
Yet I believe Your words and so resign
My soul to Your justice at the recline,
And pray that every morsel that's ill spent
Burn on the tongue of those who'll not
relent.

I look, Beloved, from here beneath my vine
And sip the inextinguishable wine.

16 "Fathers shall not be put to death
For *their* children, nor shall the breath
Of children be taken for father,
A person shall be punished *rather*
For his own sin. 17 "You'll not pervert
Justice due the stranger or *hurt*
The fatherless, nor take garment
Of a widow as a pledge *sent*.

18 "But you shall remember that you
Were a slave in Egypt, and YHWH
Your God redeemed you all from there,
Therefore I command you this share.
19 "When you reap your harvest in field,
And forget a sheaf in the field,
You shall not go back to get it,
It shall be for the stranger's *kit*,
The fatherless, and widow, that
YHWH your Alohims may bless you
In all your hands' work where you sat.

20 "When you beat your olive trees, you
Shall not go over boughs again,
It shall be for the stranger *due*,
The fatherless, and widow *then*.

21 "When you gather your vineyard's
grapes,
You'll not glean after it with scrapes,
It shall be for the stranger, and
Fatherless, widow *in the land*.

22 "And you shall remember that you
Were a slave in Egypt's land too,
Therefore this thing I command you.

I live upon the gleanings of the rich
That I find cast up on the heath and ditch.
And so I must share the thanks I give You
With the oppressors of the faint and crew.
I take the leavings and my heart swells high
In praise to You whose hand created nigh
The refuse dump and flee market to be
The source of every nourishment to me,
Despite the revenue upon the dearth.
The symbiotic dance of dog and flea,
The web of life that glorifies the earth,
I find full of Your praises and Your worth,
And turn the bitter herb and fitly bread
To banquets, my Beloved, where we are
fed.

Deuteronomy 25

1 "If there's a dispute between men,
And they come to the court again,
That the *judges* may judge them, and
They *justify* the righteous and
Condemn the wicked *by command*,
2 "Then it shall be, if wicked man
Deserves to be beaten, *by plan*
The judge will cause him to lie down
And be beaten before his frown,
According to his guilt, with such
A number of blows. Not too much,
3 "Forty lashes he may give him
And no more, lest he should pass brim
And beat him many blows above these,
And your brother, *and not to love these*,
Diminish in your sight. 4 "You'll not
Muzzle an ox treading what's sought.

Three punishments recur, Beloved, in Your
Law, first that of restoring to the store
What has been stolen, second death it
seems

For sundry offences from lusty dreams
To homicide, and lastly for some things
A caning before all the court for kings
And commoners alike. The limitation
On lashes is so no one in the nation
Will be despised. Beloved, Your way of
looking

At things is more far out than German
cooking.

The pagan way to justice is take fines
To support state and lobbyist oil mines,
Or to incarcerate the convict years.
The victim we leave to his fate and fears.

5 "If brothers live together, and
 One of them dies and *on the land*
 Has no son, widow of the dead
 Man shall not *marry in his stead*
 A stranger outside *family*,
 Her husband's brother shall go free
 In to her, take her as his wife,
 And perform the duty of life
 Of a husband's brother to her.
 6 "And it shall be *that at the stir*
 The firstborn son which she bears will
 Succeed to the name of his *still*
 Dead brother, that his name may not
 Be blotted out of Israel's *spot*.

The levirate is known to Israel's fame
 In ancient times and to some early claim
 Of primitives down to the century
 Of world wars. Does that make the bishop
 see

That feathered, painted flocks sometimes
 compare
 To Your law better than the great and fair
 In dainty gatherings to eat pork pie?
 I doubt that porkers have yet learned to fly.
 Are You concerned about transmission of
 A family name more than a match of love?
 In some societies the name goes down
 By woman rather than by man and crown.
 In such case should a woman's sister take
 The living husband for the dead girl's sake?

7 "But if the man does not want to
 Take his brother's wife, what she'll do,
 His brother's wife will go up to
 The gate to the elders, and say
 'My husband's brother will not stay
 To raise up a name to his brother
 In Israel, he'll not for another
 Perform my husband's brother's duty.'

8 "Then his city's elders in *beauty*
 Shall call him and speak to him. But
 He stands firm and says *his word shut*,
 'I do not want to take her,' 9 "then
 His brother's wife before the men,
 Shall come to him in elders' sight,
 Remove his sandal from his *right*
 Foot, spit in his face, say responding,
 'So shall it be to man *desponding*
 Who will not build his brother's home.'

10 "And his name shall be called *for gnome*

In Israel, 'The house of him
 Who had his sandal removed *grim*.'

What of the case, Beloved, when woman
 hates
 The very shadow of her husband's brother's
 Awakening to put on roller skates?
 I guess such women ought to take another
 Look at the brother before saying yes
 To marriage proposal, oh yes, I guess.
 Don't marry man unless you're satisfied
 To marry all the brothers and abide.
 There's no levirate in this time and place
 Which may explain why families of that
 race
 Are now extinct. The honoured world gets
 by
 Without the noble genealogy
 That harks back without intermission to
 Adam the first and give or take a few.

11 "If *two* men fight together, and
 The wife of one draws near *her hand*
 To rescue husband from the hand
 Of the one attacking him, and
 Puts out her hand and seizes him
 By genitals, 12 "then you shall trim
 Off her hand, your eye shall not pity,
For what she did just was not witty.

Zounds! A punishment, fourth to beat the
 track!

And one to compare with the glorious back
 Of eye for eye and tooth for tooth in slack.
 At least the woman that lays hold upon
 And twists a man's balls is not kept till
 dawn

To fret about her fate, how many years
 She'll be behind bars and to feed her tears
 With fines. The same is given by
 The holy Qur'an for the cunning sly
 One who steals aught from market
 property.

A tooth for chewing and an eye to see,
 Such restitution sets the convict free
 To sin perhaps or else act righteously.
 Beloved, I cantillate Your word and try.

13 "You shall not have within your bag
 Differing weights, heavy *to sag*
 And a light. 14 "You shall not have in
 Your house differing measures' *bin*,

A large and a small. 15 "You'll have right
 And just weight, and a right and just
 Measure, that your days may be light
 And long in the land *on the dust*
 Which YHWH your Alohim gives you.
 16 "For all who do such things, all who
 Behave unrighteously with lust,
Are atrocious to YHWH your God.

There's not a man who breathes but
 understands
 That just measure and weight upon the
 sands
 Makes for just and peaceful society.
 And just as much there's hardly one to be
 So just in all he does and faithfully.
 Who does not have a friend to whom he
 spills
 A cheaper rate than writ on others' bills?
 The benefit to friends also makes ill
 And constitutes a difference in weights
 And measures and a juggling of the scales.
 I wonder if society of whales
 Might not be more to suit Your words and
 law,
 And whether the souls that must screech
 and caw
 Are not more in line with the heavenly
 tales.

17 "Recall what Amalek *with prod*
 Did to you on the way as you
 Were coming out of Egypt *too*,
 18 "How he met you upon the way
 And attacked your rear ranks *and stay*,
 All the stragglers at your rear, when
 You *were both* tired and weary men,
 And he did not fear Alohim.
 19 "Therefore it shall be, *as in dream*,
 When YHWH your God has given you rest
 From your enemies east and west,
 In the land which YHWH your God's
 giving
 You to possess *as place* to live in,
 That you'll blot out remembrance of
 Amalek from under heaven's *love*.
 You'll not forget *Amelek's sin*.

The retribution paid on the grandsons
 Of those who under evil, bloody suns
 Lashed out upon the straggling ewes and
 lambs,

And struck the feeble in their cogs and
 cams,
 Lacks sweetness of revenge, not done in
 hate,
 But at the instigation of Your State.
 You command killing all the progeny
 Of those who damaged hand and head and
 knee
 And thus fulfilled commanding to the letter
 Of visiting on generations better,
 On third and fourth for what grandfathers
 did.
 Would not Israel have fought with fuller
 lust
 If You had forbidden the sacred trust?
 No wonder, Beloved, that You went and
 hid.

Week 50 Deuteronomy 26

1 "And it shall be, when you come to
 The land which YHWH your God gives
 you
As an inheritance, and you
 Possess and live in it, 2 "that you
 Shall take some of the first of all
 The produce of the ground *to fall*,
 Which you shall bring in from your land
 YHWH your God's putting in your hand,
 And put *it* in a basket and
 Go to the place where YHWH your God
 Chooses to put His name on sod.
 3 "And you shall go to the one who
 Is priest in those days, and say to
 Him, 'I today tell YHWH your God
 That I've come to the land which YHWH
 Swore to our fathers to give us.'
 4 "The priest shall take the basket out
 Of your hand and *without a fuss*
 Set it down in front of the altar
 Of YHWH your God *and not to falter*.
 5 "And you shall answer, you shall say
 Before YHWH *your God without shout*
 'My father was a Syrian,
 About to perish, *a lone man*,
 And he went down to Egypt and
 Lived there, few in number *at hand*,
 And there he became a great nation,
 Mighty and populous *in station*.
 6 'The Egyptians mistreated us,
 Afflicted us, and laid on us
 Hard bondage. 7 'Then we cried out to
 YHWH Alohim, our fathers' *view*,

And YHWH heard our voice and looked on
 Our affliction and woebegone
 Labour also our oppression.
 8 'So YHWH brought us out of Egypt
 With a mighty hand *and not clipped*
 With an outstretched arm, and with great
 Terror and with *appropriate*
 Signs and wonders. 9 'He has brought us
 To this place and has given us
 This land, "a land flowing with milk
 And honey *sweet and soft as silk,*"
 10 'And now, indeed, I here have brought
 The firstfruits of the land *I sought*
 Which you, O YHWH, have given me.'
 Then you shall set it before YHWH
 Your God, and worship *faithfully*
 Before YHWH your God *as is due.*
 11 "So you'll rejoice in every good
 Which YHWH your God's given *or could*
 To you and your house, and to you
 And the Levite and the strange few
 Aliens who are among you.

Where the grandfathers have a village
 house
 Not to be pillaged by the village mouse
 The people bring in basket and in store
 The firstfruits of the red-earthed land and
 more.
 But I live here beneath the fir and pine,
 And my firstfruits are but the slender wine
 Of birch and aspen on a rocky shore.
 My birchen basket holds hardly a score
 Of berries as the summer turns to fall.
 The firstfruits I bring You, Beloved, are
 small.
 Yet I bring You the sacrifice of self
 And what I've saved for You upon the
 shelf,
 I bring them all into the temple vast
 Of sun shining at midnight unsurpassed.

12 "When you have finished laying by
 All the tithe of your increased *rye*
 In the third year, the year of tithing,
 And given *it* to the Levite *writhing*,
 The stranger, fatherless, and widow,
 So they may eat in your gates, *kiddo*,
 Be satisfied, 13 "then you shall say
 Before YHWH your God 'I've removed
 The holy *tithe as was approved*
 From *my* house, and also have given

Them to the Levite, stranger *striven*,
 The fatherless, and widow, by
 All Your commandments which You *try*
 To lay upon me, I have not
 Transgressed Your commandments *a jot*,
 Nor have I forgotten *them aught*.
 14 'I have not eaten any of
 It when in mourning, nor *like dove*
 Have I removed for an unclean
Use, nor given *some* for the dead.
 I have obeyed the voice *instead*
 Of YHWH my God, and have been *seen*
 To do according to all that
 You have commanded where I sat.
 15 'Look down from Your holy abode,
 From heaven, and bless Your people's *load*,
 Israel and the land which You've given
 Us, just as You swore for to live in
 For our fathers, "a land flowing
 With milk and honey *in a string.*"

Ah my Beloved, might I give true account
 That I have kept Your law given on the
 mount
 And spoken by my own tongue every week
 And many evenings as my poor soul seek
 The coming of the morning at Your breath.
 Might I witness I've kept Your law till
 death.
 As You look down from Your holy abode
 And see the earth spread out and well-
 bestowed,
 I pray You might see also that I keep
 Your holy law both when I wake and sleep.
 Turn out Your blessing on my lifted hand
 And let the other confer where I stand
 Upon the dergah and on those who weep
 And on those joyful ones who dance and
 leap.

16 "This day YHWH your God commands
 you
 To observe these statutes *in view*
 And judgements, therefore you shall be
 Careful to observe them freely
 With all your heart and all your soul.
 17 "Today you have proclaimed the goal
 That YHWH's to be your Alohim,
 And that you'll walk His ways and deem
 To keep His statutes, His commands,
 And His judgements, and that *in bands*
 You will obey His voice. 18 "Also

Today YHWH has proclaimed the mot
 That you're to be His special folk,
 Just as He promised you *a poke*,
 That *you* should keep all His commands,
 19 "And that He will set you high *hands*
 Above all nations which He's made,
 In praise, in name, in honour *paid*,
 And that you may be holy folk
 To YHWH your God, just as He spoke."

The purpose of the heart and soul or nafs
 Is stated here, quite simply without gaffs,
 To observe these statutes and judgements
 that

You once spoke on Sinai where the folk
 sat.

The nafs is not a thing to struggle out,
 The heart is not a place to feel about,
 But both are fields among illusions' sway
 To observe Your laws each and every way.
 The thunder and the still small voice
 combine

To cantillate the pleasures of the wine
 Of Torah and to sigh the words alone
 In melancholy or unfeeling stone.
 Beloved, I flee from nafs to You once more
 And find nafs still filling the true heart's
 store.

Deuteronomy 27

1 Now Moses, with the elders of
 Israel, commanded folk *in love*,
 Saying "Keep all the commands I
 Command to you today *for aye*.
 2 "And it shall be, on the day when
 You cross over the Jordan *then*
 To the land which YHWH your God gives
 You, that you shall set up *like sieves*
 For yourselves large stones, and whitewash
 Them with lime. 3 "You shall write *in posh*
Letters on them all this law's words,
 When you've crossed over *eating curds*,
 That you may enter in the land
 Which YHWH your Alohim in hand
 Is giving you, 'a land flowing
 With milk and honey *like a spring*,'
 Just as YHWH the God of your fathers
 Promised you. 4 "Therefore *without*
bothers

It shall be, when you have crossed over
 The Jordan *after you've been rover*,
 That on Mount Ebal you shall set

Up these stones, which I command yet
 This day to you, and you'll whitewash
 Them with lime *and so make them posh*.

The stones set up on Ebal so I fear
 Have been bones of contention many a year
 Despite the fact, if fact it is, that they
 Have disappeared from sight for many a
 day.

The whitewashed stones are gone, and yet
 the power

That made them in men's hearts forget the
 hour

Is still to be found where sectarian views
 Rise up to make the wayward people
 choose.

The Jew is pitted once against the folk
 Of Samaria, which was Persian cloak
 Of divide them to rule them, so they chose
 To differ about Eli and the rose.
 Once Arius and Nestorius fell in plot,
 The Chalcedonian fight raised up a clot.

The stones of Ebal still stand in men's
 hearts

Despite their passing from the mountain's
 parts.

The quarrel about Eli meets its goal
 In prophetic fulfilment in the soul
 Of Ali, who divides the Muslim camp
 Into sectarian parties on the ramp.
 Ah my Beloved, I love both Eli and
 Ali who rose to fight and then to stand,
 But I chose no sect in the flying field
 To batter or to barter with my yield.
 Instead I flee to You alone and take
 The epithets of all and for Your sake
 Live Jew, Samaritan and Christian too,
 Both Sunni and Shi'ite in what I do.

5 "And there you'll build an altar to
 YHWH your God, a stone altar, you
 Shall not use an iron *tool* on them.

6 "You'll build with whole stones *all the*
hem

Of the altar of YHWH your God,
 And offer burnt offerings *on sod*
 To YHWH your Alohim. 7 "You'll offer
 Peace offerings, and shall eat there *coffer*,
 And rejoice before YHWH your God.

8 "And you shall very plainly write
 On the stones all this law's words bright."

9 Then Moses and the priest, Levite,
Spoke to all Israel, saying "Take
Heed and listen *for your own sake*,
O Israel, this day you've become
The folk of YHWH your God *in sum*.
10 "Therefore you shall obey the voice
Of YHWH your Alohim by choice,
And observe His commandments and
His statutes I this day command."

Perhaps because the bronze age was the
best
In sight of the conservative to rest
Who looked back with nostalgia on the
high
And great of civilisation gone by
That iron should not touch stone upon the
altar
Or upon plaques where Your law did not
falter.
Of course that may be why there are no
words
To read on any stones set up for birds
To perch upon and tangle with their feet,
Touch with their beaks and with the
treasure meet
Of their whitewash betray the whitewash
You
Commanded to be brushed on in our view.
I set the words again on tongue and heart
And thereby become Yours for my own
part.

11 And Moses commanded the folk
On the same day in which *he spoke*,
Saying 12 "These shall stand on the mount
Of Gerizim to bless the folk,
When you've crossed over Jordan's *stream*:
Simeon, Levi, Judah's *cream*,
Issachar, Joseph, Benjamin,
13 "And these shall stand *yet without sin*
On Mount Ebal to curse: Reuben,
Gad, Asher, Zebulon, Dan, and
Naphtali. 14 "At the Levites hand
They'll speak with a loud voice and say
To all Israel's folk *in the way*:
15 'Cursed *is* the one who makes a carved
Or moulded image *to be starved*,
Atrocious thing to YHWH, the work
Of craftsmen's hands *that do not shirk*,
And sets *it up* in secret.' And
All the people *upon command*

Shall answer and repeat 'Amen!'
16 'Cursed *is* the one who treats again
His father or mother with scorn.'
And all the folk shall say 'Amen!'
17 'Cursed *is* the one who moves the bourn
Of his neighbour.' And all the folk
Shall say 'Amen!' 18 'Cursed *is* the bloke
Who makes the blind to wander off
The road.' And all the folk shall scoff
'Amen!' 19 'Cursed *is* the one who twists
Justice due the stranger, insists
Against fatherless and widow.'
And all the people shall *in show*
Say 'Amen!' 20 'Cursed *is* the one who
Lies with his father's wife, to do
Uncovering his father's bed.'
And amen all the people said.

I curse indeed the hand and heart that make
An image to You and for worship's sake.
I curse that hand and heart if it be mine,
I curse it still in enemy or fine
Friend or in kith or kin, I curse them all
Who find another god and follow call.
Beloved, let me not even think the name
Of any other to eternal shame,
But let me ever seek and find the true
God who is one and only, who is You.
Then every other thing shall fall in place,
Respect to parents, to the land and race
Of blind and orphan, widow and the
stranger,
Avoiding every impure kind of danger.

21 'Cursed *is* the one who lies with any
Kind of beast even *for a penny*.'
And all the folk shall say 'Amen!'
22 'Cursed *is* the one who lies *again*
With his sister, his father's daughter
Or even with his mother's daughter.'
And all the folk shall say 'Amen!'
23 'Cursed *is* the one who lies *again*
With his mother-in-law.' And all
The folk shall say 'Amen!' *in call*.
24 'Cursed *is* everyone who attacked
His neighbour secretly *in fact*.'
And all the folk shall say 'Amen!'
25 'Cursed *is* the one who takes a bribe
To slay innocent in the tribe.'
And all the folk shall say 'Amen!'
26 'Cursed *is* one who does not confirm
All this law's words and not to squirm.'

And all the folk shall say 'Amen!'

I heartily confirm, I do concur,
All this law's words and raise myself and
stir

To keep them with my tongue and heart
and hand.

I draw down on myself no curse of band
On Ebal, but joy in the solemn sound
Of Your words cantillated on the ground.
Beloved, as I look on the mountain peak
And see the purple sun's horizon streak,
And lean against the stirring of the air
To find the sparrow twittering on the stair,
I mind me of the time of long ago
When silence was well broken with the
show,
And confirm now too that Your word is
best

As I look out upon the rising west.

Deuteronomy 28

1 "Now it shall come to pass, if you
Faithfully obey voice of YHWH
Your God, to observe carefully
All His commandments which *you see*
I command you today, that YHWH
Your God will set you high to do
Above all nations of the earth.

2 "And all of these blessings of worth
Shall come upon you, overtake
You, because you obey *for sake*
Of voice of YHWH your Alohim:

3 "Blessed *shall* you *be* in city *stream*,
And blessed you in the countryside.

4 "Blessed *shall be* the fruit of your bride,
The produce of your ground, increase
Of your herds, your cattle's increase
And all the offspring of your flocks.

5 "Blessed *shall be* your basket *and box*
And your kneading bowl. 6 "Blessed *shall*
you

Be when you come in, and when you
Go out. 7 "YHWH will cause your foes
who

Rise against you to be defeated
Before your face, *at once depleted*,
They'll come out against you one way
And flee before you seven ways.

8 "YHWH will command blessing this day
On you in your storehouses' *phase*
And in all to which you set hand,

And He will bless you in the land
Which YHWH your God gives to your
band.

Truly I am blessed and indeed each day
I seek to walk according to the way
That You command. Yet I look out upon
The peaceful red of the arising dawn
And know it falls upon the righteous head
That is bowed down with sorrows having
bled

Because of the oppression of the folk
Who being wicked still stand by the stroke.
The basket and the store do not reveal
The content of the soul for woe or weal.
I join the prayers of those who sorrow and
Those who rejoice for blessing on the land.
Beloved, I pray that blessing may increase
Upon a land where righteousness not cease.

9 "YHWH will establish you as folk
Holy to Himself, as He spoke
Swearing to you, if you will keep
YHWH your God's commandments and
steep

And walk in His ways. 10 "Then all folk
Of the earth shall see *at a stroke*
That you are called by name of YHWH,
And they shall be afraid of you.

11 "And YHWH will grant you goods in
plenty,

In the fruit of your body *benty*,
In the increase of your livestock,
And in the produce of your rock,
In the land of which YHWH *once* swore
To your fathers to give you *shore*.

12 "YHWH will open to you His good
Treasure, the heavens, to give *as should*
The rain to your land in its season,
And to bless all your hand's work feasen.

You'll lend to many nations, but
You shall not borrow *which or what*.

13 "And YHWH will make you head, not
tail,

You'll be only above, *not fail*
Nor be beneath, if you will heed
YHWH your God's commandments *indeed*,
Which I command to you today,
And are careful to keep *their way*.

14 "So you shall not turn aside from
Any of the words which in sum
I command you this day, *to right*

Or to the left, to go *in sight*
After other gods to serve *slight*.

Your Christ once said that rain comes down
on all,

Both just and unjust to Your beck and call.
By the same broken, dearth strikes all the
land

Where stay both righteous and the
contraband.

Beloved, in cloud and thunder and stand
still

To hear and do Your word and righteous
will,

And under clear skies, when I look in vain
For pattering like goats' feet gentle rain,
I bend my will and hand to obey You
In everything I think and say and do.
For judgement You have set a time and
place

When all alike shall come before Your
face,

But I, Beloved, rush to You here and now
Whether in fruited fields or broken plough.

15 "But it shall come to pass, if you
Do not obey the voice of YHWH
Your God, to observe carefully
All His commandments and truly
His statutes which I command you
This day, all these curses on you
Will come and overtake you *too*:

16 "Cursed *shall* you *be* when in the town,
And cursed *shall* you *be* in the brown
Countryside. 17 "Cursed *shall* be your
basket

And your kneading bowl *if you ask it*.

18 "Cursed *shall* be the fruit of your body
And the produce of your land *soddy*,
The increase of your cattle and
The offspring of your flocks *that stand*.

19 "Cursed *shall* you *be* when you come in,
And cursed *shall* you *be* in your *sin*
When you go out. 20 "And YHWH will
send

On you cursing, confusion's *blend*,
And rebuke in all that you set
Your hand to do, until you've met
Destruction and until you quickly
Perish, because of *all the sickly*
Wickedness of your doings in
Which you've forsaken Me *for sin*.

Curse not, Beloved, the innocent of cattle
Who have no portion in the moral battle!
The gentle cow, the newborn calf do spare
From the requirement of the pestful air.
Think only how she licks the little calf
In joy that fresh earth sprouts a greening
laugh.

She knows nothing of master's fainting
ways

Rebellious on the lazy summer days.

Spare, O Beloved, the running, tinkling
goats

That try their new feet telling anecdotes
To rocks precarious on pastures scant.

Curse not, Beloved, every inhabitant
Of stall and field no matter what men do.
The flocks and kine never fail to praise
You.

21 "YHWH will make the plague cling to
you

Until He has eaten up you

From the land which you're going to
Possess. 22 "YHWH'll strike you with tb,
With fever, inflammation, *see*,
With severe burning fever, and
With the sword, with scorching *the land*,
And with mildew, they shall pursue
You until you perish *in few*.

23 "And your heavens over your head
Shall be brass, and the earth *instead*
Which is under you *shall be ferric*.

24 "*For leading astray by the cleric*
YHWH will change the rain of your land
To powder and dust, from the hand
Of heaven it shall come down on you
Until you are destroyed *and few*.

25 "YHWH will cause you to be defeated
Before your enemies *depleted*,
You'll go out one way against them
And flee seven ways before them,
And you shall become troublesome
Upon the earth to each kingdom.

26 "Your carcasses shall be food for
All the birds of the air and *more*
The beasts of the earth, and no one
Shall frighten *them* away and *run*.

27 "And YHWH will strike you with the
boils
Of Egypt, and with tumours' *coils*,
With scab, and with the itch, from which

You cannot be healed *though you're rich*.

My good health is no proof that I am true
To You, Beloved, Gabriel was true too
And yet was plagued. The sky of burning
brass

And earth of iron instead of sprouting grass
Is the fate of all men who live on earth
And see the scorching and the craving
dearth

Brought on by Rome whose pax is but a
pox

On centuries of empires in its locks.
The kingdom of the earth is Yours alone,
While the usurper sits upon the throne
Of human institutions made for ill
Despite the human hopes to fill the bill.
Beloved, the ten commandments still reign
here

Despite the flaming fashions that appear.

28 "YHWH will strike you with madness
and

Blindness and confusion of heart.

29 "And you shall grope at noonday *stand*,

As blind men gropes in dark apart,
You shall not prosper in your ways,
You'll be only oppressed and *crazed*
With constant plunder, and no one
Shall save *you*. 30 "You shall get engaged

To a woman, but *when you're paged*
Another man shall lie with her,
You'll build a house, but in the blur
You shall not live in it, you'll plant
A vineyard, but not gather *scant*
Even of its grapes. 31 "Your ox *shall*
Be slaughtered by your eyes' *canal*,

But you shall not eat of it, your
Donkey *shall be* taken away
With violence and from before
You, and they will never restore
It to you, your sheep on the *stray*
Shall be given to enemies,
And you shall have no one to please
Rescue *them*. 32 "Your sons and your
daughters

Shall be given up to the *slaughters*
Of another folk, and your eyes
Shall look and fail *with longing sighs*
For them all day long without *strength*
Of God in your hand *and at length*.

33 "A nation whom you have not known

Shall eat the fruit *without a groan*
Of your land and the produce of
Your labour, and you shall *above*
Be only oppressed, always crushed.
34 "So you shall be driven and rushed
To madness because of the sight
Which your eyes see *by day and night*.

No doubt I'm mad, since I have seen the
sight

Of the oppression that with secret might
Lays low the human spirit to obey
With eagerness the earthly crowns that
slay.

The bestial, ruthless, joyous swords that
took

The lives of people in the old days look
Like toys beside the sleek and prideful
things

That blind men now to do without their
kings

And give more to shopkeepers than they
did

To kings when empire showed and deceit
hid.

I must be mad for seeing what I've seen,
For surely madness is the mark and mean
Of all consumer wealth and business shine
That spreads out awfully by shore of mine.

35 "YHWH will strike you upon the knees
And on the legs' extremities
With severe boils which cannot be
Healed, and from the sole of your foot
To the top of your head *I'll put*.

36 "YHWH will bring you and the king,
see,

Whom you set up to lord it over
You to a nation *and a drover*
Which neither you have known nor your
Fathers, and there for you *in store*
You'll serve other gods, wood and stone.

37 "And you'll be an astonishment,
A proverb, and a byword thrown
Among all nations where YHWH sent
You. 38 "And you'll carry much seed out
To the field but gather about
But little in, for the locust

Shall devour it. 39 "and you shall *trust*
To plant vineyards and tend *them*, but
You'll neither drink the grape juice glut
Nor gather, for the worms shall eat.

40 "You shall have olive trees *set neat*
 Throughout your country, but you'll not
 Anoint *yourself* with the oil *got*,
 For your olives shall drop off *green*.
 41 "You shall beget sons on the scene
 And daughters, but they'll not be yours,
 For they'll go to captivity.
 42 "Locusts shall consume all your stores
 Of trees and the produce *you see*
 Of your land. 43 "And the stranger who
 Is among you shall rise and do
 Higher and higher above you,
 And you shall come down lower and lower.
 44 "He shall lend to you, *sower and*
grower,
 But you shall not lend to him, he
 Shall be the head, and you shall be
 The tail *in everything you do*.

Beloved, to worship other gods but You
 Is said to be a punishment. The cue
 Is that the whole world it seems at this date
 Is punished with the vengeance of Your
 hate.

For everywhere I turn I find the gods
 Are worshipped among all the lords and
 sods.

Great punishment indeed You have set out
 Upon the populace to dance and shout
 In lustful rage and call it solemn joy.
 The world is punished well in its employ.
 The narrow trickle of my forest spring
 Gives drink beyond compare, despite the
 ring

Of city water that goes on to stir
 The neighbour with a lesser drought and
 bur.

45 "Indeed all these curses shall come
 Upon you and pursue in sum
 And overtake you, until you
 Are destroyed, because you did not
Bow to obey the voice of YHWH
Your Alohim, to keep the plot
Of His commandments and His clear
Statutes which He commanded you.
 46 "And they shall be upon your *fear*
 For sign and wonder, and on your
 Descendants always *on that score*.
 47 "Because you did not obey YHWH
 Your God with joy and gladness *too*
 Of heart, for the abundance of

These things, 48 "therefore you *without*
love

Shall serve your enemies, whom YHWH
 Sends against you, in hunger, thirst,
 In nakedness, and *what is worst*
 In need of everything, and He
 Will put a yoke of iron *to be*
 On your neck till He's destroyed you.
 49 "YHWH brings a nation against you
 From afar, from the ends of earth,
 As eagle flies *for all its worth*,
 A nation whose language you'll not
 Understand, 50 "a nation *begot*
 Of fierce features, and which does not
 Respect the old nor favour young.
 51 "And they shall take upon their tongue
 The increase of your livestock and
 The produce *coming* from your land,
 Until you are destroyed, they'll not
 Leave you corn or new grape juice *wrought*
 Or oil, *or* increase of your cattle
 Or offspring of your flocks *for battle*,
 Until they have destroyed your *plot*.

The yoke of iron surrounds the earth indeed
 As Daniel saw it once revealed in seed,
 In image where the legs of iron decreed
 That Rome would master orient and west.
 The feet of iron and clay feel hardness best,
 Where metal squeezes out the clay with
 pinch

Of craven greed to make the poor clay
 squeak
 And weep for pain and hunger at the leak.
 You are no fool, Beloved, and though Your
 hand

Seem not to interfere with cunning band,
 Still poverty cannot compel the mind
 Nor dazzlement of products always blind.
 Who take You not into account take not
 Into account the divine human lot.

52 "They shall besiege you at your gates
 Everywhere until your high *states*
 And fortified walls that you trust
 In all your land come down to dust,
 And they shall besiege you at all
 Your gates *and under every wall*
 Throughout your land which YHWH your
 God
 Has given you *upon the sod*.

53 "You'll eat the fruit of your own loins,

The flesh of your sons daughters joins,
Whom YHWH your God has given you,
In the siege and the horrors you
Find enemy distressing you.

54 "The sensitive and refined man
Among you will have hostile plan
Against his brother, toward the wife
Of his bosom, and toward the rest
Of his children whom in the strife
He leaves behind him *in the test*,

55 "So that he'll not give any of
Them the flesh of his children's *love*
Whom he will eat, because he has
Nothing left in the siege and as
The horrors of your enemy
Distress you at all your gates free.

56 "The tender woman, delicate
Among you, who would not instate
The sole of her foot on the ground
Because of her daintiness round,
Will refuse to the husband of
Her bosom, and to her son's love
And to her daughter, 57 "afterbirth
That runs between her legs and worth
Of children that she bears, for she
Will eat them for lack secretly,
In the siege and the horrors which
Your enemy's distressings pitch
Upon you at all of your gates.

58 "If you do not in careful rates
Observe all the words of this law
Written in this book *and with awe*,
That you may fear this glorious name
And awesome, YHWH your Alohim,
59 "Then YHWH will bring upon your
shame

And your descendants it will seem
Phenomenal plagues, great and long,
Awful diseases *at a gong*.

Who keep no Sabbath as You did command
You turn to pigs and monkeys on the land,
So it is punishment again from You
That people eat the pigs as though their
due,

And thus show they are cannibals for good.
Let no impure flesh cross my lips to be
The punishment that I have been set free
Of divine law and Your command to share
The swill of ape and pig as all men dare.
The archbishop once told me at a meal
Where I sat by his side, that if you feel

A morsel is good to eat and you give
Thanks for it then it's good to eat and live.
I let the bishop eat beneath his hood.

60 "Moreover He'll bring back on you
All the sickness of Egypt's *crew*,
Of which you were afraid, and they
Shall cling to you *both night and day*.

61 "Also every sickness and plague,
Which *is* not written *set down vague*
In this Book of the Law, will YHWH
Bring upon you until your *crew*
Are *all* destroyed. 62 "You shall be left
Few in number, *alas bereft*,

Whereas you were as heaven's stars
In multitude, because your *tars*
Would not obey the voice of YHWH
Your God. 63 "And it shall be, *that* just
As YHWH rejoiced at you and must
Do you good and multiply you,
So YHWH will rejoice over you
To destroy you and bring to naught,
And you shall be plucked from your plot
To which you go to have and hold.

64 "Then YHWH will scatter *in the cold*
Among all peoples, from one end
Of earth as far as may extend,
And there you shall serve other gods,
Which neither you nor fathers' *prods*
Have known, *gods of both* wood and stone.

65 "And among those nations *alone*
You shall find no rest, nor the sole
Of your foot have a resting hole,
But YHWH will give you trembling heart,
Failing eyes, soul anguish *in part*.

66 "Your life shall hang in doubt before
you,

Misgivings day and night abhor you,
And fears for life *always* implore you.

67 "At morning you shall say 'Oh, that
It were the evening!' And then at
The evening you shall say 'Oh, that
It were the morning!' for the fear
Which terrifies your heart *and ear*,
And because of the *cruel* sight
Which your eyes see *both day and night*.

68 "And YHWH will take you back in
ships

To Egypt, by the way *of slips*
Of which I said to you, 'You'll not
See it again.' There as a lot
You'll be put on sale to be bought

By enemies as slave and maid,
But none will buy you *in the raid*."

Though Israel of men have gathered round
Jerusalem again to find their ground,
And are no longer scattered at the sound
Of the invader, they are scattered still
Who are righteous to do Your sacred will.
There is no church or synagogue that's
found

Where all who gather are among the just.
The ones who know and do Your will now
must

Be scattered on the wind like flying dust
And lie invisible upon the world
Like salt that's only known by tongue
uncurled.

Beloved, I am Your slave of love though I
Remain unbought beneath an iron sky.

Deuteronomy 29

1 These *are* the words of covenant
Which YHWH commanded Moses *spent*
To make with Israel's folk in land
Of Moab, besides the command
Of covenant which He had made
With them in Horeb *where they stayed*.

2 Now Moses called all Israel
And said to them *as in farewell*:
"You have seen all that YHWH had done
Before your eyes in the land *spun*

In Egypt, to Pharaoh and all
His servants and to all his land,

3 "The great trials which *like contraband*
Your eyes have seen, the signs, and those
Great wonders. 4 "Yet YHWH *in the close*
Has not given you heart to fear
And eyes to see and ears to hear,
To this *very day bold and clear*.

5 "And I have led you forty year
In wilderness. Your clothes have not
Worn out on you, your sandals wrought
Have not worn out upon your feet.

6 "You have not eaten bread *for treat*,
Nor have you drunk grape juice or such,
That you may know that I *as much*
Am YHWH your God. 7 "And when you
came

To this place, Sihon *who by name*
Was king of Heshbon and Og king
Of Bashan came out *for the sting*
Of battle against us to bring,

And we conquered them *at the spring*.
8 "We took their land and gave it to
The Reubenites, the Gadites' *crew*,
And half the tribe of Manasseh
As a possession *in their way*.

My daily walk does not see great deeds
done
By Your power and strength in the battles
won,

But rather smaller things as it would seem,
The quiet things that go by as in dream,
Forgetful of the time of forty years,
In rare moments of bliss and rare of tears,
But mostly in the quiet calm of park
Where digging in the soil's the greater
spark.

And yet I think the sprouting in the spring
Of all the things that make my mealtime
ring

From meadowsweet to goutweed is a
greater

Act on Your part than overcoming satyr
Of Egypt, Bashon, Heshbon on the wing.
It's praised at least by chirping ones that
sing.

Week 51

9 "So keep the words of this promise,
And do them, that you may find bliss
In all that you do. 10 "All of you

Stand today before your God YHWH:
Your leaders and your tribes and your
Elders and your officers *score*,

All men of Israel *before*,
11 "Your little ones and your wives too,
Also the stranger in your camp,

From the one who cuts your wood *damp*
To the one who draws your water,

12 "That into pact you may enter
With YHWH your God, and in His oath,
Which YHWH your God makes, *and not*
loath,

With you today, 13 "that He may set
You *firmly* this day as a folk
For Himself, and *that* He may get
To be Alohim to you folk,
Just as He *promised* you *and* spoke,
And just as He's sworn to your fathers,
Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob
Who are now sleeping, don't wake up,
14 "I make this covenant, *no bothers*,

And this oath, not with you alone,
 15 "But with *him* who stands *on the stone*
 Here with us this day before YHWH
 Our God, as well as with *him* who
Is not here with us on this day,
 16 For you know that we lived away
 In Egypt's land and that we came
 Through nations which you passed *in*
blame,
 17 And you saw their abominations
 And their idols among those nations,
 Of wood and stone, silver and gold,
 18 "So among you let not be told
 A man or woman, kin or tribe,
 Whose heart turns away *at the bribe*
 This day from YHWH our God, to go
And serve the gods these nations *grow*,
 And that there may not be among
 You a bitter root or one strung
 With wormwood, 19 "and so it may not
 Happen, when he hears the words taught
 Of this curse, that he bless himself
 In his heart, saying *like an elf*,
 'I shall have peace, even though I
 Follow my heart cunning and sly,'
 As though the drunkard could be counted
 Among the sober ones *amounted*.

I am one of those ones who on that day
 Were not there to make covenant to stay
 Upon the pathway of Your word, and yet
 You still set up the covenant to get.
 I lay hold on the ten commandments still
 And turn my eyes away from busky hill
 Where Baal and Ashtoreth still have their
 groves
 And priests and ministers pass out the
 loaves
 Of human flesh well paid for in their
 droves
 By those who deal in traffic with proud
 Rome
 And fetch the air and seaways back to
 home.
 Beloved, I cling to You though I was not
 Present upon that Moabitic spot
 To engage in the divine call and plot.

20 "YHWH would not spare him, for the
 wrath
 Of YHWH upon His jealous path
 Would burn against that man, and all

The curses writ in this book fall
 On him, and YHWH would blot his name
 Out from under heaven *and its claim*.
 21 "And YHWH would separate him from
 All the tribes of Israel to come
 For trouble, according to all
 The curses of the promised call
 That are written within this book
 Of the law *if you take a look*,
 22 "So that the coming generation
 Of your children who *in elation*
 Rise up after you, and the stranger
 Who comes from a far land *and danger*,
 Would say, when they see all the plagues
 Of that land and the sickness' *dregs*
 Which YHWH has laid on it: 23 'The
 whole

Land *is* brimstone, salt, and a *hole*
 Burning, it's not sown, nor does bear,
 Nor does there any grass grow there,
 Like the fall of Sodom, Gomorrah,
 Admah, and Zeboim *in sorrow*,
 Which YHWH overthrew in His wrath
 And anger.' 24 "And in aftermath
 All nations would say 'Why has YHWH
 Done so to this land? And what do
 These burnings of great anger mean?'
 25 "Then *people* would say 'To be seen
 They've forsaken the covenant
 Of YHWH God of their fathers *meant*,
 Which He made with them when He
 brought

Them out of land of Egypt *sought*,
 26 'For they went and served other gods
 And worshipped them, the empty *pods*
 That they did not know and that He
 Had not given to them *to see*.
 27 'Then the anger of YHWH was roused
 Against this land *and those it housed*,
 To bring on it each curse that's writ
 In this book. 28 'And YHWH *in a fit*
 Uprooted them out from their land
 In anger, in wrath, and in *grand*
And great indignation, and cast
 Them into another land *fast*,
 As *it is to* this day.' 29 "The hidden
 And secret *things belong* to YHWH
 Our God, but those *things which are* bidden
Belong to us and to our crew
 Of children forever, to do
 All the words of this law *in view*.

Blot out, Beloved, the name of all who care
To deny Your law and refuse to share
Equally with all men the conscious I
Who is the speaking of Your heart though
shy

In every man born, though without the
claim

Of baptism in the tri-holy name
Or circumcision on Babylon's plain
Where the image is set up once again.
Blot out, Beloved, the image and each one
That bows beneath that symbol of the sun
To eat and drink the golden flood begun.
Blot out, Beloved, in me the residue
Of serving any gods at all but You.
Let me keep this law's words always in
view.

Deuteronomy 30

1 "Now it shall come to pass, when all
These things come on you, blessings fall,
And the curse which I've set before you,
And you call *them* to mind *to floor you*
Among all the nations where YHWH

Your Alohim will drive you to,
2 "And you return to YHWH your God
And obey His voice *at the prod*,

According to all I command
You today, you and all your band
Of children, and with all your heart
And with all your soul *for a start*,

3 "That YHWH your Alohim will bring
You back from captivity's *spring*,
And have compassion on you, and
Gather you again from the hand
Of all the nations where YHWH your
God has scattered you *there before*.

4 "If *any* of you're driven out
To the farthest *parts* under heaven,
From there YHWH your God *without*
leaven,

Will gather you, and from there He
Will bring you back *and faithfully*.

Each day I step out in captivity
To many nations where I rush to be,
I walk a world of marvels and of pest,
I see the wonders, pleasures, and the rest.
I worship many gods, speak many tongues,
And treasure what I find in heart and lungs.
The colours, scents, rejoinders, songs and
plays

Record the travels of each of my days.
And after all the labour and the chill,
The heat, the fever, meat and useless frill,
I enter once again my chamber close,
Awaking from dream-studded comatose,
And find as at the first and last that You
Are One, the lovely, and in all the true.

5 "Then YHWH your God will bring you
out

To the land which your fathers held,
And you'll possess it all about.
He'll prosper you *unparalleled*
And multiply beyond your fathers.

6 "And YHWH your God, beyond your
bothers,

Will circumcise your heart and heart
Of your descendants for their part,
To love YHWH your God with all your
Heart and with all your soul *in store*,
That you may live. 7 "And also YHWH
Your God will put these curses too
On all your enemies and on
Those who hate you, the paragon
Who persecuted you. 8 "And you
Will obey again voice of YHWH
And do all His commandments *too*
Which I command to you today.

9 "YHWH your God will make you abound
In all the work to which you lay
Your hand, and in your body's sound
Fruit, in the increase of your stock,
And in the produce of your rock
For good. For YHWH'll again rejoice
Over you for good as *with voice*
He rejoiced once over your fathers,

10 "If you obey, *and without bothers*,
The voice of YHWH your God, to keep
His commandments also His *deep*
Statutes which are written in this
Book of the law, *and if in bliss*
You turn to YHWH your God with all
Your heart and with all your soul's *call*.

The circumcision of the heart is needed
By every man, both heeded and unheeded.
Some say the circumcision of the flesh
Is useless in the covenant that's fresh.
I trow that's true, and just as much for
bread.
The heavenly loaf with which each one is
fed

Is what is necessary on life's way.
 The filthy, fleshly bread be thrown away.
 The spirit only meets the triumph call
 Of those who mount the airy, fiery hall.
 Who in the covenant of Christ repose
 Need not eat corny bread, drink wine, wear
 clothes
 Of linen or of wool, for they are clad
 In light, eat words, and keep their penis
 glad.

11 "For this commandment which I give
 You this day's not too deep to live,
 Nor *is* it far off. 12 "It *is* not
 In heaven, that you should say 'Who's
 sought
 To ascend into heaven for us
 And bring it to us *without fuss*,
 That we may hear it and do it?'
 13 "Nor *is* it beyond the sea's *writ*,
 That you should say 'Who will go over
 The sea for us and bring it, *rover*,
 To us, that we may hear and do?'
 14 "But the word *is* right near to you,
 In your mouth and in your heart *too*,
 That you may *hear and* do it *too*.

Ah, do You mean, Beloved, that Your word
 spoken
 On Sinai for a covenant and token,
 Which is near to the heart and on the
 tongue,
 And graven on the tablets and is sung
 To melodies both simple and ornate,
 Do You mean that word has not come too
 late?
 Do You mean that it's easy to observe,
 A light yoke and from which one need not
 swerve?
 That is good news, and yet the good news
 heard
 From every pulpit seems to be a turd,
 That Your commandment's too hard and
 too high
 For humans to believe, act and live by.
 Instead we need a human sacrifice,
 And crucifying someone makes things nice.

15 "Behold, this day I've set before
 You life and good, and death in store
 And evil, 16 "in that I command
 You today to love YHWH and stand

Before your God, to walk His ways,
 And keep His commandments *in lays*,
 His statutes, and His judgements *set*,
 That you may live and multiply,
 And YHWH your Alohim *in sky*
 Will bless you in the land which you
 Go to possess. 17 "But if your heart
 Turns away so that you don't start
 To hear, and drawn away to view
 And worship other gods and serve
 Them, 18 "I announce to you with verve
 Today that you shall surely perish,
 You shall not prolong *your days*, *cherish*
Them in the land which you cross over
 The Jordan to go in as rover
 And possess. 19 "I call heaven and earth
 To witness this day on your worth,
That I have set before you life
 And death, blessing and cursing *strife*,
 Therefore choose life, that both you and
 Your descendants may live *on land*,
 20 "That you may love YHWH and your
 God,

And obey His voice *and His rod*,
 And that you may cling to Him, for
 He *is* your life and the length *more*
 Of your days, and that you may live
 In the land which YHWH swore to give
 To your fathers, to Abraham,
 Isaac, and Jacob, to give them."

One sage took note that daily choice is
 given
 To take the good and set the evil striven
 Aside, and yet the tragedy of man
 Is that he chooses evil though he can
 Choose good. Beloved, this day let me
 choose good
 And walk upon the pathway as I should.
 Let me choose life, a living sacrifice,
 Where my will is annulled and Yours
 suffice.
 Let me in love to You, Beloved arise
 And view the morning and the evening
 skies
 From summits I have crossed to make the
 mark
 That You set before each man in the park
 To choose life and give You alone the sight
 To determine what's wrong and what is
 right.

Deuteronomy 31

1 Then Moses went and spoke these words
To all Israel, *humans and birds*.
2 And he said to them, "I *am* one
Hundred and twenty years when done
Today. I can no longer go
Out and come in. And *also know*
YHWH has said to me, 'You shall not
Cross over this Jordan *you've sought*.'
3 "YHWH your God Himself crosses over
Before you *into fields of clover*,
He will destroy these nations from
Before you *in the land you come*,
And you shall dispossess them too.
Joshua himself crosses *new*
Before you, just as YHWH has said.
4 "And YHWH will do to them *instead*
As He did to Sihon and Og,
The kings of the Amorites' *bog*
And their land, when He destroyed them.
5 "YHWH will give them over *in hem*
To you, that you may do to them
According to every command
Which I've commanded in your *land*.
6 "Be strong and of good courage, do
Not fear nor be afraid of them,
For YHWH your God, He *is* the One
Who goes with you. He'll not leave you
Nor forsake you *when He is done*."
7 Then Moses called Joshua and
Said to him in the sight of all
Israel, "Be strong and *take in hand*
Good courage, for you must *recall*
To go with this folk to the land
Which YHWH has sworn to give their
fathers,
To inherit it without bothers.
8 "And YHWH, He *is* the one who goes
Before you. He will watch your toes,
He will not leave you nor forsake,
Don't fear nor be dismayed *at stake*."

I shall be strong and take good courage too,
Beloved, as I seek to worship just You,
And leave aside the ungodly god crew.
Idolatry entices every day
To see the many and so turn away
From knowing that behind the many veils
Of personalities with flying sails,
There is just one and that One is divine,
You are the only I in human shrine,

The stony chambered heart of flesh and
wine.
Though I meet many rogues and many
saints,
They both express the veils and the
complaints
Of living in illusion. Only You
Even in shadow lands arise to do.

9 So Moses wrote this law and gave
It to the priests, the sons, *not slave*,
Of Levi, who carried the ark
Of covenant of YHWH *to park*,
To all the elders of Israel.
10 And Moses commanded them *well*,
Saying "At end of seven years,
At the appointed time appears
In the year of release, at feast
Of tabernacles, 11 "when the least
And great and all Israel comes to
Appear before your God and YHWH
In the place which He chooses, you
Shall read this law before the ears
Of all Israel's folk, each that hears.
12 "Gather the folk together, men
And women and little ones *then*,
And the stranger who's in your gates,
That they may hear and learn the *rates*
To fear YHWH your God and observe
All the words of this law *with verve*,
13 "And *that* their children, who have not
Known it, may hear and learn *what's taught*
To fear YHWH and your Alohim
As long as you live in the *dream*
Land which you cross Jordan to cream."

With eager trembling I take down the book
And open it again to have a look,
And chant again the liquid words and hear
Your voice awoken once more at my ear.
Beloved, Your law is sweet, entire and
sweet,
And I bow at its sighing to Your feet,
And set my soul in ecstasy to climb
The stairs toward Your throne in ring and
rhyme.
I hear and I become a child again
At age when the majority of men
Build towers and fortunes for their pride
and use.
I only build a melody's excuse
And rush to You for art and for my pay

To join with You as on my first birthday.

14 Then YHWH said to Moses, "Indeed,
The days approach when you *decreed*
Must die. Call Joshua, present
Yourselves before the meeting tent,
That I may ordain him *as sent*."

So Moses and Joshua went
And presented themselves in tent
Of meeting. 15 Now YHWH appeared at
The tabernacle *where He sat*

In a pillar of cloud, which stood
Above the tent door where He would.

16 And YHWH said to Moses, "Indeed,
You'll rest with your fathers *in weed*,
And this people will rise and play
The harlot with the gods that sway
The strangers of the land, where they
Go *to be* among them, and they
Will forsake Me and break My pact
Which I have made with them *in fact*."

17 "Then My anger shall be aroused
Against them in that day *bebrowsed*,
And I'll forsake them, and I'll hide
My face from them, where they abide
They'll be consumed. And many plagues
And troubles shall befall their *dregs*,
So that they will say in that day,
'Have not these evils come *this way*
Upon us because our God's not
Among us *here and where we sought*?'"

18 "And I will surely hide My face
In that day because of the race
Of evil which they've done, in that
They've turned to where other gods *sat*."

19 "Now therefore, write you down this
song,

And teach it to the children long
In Israel, put it on their tongue,
That this song may be witness sung
For Me against Israel's folk *strung*."

20 "When I have brought them to the land
With milk and honey on the sand
Flowing, of which I swore their fathers,
And they have eaten *without bothers*,
And filled themselves and have grown fat,
Then they'll turn where other gods sat
And serve them, and they will provoke
Me and break My pact at a stroke."

21 "Then it shall be, when many plagues
And troubles have come on their legs,
That this song will testify true

Against them as a witness *new*,
For it will not be forgot in
The mouths that their descendants *win*,
For I know how their conversation
Is like to turn this day and ration,
Even before I've brought them to
The land I swore *to give them due*."

At morning and at dawn I sit before
The narrow opening of my tent door
And wait the coming of the rosy cloud
From which I hear or almost hear aloud
Your voice in silence spring like long ago
You spoke to Moses there above the glow
Of fire by night and cloud by day for show.
At evening and at night I sit upon
The same carpet I used to find the dawn,
And there I sire in soul to meet Your throne
Among the forties whirling there as shown
To every prophet and divine guide driven
To know reality in what we live in.
And there I hear again Your voice alone.

22 Therefore Moses wrote out this song
The same day, and taught it along
To the children of Israel. 23 Then
He ordained Joshua *of men*
The son of Nun, and said "Be strong
And of good courage, for you'll bring
The children of Israel *to sing*
In the land of which I swore them,
And I will be with you *and them*."

24 So it was, when Moses had done
Writing the words of this law *run*
In a book, and when they had done,
25 That Moses commanded Levites,
Who carried in the people's sights
The ark of covenant of YHWH,
Saying 26 "Take this Book of the Law,
And put beside the ark *in awe*
Of covenant of YHWH your God,
That it may be there *and to prod*
You as a witness against you,

27 "For I know your rebellious *crew*
And your stiff neck in what you do.
If today, while I'm yet alive
With you, you've been rebellious *hive*
Against YHWH, then how much more still
After my death *you will act ill*?

28 "Gather me all the elders of
Your tribes, and your officers' *glove*,
That I may speak these words in hearing

Of them to call heaven and earth *clearing*
 To witness against them. 29 "For *fearing*
 I know that after my death you
 Will be a wholly corrupt crew,
 And turn aside from the way which
 I have commanded you to stitch,
 And evil will befall you in
 The latter days, because your sin
 Will rise up in the sight of YHWH,
 Provoking Him to anger through
 The work of your hands." 30 Moses spoke
 In the hearing of every bloke
 In Israel gathered *every* word
 Of this song until they were stirred.

Despite the fact that You leave divine guide
 To comfort the folk, teach and prod and
 chide,

They still will disobey and go aside.
 What was true then is true also today.
 Many claim to follow the twelfth way,
 And yet they follow the authorities
 That set themselves by awful guarantees
 In Moses' seat. I set aside the laws
 That such imagine based on their own
 claws.

I hold to the divine command and wait
 Upon the leading to Joshua's gate.
 Let Sanhedrin and elders' counsel wait,
 As well as every democratic state.
 Joshua was not chosen by folk's paws.

Week 52 Deuteronomy 32

1 "Give ear, O heavens, and I will speak,
 And hear, O earth, my mouth's words
 meek.

2 Let my teaching drop as the rain,
 My speech distil as dew *for gain*,
 As raindrops on the tender herb,
 As showers on the grassy *curb*.

3 For I shall cantillate the name
 Of YHWH and publish and proclaim
 The greatness of our Alohim.

4 He is the rock, and His works seem
 Perfection, for His ways all just
 Show Him a God of truth who must
 Be without guile, righteous is He
 And upright through eternity.

I cry out Huu to end this proclamation.
 Yes, just and right is Huu in every nation.

So my Beloved, You are both just and
 right,

A rock of refuge in the heathen's sight,
 Truth is Your name and everything You do
 Is justice, so I cry out once more Huu.

If I proclaim Your name as I recite
 The Hebrew words wrote here in dark and
 light,

It is because the Prophet Moses cried
 To end his sentence Huu and then he died.
 The skies and earth lend ear to hear the
 sound,

The dew and tender rain fall to the ground
 And make prostration on the slender grass.
 I too bow down to You before I pass.

5 "They've corrupted themselves, *they're*
 not

His children, for their blemish spot:
 A perverse, crooked generation.

6 Do you thus deal with YHWH, O nation
 Foolish and unwise? *Is* He not
 Your Father, *He who also* bought
 You? Has He not made you and *then*
 Established you *like other men*?

Beloved, You are four things to me by this
 Chant in the Scriptures that I cannot miss.
 You are my Father, though You do not bear
 Children nor take a wife among the fair.
 You are my Master, for You have bought
 me

And paid the price of purchase for my fee.
 You are Creator of my life and all
 I am and do, things both great and the
 small.

You are the One Establisher of my
 Life day to day, although I wonder why
 The this and that of things that I live by.
 Father and Master, Creator and One
 To establish my living till I've done,
 Four in four gates until my race is won.

7 "Remember days of old, and think
 Of many generations' brink.
 Ask your father, and he will show
 You, your elders, and they will *know*
 To tell you: 8 When the Most High split
 Inheritance to nations *fit*,
 Dividing up the sons of Adam ,
 He set bounds for the folk *that had them*
 According to the number of

The children of God *and His love.*

9 For YHWH's portion *will be* His folk,
Jacob's the place of His own stroke.

10 "He found him in a desert land
And in the wasteland, howling sand,
Encircled him, instructed him,

He kept him as apple and hymn
Of His eye. 11 As an eagle stirs
Up its nest, hovers on and whirs
Over its young, spreads out its wings,
Taking them up upon its wings,
12 So YHWH alone led him, and *there*
Was no foreign god El to share.

13 "He made him ride in the earth's heights,
To eat the produce of his rights
Of the fields, He made him draw honey
From the rock, and oil *without money*
From the flinty rock, 14 Curds from cattle,
And milk of the flock *without battle*,
With fat of lambs, and rams of Bashan,
And goats, with the choicest wheat *ration*,
And you drank grape juice, and the blood
Of the grapes *coming in a flood*.

You are my portion and inheritance,
Beloved, the dergah where I sing and
dance,

But marvellous beyond reality
Is that for Your portion You've taken me.
Beloved, see what my wealth is on the
block,

While You are drawn in poverty of stock.
For I have You for riches, wealth unbought,
While You have only me, a barren plot.
While I eat honey and drink for the dew
The blood of grapes, what is there left for
You?

I cantillate You lovely names' recall
That speak in memory like granite wall,
While You for recitation give me breath
And keep in love my heart and soul from
death.

15 "But Jeshurun grew fat to kick,
You grew fat, you *also* grew thick,
You are rotund! Then he forsook
Allah *who had* made him, and look
Askance at his salvation's Rock.

16 They provoked Him to jealous shock
With foreign *gods*, with things atrocious
Provoked His wrath *to be ferocious*.

17 They sacrificed to demons, not

To Allah, *to gods* they did not
Know, to new *gods*, new that your fathers
Did not fear. 18 But of the Rock's *bothers*
Who brought you forth, you are unmindful,
And have forgotten the God blindful,
El who fathered you on the spot.

Political correctness does not mark,
Beloved, Your speech not spoken in the
dark.

Obesity is holy in this day,
And You should know in everything You
say

Not to offend the fat by word or deed.
You've fallen on Your face, Beloved, take
heed.

Unless You address people with the stock
Of right words at the right time of the
clock,

You'll find they choose a kinder kind of
god

Who does not berate heads with speckled
rod.

Apologize right now to Jeshurun,
And the elite will raise You to the moon,
Or keep Your silence and stand fare to lose
Respect from every crowd out there to
bruise.

19 "And when YHWH saw *it*, He spurned
them,

Because of provocation's *stem*
Of His sons and His daughters *too*.

20 And He said 'I will hide My *true*
Face from them, I will see their end,
For they're a perverse generation,
Children in whom *is* no faith *bend*.

21 They have provoked Me *in My station*
To jealousy by *what* is not
El, they have moved Me to a *spot*
Of anger by their foolish idols.

But I'll provoke them in *their bridles*
To jealousy by *those who're* not
A nation, I'll move them to wrath
By a foolish nation *in path*.

22 For a fire's kindled by my wrath,
And shall burn to the lowest hell,
It shall consume the earth *as well*
With her increase, and set on fire
The mountains' foundations in pyre.

Beloved, I am no nation here alone

Reciting Your sweet names within the
stone
Chamber of my heart where I find Your
face.
Make jealous every one of sacred race
By Your elopement to my trysting place
To dine with me on grapes and nuts and
plums
While others are proud to be erring bums.
No error is there for the one who waits
Upon Your Decalogue and at the gates
Finds to obey Your law is grace enough,
And in Your law the gate of love as rough
Opens the door to awareness that You
Are One the only God, the One and true.
Beloved, cause jealousy to topple states.

23 I'll heap disasters on them, I
Will spend My arrows till they die.
24 *They'll be* wasted with hunger, and
Devoured by pestilence *at hand*
And bitter destruction, I'll send
Against them the beasts' teeth to rend,
With poison of snakes in the dust.
25 The sword shall destroy *without rust*,
There'll be terror within the trust
Of the young man and virgin, and
The nursing child with the man's *hand*
Who has grey hairs *and cannot stand*.

I have grey hair. That puts me in the class
That finds terrors a-lurking in the grass.
I have no hunger unless I make fast,
I meet no poison of the serpents cast,
Although there's poison in the bread I eat
If I buy it at supermarket treat,
Where additives, preservatives are meet
To make it palatable for a week.
But if I am humble enough to seek
The lowly crust, no poison threatens me.
I only have my grey hair for my fear
And even that is thinning by the year.
Beloved, in all my drawn simplicity,
I take hold of Your law and become free.

26 I would have said "I'll dash in pieces
Until the memory of them ceases
From among men," 27 Had I not feared
The wrath when enemy appeared,
Unless their adversaries be
Misunderstanding, lest declare
"Our hand *is* high, we cannot see

That it's YHWH that's made all this bare."
28 "For they're a nation void of sense,
In understanding they are dense.
29 Oh, that they were wise, *and that* they
Understood this, *that* they'd relay
Their latter end! 30 How could one chase
A thousand, and two put to race
Ten thousand in flight, but their Rock
Had sold them, *barrel, stock and lock*,
And YHWH'd surrendered them *in block*?
31 For their rock *is* not like our Rock,
Even as judge our enemies.
32 For their vine's of the vine *and trees*
Of Sodom and fields of Gomorrah,
Their grapes *are* grapes of gall *and sorrow*,
Their clusters bitter. 33 Their grape juice
Is serpents' poison for the use
Of cobras' cruel venom's abuse.
34 *Is* this not laid Me up in store,
Sealed up among My treasures' *floor*?
35 Vengeance is Mine, and recompense,
Their foot shall slip in *due* time *hence*,
For the day of calamity
Is at hand, and things hastily
Come on them.' 36 "For YHWH will be
judge
Of His people and He will budge
In compassion on His servants,
When He sees that *their* power's hence,
And *there's* no one *remaining*, bond
Or free. 37 He'll say 'Where *is the wand*
Of their gods, the rock in which they
Sought refuge? 38 Who ate fat and whey
Of their sacrifices, *and* drank
The wine of their drink offering *rank*?
Let them arise up now and help,
And be a refuge to your *whelp*.
39 'Now see that I, *even* I, *am* He,
And *there is* no God beside Me,
I kill, I make alive, *set free*,
I wound and heal, and *there is none*
To deliver from My hand *won*.

Beloved, do You mean You are God alone?
I know You reject images of stone,
But do You also cast aside the Three
That make up one god in a Trinity?
Ah, many are the creeds that say You're
wrong,
Beloved, God of the Scriptures, and the
strong
And mighty El Shaddai of Abraham!

You spoke to Moses as the great I AM,
To David as the one from Your own heart.
All other gods are ones contrived by art
And art's philosophies. That stubborn Me
You choose to call Yourself lets none go
free.

So bind my heart and soul to only One,
And let's have trinities and idols done.

40 I raise My hand to heaven, and say
"I live forever, 41 If I *weigh*
And whet My glittering sword, and My
Hand takes hold on judgement, then I
Will render vengeance to My foes,
And repay those who hate My *nose*.
42 I'll make My arrows drunk with blood,
And My sword shall devour *the flood*
Of flesh, with the blood of the slain
And the captives, heads of the main
Leaders of the enemy *vain*. "
43 "Rejoice, O Gentiles, *with* His folk,
For He'll avenge the blood *He spoke*
Of His servants, and vengeance make
On His enemies, He'll provide
Atonement for His land and *wide*
Atonement on His people's side."

Are You, Beloved, a God of mercy and
A God of justice? Let me understand.
This world is full of universal love
Expressed in song and dance and millions
of
Land mines in loving silence waiting where
The soft caress of some child's hand in air
Will set off universal love again.
Why do I always meet such love in pain?
Instead of universal love I wait
For mercy in Your coming judgement's
gate.
The three great heresies join to agree
That You must come to judge and that
quickly.
Come end this universal love with fire
Is Dervish Ali Haydar's firm desire.

44 So Moses came with Joshua
The son of Nun and spoke *in awe*
All the words of this song in hearing
Of the people *trembling and fearing*.
45 Moses ended all these words' speech
To all Israel, 46 and said to each,
"Set your hearts on all the words which

I witness among you *for switch*
Today, which you shall command your
Children to be careful in chore
To observe, all words of this law.
47 "For it's not futile, but for awe
To you, since it *is* your *own* life,
And by this word *and without strife*
You'll prolong *your* days in the land
Which you cross over Jordan's sand
To have and hold. 48 And then YHWH
spoke

To Moses that same day *a stroke*,
Saying 49 "Go up into this mount
Of the Abarim, *to the fount*
Of Mount Nebo, that's in the land
Of Moab, across from *the hand*
Of Jericho, and view the land
Of Canaan, which I give the band
Of Israel as a living space,
50 "And die on that mountain *and place*
Which you ascend, and be gathered
To your people, *who shall be stirred*,
Just as Aaron your brother died
On Mount Hor and gathered beside
His people, 51 "because you trespassed
Against Me among Israel's cast
At the waters of Meribah
In Kadesh, in the desert awe
Of Zin, because you did not keep
Me holy among Israel's heap.
52 "Yet you shall see the land before
You, though you shall not enter store,
Or go into the land I'm giving
To Israel's folk *for board and living*."

Like Moses I prolong my life in You
By taking hold of Your law that is true,
The Decalogue once spoken on Sinai
And carried in both ark and heart and sigh.
The song that Moses taught the people
there
Arose in cadences upon the air
To remind them again, again declare
The ten commandments still are right and
good
To tell the soul to speak and act as should.
Beloved, I prolong my life in that word
And song that long ago the people stirred,
And sing again the Hebrew melodies
Until the tides run out upon the leas.
Though landless I am blessed with corn and
trees.

Deuteronomy 33

1 Now this *is* the blessing which Moses
The man of Alohim *that chose us*
Blessed Israel's folk before his death.
2 And he said "YHWH from Sinai's breath
Came and dawned on them from Seir, He
Shone forth from Mount Paran, and He
Came with ten thousands of His saints,
From His right hand *came without taints*
A fiery law for them. 3 Yes, He
Loves the people, and all His saints
Are in Your hand, they sit down at
Your feet, *everyone* receives that
Of Your words. 4 Moses commanded
A law for us, heritage hid
For Jacob's congregation. 5 He
Was King in Jeshurun, and when
The leaders of the folk *and men*
Were gathered, all the tribes together,
Of Israel *to find out whether:*

A fiery law indeed, Beloved, let me
Burn in the sweet fire of eternity
That kindles from Your law and to the gate
Of Truth extends unbowed, commensurate.
The saints of forties all bound in Your hand
Whirl and rewhirl and never come to stand,
But like the stars obedient in the sky
Cast up their burning eyes and hands to fly.
Cast me up burning too among the throng
Of those who hear the chirping of the song
Of Your law burning, burning with desire.
I rush like winged and bright moth to that
fire,
Extinguish phantom will in You alone
And touch again my soul with flesh and
bone.

6 "Let Reuben live, let him not die,
Nor let his men be few nor cry."
7 And this he said of Judah, "Hear,
YHWH, the voice of Judah, *lend ear,*
And bring him to his people, let
His hands be sufficient *to get*
For him, and may you be an aid
Against his enemies *once swayed."*

The pinnacle of Torah here is found,
The blessing on the twelve and all around.
The blessed names, the names of holy few
Sparkle upon the sward like morning dew,

Like jewels cut with rare skill and with
taste

Upon a night sky starred and unerased.
The voice of Judah, hand of Reuben
sought,

They lend an arm to Your law where it's
taught,

And take a streaming banner from the fire
To lighten up the world for an umpire.

The twelve come here as they did from
Ishmael

And sound again in the sons of Israel,
To come in judges, prophets, kings and last
In the divine guides sent and unsurpassed.

8 And of Levi he said "*Let* your
Thummim and your Urim *be store*
With your holy one, whom you tested
At Massah, and of whom you bested
At the waters of Meribah,

9 Who says of his father *to caw*
And his mother, 'I've not seen them',
Nor did acknowledge brothers' *gem,*
Or know his own children, for they
Have observed Your word in the way
And kept Your covenant. 10 They'll teach
Jacob Your judgements, and *they'll preach*
To Israel Your law. They'll put
Incense before You *and your foot,*
And a whole burnt sacrifice on
Your altar. 11 Now then, bless his *lawn*
And substance, YHWH, accept the work
Of his hands, strike the loins *and dirk*
Of those who rise against him, and
Of those who hate him *in the land,*
That they rise not *again to stand."*

The Thummin and Urim by which the crew
Of Levi used to answer questions true
Are now reputed lost, what shall we do?
Two sapphire jewels still remain upon
The breast of every priest and king at dawn,
The tables of the law, criterion
Established by Qur'an and set to light
The way to Paradise, the way by sight.
I need no faith nor document writ fair
From history's long corridors to share,
But ask the flashing stones for guidance to
The right way in the things that I should do.
Beloved, I praise Your name, Your law,
Your grace,

And live by sight, not faith, before Your face.

12 Of Benjamin he said "Beloved
Of YHWH shall live by Him engloved,
Who shelters him all the day long,
And he shall live *and with a song*
Between His shoulders." 13 And he said
Of Joseph "Blessed of YHWH's his land,
With precious things of heaven *planned*,
With dew, and the deep lying there,
14 With the sun's precious fruits and bare,
With the months' finest produce fair,
15 With the best things of ancient mounts,
With precious things in precious founts
Of everlasting hills *and rills*,
16 With costly things that the earth fills,
And favour of who lived in bush.
Let come on Joseph's head to push,
And on the crown of his head *who*
Was separate from his brothers' *crew*."
17 His glory's *like* a firstborn bull,
And his horns *like* the horns *that pull*
The wild ox, together with them
He'll push the peoples to the hem
Of the earth, they *are* Ephraim,
Ten thousands, and they *it would seem*
The thousands of Manasseh's *dream*."

So little Benjamin takes the fourth place,
The slot of one before whose tragic face
The martyrs died at Kerbela, Ali
The Zeynul-'Abideen, who was set free
For having been delivered from the rage
By Your protection and a hermitage
Amid the battle and its woeful sounds.
I too have travelled long and made the
 rounds,
But never heard from hiding place the like
That he heard from the wicked tyrant's
 strike.
Benjamin, son of the right hand, well
 makes
The prophecy of Ali for the sakes
Of those to come, and those who stop to weep,
And those who know that praises don't
 come cheap.

18 Of Zebulon he said "Rejoice,
Zebulon, in your *firstling choice*
To go out, and Issachar in

Your tents *and barns and stalls and bin*!
19 They'll call the peoples *to* the mount
Where righteous sacrifices mount,
For they shall partake *of* the plenty
Of the seas and *of* treasures *twenty*
All hidden in the sand *and fount*."

While Issachar takes seventh place here, he
Becomes the harbinger eternally
Of hidden and outright among the free
And divine guides. The double reign
 restores

The treasures of the secret, heavenly doors,
And calls to feast of sacrifice upon
The mountains overlooking sea at dawn.
The tents are opened to the ripening wind
And all the grief's forgotten and who
 sinned.

The sands shine clear and coloured with the
 glow
Of love between the brothers who must go
And those who stay to guard the camps and
 flocks.

Beloved, I do not hold with those with
 locks,
But break into the treasury by force
And tear down all the veils of the divorce.

20 And of Gad he said "Blessed *is* he
Who enlarges Gad, he dwells *free*
As a lion, and tears the arm
And the crown of his head *from harm*.
21 He readied the first for himself,
Because that a lawgiver's shelf
Was reserved there. He came *with* heads
Of the people, applied the beds
Of justice of YHWH, and all his
Judgements with Israel *as is*."

Descended from the eighth holy imam
Was Hajji Bektash who desired no alm
But laid his shoulder to the lion's whelp
And gave a hand to every deer for help.
The law came clear and undeterred through
 him
When others bound to kings spoke low and
 dim,
And so Gad represents that fateful whim
That received of the promises and yet
Had to go empty from the stage and set.
Despite the heads of people fickle, bare,
The justice he applied on desert air

Remains the judgement to look to and fair.
Beloved, let Gad remain the founder of
The oracles of justice and of love.

22 And of Dan he said "Dan's a whelp
Of lion, he shall leap from *help*
Of Bashan." 23 And of Naphtali
He said "O Naphtali, well filled
With favour, and full of the *spilled*
Blessing of YHWH, possess the west
And south and live *among the best*."
24 And of Asher he said "Asher
Is most blessed of sons, let the fer
Be favoured by his brothers, and
Let him dip foot in oil *at hand*.
25 Your sandals *shall be* iron and bronze,
As your days, your strength *for by-gones*.

Asher is happiness, perhaps, but see
The sandals of the warrior and the free
Fit to his feet, see how he stands and goes
With banners and with chariots to his foes.
His brothers favour, yes, and bless his
name
Who rises to the great task without shame.
Though days obscure the task with fading
light

And Askeri like Asher's out of sight,
Still I remember to the end of life
The blessedness that Asher lends the strife,
And so strive on to find the secret one
Who hides behind the grails that have been
won.

Ah my Beloved, bless still eleventh son
Until the great occultation is done.

26 "*There is* no one like the God of
Jeshurun, *who* rides up above
The heavens to help you, and in His
Excellency on the clouds is.
27 The eternal Alohim *is*
Your refuge, and underneath *are*
The everlasting arms, He'll thrust
Out the foe from before your *trust*,
And will say 'Destroy!' 28 Then shall live
Israel in safety, *fugitive*
No more spring of Jacob alone,
In a land of corn and new *blown*
Grape juice, His heavens also drop dew.
29 O Israel! How blessed are you!
Who *is* like you, a people saved
By YHWH, the shield of your help *craved*

And the sword of your majesty!
Your enemies submissively
Bow to you, and you shall tread down
Their high places *outside the town*."

The twelfth name is a hidden name to last
And many have in crowded streets gone
past
The hidden divine guide who might have
given
The answer to the questions they had
striven
To find to save their souls and show the
blessed.
The last name though not mentioned is the
best

In days of life, in sweet communion's fold.
His comings and his goings go untold.
Yet one day in the brightness and the cold
His enemies submissively though bold
Shall bow before him and take grateful
hold
On the faith that he kept secret and true.
Who now bow down to idols and their crew
Shall one day, my Beloved, acknowledge
You.

Deuteronomy 34

1 Then Moses went up from the plains
Of Moab to Mount Nebo *rains*,
To the top of Pisgah, which lies
Across from Jericho's describes.
And YHWH showed to him all the land
Of Gilead as far as Dan,
2 All Naphtali *on every hand*,
Land of Ephraim and Manasseh,
All land of Judah to the way
Of western sea, 3 the south, and plain
Of the valley of Jericho,
The city of the palms *in train*,
As far as Zoar. 4 Then YHWH said
To him, "This *is* the land of which
I swore to make Abraham *rich*,
Isaac, and Jacob, saying 'I'll
Give to your descendants *a while*.'
I've made you see *it* with your eyes,
But you'll not cross over *the rise*."

How Moses longed to enter in the land
Of promise, yet a better thing in hand
You gave him! Such is punishment You
mete.

It's better far that any former treat,
And instead of the better, it tastes sweet.
Punish me too, Beloved, with visions grand
That cover all the glories of the sand
Of the salt sea until the western rise
Gives way to olive green and purple skies.
Give me the visions Moses saw to know
The way that righteous people ought to go,
As well as visions of the mountain steep
Covered with sorrels, lichens, and the
 deeps
Of valleys where the secret lilies grow.

5 So Moses the servant of YHWH
Died there in Moab's land *and true*,
According to the word of YHWH.
6 And He buried him in a vale
In the country of Moab's pale,
Opposite Beth Peor, but none
Knows his grave to this day *when done*.
7 Moses *was* one hundred and twenty
Years old when he died *full and plenty*.
His eyes were not dim nor his strength
Diminished *in all of his length*.
8 And the children of Israel wept
For Moses in Moab's plains kept
For thirty days. So days of weeping
And mourning for Moses were keeping.

Some mourn for thirty days, a month of
 time,
And some for forty scented with the thyme,
But I, Beloved, in mourning dress or not,
In silence keep a vigil on the plot
Of silvered willow, trembling aspen leaf,
And carve in granite eyes a narrow grief.
Some mourn for thirty days as Moses done
When Moab's shadows on the hills had run
In red and purple fingers, hands and hips,
And some mourn forty days not moving
 lips.
But I, Beloved, range through the virgin
 wood
And keep within the chamber of my mood
The joys of knowing, sadnesses to part,
And pass alone beyond the veils that start.

9 Now Joshua the son of Nun
Was full of wisdom's spirit won,
For Moses had laid hands on him,
So Israel's children heeded him,
And did as YHWH'd commanded Moses.

10 But since then there's not come nor
 chose us
In Israel a prophet like Moses,
Whom YHWH knew face to face, 11 in all
The signs and wonders which YHWH's *call*
Sent him to do in Egypt's land,
Before Pharaoh, before his *own*
Subjects, in all his land *of stone*,
12 And by all that mighty power and
All the great terror *in the land*
Which Moses did *in the daylight*
Before all Israel in their sight.

Ah, face to face, Beloved, what priceless
 joy!
The Prophet basked in blessings, happy
 boy!
I seek Your face among the busy crowd,
And sing remembrance to Your name
 aloud.
I turn around in penitence and whirling,
Give alms in caret gold and tarnished
 sterling.
I seek Your face beyond the sunrise, yet
The sunset covers empty blue, I get
No nearer to the goal. Ah, face to face
Is rare encounter in the hour and place.
I cannot see Your face, though You see me,
Not only since You bear no edge to see,
But more because You are too close to
 know,
Closer than self, and closer, closer grow.